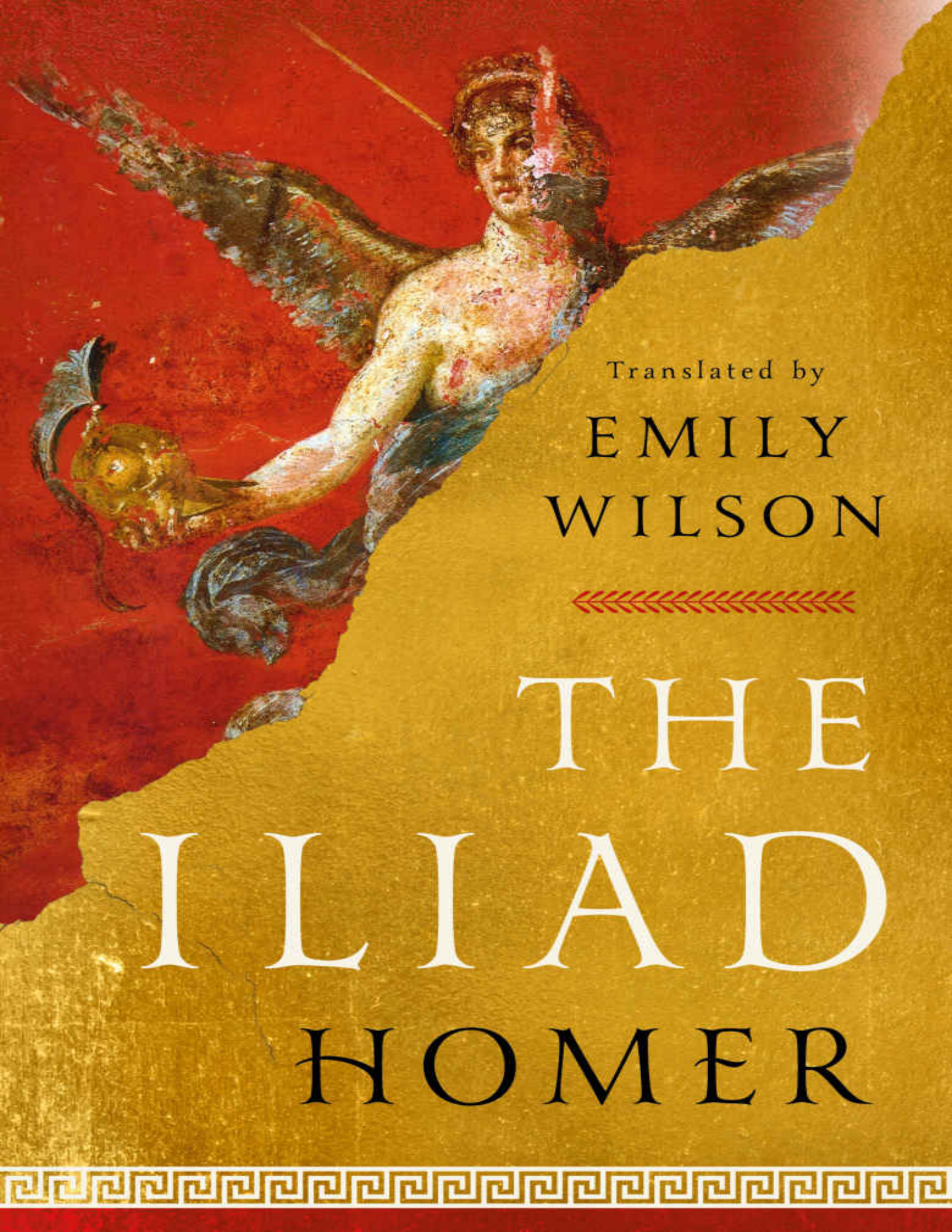




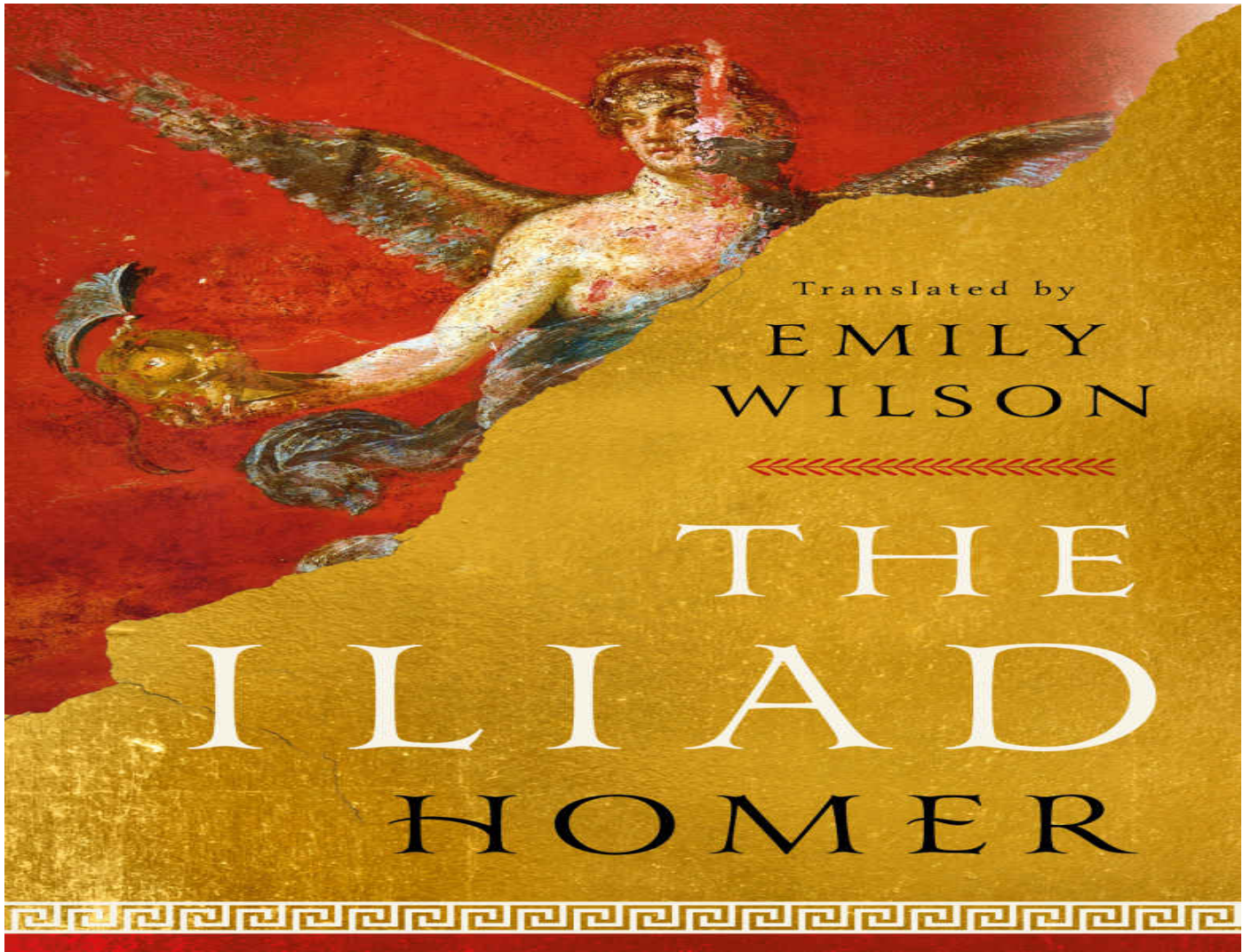
Translated by

EMILY  
WILSON



THE  
ILLIAD  
HOMER





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THE  
ILIAD  
HOMER

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TRANSLATED BY EMILY WILSON



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Adjusting type size may change line breaks. Landscape mode may help to preserve line breaks.

*To the memory of my mother,  
Katherine Duncan-Jones (1941–2022),  
who first taught me to love poetry.*

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# INTRODUCTION

*The Iliad*, a long epic poem set in the mythical Trojan War, tells two interwoven stories across its twenty-four books. The first describes the overwhelming anger of a Greek warrior, Achilles, and its catastrophic consequences. The second tells how a brave Trojan warrior, Hector, leaves his city and family to attack the Greek invaders—and returns home only after death. The two stories are closely braided together. Achilles' rage, and his consequent absence from battle, enables Hector's successful advance toward the Greek camp. Hector kills Achilles' dearest friend, Patroclus, and the rage of Achilles turns against Hector. The two story lines are resolved together, when Achilles allows the dead Hector to be brought back to his people to be mourned. The struggles of many others—men, women, goddesses, and gods—are woven into the same grand tapestry.

The poem evokes human greatness and human vulnerability. People are “godlike” in their courage and skill, but even the greatest mortals fall and clutch the dust between their bloody fingers. The beautiful word *minunthadíos*, “short-lived,” is used of both Achilles and Hector, and applies to all of us. We die too soon, and there is no adequate recompense for the terrible, inevitable loss of life. Yet through poetry, the words, actions, and feelings of some long-ago brief lives may be remembered even three thousand years later.

## Loss and Compensation

Two epic poems are ascribed to Homer: *The Iliad* and *The Odyssey*. *The Odyssey*, set when the Trojan War is over, describes how one extraordinary man, the Greek warrior Odysseus, recovers everything he had lost: his home, his family, and his status as head of his household and lord of Ithaca. *The Iliad*, set in the final year of the Trojan War, immerses us in the world of war, and shows us what happens to all the warriors who never come home alive.



Like Odysseus, Achilles and Hector are warriors separated from their people. Like him, each eventually finds his way back to his community. But unlike Odysseus, the great warriors of *The Iliad* never fully reclaim what they have lost. The attempt to repair one loss leads only to further losses. Hector's homecoming happens after death. Achilles mourns his beloved friend, Patroclus, and eventually shares his grief with the grief of others. But his friend is still dead, and always will be. So are countless others, including those who are forgotten and unnamed. The past cannot be undone. The dead never come back to life.

*The Iliad* is framed by scenes of loss and restitution. At the beginning of the poem, a priest named Chryses loses his daughter, but recovers her alive, thanks to the intervention of the god Apollo. In the final book, another father recovers another lost child—but this son, Hector, comes home as a corpse.

When people are captured alive, they may be bought back by their families. If the captors refuse to relinquish the captive, kinsmen may fight to recover them—as they do, on a grand scale, for Helen, the daughter of Zeus and wife of the Greek warrior Menelaus, whose abduction by the Trojan Paris is the premise for the Trojan War. But recovery of a living captive is rare in *The Iliad*. The priest's daughter, Chryseis, is exceptional because she is guarded by Apollo. Without divine protection, mortal women captured in war are usually enslaved for the rest of their lives. On the battlefield, men are usually not captured alive, but killed.

When a man is slain in times of peace, families can gain partial compensation for their loss by exacting a blood-price from the killer. Killers may also be forced to leave the community and take refuge elsewhere, as Patroclus did as a boy after he accidentally killed another boy in an argument over a game; he was adopted by his cousin Peleus and raised beside Achilles, like an older brother. In such cases, the killer's loss of his original home comforts the family in their need for vengeance. But in war, killers recognize no binding obligation to compensate the families of their victims. The only way the bereaved can recoup their losses is to kill the killer—whose comrades will demand vengeance in their turn. Killing begets killing, death begets death, and every loss of life generates further loss of life.

Yet even in wartime, people can get partial, inadequate compensation for the loss of a loved one. When it is too late to save a warrior's life, friends and kinsmen may be able at least to save his weapons and his armor. If those have been stripped, the companions of the dead man may at least save his body. Long and bitter battles are fought in the attempt to rescue the dead—including the dead Sarpedon, the dead Patroclus, and the dead Hector—from desecration at the hands of the enemy. If the body is recovered, friends and family can at least provide their loved one with the honors due the dead. A funeral cannot compensate the bereaved for their loss. It cannot bring the dead back to life. But it is often the only recompense we have. In accepting such

inadequate forms of compensation, we also accept our own limitations and our mortality.

The extraordinary wrath of Achilles entails an insistent, deadly refusal to accept any of the traditional forms of compensation for the various losses he experiences. In the first stage, Agamemnon insults Achilles by robbing him of a female captive, Briseis. Agamemnon later realizes his mistake and offers to give the woman back untouched, along with a lavish set of gifts as compensation for the affront. But Achilles adamantly rejects the offer, insisting that even an infinite number of gifts—as many as the sands of the sea—could never be adequate compensation for his original humiliation.

*“Not even if his gifts to me could match  
the grains of dust and sand—not even then  
would Agamemnon ever sway my heart. . . .”*(9.495–97)

Achilles associates his social losses—of status, trust, and goodwill among comrades—with something else that he will soon lose, if he stays to fight in the war: his own brief life. He insists that the traditional warrior code, whereby fighters receive honor as compensation for risking their lives, has been violated:

*“Cowards and heroes have the same reward.  
Do everything or nothing—death still comes.”*(9.409–10)

Moreover, perhaps the trade was never worth it in the first place. Material wealth—such as treasure or animals—can be traded and recovered, but this loss can never be recouped:

*You can raid fine cattle  
or well-fed sheep, and you can trade to get  
tripods and horses with fine golden manes.  
But human life does not come back again  
after it passes through the fence of teeth.  
No trade or rustling can recover it.*(9.524–29)

The almost childlike simplicity and truth of the observation is overwhelmingly powerful. Teeth are a fence between the interior and exterior of the body, like a barrier that keeps animals inside their pen. But this little fence is too frail to keep human life locked inside. Achilles, an experienced looter and cattle thief, knows how easily

animals can be filched from their original owners, and how hard it may be to track down a stolen horse or herd. To recover a lost life is not hard, but impossible.

After the death of Patroclus, Achilles' wrath changes. He accepts Agamemnon's gifts, along with the return of Briseis. But he does so halfheartedly: his mind is elsewhere. Achilles' original losses—of the woman, of dignity, and of trust in Agamemnon—have become irrelevant compared to his far greater loss of his dearest friend, Patroclus. Death makes every other loss seem small. In this second phase, the object of his wrath shifts from Agamemnon to Hector, the killer of Patroclus, on whom he wants to inflict infinite pain and humiliation.

In this second phase, Achilles again refuses to accept any form of compensation. No amount of slaughter, no amount of humiliation, can ever or could ever make up for the loss of this beloved friend and companion, who is gone forever. Achilles dams up the River Xanthus with the corpses of Trojans, but it is not enough. He slays Hector, but killing the killer is not enough. Achilles then pierces Hector's ankles—a vicious reminder that the Trojan's legs were not fast enough to outrun the Greek's swift feet—threading strips of oxhide through them, and drags the naked body behind his chariot round and round the walls of Troy, again and again, day after day. The dead man's parents, wife, and people are made to watch the desecration of his corpse. Still it is not enough for Achilles. It will never be enough. He could humiliate Hector for all eternity, and Patroclus would still be dead.

It is only in the final two books, with the help of divine advice and human rituals of mourning, that Achilles begins to relent in his obstinate wrath. He recognizes at last that loss cannot be avoided or eliminated, and sometimes there is no possibility of adequate compensation. When we accept inadequate forms of compensation, knowing that they are not enough and that they are all there is, we can at least share in the universal experience of loss. Achilles shares his grief with his comrades in Book 23, through funeral rites and games to honor the dead man. In Book 24, he shares his grief even with his enemy: Priam, the old man whose son he has killed. Achilles welcomes Priam into his tent, sits and weeps with him, and says,

*Two jars are set upon the floor of Zeus—  
from one, he gives good things, the other, bad.  
When thundering Zeus gives somebody a mixture,  
their life is sometimes bad and sometimes good.  
But those he serves with unmixed suffering  
are wretched. Terrible starvation drives them  
across the shining world. They have no honor  
from gods or mortals.* (24.653–60)

Wine was generally mixed with water in antiquity and served from large mixing jars into cups. In Achilles' parable, one of the cosmic jars contains unmixed suffering, like a wine-jar with nothing but water. The other contains a mixture of a blessings and pain, like wine mixed with water. It is a drink for those who have experienced great honor and wealth, as well as terrible loss. Achilles now understands that he, like Priam, has been fortunate: he has known success, glory, and love, as well as loss. The implied third jar containing only blessings, like unmixed wine or ambrosia, is for only the immortal gods.

Achilles' wrath is driven by a belief that he, an extraordinarily talented, quick-footed fighter with divine blood in his veins, should never have to suffer loss without adequate compensation. His wrath can end only once he recognizes that no mortal, even the son of a goddess, can ever hope for such good fortune.

## The City of Troy

The wealthy ancient city, known as Wilusa to the Hittites, and Ilios or Troia to the Greeks, was built just to the south of the Dardanelles, in what was then Anatolia, now Türkiye. The location was an essential trading post because the narrow strait of water known to the Greeks as the Hellespont links the Mediterranean and Aegean seas with the Sea of Marmara and the Black Sea. Archaeologists have identified nine distinct layers of the city, representing multiple different eras of habitation followed by destruction, dating back as far as the Early Bronze Age; "Troy 0," the earliest identifiable layer, goes back as far as 3500 BCE. The city was destroyed many times, by earthquake, fire, and human conflict, and repeatedly rebuilt. There were many Troys, constructed one on top of the other over many centuries. There were many Trojan wars.

Those sailing past this coast in the eighth century BCE would have glimpsed the ruins of an ancient lost city, and large mounds associated with long-dead heroes. These mounds, so legend had it, included the tomb that held the bones of two loving comrades: Achilles, the greatest warrior who ever lived, and his dearest friend, Patroclus, both killed in war and buried together.

From ancient times, people have searched for the historical truth that might lie behind the myths about "the" Trojan War, and the city as described in *The Iliad*. Heinrich Schliemann in the 1870s was one of the earliest modern archaeologists to dig at the historical site known as Hissarlik. Schliemann, who shoveled his way through the mound of the ancient city, destroying invaluable evidence as he did so, was convinced he had discovered the real treasure of Priam. Contemporary archaeologists observe that Schliemann's treasures were far too old to correspond to the poem. They are from Troy

II, which was destroyed around 2300 BCE—over fifteen hundred years before the earliest possible dating of the written epic.

The Late Bronze Age city of Troy VI roughly corresponded with the flourishing of Mycenaean culture in the Greek-speaking world, when there were great palaces in places such as Mycenae, Pylos, Athens, Tiryns, and Thebes, with centralized economies and hierarchical power systems. This culture was literate, using a form of script known today as Linear B. Writing seems to have been used primarily for keeping records, so that the great lords could keep track of their wealth. Troy VI was destroyed around 1250 BCE, and at approximately the same time, many of the great Mycenaean palaces were destroyed, burned, or seriously damaged.

With the collapse of the palace economies that had required bookkeeping, Greek speakers lost the use of literacy for over three centuries. Bards developed tales about a bygone era, when great heroes, many half divine, killed monsters, sailed on adventures, interacted with goddesses and gods, performed extraordinary exploits, and fought in monumental wars around the majestic cities of Thebes and Troy.

Ancient audiences would have been familiar with many stories about the Trojan War. The title by which this poem has been known since antiquity, *The Iliad*, implies that its subject is the city known to the Greeks as Ilios or Troia—names associated with the city's legendary founder, Tros, and his son, Ilus. With divine aid, these kings built a mighty city, rich in gold and horses. But Laomedon, the son of Ilus, incurred divine anger when he forced two gods, Apollo and Poseidon, to build thick defensive walls for the city, and then broke his promise to pay them for their service. Thereafter, Poseidon and Apollo planned to destroy the city and its people.

A second set of divine machinations brought yet more trouble to Troy. An obscure sea goddess, Thetis, was desired by Zeus and Poseidon. But a prophecy foretold that the son of Thetis would be more powerful than his father. The Olympian gods forced Thetis into marriage with a mortal, because the existence of a deity greater than Zeus or Poseidon would threaten their own hold on cosmic power. They held a wedding for Thetis to marry Peleus, who would father Achilles. But they failed to invite Conflict (Eris) to the party. She showed up anyway, Malificent-style, and threw a golden apple amid the divine partygoers, inscribed with the word *kallistei*: “for her who is finest” (or “most beautiful” or “best”). Three goddesses—Hera, Athena, and Aphrodite—each claimed the apple, and a bitter quarrel ensued. Paris, a young son of Priam (then king of Troy), was chosen to adjudicate. All the contestants bribed the judge, in the hope of success. Hera offered power; Athena promised intelligence. But Aphrodite vowed to give him the most attractive woman in the world as his wife—Helen, a half-human daughter of Zeus who had been courted by every leading warrior in Greece. Paris chose Aphrodite.



Helen was already married to Menelaus of Sparta. Paris went to visit the happy couple and abducted her—a violation of the norms of hospitality (*xenia*). Inspired or enabled by Aphrodite, he took Menelaus' wife back to Troy. Helen went with him, either willingly or unwillingly; ancient accounts differ about her feelings, thoughts, and actions. Some say she never went at all but stayed in Egypt while the Greeks and Trojans fought over a phantom in her likeness. In any case, the loss of his wife was not welcome to Menelaus, a rich, powerful man, whose brother was the even more powerful king of Mycenae, Agamemnon. Moreover, Helen's former suitors had vowed to join forces to retrieve her if she slipped from the clutches of her chosen husband. Menelaus and his brother invoked the oath and worked to assemble a massive naval force, led by leaders from all over the Greek world, to set sail on Troy and make war, to recover Helen, and punish the Trojans.

The divine walls of Troy held firm, and the Trojans kept the enemy out of their city for ten years. Many of the greatest Greek warriors were killed, including Achilles, shot by Paris with an arrow through his heel (which was, according to legend, the only area where he could be hurt). Odysseus and Diomedes crept into the city and stole the statue of Athena from the citadel, thus ensuring that the city's divine protection was lost. Finally, Athena gave Odysseus the idea of creating a huge wooden horse, purportedly as a gift to the temple of Troy. Armed Greek warriors hid inside the structure, and when it was dragged inside, they leapt out, opened the gates for their comrades, and sacked the city. Priam and the other men, boys, and children of Troy were slaughtered. The surviving women were raped, enslaved, and taken by their enslavers to many different areas of Greece.

The outline of these stories was familiar throughout the archaic Greek-speaking world, along with many variations. We know about many of them from quotations and summaries of lost texts, such as the *Cypria*, the *Little Iliad*, and the *Aethiopis*, all non-Homeric epics about Trojan legends. Numerous ancient poets, dramatists, and visual artists recycled and reinvented this rich body of myth. And yet almost none of these stories appears directly in *The Iliad*. The poem avoids all the obvious highlights of the traditional story, including the Wooden Horse. It does not start at the beginning—with the Judgment of Paris, the wedding of Peleus and Thetis, the abduction of Helen, or the muster of ships at Aulis—or end with the fall of the city. Instead, the action takes place over a few days in the last year of the war—neither the beginning nor the end. A brief and ostensibly trivial episode—a squabble between two Greek commanders—becomes the subject of a monumental twenty-four-book epic.

Moreover, *The Iliad* eschews the obvious way for Greeks to tell the Trojan War story: as a conflict between “us” and “them.” The Trojans are not dishonest foreigners, despite the fact that Paris abducted his host's wife. Implausibly, they speak the same language and worship the same gods as the Greeks.

The poem is ancient from our perspective. But it came at the end, not the beginning, of a long poetic tradition. Whoever created *The Iliad* used the myths, tropes, and techniques developed by many generations of oral poets, and reinvented them to create an extraordinarily original and surprising written epic.

## Who and When Was Homer?

The singers of Iron Age Greece developed a world of stories that were repeated and altered in the course of many retellings. Bards chanted their songs with musical accompaniment, echoing and reinventing the tales they had heard from others.

The Homeric poems themselves are set in a world that is almost entirely illiterate. The only reference to writing comes in Book 6 of *The Iliad*, where a jealous husband sends Bellerophon, a man accused of trying to rape his wife, off to another rich man's house, bearing a tablet inscribed with instructions to kill the bearer. The writing, which is incomprehensible to Bellerophon himself, is described as “dangerous and deadly symbols” (6.226), because literacy is an unusual skill, liable to get people into terrible trouble. These great written epics evoke a distant world in which they themselves did not and could not exist.

But around the mid-eighth century BCE, Greek speakers borrowed the Phoenician alphabet, and the Greek world became literate again. Sometime between the late eighth and late sixth centuries, this new technology was used to create the two long poems attributed to Homer: *The Iliad* and *The Odyssey*. How, where, when exactly, and by whom the poems were made, we do not know. Maybe an oral poet, or several such poets, became literate. Maybe an illiterate or semiliterate poet, or group of poets, collaborated with one or more scribes, perhaps using dictation. Perhaps one great composer was named Homer (a name that was associated in antiquity with the word for “hostage,” *homeros*, although various other speculative etymologies were also posited). The composer may have been “a blind man who came from rocky Chios,” as the narrator of the *Hymn to Delian Apollo* asserts—although this was only one of numerous rival local legends about this most elusive of poets. Every statement about the historical person or people who composed *The Iliad* must be hedged with maybes. Ancient “lives” of Homer are set in the cloudy lands of biographical myth.

Somehow or other, the written poems had been produced by the late sixth century. But the Homeric poems were still often performed and experienced orally. Ancient rhapsodes (poetry-performers) provided entertainment at banquets, drinking parties, festivals, and competitions with thrilling dramatic renditions of passages from Homer. As happens with any popular performance text, *The Iliad* was altered in numerous ways by the creative performers who recited it over the course of many years—although such

variations were relatively small, compared to the vast variations possible within an entirely oral tradition. For instance, we know of alternative versions of Book 1, line 6, which reads either “a banquet for the birds,” *oionoisi te daita* , or “for all the birds,” *oionoisi te pasi* . But we do not have evidence of the kind of wholesale alterations in plot and characterization that we might expect if the poem were being reinvented without the use of a script. We do not know of an *Iliad* in which Hector kills Achilles, or an *Iliad* in which Patroclus survives—and arguably, such a poem would not be *The Iliad* . Rhapsodes presumably used written texts of the Homeric poems to learn their lines. Meanwhile, throughout antiquity, poets continued to tell, embellish, and invent other stories from the mythic cycle—including tales of heroes who are unmentioned or marginalized in *The Iliad* and many alternative versions of the old stories that are now lost to us forever.

The earliest extant texts of Homer, as of other archaic Greek literature, are fragments of the papyrus editions of Homer created in Egyptian Alexandria in the third century BCE, when scholars labored to establish fixed texts of these poems and other canonical works from the archaic and classical past. The ancient papyri were eventually copied by medieval scribes, whose manuscripts form the basis for all modern editions of *The Iliad* and *The Odyssey* , including the Oxford Classical Text, the Greek edition used for this translation.

It is usually illuminating to situate a work of literature in its own time and culture. But it is peculiarly difficult to do this with the Homeric epics, because they draw on the multiple distinct eras and places in which the oral poetic tradition developed. Homeric Greek is a mixture of dialects from different areas and periods, never spoken simultaneously by any single person—just as no speaker would employ Chaucerian, Victorian, Glaswegian, Californian, and Australian phrases and forms of English together in any normal conversation. In theme and content, too, the Homeric poems are a strange conglomeration. They look back to a fictionalized version of the Mycenaean past. But they also engage deeply with the much later cultural developments of their own time of composition, including widespread Greek colonization of non-Greek regions in the archaic period, as well as the expansion of trade routes across the Mediterranean and beyond. The Greek warriors in *The Iliad* , like the historical Greeks of the eighth and seventh centuries BCE, enrich themselves by sacking local towns and settlements, and appropriating goods, animals, and enslaved humans from those places. Their swift black ships are tools of colonization and conquest, as was the case for historical Greek captains, sailors, and pirates.

“Greece” did not exist as a political entity in the archaic period. Yet Greek speakers were becoming increasingly aware of their common identity. They also developed new pride in their own local communities and in newly flourishing city-states. The leading men of neighboring territories vied with one another through trade, sports, war, and

colonization. Some of the new city-states were governed by powerful autocrats known as tyrants, and others were ruled by an oligarchy (“the rule of the few”), in which a group of elite men, unrelated to each other by birth, shared power together. People became intensely aware of the presence of conflict, both between Greeks and non-Greeks, and within Greek communities. *The Iliad* reflects all these social and cultural changes, and reinvents myths of the distant past to become directly relevant to the concerns of its present: a time of intense rivalry between the Greeks themselves as well as between Greek speakers and their neighbors.

## Ten Tongues

The oral poetic heritage of *The Iliad* explains features of its style and poetic technique that are otherwise likely to seem puzzling. Oral poets had developed traditional ways of describing everything and everyone who might appear in a heroic story. These formulas made fluent oral storytelling much easier: there was no need to pause and come up with new adjectives for any proper name or noun. Achilles is “swift-footed” or “the son of Peleus,” Diomedes is “master of the war cry,” Agamemnon is “the son of Atreus, the lord of men.” Elite female characters always have white arms, trailing dresses, neat sashes, and well-braided hair. Such descriptors mark the characters’ honorable status in the narrative; they are not individual characteristics or fashion choices. Ships are generally “black,” “swift,” “well-balanced,” or “equipped with benches,” depending on the metrical requirements of the line. Known as epithets, such descriptors evoke a general characteristic of the object or person and are used even when they are irrelevant to the action or events described. The Greek ships remain “swift” despite having been stuck on a beach for the past ten years. Zeus is “cloud-gathering Zeus” even when the sky is clear. Achilles is “swift-footed” even when he spends many days sitting in his tent. Sometimes there are resonant ironies in the use of traditional epithets, as when Helen thinks of her brothers, not knowing that “they lay beneath the earth, the source of life” (3.298).

Oral poets also developed patterns for how to narrate particular kinds of scene, although there might be infinite variations on the general pattern. These include arming scenes; scenes of successful, glorious massacre (*aristeia*); scenes of sacrifice, hospitality, feasting, lament, mockery, and council discussions. *The Iliad* creates a virtuosic range of new variations on these limited traditional tropes. For instance, in Book 14, the general structure of an arming scene—typically used to describe male warriors preparing for an important battle—is used when the goddess Hera “arms” herself with a great outfit, fabulous skin creams, and the perfect accessories, before

setting out for her “battle” to seduce her brother-husband, Zeus, and distract him from his military plan.

Another traditional narrative technique prominent in *The Iliad* is the use of lists or catalogs. To a reader accustomed to the norms of modern prose, these passages may look off-putting on the page. Read them out loud: in mouth and ear, the long lists of names become music. Catalogs also serve to evoke the vast scale of the war and the world, and to gesture towards all the many people and events that are omitted from the narrative. The Catalog of Ships is long, but it suggests that there are many times more people at Troy than can ever be named. The poet needs something more than a normal human voice to tell such a vast story:

*I could not tell or name the multitude,  
not even if I had ten tongues, ten mouths,  
a voice that never broke, a heart of bronze. . . . (2.586–88)*

Catalogs give a human singer something like ten tongues: they enable a single poem to encompass the whole world and remember all the numberless dead.

Perhaps the most beautiful technique drawn from the oral poetic tradition is the extended simile. Similes, like catalogs, allow the narrative to contain far more worlds within itself than we might expect—including domestic activities in peacetime, vivid descriptions of animal behavior, and thrilling evocations of fire, snow, storms, and winds. Often these images create a sense of shifting scales—from small to vast, or from the human to the divine—as when Athena saves Menelaus by brushing an arrow gently aside,

*as when a mother strokes away a fly  
to keep it from her baby, sweetly sleeping. (4.169–70)*

Apparently abstract feelings can be represented by concrete imagery—as in this marvelous simile of a storm at sea, comparing a psychological crisis to a clash between winds and waves:

*as when two winds stir up the fish-filled water,  
Zephyr and Boreas, who all at once  
appear from Thrace and blast the sea—black waves  
crest high and clash haphazardly, and pour  
masses of seaweed from the salty depths—  
so the Greeks’ confidence was ripped apart. (9.5–10)*

The extraordinary poetic effects are created by alliteration and by the energetic pileup of verbs, as well as by the inclusion of numerous vivid details.

Extended similes usually have more than one point of comparison, and often provide unexpected insight into how the characters in the narrative feel. One of the great joys of Homeric poetics is the invitation to consider how each simile does and does not match its main point of comparison. So when the Trojans build fires out on the plain and wait for battle in the morning, the primary point of comparison in the simile is between the appearance of these fires, and the appearance of stars emerging suddenly from behind the clouds:

*Hearts high, they sat in lines arranged for war  
all night and burned a multitude of fires,  
as when around a dazzling moon, bright stars  
shine in the sky when no wind moves the air—  
all the high lookout points and tall clifftops  
and valleys suddenly are visible—  
the vast expanse of upper air breaks open,  
and all the stars are seen—the shepherd's heart  
is glad—so many were the gleaming fires  
burned by the Trojans on the plain of Troy. . . . (8.727–36)*

The fires are as bright and as revelatory as the stars, and the inclusion of the shepherd's perspective takes us, for a moment, to the emotional state of the Trojans. But the image is different as well as similar. The shepherd is glad because he looks forward to a peaceful day herding his animals in the sunshine, whereas the Trojans survey their watchfires with the optimism of warriors who hope to slaughter their enemies in the morning.

## Narrative Composition

In Book 18, Hephaestus builds a great shield for Achilles, depicting the whole world forged out of precious metals. There is a city at war, a city at peace, and numerous other images of people, animals, and the natural world, arranged with divine skill and encircled by the great River Ocean, which wraps around the earth itself. This shield parallels the composition of the poem itself, which also provides an image of the whole world, and does so through artfully symmetrical patterns, balancing one episode against another. Metallic images do not usually move, sing, dance, or speak, and yet the god's shield seems magically kinetic and noisy. The poem performs an analogous work of

magic: its purely verbal art seems to engage the eyes and hands as well as ears, through the artful manipulation of perspective.

The narrator shifts with ease from inside the city to the windswept plain, from an individual character's feelings to the sights and sounds of the battlefield, appearing before us as if from a god's eye view:

*they clashed together—shields of leather, spears,  
bronze-armored bodies, and fierce human will.  
Their shields collided and the metal bosses  
clanged in cacophony. On every side  
men shouted out in agony and triumph,  
killing and being killed. The earth was flooded  
with blood. . . . (4.596–602)*

Many diverse experiences—"agony and triumph, / killing and being killed"—are forged into a single story. We feel the thrill and glory of successful slaughter, and we feel equally clearly how it feels to watch the darkness cover your eyes for the last time.

Like the shield of Hephaestus, *The Iliad* contains multitudes within a single monumental composition. The poem repeatedly alludes to stories it does not tell directly—like the first gathering of the fleet at Aulis (told indirectly in the Catalog of Ships in Book 2); or the first abduction of Helen (told indirectly in the abduction of Helen in Book 3); or the theft of the statue of Athena by Diomedes and Odysseus (told indirectly in the night-raid episode of Book 10); or the sack of the city (told indirectly in the death of Hector). Through its artful use of parallel stories, the poem enfolds numerous different myths into its own encyclopedic narrative.

The shield of Hephaestus creates visual symmetry between one image and another: the city at war is balanced by the city at peace. So too in the poem. One warrior fights with gods (Diomedes in Book 5), as does another (Achilles in Book 21). One quarrel (between Agamemnon and Achilles) is mirrored by another (between Zeus and Hera). Imagery often invites us to hear an echo. For example in Book 1, a mother, Thetis, comforts her weeping child, Achilles, and grants him what he asks—a gift of honor that will cause his death. In Book 16, Achilles compares himself to a mother, with Patroclus as his weeping daughter. Like his own mother, Achilles agrees to the request of his short-lived "child."

But as on the shield, symmetry is not the only principle of composition. There are also separations that demarcate contrasting areas of the design: the pasture is separated from the dancing floor, the vineyard from the field of harvest. So too in the poem, there are breaks dividing sections of the narrative, like the walls and rivers that cross the great plain of Troy. Like other ancient texts, *The Iliad* is divided into "books" (not



“chapters”)—a unit whose size is limited by the length of a manageable scroll. But the division into twenty-four books, which was probably established significantly later than the original composition, is far from the only organizing pattern. The first nine books, beginning with the quarrel of Achilles and Agamemnon, culminate in the embassy, in which Achilles reiterates his position, and refuses to accept Agamemnon’s first attempt at reconciliation. In the next seven books (10–16), the Trojans grow ever closer to burning the Greek fleet, until Patroclus enters the battle and is killed. The final sequence of the poem, Books 17–24, show how Achilles’ feelings are transformed after the death of Patroclus.

Within this large three-act structure, there are several smaller units of story. Books 1–4 trace the failure of diplomatic solutions. Books 5–9 show the rise of Hector (while also introducing us to the warriors who lead the Greek war effort in Achilles’ absence, most notably Diomedes). Books 10–11 evoke two Greek missions into hostile spaces, one unsuccessful and one successful (providing symmetry at the heart of the poem). Books 11–15 focus on what is often dubbed the Great Battle, the long day of fighting in which Hector approaches the Greek ships and eventually, in Book 16, Patroclus dies. Books 17–22 describe the return of Achilles to the battlefield. Books 23 and 24 are another pair, with two counterpoised scenes of lament and mourning for the dead: the Greek Patroclus, celebrated with athletic games, and the Trojan Hector, lamented by the women.

*The Iliad* evokes the sublime magnitude of the world, and aims to entertain listeners for whom all the old tales of the Trojan War are deeply familiar. The narrative patterning is always complicated enough to ward off boredom and to suggest a grand plan beyond the ken of humans. The poem repeatedly confounds and surprises its listeners with the artful dispersal of narrative fog—just as Zeus, god of plotting and strategy, knows when to favor human warriors with a clear bright sky, and when to obscure their actions in a baffling thick mist. Even on the second or tenth or twentieth iteration, it is easy to feel lost, unsure which side has the upper hand or where the story is going. Patterns in one direction are crossed by countercurrents, like weft and warp on a loom.

The mythical story of the Trojan War presents the Greeks as the attackers, who push forward into the city of Troy, and destroy it. Yet *The Iliad*’s narrative arc moves in exactly the opposite direction. The great plan formed by Thetis and Zeus honors Achilles by making the Greeks suffer terribly in his absence. For much of the poem, it is the Trojans, not the Greeks, who are on the offensive. The Greek ships and camp are besieged by the troops of Hector and Sarpedon, who almost manage to burn this temporary home to the ground. The narrator makes us constantly worry for Greeks; even if we know that ultimately they will win the war, we are also shown how many smaller battles they will lose, and how many men die along the way.

But there are even deeper crosscurrents in the monumental plot. The tide of battle shifts and turns, like great winds and waves that “clash haphazardly” towards the shore and out again to sea. We can never assume we know what will happen in the thick of war. Despite the divine plan formed by Zeus and Thetis, the poem repeatedly pushes back again in the opposite direction—driven by the opposing plans of other deities and the prowess of other mortals. The Greeks achieve great victories through the zeal of Diomedes in Book 5. The multiple blockades set across the plain—the Greek wall and trench, and the river—echo the narrator’s artful ways of blocking the narrative momentum, ensuring that the endings we expect (the glorification of Achilles, the fall of Troy) cannot happen too soon, and can never be taken for granted. The spy mission in Book 10 and Hera’s seduction of Zeus in Book 14 both contribute to Greek success and Trojan loss, in contradiction to the primary narrative drive towards the triumph of Hector. The Great Battle sequence of Books 11 to 15 encapsulates the extraordinary way the poem deals with time and story on the battlefield, telling of a single, impossibly long day of fighting, in which the movement towards Trojan triumph and the burning of the ships is repeatedly counteracted with Greek pushback, and success and glory for several important warriors on both sides. Waves of defeat, panic, and bewilderment buffet both Greeks and Trojans. The plans of Zeus are repeatedly countermanded by the counterplots of Hera, Athena, and Poseidon, while Ares, god of war, rages across mortal divisions, causing terror and panic rather than ultimate victory for either side.

## Conflict and the Norms of War

“Conflict” (*eris*) appears at the start of Hesiod’s *Works and Days*, a didactic poem about rural life from the same era as *The Iliad*. Hesiod’s narrator declares that there are two types of conflict, one bad and one good. Bad conflict causes war and destroys communities, while good conflict motivates people to outdo their neighbors. When one potter competes with another, everyone wins. Even the less successful artisan ends up with a better piece of work.

But *The Iliad* suggests that “good” and “bad” kinds of conflict cannot be so easily disentangled. The desire to outdo rivals inspires brave, glorious actions, and also leads to massive loss of life. Battle is the “sphere where men win glory” (*kudianeira*), but also where many lose their lives—so war is also “the cause of many tears,” “the cause of so much grief” (*polydakrytos*, *polystonos*).

The work of war entails a constant struggle to gain glory or a win (*kudos*) and an opportunity to boast (*euchos*), which must be achieved by outdoing fellow warriors on the battlefield, gaining both the glory and the material wealth that comes from slaughtering, stripping, and humiliating the enemy. The more people you kill, the greater

your triumph. An individual fighter gains an *aristeia* (“bestness”—a period of extraordinary military success) when he robs numerous opponents of their lives, their weapons, and their honor, and thus shows himself the “best” among his peers. Warriors compete against not only their enemies but also, simultaneously, their own comrades, who are their rivals for the title of “best” (*aristos* ).

In the Greek encampment, there is constant potential for rivalry. All the leaders come from different homelands and lead separate assemblies of troops, and there is no clear order of command. Agamemnon is the richest and brings the most troops to Troy, but Achilles is the fastest, most athletic fighter—and Odysseus is best at strategy, Telamonian Ajax at heavy-armed close combat, Diomedes is a proven city-sacker who excels at chariot driving, Nestor is the oldest warrior with the longest memory, and Menelaus, master of the war cry, is the husband for whose wife the whole war is fought. The clash of incommensurable talents and interests creates irreconcilable conflict among the Greek leaders, as among the three “finest” goddesses. There is no agreement about how collaboration between different types of excellence might happen. Such differences might not matter if multiple leaders could share power, or if—as with Hesiod’s potters—there could be multiple winners and multiple forms of success. But in *The Iliad* , every great warrior wants to be the only winner, outperforming his peers, comrades, and allies as well as defeating his enemies.

The warrior’s glory (*kleos* ) is created by his community. People honor and praise the most successful fighters as if they were gods, and their names are remembered and handed down in songs such as *The Iliad* itself. The yearning for greater and greater honor drives the hero to ever-greater demonstrations of his own superiority. And yet the values and practices of the community also provide checks on the warrior’s yearning for success at any cost. Treaties and oaths can be formed even between enemies, and ratified by the gods. Supplication, as well as the possibility of taking prisoners alive rather than dead, offers the warrior a chance to display his capacity for mercy—and to gain further profit, because a living captive can be sold into slavery on the open market, whereas a dead one has no value except to his family. Battle generally takes place during the daylight hours; Ajax famously prays that he may at least die in the light. Both sides are expected to allow for breaks in the fighting so that the dead can be retrieved and buried with due honor.

*The Iliad* shows what happens when all these social norms are violated, and fighters push for victory at any cost. When Achilles reenters the battlefield after the death of his dearest friend, he refuses mercy to suppliants, mocks the idea of treaties, and rebuffs the usual temporal and social limits placed around the battlefield, such as pausing in the fighting to eat, rest, sleep, and wash. Achilles even pushes beyond the norms inscribed by the gods and by the natural world. He fills the river with corpses, and in a chilling episode in Book 21, the river god himself speaks out against him:

*“My lovely streams have been filled up with corpses.  
I cannot freely pour my waters down  
into the shining sea, because the bodies  
choke me, but you keep killing even more,  
annihilating everyone. Come on,  
leader of troops, stop now! This is too much.”* (21.288–93)

Achilles’ wrath is far deadlier than ordinary human rage, and Achilles pushes conflict beyond its usual bounds, by slaughtering with the indiscriminate rage of Ares himself—and then by desecrating his enemy’s body after death.

*The Iliad*, like *Works and Days*, treats conflict as an inevitable feature of life, both in war and in peace. But the final sequence of the poem marks a return to the norms that Achilles had violated in his wrath. The athletic games of Book 23 feature conflict without death, and the distribution of prizes without further conflict. In the final book, Achilles treats the suppliant Priam with mercy, and allows for a brief cessation of fighting to enable the dignified burial of his enemy Hector. The limitless wrath of Achilles can end only once he recognizes that no absolute, permanent victory is ever possible. Everyone must bear unbearable losses, for which no compensation could ever be enough. In the end, we all lose. Our best hope is to accept partial, temporary limits on conflict, accepting human companionship and community as our only, always inadequate compensation, for the pervasive experience of loss.

## The Code of Honor

The violence of war is enabled by preexisting social hierarchies: glorious leaders gain the resources to make war on one another because they already subjugate so many others. Vast quantities of wealth—weapons, animals, and human bodies—lie in the possession of a few well-born commanders. Most combatants at Troy receive no honor at all. The common troops (*laoi*) row the ships to Troy and populate the battlefield, but their deeds are unremembered, their deaths forgotten. They join the war out of necessity: Agamemnon and the allied Greek leaders impose fines on men who refuse to join the expedition to Troy (“the Greeks’ steep fine,” 13.884), making it economically ruinous to stay home. The common troops die of plague with the dogs, and when they die in battle, the dogs and birds will feed on their forgotten corpses. The presence of these underarmed, underequipped, and unwilling common fighters allows the leaders to win honor by rushing to battle ahead of them, clad in glittering bronze.

Only one named character may be a member of the common troops: Thersites, who may be a commoner, or perhaps a second-tier leader. He speaks out against the Greek

commanders in Book 2 and is described as “the ugliest man who marched on Troy” (2.259). Thersites is punished for his outspokenness by Odysseus, who thrashes him with his golden staff:

*a bloody weal puffed up beneath the rod  
of gold. He sat down, frightened and in pain  
and helplessly he wiped away his tears.* (2.327–29)

Odysseus’ violent response demonstrates the threat posed to the existing command structure by the possibility of resistance from below. The leaders are outnumbered and must force subordinates into line. The narrator’s emphasis on Thersites’ “ugliness” reinforces *The Iliad*’s preference for the aristocratic and sturdy warrior ideal. His silencing reminds us that we are in the world of heroic epic, not satirical or comic poetry (rival genres that were also popular in archaic Greece). Yet Thersites’ critique of the leadership of the expedition is reminiscent of Achilles, who also insists that it is pointless to risk his life shoring up wealth for Agamemnon.

In contrast to the common troops, who are forced to fight, the dominant warriors in *The Iliad* choose to risk death in battle for the sake of honor. The poem itself glorifies these brave fighters, showing us the beauty and magnificence of those who willingly risk death in battle. It also shows the terrible dangers and costs of the warrior code—not only for the numberless, largely nameless people killed, raped, and enslaved by the most brilliant celebrity fighters, but even for the warriors themselves.

Elite fighters always have “excellence” (*aretē*), because of their skill in fighting and their noble birth. But they also aspire to the highest possible social status—a position that always depends on the opinions and actions of others. Honor is often acquired through material possessions—and these things can be lost or taken away. A “trophy” or “prize of honor” (*geras*) is a piece of important property, awarded to the most successful or honorable warriors once a battle has been won. These trophies include the most highly valued women enslaved after the sack of a city or settlement, as well as other valuable possessions, such as tripods (made of valuable metals like bronze or gold) or herd animals (for food and sacrifice). Briseis, awarded first to Achilles and then seized by Agamemnon, is such a trophy. The quarrel of these two leaders reveals the double-sidedness of such possessions as generators of status. A man who enslaves a valuable woman increases his own status by doing so. But his social position also becomes dependent on his ability to retain possession of her, because it is humiliating to be deprived of a prize. The same applies to prizes won in athletic competitions (*aethlia*, from which we get the word “athletics”).

The possession of trophies, prizes, and other honorific goods, such as the finest cuts of meat at a banquet, or lavish funeral honors in death, all contribute to a man’s portion

of social status or value in society (*timē*). A person who has been robbed of such objects can demand recompense (also *timē*), as Menelaus does in his demand that the Trojans return his wife and all the other wealth stolen from Sparta by Paris. Through lavish gifts, Agamemnon tries to compensate Achilles for the humiliation of the original quarrel.

Status is also built out of language (*kleos*, a noun cognate with the verb *kaleo*, to “call” or “name”). Warriors are inspired to fight by the promise of praise and memory in stories like the poem itself. Homeric men use each other’s full names, titles, and patronymics to show their respect for one another, and to acknowledge their place within a larger social system, as sons, grandsons, and comrades of other men, and as leaders from particular places. Warriors are also inspired to fight by the threat of shame if they shirk from battle. Some of the most common terms of insult involve comparing the opponent to an animal (“dog!”), or suggesting that he is a gymnast or dancer rather than a warrior, or impugning his gender identity (for instance when Thersites calls his fellow fighters “girls, not men,” at 2.282).

The leaders with the highest status—like Agamemnon, Achilles, and Hector—are most vulnerable to the threat of shame. Any slight, such as an insult or the loss of a particular prize, may threaten a leader’s whole identity as well as his standing in the eyes of his peers and his inferiors. The furious insults hurled by Achilles and Agamemnon at each other in Book 1 may seem overblown or even ridiculous, unless we realize how much both men have to lose from even the smallest diminution of honor. Those who are the greatest winners can be damaged most by any loss. Privilege entails terrible vulnerability.

The elite warrior earns his social privileges, such as the best cuts of meat at banquets, by fighting at the front lines of battle and thus risking his life. This trade is worthwhile, as Sarpedon movingly explains, because nobody, even those without any honor at all, gets to live forever. Zeus never serves any human from the third jar.

*“You see, my brother, if we could escape  
this war and then be free from age and death  
forever, I would never choose to fight  
or join the champion fighters at the front,  
nor would I urge you to participate  
in war where men win glory. But in fact,  
a million ways to die stand all around us.  
No mortal can escape or flee from death.  
So let us go. Perhaps we shall succeed,  
and win a triumph from another’s death,  
or somebody may triumph over us.”* (12.395–405)

Sarpedon, a mortal son of Zeus, will lose his life at Troy, although his divine father weeps for him and wishes he could be saved.

Sarpedon, a Lycian ally who has traveled to Troy to help the Trojans against the Greeks, is presented as a team player, admirably focused on the collective need to defend the people of the region from the invaders. He speaks not of why “I” should risk my life, but why “we” should do so. His warrior ethic is founded explicitly on the trade of life for honor, but implicitly on the close bond he has with his comrade, Glaucus—as well as his other fellow fighters.

But Sarpedon’s public-spiritedness is not easy for an elite warrior to maintain. The desire to outdo peers and gain glory can isolate the greatest fighters from their own communities, and even from their closest comrades and family members. In a terrible irony, the warrior’s high-risk behavior in battle both wins him social approval and also isolates him from his own society. The two greatest fighters in the poem—the Trojan Hector and the Greek Achilles—frame the warrior code in tragically solitary terms. The poem traces the terrible slippage between fighting for one’s people, and fighting for individual glory.

When Hector bids farewell to his wife, Andromache, in Book 6, she echoes the words of his parents and begs him not to fight alone outside the city walls. She reminds her husband that he risks not only his own life, but his whole city, which will fall after he is killed. His baby son will be thrown from the city walls by the victorious Greeks. Hector’s rash courage also endangers Andromache herself, who knows that she may soon be widowed, raped, and enslaved. Hector responds that he knows that Troy will fall, and that Andromache will be enslaved—as if these things were inevitabilities, rather than the result of his own choices.

*“You see, my heart and mind  
know this for sure—that there will be a day  
when holy Troy will be destroyed, and Priam,  
lord of the ash-wood spear, and all our people.  
But no one matters more to me than you.”* (6.606–10)

Hector loves his wife. He genuinely minds that she will be widowed and enslaved. But he does not mind enough to risk his honor. As he notes, death will at least spare Hector from hearing his wife’s screams—a thought that may not be particularly comforting to Andromache.

The little child, Astyanax, is frightened by his father’s helmet, and shrinks away from him:

*The baby wailed and wiggled back to snuggle  
into his well-groomed nurse's lap and dress.  
The child was scared by how his father looked,  
shocked at the terrifying horsehair plume  
that nodded at the top part of his helmet.*(6.636–40)

The parents laugh, and Hector takes off his helmet for a moment—but only to pray that his son will grow up to be a warrior, like himself, and will bring back bloody armor to make his mother happy. The baby, who will in fact never grow big enough to wear a man's armor, is right to be frightened of the helmet. But soon Hector puts it back on and resumes his role as a warrior, declaring, “War is a task for men—for every man / born here in Troy, but most especially, me.” He knows that his own choices will hasten the catastrophe, not only for himself but for his city and his family. But the dread of shame, the desire to win a good name for himself, and the pressure of his social role as a warrior are overwhelmingly strong motivations.

*“Woman, I care about all these things too.  
But I feel overwhelming shame in front of  
the Trojan women in their trailing dresses  
and Trojan men, if I shrink back from war  
as if I were a coward. And my spirit  
tells me I must not stop, for I have learned  
always to be a warrior and fight  
among the frontline champions of Troy,  
to win great glory for the king my father  
and for myself.”*(6.597–606)

This speech is sometimes described as if it were about Hector's desire to defend his people. But both husband and wife agree that Hector should defend Troy. They disagree about how he should do so. Andromache wants Hector to stay on the city wall and defend its most vulnerable spot from invaders, rather than march out to meet the enemy on the plain, where he is likely to be killed (and thereby become useless as a defender). For her, the priority is the safety of the city and the family, and she suggests a pragmatic strategy for keeping the Greeks out of her home. For Hector, the priority is his own individual glory (*kleos*). Fighting alone, out ahead of all his fellow fighters, is his best chance of avoiding the pain of humiliation for himself—even if this prize is won at the cost of everything and everybody else.



The tragic death of brave, honorable Hector is necessary, in that it is an element of the mythic tradition. All listeners are expected to know that he will die. But the poem could have shaped this story in any number of different ways. The Iliadic narrator presents Hector's doom as the result of his own choices, but more fundamentally, as the result of the warrior code. To do what the nameless, perhaps partly imaginary Trojan women expect of a war hero, Hector must reject what his own people actually need. The collective desire to see a lone warrior act with glorious courage puts everyone at risk.

Hector so thoroughly internalizes the social pressures about how warriors should act that he is estranged from the society he hopes to please. He is a loving and devoted family man who repeatedly abandons his family, to win glory and demonstrate superiority in battle. In Book 6, and again in Book 22, Hector resists his family's appeals to remain in the city, and instead goes to his death. Hector's loneliness and estrangement from his loved ones, prompted by his intense desire for social approval, adds pathos to the heartbreak of the moments immediately before Hector's death, when he suddenly realizes that the gods have tricked him and led him to his doom. He thinks that he has been blessed by Zeus and accompanied by his brother, Deiphobus—but he is, and always has been, alone.

Achilles exhibits comparable estrangement from his own people in his deadly and overwhelming wrath against Agamemnon—and this estrangement, too, is the result of Achilles' attachment to the warrior code of honor. In Book 1, Achilles swears a great oath by the staff used as the speaking stick in the Greek council, and describes how the staff has been cut from a tree on the mountain, and will never return to its roots:

*It was cut upon the mountain  
and left its stump behind, and it will never  
sprout with fresh shoots, because the bronze has stripped  
its leaves and bark. (1.315–18)*

Like this staff, the fighters at Troy, even the Trojans, are far from their families, and most will never go home again.

Yet the poem's grand narrative tells how two estranged warriors find a way back into their communities, although neither comes home alive. Through his overwhelming grief for Patroclus and recognition of his own mortality, Achilles is reconciled with his surviving comrades for the brief time that remains to him. Hector rejoins his family and his city, although only after death.

## Fate and the Portions of Life

At a Homeric banquet, each warrior hopes to receive at least an equal share of meat. The most important leaders receive even more, taking the best cuts of meat and full cups of strong wine as a reward for their service and as a marker of their social superiority. Social systems of sharing resources, as with meat at a feast, provide the primary imagery for a concept we might call “fate” or “luck.” Every person has a specific share or measure of life (*moira* , *moros* , *aisa* , all words connoting a “share” of life and luck, or *to peprōmenon* , “what is given”), weighed out and apportioned in the scales of Zeus, or spun by mysterious goddesses, the personified Fates.

Thetis is outraged when Agamemnon disrespects her son, because she assumes that a man’s share of life should correlate to the apportionment of honor. Sarpedon’s small “portion” of life is compensated by his large share of wine, meat, and honor. Similarly, Achilles is destined to receive only a small serving of days under the sun. He is “short-lived” (*minuthadios* ), and therefore, his mother insists, he should receive a larger portion of glory, and be able to avoid the pain and grief apportioned to him by Agamemnon’s mistreatment.

*“I wish you could sit quietly by your ships,  
and never have to suffer tears or trouble,  
because it is your destiny to live  
so very short a time, not long at all.”* (1.549–52)

Beyond his personal anger at Agamemnon’s rude behavior, Achilles’ wrath is motivated by the sense of cosmic unfairness. As the son of a goddess and the quickest, bravest, most athletic of all the Greek leaders, he feels entitled to the largest servings of honor, prizes, comfort, and life. And yet his allotment falls pitifully short in every single category.

Servings at the cosmic banquet are never fair, as even Achilles eventually understands. Even in carefully controlled settings—like real banquets, where participants always receive fair shares of meat, and like the funeral games of Book 23, where there are unlimited prizes to go around—it takes careful management to ensure universal satisfaction. In the apportionment of more nebulous prizes, like social status, success, and days of life, nobody gets everything they want. Most people get nothing at all. Their servings come only from the jar of pain.

To create a partial balance in the cosmic scales, every success brings the warrior closer to death. This is true in a special way for Achilles, because of the prophecy that he will die if he decides to stay at Troy. He must choose between a larger quantity of life, and a larger quantity of honor; he cannot receive both. Achilles knows what is at

stake for him when he finally rises up from his prostrate grief and rejoins the battlefield in Book 19. That choice will cause the deaths of Hector and other Trojans, and ultimately the fall of Troy, and also the death of Achilles himself. Soon after he kills Hector, he must die, as he himself knows.

Achilles' intimate awareness of death, including his own, gives him a chilling power on the battlefield. He tells Lycaon, a Trojan who begs him for his life,

*"So die, my friend. Why are you so upset?  
Patroclus has already died as well,  
and he was far superior to you."* (21.141–43)

Knowledge of death motivates Achilles to kill with terrifying gentleness and dispassion, calling his enemy "my friend" even as he ends his life. Achilles, who strums a looted lyre and sings "heroic stories" (9.241), here comes as close as a character within the poem can get to the perspective of a poet, or a god.

For most fighters, death in battle is a possibility, not a certainty. Warriors choose to risk death for glory, but the mistiness of the future allows them to fantasize that they might be able to have it all: to win a great victory and still come home alive. The tragic pathos of the mortal warrior's vain hopes of survival is evoked most touchingly in the figure of Hector, who knows in theory that he may die in battle. But he also, repeatedly, dismisses human advisors and divine portents that point to danger. He talks grandly of "destiny" or "apportionment" (*moira*), as when he tells Andromache,

*"No man can send me to the house of Hades  
before my time. No man can get away  
from destiny, first set for us at birth,  
however cowardly or brave he is."* (6.662–65)

Hector's phrasing suggests an optimistic fantasy that he may be destined to survive his journey outside the city. He insists that he cannot die "before my time" (beyond *aisa*)—but does not consider the less positive corollary, that he cannot survive after his allotted time of death. When Polydamas warns him that a Trojan attack on the Greek ships is destined to be unsuccessful, as a bird sign (from an eagle) has shown, Hector insists on pushing ahead, dismissing the portents and declaring,

*"Patriotism is the one true bird."* (12.293)

This famous line suggests that Hector imagines that his allotted destiny could be under his own control: courage is the only fate he needs.

Hector is no fool, and his overconfidence is not merely the result of egotism. It is nurtured and encouraged by the gods, especially Zeus—who needs Hector to succeed temporarily, in order to fulfill his promise to Thetis by enabling Trojan success. Like most mortals, Hector cannot grasp the whole of the misty plans of Zeus. He realizes too late that he has been deliberately misled by the gods, exclaiming, “The gods have called me to my death” (22.399). Hector, like most of us, understands the inevitability of his death only when his allotted time has already run out.

Length of life and time of death are apportioned by the Fates, the gods, and the scales of destiny. But they are also served out by the narrator of the poem, and by the poetic tradition. The audience is always more aware of Hector’s destiny than he is because we know his story ahead of time. The destined time of death or disaster is sometimes evoked through the metaphor of a rope or net, cast over the doomed person or doomed city and pulled taut—as when disaster is “fastened tight” to the Trojans (6.326). It is destined that Troy will eventually fall, according to myth as well as fate—if the two can be distinguished. There is no version of the Trojan War story in which the Trojans win. Achilles and Hector can never survive the war. The mysterious plans of Zeus echo the unfolding plan of the poem itself. Both involve an ongoing tension or tug of the rope, between what must ultimately happen (such as the fall of Troy) and the possibilities for the story to go in different directions in the meantime (as when Zeus temporarily lets Hector succeed).

It is Helen, daughter of Zeus, who most clearly articulates the relationship between her father’s plans and those of the poetic tradition:

*“Zeus set an evil lot upon us all,  
to make us topics of a singer’s tale  
for people in the future still unborn.”* (6.479–80)

Helen knows that she is destined to play a part in *The Iliad* itself. According to the lost epic the *Cypria*, Zeus designed the Trojan War in order to reduce the pesky population of humans. He needed only two elements: Helen, the premise for the war, and Achilles, its greatest warrior. Without Helen’s abduction, there could be no war. Without the Trojan War, there is no story. Like Achilles, Helen has a particularly broad perspective on the wider narrative in which she plays a crucial part: she can view and name all the Greek warriors from the walls of Troy (in Book 3), and she can represent their stories in her weaving:

*. . . a massive double-layered cloth  
in dazzling colors, patterning upon  
the many troubles, tests, and tribulations  
that Trojan horsemen and bronze-armored Greeks  
suffered at Ares' hands because of her.*(3.155–59)

Neither Achilles, nor Helen, nor the poet, can change the outcome of the Trojan War, or save any mortal from death. But each can offer a sense of the larger story within which each life's thread is woven.

Patroclus, Hector, and Sarpedon—and ultimately also, Achilles, Priam, and all the other men and boys in Troy—must die. All the women will be seized and enslaved, and the beautiful lofty city of windy Troy will be sacked and burned to the ground. We always know that these things are destined to happen. But *The Iliad* makes us feel the excitement and the heartbreak of these well-known, entirely predictable plot points, by nurturing doomed hope, dwelling on what happens before the rope of destiny is pulled tight, when the endings of the characters' stories seem, for a brief moment, undecided. The impossible seems only just out of reach. We seem so close to the alternative story, when the scales might turn the other way, these brave young men might not have to die, these women might not lose their homes and their freedom, and the city of Priam could have remained standing into future times.

## Emotions

Hector makes a short but momentous journey in the course of the poem. He travels from the city of Troy to the Greek ships, and back again. But he also makes a cognitive and emotional journey, from courageous confidence to a final realization of his own mortality. Swift-footed Achilles barely moves at all for three-quarters of the poem, until he finally rises up in Book 19. He shifts from overwhelming wrath against Agamemnon and his fellow Greeks to rage against Hector and the Trojans, and finally to grief and a deeper understanding of the inevitability of loss.

Epic poems describe the famous deeds of men (*klea andrōn*). But *The Iliad* is a strange kind of action story, in which feelings—fear, joy, lust, aggression, love, rage, sorrow—often seem to matter more than external behaviors. The first word in the Greek original, *mēnin* (from *mēnis*, “wrath”) denotes Achilles' deadly and superhuman rage; the term is usually applied to the anger of gods. *The Iliad* ends with a different and fully human emotion: the desperate grief of mortal women over the death of Hector, the imminent fall of Troy, and the end of their freedom.

Emotions have their own agency: no Homeric character suggests that one could ever entirely avoid unpleasant or dangerous emotions. The desire to fight and kill can be as overwhelming as hunger, and war can become even “sweeter” than the dream of returning home. Fighting can become an immersive experience, comparable to the intense, total engagement of participation in dancing, sports, or acrobatics. Rage, grief, weariness, panic, fear, and energetic zeal all “take,” “seize,” or “enfold” the person. Panic and fear, or their counterparts, aggression and the passionate eagerness to fight that seizes men on the battlefield (*menos* and *thymos*), are all located in the body, as when Oilean Ajax tells Telamonian Ajax, “My feet and hands are itching for a fight” (13.95). These impulses inspire men, deities, and even horses to dash away from the battle in terror, or rush into the middle of the action.

Homeric characters express their intense emotions in ways that are likely to be alien to many modern readers. Men regularly show their rage by hurling inventive insults and threats at one another, even in the midst of battle. Warriors slap their thighs and groan aloud in grief or frustration. Weeping, screaming, shouting, and sobbing are treated as normal expressions of grief, including male grief.

Some emotions, such as fear and shame, are treated as less honorable and less manly than others. Leaders spur their peers and subordinates into battle by threatening them with dishonor if they yield to fear, and by whipping up their aggressive impulses. The eager will to fight (*menos*) drives men to risk their lives for the hope of glory, even when they feel no personal anger against the men they kill. The will to fight is closely related to anger, but it is not motivated by any particular slight or loss, and lacks a specific object. This kind of aggression can be just as dangerous as anger for the fighter himself: Andromache tells Hector, “Your will to fight will kill you!” (6.550)—and she is right.

The full range of emotions, including the ability to express rage, is available only to the most powerful beings in the Homeric universe: deities and the greatest men. Chryses, the priest of Apollo, must move far away along the beach before he can safely express his rage at the Greeks for the abduction and enslavement of his daughter. Women regularly express grief over their slaughtered menfolk, but never anger about what they themselves suffer. Chryses tells his anger to the god Apollo and achieves revenge against the Greeks on behalf of his kidnapped daughter—but Chryseis herself does not speak. Hecuba, the most powerful mortal woman in the poem, is exceptional in her ability to articulate her incandescent rage. She longs, like Hera, to destroy and even devour those who have wronged her, declaring of Achilles,

*“I wish I could latch  
my teeth into the center of his liver  
and eat it!”* (24.267–69)

But even Hecuba expresses anger on behalf of her son, rather than herself.

Among deities and godlike men, anger (*cholos*) is a normal response to any insult, injury, or loss, such as the killing of a loved one. Anger implies both a sense of being wronged, robbed, or hurt, and an insistent desire to impose equivalent suffering on those responsible for the wrong. Achilles' extraordinarily high status is confirmed by the extraordinarily high rate of casualties that result from his wrath—on the Greek as well as the Trojan side.

And yet rage is shown to be destructive for the enraged person himself, as well as for those who die as a result. After the death of Patroclus, Achilles expresses regret at his own rage, which is the ultimate cause of his beloved friend's death as well as the deaths of so many others. He describes anger itself (*cholos*) as a force that enters the body, and may seem sweet at first, although it becomes bitter:

*"I wish anger  
did not exist. Even the wisest people  
are roused to rage, which trickles into you  
sweeter than honey, and inside your body  
it swells like smoke. . . ."* (18.135–39)

The imagery suggests a parallel between anger and the myth of the Wooden Horse: it is welcomed in, like a gift, but insidiously becomes destructive to the enraged person himself as well as those around him.

The feelings that spur men to fight include love and grief as well as rage, aggression, and the fear of shame. Men fight to save their loved ones, families, and comrades, both living and dead. This is more obviously true for the Trojans than the Greeks, because they are fighting to protect their homeland, their city, and their families. There is a vast difference between the deadly plain and the battlefield beyond the city's walls, and the intimate domestic space inside the city, where women, old and young, enslaved and free, prepare clothes, baths, and meals, and take care of children.

The love of men for women has little place in the world of the Greek encampment. Agamemnon and Achilles quarrel over women (Briseis and Chryseis), and the Trojan War resulted from the rivalry of Paris and Menelaus over another woman (Helen). But the female "trophies" seized in war are desirable as markers of status, not because of any romantic connection. The warriors' relationships with the numerous women whom they capture, claim, and enslave are generally brief and trivial compared to their relationships with one another—despite Agamemnon's grandiose claim that he values Chryseis more highly than his legitimate Greek wife, Clytemnestra. There is no mention of any children in the Greek camp, even though the warriors have been seizing and raping female captives for almost ten years.

For the Greeks encamped at Troy, far from their parents, children, and wives, if they have any, the most intimate loving relationships are with each other. Homeric chariots are pulled by two horses and have room for two men—one to drive and one to fight. These pairs of men share the work of war, and often share an intimate fraternal and/or romantic love as well. Many of the most prominent Greek warriors work in pairs, like the Cretans Idomeneus and Meriones, or the two named Ajax (not brothers, but close friends), or the two Lycian allies of Troy, Glaucus and Sarpedon. On the Greek side, Diomedes and Sthenelus fight closely together, and Diomedes fantasizes that, if the other Greeks give up and go home, they might stay together and sack the city together, just the two of them—“we two, Sthenelus and I” (9.57). The love between a pair of warrior comrades is distinct from the warrior’s feelings about his larger society, which may be far more distanced—or even, as in Achilles’ case, entirely alienated. Many of the most intense battles in the poem hinge on the desire of one group of fighters to strip a dead enemy of his weapons, and the desire of his comrades to reclaim his honor by taking him home for a proper funeral. The battle is often constructed out of a series of interpersonal vendettas: Achilles is one of many warriors motivated by the desire to avenge a beloved friend killed in action.

The devoted love between Achilles and Patroclus drives the final third of the poem. Patroclus dies as Achilles’ second self, dressed in his armor, using his weapons, and serving as leader of the Myrmidons in his stead. Achilles’ desperate grief for Patroclus inspires his wrath against Hector—and will ultimately ensure his own death, so that the two men die for each other, albeit not at the same time. From at least the fifth century BCE onward, readers have assumed that Achilles and Patroclus were lovers, although *The Iliad* itself does not say so. Both sleep with enslaved women at their side, although they also sleep beside each other.

The Homeric narrator does not make the common modern assumption that the closest and most important relationships must be sexual and does not assume any particular connection between sex and intimacy. The most detailed sex scene in *The Iliad*—the vivid comic episode in Book 14 where Hera seduces Zeus to distract him from battle with a solid nap afterwards—shows how sex can be weaponized. Sex between Hera and Zeus measures their distance, not their closeness. We glimpse, in the brief sex scene in Book 3 between the impassioned Paris and the reluctant Helen, that sex can be both nonconsensual and anticlimactic; the buildup is full of drama and extraordinarily momentous (in that this scene serves as a replay of the original abduction of Helen), but the actual sex is formulaic and finished in a single line. *The Iliad* marks out its areas of interest, in the public sphere, communities, and warfare, and its relative lack of interest in the spheres presided over by Aphrodite, the weakest and most ridiculous deity on the battlefield. The marginalization of sexual desire (*erōs*) as a topic for poetry is part of *The Iliad*’s definition of its own generic identity, with its



focus on grand, mythical wars, gods, heroes, and mortality—in contrast to the kinds of archaic Greek lyric poetry that focused on desire, love, marriage, or pleasure, of which we have extant examples in the fragmentary poems of Sappho, Alcaeus, and Mimnermus.

Domestic and familial intimacy is evoked in other terms: through the preparation of food, and the care and cleansing of the bodies of loved ones, whether living or dead. The depth and intimacy of the bond between Achilles and Patroclus is like that of husband and wife, in that they share a domestic life together, with a shared set of furniture and a shared retinue of enslaved people under their command. In Book 9, it is Patroclus, not one of the enslaved women, who prepares food for Achilles and his guests—as a wife might do.

Achilles' old tutor, Phoenix, speaks of how Meleager was brought back by the intervention of his wife, "Cleo-patra"—whose name is an inverted and feminized version of "Patro-clus." The relationship between the two men is compared to that of a parent and a child, as when Achilles tells Patroclus that he is nagging and begging him like a little girl, tugging her mother's dress (16.8–11), and at 18.393, the grieving Achilles is like a mother lion who has lost her cubs. In the most extreme moments of his grief for his most beloved person, Achilles presents Patroclus not as his child, parent, or wife, but as himself.

The ultimate form of love is to see no difference between the self and the beloved. Patroclus' journey into battle wearing the armor of Achilles transforms him into his friend, in the eyes of the Trojans. He becomes Achilles also, tragically, in his violent death before the walls of Troy, killed by Trojans through the help of Apollo, just as Achilles soon will be. Once Patroclus is dead, Achilles tries to transform himself into his dead friend, by rolling in the dust and, like a dead man, abstaining from food, sleep, or sex. He anticipates joining Patroclus again, and becoming indistinguishable from him in death, when their bones are together in one jar.

Grief is closely allied with anger. They are expressed with similar sounds: moans, groans, shouts, and screams. Like anger, grief responds to a terrible loss or terrible harm done—but without any sense of the possibility of reparation. Anger turns the pain outward, against others; grief turns it inward, to the self. People subsumed by rage try to replicate the wrongs they have suffered by hurting others. Those consumed by grief long to turn their own bodies into that of the dead loved one, by lying down in the ground, cutting the hair, scratching the face, and rolling in the dust. The enraged want to humiliate, hurt, or kill; the grief-stricken want to be dead and to inhabit the perspective of the dead.

But grief is different from anger, because it can be expressed and experienced collectively. Through the funeral rites and games for the dead Patroclus in Book 23, Achilles shares his loss with other Greek warriors, just as the Trojans in Book 24 are

able to share their grief at the death of Hector. Even enemies, like Priam and Achilles, can share a moment of grief. Anger drives communities apart; grief brings them together, over a shared acknowledgment of irredeemable loss.

## The Mortal Body

At the center of *The Iliad* is the mortal human body. The poem focuses especially on the bodies of strong men at the height of their physical power, in all their glorious beauty and all their terrible vulnerability—as in the famous simile evoking the wounding of Menelaus' thigh:

*At once the wound gushed blood as black as clouds,  
as when a woman from Maeonia  
or Caria stains ivory with purple  
to make a horse's cheekpiece, which is stored  
inside an inner chamber, and great numbers  
of charioteers are longing to possess it,  
but it is saved as treasure for a king,  
a beautiful decoration for the horse,  
and glory for the driver—Menelaus,  
so were your handsome thighs all stained with blood,  
so were your handsome calves and shapely ankles. (4.181–91)*

The narrator speaks directly to Menelaus, as occasionally happens at moments of high emotion. The simile suggests that this leg becomes even more beautiful and valuable for being stained with blood. The pain and violence are essential elements in the aesthetics of war.

The bodies of the finest warriors are usually clad in complex suits of bronze armor: a helmet, a breastplate that sometimes covers both front and back of the torso, a shield, and greaves on the legs are all common accessories. These warriors carry multiple weapons: light spears for throwing, heavy spears for thrusting at close quarters, a sword for hand-to-hand combat. Some have a bow and arrows. Some ride on war chariots, pulled by a pair of horses (the horses almost always serve only to pull the chariots, rather than to be ridden). Many also wear capes or cloaks of fur, and underclothes of leather or linen. All this splendid technology transforms the body itself into a well-crafted weapon of war. And yet war demonstrates the inadequacy of even the most elaborate equipment to protect even the most skillful young warriors from death. Sharp weapons pierce through the glittering bronze like so much tinfoil, and the

poem always makes us feel the pain and loss of the victim, who has a name, parents and a homeland to which he will never return.

The horror of war is stained, like ivory, with beauty. We feel the joy of the spear at tasting human flesh, and the purely sensory details: the gleam of metal, the softness or wetness of the muscle and blood, the noisy clash of armor and bones as they hit the ground. The triumphant warrior demonstrates his creativity in finding, repeatedly, new ways to unloose the ties that briefly tie together our short-lived human limbs. The heartbreaking sequences of death piled on death are also an opportunity for poetic virtuosity: apparently endless narrative variation can be created out of a tiny repertoire of tropes. Every death is the same: sharp bronze pierces flesh, the armor clatters around the falling victim, darkness covers the eyes, the knotted limbs unravel, the armor clatters to the ground as the victim falls. Every death is also different. If one man is killed with a spear through the throat, the next will take the bronze through a different body part—flank, back, chest, liver, nose, buttocks, ear, ribs, nipple, skull, right side or left, front or back. Killing can be performed with a wide variety of means: light throwing-spear, heavy thrusting-spear, sword, arrow, stone, axe. The most impressive heroes can even kill each other by doing nothing at all: Achilles' inaction is the ultimate cause of almost all the Greek casualties and injuries depicted in the poem.

Most physical wounds in *The Iliad* are fatal immediately. The poet does not ruin the pace by making us wait to find out if a character has bled out or died of infection. These deaths are often anatomically implausible or impossible, as in the repeated motif of eyeballs popping from the skull as the result of a blow; vividness and emotional impact take priority over realism. Sometimes, the means of death have a particular appropriateness for the character or scene, as when Pandarus boasts, and then has his tongue sliced off (5.385). More often, death is simply the consequence of mortality. Bodies of flesh, blood, and bone, surrounded by sharp bronze weapons, are liable to die.

But there are exceptions. Wounds to wrists, hands, or lower legs tend to be relatively trivial. Several warriors, including Menelaus, Agamemnon, Diomedes, and Odysseus, sustain such injuries and survive—as does Aphrodite. One of the Greeks, Machaon, serves as doctor to the wounded, and Nestor also has access to a medicinal drink that seems to help heal those injured in battle. Patroclus, who has been taught medicine by the Centaur Chiron, aids the wounded Eurypylus—a mark of his kindness and his belief in the possibility of improvement. Healing is an important theme in a poem that focuses so intensely on the distinction between harms that can be changed or healed (such as mild wounds to the body, and injuries to honor) and the irreparable fact of mortality.

Life is a temporary connection between body parts, which can all too easily be undone. Death is often described as unknotting or untying. The spirit (*psychē*) leaves

the body at death and lives a shadowy existence in the house of the god Hades. But this bodiless spirit is not fully identified with the person or their essence (unlike the later concept of a “soul”). In Book 11 of *The Odyssey*, the spirits can speak to the living Odysseus only when they borrow back some physical life by drinking blood. When warriors fight over their fallen comrades and try to recover them from the battlefield for proper burial, the language does not usually refer to “the body of” Patroclus or Hector, but rather, “Patroclus,” or “Hector.” Priam comes into the Greek camp, at enormous personal risk, because he hopes to retrieve his son, who is suffering from the worst possible form of disempowerment, unable to move or defend himself from dishonor.

Corpses are not relics or husks, but particularly vulnerable people who still want and need the living. Care for the dead is provided through the rites of washing and wrapping the body, wailing and weeping for the deceased, and laying them on the funeral pyre. Funeral games make the dead man again a vicarious winner. The construction of mounds marks the landscape with his memory. The terrible alternative to these humanizing rites is for the dead to become food and prey for dogs and birds, who will never speak the names of those whom they devour.

## Women

Dead warriors, if they are lucky enough to avoid the hungry mouths of dogs, are washed, clothed, mourned, and remembered by the people who survive: the women, who live on after the men are dead at one another’s hands. The sequence of three female voices raised in lament for Hector at the end of the poem (24.904) suggests a symbiotic relationship between the male-dominated poetic genre of heroic epic and the female-dominated genre of choral lament. Andromache, Hecuba, and Helen all tend, honor, and remember the dead Hector. Each also tells a different set of truths about what women lose and gain in wartime.

Andromache, his wife, recognizes a personal and physical loss, of the husband whose arms will never hold her again, whose voice will never speak to her again. She also acknowledges other consequences: the sack of the city, the loss of her own freedom and that of all other surviving women of Troy, and the imminent enslavement or death of the children, including their son, Astyanax. Hector’s military prowess could be an asset to his family and fellow Trojans while he lived, but after he is dead, it is a threat to all of them.

The second mourner, Hector’s mother, Hecuba, provides a paradoxical lament, because she celebrates the dewy freshness of her son’s dead body, which even Achilles could not manage to defile. Even now that he is dead, Hecuba takes vicarious pride in her warrior son, and joy in remembering that Hector caused permanent, irredeemable

pain to Achilles by killing Patroclus. Women cannot be winners by themselves, but they can take delight in the triumphs and glory of their menfolk, as well as in the downfall and suffering of their enemies.

The final lament for Hector comes from Helen, daughter of Zeus, the only character who has been both Greek and Trojan. Helen's lament emphasizes Hector's ability to see her as a human being, in a context when most of the Trojans were unable to do so. Implicitly, her lament for Hector is also a lament for the dehumanization, unkindness, and cruelty towards women, subordinates, and captives that are normalized in war, and will proliferate after the death of the city's primary defender.

Women are raped and abused during the sack of cities. Even after the war is over, the female captives will remain enslaved, treated as the human property of the conquerors for the remainder of their lives. Triumphant warriors force captive women to labor for them, to satisfy their sexual desires, to bear their children, to create textiles and other crafts for their households. The most important warriors in the Greek encampment are all waited on and cared for by multiple female captives, of whom the most valuable are subject to repeated rapes in the beds of their enslavers. Their subjugation demonstrates the status of the enslaver to his peers. The silencing, rape, subjugation, kidnapping, and enslavement of women in war are essential instruments for the construction of male honor.

But the subjugation of women is terribly costly for men as well as for the women themselves. Women are the ones who are expected to devote themselves to the care of men; when women are marginalized, enslaved, and silenced, very few men will be capable of any form of kindness. The few men capable of even small tokens of kindness to the more vulnerable members of society—men like Priam, Patroclus, and Hector—will die.

There are several references to male prisoners of war who are ransomed back by their families, and Achilles boasts that, before the death of Patroclus, he frequently sold captive male Trojans into slavery abroad ("Before Patroclus died . . .," 21.134). But this is not the norm for female captives. The initial sequence of the poem, in which an enslaved woman is set free and restored to her original home, is unprecedented within the world of Homer, and occurs only because of the intervention of Apollo. No other mortal female character is so lucky, with the partial exception of Helen, daughter of Zeus, who will eventually be restored to her original husband's home, after the events of the poem are over.

The rape and abduction of an elite woman in peacetime, like the removal of Helen from her husband's house in Sparta, is a terrible violation of social norms, because it threatens the male homeowner's control over his own household, including its wealth, its social power, and the subordinate household members. Paris has done something not only ethically questionable, but also extremely imprudent. But in wartime, there are bad

consequences for those who kidnap women only when a god's desires or honor are violated—as with Chryseis, whose priestly father has a special relationship to Apollo.

In war, successful warriors like Achilles repeatedly rape and enslave women, kill their children, fathers, brothers, and husbands, destroy their homes, and end their brief time or “day” of freedom—a repeated phrase that emphasizes how fast, like the movement from one day to the next, a woman's life can become lifelong servitude.

The horrors of war for women and children were well-known to ancient storytellers and audiences, who would have included women and children. These horrors are implicit in *The Iliad*. But mortal women's experiences are not as central in this epic as they were in other ancient Greek poetry, such as wedding songs, songs of lament, and, later, Athenian tragedy. Enslaved women form a normalized part of the labor economy of the Greek encampment, preparing the meals and clothing, but the poem tells us of their names or homelands only rarely—as with the reference to old Hecamede, originally from Tenedos but captured and enslaved by Nestor, the woman who skillfully prepares medicinal potage for the wounded—or Iphis, enslaved by Achilles on Scyros and given to Patroclus—or Diomedes, captured and claimed by Achilles from Lesbos, and taken to his bed once the captive of higher status, Briseis, captured in Lyrnessus, has been confiscated from him. We learn little about the heritage and traditions and perspectives of these women. The poem never tells us what it feels like to be dragged into slavery, raped, and claimed as property by the killers of the victim's male kinsmen and children. This suffering is assumed, and the plot hinges on it—and yet the narrative centers the actions and emotions of the powerful, not those of the enslaved.

There is only one word—“unwillingly”—to describe the reluctance of Briseis to leave the tent of Achilles to be taken to Agamemnon, moving from one enslaving rapist to another. The narrator does not tell us how it felt for her to lose whatever autonomy she may have had in her original home. We glimpse the vulnerability, rage, and emotional desperation of the enslaved Briseis only in sideways fashion, for instance in her desperate lament for the dead Patroclus (19.366–92). She wails in grief for the fallen warrior—a task that always belongs to the female survivors. But Briseis' specific comments on how “kind” Patroclus was to her can also be heard as laments for how little kindness she has received, and for the loss of her only hope of relative freedom in the future (if, through the intervention of Patroclus, Achilles had taken her home to Phthia as his wife). Similarly, we glimpse Andromache's terror for her child and for herself, when she begs Hector in Book 6 to fight defensively, not risk everything for honor. The biological family is accompanied by a fourth member of the household: the enslaved woman who holds the baby, whose presence reminds us of Andromache's own future after her husband and child are killed. She too will be enslaved and forced to care for the family of her new captors. But the narrative tells us nothing about what the silent, enslaved nurse thinks or feels.

The only moment in the poem that gives a more expansive account of the emotions of a woman dragged into slavery against her will is a deeply paradoxical representation of the subject. It is the scene between Aphrodite and Helen in Book 3, where Helen tries to plead with the goddess to allow her not to go back to bed with Paris, a man for whom she has no respect. The goddess threatens the mortal woman, who is forced to comply.

This scene provides an acknowledgment of the abuse and subordination of women in war. Helen—like Briseis, like Chryseis, like countless nameless others—is taken from one man and claimed by another against her will. Shame accrues to the woman through the actions of men, regardless of her wishes. The scene makes clear that, despite her divine heritage and her extraordinary intelligence, Helen has no more choice than Briseis about whose bed she shares.

But the blame for Helen's disempowerment is laid ultimately not on the men who tussle over her, but on a female divinity—her own half sister, Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus. Similarly, Agamemnon blames his mismanagement of Achilles on a female abstraction, Ruinous Delusion (*Atē*). Achilles blames his sufferings on his mother Thetis (who gave birth to him), and on the goddess Artemis (who failed to kill Briseis as soon as Achilles had captured her). Hector knows that it is the gods who led him to his death, and thereby ensured his city's fall. It is deities, and largely, female deities (Hera, Athena, Aphrodite, Thetis, and Eris), not men, who are represented as to blame both for war and for the suffering and enslavement of mortal women.

## Deities and Godlike Men

The incursions of the divine into the human world create some of the most sublime moments of the poem, as our perspective suddenly shifts up and outward, beyond the merely mortal. The narrator makes us feel shock and surprise at the otherworldly existence of these extraordinary beings:

Like night the god descended.[1.67]

The goddess led the way.[3.529]

And Apollo left him.[22.284]

The resonant brevity of these phrases shows how little mortals can ever know of the immortals.

Deities have extraordinary power and abilities beyond even the strongest of human beings. They can transform themselves at will into any disguise. They can cast magical mist to obscure the sight of mortals. They can move at amazing speed across any distance: Poseidon can travel from Samothrace to Aegae in four enormous strides (13.22), and Hera swoops across mountaintops as quickly as the speed of thought (14.291). They have marvelous cloaks, weapons, jewelry, and chariots, and they live a life of extraordinary ease, often sitting high on the mountaintops, sipping ambrosia from golden cups.

Deities can treat the quarrels and deaths of mortals as pure entertainment, just as the audience of the poem can do. Gods yearn for excitement, and they, like us, can enjoy the thrilling stories and spectacle of war without any risk of death. Like us, they have their own favorite characters, their own preferences and desires. If the gods seem at times cruel, fickle, or indifferent, the same is true of us. Like gods, we love stories about other people's pain, and we warm our shivering lives with the thrilling deaths that are the subject of the poet's song.

Some deities are less fully anthropomorphized than others. The poet creates a more vivid and interactive story by describing certain abstract qualities as deities, but without needing to characterize them beyond their symbolic meaning. Divine beings such as Themis (Righteousness), Charis (Grace), Conflict (Eris), Flight, Terror, and Panic (who join Ares in battle), or the spirits of supplication, the Prayers (Lites) described by Phoenix in Book 9, are allegories come only partially to life. Conflict, for example, is aggressive and frightening—a divine force who inspires warriors to attack one another. But we know nothing of her domestic or family life, or her experiences and feelings beyond the battlefield.

Of the Olympian gods, two come closest to this purely symbolic identity: Ares, the war god who inspires men on the battlefield with joy in battle and the intense desire for slaughter, and Aphrodite, who presides over sexual desire and all the arts of seduction. In abstract terms, these two deities motivate the whole Trojan War, and the quarrel of Achilles and Agamemnon: Aphrodite's lust inspires men (like Paris or Agamemnon) to seize other men's women, and Ares' aggression arouses the subsequent conflict. But Aphrodite and Ares are wounded in battle (by Diomedes in Book 5), and both respond with ridiculous self-pity at their own trivial injuries. Ares and Aphrodite lack honor because they are so closely associated with the basest and most simplistic of human motivations. A poem that was simply a glorification of war should idealize the god of war. But Ares is hated both by humans and by his fellow gods. He is described repeatedly as *brotoloigos*, "the ruin of humanity." The war goddess, Athena, is as deadly and cruel as Ares, and takes as much joy as he does in a good, bloody massacre. But Athena is far more dignified, because she loves glory and strategy, rather than only indiscriminate slaughter. Similarly, despite the poem's deep and attentive interest in



beauty, aesthetics, and charm, Aphrodite is treated with scorn by her divine family members—unlike Hera, goddess of marriage, whose power is second only to that of Zeus, and who uses the instruments of seduction only to achieve her larger strategic goals—to claim power and honor for herself, and crush her enemies.

Other semipersonified deities are closely linked to specific locations, like spirits of the landscape. Rivers, lakes, springs, seas, mountains, caves, and woodlands—places where humans feel close to the divine—always have their own specific presiding deity. Local nature deities are often female (called *nymphs*, a Greek word that suggests their ageless, magical youth), although larger rivers are more often associated with a male god. Two nature deities play essential roles in the poem. The first is Thetis, mother of Achilles—a sea goddess, daughter of the sea god Nereus (and hence, a Nereid). The second is Xanthus, also known as Scamander, the river running across the Trojan plain, who rises up against Achilles when he begins to choke the water with the corpses of his victims. The prominence of these two natural deities underlines the magnitude of the conflict, and the vast elemental forces that both enable and limit human achievement.

Yet Thetis and Aphrodite are far more fully characterized than allegorical entities like Conflict. Silver-footed Thetis has a close relationship with Hephaestus, from having nurtured him when he was abandoned by his mother, Hera, and she has a fierce maternal love for her mortal son, Achilles. Aphrodite ventures onto the battlefield, weeps on her mother's lap, and tries to protect her son, Aeneas, from death.

Athena, Hera, Poseidon, Zeus, Apollo, Hephaestus, Aphrodite, and Hermes all have detailed personal histories and a complex range of attributes, interests, and relationships. Most are associated closely with specific places (generally, locations where they were worshipped), and particular attributes or qualities; but they are not reducible to symbols, any more than the human characters are. The two messenger gods—Hermes, the elusive guide to travelers, and Iris, the clever, tactful goddess of the rainbow—are entirely distinct from each other in personality. Athena is both the protector of cities, whose temple stands at the top of Troy, and the goddess who exalts in slaughter and relishes the spoils when cities are sacked. She is a strategist and problem solver, inheriting a more pragmatic version of her father's skill in strategy. She is also a daughter who has a fraught relationship with her only parent, and who forms a close alliance with her stepmother, Hera, in their shared hatred of Troy. Poseidon is associated with the sea, but also with earthquakes and horses; he resents his domineering younger brother, Zeus. Apollo, the aloof god of sunlight and prophecy, healing and sickness, maintains a complex position both in the divine family and in the conflict between Trojans and Greeks. He kills Greek troops with plague and enables Hector to kill Patroclus—but then allies with the other gods to bring Hector to his doom.

The overwhelming power of the divine is expressed in many different forms. The seductive smiles of Aphrodite are just as deadly as the blood-red hands of her raging, impulsive brother, Ares. The arrows of distant Apollo can kill as fast as the furious hands of his warmongering sister, Athena, or his raging stepmother, Hera. The rumbling wrath of Poseidon, god of earthquakes, is expressed differently from the misty manipulations of his brother, Zeus, the god of dark clouds. Hephaestus is different from his divine family members, in that he lives in a separate location, far from Olympus, rejected by his mother, Hera, and other gods laugh at his gait. But he is also able to save his mother from the violence of his father, Zeus, and to clothe Achilles in the magical armor with which he will slaughter Hector. Hephaestus is described as the “god whose legs are bent” (*amphiguēis*) and “limping” (*choleuōn*, a word used also of Thersites). But as an expert in technology and metallurgy, he uses marvelous enslaved robots to carry him around his workshop and his home. His unusual body is not necessarily an impediment to him, beyond the reactions of the other deities; he is agile and extraordinarily competent. As the god of fire, his curving body echoes the flexibility of flame—the element that enables the metallic wealth of Troy, rich in gold, and the wealth and armor of the Greeks, but also scorches the river and the plain in Book 21 and will burn the city to the ground.

Like humans, deities compete and quarrel with one another, and they have intense desires for honor, power, and victory as the ultimate marker of superiority. Like humans, too, deities find their power limited by chance and fate. Zeus, god of strategy, is the most powerful deity in the universe, and yet he defers his most important decisions to the higher power of fate, by holding up his cosmic scales and letting destiny decide. Fate can override even the strongest wishes of Zeus—as when, in Book 16, he longs to save his beloved mortal son, Sarpedon, but is reminded by Hera that Sarpedon is doomed to die at Troy. The love of a deity can increase a mortal’s honor, but it cannot extend his allotted thread of life, which has been spun out long ago.

Each deity’s power is also limited by the power of all the other gods—just as the power of Agamemnon is checked by the other Greek leaders. In a polytheistic world, no deity can be omnipotent. The less powerful deities are frightened when Zeus expresses his anger, but even Zeus, god of the bright sky, is afraid of the goddess Night, and needs to bargain and compromise with his wife and sister, Hera.

In a chilling passage at the start of Book 4, Hera and Zeus argue about the future of Troy. Hera, who hates Troy, proposes a compromise with Zeus: if he allows for the total devastation of Troy, a city that he loves, she will allow him to destroy three of her own favorite cities—Sparta, Mycenae, and Argos, all flourishing centers in Mycenaean times. Zeus agrees, even while expressing his love for Troy:

*Of all the towns on earth where humans live*

*beneath the sun, beneath the starry sky,  
none is more precious, none more dear to me  
than holy Troy and Priam and the people  
of Priam with the good ash spear. . . . (4.57–61)*

With this, we know the city is doomed. Zeus expresses his love for mortals only when they are near death. The god can afford to accept the compensation offered by Hera, even though the destruction of more cities will do nothing to help the Trojans. Deities have the privilege of immortality, so they can treat even the greatest losses with equanimity. For them, there is always a next time and always another city to destroy.

Zeus, Hera, and the other deities compromise with one another to avoid the fate of the earlier generation, the Titans—who were defeated by Zeus and his siblings, and remain confined beneath the earth and unable to move freely. The poem hints at the possibility that there could be a cosmic disruption, if the gods began again to fight each other—as the Titans fought against the Olympians, or as happened in the mythical past, when Hera and the other gods challenged Zeus and were chained up as punishment. But within the world of the poem, divine quarrels end in laughter, because the cost is always shouldered by mortals. The destruction of human lives and human cities is the price paid for the divine world order.

And yet deities are not entirely indifferent to the pain of humans. They are sometimes struck by grief at the death of those they love, as when Zeus weeps for Sarpedon, his mortal son who must die at Troy. They sometimes swoop down to save their favorites from death, as Aphrodite does for Paris in Book 3. They manipulate the tides of battle, either inspiring mortals on their favored side with greater will to fight or instilling panic and fear in the enemy. They intervene in individual decisions at crucial moments in the poem's action: Athena restrains Achilles from killing Agamemnon, Apollo and Athena lure Hector to turn and face Achilles, and in Book 24, the gods arrange for Achilles to return the dead Hector to Priam. Thetis provides her short-lived son with glory and a beautiful set of armor, although she cannot save his life. The gods feed Achilles with ambrosia to sustain him for battle when he refuses to eat, and they keep the body of Hector fresh, even when Achilles drags it multiple times around the tomb of Patroclus.

But wrath, not love or grief, is the dominant divine emotion. Any deity may become enraged when their honor or something belonging to their proper sphere is damaged or imperiled. The poem begins with the anger of Apollo at the Greeks, because of Agamemnon's treatment of his priest. Hera and Athena are continually enraged at the Trojans, as the people favored by their rival, Aphrodite. Poseidon is also angry at Troy and the Trojans, because Priam's father, Laomedon, failed to pay either Poseidon or Apollo for building the city walls. The love of gods for humans cannot save them from

death, but the anger of gods, even when that anger is primarily directed at other gods, generally causes massive loss of human life.

The pervasive presence of divine influence might seem to suggest that humans have no responsibility for their own choices. This view is taken by the “lord of men,” Agamemnon, who conveniently blames his troubles on divine powers.

*“It was not my fault!  
The ones to blame are Destiny and Zeus  
and the avenging night-walker, the Fury,  
who set a wild delusion in my mind  
during the council meeting on the day  
when I removed the trophy from Achilles.  
But what was I to do? It is a god  
who carries everything to its conclusion.”* (19.112–19)

Agamemnon is not entirely wrong. The misty plans of Zeus, including his agreement with Thetis, did indeed influence the huge Greek death toll in the wake of the quarrel. Moreover, blaming the gods is the only way a great leader can acknowledge an error of judgment while maintaining his status. Agamemnon’s belated, exaggerated acknowledgment of divine power is a partial correction of his earlier mistakes in underestimating Chryses, Calchas, and, especially, Achilles—all of whom had deities on their side.

But Agamemnon’s grand claim that human actions are caused exclusively by divine manipulation is not supported by the narrative. There are always multiple causes at work. In Book 1, Achilles half draws his sword, ready to kill Agamemnon, when Athena suddenly pulls him by the hair, and he hesitates. The goddess does not force him one way or the other, but nudges him towards one of the options that he was already considering.

In some earlier myths about Troy, as in many later ones, divine influence and magical objects played a far greater role than they do in *The Iliad*. For instance, in other tellings, the walls of Troy, built by Poseidon and Apollo, were magically impregnable—and hence, the city could be infiltrated only by the trick of the Wooden Horse, not by besiegers breaking down the walls. But in *The Iliad*, we are never told that the city walls are magically strong. The narrator insists that the wall built by the Greeks around their encampment is both an extraordinary achievement and doomed to be erased from the landscape by the gods (12.4). Similarly, in other versions of the myth, the arms and armor of Achilles made the wearer invincible. In other tellings, his body was also invulnerable, apart from the heel. *The Iliad* says nothing about magical qualities of either the armor or the body of Achilles, although the details of Patroclus’

death hint that the narrator knows about this legend: Apollo removes Achilles' armor from Patroclus before he is killed (16.1004).

Thetis can provide her son with glory, but she cannot save him from mortality. So too, the immortal horses of Achilles speak only to remind the hero of his own death. The stallion Bay tells Achilles,

*"We could run as fast as Zephyr,  
the wind they call the fastest of them all,  
but it is fated that you will be killed  
both by a human and a god."* (19.542–45)

Achilles' divine heritage grants him only a more clear-eyed vision of his own mortality.

Thetis successfully entreats Zeus to glorify her son by providing success to the Trojans in his absence, and to cause massive loss of Greek life—so that Achilles can demonstrate to Agamemnon that he is essential to Greek victory, and not to be slighted. Zeus fulfills the prayer of Thetis by keeping the other gods away from the battlefield and granting temporary success to Hector, until he sets fire to the Greek ships. But this in turn causes Patroclus to join battle and lose his life—so that Achilles suffers the loss of his dearest friend, his second self. The successful prayers of Achilles and his mother bring the short-lived hero great glory, and in doing so, they also bring him the most terrible pain. As he himself exclaims, having learned of his dear friend's death,

*"Yes, Mother, Zeus has granted me that prayer.  
But now what good to me is any of it?  
My friend Patroclus, whom I loved, is dead.  
I loved him more than any other comrade.  
I loved him like my head, my life, myself.  
I lost him, killed him. Hector slaughtered him,  
and stripped from him the marvelous magic armor,  
the lovely gifts the gods gave Peleus  
the day they led you, an immortal goddess,  
into a mortal's bed."* (18.97–106)

Divine gifts, like the Wooden Horse, must be accepted, but they always hide a terrible cost inside. Those who enjoy these gifts to the greatest degree, as the semidivine Achilles and Helen both do, are not luckier than other mortals, and may in fact suffer in extraordinary ways. Their suffering, as much as their glory, makes them worthy topics of a poet's song. As Paris comments in the context of his own seductive handsomeness—a

quality that is disparaged as unmanly and unwarlike by his brother, Hector, and that is on some level the cause of the Trojan War:

*“Glorious gifts  
that come from gods, that they themselves have given,  
must not be thrown away—although no human  
chooses them willingly.”* (3.81–84)

Neither Paris nor Helen made a free choice to attract the attention of the goddess Aphrodite—nor, once chosen, could either of them free themselves from the suffocating and terrifying love of the goddess.

Many heroes have divine heritage, in their near or distant ancestry: Sarpedon is a son of Zeus, Aeneas is a son of Aphrodite, and Achilles is a great-grandson of Zeus. Many are “godlike,” “dear to Zeus,” or “a friend of Ares.” All shine bright while they live. But none of these great men can escape from death. The poem’s insistence on human mortality is felt all the more acutely because we are shown so clearly what it would be like to be an immortal, and invited to contemplate how close some humans come to the condition of divinity—barring the one crucial element of immortality.

Hector believes that he is supported by deities, which is never a safe assumption. The gods frequently change sides or abandon a favored mortal, as they will. Achilles’ birth as a mortal, and his intermediary position as the almost-son of Zeus, are constant reminders of the fragile hold of the Olympians on the cosmic world order, and of the heartbreaking idea that humans, at least the most talented and glorious of humans, might be almost like immortals—except that no human, even the most magical, can ever escape from grief, loss, and death. The presence of immortal characters in the poem allows us to see with far greater precision that death makes all the difference. Death enables human communities, and stories.

## Memory

An elite warrior hopes, above all, to be remembered, in tales that will survive among the people in the future, even after his own death. The dead remain alive for future generations, through physical memorials, like burial mounds, and in the singing of tales, like *The Iliad* itself.

The poem is a mythologized act of memory, preserving forever the names of people who never lived, and providing mourning and glorification for the past on every occasion of the poem’s iteration. But the deathless gods oppose the human desire to live forever. At the beginning of Book 12, we are told that the glorious wall, constructed

with great labor by the Greeks to protect their ships and their camp, will be washed away by the combined efforts of Poseidon and Apollo, who view wall construction, and wall demolition, as their exclusive province. The gods will make the rivers flood and destroy “the whole foundation of the wall / on which the Greeks had labored long and hard.” The narrator tells of its destruction—an event that is in the future, from the perspective of the poem—as having already taken place:

*Beside the swirling Hellespont, the god  
flattened the land and coated the long shore  
with sand again, and so wiped out the wall. . . . (12.39–41)*

The worst fears of every hero will come true. All their labor will be for nothing, their names lost, their bodies left as carrion, and the landscape of the plain between the two rivers, which seems so irreparably marked by the struggles of the characters, will revert back to its former state: “the work of human beings turns to nothing” (16.502). The poem teaches us to care intensely for the efforts of mortals. We thrill at their courage and weep for their deaths, their griefs, their disappointments. We learn also to recognize alternative perspectives, to glimpse how easily all the “great deeds of men” can be forgotten. No material construction, however monumental, can preserve memory across generations. Only words, not walls, can hope to build a lasting memorial for the dead.

Mortals can find solace for inevitable, permanent, irreparable loss only from a larger pattern. The tale of Achilles’ wrath, and therefore the poem, ends only once the alienated hero is able to accept loss as an inevitable element in the shared life of mortals. Achilles moves from anger to grief when he can partially, temporarily, share his losses with Priam’s, and make sorrow part of a shared story. Hector, who insisted on going out by himself beyond the city walls, is welcomed back into the city once he is dead, and the women who loved him sing songs of lament over him—again integrating the loss into a larger pattern of storytelling. Memorializing the story of the fallen warrior is the only way of bringing him back. *The Iliad* ends there, not telling of the Wooden Horse or the fall of the city, because the death of Hector already portends the fall of Troy. Horse-lord Hector is himself a Trojan Horse: he comes from the Greek camp, enters the city, and foreshadows the end.

*The Iliad* celebrates male achievement, male honor, and male violence, but ends with three female voices, singing of loss, memory, and what might remain, after the men are dead. We have been reminded at the start of Book 24 of the three goddesses who began the Trojan War, with their rivalry for the apple awarded to the best of them. The poem ends with three mortal female voices raised in a more cooperative form of competition, each capping the other’s song with another song, each telling of a loss that can never be recuperated, except through memory, poetry, and story. The three women

who lead the laments will soon be separated—Hecuba and Andromache will be enslaved, and Helen, who is a Greek as well as a Trojan woman, will return to Sparta with her former husband. But for a brief moment, they are together in remembering Hector, and in mourning the city that will soon fall.

If we can remember anything of the past, it is through words and stories: the laments of women, and the tales of poets. Words enable the sharing of grief, when there is no other comfort to be found.

*The Iliad* has not always had the cultural prominence that it now enjoys. Virgil's *Aeneid*—which includes more of the famous myths, such as the story of the Wooden Horse, and offsets the tragic fall of Troy with a more hopeful narrative about the survival of refugees and the rise of Rome—was far more popular for many centuries after antiquity. The Homeric poem was not translated into English until the early seventeenth century, by the wonderful playwright and poet George Chapman. Many readers continued to prefer the stately Latin hexameters of Virgil over the emotional intensity and corporeal vigor of *The Iliad*.

But over the past century, in the wake of the two world wars and amid shifting attitudes towards masculinity and heroism, *The Iliad* has received renewed attention. Recent interpretations often view *The Iliad* as a poem less of glory than of mourning. In its attentiveness to the visual as well as auditory qualities of the world, *The Iliad* can feel entirely at home in our own image-focused media landscape. Twenty-first-century readers and listeners may see the inequalities in the poem's social worlds with particular clarity. The emotional intensity of the poem's representation of conflict feels in tune with the anguish and partisanship of our era.

We are now in a period of crisis not for a specific nation but for humanity, inhabiting a planet that is becoming less and less habitable. A new kind of heartbreak can be felt in *The Iliad*'s representation of a city in its last days, of triumphs and defeats and struggles and speeches that take place in a city that will soon be burned to the ground, in a landscape that will soon be flooded by all the rivers, in a world where soon, no people will live at all, and there will be no more stories and no more names.

You already know the story. You will die. Everyone you love will also die. You will lose them forever. You will be sad and angry. You will weep. You will bargain. You will make demands. You will beg. You will pray. It will make no difference. Nothing you can do will bring them back. You know this. Your knowing changes nothing. This poem will make you understand this unfathomable truth again and again, as if for the very first time.



## TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

I first began reading Homer in high school, early in my study of ancient Greek. I liked *The Odyssey*, but I loved *The Iliad* with a passionate devotion. I have now lived with this poem for some thirty-five years—rereading it, teaching it in the original and in various translations, and, now, rendering it into English. For the past six years, I have worked intensively on this translation. But even now, when I turn back to lines I have read hundreds of times already, I find that the raw power of the Greek still startles me, like Athena suddenly tugging Achilles by the hair to stop him in his tracks. Often, I am unable to read without goose bumps, tears, or both.

Human mortality is at the center of it all. I know no other narrative that evokes with such unflinching truthfulness the vulnerability of the human body. Yet *The Iliad* also makes the whole world feel gloriously alive. People, gods, animals, and even objects are always in motion, swooping down mountains or dashing across the field of battle. The beautiful, rhythmical language evokes the noisy clash of bronze and the rumble of the sea. We hear many voices: almost half the poem consists of direct speech, and richly varied personalities are audible in the distinct ways that each character talks. No thought, no feeling, is left unexpressed; men scream, sob, shout, and weep. There is quiet tenderness—as when Hephaestus welcomes his foster mother, Thetis, to his home, or when Dione soothes her daughter for her slightly scratched wrist. There is comedy, as when Idomeneus and Meriones argue about who has the bigger spear. There are sublime thrills, as when shield clashes on shield like the buffeting winds at sea. The poem's imagery is extraordinarily varied and vivid: the narrator can shape-shift like Proteus, becoming by turns a frightened lion, a furious boar, a shepherd, a frazzled mother, a thought, a dream, a storm.

There is nothing like *The Iliad*. No translator, including me, can fully replicate all the poetic, dramatic, and emotional effects of the Greek. No translation can be simply “the same” as the original. A translator who underestimates her task will produce a clunky, incoherent mess. So I knew from the start that I had to make careful decisions about which features of the Greek poem I most wanted to echo, and work with

diligence, humility, and creativity to find ways to construct those effects from scratch, within the entirely different palette of the English language.

I began with sound. The vast majority of contemporary English translations of the Homeric poems render the regular meter of the Greek into prose or nonmetrical free verse—using line breaks, but no regular sonic pattern. These translations are written for the page, not the tongue and the ear. Nonmetrical renditions of Homer do not provide the auditory experience of immersion in a long narrative poem, where the immutable pattern of sound is as omnipresent as the waves beating against the shore. I wanted to honor the poem's oral heritage with a regular and audible rhythm, and with language that would, like the original, invite reading out loud, and come to life in the mouth.

Moreover, *The Iliad* emerges from a long oral tradition, shaped by many minds and many voices, and its narrative includes a multitude of perspectives, voices, and points of view. Achilles has a particularly unusual way of speaking, and the speech patterns of other characters are also clearly distinguished. But in many English translations, all the characters sound more or less the same. Recent Homeric scholars have traced the subtle shifts in narrative point of view, so that, for instance, we see Andromache's external actions when she hears bad news of Hector—she drops her shuttle, she dashes to the wall—but then we begin to see as through Andromache's eyes, when she notices bitterly that the horses dragging her dead husband are not showing care for him, as she could do herself—and that the clothes she worked so hard to make are getting ruined. Yet translations often reduce this narrative flexibility, creating a more monolithic voice for the Homeric narrator—and often a voice that is more unambiguously militaristic and aristocratic than that of the Greek original. I hoped to fashion a language for Homer in English that might be supple enough to encapsulate numerous shifts in perspective, both large and small.

*The Iliad* feels grand, noble, and sublime, but it uses simple, direct syntax, designed for ready comprehension when the poem is performed out loud. Homeric verse is magnificent but not difficult; the language is far easier and more straightforward than, say, Pindar, Thucydides, or Aeschylus. However, many modern English translations of Homer use contorted, unnatural language that seems to me quite alien to the experience of the Greek. Many versions create a reading experience that mirrors how first-year language students labor valiantly through each word, but have only a foggy notion of what it all means. I wanted my English to enable an experience more like that of an ancient listener, who would have heard and understood Homer in oral performance from childhood onward, as a gripping form of live entertainment, and as a formative guide to life—not as a difficult old book requiring slow, belabored reading and a mountainous set of footnotes. At the very least, I hoped to create an experience parallel to that of a modern person who can read the original fluently. In translation, as in the

original, Homer's language should enable immediate comprehension and deep emotional engagement.

Ideally, literary translators should not grind the beef, pork, and lamb of their originals into an unidentifiable hot dog. Instead, the distinctive stylistic features of each original should remain distinct in translation. Having published English translations of Seneca, Euripides, and Sophocles, I wanted to make Homer in my translations sound different from any of them—just as the originals are composed in wildly different styles of verse. In Homer, there is none of Euripides' allusive, witty cleverness, Seneca's rhetorical bombast, or Sophocles' densely metaphorical, riddling phrasing. Homeric Greek has a limpid clarity and freshness that needs to sparkle in the English, like the clear, almost painful brightness of sunlight on bronze. My task was to make this ancient poem about death feel vividly, unarguably alive. I wanted to echo its rumbling, regular musicality, its proto-dramatic array of characters, and its noble simplicity.

To glimpse a goalpost glinting in the distance is one thing. It is another to urge the clattering chariot and sweating horses onward to attain it through the haze and dust. In turning from *The Odyssey* to *The Iliad*, I knew I had to start again as if from scratch. Nothing could be taken for granted. For the first two years of working on the translation, I was more or less completely stuck. I read and reread lines and passages from the original out loud, and read and reread my own early, stillborn failures, experimenting with phrasing and line lengths and rhythm, rejecting one unsatisfactory solution after another, and hearing, repeatedly, the vast gap between my grasp and my reach.

Gradually, my task became clearer—as when Zeus clears the thick fog from the battlefield in Book 17, so that the mortals who struggle to claim the dead Patroclus can at least die in the light. I slowly began to understand with more precision how my *Iliad* translation must necessarily be different from my *Odyssey*. *The Odyssey* required a fluid sequence of disguises, supple and strong as an olive branch winding through stone. For *The Iliad*, I needed a voice of bronze, a voice of wind, a voice of fire. I needed to forge greatness without hyperbole, power without pomposity: as massive as a mountain, as soft as night, as powerful as sleep.

*The Iliad* is constantly engaged with issues of scale. The poem evokes the gaps between the individual and the community, between the brief dazzle of sunlight on a single day and the long winding river of many human generations. I spent many days weighing words to convey the elemental qualities of sound, light, weight, touch, and size—apparently distinct categories that constantly transmute into one another. I needed to make readers or listeners feel and hear the intense, relentless din of clashing metal and falling flesh, and to experience the poem's intense emotions: rage, grief, horror. The poem's muscular music is bound up in a complex poise and counterweight of speed versus immobility, the quick arrows, spears, actions, voices, ships, birds on the wing, against the weight of bodies, treasure, metal, stones, the sea, the dark earth.

A careful consideration of pace was essential in translating a poem that centers on an insistent truth-telling young warrior, whose quick feet are set on the quickest path to death—but who spends most of the time aggressively doing nothing. After many drafts and experiments, I realized that I needed to use more lines than the original, to accommodate the numerous names, titles, and patronymics that are all extremely important in *The Iliad*. In *The Odyssey*, Odysseus is extraordinary for the flexibility with which he can inhabit many different names, or no name at all. It is this quality of being multinamed and nameless that enables him to survive. By contrast, almost all the warriors of *The Iliad* yearn to have a name and a story that lasts forever. Their many names and titles, as sons and brothers and comrades and fathers and rulers, are essential to their identities, their connections with one another, and their fame after death. They fear, above all, being humiliated (cursed with a negative name), or forgotten and nameless. The lists and catalogs of names are essential to the poem's own work, of memorializing and mourning the dead. Once the bodies return to dust, these syllables are all that remain.

To accommodate these long names, I experimented with using a longer line. I made a brief attempt at stressed dactylic hexameters, but the results felt forced and unnatural and slow—qualities that are antithetical to the effects of the original. To make this alien rhythm work in English, it was more or less impossible not to resort to peculiar word choices—such as “scion of Atreus,” where the original does not use markedly weird language. So I tried alexandrines (stressed iambic hexameters), but these long English lines felt like wet, unrisen dough, lacking the quick energy of the original. I therefore came back to iambic pentameter. I felt it was the only meter that would allow me the flexibility and energy necessary to evoke the experience of reading the Greek. Moreover, only iambic pentameter could echo a centuries-long poetic tradition in English, just as the original's dactylic hexameter echoes a centuries-long poetic tradition in Greek.

Once I understood that I needed more lines than the original, I realized I could sometimes use lovely long, polysyllabic English words, echoing the original's use of powerfully long, often compound words interspersed with many shorter connectives, verbs, and particles—such as the four-syllable “cataclysmic” at the start of Book 1, for the four-syllable *oulomenen*. I thought constantly about how to echo the beautifully varied pacing of the original—sometimes slow and contemplative, often breathlessly fast and action-packed. I have often felt like the poor mortal horse, Jumper, harnessed alongside the immortal horses of Achilles: like him, I struggled to keep up, always knowing that the original poem, my model and constant companion, would always gallop ahead.

The poem's nuanced representation of war required constant care and attention. *The Iliad* aestheticizes and glorifies violence, and any reader or listener ought to understand

the excitement and joy of holding a weapon and plunging it into the soft flesh of an enemy. At the same time, we should feel equally clearly how it feels to be the victim in that encounter, to watch the darkness cover your eyes for the last time. Homer's great, marvelously multivocal, often deeply tragic evocation of pathos and grief is not merely a jingoistic celebration of military glory. There is a wide emotional range, including rage, grief, and horror, but also laughter and moments of calm and awe.

There are other surviving poems from roughly the same era as *The Iliad* that have little or no ambivalence in their representation of existing social hierarchies and social exclusion. In the seventh century BCE, Semonides of Amorgos wrote a lively satirical poem comparing the various types of women to different animals and natural objects—the dirty, pig-type woman, the greedy, dog-type woman, and so on—that concludes, “This is the greatest evil made by Zeus—women!” Also in the seventh century, Tyrtaeus of Sparta wrote a series of militaristic songs, urging listeners to perform bravely in battle. Both these poets articulate simple and unsurprising ideological stances, and ones that overlap quite extensively with existing modern perspectives. First-time readers of *The Iliad* may expect to find in it the straightforward misogyny of Semonides, or the straightforward militarism of Tyrtaeus. But instead, *The Iliad* has a startlingly humane vision of war, gender, power, and violence, from many different points of view. It is not more modern than other archaic Greek poetry, but more holistic in its understanding of the social and natural world. As a translator, I thought constantly about how to enable readers to see and feel *The Iliad*'s breadth and multiplicity of vision, in its account of the damage caused to communities by a social system that values individual warriors' glory so highly.

Homer transports us to a world that is very distant from our own. And yet some of the most difficult challenges of translation emerged as much from the closeness as from the distance between the worlds. For a twenty-first-century reader, there is nothing unfamiliar about a partisan society riven by constant striving for celebrity, dominance, and attention, where rage and outrage are constantly whipped up by extreme rhetoric and the threat of humiliation, and where grief and loss constantly bleed into yet more rage and aggression. But current attitudes and experiences of “status,” or “fame,” or “celebrity” (all of which may have negative connotations) are quite different from attitudes about “honor,” “glory,” or “renown” (semiarchaic words with more positive connotations). The various terms for social approbation in *The Iliad*, including *kudos* and *kleos*, do not correspond exactly to any of these terms: they are neither negative nor archaic nor grand. Where possible, I have used words that evoke the ordinariness and pervasiveness of the Homeric warrior's desire to win by defeating, slaughtering, and stripping his opponents in battle, and by outdoing his peers—for instance by rendering *kudos* as “success.” I have also frequently resorted to the more positive, more old-fashioned terms (for instance, “honor,” not “celebrity”), in the hopes that the reader can

adjust to a world in which the desire for an eternal name is viewed both as marvelously heroic and terribly costly, and also quite normal. I echo the original in using different words for different categories of status-symbol objects, even though English generally does not make this distinction: I used “trophy” for *geras* —an object or enslaved woman won in war—but “prize” for *aethlon* —an object or enslaved woman won in athletic competition. I hoped the social world of the poem would emerge as alien in certain precise ways, but never incomprehensible.

I struggled constantly with terms for social categories. Many translations describe the dominant warriors as “princes”—but this term is more appropriate for an early modern nation-state than for the little clusters of men from different territories who travel to Troy to fight. I aimed for more neutral language, such as “leader” (for the Greek *basileus* or *archos* ) and “troops” (for the Greek *laos* ), to allow the reader gradually to discover the social structures and hierarchies of this strange yet comprehensible world. Similarly, I avoided the word “castle” either for Priam’s dwelling place or for the mound of sand knocked down, in a famous simile, by a child. The world of Homer is not medieval or early modern, and I hoped to provide a clearer sense of the small scale of the whole Trojan War by making the warriors live in huts, tents, and houses, not pavilions.

The poem’s story, and its intense emotional and poetic power, always takes precedence over any ethical, political, or personal lessons that readers may want to take from *The Iliad* . Evaluative language risks connoting specifically modern schemes of value. For example, I considered, but rejected, using “macho” or “machismo” as renderings of specifically masculine forms of aggression, such as *agēnor thymos* and *agēnoriē* (both related to *anēr* , “man,” with the prefix *ag* - suggesting excess: terms that are central to the poem’s precise account of the intimate relationship between aggression, arrogance, and masculinity). In translating this cluster of terms, I generally use fairly plain words such as “pride,” which is much less obviously gendered than the Greek. Similarly, I have used terms such as “skill” and “talent” for *aretē* , a word that came to mean “virtue” in later Greek, but in the world of *The Iliad* primarily connotes military excellence.

The dangers of anachronism always needed to be balanced against an equally pressing danger: that archaizing or unidiomatic English risks suggesting that *The Iliad* is both more alien and more simplistic in its values than it really is. I wrestled constantly with the delicate balance whereby the slaughter that is central to the epic is presented as both glorious and terrible. The horror and grief of war is imagined in ways that are quite unmodern: this is a world with no concept of human rights, no written laws, no hospitals or antibiotics, and no Geneva Convention. I hoped the translation could, like the original, suggest compassionate understanding of the tensions and fault lines within the competitive, hierarchical, aggressive societies it evokes.

I wanted the characters in my translation, like those of the original poem, to sound comprehensible in their motivations and actions. A constant difficulty was to find language for feelings and motivations that would be neither jarringly peculiar nor jarringly anachronistic. I tried to enable readers to experience some of the alien features of Homeric psychology, such as how feelings are always experienced in the body: anger, rage, and grief all well up in the chest or in the heart, and fury quickens the hands and feet.

Translators always wrestle with idioms, which are never identical from one language to another. A translator can legitimately render an idiom by another, different idiom, to honor the clarity and register of the original—on the principle that an idiomatic original should not be rendered with stilted translationese. Clear water should not be transformed into mud, and a strong Greek sentence should not be turned into a mangled mess. But there is a fine line between idiom and slang. I tried to avoid colloquial or slangy phrases, which will date quickly and detract from the partially elevated tone of the poem. Characters in Homer express intense feelings, but without curse words, obscenities, or blasphemy.

The Greek original has none of the chatty, current language that we find in Aristophanes. It sounds at once traditional and fresh—a very difficult note to strike in translation. Terms of address were a particular problem. For a time, I wondered if Homeric warriors could address one another as “buddy” (as real North American warriors might do), and if horses could be told to “Giddy up!” or “Hyah.” But eventually I eliminated all of these, as too specific to a particular register, and out of keeping with the tone of the poem. The common Homeric exclamation of surprise and shock, *ō popoi*, was similarly challenging. I realized that none of the possible options—“Wow!” “Damn!” “Gosh!” “Argh!” “Oh no!” “Ugh!”—was viable. All were too slangy, too cartoonish, too silly. Instead, whenever this common phrase occurred, I worked to make the speaker’s shock apparent by other means within the rest of the sentence.

I worked hard to avoid clichés, while recognizing that there may be a fine line between an idiom and a cliché. For example, I do not use “desperate straits,” “the lap of luxury,” “grisly death,” “well-honed blade,” or dozens of similar phrases popular with many North American Homeric translators. I believe the use of such clichés can make the Iliadic world seem a little too familiar, too easy to access, and can offer a confusing counterpart to Homeric formulas and repeated phrases: Homeric formulaic language is quite different from modern cliché, but the difference can be impossible to discern in a translation that is full of contemporary American idioms. I aimed for clarity, but I trust the reader to adapt to some slightly alien terms or phrases, especially where the Homeric idioms are fundamental to the poem’s understanding of life or death. For instance, I tried to echo the Homeric understanding of the dead person as still a person,

rather than inserting terms such as “the body of,” when the Greeks and Trojans grapple over the dead Patroclus or the dead Sarpedon. I replicate the original’s repeated metaphors of “winged words,” of death as an unknotting or untying of the limbs, and of fate as a rope tied tight around the doomed.

I wanted Homer’s intense expressions of rage and grief to be appropriately intense, but never ridiculous or kitsch—given that some modern readers may have little experience of a world in which grown men constantly wail and slap their thighs in grief, or scream marvelously inventive insults at each other in their rage. There was a delicate balance in allowing the characters, their emotions, and their interactions to emerge in full—as convincing human beings—without ever giving the sense that the poem views them with anything other than compassion. The narrator may sometimes seem to smile, for instance at Hera’s cunning in seducing Zeus to achieve her own ends, or at Agamemnon’s brittle self-aggrandizement, when he and the equally fragile, equally arrogant Achilles hurl insults at each other, or at Paris’ swaggering pride in his own attractive appearance. During readings of my work in progress, I have been pleased to find that audiences laugh when I read the quarrel from Book 1 out loud (I ham it up with appropriately enraged voices). People often express surprise to realize that *The Iliad* is funny as well as sad. But laughter should never detract from deep empathy. I have never heard laughter when I read the death of Patroclus, the death of Hector, or the meeting of Hector and Achilles, scenes that should arouse chills and tears, not smiles. The poem enables us to feel and sympathize with the fears, anxieties, and motivations of the most powerful beings in the Homeric world, including both mortal leaders and gods. We also glimpse, more rarely, the perspectives of their subordinates.

Because of their oral heritage, the Homeric poems are full of repeated formulaic expressions, phrases, and epithets—the terms that are regularly attached to specific characters or objects. It seemed to me essential to provide the reader or listener with a sense of the repetitive qualities of Homeric poetics, and I have used many repeated phrases to echo those of the original. These may seem alien at first, but after a few instances, they can serve to orient any listener in the poem’s world: we know Achilles not only as “Achilles,” but as “swift-footed Lord Achilles,” a phrase I have used repeatedly, echoing the original’s *podas okus Akhilleus*. The epithets, titles, and patronymics let us know how important the character is, and the repetition allows us to see difference within sameness: Achilles’ swiftness means one thing when he is the quickest to respond to the plague, another when he is immobile in his tent, and it takes on a different set of connotations again when he dashes round the walls in pursuit of Hector. Similarly, in my translation as in the original, Diomedes and Menelaus are repeatedly “master of the war cry,” and Agamemnon is generally “lord of men,” “son of Atreus,” “shepherd of the people,” or all three, again reflecting the formulaic phrasing of the original.



Like almost all modern translators, I have sometimes varied the phrasing of certain formulaic phrases, usually for sonic or rhythmical reasons. So, for example, Zeus appears in this translation both as “cloud-gathering Zeus” and as “Zeus who gathers clouds together.” Minor variations of this kind seemed to me in keeping with the poetic techniques of the original poem, in which epithets are often chosen for metrical reasons as much as anything. Moreover, I am under no illusion that any phrases made up by me can fully echo the heft of the original phrases, developed over centuries of poetic tradition. In the highly literate sociolinguistic context of contemporary English, repetition always risks sounding redundant or stale. I felt the repetitiveness of the original needed to be evoked with some degree of flexibility, so that the literate reader’s eyes will not glaze over. I hoped to allow the reader to experience formulas as an essential element of traditional Homeric word-building, without making the text entirely unreadable. I reminded myself constantly that the original is never boring; the translation should strive to be equally gripping to its listeners or readers.

In order to enable a modern reader to feel as engaged and immersed in this poem as an ancient listener might have done, I felt my English should never be more difficult or more obscure than the Greek original. This principle extended also to the names and titles for the characters. The collective Greek forces are generally referred to in the poem as “the Achaeans,” because “Greece” did not exist as a collective political entity in the Bronze Age; “Achaea” is a geographically vague term that overlaps with the territory known as “Greece.” I therefore chose to call the invaders “the Greeks,” because “the Achaeans” (or, worse, “the Akhaians”) would risk alienating or confusing the reader for no particularly good end that I could see. Where the original is not likely to have caused puzzlement to an ancient reader, I want the reader of the translation to feel equally at home.

The original poem is composed in a mix of dialects from many different parts of the Greek-speaking world and many different eras: it is a linguistic mishmash, a language nobody ever actually spoke, representing a conjunction of many different people’s voices and traditions and dialects. There is no way to invent such a tradition for English from scratch. An invented multilingual tradition (in the manner of Francis Newman’s wonderfully unreadable and peculiar translation) would not provide a realistic equivalent for a real one, and it would offer little or no access to the poetic and narrative qualities of Homer. I have used language that I hope is accessible to readers who speak a wide range of different dialects and accents and forms of English, including voices very different from mine. Readers should feel free to make the text their own, by reading aloud, performing and re-creating these words in any ways they may see fit.

Every language individuates the world differently—a challenge for translators even when both source and target languages are from the same historical era. One small but

constant set of challenges for me with *The Iliad* was how to find enough words for “spear”—given that the original has *enchos* and *doru* , in addition to *belos* for any thrown weapon. “Missile” is likely to suggest modern technology, rather than a simple projectile; “projectile” suggests vomiting; “dart” suggests a pub game; a “javelin” is usually now used in sport not war. And yet to repeat “spear” in quick succession, where the original term varies, would suggest a clunkiness that is not truthful to the Greek. Similar issues arose constantly about the range of words for “kill” or “slaughter,” especially because many of the English options were too colloquial or suggested the wrong kind of military technology (“fire”). Combat scenes in *The Iliad* rely on a sharp distinction between hurling a weapon from a distance to strike an opponent (described in the single verb *ballein* ), and striking at close quarters, with weapon in hand (*tuptein* ). The English verb “strike” can suggest either of these. I was therefore conscious of a particular need, in this and many other areas, to make sure that what was clear in the original should be clear in the translation. On occasion, I needed to use a few more words to achieve that aim—although I also knew that pace and momentum were crucial elements of the gripping scenes of massacre and slaughter.

I encountered constant challenges in how to deal with the rich array of Homeric terms for light, brightness, glitter, and shining—all of which must feel dazzling, vivid, and distinct from one another—and even more difficult challenges in the world of sound. The Homeric battlefield is a noisy place, and for the purposes of a translator of *The Iliad* , English does not have quite enough terms for very loud crashing sounds, as created by the clash of metals, the thud of feet, the fall of bodies, the clatter of horses’ hooves, the cry of birds, the crash of waves, the roar of wind, the shouts of warriors hurtling forward to kill, the cacophony of wails and shrieks intermixed, or the screams of the dying. Further difficulties arise in the wide range of Homeric terms for wailing, crying, keening, or weeping in grief, and for shouts or whoops of triumph.

My research for the translation included all the predictable resources—various editions of the Greek text, Greek dictionaries, commentaries and scholarly books and articles. But I also found myself looking more carefully at the play of light on metal, water, or skin, and listening with extra care to the crash of the ocean, the sound of winds or storms or dogs or horses, or people shouting or weeping. Immersion in *The Iliad* has given me a new appreciation for movement as the sixth sense. Because some elements of the Homeric battlefield are not part of my daily life, I looked up videos of lions and boars, and of people measuring grain, working at standing looms, and shooting long bows. I constantly considered how to evoke the multilayered light-scape and soundscape of the original poem, by using a wide array of different words and phrases to echo the rich lexicon of the original.

Working on this translation, I have thought constantly of my experiences in the classroom over the past few decades, and especially the needs of students approaching

the poem for the first time. I have also thought constantly about the needs of general readers of any age, who may have read *The Iliad* numerous times before in different versions, and whose needs may be different from those of students working through the text with an instructor. I want these readers to have, in the present volume, everything they may need to experience the devastating power of this epic.

In ways that are often hard to articulate but run through everything, my work has been deeply informed by my own experiences. I have been reading Homer throughout my adult life. Whenever I hear blustering winds and rainstorms, surging rivers or choppy seas, when I watch a flock of geese or a swooping hawk, when I walk through rustling woods or up a mountainside, I know I am inside the world of Homeric similes. Even the most trivial moments of daily life remind me of Homer. I notice that my feet are not “well-oiled” whenever I tie my sandals on. I cannot watch my dog happily rolling in mulch without thinking of Achilles, prostrated by grief and tossing around in the dust. More seriously, the poem gives me a language to understand my deepest emotions and those of people around me. When I weep for my mother, who died recently in a distant land, I remember the grief of Achilles and of Priam. *The Iliad* is with me always. My own life, as a parent, a child, and a human being, has taught me to understand the poem more deeply.

As a civilian with no direct experience of combat, I have been particularly grateful and honored to have the opportunity to talk to a number of military veterans in Dartmouth, Philadelphia, and New York, as well as cadets and officers at West Point, about the Homeric representation of war. These brave and thoughtful servicemen and servicewomen often say that *The Iliad*, more than modern popular representations of warfare in film, video games, or fiction, strikes them as true to their own complex experiences, although the military terrain and technology evoked in the poem is entirely different from those of any modern conflict.

Even people who have enjoyed *The Odyssey* often tell me they have found *The Iliad* difficult, boring, or both. But the original is the most gripping and heartbreaking work of literature I know. I hope my translation allows even a few more readers to feel the power of this extraordinary poem, and may invite others to hear this marvelous narrative again in a new voice.

## A Note on the Text and the Meter

My main source for this translation was the Greek poem as printed in the Oxford Classical Text, edited by David Monro and Thomas W. Allen (3rd ed., 1920). Like other ancient texts in scholarly modern editions, this Oxford Classical Text includes information at the bottom of the page (known as the *apparatus criticus*) about

alternative readings from the various fragmentary ancient papyri and the various medieval manuscripts, some of which have more authority than others (because some contain more obvious scribal errors and so forth). I took these alternatives into consideration and I have occasionally departed from the text as printed in Monro/Allen where I believe another reading makes more sense; in such cases, I have added an endnote explaining my reasoning. I have also regularly consulted the Teubner edition of the Greek poem (edited by Martin West, 1998–2000). I made heavy use of several commentaries on the Greek poem, especially the six-volume Cambridge commentary (edited by G. S. Kirk and others, 1985–1993), and I also read individual commentaries on specific books of the poem (such as the Cambridge “Green and Yellow” commentaries), as well as the 1970 Martin Willcock commentary. I wore out my copy of Richard John Culiffe’s *Lexicon of the Homeric Dialect* (enlarged edition, 2012), and I regularly consulted Liddell and Scott’s *Greek Lexicon* and the Brill *Etymological Dictionary of Greek*. Margalit Finkelberg’s *Homeric Encyclopedia* (3 vols.; Wiley-Blackwell, 2011) was a useful resource for numerous topics. Many other books and articles helped shape my understanding of particular topics, passages, and characters, and I am grateful to numerous other scholars and colleagues, both living and dead.

The text of this translation includes two numbering systems, because there are more lines in the translation than in the original poem. The primary lineation, marked to the right of the text-column, marks the line numbering of the translation. The one to the left of the translation, in smaller font, is keyed to the original Greek numbering. Both are included so that the reader can refer precisely to lines in the translation itself, and so that those who read the original Greek, or who consult books or articles about the poem, can readily find any given passage and compare it with the original and with its rendition in other translations. In the notes, line-number references are keyed to the lineation of the translation, except where I indicate specifically that the reference is to the Greek (as in “see Greek line xxx”).

The original Greek poem is composed in a regular, musical meter called dactylic hexameter—a regular pattern of long and short syllables, designed to be chanted with the accompaniment of a lyre. A dactyl (*daktylos*) is a “finger”: a long beat followed by two shorter ones. In a hexameter (from *hex*, “six”), this basic metrical unit (the “foot”) is repeated six times, with the final beat missing to mark the end of the line: lālala-lālala-lālala-lālala-lālala-lāla. Ancient Greek verse did not rhyme, but it always used regular rhythm. This rhythm was quantitative, meaning that the sonic patterns were created primarily by the length of syllables, rather than by patterns of stress, as in English verse. There are certain acceptable variations in the rhythm, which add variety to the pacing: the verse may speed up with more short syllables, or acquire sudden slow weight with the heavy thud of several long beats in a row.

I have used very regular iambic pentameter throughout this translation, as the closest equivalent in the anglophone poetic tradition to the original's dactylic hexameter. I hope that the use of this meter will invite reading out loud, honoring the oral heritage of the original. I believe, too, that the use of a meter that has been in regular use in English verse for many centuries can provide at least a partial parallel to the experience of the original, which also uses a verse form that had been used and developed by archaic Greek for hundreds of years before the poem's composition.

Iambic pentameter, as the name suggests, is a rhythmical pattern of five iambic feet, with an iamb being an unstressed (or lightly stressed) syllable, then a heavier syllable: da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM: "We keep the wall between us as we go." There are two very common variants in iambic anglophone poetry. One is the inverted first foot, so that the first two syllables may be a trochee (DA-dum), rather than an iamb (da-DUM)—as in "Better to reign in hell than serve in heaven." The second normal variant is an eleventh light syllable at the end of the line—as in "Tomorrow and tomorrow and tomorrow" (a line that is fittingly a little long), or "To be or not to be, that is the question" (where the speaker's thoughts spill beyond ten syllables). The use of both variants can provide energy and variety of pacing within a regular rhythm; iambic verse without any first-foot inversions or falling final syllables risks sounding too trit-trot, too monotonous. I have used both variants freely in both my *Odyssey* and *Iliad* translations; for instance, I begin both poems with an inverted first foot.

I have aimed to be flexible as well as regular in my use of meter, and to intercut the metrical unit of the line with other kinds of sonic pattern, especially by enjambment, assonance, and alliteration, all of which are features of the original. I tried to avoid phrasing that seemed too pretentious, too quaint, or too obviously allusive or learned—qualities that seemed to me antithetical to the folk-poetry feel of the original. I hope that most readers of this translation do not realize how deeply I love Shakespeare, let alone Milton.

Calliope, the Muse of heroic poetry, probably has better things to do than help a mere translator. Nevertheless, I have prayed for her aid daily for over a decade, as I worked to create these two translations of the Homeric epics. Now that the task is done, I lay my words at the feet of the goddess.



**GREECE  
and  
WESTERN  
ANATOLIA**

MILES 0 20 40 120  
KILOMETERS 0 50 100 200





# JOURNEYS to TROY

## LEADERS of the GREEK MUSTER

Boeotia, Phocis, Locris, Euboea, Attica, Salamis, Argolis

1. Peneleus
- Leitus
- Arceilaus
- Prothoenor
- Cleonus
2. Ascalaphus
- Ialmenus
3. Schedius
- Epistrophus
4. Oilean Ajax
5. Elphenor
6. Menestheus
7. Telamonian Ajax
8. Diomedes
- Sthenelus
- Euryalus
9. Agamemnon

Laodamia, Messenia, Arcadia

10. Menelaus
11. Nestor
12. Agapenor
- Elin, Cephalonia, Aetolia
13. Amphimachus
- Thalpius
- Diores
- Polyxenus
14. Meges
15. Odysseus
16. Thoas

Crete, Rhodes, Syme, Nisyros, Cnathus, Cos, Calydonae Islands

17. Idomeneus
- Meriones
18. Teipolemus
19. Nireus
20. Eurypolus
- Phidippus
- Antiphus

Pelopia, Phthia, Helios, Epirus, Magnesia

21. Achilles
22. Protesilaus
- Podarces
23. Eumelus
24. Philoctetes/Medon
25. Podalirius
- Machaon
26. Eurypylus
27. Polypoetes
- Leonteus
28. Gouneus
29. Prothous

## LEADERS of the TROJAN and ALLIED MUSTER

The Troad

- A. Hector
- B. Aeneas
- Archelochus
- Acamas
- C. Pandarus
- D. Adrastus
- Amphius
- E. Asius
- F. Hippothous
- Pylaeus

Thrace, Paonia, Paphlagonia

- G. Acamas
- Piros
- H. Euphemus
- Pyraechmes
- Pylaemenes

Allye

- I. Odus
- Epistrophus
- Myria, Phrygia
- J. Chromius
- Ennomus
- K. Phorcys
- Ascanius

Lydia, Maeonia, Caria, Lycia

- L. Mesthles
- Antiphus
- Nastes
- Amphimachus
- M. Sarpedon
- Glaucus

## WOMEN TAKEN to TROY

- (a) Chryseis [to Agamemnon]
- (b) Briseis [to Achilles; to Agamemnon]
- (v) Helen [to Paris]
- (s) Aethra [to Helen]
- (e) Andromache [to Hector]
- (d) Diomedes [to Achilles]
- (i) Iphis [to Patroclus]
- (B) Hecamede [to Nestor]

N.B. Army leaders are in the order they appear in the Catalog of Ships (Book 2). Women are in the order they appear in the poem.

Map is indebted to B. Graziosi, *Homer* (2016), p. 48, with thanks.





# The TROAD REGION







Orion

The Pleiades

The Hyades

THEATER  
of the  
TROIJAN WAR

*Hellespont*

A scale bar with two units: miles and kilometers. The miles scale is at the top, with markings at 0, 1/2, 1, and 2. The kilometers scale is below it, with markings at 0, .5, 1, and 2. A vertical line connects the 1/2 mark on the miles scale to the .5 mark on the kilometers scale.

(AEGEAN SEA)

early Bronze Age bay

*Sigeion*

Rhoiteion

Callicolone

R. Simoes

temple

Citadel/Pergamum

Troy/Ilion

### Dardanian Gates

Batea (Myrine's tomb)

Tomb of Aesyetes

fig tree

21

washing-pools

for

PLAIN

TROJAN

Δ  
Tomb of Ilus

Thymbre

Mt Ida

Freibus

# THE ILIAD



## BOOK 1



## The Quarrel

Goddess, sing of the cataclysmic wrath  
of great Achilles, son of Peleus,  
which caused the Greeks immeasurable pain  
and sent so many noble souls of heroes  
to Hades, and made men the spoils of dogs,  
a banquet for the birds, and so the plan  
of Zeus unfolded—starting with the conflict  
between great Agamemnon, lord of men,  
and glorious Achilles.

Which god set  
the pair apart and prompted them to fight?  
Apollo, son of Leto and of Zeus.

Furious at the son of Atreus,  
the god spread deadly plague throughout the camp,  
so that the common troops began to die,  
because their leader, Agamemnon, treated  
Chryses, Apollo's priest, with disrespect.  
This priest had come towards the swift Greek ships,  
and faced the warriors bedecked in bronze

to free his daughter with a countless ransom.  
He had removed his sacred diadem,  
the emblem of the distant god Apollo,  
and held it wrapped around a golden staff,  
and prayed to all the Greeks, and most especially  
the pair of men who brought the troops to Troy,  
the sons of Atreus—Lord Agamemnon  
and Menelaus.

20

“Sons of Atreus,  
and all you other warriors from Greece,  
I pray the gods who live on Mount Olympus  
allow you to destroy King Priam’s city  
and safely reach your homes—if you return  
my darling child to me. Accept this ransom,  
and satisfy Apollo, son of Zeus,  
the god who shoots and strikes from far away.”

30

Then all the other Greeks agreed to take  
the lavish ransom and respect the priest.  
But this proposal did not please the heart  
of Agamemnon, son of Atreus.  
He spoke to him aggressively and sent him  
harshly away.

“Be off with you, old man!  
You must not let me catch you lingering here  
beside our hollow ships a moment longer!  
And if you ever come back here again,  
your staff and diadem will not protect you.  
I will not let her go. She shall grow old  
a very long way from her fatherland  
in Argos, in my house, and work the loom,  
and share my bed. Now go! Do not enrage me!  
Go, if you want to get away alive!”

40

At this, the old man was afraid. He left,  
and walked in silence on the shore, beside

50

the loud-resounding rumble of the sea.  
Once he was far away from everyone  
he prayed to Lord Apollo, son of Leto,  
the goddess with the lovely braided hair.

“Lord of the silver bow, now hear my prayer!  
Great guardian of Tenedos and Chryse  
and sandy Cilla! Mouse Lord! If I ever  
built temples to your liking, ever burned  
fat thighs of oxen or of goats for you,  
fulfill this prayer for me, and let the Greeks  
suffer your arrows to avenge my tears!”

This was his prayer, and Phoebus heeded him.  
Enraged at heart, he swooped down from the peaks  
of Mount Olympus, bearing on his shoulders  
his quiver and his bow, and as he moved  
in rage, his arrows clattered at his back.  
Like night the god descended. Then he sat  
a distance from the ships and started shooting.  
His silver bow let out a dreadful howl.

First, he attacked the mules and nimble dogs,  
then turned his piercing weapon on the men,  
and pyres were always burning, piled with corpses.  
For nine long days the god’s darts flew through camp,  
and on the tenth, Achilles called the troops  
to gather at the meeting place. This thought  
was put into his mind by white-armed Hera,  
because this goddess cared about the Greeks.  
She saw that they were dying. When the men  
were gathered and assembled for the meeting,  
swift-footed Lord Achilles stood and spoke.

“Now Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
if we are crushed by war and plague at once,  
we will be forced to swivel round again  
and go back home to save ourselves from death.  
But come now, we must ask a priest or prophet



or somebody who knows the ways of dreams—  
for certainly, dreams come to us from Zeus—  
to tell us why Apollo is enraged.  
He may be angry at a broken vow  
or lack of lavish offerings to him.  
He may accept the fat of sheep and goats,  
and turn this plague away from us.”

90

With that,  
Achilles sat back down again and Calchas,  
the son of Thestor, stood. He was by far  
the best interpreter of signs from birds.  
70 He knew the past, the present, and the future.  
He was the guide who brought the fleet to Troy  
through skill in prophecy, bestowed on him  
by Lord Apollo. With goodwill, he spoke.

“Achilles, favorite of Zeus, you tell me  
to speak about the wrath of Lord Apollo,  
the distant archer god—and I will do so,  
if you will swear that you will keep me safe.  
Protect me with your actions and your words.  
I am afraid I may enrage a man  
who has great power over all the Greeks,  
whom everybody follows and obeys.  
A leader is more powerful and stronger  
80 when he is angry with a lesser man.  
He may consume his anger for that day,  
but he will keep the grudge inside his belly  
until at last he acts on it. So tell me  
if you will keep me safe.”

100

110

And in reply  
swift-footed Lord Achilles said to him,  
“You do not need to worry now. Speak freely  
and tell us what you know about the gods.  
By Lord Apollo, the dear son of Zeus,  
to whom you pray when you reveal to us

the gods' intentions, Calchas, this I swear—  
no one will lay a heavy hand on you  
beside the hollow ships, not while I live  
and see the light. Not one of all the Greeks  
will harm you, even if you speak about  
90 Lord Agamemnon, who now styles himself  
the best by far of all the Greeks.”

120

At this,  
the seer took courage and replied, “The god  
is not upset about a broken vow,  
or lack of lavish offerings to him.  
It is the priest whom Agamemnon scorned,  
whose daughter he would not give back for ransom.  
That is the reason that the archer god  
gives us these troubles and will give yet more.  
He will not drive away the deadly plague  
that now afflicts the Greeks till Agamemnon  
returns the bright-eyed woman to her father  
without a ransom or reward, and carries  
100 a hecatomb to Chryse. Then we may  
appease the god.”

130

With this, he sat back down.  
But Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
the mighty lord and warrior, stood up  
aggrieved, his black heart full of furious rage.  
His eyes shone bright as fire. He scowled at Calchas  
and said to him,

140

“You prophet of disaster!  
Your words have never done me any good.  
You always love foretelling pain and trouble  
but you have never mentioned or fulfilled  
one single good thing. Now you tell the Greeks  
more tales about the wishes of the gods.  
110 You claim the archer laid this pain on us  
because I did not want to take the ransom.

150

I want the girl Chryseis in my home.  
I like her more than my own Clytemnestra,  
my wife. You see, she is no worse than her  
in figure, height, intelligence, or skill.  
But I am still prepared to give her back,  
if that is best. I want the army safe,  
not dead. Now go, find me another trophy,  
so I am not the only Greek commander  
who lacks a trophy. That would be unfair.  
You can all see my trophy going elsewhere.”

120

160

Swift-footed Lord Achilles answered him,  
“Lord Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
no one is more acquisitive than you!  
How can the valiant Greeks give you a trophy?  
We see no heaps of treasure lying round  
ready to be divided up. The wealth  
that we have looted from the neighboring towns  
has been shared out, and it would be unfair  
to make the warriors return it all.  
You have to send this woman to the god  
at once. One day we Greeks will pay you back  
with treasure worth three times as much, or four,  
if ever Zeus grants us the chance to take  
the high-walled town of Troy.”

170

Lord Agamemnon  
answered and said to him, “Godlike Achilles,  
however brave and skillful you may be,  
stop playing tricks! And do not try to rob me!  
You will not make me do as you propose  
and you will never get ahead of me.  
You obviously want to keep your trophy  
and leave me sitting here with none at all!  
Are you commanding me to give her back?  
Fine—if the Greeks provide another trophy  
to satisfy my heart and make it fair.  
But if they do not give one, I shall come  
and seize a trophy for myself—your trophy!

130

180

Or that of Ajax or Odysseus!

The man I visit will be furious.

140 We will discuss all this another time.

But come now, let us drag the black ship down  
and launch it on the bright salt sea and gather  
a crew of rowers, and then stow aboard  
the hecatomb and beautiful Chryseis.

One council member needs to go and lead them—  
perhaps godlike Odysseus or Ajax  
or Idomeneus or you, Achilles,  
the wildest, most aggressive man alive.  
This leader must appease the god of distance  
by making proper sacrifice to him.”

190

Swift-footed Lord Achilles scowled and said,

200

“Incredible! You dress in shame! You are  
obsessed with getting profits for yourself!

150 Which of the Greeks would willingly agree  
to make a trip because you told them to,  
or fight against an enemy for you?

I did not come to Troy because I wanted  
to fight against the warriors of Troy.

They never did me any harm at all.

They never raided cows from me nor horses,  
nor blighted fertile fields that feed the men  
of Phthia, far away across so many  
shadowy hills, reverberating seas.

210

I came with you, you brazen cheat, to please you!  
To claim back compensation from the Trojans  
for Menelaus and for you—you dog-face!

160 But none of that means anything to you.

You do not even care! And now you threaten  
to take away the trophy that I worked for,  
after the sons of Greece gave it to me.

You always get a better one than mine,  
when we sack any wealthy Trojan town.

220

My hands work hardest in the frenzied fighting,  
but when we share the spoils, you get much more.  
I come back to the ships worn out from battle,

with something valuable to me, but small.  
So I will go back home to Phthia now,  
in my curved ships, because that is much better.  
170 I will not stay here to be disrespected,  
serving up wealth and revenue for you!”

And Agamemnon, lord of men, replied, 230  
“Then off you go, if that is what you want!  
I certainly will not be begging you  
to stay at Troy for me. You see, I have  
plenty of other helpers at my side,  
ready to treat me with respect and honor—  
including Zeus, the god of strategy!  
I hate you more than any other leader,  
any of those whom Zeus protects and loves.  
You always relish war and fights and conflict.  
You may be strong, but some god gave you that. 240  
Go home! Take all your ships and your companions  
and rule your Myrmidons. I do not care!  
180 To me, you are entirely unimportant.  
Your anger does not bother me at all.  
But this I swear to you. Just as Apollo  
will take Chryseis back, away from me,  
when I send her to him on my own ship,  
escorted by my very own companions,  
so I shall take your beautiful Briseis,  
your trophy. I myself will come and get her 250  
in person from your tent, so you will see  
how far superior I am to you,  
and other men will shrink from talking back  
to me, as if we were on equal terms.”

At this, Achilles, son of Peleus,  
was deeply troubled, and his inmost heart  
inside his hairy chest was split in two,  
as he considered whether he should draw  
190 the sharp sword that was hanging by his thigh,  
and rouse the men, and slaughter Agamemnon—  
or curb his anger and restrain his impulse. 260

And as he pondered in his mind, he started  
to draw the mighty blade out from its sheath—  
but then Athena swooped down from the sky.  
She had been sent forth by the white-armed goddess  
Hera, who loved both men. Athena stood  
behind Achilles, son of Peleus,  
and grabbed him by his chestnut hair. She was  
invisible to everyone but him.  
Achilles, startled, turned and recognized  
Athena. She had bright, unearthly eyes.  
His words flew out.

270

“Why have you come here, daughter  
of Zeus, the god who holds the royal aegis?  
Was it to see the cruel violence  
of Agamemnon, son of Atreus?  
I tell you, this will surely come to pass—  
soon he will die for all his arrogance!”

Gray-eyed Athena said, “I came from heaven  
to hold your fury back, if you will listen.

The white-armed goddess Hera sent me here  
because she loves and cares for both of you.

280

Now stop this quarrel, do not draw your sword.  
Taunt him with words and tell him what will happen.  
I promise you that this will be fulfilled.  
You will receive three times as many gifts  
one day, because you suffered this affront.  
Listen to me. Hold back.”

And in reply,  
swift-footed Lord Achilles said to her,  
“Goddess, when you two speak, a man must listen,  
however furious his heart may feel.  
It is the better choice. The gods take heed  
of those who show obedience to them.”

290

Grasping the silver hilt with his strong hand,

he pushed the big sword back into its scabbard.  
220 He did not disobey Athena's words.  
And she rejoined the gods on Mount Olympus  
inside the house of aegis-bearing Zeus.

Achilles, son of Peleus, again  
berated Agamemnon with harsh words.  
His anger was not over yet. He said,

300

“You dog-face! Drunk and heavy with your wine!  
You have the heart and courage of a deer!  
You never dare to put your armor on  
and march to battle with the common troops,  
or join the finest fighters on a raid.  
That seems like death to you. You much prefer  
to saunter through the mighty Greek encampment  
230 and steal from any man who speaks against you.  
Cannibal king, you eat your people up!  
You are a leader of nonentities!  
Otherwise, Agamemnon, this would be  
the very last time you abuse someone.  
And I shall swear to you a mighty oath,  
by this staff here, which will not grow more leaves  
or branches. It was cut upon the mountain  
and left its stump behind, and it will never  
sprout with fresh shoots, because the bronze has stripped  
its leaves and bark. And now the sons of Greece  
pick up this staff and hold it in their hands  
when they are passing judgments to protect  
the customs and the laws that come from Zeus.  
By this I swear to you a mighty oath.  
240 The Greeks will all be longing for Achilles  
one day and you will have no power to help,  
and you will grieve and many men will die  
at Hector's murderous hands. Then you will tear  
your heart inside you in a bitter rage  
because you failed to pay the best Greek fighter  
proper respect.”

310

320

330

Achilles spoke these words,  
hurled to the ground the golden-studded scepter  
and then sat down himself. Across from him,  
the son of Atreus, Lord Agamemnon,  
was seething in his wrath. Among them, Nestor,  
the eloquent, clear speaker, lord of Pylos,  
stood up to talk. His fluent voice poured sweeter  
250 than honey from his tongue. Two generations  
of mortal men had grown and lived with him,  
and passed away, and now he ruled the third  
in holy Pylos. With goodwill he spoke,  
and said to the assembly,

340

“This is dreadful!  
What pain is coming to the land of Greece!  
Priam and Priam’s sons and all the Trojans  
would be delighted if they learned you two,  
the best of all the Greeks at war and council,  
are quarreling among yourselves like this.  
But you must listen now to my advice.  
Both of you are much younger than I am.  
I have spent time in days gone by with men  
260 who were superior to both of you,  
and those great men did not look down on me. 350  
I never saw their like. I do not now.  
I used to know Pirithous and Dryas,  
the shepherd of the people, Caeneus,  
Exadius and godlike Polyphemus,  
and Theseus, who seemed like an immortal.  
Those were the strongest men alive on earth.  
They fought the strongest mountain beasts and killed them.  
270 I was in distant Pylos but they asked me  
to join them, and alone I went to battle.  
No man on earth today could fight with them. 360  
But they paid heed to my advice and listened  
and did as I advised. So you should also  
listen to me. Obedience is best.  
You, Agamemnon, are a mighty man,  
but do not take that woman. Leave her be.



The Greeks gave her to him to be his trophy.  
And you, Achilles, son of Peleus,  
do not confront a ruler face to face.  
A ruler with a staff, who has been granted  
glory by Zeus, receives a special status.  
So even if you are the stronger man,  
and even though a goddess was your mother,  
he is more powerful because he rules  
over a much larger group of people.  
But son of Atreus, Lord Agamemnon,  
restrain your rage, give up your furious anger  
against Achilles—please, I beg of you.  
He is the great defense for all the Greeks  
against horrific war.”

370

Lord Agamemnon  
replied, “Old man, all that is well and good.  
But this man wants to be superior  
to everybody else—to dominate,  
to lead us all, to rule us all, to give  
orders to everyone. In my opinion,  
nobody will comply with his commands.  
If deathless gods have made him good at fighting,  
must his insulting slanders sprint ahead?”

380

Godlike Achilles interrupted him,  
and said, “I would be surely called a coward  
and a nonentity, if I bowed down  
to follow you in everything you say!  
Go and give orders to the other men,  
but do not ever tell me what to do.  
I am all done with listening to you.  
But I will tell you this—take it to heart.  
I will not use my hands to fight with you  
about a woman—or with anyone,  
though you gave her to me then took her back.  
But I will keep the other things I have  
beside my swift black ship. You cannot come  
and steal a single one of them from me.

390

400

And if you try—let these men be the witness—  
your black blood will soon spurt around my spear.”

With these aggressive words the two men fought,  
then both of them stood up, and so they ended  
the meeting of the Greeks beside the ships.

Achilles, son of Peleus, went back  
to his own steady ships and his own tent  
and with him went Patroclus and their men.

And Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
launched the swift ship to sea, chose twenty rowers,  
and drove the cattle for the god on board,  
and led fresh-faced Chryseis to sit down.

410

Artful Odysseus embarked as leader.  
When everybody was aboard, they sailed  
across the ways of water—and meanwhile,  
the son of Atreus, Lord Agamemnon,  
ordered the common troops to cleanse themselves.

They did so and then poured the dirty water  
into the salty sea and sacrificed

420

the perfect hecatombs of bulls and goats  
along the shore beside the barren sea  
to please Apollo. And the savor twisted  
up through the smoke and rose into the sky.  
These were the tasks the men performed in camp.

But Agamemnon did not stop the conflict.

He carried out the threat that he had made  
against Achilles earlier, and ordered

Eurybates and quick Talthybius,  
who were his trusted messengers and aides,

430

“Go to Achilles’ tent and take the hand  
of fine, fresh-faced Briseis. Bring her here.  
And if he will not give her up, I shall  
go there myself with more men—which will be  
the worse for him.”

With these aggressive words  
he ordered them. Unwillingly they went  
along the beach beside the barren sea,  
and reached the place the Myrmidons were camped.  
They found him by his black ship, by his tent.  
330 Achilles was not pleased to see them come. 440  
The men stood awestruck, frightened at the ruler,  
and did not speak to him or say a word.  
He understood, and said,

“Come in, and welcome!  
Heralds are messengers of Zeus and men.  
I do not blame you. I blame Agamemnon.  
He sent you here to get the girl, Briseis.  
Go then, divine Patroclus, bring the girl  
and let them take her. Let these two be witness  
340 to gods and mortals and that cruel lord, 450  
if one day I am needed to protect  
others from ruin. Now destructive thoughts  
seethe in his mind. He is incapable  
of planning for the near or distant future,  
to let the Greeks fight safely by the ships.”

Patroclus did as his dear friend had asked,  
and brought fresh-faced Briseis from the tent  
and gave her to the men to take away.  
They started walking back beside the ships.  
The woman walked unwillingly beside them.  
Meanwhile, Achilles went to sit alone, 460  
away from all his comrades, and he wept  
350 beside the salt gray water, looking out  
across the endless sea. He raised his arms  
and made a fervent prayer to his dear mother.

“Mother, you birthed me for so short a life  
that Zeus, high god of thunder, on Olympus,  
should give me glory at the very least—  
but I get nothing! Now this lord of lords,

this Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
has disrespected me! He took my trophy!  
He seized it and now keeps it for himself!”

470

He spoke through tears. His goddess mother heard him  
down in the salty depths where she was sitting  
beside her father. Instantly she rose  
out of the dim saltwater like a mist  
360 and sat beside him as he wept, and touched him,  
stroking him with her hand, and said his name,  
and spoke and asked him,

“Child, why are you crying?  
What pain has touched your heart? Do not conceal it.  
Tell me and let us both know.”

Sobbing hard,  
swift-footed Lord Achilles said, “You know!  
Why ask me this, when you know everything?  
We went to Thebe, sacked the holy town  
of Eetion and looted everything.  
The sons of Greece divided up the spoils  
equitably, and gave fresh-faced Chryseis  
to Agamemnon, son of Atreus.  
370 But Chryses was the father of Chryseis—  
a priest of Lord Apollo, distant archer.  
And so this priest approached the swift Greek ships,  
and faced the warriors bedecked in bronze  
to free his daughter with a countless ransom.  
He had removed his sacred diadem,  
the emblem of the distant god Apollo,  
and held it wrapped around a golden staff,  
and prayed to all the Greeks, and most especially  
the pair of men who brought the troops to Troy,  
the sons of Atreus. The others all  
agreed they should accept the lavish ransom,  
and show respect and reverence to the priest.  
But this proposal did not please the heart

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490

500

of Agamemnon, son of Atreus.

He spoke to him aggressively and sent him  
harshly away. The old man was enraged.

380 He left the Greeks and prayed to lord Apollo.  
Apollo heard his prayer—he loved the priest—  
and shot his fatal arrows at the Greeks.

The people kept on dying as his weapons  
flew everywhere, all through the great Greek camp.

The prophet knew the archer god's intentions,  
and told us, and at once I said we must  
appease the god. But rage seized Agamemnon.

510

He jumped up right away and made a threat,  
which now has been fulfilled. The bright-eyed Greeks  
are taking her by swift ship back to Chryse,

390 with offerings for the god. Just now his heralds  
came to my tent and took the girl, Briseis,  
the one the sons of Greece had given me.

But Mother, throw your arms around your child  
and save me and protect me, if you can.

520

Go up to Mount Olympus, pray to Zeus,  
if you have ever helped him in the past  
and pleased his heart by any word or deed.

I often heard you in your father's halls  
claim that you are the only deathless god  
who saved the son of Cronus, storm-god Zeus,  
from ruin, when the others on Olympus—

400 Hera, Poseidon, and Athena— tried  
to bind him. Goddess, you released his chains.

You quickly summoned up to high Olympus  
the hundred-handed giant, who is named  
Briareus among the gods, but humans  
name him Aegeon. You called him because  
his strength is even greater than his father's.

530

He sat by Zeus, exultant in his glory.

The gods who live at ease were terrified  
and gave up their attempt to chain up Zeus.

You must remind him now about all this.

Go sit beside him, touch his knees, and ask him  
to help the Trojans and to trap the Greeks

540

410 between the ships and salty sea to die,  
so all of them can profit from their ruler,  
and Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
can recognize his own insanity.  
He paid the best Greek fighter no respect.”

Thetis in tears replied, “My boy, my child,  
why did I birth you for such suffering?  
Why did I mother you, take care of you?  
I wish you could sit quietly by your ships,  
and never have to suffer tears or trouble, 550  
because it is your destiny to live  
so very short a time, not long at all.  
But even as your death runs fast behind you  
you are the most unhappy man alive.  
A curse attended at your birth. I shall  
go to Olympus where the snow lies deep  
420 and talk to Zeus, who loves the thunderbolt.  
I hope I can persuade him. And meanwhile,  
sit by your ships and rage against the Greeks,  
and stay entirely away from war. 560  
Yesterday, Zeus went off to Ocean, joining  
the noble Ethiopians for a feast.  
The gods all went with him. But in twelve days  
he will come back again to Mount Olympus.  
Then I shall go inside the house of Zeus  
and stand upon the pavement of bronze  
and take him by the knees and supplicate him.  
I think I shall persuade him.”

With these words  
she went away and left Achilles there,  
still angry in his heart about the woman, 570  
taken by force from him against his will.

430 Meanwhile, Odysseus had come to Chryse,  
bringing the hecatomb. When they had sailed  
inside the deep recesses of the harbor,

they furled the sails and packed them in the ship,  
quickly pulled down the mast with stays, and set it  
inside its holder, and then rowed to shore.

They cast the anchor-stones and tied the ropes  
to stern, then disembarked in breaking waves.

They drove the hundred cattle off the ship  
to offer to the archer god, Apollo.

Chryseis also left the quick black ship.

440 And then Odysseus, the mastermind  
of strategy, led her towards the altar,  
into her loving father's arms, and said,

“Chryses, commander Agamemnon sent me  
to bring your daughter, and to sacrifice  
a holy hecatomb on our behalf,  
to mollify Apollo, who has cast  
a terrible catastrophe upon us.”

580

590

He handed her into her father's arms,  
who joyfully received his darling daughter.  
The men soon set the cattle round the altar,  
and cleansed themselves and sprinkled barley grains.  
450 Chryses, arms lifted, loudly prayed for them.

“Silver Bow, guardian of Chryse, lord  
of holy Cilla and of Tenedos,  
as once before you listened to my prayers,  
and honored me and overwhelmed the Greeks,  
so now, fulfill for me this new request.  
Drive off their deadly plague.”

600

Apollo heard him.

460 The men prayed too, and sprinkled barley grains,  
pulled back the cattle's heads and slit their necks,  
and skinned them, and cut off the thighs and laid  
two strips of fat on across them, with raw meat  
on top. The old man burned them on a log,  
and poured the flashing wine as a libation.

The young men at his side held five-pronged forks.  
They burned the thighs and ate the inner parts,  
and carved the rest, and put the meat on spits,  
and roasted it with care, then drew it off.

610

They finished with the work of making food,  
then ate, and everybody had his share.

470

But when their hunger and their thirst were sated,  
the boys filled full the wine-bowls, and they made  
libations, and they filled up every cup.

All day the young Greeks pacified the god  
with dancing and with singing lovely hymns  
to please Apollo. And the archer god  
heard and was glad at heart. But when the sun  
set and the darkness came, they all lay down  
to sleep beside the cables of the ship.

620

When rosy-fingered Dawn appeared newborn,  
they made their way towards the Greek encampment.  
Apollo, distant archer, sent fair wind.

480

They raised the mast and let the white sail fly.  
The wind filled up the belly of the sail.

The frothing wave crashed loudly round the stem  
as through the sea the ship sped on and reached  
her destination. When the men arrived

630

at where the large Greek army was encamped,  
they dragged the black ship onto shore, high up  
upon the sand and set long props beneath.  
Then they dispersed to their own tents and ships.

But all the while, swift-footed Lord Achilles,  
the son of Peleus, whom Zeus had favored,  
still sat beside his ships and seethed with wrath.

490

He never went to council where men gain  
glory, nor into battle. He stayed there  
and wore his heart away. He longed for war  
and battle cries. But when the twelfth dawn came,  
the gods who live forever, led by Zeus,  
came back to Mount Olympus. Meanwhile, Thetis  
had not forgotten what her son had asked.  
In misty morning from the waves she rose

640



up to the sky and up to Mount Olympus.  
She found the mighty son of Cronus, Zeus  
whose voice extends around the world, alone,  
sitting upon the very highest peak  
among the many ridges of Olympus.

650

500 She sat before him and her left hand grasped  
his knee. Her right hand touched beneath his chin.  
She begged him,

“Father Zeus! If I have ever  
helped you in word or deed among the gods,  
fulfill this prayer for me, and glorify  
my son, whose fate runs faster after him  
than any mortal’s. Now Lord Agamemnon  
has disrespected him. He took his trophy,  
to keep himself. Wise Zeus, Olympian,  
honor him! Give the Trojans power until  
the Greeks respect my son and grant him glory.”

660

510

Cloud-gathering Zeus did not reply, but sat  
for a long time in silence. Thetis stayed there,  
and kept on grasping at his knees, as if  
grafting herself to grow there. Finally,  
she spoke a second time.

“Make me this vow,  
a solemn promise, and then nod to it.  
Or else refuse, because you have no fear.  
Then I will know for sure I am the god  
most disrespected out of all of us.”

670

Then Zeus who gathers clouds was deeply troubled,  
and said to her, “You have imposed on me  
a dreadful task— to make an enemy  
of Hera, who is always scolding me.  
Among the deathless gods she always blames me  
and says I help the Trojans in the war.  
You have to leave now, in case Hera sees you.

520

But I will try my best to grant your wish.  
And so that you will trust me, I shall nod,  
my firmest guarantee among the gods.  
When I have nodded with my head, my word  
is trustworthy, irrevocable, sure.  
What I have promised must be carried out.”

680

530 With this, the son of Cronus bowed his head,  
with storm-dark brows. The god’s immortal hair  
flowed from his deathless head and shook Olympus.  
The meeting between Zeus and Thetis finished.  
They parted. She leapt down from bright Olympus  
into the deep salt sea, and Zeus returned  
to his own house. No god dared hesitate  
when he arrived. They leapt up from their chairs  
to greet their father right away. Then he  
sat on his throne. As soon as Hera saw him,  
she realized that silver-footed Thetis,  
child of the old sea god, had plotted with him.  
Immediately she scolded Zeus.

690

540 “Which god  
has schemed with you this time, you clever trickster?  
You always love to make these secret plans  
without me, and you never dare to tell me  
openly what you have in mind.”

550 The father  
of humans and of gods replied, “Do not,  
Hera, expect to know all my intentions.  
They are too difficult to understand,  
even for you, although you are my wife.  
When there is something suitable to tell,  
no one will know about it before you,  
not god nor human. But when I decide  
to keep a secret from the other gods,  
you must not question me or ask about it.”

700

Then ox-eyed Hera said, “Most fearful Zeus,  
what do you mean? I never ask you questions.  
You think whatever thoughts you like in peace.  
And yet I fear that silver-footed Thetis,  
the sea god’s daughter, may have talked and turned you.  
She came at dawn and sat in front of you  
and took your knees. I think you bowed your head  
and promised you would glorify Achilles,  
destroying many men beside the ships.”

710

560 Then Zeus, who gathers clouds together, answered,  
“You startle me! You always have your notions!  
I never get away with anything.  
But still, your actions will accomplish nothing  
except to make me even more enraged,  
and that will surely be the worse for you!  
If this did happen, it was as I wished.  
Sit down, be quiet, and do as I say.  
The others on Olympus will not help you  
when I lay overpowering hands upon you.”

720

The ox-eyed goddess Hera was afraid.  
She sat down quietly and quelled her rage.  
Within the house of Zeus on Mount Olympus  
570 the gods were worried, and the famous craftsman  
Hephaestus spoke up to support his mother,  
the white-armed goddess Hera, whom he loved.

730

“It will be terrible, unbearable,  
if you two fight like this because of mortals,  
and cause a ruckus, ruining our pleasure  
in noble feasting. Baser things prevail.  
So I advise my mother—she herself  
already knows that this is for the best—  
to help dear father Zeus, so he will not  
scold her again and so disturb our feast.  
580 If the Olympian lord of lightning wants  
to hurl us from our seats, he can do so.

740

He is the strongest of us all by far.  
So Mother, talk to him with gentle words,  
and soon he will be kind to us again.”

Then he picked up a double-handled cup,  
and handed it to his dear mother, saying,  
“Be patient, Mother. Though you are upset,  
restrain yourself. I cannot bear to see  
my mother, whom I love so very much,  
beaten before my eyes. I could not help you,  
although I would be very sad about it.  
Zeus the Olympian is hard to challenge.

750

590 One time before, when I tried helping you,  
he seized my foot and hurled me from the threshold  
of heaven. All day long I dropped. At sunset  
I fell on Lemnos, little short of death.  
The Sintians took care of me.”

White-armed

760

Hera was smiling. With a smile she took  
the cup from her son’s hand. He drew sweet nectar  
out of the bowl and poured it left to right  
for all the other gods who live at ease.  
Ebullient laughter rose among the group  
600 watching Hephaestus bustle round the hall.  
All day till sunset at the feast they shared  
the food out equally, and also shared  
the beauty of the lyre—Apollo held it.

The Muses sang, exchanging lovely voices.

770

But when the dazzling sun had set, they went  
to their own homes to sleep—each one was built  
with skill and cleverness by great Hephaestus,  
the famous artisan whose legs are bent.

But Zeus Olympian, the lord of lightning,  
went to his own bed, where he always lay  
610 when sweet sleep came upon him. There he slept,  
with Hera of the golden throne beside him.

## BOOK 2



# The Multitude

All through the night the men who master horses  
slept, and the gods slept too—except for Zeus.  
No gentle slumber seized him, and his heart  
was wondering how he could glorify  
Achilles, and bring death to many men  
beside the Greek ships. So he formed a plan  
to send a deadly dream to Agamemnon,  
the son of Atreus. His words flew out.

“Rush to the swift Greek ships, destructive dream,  
and go inside the tent of Agamemnon.

10

10

Convey precisely what I say to him.  
Tell him he has to arm the long-haired Greeks  
at once. Now is the moment he can capture  
the Trojan city with its spacious streets.  
The deathless gods who live on Mount Olympus  
no longer disagree with one another.  
Hera appealed to them and changed their minds.  
Disaster has been fastened to the Trojans.”

Hearing these words, the dream dashed off at once  
and quickly reached the swift Greek ships and found  
the son of Atreus inside his hut.

20

Immortal sleep was swirling all around him.

20 The dream stood by his head and took the form  
of Nestor, son of Neleus, the elder  
whom Agamemnon held in greatest honor.  
In this man's likeness, the divine dream said,

“You are asleep, great son of Atreus,  
the skillful horse-lord. But a man who forms  
plans for the people who rely on him,  
who has so much responsibility,  
ought not to sleep all night. Now hear my voice.  
I am a messenger from Zeus, who loves you  
and pities you from far away. He says  
that you must arm the long-haired Greeks at once,  
because this is the moment you can capture  
the Trojan city with its spacious streets.  
30 The deathless gods who live on Mount Olympus  
no longer disagree with one another.  
Hera appealed to them and changed their minds.  
Disaster has been fastened to the Trojans  
by Zeus. Keep this in mind. Do not allow  
forgetfulness to seize you when the honey  
of sleep releases you.”

30

40

So spoke the dream  
and left him there. Then Agamemnon's heart  
imagined things that would not come to pass.  
He actually believed that he would capture  
the town of Priam on that very day.  
Poor fool! He did not know the plans of Zeus.  
The god intended to bring pain and grief  
40 to both the Greeks and Trojans through fierce fighting.  
The voice the gods had sent to Agamemnon  
suffused his senses when he woke from sleep.  
He sat up straight, put on a fine, soft tunic,  
new made, and wrapped his big cloak round himself,

50

and tied his sandals to his well-oiled feet.  
He slung his sword, adorned with silver studs,  
across his back, took his ancestral staff,  
which never ages or decays, and went  
beside the ships, among the bronze-clad Greeks.  
The goddess Dawn ascended high Olympus,  
portending light to Zeus and all the others  
who live forever. Meanwhile, Agamemnon  
50 ordered the clear-voiced heralds to assemble  
the Greeks with flowing hair. They gathered quickly.  
He made the valiant councillors sit down  
beside the ship of Pylian Lord Nestor,  
then shared his clever strategy.

60

“Now listen,  
my friends. I had a marvelous dream that came  
through the ethereal night while I was sleeping.  
In its appearance, figure, size, and shape,  
it looked most similar to godlike Nestor.  
It stood above my head and said to me,  
60 ‘You are asleep, great son of Atreus,  
the skillful horse-lord. But a man who forms  
plans for the people who rely on him,  
who has so much responsibility,  
ought not to sleep all night. Now hear my voice.  
I am a messenger from Zeus, who loves you  
and pities you from far away. He says  
that you must arm the long-haired Greeks at once,  
because now is the moment you can capture  
the Trojan city with its spacious streets.  
The deathless gods who live on Mount Olympus  
no longer disagree with one another.  
Hera appealed to them and changed their minds.  
Disaster has been fastened to the Trojans  
70 by Zeus. Keep this in mind.’ With that, the dream  
flew off and so was gone, and then sweet sleep  
released me. So come on now. We must call  
the sons of Greece to arms. But first I shall  
test them myself with words, as is the custom,

70

80

90

and order them to row the fleet away.  
Meanwhile, you call them from the other side  
and try to hold them back!”

He sat back down,  
and Nestor, who was lord of sandy Pylos,  
stood up, and spoke among them with goodwill.

80 “My friends! Great lords and councillors of Greece!  
If any other Greek had told this dream,  
we would declare it false and turn away.  
But this is someone with a claim to be  
the best of all the Greeks. So now, come on!  
We have to arm the fighters if we can.”

100

With that, he led them from the council meeting.  
The leaders with their staffs in hand stood up  
and walked behind the shepherd of the people.  
The troops rushed out, as swarms of bees come rushing  
out of a hollow rock, more always coming,  
and fly and cluster on the springtime flowers,  
90 myriads here and there—so many swarms  
of men from ships and huts were marching out  
along the wide beach to the meeting place.  
Among them, Rumor burned. She brought the news  
from Zeus, and coaxed them on. The crowd assembled.  
The place was chaos and the ground beneath them  
groaned as they sat. The noise was deafening.  
Nine heralds shouted at them to restrain them,  
to make them hush and listen to the leaders,  
whom Zeus holds dear. At last the troops sat down  
and stopped their noise, submissive on their benches.  
100 Lord Agamemnon stood up, with the staff  
constructed by the craftsman god, Hephaestus.  
Hephaestus had first given it to Zeus,  
the noble son of Cronus, and Zeus gave it  
to Hermes, lord and guide who once killed Argos,  
who gave it to the man who whipped his horses,

110

120



Pelops, and Pelops gave it in his turn  
to Atreus, the shepherd of the people,  
who left it to Thyestes, rich in lambs.  
Thyestes passed it down to Agamemnon,  
to hold and rule an archipelago  
and all of Argos. Leaning on this staff,  
Lord Agamemnon spoke.

130

110

“My friends! Greek fighters!

Servants of Ares! Zeus, the son of Cronus,  
has bound me tight within a heavy curse.  
That cruel god once gave his nod to me,  
and promised I would sack the sturdy walls  
of Troy and go home safe. But he has played  
an evil trick on me. He sends me home  
to Argos in dishonor, as the leader  
responsible for losing all these troops.

140

This, I suppose, must be the will of Zeus,  
the mighty god who has destroyed so many  
majestic cities and will ruin more.

He has the greatest power. This will be  
shameful, when people in the times to come  
hear that so vast an army of the Greeks  
made war against so few with no result,  
in vain, achieving nothing. If both sides,  
the Greeks and Trojans, could agree to swear  
firm oaths, and offer sacrifice, and count  
how many Trojans live beside their hearths,  
and all of us were grouped in sets of ten,  
picking a Trojan man for every group  
to pour our wine, then many groups would lack  
a server. By so much, I say, we Greeks  
outnumber all the Trojans living here.

120

150

But they have many allies bearing spears  
from many other towns, who beat me back,  
preventing me from sacking this fine town.  
Great Zeus has let nine years go by. The timbers  
and cables of our ships are rotten through.  
Our wives and little children sit at home

130

160

waiting, and still we have not done the work  
for which we came here. Listen, all of you,  
and do as I suggest. Let us retreat.

140 Let us leave here and sail back to our homes,  
the native lands we love. We can no longer  
expect to take the spacious streets of Troy.”

These words stirred every man within the crowd,  
except those who had heard the council meeting.

170

The group was moved, as mighty waves at sea  
beside Icaria are roused by Eurus  
and Notus, rushing from the clouds of Zeus,  
their father, or when Zephyr blasts thick wheat  
and bends the ears with blasts of boisterous wind—  
so the whole crowd was moving. With a yell

150 they dashed towards the ships. Beneath their feet  
dust rose. They told each other, “Seize and drag  
the ships towards the bright sea! Dig the furrows!”  
Their shouting reached the sky. They longed for home.  
They moved the props from underneath the ships.  
And then the homeward journey of the Greeks  
would have begun too soon, before due time,  
if Hera had not spoken to Athena.

180

She said,

“This is disastrous! Look, Athena,  
unwearied child of aegis-bearing Zeus!  
Those Greeks will sail back home to their own country,  
riding the broad sea’s back, and leaving Helen  
160 for Priam and the Trojans to gloat over!

So many Greeks have died for her at Troy,  
so distant from their own dear native lands.  
Now mingle with the bronze-clad warrior Greeks  
and coax each man with mollifying words.  
They must not drag those curving ships to sea.”

190

The goddess with the flashing eyes, Athena,  
heard her and hurtled down from Mount Olympus,

and swiftly reached the quick Greek ships, and found  
Odysseus, whose cunning equals Zeus’.

170 He had not touched his black ship set with benches,  
because his heart was troubled. With bright gaze  
Athena stood near him and said,

200

“Zeus-born  
son of Laertes, master strategist,  
will you all run away like this, and fall  
upon the rowing benches of the ships?  
Will you go back to your dear fatherland,  
and leave behind for Priam and the Trojans  
a glorious sign of triumph—Argive Helen,  
for whom so many Greeks have died at Troy,  
far from their homes? Go now among the army.

180 Do not hold back. Speak calmly to each man,  
and stop them. Do not let them drag the ships  
down to the sea.”

210

Athena told him this.  
He recognized the goddess by her voice,  
and started running, tossing off his cloak.  
Eurybates, his Ithacan attendant,  
collected it. Odysseus approached  
the son of Atreus and took from him  
the everlasting scepter of his fathers.  
With this he went beside the ships, confronting  
the bronze-clad Greeks. Whenever he encountered  
an elite warrior, he stood beside him  
and spoke to calm him and to hold him back.

220

190 “A spirit has possessed you. You must not  
be frightened like a coward or a peasant.  
Sit down and make the others sit as well.  
You do not understand what Agamemnon  
intends to do. This is a test! He will  
soon smite the sons of Greece if they should fail.  
Did we not all hear what he said in council?

Do not let him get angry and cause harm  
to our own troops. Great is the willfulness  
of rulers who enjoy the gods' protection,  
because their honor comes from Zeus, and Zeus,  
the god of strategy, loves them so much."

230

But when he saw and heard a common man  
shouting, he used his staff to beat him back,  
and called to him with orders and commands.

200 "A spirit has possessed you! Now sit down,  
be quiet, pay attention to your betters.  
You are a coward and unfit for battle,  
worthless in war and worthless in the council.  
We cannot all be rulers in this army.  
It is not good for many to share power.  
Only one man should rule and be a master—  
the man on whom the son of crooked Cronus,  
Zeus, has bestowed the staff and laws by which  
the ruler makes the plans for other men."

240

210 So masterfully he controlled the army.  
They left the ships and huts again and rushed  
back to the meeting place—just as when waves  
of loud-reverberating water crash  
onto the long shore, and the deep sea rumbles.  
The men sat down, submissive on their benches.  
Only foul-mouthed Thersites argued back.  
This man knew how to blather on for hours  
with pointless and irrelevant complaints  
against the rulers—anything he thought  
might raise a laugh among the other Greeks.  
He was the ugliest man who marched on Troy.  
One of his legs was weak, the other twisted.  
His shoulders hunched across his chest. His head  
was pointy and his sprouts of hair were sparse.  
220 Achilles and Odysseus especially  
loathed him, because he always scolded them.

250

260

But now his piercing voice shot sharp reproofs  
at glorious Agamemnon, and the Greeks  
blamed him inside their hearts. They were enraged.  
Thersites yelled and cursed at Agamemnon.

“You, son of Atreus! What do you need?  
What is your grievance? You already have 270  
huts full of bronze and full of handpicked women  
whom we Greek warriors assigned to you.  
You get first choice whenever we take towns.  
Do you need yet more gold? Some Trojan horse-lord  
230 will bring it out of Troy to free his son,  
captured by me or by some other Greek  
and brought to you. Or do you need a woman,  
a young one to have sex with and to keep  
all for yourself? It is not right for you,  
a leader, to involve the Greeks in ruin. 280  
Sweethearts, you are a terrible disgrace—  
Greek girls, not men. Now let us sail back home  
with all the ships and leave this man behind!  
Let him consume his winnings here at Troy,  
so he can see if we helped him or not.  
Just now he brought dishonor to Achilles  
who is a better man than him by far.  
240 He took his trophy from him and has kept it.  
No anger lurks inside Achilles’ heart.  
He lets things go. If he were more persistent, 290  
this would have been the last time, Agamemnon,  
you would have treated anyone so badly.”

So spoke Thersites as he criticized  
the shepherd of the people, Agamemnon.  
Quickly Odysseus stepped in and scowled,  
and scolded him.

“You blabbermouth, Thersites!  
You are quite marvelous at public speaking.  
But now shut up! You must not pick a quarrel

alone against the rulers of the army.

You are the very worst, in my opinion,  
of all the mortal men who came to Troy  
with Agamemnon, son of Atreus.

300

250 Your mouth should never speak the names of rulers.

You must not level insults at your betters,  
or look around for chances to get home.

We do not know yet how these things will go—  
whether the sons of Greece will get home safe,  
or have a bitter journey. You sit there  
and criticize the son of Atreus,

Lord Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,  
because the Greeks have given him so much.

310

You keep complaining, but I tell you this,  
and swear that it will surely come to pass,  
if I find out that you continue acting  
as stupidly as you are doing now,

I hope my head stops resting on my shoulders,  
and let Odysseus no more be called

260 the father of Telemachus, unless

I grab you, rip your cloak and tunic off,  
expose your private parts, and beat you up,  
humiliating you with blows. I shall

320

force you to leave the meeting place and go  
back to the swift ships, weeping and ashamed.”

With that, Odysseus began to use  
his staff to thrash Thersites on his shoulders  
till he hunched over, sobbing. On his back  
a bloody weal puffed up beneath the rod  
of gold. He sat down, frightened and in pain  
and helplessly he wiped away his tears.

270 The men were troubled but they smiled and laughed,  
and told each other,

330

“This is something special!

Odysseus has often done great things.

He forms good plans and marshals troops for war.

But now he has performed his greatest service

for all of us—he silenced that rude windbag!  
Thersites will not come back here again,  
led by his strong proud heart to criticize  
the rulers with insulting words.”

So spoke

the multitude. And then Odysseus,  
sacker of cities, straightened up and held 340  
his scepter high. Athena stood beside him,  
280 with flashing eyes. She looked just like a herald.  
She made the troops be silent, so the Greeks,  
both those in front and those right at the back,  
could hear the speech and listen to his plans.  
He spoke among the people with goodwill  
and said,

“My lord, great son of Atreus,  
the Greeks now want you to experience  
the worst disgrace of any man on earth.  
They mean to break the oath they swore to you 350  
when they set out from Argos, land of horses,  
that they would sack the sturdy walls of Troy  
before returning. Now they weep and wail  
like little boys or women struck by grief,  
290 because they want to go back home again.  
Our troubles would make anyone give up.  
A man who waits for just a single month  
trapped on the benches of his ship by gusts  
of winter storms and choppy surging seas  
far from his wife will surely grow impatient. 360  
We have been waiting here for nine years now.  
I do not blame the Greeks for growing restless  
beside the curving ships. But it is shameful  
to stay so long and then go back with nothing.  
My friends, endure and wait a little while,  
300 until we learn if Calchas told the truth.  
Those of you not yet carried off by death  
are witnesses that lately, when Greek ships  
gathered at Aulis, to bring pain to Priam

and to the Trojans, we were sacrificing  
 a perfect hecatomb for the immortals  
 beside the holy altars, underneath  
 a lovely plane tree by a dazzling spring,  
 the water spouting from the tree. Then came  
 a miracle—a red-backed snake, a horror  
 sent to the sunlight by Olympian Zeus,  
 slipped slithering from underneath the altar

310 towards the tree. The sparrow chicks were huddled  
 upon the highest branch beneath the leaves.

There were eight chicks, the mother was the ninth.  
 He ate the chicks, still piteously chirping.

380

Their mother, squawking in her grief, flapped round  
 her darling children, but the snake entwined her  
 and seized her by the wing and ate her up.

When he had eaten her and all her children,  
 then Zeus, the son of double-dealing Cronus,  
 who had revealed the snake, converted him  
 into a sign by turning him to stone.

320 We stood there in amazement at these marvels.

The sparrows and the snake had interrupted  
 the holy hecatomb, and right away

390

Calchas the seer spoke up. ‘Why are you silent,  
 long-haired Greek warriors? Wise Zeus has shown us  
 a marvelous divine sign, slow to come  
 and slow to be fulfilled, the fame of which  
 will never die. Just as this snake devoured  
 the sparrow and her children, eight of them,  
 their mother making nine, so we will fight  
 this war at Troy for nine years. In the tenth,  
 we take the city with its spacious streets.’

400

330 He prophesied and now it all comes true.

So you must all stay here, well-armored Greeks,  
 until we sack the mighty town of Priam.”

At this, the Greeks cheered loudly and around them  
 the ships resounded back a dreadful echo.  
 They praised the speech of great Odysseus.  
 Gerenian Nestor, horse-lord, spoke to them.



“This is appalling! You behave in council  
 like little children, with no thought or care  
 about the work of warfare. What will happen  
 to all our oaths and pacts? Our plans, our councils,  
 right-hand-shakes given as a mark of trust  
 340 and pure libations? All of them can burn!  
 We bicker endlessly with all these speeches,  
 wasting our time and finding no solution.  
 You, son of Atreus, hold firm your purpose  
 and lead the Greeks through every violent conflict.  
 And death to any man, or pair of men,  
 who form a separate plan, which will not work,  
 to go back home to Greece before we learn  
 if aegis-bearing Zeus will keep his word.  
 350 I say that the almighty son of Cronus  
 nodded his blessing on the day we Greeks  
 set sail in our swift ships to carry ruin  
 to all the Trojans. He sent bolts of lightning  
 on our right hand—an omen of success.  
 So no man ought to hurry off back home  
 before he shares a Trojan woman’s bed  
 to pay for Helen’s sufferings and struggles.  
 But if some man is desperate to go home,  
 430 then let him touch his black ship’s rowing benches,  
 and he can meet his fated end and die  
 right here in front of everyone. Now then,  
 360 my lord, make your own plans, but hear me also.  
 I tell you something not to be ignored.  
 Pick men by tribe and kinship, Agamemnon,  
 so tribe helps tribe and kinsmen help their kinsmen.  
 If you do this and all the Greeks obey,  
 you will soon see which leaders and which men  
 are cowardly and which are brave and strong,  
 440 because they will be fighting in their groups.  
 So if you do not manage to take Troy,  
 then you will know if it was heaven’s will  
 or human cowardice and ignorance  
 of war.”

And mighty Agamemnon answered,  
370 “You beat all other Greeks at council speeches.  
If I only had ten men just like you  
to strategize with me, then certainly,  
by father Zeus, Athena, and Apollo,  
the city of Lord Priam soon would crumble, 450  
captured and ruined by these hands of ours.  
But Zeus the aegis-bearing son of Cronus  
has given pain and suffering to me,  
embroiling me in quarreling and conflicts,  
impossible for anyone to manage.  
Achilles and myself exchanged harsh words.  
We fought about a woman. I began it.  
I lost my temper and I acted harshly.  
But if one day we strategize together,  
380 the Trojans will have no relief from pain, 460  
not even for a moment. All of you,  
go eat your dinner and prepare for Ares.  
Sharpen your spears and lift your shields and feed  
the swift-hoofed horses. Check the chariots  
carefully, minds on war, so we can meet  
the test of cruel Ares all day long.  
There will be no break, even for a moment,  
until night comes and parts the eager fighters.  
The strap that holds your shield against your chest  
will sweat around your body, and your hand 470  
will weary as it grasps your sword. Your horse  
390 will sweat and strain to pull the gleaming carriage.  
But anyone I catch in the attempt  
to stay back here beside the curving ships  
and shirk from battle will not have a chance  
to save himself from hungry dogs and birds.”

At this, the warriors shouted, as the sea,  
roused up by Notus, crashes on the rocks  
beneath a cliff, when gusts from all directions  
drive never-ending waves against the shore. 480  
The men jumped up, dispersed, and dashed away  
towards their ships. Smoke rose amid the huts

as they made dinner. Each man sacrificed  
400 to one of the immortal gods and prayed  
he would survive the struggle set by Ares.  
When Agamemnon, lord of men, had offered  
a fat bull, five years old, to mighty Zeus,  
he summoned all the finest of the Greeks—  
first Nestor and lord Idomeneus,  
then the two Ajaxes, and Diomedes,  
and sixth, Odysseus, whose wily cunning  
could rival that of Zeus. And Menelaus,  
the master of the war cry, came to join  
his brother without needing to be called.  
He knew what Agamemnon had been doing.  
These leaders formed a circle round the bull,  
410 and took some barley grains, and Agamemnon  
spoke in their midst.

“Almighty Zeus, great god  
of dark clouds, god in heaven, before sunset,  
before the shadows come, may I hurl down  
the hall of Priam, blacken it with smoke,  
and set his gates ablaze with deadly fire,  
and let my spear slice Hector’s shirt to shreds,  
and may his multitude of friends and comrades  
fall to the dust, their teeth sunk deep in earth.”

But Zeus, the son of Cronus, did not yet  
fulfill his prayer. He took the offering,  
420 but magnified their pain. When they had prayed  
and sprinkled barley, they pulled back the head  
and slit the throat and skinned the animal,  
cut off the thighs and covered them with fat,  
a double layer, with raw meat on top,  
and burned them on the leafless twigs. They put  
the innards onto spits and held them over  
the fire, Hephaestus. Once the thighs were burned,  
they ate the innards, chopped the rest and put  
the meat on spits and roasted it with care,  
430 then pulled it off. And once their work was done,

490

500

510

the cookery complete, they ate the feast,  
and no one lacked an equal share. But after  
their hunger and their thirst had been appeased,  
Gerenian Nestor, horse-lord, spoke up first.

520

“Most honored lord and master, Agamemnon,  
great son of Atreus, let us not stay  
assembled here for long. Let us not long  
postpone the task the god enjoins. Come on,  
let heralds call the army of the Greeks  
to gather by the ships dressed all in bronze.  
Let us together cross the great encampment  
and quickly waken Ares, god of war.”

440

530

Lord Agamemnon heeded him. At once,  
he told the clear-voiced heralds they must summon  
the long-haired Greeks to battle, and they did so.  
The men were gathered quickly and the rulers  
favored by Zeus, at Agamemnon’s side,  
hurried to marshal them, and in their midst  
bright-eyed Athena held her special goatskin—  
the precious, ageless and undying aegis,  
from which a hundred braided tassels flutter,  
each of pure gold, each worth a hundred cattle.  
Wearing this cape, she dazzled as she swooped  
among the troops and urged the men. She roused  
in every heart the will to fight forever.

450

540

At once, the thought of war became to them  
sweeter than sailing home in hollow ships  
back to their native lands, the homes they loved.  
As deadly fire blazes through a forest  
across the mountain peaks and from afar  
the gleam is visible, so brightly shone  
the shimmering brightness of majestic bronze  
as men advanced. It reached through air to sky.

550

460

Just as when many flocks of geese or cranes  
or long-necked swans take wing across the meadow  
in Lydia around the streams of Cayster—  
they soar in all directions, relishing

their wings, then with loud cries they swoop and settle,  
so that the fen resounds with noise—so many  
flocked to Scamander's plain from ships and tents.

The earth was ringing with the dreadful din  
of feet and hooves. A multitude assembled

560

among the meadow flowers by Scamander,  
as many as the flowers and leaves in spring—  
as many as the throngs of buzzing flies,  
flittering round a sheepfold in the spring

470

when every canister is full of milk—  
so many long-haired Greeks stood on the plain,  
facing the Trojans, eager to destroy them.

As goatherds easily divide large flocks  
mixed in the pasture, so the leaders split  
the massive army into ranks and marshaled  
the men for war. And powerful Agamemnon  
stood in their midst, and in his eyes and stature  
he looked like thunder-loving Zeus. His waist  
was like the waist of Ares, and his chest

570

480

was like Poseidon's. Like a bull who stands  
supreme above the assembled herd of cattle,  
just so Zeus made the son of Atreus  
supreme that day among so many fighters,  
the greatest of them all.

Now tell me, Muses,

who have your houses high on Mount Olympus,  
for you are goddesses and you are here,  
and you know everything, you see it all,  
while we can only listen to the stories—  
we have seen nothing and we do not know.

580

Who were the lords and leaders of the Greeks?

I could not tell or name the multitude,  
not even if I had ten tongues, ten mouths,  
a voice that never broke, a heart of bronze,  
had not the Olympian Muses, who are daughters  
of aegis-bearing Zeus, made me aware

490

how many came to Troy. I catalog  
only the captains and the ships they brought.

590

Those from Boeotia had as their commanders  
Clonius, Leitus, Peneleus,  
Arcesilaus, and Prothoenor.

They came from Graea, wide Mycalessus,  
Hyria, rocky Aulis, Schoenus, Scolus,  
Thespeia, Harma, hilly Eteonus,  
Eilesion, Erythrae, Eleon,

500 Hyle, Peteon, Ocalea, Copae,  
Glisa, the citadel of Medeon,

Eutresis, Thisbe where the pigeons flock,  
Plataea, the lush grass of Haliartus,  
the border town Anthedon, Coroneia,  
Midia, well-constructed Hypothebae,  
holy Onchestus, sacred to Poseidon,  
Arne, where rich vines grow, and holy Nisa.

510 These men had fifty ships. And in each ship,  
a hundred twenty young Boeotians sailed.

600

From Aspledon and Orchomenus came  
the Minyans, whom Ascalaphus commanded,  
and Ialmenus. They were two sons of Ares.

The forceful god had secretly lain down  
with admirable Astyoche, the daughter  
of Actor, son of Azeus. She went  
up to the top room of her father's house,  
and there the girl gave birth to twins, who now  
had sailed to Troy with thirty hollow ships.

610

The leaders of the men who came from Phocis,  
Epistrophus and Schedius, were sons  
of Iphitus, who was the valiant son  
of Naubolus. They came from Cyparissus,  
and rocky Pytho, holy Crisa, Daulis  
and Panopeus, and Anemorea  
and from Hyampolis, and others lived  
by shining River Cephissus. Some came  
from near the river's source in Lilaea.

520

Forty black ships sailed with them, and the captains  
stationed the ranks of Phocians with great care,

620

and set them in full armor on the left  
of the Boeotians.

630

Of the Locrians,  
the son of Lord Oileus was captain—  
Ajax the swift, known also as the lesser  
because he was much smaller than great Ajax  
the son of Telamon. The lesser Ajax  
was small and wore a corselet made of linen,  
530 but with the spear, he was the best of all.  
With him came those who lived in Opoeis,  
lovely Augeae, Cynus, Bessa, Scarphe,  
Tarphe, Calliarus, and Thronius,  
beside the streams of the Boagrius.  
Forty black ships came with him, bringing men  
from Locris, facing sacrosanct Euboea.

640

Those from Euboea, breathing force, Abantes,  
from Eretria, vineland Histiaea,  
Chalcis, the beach town Cerinthus, the high  
citadel Dion, Carustas, and Styra—  
540 their leader was Elphenor, friend of Ares,  
the son of Chalcodon. He led the brave  
Abantes and they swiftly followed him,  
hair long behind them—spearmen who were eager  
to smash the enemy's breastplates with their weapons  
of ash, held high and ready. With him came  
forty black ships.

650

And those from mighty Athens,  
people of great Erechtheus, the son  
of earth that gives us wheat, raised by Athena,  
daughter of Zeus. She settled him in Athens,  
in her own wealthy temple, where the youths  
550 offered her bulls and sheep as years went round.  
Menestheus, the son of Peteos,  
led them. No man on earth matched him as marshal  
of horses and of warriors with shields.

660

Nestor could rival him, but he was older.  
And with him, fifty black ships came to Troy.

And Ajax led twelve ships from Salamis,  
and stationed them beside the lines from Athens.

560 The men of Argos and of high-walled Tiryns,  
Hermione and Asine, which both  
control deep bays—and Mases, Troezen, 670  
Aegina, Epidaurus rich in vines,  
and Eiones, were led by Diomedes  
and Sthenelus, the well-loved son of famous  
Capaneus. Euryalus came with them,  
a great and godlike man, their third commander,  
the son of King Mecisteus and grandson  
of Talaus. But of them all the leader  
was Diomedes, master of the war cry.  
Eighty black ships came with them.

570 From Mycenae,  
the sturdy citadel, from wealthy Corinth,  
fine Araethyria, well-built Cleonae, 680  
and Sicyon where first Adrastus ruled,  
from Hyperesia and from the hills  
of Gonoessa, Orneia, Pellene,  
and those who used to live around Aegion  
and all Aegialus and Helice,  
a spacious area—a hundred ships,  
led by the mighty son of Atreus,  
Lord Agamemnon. With him came by far  
the largest, finest army, and with pride  
he dressed himself in shining bronze and stood 690  
superior to all his fighting men  
because he was the best and led by far  
580 the greatest forces.

Those from Lacedaemon,  
the land of valleys and ravines, from Pharis,



Sparta, and Messa where the pigeons flock,  
Bryseae, fine Augeae, Amyclae,  
Helus-on-Sea, Laas, and Oetylus,  
were led to Troy by Agamemnon's brother,  
the master of the war cry, Menelaus,  
who came to Troy with sixty ships. His troops  
were arming separately. He walked among them,  
self-confidently urging them to war.  
He had the greatest yearning for revenge  
for Helen's suffering and struggles.

700

Those  
from Pylos, beautiful Arene, Thryon  
ford of the Alpheus, and well-built Aepy,  
and those who came from Cyparisseis,  
Amphigenea, Pteleus, and Helus,  
and Dorion, the place the Muses met  
Thracian Thamyris and then stopped his singing,  
when he had traveled from Oechalia  
to visit Eurytus. Thamyris boasted  
that he could even win against the Muses,  
if they, the daughters of the high king Zeus,  
the god who bears the aegis, sang against him.  
Enraged, they mutilated him and robbed him  
of godlike song and forced him to forget  
the lyre. These Pylians were led by Nestor,  
Gerenian horse-lord. Ninety hollow ships  
came with him.

710

From Arcadia there came  
more warriors who battle hand to hand.  
They lived around the tomb of Aepytus,  
beneath the rugged mountain of Cyllene,  
in pastoral Orchomenus and Stratia,  
Pheneus, Rhipe, windy Enispe,  
beautiful Mantinea and Tegea,  
Stymphelus, and Parrhasia. Their leader,  
the son of Lord Ancaeus, Agapenor,  
had sixty ships and in each ship embarked

720

590

600

610

many Arcadians, skilled warriors.

730

The great commander Agamemnon had  
given them galleys, which they rowed to Troy  
across the wine-dark sea, because they cared  
nothing for sailing.

From Bouprasion

and glorious Elis, which contain Hyrmine,  
farthest Myrsinus, the Olenian Rock,  
and from Alesion inland came four captains,  
and each had ten swift ships. In each embarked  
many Epeans, and their leaders were

620

Amphimachus, the son of Cteatus,  
and Thalpius, the son of Eurytus—  
who both were sons of Actor—and Diores,  
the sturdy son of Amarynceus.  
The fourth was godlike Lord Polyxenus,  
son of Agasthenes, Augeas' son.

740

Those from Dulicium and the holy islands  
of the Echinades, which lie at sea  
across from Elis, had as their commander  
Meges, as fierce as Ares. And his father,  
the horseman Phyleus, whom Zeus had favored,  
migrated to Dulicium long ago  
in anger at his father. Meges captained  
forty black ships.

630

750

Odysseus commanded

brave-hearted men from Cephallenia,  
who held the territory of Ithaca,  
the quivering woods of Neritus and rough  
Aegilips, Crocyleia, and Zacynthus,  
Samos, the mainland, and the facing regions.  
This leader was a match for Zeus in cunning.  
Twelve ships with red cheeks followed him to war.

760

Of the Aetolians, the king was Thoas,

the son of Andraemon. They came from Pleuron,  
640 Olenus and Pylene, seaside Chalcis,  
and rocky Calydon. Brave Oeneus  
was dead, as were his sons. Blond Meleager  
was also dead. So all rule fell on Thoas.  
Forty black ships came with him.

Of the Cretans,  
Lord Idomeneus, the famous spearman,  
was captain. Those men came from high-walled Gortys,  
Knossos, Miletus, Lyctus, white Lycastus,  
Phaestus and Rhytius, those splendid cities,  
and others from the hundred towns of Crete.  
650 Their chiefs were Idomeneus the spearman,  
and Lord Meriones, who slaughtered men  
like Ares, god of war and god of fury,  
and eighty black ships sailed at their command.

Tlepolemus, a son of Heracles,  
a powerful tall fighter, brought with him  
nine ships of noble warriors from Rhodes,  
an island that is sectioned in three parts—  
Lindos and Ialysus and white Cameirus.  
Astyochea bore Tlepolemus.

The mighty Heracles had taken her  
from Ephyra, by the Selleis River,  
after he desolated many towns  
660 of thriving, lively people loved by Zeus.  
Tlepolemus was raised in her fine mansion,  
but killed his father's own maternal uncle,  
marital Licymnius. The other men,  
grandsons and sons of mighty Heracles,  
threatened him, so he quickly built a fleet,  
amassed an army, and escaped by sea,  
and after many wanderings and troubles  
he came at last to Rhodes and there he settled.  
They had three tribes, all dearly loved by Zeus,  
the son of Cronus, lord of gods and humans—  
670 he poured on them unearthly wealth.

770

780

790

From Syme,  
Nireus led three ships—Aglaea's son  
Nireus, son of Lord Chaeropeus,  
Nireus, the most handsome of the Greeks  
who came to Troy, except for great Achilles.  
But he was weak and few troops came with him.

800

The men from Nisyrus, Crapathus, Casus,  
and Cos, the town of Lord Eurypylus,  
and the Calydnae islands had as leaders  
Antiphus and Phidippus, the two sons  
of Thessalus, the son of Heracles.  
680 With them came thirty hollow ships.

Now from  
Pelagian Argos came the men from Alus,  
from Phthia, Trechis, Alope, and Hellas,  
where women are most beautiful. These men  
are called the Myrmidons, Hellenes, Achaeans.  
Achilles led them there in fifty ships.  
But they ignored the brutal war. They had  
no one to lead them to the battle lines.  
Swift-footed Lord Achilles lay unmoving  
among the ships, because he was still angry  
about the woman with the pretty hair,  
Briseis, whom he worked so hard to capture  
690 out of Lyrnessus when he sacked that town  
and razed the walls of Thebe, and then killed  
Epistrophus and Mynes, nimble spearmen,  
sons of Evenus, son of Selepus.  
He lay there suffering for her—but soon  
he would rise up again.

810

820

From Phylace  
and windy Pyrasus, Demeter's place,  
Iton, where flocks are fostered, seaside Antron,  
and Pteleus, the bed of grass, came men  
led by the warrior Protesilaus,

while he had been alive. By then already  
 700 the black earth held him. Back in Phylace,  
 his wife was left to rip both cheeks in grief,  
 his house was left half built. A Dardan killed him  
 as he was jumping from his ship to shore—  
 the first of all the Greeks. His troops were sorry  
 to lose him, though they did not lack a leader.  
 Their new commander was a friend of Ares,  
 Podarces, son of Iphiclus, a grandson  
 of Phylacus, who herded many sheep.  
 Podarces was in truth the younger brother  
 of brave Protesilaus, who had been  
 a stronger warrior, a better fighter.  
 The troops were sorry to have lost their leader,  
 although they had a new one. With Podarces  
 710 came forty ships, all black.

840

And those from Pherae  
 had come from Boebe, by Lake Boebeis,  
 from mighty Iolcus and from Glaphyrae.  
 Eumelus led them in eleven ships.  
 He was the dear son of Admetus, born  
 to marvelous Alcestis. Of the daughters  
 of Pelias, she was the loveliest.

850

From Meliboea and Methone, rugged  
 Olizon, and Thamacia came men led  
 by Philoctetes, skillful with his bow,  
 in seven ships. In each were fifty rowers,  
 720 all talented at archery in combat.  
 But Philoctetes lay in agony  
 on holy Lemnos, where the Greeks had left him—  
 a deadly water snake had wounded him.  
 He lay there suffering, but soon the Greeks  
 beside their ships would once again remember  
 Lord Philoctetes. Now his troops were sorry  
 that he was gone, although they had a leader—  
 Medon. Oileus, the city-sacker,  
 fathered him out of wedlock, and his mother

860

was Rhene.

And from Tricca, rough Ithome,  
730 and all the land around Oechalia  
and from the city ruled by Eurytus,  
a pair of brothers led the troops—Machaon  
and Podalirius, both skillful doctors,  
both sons of great Asclepius, the healer.  
With them came thirty hollow ships.

870

Those from  
Ormenion, Asterion and white-cliffed  
Titanus, and Hyperia sailed under  
noble Eurypylus, Euaemon's son.  
Forty black ships came with him.

From Argissa,  
Gyrtone, Orthe, white Oloosson,  
and from the town of Elone, tenacious  
740 warrior Polypoetes led the men—  
son of Pirithous, grandson of Zeus.  
Hippodamia birthed him on the day  
Pirithous chastised the hairy Centaurs,  
and drove them from Mount Pelion towards  
the Aethices. He did not fight alone,  
but with Leonteus, the martial son  
of brave Coronus, son of Caeneus.  
These troops arrived at Troy with forty ships.

880

Gouneus brought from Cyphus twenty-two.  
He was the leader of the Enienes,  
the staunch Peraebi, and the men who live  
750 around Dodona, where harsh storms are frequent,  
and in the fields by lovely Titaressus,  
which pours its beautiful clean water into  
the silver eddies of the Peneus,  
yet does not mix with it but flows on top  
like oil, because the River Peneus

890

flows as a tributary of the Styx,  
the water by which dreadful oaths are sworn.

Vigorous Prothous, Tenthrydon's son,  
led the Magnesians from the Peneus  
and from Mount Pelion, where forests quiver—  
and forty ships had sailed to Troy with him.

900

760 Those were the lords and leaders of the Greeks.  
Now tell me, Muse, who was the best of all  
the men and horses who set sail to Troy,  
and followed the two sons of Atreus?

By far the best warhorses were the mares  
of Pheres' son, Admetus. Eumelus  
drove them—their hooves could fly as swift as birds.  
Their coats were matching and their withers level.

910

Apollo of the silver bow had raised them  
in Peria. Both mares, they brought with them  
terror in war. Of men, the best by far  
was Telamonian Ajax, while Achilles  
770 was wrathful. He was far superior,  
as were his horses. But he lay beside  
his fleet of steady, curving boats and raged  
at Agamemnon, shepherd of the people.  
Beside the breaking waves his men enjoyed  
throwing short spears and discuses and shooting  
920 with arrows. By their chariots, the horses  
were standing still and grazing on the clover  
and water-parsley, which the mud had fed.  
The chariots were covered up and stored  
inside the leaders' huts. Achilles' men  
were traipsing round the camp. They missed their leader,  
warlike Achilles, and they did not fight.

780 But all the other troops began to move,  
as when the whole earth is consumed by fire.  
The ground beneath them groaned, just as when Zeus,

930

the god who loves the thunder, is enraged  
and whips the land in Arimi, around  
Typhoeus, where they say the giant sleeps,  
so roared the earth beneath the fighters' feet,  
so fast they sprinted all across the plain.

The messenger on feet of wind, swift Iris,  
went to the Trojans with the dreadful news  
from Zeus who wears the aegis. By the gates  
of Priam's house they gathered, young and old.  
Swift-footed Iris stood among the crowd.  
She made her voice like that of Priam's son  
Polites, swift at sprinting, who was posted  
beside the tomb of old Aesyetes  
to watch for when the Greeks might leave their ships.  
Resembling him, swift-footed Iris said,

"Father, you always love unending speeches,  
now as in former times, in days of peace.  
But now unceasing war has risen up.

I have engaged in many fights and battles,  
but I have never seen so large an army.

Like leaves or grains of sand they cross the plain  
to fight before our town. I speak to you,  
Hector, especially—do as I say.

In Priam's mighty town are many allies,  
and languages of distant people differ.  
Let each commander marshal all his forces  
and lead his men to war."

She finished. Hector,  
who realized a goddess had been speaking,  
immediately ended the assembly.

They rushed to arms and all the gates were opened.  
The troops leapt out, with horses and on foot.

A great cacophony arose. There is  
a steep hill on the plain in front of Troy,  
with space all round, which humans call Batea,





carried him from Arisbe, by the shores  
of the Selleis.

And Hippothous  
840 brought swordsmen from Larissa's fertile earth—  
Pelasgians, led by Lord Hippothous  
and warrior Pylaeus, those two sons  
of Lethus, son of Teutamus.

The Thracians 1000  
were led by Acamas and mighty Piro  
from land encircled by the Hellespont  
with its strong current.

And Euphemus, son  
of Troezenus, son of kingly Ceas,  
led the Ciconian spearmen.

And Pyraechmes  
led the Paeonians with their curving bows  
from distant Amydon beside the wide  
waters of River Axios, whose streams  
850 spread with exquisite beauty over earth.

Wild, hairy Pylaemenes led the men 1010  
from Paphlagonia, the Eneti,  
who live among the herds of wild she-mules,  
and from Cytorus and around Sesamon  
and from the famous cities by the River  
Parthenius, from Cromna, and the heights  
of Erythini and Aegialus.

The Halizones came from far away,  
from Alybe, birthplace of silver, led  
by Lord Epistrophus and Odius.

The Mysians were commanded by two leaders— 1020

Chromius and Ennomus, a seer  
who could interpret birds—but augury  
could not protect him from black death and fate.  
860 Swift-footed Lord Achilles' hands killed him,  
in that same river where he massacred  
all of those other Trojans.

From far distant  
Ascania, godlike Ascanius  
and Phorcys led the Phrygians. They were eager  
for combat in the throng of battle.

Those  
who had been born beneath Mount Tmolus, named  
Maeonians, were led by Antiphus  
and Mesthles, who were sons of Talaemenes.  
Their goddess mother was the Lake Gygaea.

1030

And Nastes led to Troy the Carians,  
who spoke a foreign language—from Miletus  
and from Mount Phthires, dense in foliage,  
and from the heights of Mycale, and from  
the streams of the Meander. They were led  
870 by Nastes and Amphimachus, bright children  
of Nomion. One brother came to war  
dressed in gold ornaments, just like a girl.  
These baubles did not save his life, poor fool!  
The grandson of Aeacus, swift Achilles  
seized hold of him and killed him in the river.  
The victor took possession of his gold.

1040

Sarpedon and incomparable Glaucus  
were leaders of the Lycians, who had come  
from far away beside the eddying Xanthus.

## BOOK 3



# Gifts of the Goddess

When all the warriors had been assembled,  
arranged in proper order with their leaders,  
the Trojans marched with calls and cries like birds—  
just like the cries of cranes across the sky  
when they escape torrential winter rains  
and fly away towards the streams of Ocean,  
and bring destruction to the Pygmy people—  
out of the air they strike and start the conflict.

The Greeks marched silently, breathing aggression,  
their hearts determined to protect each other.

10

10 As on the peaks of some high mountaintop  
the south wind, Notus, pours a fog so thick  
that nobody can see beyond a stone's throw—  
unwelcome to the shepherds, but for thieves  
better than night—so rose the cloud of dust  
beneath their feet—they hurtled at such speed  
across the plain. As they drew near each other,  
the fighter at the forefront of the Trojans  
was godlike Paris Alexander, wearing  
a cloak of panther-skin draped round his shoulders.

20

He held a curving bow and sword, and brandished  
two spears, both tipped with bronze. He stood in front  
and summoned all the bravest of the Greeks  
20 to fight him hand to hand in deadly combat.

When Menelaus, friend of Ares, noticed  
Paris come striding out before the crowd,  
he was delighted—as a starving lion  
is thrilled to come upon a massive carcass—  
a stag with antlers, or a mountain goat—  
and avidly begins to eat the flesh,

30

even if eager hunters and quick hounds  
attack him—in the same way, Menelaus  
was thrilled to set his eyes on godlike Paris,  
believing he would make the culprit pay.  
At once he seized his weapons and jumped down  
out of his chariot onto the ground.

30 When godlike Paris Alexander saw him  
appear among the foremost line of fighters,  
his confidence was battered and he slunk  
back to his group of friends, avoiding death.

40

As in the valleys of a mountainside  
when someone sees a snake and startles back,  
their body trembles and their cheeks turn pale  
and off they run—so godlike Paris, frightened  
of Menelaus, son of Atreus,  
drew back among the throng of Trojan fighters.  
But Hector saw him and reproached and shamed him.

“ Pathetic Paris! Womanizer! Cheat!

You are the very best at looking pretty.

40 Oh, how I wish that you had never lived  
or died unmarried. That would be far better  
than life as such an object of contempt.

50

The Greeks will surely laugh at you and say  
you look so handsome, like a champion,  
but in your heart there is no will to fight,  
no courage—yet, despite your feebleness,  
you gathered up a crew of trusty men  
and sailed in sturdy ships across the sea

to intermingle with the foreigners,  
and brought a pretty woman back with you, 60  
whose relatives by marriage are strong spearmen.  
You brought great suffering to all of us—  
50 your father and your city—all our people.  
You pleased our enemies, but shamed yourself.  
Why could you not face warlike Menelaus?  
You ought to know the man whose wife you took!  
The gifts of Aphrodite will not help you—  
your lyre, your hair, and your attractiveness—  
when you are lying mingled with the dust.  
The Trojans are such cowards! Were they not, 70  
they would have dressed you in a shirt of rocks  
for all the evils you have perpetrated.”

But godlike Paris Alexander answered,  
“Hector, it is quite reasonable for you  
to scold me in this way. Your heart is always  
60 tough as an axe that slices through a tree,  
used by a skillful man to build a ship.  
It magnifies the power of the man.  
The spirit in your heart is just as fearless.  
But do not blame me for the lovely gifts 80  
of golden Aphrodite. Glorious gifts  
that come from gods, that they themselves have given,  
must not be thrown away—although no human  
chooses them willingly. Now if you want me  
to fight in battle and to join the war,  
you must line up the other Greeks and Trojans,  
and in the middle of them all, set me  
to fight with Menelaus, friend of Ares,  
70 for Helen and for all the wealth and treasure.  
And let the winning man, the stronger fighter, 90  
get all the wealth and take the woman home.  
The rest of you must sacrifice and swear  
a solemn oath of friendship. Keep your homes  
in fertile Troy and let the Greeks return  
to Greece, where horses pasture in the fields,  
and women are most beautiful.”

These words  
delighted Hector, and he went among  
the lines of Trojan troops and held them back,  
grasping the middle of his spear. All sat.  
The long-haired Greeks hurled javelins at him,  
and pelted stones and shot at him with arrows.  
But Agamemnon, lord of men, called out,

100

“Hold back, young men of Greece, and do not shoot him!  
Hector in his bright helmet comes to talk.”

At once they stopped attacking and fell silent.  
Hector addressed both armies.

“Listen now,  
Trojans and well-armed Greeks, to what the man  
who started this whole conflict has to say.  
Paris is asking all the other Trojans  
and all the other Greeks to set aside  
our splendid weapons on the earth that feeds us,  
while he himself fights warlike Menelaus,  
holding a duel in the midst of us  
for Helen and for all the wealth. The winner  
will get the wealth and take the woman home.  
The rest of you must sacrifice and swear  
a solemn oath of friendship.”

110

So he spoke.  
Then everyone was silent—no one spoke,  
till Menelaus, master of the war cry,  
called out to them, “Now listen to me also.  
My heart is suffering from dreadful grief.  
I think the Greeks and Trojans must disperse.  
You have already suffered too much harm  
from my dispute with Paris, which he started.  
Death is the destiny of one of us.  
Let that man die. The rest of you, fall back  
at once. And let the Trojans bring two sheep—

120

a white ram and a black ewe, as their gifts  
for Earth and Sun. We shall provide a third  
to sacrifice to Zeus. Call Priam here  
to sacrifice and swear the oath himself,  
because his sons are arrogant and faithless.  
Let no one overstep the oaths of Zeus.  
The minds of younger men are always flighty.  
When an old man is present at a meeting,  
he can assess the interests of both sides,  
because he looks to both the past and future.”

130

At this, the Greeks and Trojans were delighted.  
They hoped the agonizing war would end.  
They lined the horses and the chariots up,  
got out and took their weapons off and set them  
heaped on the ground, one laid beside the next,  
covering almost every inch of earth.  
Then Hector made the heralds rush to town  
to bring the sheep and summon Priam out.  
Lord Agamemnon sent Talthybius  
down to the hollow ships to bring the ram.  
The man obeyed great Agamemnon. Iris  
went as a messenger to white-armed Helen,  
shaped like Laodice, her husband’s sister,  
the wife of influential Helicaon,  
Antenor’s son. She was the prettiest  
of Priam’s daughters, and in this disguise,  
Iris found Helen in the palace hall,  
weaving a massive double-layered cloth  
in dazzling colors, patterning upon it  
the many troubles, tests, and tribulations  
that Trojan horsemen and bronze-armored Greeks  
suffered at Ares’ hands because of her.

140

150

Swift-footed Iris stood near her and said,

160

“Sweet sister, come with me, so you can see  
the new, extraordinary behavior

130



of Trojan horsemen and of bronze-armed Greeks.  
Before, they were intent on deadly war.  
Across the plain they carried to each other  
Ares, the god of tears, the god of war.  
But now they sit in silence. War has ceased.  
The warriors lean back against their shields,  
their long spears fixed beside them in the earth.  
Paris and Menelaus, friend of Ares,  
will fight a duel for you with long spears.  
You will be called the winner's loving wife."

170

With this, the goddess poured into her heart  
sweet longing for her city and her parents,  
and for her former husband. Then at once  
she wrapped herself in fresh white linen clothes,  
and hurried from her bedroom, crying softly.  
She did not go alone—two slaves went with her,  
Aethra, the child of Pittheus, and ox-eyed  
Clymene. Soon they reached the Scaean Gates,  
where Priam's senior advisors sat—  
Panthous, Lampus, warlike Hicataon,  
thoughtful Antenor, wise Oucalegon,  
Clytius, and Thymoites. All these men  
were now too old for war, but good in council,  
just as cicadas settle in the trees  
and fill the woods with sound as sweet as lilies.  
These were the Trojan leaders on the tower.  
When they saw Helen coming there, their words  
flew forth. The old men said to one another,

180

190

"The Trojans and the Greeks in their fine armor  
should not be blamed for suffering so long  
for such a woman, being as she is.  
It is uncanny how she seems to look  
like the immortal goddesses. But still,  
though she is like this, let her sail away,  
or she may bring about catastrophe  
for us and for our children in the future."

160 So spoke the old men. But then Priam called  
Helen to come to him, and said,

200

“Dear child,  
come sit by me and watch your former husband  
and family and friends and relatives.  
I do not blame you in the least for this.  
I blame the gods who roused the tears of war,  
in conflict with the Greeks. Now who is that  
enormous man down there? Please let me know.  
I have seen others taller, but my eyes  
have never seen a man with such good looks,  
170 with such authority. Indeed, he seems  
so like a leader.”

210

Glorious Helen answered,  
“Father-in-law, I love you and respect you.  
I wish that I had chosen painful death  
the day I came here with your son and left  
my bedroom, kinsmen, late-born precious daughter,  
and cherished group of women friends. I did not.  
That is why I have melted into tears.  
But I can give an answer to your question.  
That man you see down there is Agamemnon,  
the son of Atreus, whose power spreads  
across a wide expanse of land. He is  
a skillful leader and a strong spear fighter,  
and he was once my kinsman through his brother,  
the former husband of my dog-face self—  
180 if any of these things took place at all.”

220

Old Priam marveled at the Greek commander  
and said, “You are so lucky, Agamemnon!  
Favored by gods and born the child of fortune.  
So many Greeks are under your command.  
I went to Phrygia where the rich vines grow,  
and saw the massive Phrygian armies led  
by Otreus and godlike Mygdon, driving

230

their quick, bright horses, when those troops were marching  
beside the banks of the Sangarius.

I served among them on the very day  
the Amazons, who rival men, arrived.

190 These quick-eyed Greeks outnumber all of them.”

Then old King Priam saw Odysseus  
and said, “Dear daughter, come now, tell me also  
who that man is—much shorter in his stature  
than Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
but broader in his shoulders and his chest.  
His weapons have been set down on the earth  
that feeds us all, and he himself is pacing  
among the lines of soldiers, like a ram.  
I would compare him to a thick-fleeced ram  
among a mighty flock of bright white sheep.”

240

And Helen, child of Zeus, made this reply.

200 “That is intelligent Odysseus,  
Laertes’ son, brought up in Ithaca,  
a rugged island. He knows every trick  
and he can always form the wisest plans.”

250

Then wise Antenor said to Helen, “Lady,  
your words are true. Godlike Odysseus  
came into Troy with warlike Menelaus  
a while ago, upon an embassy  
to try to get you back. They were my guests  
inside my home. I welcomed both of them  
into my halls. I got to know their looks  
and how they think. They joined us in assemblies,  
and when they both were standing, Menelaus  
was more imposing, with his massive shoulders.  
But when they sat, Odysseus had more  
authority. When they were weaving words  
and telling everybody their proposals,  
then Menelaus could speak fluently,  
few words but clear ones, brief and to the point.

260

210

But when the brilliantly intelligent  
Odysseus leapt up, he kept his eyes  
fixed on the ground and did not move his staff  
forward or back, but kept it still—as if  
entirely ignorant of its proper use.

270

220 You might think he was angry, or a fool.  
But when he did release his mighty voice  
from deep inside his chest, he poured forth words  
like winter snowflakes. No one then could match  
Odysseus and we no longer thought  
to notice his appearance.”

Then old Priam  
saw a third fighter, Ajax, and he asked,  
“Who is this other big, strong Greek, who stands  
taller by head and shoulders than the rest?”

280

230 Majestic Helen in her long fine dress  
replied, “That giant warrior is Ajax,  
the Greek defender. On his other side,  
the godlike Idomeneus is standing  
among the Cretans, and the Cretan leaders  
are gathered round him. Warlike Menelaus  
hosted him often in our home, whenever  
he visited from Crete. Now I can see  
all of the quick-eyed Greeks whose names I know,  
except for two commanders in the army—  
Castor the horseman, and the boxer, Pollux,  
my full-blood brothers. We all shared a mother.  
Perhaps they did not march from lovely Sparta,  
240 or else they did sail here across the sea,  
but now they do not want to join the fighting,  
frightened of all the insults and the shame  
leveled at me.”

290

She said this while already  
they lay beneath the earth, the source of life,  
back home in Sparta, in their own dear land.

Now heralds brought through town the offerings  
to sanctify the oaths—two sheep, and wine  
that cheers the heart, the harvest of the field,  
inside a goatskin flask. A herald named  
Idaeus brought a shining bowl and cups  
of gold. He stood beside the old King Priam  
to rouse him into action, saying,

250      son of Laomedon. They summon you—  
the leaders of the Trojans, lords of horses,  
and of the Greeks in tunics forged of bronze—  
down to the plain to sacrifice and swear  
a holy oath. Now Paris Alexander  
and warlike Menelaus will do battle  
with long spears for the woman. She must follow  
the winner, who will also claim the wealth.  
The rest of us will offer sacrifices  
and solemn oaths, and go on living here  
in fertile Troy. Those men will go back home  
to Argos, where the horses graze in pastures,  
and where the women are so beautiful,  
in Greece.”

When he said this, the old man shuddered.  
He told his men to harness up the horses,  
and they obeyed at once. King Priam mounted  
his splendid chariot and took the reins.  
Antenor climbed beside him and they drove  
the galloping horses through the Scaean Gates  
out to the plain and reached the waiting armies,  
and there they stepped down from the chariot  
onto the earth that feeds the world and strode  
into the middle of the Greeks and Trojans.  
Immediately, the great Lord Agamemnon  
stood up, as did the master strategist  
Odysseus. The noble stewards brought  
the offerings to ratify the truce  
and mixed the wine inside the bowl and poured

330

270 the washing water on the leaders' hands.  
Then Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
drew out the butcher's knife that always hung  
beside the mighty scabbard of his sword,  
and lopped off tufts of head hair from the sheep.  
The stewards shared the tufts among the leaders.  
Then Agamemnon raised his hands and prayed.

340

“Lord Zeus, our mighty father, nursed on Ida,  
you are the most magnificent and greatest!  
And Helios, the sun, you see and hear  
everything! And you, rivers! And you, earth!  
And Hades and Persephone, who punish  
the weary humans in the underworld,  
if any of them cheated on a promise.  
280 You be our witnesses, protect our oaths.  
If Paris slaughters Menelaus, let him  
keep Helen and keep all the wealth and treasure,  
and let our fleet sail home across the sea.  
If light-haired Menelaus slaughters Paris,  
then let the Trojans give back all the wealth  
and Helen, and they also have to give  
appropriate compensation to us Greeks,  
to glorify us even in the eyes  
of people in the future. But if Priam  
and Priam's sons refuse to pay the price  
when Paris is defeated, I shall fight  
290 to make them give me recompense, and stay  
right here until I make an end of war.”

350

360

With that, he used his pitiless bronze to slit  
the sheep's throats and he laid them gasping down  
upon the ground to take their final breaths.  
The bronze blade took their strength. The Greeks and Trojans  
ladled the wine out of the mixing bowl  
and poured it into cups and then they made  
prayers to the everlasting gods like this—

“Zeus, the most glorious and mightiest,  
 and all you other deathless gods, let those  
 who are the first to violate these oaths  
 have their brains spattered on the ground, just like  
 300 this wine—theirs and their children! Let their wives  
 become the property of other men.”

That was their prayer, but Zeus, the son of Cronus,  
 did not yet grant it. Then Dardanian Priam  
 addressed them all.

“Now listen to me, Trojans  
 and well-armed Greeks. I will go back towards  
 the windy town of Troy. I cannot bear  
 to watch with my own eyes my own dear son  
 fighting with Menelaus, friend to Ares.  
 Zeus and the other deathless gods must know  
 which of the two has been ordained to die.”

380

310 With these words Priam, equal of the gods,  
 loaded the lambs inside his handsome carriage,  
 and mounted it himself and took the reins.  
 Antenor climbed beside him and the two  
 sped back to Troy. Then Hector, Priam’s son,  
 and glorious Odysseus first measured  
 the area, then took the lots and shook them  
 in a bronze helmet to find out which fighter  
 should hurl his bronze spear first. The people prayed,  
 lifting their arms up to the gods, and each,  
 Trojans and Greeks alike, made prayers like this.

390

320 “Lord Zeus, our mighty father, nursed on Ida,  
 you are the most magnificent and greatest!  
 Whichever of these two men is to blame  
 for what is happening to Greece and Troy,  
 let that man die and so descend to Hades,  
 and may we have a truce and pact of friendship.”

400

So spoke the men, and mighty bright-helmed Hector,  
keeping his eyes averted, shook the lots.

The lot of Paris jumped right out at once.

The fighters sat in rows, and each man set  
his finely fashioned weapon at his side.

The horses kicked their hooves beside the men.

But godlike Paris Alexander, husband  
of Helen with the lovely braided hair,

410

330 first strapped his armor to his lower legs—  
beautiful greaves equipped with silver anklets.

Around his chest he fixed a corselet, borrowed—  
although it fit him nicely—from his brother

Lycaon. Then he slung across his shoulders  
a silver-studded sword of bronze, and seized  
his massive, heavy shield. On his strong head  
he put a well-made helmet with a horse-plume.

The crest on top looked fearsome as it swayed.

He took his sturdy sword—it fit his hand.

420

And warlike Menelaus likewise armed.

340 When they were ready, from each side they strode  
into the middle of the Greeks and Trojans,  
glaring at one another. As they watched,  
the well-armed Greeks and Trojan horsemen marveled.

The two men now stood very close together  
inside the measured area and brandished  
their spears, in furious anger at each other.

Paris let fly his spear that cast long shadows.

The bronze struck hard against the balanced shield  
of Menelaus, son of Atreus,

430

but did not penetrate. The weapon's tip  
buckled against the sturdy shield. In turn,

350 Lord Menelaus, son of Atreus,  
leapt up and raised his spear of bronze and prayed  
to father Zeus.

“Lord Zeus! Grant that I punish  
this man who wronged me first, this godlike Paris!  
Bring him down low beneath my hands, so that  
all people in the future shrink from harming



a host who treated them with love and friendship.”

440

With that, he aimed, then hurled his long, dark spear,  
and struck the finely balanced shield of Paris.

The sturdy weapon pierced the shining shield,  
went through the intricate breastplate, and then cut  
right through his tunic to his flank. But Paris  
360 escaped black death by leaning to the side.

Then Menelaus, son of Atreus,  
drew out his silver-studded sword and raised it  
high, and then smashed it on the decoration  
of his opponent’s helmet. But the blade  
450 shattered and broke in fragments, three or four,  
and fell out of his hand, and Menelaus  
groaned and looked up towards the spreading sky,  
and shouted,

“Father Zeus! No other god  
could be more cruel than you are! I thought  
that I would punish Paris for his crimes.  
But now my sword is broken in my hands!  
I threw my spear away from me in vain!  
I did not hit him!”

Then he leapt on Paris,  
and grabbed him by the shaggy horsehair helmet,  
460 twisted him round, and started dragging him  
370 towards the well-armed Greeks. And Paris had  
a strap adorned with rivets that secured  
his helmet underneath his chin, which choked  
his delicate neck. Now Menelaus would have  
dragged him the whole way there and won the glory  
for all eternity—but Aphrodite,  
daughter of Zeus, looked down with her keen gaze  
and broke his oxhide leather helmet strap.

Then Menelaus with a firm, sure grasp  
470 pulled off the empty helmet, whirled it round,  
and tossed it out towards the well-armed Greeks,

and his companions caught it. Menelaus  
dashed back again, pursuing Paris, longing  
to kill him with his spear of bronze. But then  
380 the goddess Aphrodite snatched up Paris,  
with greatest ease, as gods can do, and hid him  
in a dense mist, and set him down inside  
his fragrant, perfumed bedroom. Next, the goddess  
went off to summon Helen, whom she found  
upon the high wall with some Trojan women.  
She plucked at Helen's scented dress—disguised  
in look and voice as the old spinning woman  
who fashioned pretty woolen clothes for her  
in Sparta when she lived there, who had loved her.  
In this guise, heavenly Aphrodite said,

480

“Come here!  
390 Paris is calling you back home. He is  
inside the bedroom, on the knotted bed.  
His clothes are dazzling. So is his beauty.  
You would not think he just came back from fighting.  
He seems like someone ready to go dancing,  
or just stopped dancing, sitting down to rest.”

490

With these words, Aphrodite roused her feelings.  
She saw the goddess had a throat and neck  
of most extraordinary beauty, breasts  
to stir desire, and bright shining eyes.  
She was astonished and she said,

“You, goddess?  
Why do you want to trick me in this way?  
400 Will you keep leading me to yet more cities,  
in Phrygia or in fine Maeonia  
if any other mortal takes your fancy?  
Now Menelaus has defeated Paris,  
and wants to take me home with him again,  
although I am so hateful. Is that why  
you come to me now with these tricks of yours?

500

Then go to him yourself and sit beside him!  
Give up the path of gods and let your feet  
never turn back again to Mount Olympus!  
Spend all your time on taking care of Paris,  
crying for him, until he makes you either  
his slave girl or his wife! But I will not  
ever go back. It would bring retribution.  
And I will never service that man's bed.  
All of the Trojan women in the future  
will blame me if I do, and in my heart  
I will endure more pain than I can measure."

510

Glorious Aphrodite, furious,  
said, "Stubborn girl! You must not make me angry,  
or in my rage I will abandon you,  
and start to loathe you with as deep a passion  
as I have loved you as my friend till now.  
I shall devise a strategy to make you  
loathed and abhorred by both the Greeks and Trojans,  
and you shall die a dreadful death."

520

At this,  
Helen, the child of Zeus, was terrified.  
She wrapped her bright white cloak around herself  
and slipped away in silence, secretly,  
so that the Trojan women did not notice.  
The goddess led the way. And when they reached  
the marvelous house of Paris, slaves were quickly  
scurrying round to do their work. But Helen,  
the godlike woman, went up to the bedroom.  
And Aphrodite, who loves smiles, was there.  
She drew a chair for her, and set it down  
across from Paris Alexander. Helen,  
the child of Zeus who bears the aegis, sat there.  
Her eyes would not meet his. She spoke and scolded  
her husband.

530

"So you came back from the fighting.

I wish that you had died out there, defeated  
by that strong man who used to be my husband.

540

430 Before, you claimed you were superior  
to warlike Menelaus in your strength  
and hands and spear. So go on, challenge him!  
Call Menelaus back again to fight you!  
But no. I order you to stop. Do not  
make war and fight with ruddy Menelaus.  
It would be idiotic. You would soon  
lose and lie dead beneath that fighter's spear."

Then Paris answered, "Do not scold me, wife,  
with so much criticism of my courage.

550

It is true Menelaus beat me this time—  
thanks to Athena. Next time, I shall win.  
440 We also have some gods on our own side.  
But come now, let us go to bed and take  
pleasure in making love. I never felt  
desire like this enfolded all around me,  
not even when I first took you away  
by ship across the sea from lovely Sparta,  
and afterwards, upon the isle of Cranae,  
I shared a bed with you and we made love.  
Not even then was I so seized by sweet  
desire for you."

560

He led her to the bed.  
His wife came with him and the two of them  
lay there together on the well-made bed.

But meanwhile, Menelaus paced around  
all through the crowd, like some wild animal,  
450 trying to catch a glimpse of godlike Paris.  
None of the Trojans or their noble allies  
could find where Paris was—though if they had,  
they would not have concealed him out of friendship.  
Indeed, the Trojans all detested Paris,  
as if he were black death. Then Agamemnon,

570

the lord of men, said,

“Listen to me now,  
Trojans, Dardanians, and allied fighters.  
It must be obvious that Menelaus  
has won the duel. So you must return  
both Argive Helen and the treasure with her,  
and pay a proper compensation too,  
460 so people in the future will remember.”

The Greeks approved the words of Agamemnon.

580

## BOOK 4



## First Blood

The gods were gathered around Zeus. They sat upon the golden floor, and noble Hebe poured nectar out for them to drink like wine. They raised their golden cups to toast each other, and gazed towards the town of Troy. Abruptly, the son of Cronus tried to nettle Hera. He nipped at her with these insinuations.

“Two goddesses are helping Menelaus—  
Hera of Argos and Athena, worshipped  
in Alalcomenae. And yet they sit here  
and keep their distance, happy just to watch.

10

10

Meanwhile, the ever-smiling Aphrodite  
is always by the side of Paris, always  
protecting him from death. Just now she saved him  
when he must have expected he would die.  
But warlike Menelaus was the winner.  
We have to strategize. Shall we rouse up  
terrible war and bitter strife again?  
Or should we reconcile the warring sides?

If peace is sweet and pleasing to us all,  
the city of Lord Priam may continue  
to be inhabited, and Menelaus  
can take back Argive Helen as his wife.”

20

20 At these words, Hera and Athena muttered.  
They sat beside each other, with their minds  
both fixed on causing ruin to the Trojans.  
And yet Athena held her tongue, possessed  
by fearsome rage, and scowled at Zeus her father.  
But Hera’s heart could not contain her anger.  
She said to him,

“You are the very worst  
of all the children of our father Cronus!  
What have you said? How could you make my labor  
useless—a pointless struggle to no end?  
What about all my hard work, all my sweat?  
I drove my chariot horses to exhaustion  
gathering this great army to bring ruin  
to Priam and his children. Well, go on,  
do it. But not a single other god  
will speak in favor of your choices.”

30

Zeus,  
30 the god who musters clouds, was deeply troubled.  
He answered, “Hera, you are very strange!  
What dreadful wrong have Priam and his children  
done you that you are always so insistent  
on ruining the well-built town of Troy?  
If you went through the gates of those high walls  
and ate up Priam raw, and Priam’s children,  
and all the other Trojans, only then  
you might be cured of rage. But as you wish.  
This little disagreement must not cause  
a rift between us two in times to come.  
But let me tell you something now. Take heed.  
40 Next time I crave the total devastation

40

50

of any city whose inhabitants  
are dear to you, you must not thwart my anger.  
Allow me that because I gave you this  
willingly, though my heart is far from willing.  
Of all the towns on earth where humans live  
beneath the sun, beneath the starry sky,  
none is more precious, none more dear to me  
than holy Troy and Priam and the people  
of Priam with the good ash spear, because  
my altar there is always well provided  
with offerings of drink and roasted fat,  
which we receive as special gifts of honor.”

60

50 Majestic ox-eyed Hera answered him,  
“I love three cities most of all by far—  
Mycenae with its spacious streets, and Sparta,  
and Argos. Any time you start to hate them,  
destroy them. I will not stand up for them  
or grudge you this. And even if I tried  
to stop you, if I told you not to sack them,  
I would not manage it. You are much stronger.  
But even so, you must not spoil my work,  
making it all for nothing. I am also  
a god like you. Our parents are the same.  
Our crooked father Cronus had me first,  
and thus I am the eldest of us all.  
I have the highest honor, for two reasons—  
because it is my birthright as the eldest,  
60 and also because I am called your wife,  
and you are lord of all the other gods.  
So let us compromise in these decisions.  
I yield to you, and you to me, and all  
the other deathless gods will follow us.  
Now quickly send Athena to the field  
of dreadful carnage. She must try to make  
the Trojans violate the sacred oaths.  
Let them initiate hostilities  
against the arrogant Greeks.”

70

80



So Hera spoke.

The father of the gods and humankind  
obeyed her, and at once his words took wing.  
He told Athena, “Hurry to the armies  
and join the Greeks and Trojans. Try to make  
the Trojans violate the sacred oaths.  
Let them initiate hostilities  
against the arrogant Greeks.”

90

So he spurred on

Athena, who was keen to go already.  
She swooped down from the peaks of Mount Olympus—  
just as when Zeus, the son of crooked Cronus,  
shoots forth a shining star, which is a portent  
for sailors or a massive crowd of troops,  
and from it, millions of sparks pour forth—  
just so Athena swooped to earth and leapt  
among them. All who saw her were amazed—  
the Trojan horsemen and the well-armed Greeks.  
They told each other, “Either evil war  
and dreadful carnage will begin again,  
or Zeus will reconcile the warring sides.  
Zeus is the one who serves up war for humans.”

100

So said the Greeks and Trojans. But the goddess  
entered the crowd resembling a Trojan,  
a mighty spearman named Laodocus,  
Antenor’s son. She looked for Pandarus,  
Lycaon’s son, a godlike, brave, strong man,  
and found him standing with the sturdy ranks  
of men with shields who followed him to Troy  
from River Aesepus. Athena stood  
near him and spoke winged words.

110

“Trust me in this,  
great fighter Pandarus, Lycaon’s son.  
Have courage—quickly shoot at Menelaus!  
Then all the Trojans will admire and thank you,

120

especially Lord Paris Alexander.  
Certainly he will give you splendid gifts  
as soon as he sees warlike Menelaus,  
the son of Atreus, killed by your arrow,  
and laid out on his funeral pyre. Go on,  
100 shoot with your bow at glorious Menelaus,  
and vow to give the god of archery,  
wolf-born Apollo, a fine hecatomb  
of newborn lambs, when you are home again,  
back in the holy city of Zelea.” 130

So spoke Athena, and her words persuaded  
the mindless mind of Pandarus. At once  
he took the cover off his polished bow,  
made from a nimble wild goat’s horn, which he  
had hunted. He had lain in wait and watched  
till from behind a rock the goat jumped out.  
Pandarus hit his chest right through the heart.  
The goat fell backward on the rock. This horn  
was sixteen palms in length. A master craftsman  
110 had smoothed it down and polished it all over  
and set a golden hook upon the tip.  
Pandarus carefully arranged this bow  
resting it on the ground and stretched it out,  
bending it, while his brave companions held  
their shields in front of him, in case the Greeks  
attacked before he had the chance to strike  
the son of Atreus, fierce Menelaus.  
Then Pandarus removed the quiver’s lid,  
and took a full-fledged arrow, never used,  
support for darkening pains. At once he set  
the piercing weapon on the string, and vowed  
to give the wolf-born archer god, Apollo,  
120 a glorious hecatomb of newborn lambs  
when he returned to sacrosanct Zelea,  
the city where he lived. He grasped and pulled  
the oxhide string and arrow’s notch together,  
drawing the strand in close beside his nipple,  
the arrow’s iron head beside the wood. 150

He stretched the great curved belly, then the bow  
twanged, and the bowstring thrummed. The sharp-tipped arrow  
leapt forward in its eagerness to fly  
into the crowd. But, Menelaus, you  
were not forgotten by the deathless gods.

Athena first, the one who hunts for spoils,  
the child of Zeus, stood right in front of you,  
protecting you against the piercing arrow.

She brushed it from his skin—as light a gesture

130 as when a mother strokes away a fly  
to keep it from her baby, sweetly sleeping.

She steered the arrow to the golden buckles  
clasping his belt together, where his corselet  
was folded double so its sharpened point  
alighted on the fitted belt and drove  
right through its ornate workmanship, and pushed  
on through the decorations of his corselet  
and through the band he wore against his skin,  
his last protection from sharp-pointed darts.

Even through this it made its way, and grazed  
just through the outmost layer of his skin.

140 At once the wound gushed blood as black as clouds,  
as when a woman from Maeonia  
or Caria stains ivory with purple  
to make a horse's cheekpiece, which is stored  
inside an inner chamber, and great numbers  
of charioteers are longing to possess it,  
but it is saved as treasure for a king,  
a beautiful decoration for the horse,  
and glory for the driver—Menelaus,  
so were your handsome thighs all stained with blood,  
so were your handsome calves and shapely ankles.

Lord Agamemnon shuddered when he saw  
the black blood flowing down out of the wound.

150 And warlike Menelaus also shuddered,  
seeing the arrow's binding strings and barbs  
sticking outside, and in his chest his courage  
shriveled and shrank. Then mighty Agamemnon  
groaned deeply as he took his brother's hand.

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190

Their comrades groaned in answer. Agamemnon said,

“My dear brother, did I make those oaths  
and sacrifices just to cause your death,  
when I sent you out there alone to fight  
the Trojans, while we other Greeks looked on?  
The Trojans have attacked you! They have trampled  
the sacred oaths! But it was not for nothing—  
our vows, the blood of lambs, the pure libations,  
the clasped right hands in which we put our trust.  
160 Even if Zeus the Olympian has not yet  
fulfilled these promises, the time is coming  
when they will pay a heavy price. It lies  
upon their heads, their women’s, and their children’s.  
Indeed, I know this well in heart and mind,  
that there will be a day when holy Troy  
will be destroyed, and Priam, and the people  
of Priam with the good ash spear. And Zeus,  
the son of Cronus, on his lofty throne  
high in the sky, will shake at all of them  
his storm-black cape, the aegis, in his fury  
against the Trojans for their treachery.  
This surely will come true. But Menelaus,  
my grief for you will be unbearable  
170 if you should die and fill your span of life.  
Then I would go back home to thirsty Argos  
in terrible disgrace, because the Greeks  
would instantly be thinking of their homeland.  
Then Priam and the Trojans would be gloating  
about their triumph, because we would leave  
Helen of Argos here behind. And you  
will lie here, brother, in a Trojan field.  
Your bones will rot, your quest left unaccomplished.  
One of the overweening Trojan troops  
will leap upon the mound that marks the tomb  
of famous Menelaus and declare,  
‘May Agamemnon’s anger always end  
in such futility! He led an army

200  
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230

180 of Greeks to Troy for nothing, then returned  
home to his fatherland with empty ships,  
and left brave Menelaus fallen here.’  
When they say this, I hope the wide earth gapes  
to swallow me.”

But light-haired Menelaus  
spoke to console him. “Do not be so worried,  
and do not let the Greek troops be afraid.  
The arrow did not pierce a fatal spot.  
My shimmering belt prevented it, along with  
the waistband underneath it and the strap  
created by the men who work with bronze.”  
Powerful Agamemnon answered him,  
“I do hope so, dear brother Menelaus.  
190 A doctor will lay hands upon your wound,  
applying medications that can stop  
the darkening agonies.”

240

250

And then he told  
Talthybius, the godlike herald, “Hurry,  
Talthybius, and bring Machaon here—  
son of Asclepius, the famous doctor.  
Let him examine noble Menelaus,  
the warrior son of Atreus, whom someone,  
from Lycia or from Troy, a skillful archer,  
has struck and wounded with an arrow’s shot—  
glory for him, but pain and grief for us.”

The herald listened and obeyed his orders.  
He rushed all through the camp of bronze-armed Greeks,  
looking around all over for Machaon.  
200 He saw him in the middle of his troops,  
the men with shields who came with him to Troy  
from meadowlands in Tricca, grazed by horses.  
Talthybius came near and stood beside him,  
and spoke winged words to him.

260

“Be quick, Machaon,  
son of Asclepius. Lord Agamemnon  
has summoned you to look at Menelaus,  
the warlike leader of the Greeks, whom someone  
from Lycia or from Troy, a skillful archer,  
has struck and wounded with an arrow’s shot—  
glory for him, but pain and grief for us.”

270

210 With this, he roused the doctor’s heart. Machaon  
dashed through the massive, crowded Greek encampment,  
and reached blond Menelaus, lying wounded,  
with all the finest fighters gathered round,  
encircling him. The godlike doctor came  
into the circle, stood beside the patient,  
and pulled the arrow from the fitted belt  
quickly, and as he tugged, the pointed barbs  
broke off. Then he undid the shining belt,  
and under it, the waistband and the strap,  
created by the men who work with bronze.  
And when he saw the wound where the sharp arrow  
had penetrated, he sucked out the blood,  
then skillfully applied the healing ointments  
given by kindly Chiron to his father.  
220 And while the Greeks were tending Menelaus,  
the master of the war cry, lines of Trojans,  
warriors holding shields, came marching forward.  
So then the Greeks again put on their armor,  
again remembering the joy of battle.  
You would not see majestic Agamemnon  
nod off or cower or refuse to fight.  
He rushed at top speed to the field of glory,  
but did not ride his horse-drawn chariot  
adorned with bronze. His man, Eurymedon,  
the son of Ptolemy, son of Piraeus,  
held back his panting horses at a distance.  
But Agamemnon gave him strict instructions  
to bring them any time he grew too tired  
230 from giving orders through so great a crowd.  
He ranged on foot, examining the troops.

280

290

300

Whenever any Greeks, the lords of horses,  
were straining forward eagerly, he stood  
beside them and encouraged them like this—

“Do not give up or lose your ardent courage!  
Our father Zeus will surely not provide  
help for those liars who were first to break  
the sacred oaths! The vultures will devour  
their delicate soft flesh and we shall take  
their little children and their darling wives  
home in our ships once we have sacked their town.”

310

240 But when he saw men shirking from the danger  
of hateful war, he scolded them in anger.  
“You Greeks are a disgrace! You are all talk!  
Why are you not ashamed? Why are you standing  
bewildered? Just like fawns when they get tired  
from running far across the plain, and stop,  
and none of them has any drive or courage  
inside her heart—just so you stand there, stunned,  
not fighting. Are you waiting for the Trojans  
to reach the sterns of our fine ships, which we  
dragged up the beach away from the gray sea,  
so you can see if Zeus, the son of Cronus,  
will reach his hand to save you?”

320

250 In this way,  
he walked all through the ranks of men, displaying  
his power. Then he reached the throng of Cretans  
led by the skillful Idomeneus,  
arming themselves. In their front line of fighters  
stood Idomeneus, who had the courage  
of a wild boar, while at the very back,  
Meriones was urging them ahead.  
Seeing them, Agamemnon, lord of men,  
was glad and spoke to Idomeneus  
in friendly greeting.

330

“Idomeneus,  
of all the Greeks who ride behind swift horses,  
you are the man I honor most in war,  
or any other area of action, 340  
or at a feast when all the best Greek fighters  
260 are mixing bright-faced wine inside a bowl,  
an accolade for leaders of the army.  
If other Greeks are sharing in the drink,  
your cup is always full, just like my own,  
so you can drink whenever you desire.  
Now rouse yourself for battle. Be the man  
you used to be in your old glory days.”

The Cretan leader Idomeneus  
answered him, “Son of Atreus, I shall 350  
remain your loyal comrade, just as when  
I first bowed down and made my vow to you.  
Go on, encourage other long-haired Greeks.  
Tell everybody we must fight at once,  
now that the Trojans have undone the oaths.  
270 Death and destruction are in store for them  
because they were the first to break the truce.”

At these words, Agamemnon’s heart was glad.  
He went away, passed through a crowd of men,  
and found the two called Ajax, fully armed. 360  
A cloud of men on foot came after them—  
as when a goatherd on a clifftop sees  
a cloud approaching, pushed across the sea  
by Zephyr’s blast—to him, so far above it,  
it looks like black pitch covering the water,  
bringing a great tornado—at the sight,  
he shudders and then drives his flock to shelter  
280 inside a cave—so dark, so thickly packed,  
bristling with spears and shields, the lines of fighters,  
strong men whom Zeus had favored, marched ahead, 370  
led by the two named Ajax. At the sight,  
powerful Agamemnon was delighted,  
and let his words take wing.



“Ajax and Ajax!

You are both leaders of the bronze-clad Greeks.

I need not order you or spur you on,

because you are already vehemently urging

the troops to fight with all their strength. If only,

by father Zeus, Athena, and Apollo,

all men had so much courage in their hearts.

290 King Priam’s city would then quickly crumble,  
captured and ruined by these hands of ours.”

380

With this, he left them there and went to others.

He came to Nestor, the articulate

Pyliaen councillor, who urged and ordered

his men to fight. And at his side, his comrades

were Chromius, great Pelagon, Alastor,

strong Haemon and the people’s shepherd, Bion.

Nestor had placed the cavalry in front—

the horses with their chariots and drivers.

He set the infantry to guard the rear—

numerous fighters as a barricade

in battle. And he drove the commoners

into the middle, so reluctant fighters

300 would be compelled to fight against their will.

First, he gave orders to the charioteers,

ordering them to hold their horses back

and not to panic in the throng of battle.

390

“Let none of you get overconfident

about your horsemanship or manliness

and rush ahead of everybody else

to fight the Trojans. Do not draw back either,

or you will all be weakened. When you reach

the enemy chariots, remain in yours

and stretch your spears out. That is better practice.

By this means, many men in former days

have razed and ruined towns and city walls,

keeping this same intention in their hearts.”

400

310 So did the old man, who remembered well  
the wars of long ago, urge on the men.  
Powerful Agamemnon was delighted  
to see it and he spoke winged words to him.

410

“Nestor, old soldier, how I wish your strength  
of body could still match your vigorous mind.  
But age, the equalizer, wears you down.  
I wish some other man was weak like you,  
and you could still take part with younger men.”

Gerenian Nestor, horse-lord, answered him,  
“Yes, son of Atreus, I wish that too.  
If only I could be the same as when  
I killed bright Ereuthalion. The gods  
320 do not give everything at once to humans.  
Then I was young. Now old age weighs me down.  
But I will still accompany the horsemen  
and give them orders and convey advice.  
This is the privilege of age. My juniors,  
confident in their strength, will be the ones  
to hold and hurl the spears.”

420

So Nestor spoke,  
and Agamemnon, glad at heart, walked on  
until he found Menestheus, the son  
of Peteos, who loved to whip his horses.  
Menestheus, with his Athenians  
who instigate the cry of war, was standing  
stock-still. Beside him stood Odysseus,  
330 the cunning strategist, with his own troops  
from Cephallenia. They also stood  
unmoving, although none of them were cowards.  
These troops had not yet heard the cry of war.  
The phalanxes of Greeks and Trojan horse-lords  
had only just been roused to move together.  
These men were waiting for a Greek battalion  
to come and stir them up to fight the Trojans,

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440

initiating battle. Agamemnon,  
the lord of men, saw them and scolded them,  
letting his winged words fly.

“Menestheus,  
son of a king to whom Zeus gave protection!  
And you, Odysseus! You are a genius  
at manufacturing your wicked schemes  
and plotting to advance your own self-interest.  
Why are you holding back, the pair of you?  
Why are you cowering out here, aloof, 450  
340 waiting for other people to go first?  
You ought to stand among the foremost fighters  
and meet the blaze of battle face to face.  
You are the first to hear about my feasts,  
provided by us Greeks to glorify  
the highest-ranking warriors. At them,  
you eat roast meat and drink full cups of wine  
as sweet as honey, all night if you want to.  
But now you gladly watch the other Greeks,  
ten whole battalions of defensive fighters, 460  
striving with cruel bronze, while you lag back.”

Cunning Odysseus replied with scowls,  
350 “How can you say this, son of Atreus?  
What words have slipped out past your fence of teeth?  
How can you say we are avoiding war?  
Whenever our side rouses piercing Ares  
against the Trojan horsemen, we are there.  
If you have any interest, you will see  
the loving father of Telemachus  
beside the foremost warriors, and fighting 470  
the Trojan horsemen. You are talking nonsense.”

When mighty Agamemnon realized  
Odysseus was furious, he smiled  
and took his comments back.

“Odysseus!

Son of Laertes, favorite of Zeus!

You are so full of clever schemes and plots!

I will not scold or blame you, not too much,  
or give you orders. I already know

360 that in your heart of hearts you think of me  
with deep affection. Certainly, your thoughts  
and attitudes are just the same as mine.

480

If anything unpleasant has been said,  
let it be all forgotten in the future,  
and may the gods ensure it comes to nothing.”

With that, he left them there and went to others.

He found the dauntless Diomedes, son  
of Tydeus, who stood amid his horses  
and well-constructed chariots. Beside him  
stood Sthenelus, son of Capaneus.

Lord Agamemnon scolded him on sight,  
letting his words take wing.

490

“Hey Diomedes!

370 Son of the skillful horse-lord Tydeus!

Why are you cowering and merely watching  
the channels in between the ranks of fighters?

Tydeus scorned to shirk as you are doing.

He much preferred to fight the enemy  
for his dear friends—so say the men who saw him  
at work. I never saw him, never met him.

They say he was extraordinary. In fact,  
he visited Mycenae, not in wartime

500

but as a visitor, with Polyneices,  
to gather troops. At that time, they were fighting  
against the holy city walls of Thebes.

They begged for glorious auxiliaries.

380 The Mycenaeans willingly agreed  
to give them—but Zeus changed their minds. He sent  
bad omens. So the two men traveled onward,  
and reached the rushes and the grassy banks  
of River Asopus. From there, the Greeks

sent Tydeus to Thebes to bring a message.

510

He went and found a crowd of Thebans feasting  
inside the house of strong Eteocles.

Though he was an outsider and alone,  
surrounded by so many men of Thebes,  
he was not scared. He challenged them to contests,  
and easily defeated all of them,

390 because Athena had been helping him.

The Thebans, men who whip their horses fast,  
were angry, and once Tydeus had left,

they got a group of fifty strong young men

520

and sent them to attack him. Their two leaders  
were Maeon, son of Haemon, who resembled  
the deathless gods, and Autophon's brave son,  
the fighter Polyphontes. All these men

were massacred by Tydeus—except

Maeon, whom he sent home, because he heeded  
the portents that the gods had sent to him.

Such was Aetolian Tydeus. He had

a son who is inferior in battle,

400 but better as a speaker in a meeting.”

530

Great Diomedes did not answer him,  
out of respect towards a high-ranked leader.  
But Sthenelus, son of Capaneus,  
said,

“Son of Atreus, you know the truth,  
so do not lie! We are both very proud  
to be far better than our fathers were.

We took the town of seven-gated Thebes,  
though we had marched there with a smaller army  
against a better wall than in their day.

We trusted in the signs the gods had sent  
and in the help of Zeus. Our fathers died  
because of their own stupid recklessness.

540

410 So never tell me you admire our fathers  
as much as us.”

But mighty Diomedes  
glowered at him and said,

“Be quiet, comrade.

Do as I say. For my part, I will surely  
not criticize the shepherd of the people,  
Lord Agamemnon, while he is exhorting  
the Greeks to put their armor on and fight.  
The glory will belong to him, if ever  
we kill the Trojans and succeed in sacking  
the holy town of Troy. But also his  
will be the bitterest humiliation  
in case of Greek defeat. So come, we must  
concentrate on our eagerness to fight.”

550

420 With that, he jumped out from his chariot  
onto the ground, with all his arms and armor,  
and as he moved, the bronze around his body  
clanged horribly, a noise to terrify  
even a person rarely touched by fear.  
Just as when Zephyr rouses more and more  
waves from the deafening sea to dash against  
the shore— a crest of water rises up  
out of the deep, then with a mighty roar  
it crashes on the headlands, rises high,  
and at its peak disgorges briny foam—  
so more and more Greek warriors were roused  
in never-ending phalanxes to battle.  
Each of the leaders urged his troops, who moved  
forward in silence, and you would not know  
430 that any man in that gigantic army  
could speak at all. They marched in total silence,  
because they were so frightened of their leaders.  
Around each man as they were marching forward  
the finely decorated armor shone.  
Meanwhile the Trojans—as a multitude  
of ewes confined inside a rich man’s sheepfold  
at milking time, when their white milk is bursting,  
hearing the voices of their lambs, start bleating

560

570

incessantly—so did the Trojans shout  
 in noisy clamor through their whole vast army.  
 They did not share a common tongue or accent  
 or dialect. Their language was a mixture,  
 because they came from many different places.  
 Ares roused up the Trojans, while bright-eyed  
 Athena stirred the Greeks. Among them all  
 went Terror, Panic, and insatiable

440 Conflict, who is the sister and companion  
 of murderous Ares. First she swells a little,  
 then grows until her head can touch the sky,  
 as she is traveling across the earth.

590

So now she hurled belligerence among  
 the throng of warriors and walked among them,  
 increasing the men's screams and cries of pain.  
 Once they were gathered in a single place  
 they clashed together—shields of leather, spears,  
 bronze-armored bodies, and fierce human will.

450 Their shields collided and the metal bosses  
 clanged in cacophony. On every side  
 men shouted out in agony and triumph,  
 killing and being killed. The earth was flooded  
 with blood—as when from two opposing mountains  
 from mighty springs, two river torrents, swollen  
 by winter storms, flow down the deep ravines,  
 then clash, collide, and mingle in the gorge,  
 creating an enormous flood—the shepherd  
 high on the hilltop hears the waters roar—  
 such was the noise of fighting and of screaming  
 as those two armies met.

600

#### Antilochus

killed first. He hit a splendid Trojan leader  
 on their front line—Echepolus, the son  
 of Lord Thalysius. He struck his helmet  
 beside his horsehair plume and pierced his forehead.  
 460 The tip of bronze impaled his skull, and darkness  
 covered his eyes. He fell amid the mêlée  
 like a tall tower. As he fell, the mighty

610

Elphenor, leader of the brave Abantes,  
the son of Chalcodon, seized hold of him,  
grabbing him by the feet and pulling him  
away from missile range so he could strip  
the dead man's arms as quickly as he could.  
His quest was short-lived. As he bent to drag  
the dead Antilochus away, he left  
his ribs uncovered by his shield. Agenor  
saw it, and hurled his polished spear of bronze  
to wound him there. His body was undone.

620

470 His spirit left him. Then the Greeks and Trojans  
labored in bitter fighting over him,  
like wolves attacking one another, each  
jostling and shoving other men aside.

630

Then Telamonian Ajax struck and wounded  
young Simoesius, Anthemion's son,  
a healthy boy who had been born beside  
the streams of the Simoeis when his mother  
had gone to see her parents' flocks of sheep  
upon Mount Ida. On the way back down  
she gave birth by the river. That was why  
they named him Simoesius. That boy  
would never pay his loving parents back  
for taking care of him. His life was short,  
because the spear of Ajax cut him down.

640

480 The young man stepped in front, and Ajax struck  
his chest by his right nipple, and the bronze  
pierced through and came out by his shoulder blade.  
He fell down in the dust, just like a poplar  
that grows upon a vast expanse of marshland—  
smooth on its trunk with branches high up top.  
A chariot maker with a bright iron axe  
fells it to form the rim around the wheel  
upon a glorious chariot. The tree  
lies drying out beside the riverbanks.

650

490 So Simoesius, Anthemion's son,  
was killed by Zeus-born Ajax. In response,  
Priam's son Antiphus, his breastplate gleaming,



hurled his sharp spear at Ajax through the crowd.  
He missed him but hit Leucas, the brave comrade  
of Lord Odysseus. Leucas was dragging  
the body in the opposite direction.

Antiphus struck his groin and made him drop  
the body. At the slaughter of his comrade  
Odysseus was furious and heartsick.

660

Fully equipped in bright bronze helm and armor  
he strode among the champions and stopped  
near to the killer, glancing all around,  
then hurled his shining spear at him. The Trojans  
drew back as he attacked. His weapon hit  
somebody—but it was Democoon,

500

a son of Priam fathered out of wedlock,  
who came to help his father from his home  
in Abydos, the home of swift racehorses.

670

Odysseus, enraged about his comrade,  
speared one side of his forehead, and the tip  
of bronze poked right out through the other temple.  
Darkness obscured his eyes. He fell and crashed,  
his armor clanging noisily around him.

The foremost fighters, even glorious Hector,  
gave way. The Argives, with a noisy bellow,  
pressed on and dragged their dead away. Apollo,  
looking down from the Pergamum, was angry  
and shouted to the Trojans,

“Trojan horsemen,

680

come, do not yield the battle to the Greeks!

510

Their bodies are not made of stone or iron.

When they are struck, the bronze cuts through their flesh.

Also remember that Achilles, son  
of Thetis with the finely braided hair,  
is absent from the fighting. He is sitting  
beside the ships and ripening his anger,  
to cause more heartsickness.”

So from the city  
the terrifying god addressed the Trojans.

Meanwhile Athena roused the Greeks. The goddess  
of glory, Triton-born, the child of Zeus,  
rushed through the throng and riled them up for war  
whenever she saw any of them slacking.

Then his allotted destiny bound fast

Diores, son of Amarynceus.

A jagged rock struck his right ankle, thrown

520 by Piros, son of Imbrasus, who came  
from Aenus as the leader of the Thracians.

The disrespectful stone crushed both his tendons  
and shattered both his legs. He fell down backward  
onto the dust and stretched his arms towards  
his friends as he was breathing out his life.

700

Then Piros, who had struck him, ran up to him  
and speared him through the navel. His intestines  
poured out of him onto the earth and darkness  
covered his eyes. As Piros darted back,

Aetolian Thoas struck him with his spear

beside the nipple, through the chest—the bronze  
punctured his lung. Then Thoas came in close

and pulled the heavy spear out of his chest,

710

530 and drew his sharp sword, and with that he sliced  
Piros right in the middle of his belly,  
and took his life—but did not strip his armor,  
because his Thracian comrades stood around him  
grasping their long spears, with their hair piled high.  
Though Thoas was so big and brave and strong,  
they drove him off. He drew back shivering.

So those two lay stretched out beside each other,  
the leader of Epean bronze-clad fighters  
beside the Thracian leader, in the dust.

720

And all around them many more were killed.

Now nobody could think the fighting light—

540 not even one who somersaulted through it,  
unscathed, unwounded by the sharp bronze weapons,  
if great Athena took him by the hand,  
protecting him from the barrage of arrows.

So many Greeks and Trojans on that day

lay face-down in the dust beside each other.

## BOOK 5



# Gods on the Battlefield

And then Athena gave to Diomedes  
courage and energy, so he would win  
great glory and shine bright among the Greeks.  
She kindled on his helmet and his shield  
a fire that never flagged—just like the star  
that shines the brightest around harvest time,  
when it emerges freshly washed from Ocean—  
so brightly shone the fire the goddess lit  
on Diomedes, from his head and shoulders.  
She spurred him to the center of the fray,  
where most were thronging, and among the Trojans  
he met two sons of a rich man called Dares,  
a priest of lord Hephaestus. These two sons  
were named Phegeus and Idaeus—both  
skillful in every element of war.  
They moved away from the main mass of fighters,  
and hurtled headlong straight at Diomedes,  
they in their chariot and he on foot.  
When they were near each other, first Phegeus  
tossed his great spear that cast a long dark shadow,

10

10

20

but did not hit the son of Tydeus.

The weapon's point skimmed over his left shoulder.

Then Diomedes countered, and the bronze  
flew from his hand and did not miss its mark.

It struck Phegeus right between the nipples  
and knocked him from his chariot. Idaeus

20 jumped down and left the precious vehicle,  
but did not dare stand over his dead brother.

Black death would have caught up with him as well,  
had not Hephaestus covered him with night  
and saved him, so the god's own priest, their father,  
would not be totally destroyed by grief.

Then Diomedes drove their horses off  
and let his comrades take them to the ships.

The Trojans saw one son of Dares killed  
beside his chariot, the other fleeing,  
and all were horrified. Bright-eyed Athena  
30 took reckless Ares by the hand and said,

“ Now Ares, Ares! Plague on human life,  
blood-spattered killer, city-wall destroyer,  
40 why do we two not leave the Greeks and Trojans  
to fight each other? Let us both draw back  
and let our father Zeus decide who wins,  
so we avoid his wrath.”

With this, she led  
impetuous Ares from the battlefield,  
and made him sit beside the sandy River  
Scamander. Then the Greeks began to rout  
the Trojans, and each leader killed a man.

First Agamemnon, lord of men, attacked  
the Halizonian leader, Odius,

40 a mighty man, the first to turn and flee.

The Greek king thrust a spear into his back  
between the shoulders, driving through the chest,  
and pushed him from his chariot. He fell.

30

40

50

His armor jangled, clashing round his corpse.

Then Idomeneus killed Phaestus, son  
of Borus the Maeonian, who came  
from fertile Tarne. Phaestus had been trying  
to mount his chariot, behind his horses.

But Idomeneus, the famous spearman,  
thrust his long weapon in the man's right shoulder  
and knocked him off, and deadly darkness took him.  
The men who followed Idomeneus  
stripped off his armor.

60

Menelaus, son

50 of Atreus, then slew Scamandrius,  
the skillful hunter, son of Strophius,  
who had been taught by Artemis herself  
to hunt the animals of every kind  
fed by the forests on the mountaintops.  
But Artemis the archer could not help him,  
nor could his bygone skill at archery.  
He tried to run away, but Menelaus,  
the son of Atreus, the famous spearman,  
impaled his back between the shoulder blades  
and drove the weapon deep between his ribs  
and forced him down—his weapons rang around him.

70

Meriones then slaughtered Phereclus,  
son of the carpenter Harmonides,  
60 the joiner, who was clever with his hands,  
able to fashion any artifact—

80

Pallas Athena favored him so much.  
He was the one who built the steady ships  
for Paris, those that started the disaster  
for their creator, and for all the Trojans—  
he did not know the gods' divine intentions.  
He ran. Meriones caught up and speared him  
through his right buttock, and the blade transfixed  
his bladder, underneath the bone. He groaned,

collapsing on his knees. Death wrapped around him.

And Meges killed Antenor's son Pedaeus,  
born out of wedlock, but his stepmother,  
Theano, cared for him like her own children,  
to please her husband. But the skillful spearman,  
Meges, the son of Phyleus, drew near him  
and struck his neck with his sharp spear. The tip,  
slicing up through his teeth, cut off his tongue.  
70 He bit the cold bronze, falling in the dust.

90

And then Eurypylus, Euaemon's son,  
killed fine Hypsenor, son of Dolopion,  
appointed as the priest of the Scamander,  
a noble man, respected like a god.

Eurypylus, Euaemon's shining son,  
chased him as he was trying to get away.  
Sprinting, Eurypylus dashed up and hacked  
80 Hypsenor's shoulder with his sword, and sliced  
his heavy arm off. Drenched in blood, it fell  
onto the ground. Red death possessed his eyes,  
and overpowering fate took hold of him.

100

So they were struggling amid the crush  
of violent fighting. As for Diomedes,  
you could not even tell which group of men  
he sided with, the Trojans or the Greeks.

Across the plain he hurtled, like a river  
swollen by winter rain, that overflows  
and smashes the embankments built to stop it.  
No dam, no fence around the verdant vineyards  
90 can hold its place against the sudden onslaught  
during a downpour sent by Zeus, and many  
beautiful human artifacts are ruined.

110

So Diomedes routed the dense ranks  
of Trojans, forcing them into retreat,  
although they were so numerous. But when  
glorious Pandarus, Lycaon's son,

120

saw Diomedes up ahead of him,  
rushing across the plain, routing the troops,  
he quickly bent his curving bow and shot,  
and hit him as he ran, on the right shoulder.  
The darting arrow flew right through the metal  
into his body, and the plate of armor  
was drenched in blood. Triumphant Pandarus  
shouted,

100

130

“Come on now, Trojans! Come, brave horsemen!  
The finest of the Greeks has just been wounded!  
I do not think he can survive much longer  
after my devastating arrow shot,  
if it is true that I was guided here  
from Lycia by Apollo, son of Zeus.”

This was his boast—but his swift arrow failed  
to bring down Diomedes, who retreated  
back to the horse-drawn chariot. He stopped  
in front of it and called to Sthenelus,  
son of Capaneus,

140

“Get down now, brother,  
quickly, and pull this arrow from my shoulder!”

110

So Sthenelus jumped off the chariot  
onto the ground, stood close beside his friend,  
and tugged the swift sharp arrow through his shoulder  
and out the other side. Blood spurted up,  
soaking his delicate tunic. Diomedes  
prayed at that moment in his booming voice,

“Hear me, Athena, tireless goddess, child  
of Zeus who holds the aegis—if you ever  
favored and stood beside me or my father  
in deadly war, then also now, Athena,  
be kind to me. Let that man come in range  
of my spear’s throw, and let me take him out,

150

120 because he wounded me before I saw him,  
and got away, and boasts of it and claims  
that I will shortly cease to see the sun.”

So Diomedes prayed. Athena heard him,  
and made his feet and hands and limbs feel nimble,  
and stood beside him, speaking words on wings.

160

“Now, Diomedes, do not hesitate.  
Go fight the Trojans. In your chest I put  
the dauntless courage that your father had—  
your father Tydeus, the warrior  
who rode behind his horses with his shield.  
I have removed the mist that veiled your eyes,  
so you can now distinguish gods from humans.  
If deathless gods come here to challenge you,  
130 do not fight any of them face to face,  
except for Aphrodite, child of Zeus.  
If she approaches on the battlefield,  
strike her and wound her with your piercing bronze.”

170

Bright-eyed Athena spoke these words and left him.  
Then Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
rejoined the warriors on the front line.  
Before, he had already been impatient  
to fight against the Trojans, but the rage  
that now took hold of him was three times greater—  
rage like an angry lion’s, when he leaps  
into a farmstead to attack a flock  
of fleecy sheep—the shepherd tries to fight him,  
but cannot overpower him—the lion  
is energized and ever more riled up—  
the herdsman cannot save his animals,  
140 and rushes to the paddocks to take cover—  
the ewes pour forth and huddle close together—  
still full of energy and rage, the lion  
bounds from the high-fenced farmyard and away—  
with that same passionate intensity

180



strong Diomedes mingled with the Trojans,  
and killed Hyperon, shepherd of the people,  
together with Astynous. He struck  
one with his bronze-tipped spear below the nipple,  
and slashed the other with his mighty sword  
beside the collarbone and sliced away  
his shoulder from his back and neck, then left them,  
and went to Abas and Polyidus,  
sons of Eurydamas, the old dream-seer.

190

150 The old man never read their dreams again.  
They never went back home to him. Instead,  
powerful Diomedes killed them.

200

Then,  
he moved towards the sons of Phaenops—Xanthus  
and Thoon, who were both full-grown. The father  
was frail and weakened by severe old age.  
He could not get another son as heir  
for his possessions. Diomedes killed  
both of them there, took both their lives away,  
and left their father grief and lamentation.  
He would not welcome them back home again  
alive, after the war. His whole estate  
would be divided among distant heirs.

210

160 Then Diomedes killed two sons of Priam,  
both in a single chariot—Echemmon  
and Chromius. Just as a lion pounces  
into a herd and breaks his victim's neck—  
a cow or calf out grazing in the woodland—  
so Diomedes roughly forced both brothers  
out of their chariot against their will  
and stripped them of their weapons. Then he gave  
their horses to his men to lead away,  
down to the ships.

220

Then seeing Diomedes  
draining his people's strength, Aeneas ran

amid the chaos of the battlefield,  
and through the flying mass of spears, to seek  
strong, noble Pandarus, the godlike son  
of great Lycaon, and at last he found him,  
then stood in front of him and asked him this.

170

“Where is your famous skill in archery,  
Pandarus, and your bow and flying arrows?  
No man in Troy or Lycia rivals you.  
Go on now, lift your arms and pray to Zeus,  
then shoot at him, whoever he may be,  
that man who dominates the battlefield,  
who has already killed so many Trojans  
and loosed the limbs of many noble men.  
Perhaps he is a wrathful god, enraged  
against the Trojans for some sacrifice  
that we have failed to make. The wrath of gods  
is dangerous.”

230

Lycaon’s handsome son,  
Pandarus, said, “Aeneas, council member  
among the Trojan leaders clad in bronze,  
I think his whole appearance most resembles  
great Diomedes, son of Tydeus.  
I recognize him by his shield, his helmet,  
his visor and his chariot and horses.  
Or this could be a god—I am not sure.  
But if he is a man, the one I mentioned,  
the skillful son of Tydeus, his frenzy  
must have been caused by some immortal god  
cloaked in a cloud, who stands there close beside him.  
That deity directed my sharp arrow  
aside, when I had shot at his right shoulder,  
and hit. The arrow drove right through his armor,  
and I was certain I would send him down  
to Hades—but in fact I did not kill him.  
So this must surely be some angry god.  
I have no horses and no chariots,  
although at home my father has eleven,

180

240

190

250

beautiful ones, new made and newly fashioned,  
covered in cloths. To each is yoked two horses,

260

feeding on spelt and bright white barley grains.  
When I was setting out to war, my father,  
the old spear warrior Lycaon, gave me  
useful advice. He told me I should ride  
a chariot with horses when I led

200 the Trojan forces through the thick of battle.

I did not heed him as I should have done,  
because I did not want to use the horses.

I worried that they might be short on food  
among the huddled multitude of troops,  
when they were always used to eating plenty.

270

So I left them behind and came to Troy  
on foot, relying on my bow and arrows—  
which were no use to me. I shot two leaders,  
first Menelaus, son of Atreus,  
then Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
and hit them both, and certainly drew blood,  
but all I did was agitate them more.

I suffered from bad luck, right from the day  
I took my curving bow down from its hook

280

210 and led my Trojans to majestic Troy,  
doing a favor for heroic Hector.

If ever I come home again and see  
with my own eyes my native land and wife  
and high-roofed home, I hope some total stranger  
comes by and instantly chops off my head,  
unless I smash this bow of mine to pieces  
with my own hands and hurl it in bright fire.  
This stupid thing does not help me at all.”

Aeneas, champion of the Trojans, answered,

290

“Do not say that. Things are not going to change  
until we both get up behind these horses,  
take all our weapons, and ride up to him  
and challenge him. Come on, get in my carriage,  
so you can see the nimbleness with which  
horses from Troy go racing at a gallop

220

this way and that across the battlefield,  
in hot pursuit or in retreat. This pair  
will bring us safely back inside the city,  
if it turns out that Zeus gives victory  
to Diomedes, son of Tydeus.

300

Come on now, take the whip and shining reins.  
I shall dismount and fight, or else you go  
to deal with him, while I protect the horses.”

230 Lycaon’s noble son replied, “Aeneas,  
you keep the reins and drive. This pair of horses  
will pull the chariot wheels away much better  
when someone they already know is driving,  
if we are forced to flee from Diomedes.

What if they get too scared to move at all,  
and then refuse to carry us from battle  
because they miss your voice? Then Diomedes,  
son of brave Tydeus, will rush at us  
and kill us both and take away your horses.  
So you must drive the chariot and guide them,  
and when that man attacks I will confront him  
with my sharp spear.”

310

They talked like this, then mounted  
the decorated chariot, and raced  
the galloping horses against Diomedes.

240 And Sthenelus, son of Capaneus,  
saw them approach. At once, his words flew forth.

320

“Dear Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
I love you, friend, with all my heart. I see  
two sturdy fighters rushing to attack you.  
Their strength is limitless. The skillful archer  
is Pandarus, who proudly claims to be  
Lycaon’s son, and with him comes Aeneas,  
proud of his ancestry—he is the son  
of Lord Anchises, and his mother is  
the goddess Aphrodite. So come on,

330

250 give ground, and ride away. Stop charging forward  
into the front lines, or you will be killed.”

But mighty Diomedes scowled at him  
and answered, “Do not talk to me of flight.  
I doubt that you could ever change my mind.  
It is against my nature, and my father’s,  
to play it safe in battle and shrink back.  
My spirit is as vigorous as ever.  
I do not want to mount a chariot.  
I shall go forth and face them as I am. 340  
Athena will not let me run away.  
And as for those two men—their galloping horses  
cannot enable both to get back safely,  
even if one of them may get away.  
And let me tell you something else—mark well.  
If I kill both of them, if I am given  
260 that glory by ingenious Athena,  
restrain our horses, tie them to the carriage,  
and seize the horses of Aeneas. Drive them  
off from the Trojans to the well-armed Greeks. 350  
They are descended from the horses given  
to Tros by Zeus, the great farsighted god,  
as compensation for his kidnapped son,  
Ganymede. In the light of dawn or noontime,  
no stallions were finer. Lord Anchises  
stole from their stock in secret from the king,  
Laomedon, and paired them with his mares.  
270 He got six foals from them on his estate,  
and reared up four at manger for himself,  
and gave the other two to Lord Aeneas— 360  
both excellent at forcing men to flee.  
If we could take those horses, we would win  
a noble reputation.”

So they spoke.  
The others drove the galloping horses near them,  
and Pandarus, Lycaon’s glorious son,  
called out,

“Determined, skillful Diomedes,  
son of the noble Tydeus, I see  
my swift and bitter arrow did not kill you.  
So I shall try to do it with my spear.”

280 Then he took aim and hurled his long, dark spear  
and struck the son of Tydeus on his shield.  
The bronze tip flew right through and reached his breastplate.  
Then Pandarus, Lycaon’s splendid son,  
yelled out to him,

370

“Got you, right through the belly!  
I do not think you can survive much longer.  
You gave a splendid victory to me!”

But mighty Diomedes kept his cool  
and answered him, “You missed. You did not hit me.  
But both of you, I think, will keep on trying  
till one of you falls dead and thirsty Ares,  
the well-armed god of war, will drink your blood.”

380

290 He threw his spear at Pandarus. Athena  
steered it beneath his eye and through his nose,  
smashing his white teeth. Then the tireless bronze  
cut off his tongue, right at the root— the tip  
emerged again beneath his chin. He fell  
out of the chariot. His dazzling armor  
and shining weapons clattered all around him.  
His swift-hoofed horses swerved and galloped off.  
His life and spirit were released and lost.

390

Aeneas jumped down off his chariot,  
bearing his spear and shield. He was afraid  
the Greeks would strip the armor from the corpse.  
He stood astride to guard it, like a lion  
trusting his courage, with his spear in hand,  
ready to kill if anyone attacked,  
300 his shield held steady all around his body.

He gave a roar like thunder. Diomedes,  
the son of Tydeus, picked up a boulder  
that was so large two men, as men are now,

400

could never lift it up—a massive task.  
He wielded it quite easily alone,  
and struck Aeneas on the hip, the socket  
in which the thighbone turns, the place they call  
the little cup. The jagged boulder fractured  
the pelvis, snapped his ligaments, and ripped  
his skin away. The warrior Aeneas

310

fell to his knees but kept himself propped up  
with one hand firmly on the ground. Black night  
covered his eyes. Aeneas, lord of men,  
would certainly have died right then and there,  
had not his mother Aphrodite noticed.

410

She had conceived Aeneas by Anchises  
while he was herding cows, and now the goddess,  
the child of Zeus, protected her dear son.

She threw her white arms round him and embraced him  
and wrapped him up inside her glimmering dress  
to keep him safe from weapons, so no Greek  
would gallop up and hurl a spear of bronze  
to pierce his chest and take his life away.

420

She took her darling son away from battle.

320

Then Sthenelus, son of Capaneus,  
remembered what the master of the war cry,  
Lord Diomedes, had instructed him.

Using the reins, he tied his strong-hoofed mares  
onto the chariot to keep them back,  
away from all the chaos of the battle,  
then rushed to seize the horses of Aeneas,  
the handsome long-maned stallions. He drove them  
off from the Trojans to the well-armed Greeks  
and gave them to Deipylus, his friend,  
the one he valued most of all their comrades,  
and loved, because they understood each other.

430

Deipylus drove back towards the ships,  
and Sthenelus, the warrior, climbed back  
into his chariot, behind his own

strong stallions, took up the shining reins,  
and hurried off immediately, chasing  
the son of Tydeus, Lord Diomedes,  
330 who was pursuing Cyprian Aphrodite 440  
with cruel bronze. He recognized the goddess  
who lacks all courage on the battlefield—  
unlike the goddesses who dominate  
in mortal wars, Athena and Enyo,  
sacker of cities. Diomedes, son  
of valiant Tydeus, chased after her,  
pushed through the mass of warriors, and reached her,  
then leapt and hurled his sharp spear at the goddess—  
wounding her delicate soft wrist. The weapon  
pierced through the immortal fabric of her dress, 450  
which had been woven for her by the Graces,  
and cut her skin just underneath her palm.  
Her deathless blood poured out— not blood, but “ichor,”  
340 the liquid that flows through the blessed gods.  
They do not feed on bread or drink bright wine,  
so they are bloodless and are called immortal.  
She howled and cast her son away from her.  
Phoebus Apollo caught him in his arms  
and wrapped him in a dark cloud so no Greek  
would gallop up and hurl a spear of bronze 460  
to pierce his chest and take his life away.  
Then Diomedes, master of the war cry,  
called out to her,

“Now give up war and battle,  
daughter of Zeus! You can seduce and trick  
docile, unwarlike women. Is that not  
enough for you? If you keep coming here  
350 to meddle on the battlefield, I think  
soon you will shiver even when you hear  
the name of war from very far away.”

She turned away in terrible distress. 470  
But Iris flew to her on feet of wind  
and lifted her and took her from the throng,



still weighted down by pain. Her lovely skin  
was bruised. Then on the left side of the battle  
she found impetuous Ares, sitting down.  
His spear and swift war-chariot were propped  
against a cloud. She knelt and begged her brother  
for his two horses with their crowns of gold,  
imploring him,

“Dear brother, help me, please!  
Give me your horses, so that I can go  
360 to Mount Olympus where immortals live.  
I am in agony from a dreadful wound  
inflicted on me by a mortal man,  
the son of Tydeus, who now intends  
even to fight against our father Zeus.”

480

So Aphrodite spoke, and Ares gave her  
his gold-crowned horses, and the goddess climbed  
into the chariot, still pained at heart.  
Beside her, Iris mounted, took the reins,  
and whipped the horses. Eagerly they flew,  
and swiftly they arrived at Mount Olympus,  
the home of gods, and there, wind-footed Iris  
halted the horses and unharnessed them,  
and gave them some ambrosial food to eat.  
The goddess Aphrodite flung herself  
370 into her mother’s lap. Dione hugged her,  
and held her arms around her darling daughter,  
and stroked her with her hand and said her name  
and asked,

490

“Dear child, who treated you like this?  
Which of the great inhabitants of the sky  
has been so inappropriate and foolish?  
As if you ever would have misbehaved  
in public!”

500

Laughter-loving Aphrodite

answered her, “I was wounded by the son  
of Tydeus, that arrogant Diomedes,  
because I took my dear son from the battle—  
my son Aeneas, whom I love the most  
of anyone by far. The violent fighting  
is now no longer Trojans against Greeks.  
The Greeks are fighting the immortal gods!”

510

Dione, the majestic goddess, answered,  
“My child, be strong and bear your suffering.  
Many of us who live on Mount Olympus  
have suffered at the hands of men, when gods  
and humans have been injuring each other.  
Ares was hurt when mighty Ephialtes  
and Otus, sons of Aloeus, trapped him  
in tight confinement. They imprisoned him  
for thirteen months inside a bronze container.  
Ares, with his insatiable desire  
for warfare, would have died—but their stepmother,  
most beautiful Eeriboea, told

520

Hermes, who secretly got Ares out.  
Ares had suffered very much by then.  
The cruel prison had exhausted him.  
Hera was also hurt when Heracles,  
Amphitryon’s strong son, struck her right breast,  
using an arrow with a triple barb.  
The agony she felt could not be soothed.  
Along with these, among the dead in Pylos,  
gigantic Hades suffered when that same  
Heracles, son of Zeus who bears the aegis,  
shot a swift arrow, struck him, and consigned him  
to pain. In his distress, pierced through by torment,  
he went to high Olympus and the house  
of Zeus. His heart was troubled by the arrow  
impaled in his strong shoulder. Paeon smeared  
some anesthetic ointments over it  
and cured him—since of course he was not mortal.  
Outrageous and egregious Heracles!  
He did not shrink from any wickedness.

530

540

His arrows hurt the gods on Mount Olympus.  
Bright-eyed Athena set this Diomedes,  
this son of Tydeus, to fight with you.  
He is a fool, who does not realize  
that somebody who fights immortal gods  
will not live long. He will not come back home  
from war and cruel conflict, and his children  
will never clutch his legs and call him Daddy.  
However strong he is, he should be careful.  
Some better god than you may fight with him,  
and then the daughter of Adrastus, thoughtful  
Aegialeia, wife of Diomedes,  
will stir from sleep in tears and scream in grief,  
and wake up everyone inside the house  
with keening sorrow for her noble husband,  
the best of all the Greeks, the lord of horses.”

410

550

With this, Dione used both hands to wipe  
the moisture from her daughter’s wrist. It healed—  
the stinging pain was soothed and went away.  
But Hera and Athena, watching her,  
complained to Zeus, the son of Cronus. Bright-eyed  
divine Athena was the first to speak.

420

560

“Father, I hope that you will not be angry  
at what I say, but surely Aphrodite  
must have incited one of the Greek women  
to go and join those Trojan men, whom now  
this goddess loves so much—and as she petted  
the woman’s pretty dress, she must have scratched  
her slender wrist against a golden pin.”

570

At this, the father of the gods and men  
smiled, and then summoned golden Aphrodite,  
and said to her, “My child, the work of war  
is not your area. Concern yourself  
with marriage and the workings of desire.  
Fierce Ares and Athena will attend

430

to all of that.”

While they were saying this,  
Lord Diomedes, master of the war cry,  
rushed at Aeneas, though he knew Apollo  
was holding out his hands to keep him safe.  
He did not shrink or stand in awe before  
this mighty god, but constantly kept trying  
to kill Aeneas and strip off his arms.  
Three times he lunged at him and tried to kill him,  
three times Apollo pushed away his shield.  
And yet when godlike Diomedes tried  
a fourth attack, aloof Apollo spoke  
in condemnation.

580

440 “Son of Tydeus,  
watch out and get out. Do not think yourself  
equal to gods. There is no common kinship  
shared by immortal gods and human beings  
who walk on earth.”

590

At these words, Diomedes  
moved back a little distance, to avoid  
the wrath of the far-shooting god Apollo.  
And then Apollo set Aeneas down  
safely, upon the holy Pergamum  
where his own temple had been built for him.  
Leto and Artemis the archer healed him  
and glorified him in the sanctuary.  
Apollo of the silver bow created  
a phantom fashioned to look like Aeneas,  
with armor just like his. Around this phantom,  
fine Greeks and Trojans hacked each other’s shields—  
circles of oxhide wrapped around their chests,  
and shaggy, feathery bucklers. Then Apollo  
addressed aggressive Ares.

600

450

“Ares, Ares!

You bloodstained killer, city-wall destroyer,  
plague of humanity, will you not drag  
the son of Tydeus away from battle?  
This man would even fight our father Zeus!  
He wounded Aphrodite on the wrist  
just now, and then he even rushed at me,  
as if he were a god!”

610

460                               With this, Apollo  
settled himself on the high Pergamum,  
and ruinous Ares went among the Trojans,  
urging them on. He took up the appearance  
of Acamas, the leader of the Thracians,  
and gave these orders to the sons of Priam.

“Leaders, protected by the will of Zeus,  
how long will you allow the Trojan troops  
to go on being slaughtered by the Greeks?  
Till they are fighting round the well-built gates?  
Aeneas, son of brave Anchises, whom  
we honored just as much as glorious Hector,  
has fallen. Come on then, we have to save  
our noble comrade from the battlefield.”

620

470       With this, he roused the spirit of aggression  
in every man. And then Sarpedon spoke  
reproachfully to noble Hector.

                                      “Hector,  
where is the courage that you used to have?  
You said that you alone could hold the city,  
joined only by your brothers and your kinsmen,  
without the common troops and allied forces.  
But now I cannot see your family.  
They shrink away, like dogs before a lion.  
We are just allied troops, but we are fighting.  
I came to join the war from far away,  
from distant Lycia, on the eddying Xanthus.

630

480 I left my darling wife and baby son  
and wealth, the kind a poor man dreams about.  
But still I push the Lycians into battle,  
and I myself am desperate to fight,  
although I have no animals or treasure  
at Troy that could be stolen by the Greeks.  
You held your ground yourself, but you have failed  
to tell the other fighters to hold firm  
and keep their women safe. Do not become  
plunder and spoil, ensnared inside their net.  
They will destroy the city where you live.  
490 You have to focus, night and day, on this,  
and beg the leaders of your world-renowned  
allies to hold the line unflinchingly.  
You must not give us reason to reproach you.”

640

650

Sarpedon's words bit into Hector's heart.  
He jumped out of the chariot to the ground,  
wearing full armor, brandishing sharp spears,  
and dashed all through the army. He incited  
the men to fight. He woke the dreadful noise  
of war. The Trojans turned to face the Greeks,  
who stood their ground, held tight, and would not run.  
As wind blows chaff across the winnowing floors,  
while men are laboring in the sacred space,  
500 when blonde Demeter separates the grain  
from husks through driving wind—the heaped remains  
grow white—so then the Greeks turned white with dust,  
kicked to the sky of bronze by horses' hooves  
and sprinkling down on top and all around them  
amid the armies as the fight was joined.  
The drivers turned the chariots around,  
the warriors held out their fists before them.  
Relentless Ares spread a veil of night  
over the battle. He was everywhere,  
helping the Trojans, as he had been ordered  
by Lord Apollo of the golden sword  
who told him he must rouse the Trojans' courage,  
510 because Apollo saw Athena leaving,

660

670

and she had been the helper of the Greeks.  
Meanwhile, Apollo sent the people's shepherd,  
Aeneas, from his wealthy sanctuary,  
and filled his heart with forceful will to fight.  
Aeneas joined his comrades, who were happy  
to see him back alive and in good spirits,  
and yet they did not ask him any questions.  
They were too busy with the task at hand,  
the struggles caused by silver-bowed Apollo,  
and Ares, ruin of humanity,  
and Conflict, who is always keen to fight.

680

520 Meanwhile, both Ajaxes, Odysseus,  
and Diomedes urged the Greeks to fight.  
They had no fear of any Trojan onslaught,  
no thought they might be routed. They stood firm.  
like clouds on a windless day, which Zeus holds still  
over the mountain peaks when Boreas  
and all the blustering winds whose breath disperses  
the shadowy clouds with whistling gusts of air  
are fast asleep—so still the Greeks stood waiting,  
motionless, and then Agamemnon marched  
along the lines of troops and gave them orders.

690

530 “My friends, be men, and let your hearts take courage.  
Take care of one another in the battle.  
Men who protect each other are more likely  
to stay alive and safe and not be killed.  
But there is neither glory nor protection  
for those who run away.”

700

With that, he hurled  
his spear and struck the fighter at the front,  
Deicoon, a friend of brave Aeneas.  
The son of Pergasus, he was as honored  
among the Trojans as the sons of Priam  
because he fought so nimbly at the front.  
Powerful Agamemnon speared his shield,

710

which failed to save him, and the bronze stabbed through  
his belt, and deep inside his lower belly.

540 He clattered down. His armor rang around him.

And then Aeneas killed two fine Greek fighters,  
the brothers Crethon and Orsilochus,  
the sons of Diocles, inhabitant  
of well-built Pherae. Diocles was rich,  
descended from the River Alpheus,  
whose spreading streams flow through the Pylian land.  
The river fathered Lord Ortilochus,  
who governed many, and Ortilochus  
fathered brave Diocles, who had twin sons—  
Orsilochus and Crethon, skillful fighters.

720

550 When they were grown, they sailed aboard black ships  
to Troy, the land of horses, with the Argives  
to win back recompense for Menelaus  
and Agamemnon, sons of Atreus.

But there at Troy, their death enfolded them.  
Just as two lion cubs, raised by their mother  
in densely wooded thickets on the mountains,  
snatch cows and well-fed sheep and lay to waste  
the barns of humans, until they are killed  
by people holding weapons of sharp bronze—  
just so those twins were slaughtered by Aeneas.

730

560 They fell like tall fir trees. Their fall was seen  
by Menelaus, warrior of Ares.

Grieving, he rushed among the frontline fighters  
in bright bronze armor, brandishing his spear.

Ares aroused the will to fight inside him,  
so that he would be slaughtered by Aeneas.

740

But noble Nestor's son, Antilochus,  
saw him and rushed to join him at the front,  
anxious in case the shepherd of the people  
might suffer injury and waste their work.  
So those two, with sharp spears and hands outstretched,  
kept close together as they rushed to fight.

570 Antilochus kept very near his leader,  
the shepherd of the people, while Aeneas,



although he was a very eager fighter,  
drew back when he saw two men side by side,  
holding their ground. They dragged the poor dead men  
back to the army of the Greeks and laid them  
down in their comrades' arms. Then both turned back  
and fought again among the frontline fighters.  
They slaughtered Pylaemenes, match for Ares,  
lord of the dauntless warriors with shields,  
the Paphlagonians. He stood and waited,  
and Menelaus, son of Atreus,  
the famous fighter, killed him with his spear.  
It hit his collarbone. The driver, Mydon,  
whose father was Atymnius, who served  
bravely as his attendant, started turning  
the horses and the chariot around.  
Antilochus attacked him with a stone  
and struck him in the middle of the elbow.  
The reins, bright white with ivory adornments,  
fell from his hands and lay there in the dust.  
Antilochus pressed on and with his sword  
hacked Mydon's forehead, so he gasped and fell  
out of his well-made chariot, headfirst.  
His head and shoulders smashed into the ground.  
It happened to be very sandy there,  
so that the corpse stayed upright, upside down,  
until his horses kicked him to the ground.  
Antilochus drove off that pair of horses  
back to the army of the Greeks.

750

760

770

And Hector  
saw what was happening in the battle lines  
and hurried to attack them, with a shout.  
Strong lines of Trojan warriors came with him,  
led on by Ares and divine Enyo,  
who brought with her Confusion, who is shameless  
in slaughter. Ares brandished in his hands  
a massive spear and walked alongside Hector,  
sometimes in front of him, sometimes behind.  
And Diomedes, master of the war cry,

780

shuddered and shivered at the sight of Hector—  
as when a man has crossed a mighty plain  
but has to stop, quite helpless, at a river  
in full flood, flowing down towards the sea,  
which froths with foam, reverberates, and roars—

790

600 he startles, moving back—so Diomedes,  
the son of Tydeus, drew back, and said,  
“Friends, we have always been impressed by Hector  
because he is so valiant a fighter,  
a proper spearman—and he always has  
one of the gods beside him to protect him  
from any harm. And even now, great Ares  
is with him, looking like a mortal man.  
Stay focused on the Trojans, but walk backward.  
We must not try to fight against the gods.”

800

And then the Trojans moved in close to them,  
and Hector killed two men, both skilled in battle,  
Menesthes and Anchialus, both riding  
a single chariot. But as they fell,  
610 great Telamonian Ajax pitied them,  
approached, and threw his shining javelin  
at Amphiüs, the son of Selagus,  
a wealthy man with many fields of wheat,  
who lived in Paesus, till his destiny  
brought him to help the Trojans in the war,

810

to fight with Priam and with Priam’s sons.  
Great Telamonian Ajax struck his belt.  
The spear that cast long shadows pierced right through  
his lower belly. With a crash, he fell.

In triumph, Ajax ran to strip his armor.

The Trojans rained their sharp and shiny spears  
against his strong shield, but it kept them off.

620 He put his foot onto the corpse and pulled  
the bronze spear out, but could not strip away  
the beautiful armor from the body’s torso.

820

He was assailed by too many weapons.

He feared the onslaught of the noble Trojans,  
the warriors surrounding him with spears.

Despite his size and strength and nobleness  
they pushed him off, and trembling, he withdrew.

The warriors kept laboring in battle.  
Fatal compulsion drove Tlepolemus,  
a fine big man, the son of Heracles,  
against godlike Sarpedon. Those two met,  
630 the son and grandson of cloud-gathering Zeus.  
Tlepolemus addressed Sarpedon first.

830

“Sarpedon, leader of the Lycian army,  
why do you have to skulk around out here?  
You are completely ignorant of battle.  
They say you are a son of Zeus. They lie!  
You are far less impressive than those men  
whom Zeus, the god who bears the goatskin aegis,  
fathered in former days—such as my father,  
the mighty Heracles. They say he was  
a dauntless lionhearted warrior.  
He came here once with fewer men than you,  
sailing in just six ships, to get his horses  
640 back from Laomedon—and he sacked Troy,  
and made the city and her streets a ruin.  
You are a coward, and your men are dying.  
I bet that you will fail to help the Trojans,  
although you traveled all the way from Lycia,  
and you are certainly extremely strong,  
because you will be slaughtered at my hands,  
and pass the gates of Hades.”

840

In reply,  
Sarpedon, leader of the Lycians, said,  
“Tlepolemus, it certainly is true  
that Heracles demolished holy Troy  
because Laomedon behaved so badly.  
650 He talked back rudely to a benefactor,  
and he refused to give the horses back,  
when Heracles had traveled far to get them.

850

But as for you, I tell you, you will die  
meeting a violent, black death right here,  
at my hands, and my spear will cut you down,  
and you will give the victory to me,  
and give your life to Hades, lord of horses.”

860

So spoke Sarpedon, and Tlepolemus  
picked up his spear of ash. Then both men threw  
their big long javelins. Sarpedon hit  
right in the middle of his rival’s neck.  
The painful tip pierced straight through, all the way.

660

So dark night veiled his eyes. Tlepolemus  
had hit Sarpedon’s left thigh with his spear—  
the tip flew fast but only grazed the bone.

870

His father Zeus protected him from harm.  
His noble comrades bore godlike Sarpedon  
away from battle. In his leg, the spear  
weighed heavy as they dragged him. No one noticed  
or thought to pull the weapon from his thigh,  
so he could limp along. They were too busy  
working to help him. On the other side,  
the armored Greeks bore off Tlepolemus  
out of the way of battle. Self-restrained

670

Odysseus, aware of what had happened,  
trembled in his excitement as he wondered  
in heart and mind if he should run and chase  
Sarpedon, son of Zeus whose thunder rumbles,  
or rob more Lycian fighters of their lives.

880

But it was not decreed that unrelenting  
Odysseus would kill the son of Zeus,  
mighty Sarpedon, with his sharp bronze spear.

Athena turned his mind towards the crowd  
of Lycians, among whom he killed Coiranus,  
Alastor, Chromius, and Halius,  
Alcander, Prytanis, and Noemon.

890

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And glorious Odysseus would surely  
have slaughtered even more, but mighty Hector,  
the fighter with the brightly shining helmet,  
saw him, and hurried through the frontline troops,

in dazzling bronze armor, bringing terror  
to all the Greeks. Sarpedon, son of Zeus,  
was glad to see him and cried out in anguish,

“Please, Hector, son of Priam, do not let me  
lie here as plunder for the Greeks, but save me!  
Let it be later that I lose my life  
here in your city, if I am not fated  
ever to go back safely home again  
to my dear native country and bring joy  
to my dear wife and little baby son.”

900

690 Hector in his bright helmet made no answer,  
but sprinted onward in his eagerness  
to drive the Greek troops back immediately,  
and take as many lives as possible.  
Sarpedon’s comrades set the godlike man  
under the lovely oak tree that was sacred  
to Zeus, the aegis-lord. Strong Pelagon,  
the friend he loved the most, tugged from his thigh  
the ash-wood spear, and he lost consciousness,  
but as he gasped in pain, he caught his breath—  
a gust of Boreas, the wind, revived him.

910

700 The Greeks, beset by Hector and by Ares,  
did not turn round towards their own black ships,  
nor march ahead to battle. They kept moving  
steadily backward, because they could see  
that Ares was among the Trojan troops.

920

Who was the first, who was the last man killed  
by Hector, son of Priam, and bronze Ares?  
First, godlike Teuthras, then his charioteer  
Orestes, Oenomaus, and the spearman  
Aetolian Trechus, Helenus, the son  
of Oenops, and Oresbius, who wore  
a shining sash, who used to live in Hyle,  
a town which lies beside Lake Cephisis.

He used to take great care of all his wealth.  
Other Boeotians lived in neighboring lands,  
710 and that whole territory was very rich.

930

When white-armed Hera realized the Greeks  
were dying in the skirmishes of war,  
at once her words took wing. She told Athena,

“Relentless child of Zeus, this will not do!  
We will not keep our vow to Menelaus—  
that he would sack the well-built town of Troy  
and then come safely home—if we allow  
destructive Ares to rage on like this.  
Come, let us plan for battle and for slaughter.”

940

Bright-eyed Athena did as she had said.  
720 Hera, the eldest of the goddesses,  
daughter of mighty Cronus, got to work,  
and tacked her gold-crowned horses. Hebe quickly  
latched to the chariot on either side  
the rounded wheels of bronze that had eight spokes  
around an iron axle, and their rims  
were everlasting gold, and over them  
bronze tires were fitted—marvelous to see.  
Both the rotating wheel-hubs were of silver.  
The body of the chariot had straps  
of gold and silver stretched across. Two rails  
ran all around. The pole was made of silver.  
730 And to its end she bound a golden yoke  
and fixed the fine gold collars onto that.  
Finally, Hera yoked her swift-hoofed horses.  
She longed for conflict and the din of war.  
Athena, child of Zeus who bears the aegis,  
slipped off her silky-soft embroidered dress,  
which she had made herself with her own hands,  
and dropped it on the threshold where she stood,  
inside the doorway of her father’s house.  
She changed into the tunic worn by Zeus,

950

960

the god who marshals clouds, and armed herself  
with weapons fit for war, the source of tears.  
She slung the tasseled aegis round her shoulders—  
the dreadful aegis, bordered all around  
740 with Terror, and on it were Conflict, Courage,  
and chilling Flight. And on it was the head  
of the uncanny, terrifying Gorgon,  
the menacing sign of Zeus, the aegis-bearer.  
And on her head she put her golden helmet,  
four-studded, double-plumed, and decorated  
with warriors to fill a hundred cities.  
She stepped into the chariot of fire  
and seized the massive, monumental spear  
with which she tames the ranks of human fighters  
when she, who has her father's might, is angry.  
And Hera touched the horses with the whip  
to make them gallop. And the gates of heaven  
bellowed and opened of their own accord.  
750 These gates are guarded by the Hours, who watch  
over the whole vast sky and Mount Olympus.  
They close or open up the close-packed cloud.  
Steered by the whip, the horses passed these gates.  
The goddesses found Zeus, the son of Cronus,  
sitting apart from all the other gods  
upon the highest peak of steep Olympus.  
The white-armed goddess Hera stopped the horses  
and spoke to Zeus, the foremost child of Cronus.

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980

990

“Great father Zeus, will you not reprimand  
Ares for this outrageous massacre?  
Has he not slaughtered far too many Greeks?  
He is committing lawless crimes, and causing  
terrible pain to me. And all the while,  
760 Cyprian Aphrodite and Apollo,  
god of the silver bow, are having fun!  
Sitting serene, they are encouraging  
that crazy lunatic, who has no notion  
of right and wrong. So, father Zeus, will you  
get angry with me if I roughly strike

1000

Ares, and drive him from the battlefield?”

Cloud-gathering Zeus replied, “Go on, and rouse  
Athena, goddess of the spoils of war,  
who can impose the greatest pain on him.”

The goddess, white-armed Hera, heeded him.  
She whipped the horses and they willingly  
flew all across the vault that separates  
770 the earth from starry sky. As far as someone  
sitting upon a clifftop can see out  
across the misty wine-dark sea—so far  
those whinnying horses of the gods could leap  
in just a single bound. But when they reached  
Troy, where the rivers meet, the gently flowing  
Simoeis and the streams of the Scamander,  
the white-armed goddess Hera stopped the horses,  
released them from the chariot, and poured  
a mass of mist around them. The Simoeis  
sprouted ambrosia so that they could graze. 1020  
The goddesses went forth like trembling doves,  
eager to help the Greeks. But when they reached  
780 the crowd of champions who stood around  
great horse-lord Diomedes, they resembled  
two lionesses who devour raw flesh,  
or great wild boars, who are immensely strong.  
The white-armed goddess Hera manifested  
as spirited Stentor, he whose voice of bronze  
carries as far as fifty other men’s.  
Sounding like him, she shouted out,

“For shame! 1030

You are embarrassing! Your only talent  
is looking pretty! Back when great Achilles  
joined in the war, the Trojans never ventured  
even in front of the Dardanian Gates.  
790 They feared his mighty spear. But now they fight  
far from the city by the hollow ships.”



So Hera roused their spirits and their hearts.  
Athena, goddess of the flashing eyes,  
dashed to Lord Diomedes, whom she found  
beside his horses and his chariot,  
nursing the injury he had received  
when Pandarus had struck him with an arrow.  
Under the wide strap of his rounded shield  
the sweat felt clammy and uncomfortable.  
His hand was getting tired of lifting up  
the strap to wipe away the storm-black blood.  
The goddess touched his horses' yoke and said,

1040

800 “Tydeus fathered someone who has scarcely  
any resemblance to himself! Your father  
was short in stature, but he was a fighter.  
Even when I had told him not to fight,  
and said he must lie low, when he was going  
alone, without the other Greeks, to take  
a message to the Cadmians in Thebes,  
I ordered him to feast inside their halls  
peacefully—still his heart was strong and warlike,  
as it had always been before. He challenged  
the younger Cadmians to a fight and won  
easily over all of them, because  
I stood beside him and I gave him help.  
I am protecting you as well. I stand  
here at your side and urge you fervently  
810 to go and fight the Trojans. But exhaustion,  
after so many skirmishes in battle,  
has shaken you and overpowered your body—  
or else it may be fear and laziness.  
If so, you are no longer truly son  
of Tydeus, the son of wise Oeneus.”

1050

1060

Strong Diomedes answered her, “I know you,  
daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus. I will  
be glad to talk to you. I will be frank.  
It is not fear or laziness or doubt.  
But I remember what you said to me,

1070

warning me that I must not fight directly  
with any of the other blessed gods,  
820 except if Aphrodite, child of Zeus,  
came to the battlefield, you said I should  
wound her with my sharp bronze. So that is why  
I have drawn back myself and ordered all  
the other Greeks to stay and huddle here—  
I saw that Ares dominates the battle.” 1080

Divine Athena with her shining eyes  
said, “Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
dear to my heart, do not be scared of Ares,  
nor any of the other deathless gods,  
because I will be there to keep you safe.  
Come on now, drive your horses straight at Ares,  
and strike him close at hand. Do not hold back  
830 from that shapeshifter. He was made for trouble—  
violent, and aggressive, and insane. 1090  
He promised me and Hera earlier  
that he would help the Greeks and fight the Trojans.  
But now he is colluding with the Trojans  
and has forgotten all about the Greeks.”

With this, she used her hand to pull away  
Sthenelus from the chariot. She shoved him  
onto the ground. He quickly ran away.  
Then eagerly the goddess climbed upon  
the chariot and stood by Diomedes,  
and at the weight, the oaken axle screeched,  
because the vehicle was carrying  
a mighty goddess and a dauntless man. 1100  
840 Pallas Athena seized the whip and reins.  
Immediately she drove the hard-hoofed horses  
at Ares, who was stripping off the armor  
of massive Periphas, by far the best  
of all the Aetolian warriors, the noble  
son of Ochesius. The bloodstained killer,  
Ares, was stripping off his weaponry.  
Athena put her Hades-helmet on, 1110

so that enormous Ares, who brings ruin  
to mortals, could not see her. But he saw  
glorious Diomedes, so he left  
gigantic Periphas to lie there dead.

The god had killed him, robbing him of life.

850 Then Ares went straight after Diomedes,  
tamer of horses. When the two were close,  
Ares, who longed to take the human's life,  
moved first. He thrust his bronze spear underneath  
the yoke and underneath the horses' reins.

1120

But then the goddess, great bright-eyed Athena,  
seized it and pushed it up above the carriage,  
so that the spear flew off and did no harm.

Then Diomedes, master of the war cry,  
attacked. Athena drove his spear of bronze  
into the lowest part of Ares' side,

right by his belt. She wounded him just there,  
gashing his handsome skin, and then drew out  
the spear again. Bronze Ares groaned as loudly

860 as when nine or ten thousand warriors  
call out a victory cry, when Ares leads them  
to clash in war. Then fear and trembling seized  
the Greeks and Trojans at the groan of Ares,  
the god whose thirst for war is never sated.

1130

As when dark mist appears out of the clouds,  
after great heat has roused a cruel wind,

so did bronze Ares seem to Diomedes,  
as he went up, surrounded by the clouds,  
into the wide sky. And he quickly reached  
craggy Olympus, home of gods, and sat  
by Zeus, the son of Cronus, grieved at heart.

1140

870 He showed his father how his deathless blood  
was flowing from his wound, and he complained  
in words that flew on wings.

“Great father Zeus,  
are you not angry at their wicked deeds?  
We gods are always hurting one another  
and helping humans. And we all do battle

with you, because you birthed that crazy daughter.  
Curse her! She always works her wicked deeds.  
The other gods on Mount Olympus serve you  
and bow to you and follow your commands.  
And yet you never speak or act against her!

1150

880 You actually encourage her, because  
you are the parent of this deadly child.  
Now she has sent the son of Tydeus,  
arrogant Diomedes, in a rage  
against the deathless gods. Just now, he wounded  
Cyprian Aphrodite on her wrist,  
and after that, he even rushed at me,  
as if he were a god! My quick feet brought me  
away from there, or else I might have suffered  
terrible things for longer, down among  
the gruesome corpses, or I might have been  
alive but weakened by their bronze spears' blows."

1160

Cloud-gathering Zeus replied with scowling brows,  
"Shapeshifter, do not sit with me and whine.  
Of all the gods who live on Mount Olympus  
you are the one I hate the most. You always  
enjoy hostility and war and battle.

890

You have the spirit of your mother in you,  
Hera, who will not yield or be controlled,  
and I can scarcely check her with my words.  
These things have happened to you, I believe,  
because you did as she had prompted you.  
And yet I will not let you suffer long,  
because you are my son, I fathered you,  
although she gave you birth. If you were born  
the child of any other god, and causing  
so much destruction, you would long ago  
have been brought lower than the Olympian gods."

1170

1180

With these words, he told Paeon he should heal him.  
So Paean smeared the analgesic ointments  
and healed him. After all, he was not mortal.  
As fruit juice quickly curdles bright white milk,

900

which starts out liquid but soon starts to thicken  
when someone whisks it—so fast Paeon healed  
impetuous Ares. Hebe washed him clean,  
and put fine clothes on him, and he sat down  
by Zeus, the son of Cronus, feeling proud  
of his magnificence. And then Athena,  
the guardian, and Argive Hera, came  
back to the house of mighty Zeus again,  
when they had stopped the work of dreadful Ares—  
Ares, the curse to mortals, human killer.

## BOOK 6



# The Price of Honor

Without the gods, the Greeks and Trojans clashed  
in bitter battle, aiming bronze-tipped spears.  
Now fighting spread out all across the plain  
between the Rivers Xanthus and Simoeis.

First Telamonian Ajax, like a rampart  
protecting the Greek troops, broke through the line  
of Trojans, bringing light to his companions.  
He struck the finest of the Thracian fighters,  
the son of Eussorus, strong Acamas.  
He hit the crest-piece of his horsehair plume.

10

10 The bronze tip stabbed between his eyes and pierced  
into his skull, and darkness veiled his sight.  
Then Diomedes, master of the war cry,  
slaughtered the son of Teuthras, Axylus,  
who used to live in beautiful Arisbe.  
He had a rich estate and wealthy home,  
and everybody loved him. He was kind,  
and generous and welcomed everyone  
who passed that way as guests inside his home.

None of his friends stepped in to help him now.  
No one protected him from bitter death.  
His life was taken. Diomedes killed  
Axylus and his man Calesius,  
the driver of his chariot and horses.  
So both those men sank down upon the earth.

20

20     Dresus was slaughtered by Euryalus  
who also killed Opheltius, then chased  
both Aesepus and Pedasus, twin brothers,  
sons of Abarbarea. She, a naiad,  
bore them to great Boucalion, who was  
the oldest son of King Laomedon,  
born out of wedlock. And Boucalion  
had been out herding sheep when he had met  
the water goddess and had joined with her  
in love. They slept together. She conceived  
and bore these twins. But now Euryalus,  
son of Mecisteus, destroyed them both.  
He took the life from both these handsome men  
and stripped the arms and armor from their backs.

30

30     Staunch Polypoetes killed Astyalus,  
and with his spear of bronze, Odysseus  
slaughtered Percosian Pidytes. And Teucer  
killed Aretaon. And Antilochus,  
the son of Nestor, slaughtered Ablerus  
with his bright spear. And mighty Agamemnon  
killed Elatus, from rugged Pedasus  
beside the flowing River Satnioeis.  
Phylacus tried to run, but Leitus  
seized him and slew him, and Eurypylus  
slaughtered Melanthius.

40

                                  Then Menelaus  
shouted and seized a prisoner alive—  
Adrastus, when his horses fled in panic  
across the plain and ran into a branch

50

40 of tamarisk. The curving carriage broke,  
snapped at the pole's tip, and the horses galloped  
towards the city where the rest were fleeing.  
Adrastus toppled from the chariot  
and fell flat with his mouth down in the dust.  
Then Menelaus, son of Atreus,  
straddled him, with his spear grasped in his hand.  
Adrastus grabbed his knees and pleaded with him.

60

“Please, son of Atreus, take me alive!  
I will reward you handsomely. My father  
is rich and has great wealth at home—gold, bronze,  
and well-worked iron. He will freely give you  
vast quantities of treasure as my ransom,  
if he finds out that I am still alive  
50 beside your ships.”

And these words touched the heart  
of Menelaus. Right away, he wanted  
to have his steward take Adrastus back  
towards the swift Greek ships. But Agamemnon  
ran up and scolded him.

70

“Soft Menelaus!  
Why do you take such care of men like him?  
Have Trojans always acted with great kindness  
to you and everybody in your household?  
Let none of them escape the massacre  
dealt by our deadly hands, not even one!  
Even the little babies not yet born,  
whose mothers carry them inside their bellies,  
will not escape. All males alive in Troy  
will die, obliterated all at once,  
60 with no one left to care for them.”

80

With this,  
he changed his brother's mind, persuading him  
to do what must be done. So Menelaus



pushed brave Adrastus off him with his hand,  
and mighty Agamemnon stabbed his side.  
He toppled down, face-up, and Agamemnon,  
the son of Atreus, stepped on his chest  
and pulled the ash spear out.

Then Nestor shouted  
to all the Greeks, “Comrades in arms of Ares!  
My friends! You must not linger for the spoils,  
or try to gain a greater hoard of treasure  
to bring back to the ships. We must kill men.  
70 Later, we can return and safely strip  
the corpses scattered all across the plain.”

He roused the will to fight in every heart.  
The Trojans would have fallen back to Troy,  
chased by the warlike Greeks, subdued by fear—  
had not a son of Priam, Helenus,  
the best interpreter of birds, come near  
to Hector and Aeneas and addressed them.

“Of all the Trojans and the Lycians, you two  
shoulder the greatest burden in this war,  
because you are the best in every battle  
at fighting and at strategy. Stay here,  
80 and keep the fighters shut outside the gates.  
Run through their ranks and make sure that they do not  
escape and fall into their women’s arms,  
which surely would delight the enemy.  
After you urge each phalanx to stay firm,  
we shall remain here and confront the Greeks  
however hard it is. Necessity  
forces us forward. Meanwhile, Hector, go  
back into Troy. Tell Hecuba, our mother,  
to gather all the older Trojan women  
beside the temple of bright-eyed Athena,  
high on the city’s peak. She must unlock  
the holy house and bring with her a robe,

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100

110

90 the largest and the finest in her hall,  
the one she values most of all by far, 120  
and lay it on the lap of great Athena,  
the goddess with the finely braided hair,  
and vow to sacrifice inside her temple  
twelve yearling heifers who have never felt  
the goad, if she has pity on our town  
and all the Trojan wives and little children,  
and keeps from holy Troy that fearsome fighter,  
the son of Tydeus, the source of fear,  
wild Diomedes. I believe he is  
the strongest warrior of all the Greeks. 130  
Achilles never frightened us like this,  
100 although they say his mother is a goddess.  
That Diomedes is a maniac.  
No one can stand against his will to fight.”

Hector did not ignore his brother’s words.  
At once he leapt out of his chariot  
onto the ground and brandished his sharp spears.  
He marched all through the Trojan camp and urged  
the men to fight and summoned up within them  
desire for horrifying war. The Trojans 140  
turned round again to stand and face the Greeks,  
who paused their killing spree and backed away.  
They said that one of the immortal gods  
had come down from the starry sky to help  
the Trojans and to turn them back to battle.  
110 And Hector shouted loudly to his troops,

“Proud Trojan warriors and famous allies,  
be men, my friends. Keep always in your minds  
the need for courage, energy, and zeal,  
while I go into Troy to tell our wives 150  
and the old men, our councillors, to pray  
and promise hecatombs to please the gods.”

So Hector in his flashing helmet spoke

then rushed away. The outmost rim that ran  
around his dark, embossed, hide-covered shield  
battered against his ankles and his neck.

Then Glaucus, son of fine Hippolochus,  
and Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
120 met in the middle of the battlefield,  
both keen to fight. As they drew near each other,  
Lord Diomedes, master of the war cry,  
was first to speak. He shouted,

160

“Who are you?

Are you a mortal? You look very strong.  
I never saw you here before in battle  
where men win glory. But now you have come  
far out ahead of all the others, trusting  
your own proud courage. You believe, it seems,  
that you can stand against my long, dark spear.  
I pity those whose children challenge me.

170

If you are one of the immortal gods  
descended from the sky, I come in peace—  
I am not one to fight the heavenly gods.

130 I know that strong Lycurgus, son of Dryas,  
did not live long, because he dared defy  
gods from the sky, on holy Mount Nyseion  
in bygone times when he attacked the nurses  
who cared for wild and manic Dionysus.

Using an ox-whip, murderous Lycurgus  
struck them. At once they let their sacred wands  
fall spilling to the ground. And Dionysus  
was scared and dove into the salty waves,  
where Thetis welcomed him and hugged him close,  
soothing his terror and the frightened trembling  
caused by the human’s shouting. Then the gods  
who live at ease were angry with Lycurgus,  
and Zeus, the son of Cronus, blinded him,  
140 and soon he died because the deathless gods  
all hated him. For my part, I would not  
have any wish to fight the blessed gods.

180

But if you are a mortal, one who eats  
grain from the fields, come nearer and approach  
the snares of death.”

190

But glorious Glaucus, son  
of Lord Hippolochus, said, “Diomedes,  
proud son of Tydeus, why do you ask  
about my ancestry? The generations  
of men are like the growth and fall of leaves.

The wind shakes some to earth. The forest sprouts  
new foliage, and springtime comes. So too,  
one human generation comes to be,

150 another ends. But if you really want  
a thorough knowledge of my ancestry,  
which is already known to many men,  
listen. There is a city, Ephyra,

200

nestled among the horse pastures of Argos,  
where Sisyphus, the sneakiest of men,  
was born and raised. Aeolus was his father.  
Sisyphus had a son whose name was Glaucus,  
who had a son, the fine Bellerophon.

The gods made him a very handsome man.  
But Proetus formed a plan to bring him down.  
Zeus had subdued the Argives to the scepter  
of Proetus, who had greater strength and might.  
He drove Bellerophon away in exile.

210

160 Then noble Antea, the wife of Proetus,  
went crazy with desire to seduce him  
and sleep with him in secret, but she failed  
to make him yield to her, because his mind  
was sensible and noble. So the woman  
lied to the king her husband, saying, ‘Proetus,  
I hope you die unless you kill that man,  
Bellerophon, because he tried to rape me!’

220

Hearing these words, her husband was enraged,  
but hesitant to kill the man himself.  
He sent him off to Lycia, giving him  
a folded tablet, which he had inscribed  
with many dangerous and deadly symbols.

And Proetus told Bellerophon to show it  
 170 to Antea's father, so that he would kill him.  
 Bellerophon reached Lycia through the guidance  
 of gods. And when he reached his destination 230  
 in Lycia by the swirling River Xanthus,  
 the king was very eager to provide him  
 with honor and to treat him as a guest  
 for nine days, killing nine cows for his meals.  
 But when the tenth Dawn showed her rosy fingers,  
 he asked Bellerophon to let him see  
 the token he had brought with him from Proetus.  
 And when Bellerophon revealed the token,  
 the king first told him that he had to kill  
 the threatening Chimera, who was not 240  
 180 a human but descended from the gods.  
 In head and shoulders, she was like a lion,  
 in back and tail, a snake, and in the middle,  
 a she-goat, and she breathed a dreadful blast  
 of blazing fire. But Bellerophon,  
 informed by signals from the gods, destroyed her.  
 Second, he fought the famous Solimi—  
 he said that was his very fiercest battle.  
 And third, he killed the manlike Amazons.  
 But then the king devised another trap. 250  
 He chose the finest of the Lycian fighters  
 to set an ambush for Bellerophon  
 when he returned. Instead, Bellerophon  
 190 killed all of them. None came back home again.  
 Then the king realized Bellerophon  
 must be the mighty offspring of a god.  
 He kept him at his side and gave him half  
 his royal honors, and his daughter's hand.  
 The Lycians gave him an estate to keep,  
 the best in all the kingdom, very fertile 260  
 for orchards and for crops that need the plow.  
 The wife of brilliant Bellerophon  
 bore him three children, named Hippolochus,  
 Isandrus, and Laodamea, whom  
 devious Zeus seduced. She had a son,

godlike Sarpedon, fully armed in bronze.  
200 But then Bellerophon aroused the hatred  
of all the gods. Alone and lost, he wandered  
across the Alean plain, heartsick with grief,  
avoiding any human habitation. 270  
Ares, whose thirst for war is never sated,  
slaughtered his son Isandrus when he fought  
against the famous Solimi. His sister  
was killed by Artemis of the golden reins,  
because the goddess was enraged at her.  
And I can tell you that Hippolochus  
fathered me. I declare myself his son.  
He sent me off to Troy with these instructions—  
to always be the best and to excel  
everyone else, not shame my forefathers, 280  
who were by far the finest warriors  
210 in Ephyra and all the Lycian lands.  
I proudly claim this line and blood as mine.”

The master of the war cry, Diomedes,  
was glad to hear these words. He fixed his spear  
firm in the earth that feeds the world, and spoke  
in friendship to the shepherd of the people.

“So you must be an old guest-friend of mine,  
through our forefathers. Oeneus once hosted  
noble Bellerophon inside his house 290  
and kept him as his guest for twenty days.  
They gave each other splendid gifts of friendship.  
Oeneus gave a shining belt, adorned  
with purple, and Bellerophon gave him  
220 a double-handled golden cup. I left it  
back home inside my house when I came here.  
But I do not remember Tydeus.  
He left me when I was a tiny baby,  
during the war at Thebes when Greeks were dying.  
Now you and I are also loving guest-friends, 300  
and I will visit you one day in Argos,  
and you will come to visit me in Lycia,

whenever I arrive back home again.

So let us now avoid each other's spears,  
even amid the thickest battle scrum.

Plenty of Trojans and their famous allies  
are left for me to slaughter, when a god  
or my quick feet enable me to catch them.

And you have many other Greeks to kill  
whenever you are able. Let us now

230 exchange our arms and armor with each other,  
so other men will know that we are proud  
to be each other's guest-friends through our fathers."

310

With this, the two jumped off their chariots  
and grasped each other's hands and swore the oath.  
Then Zeus robbed Glaucus of his wits. He traded  
his armor with the son of Tydeus,  
and gave up gold for bronze—gold armor, worth  
a hundred oxen, for a set worth nine.

Meanwhile, when Hector reached the Scaean Gates  
and oak tree, all the Trojan wives and daughters  
ran up and gathered round him, asking him  
about their brothers, cousins, sons, and husbands.

240 He told them they should calmly, each in turn,  
pray to the gods. But onto most of them  
disaster was already fastened tight.

320

Then Hector reached the splendid house of Priam,  
surrounded by its polished colonnade.

Inside were fifty rooms of polished stone,  
built next to one another, where the sons  
of Priam slept beside their honored wives.

Within the courtyard, on the other side,  
were twelve more rooms where Priam's daughters slept,  
built out of polished stone, adorned with roofs,  
and there the sons-in-law of Priam lay

250 beside their noble wives. And Hector's mother,  
generous Hecuba, came out to meet him.

330

She brought Laodice, her prettiest daughter.  
She hurled her arms around her son and asked him,

“My child, why did you leave the bitter fighting?  
Those Greeks—I curse their names!—who are besieging  
our city must have worn you out. Your heart  
led you to come inside the walls and raise  
your hands to Zeus from our high citadel.  
So stay a while and let me get you wine  
sweetened with honey. First, pour out libations  
for all the gods, especially father Zeus,  
and after that, you need to have a drink.  
Wine can restore a man who is exhausted,  
as you are now—so very tired from fighting  
to keep your friends and comrades safe in battle.”

But mighty Hector of the flashing helmet  
answered, “No, Mother. Do not fetch me wine,  
in case it weakens me and I forget  
my will to fight. And I would feel ashamed  
to pour bright wine for Zeus with unwashed hands.  
A person smeared with blood and gore should not  
pray to the son of Cronus, god of dark clouds.  
But you must gather all the older women  
and go with holy offerings to the temple  
of great Athena, goddess of the spoils.  
And take the loveliest and largest robe,  
the one you value most in all the house,  
and lay it in the lap of great Athena,  
the goddess with the braided hair, and promise  
to sacrifice inside her shrine for her  
twelve yearling heifers, perfect offerings,  
whose backs have never felt the goad, if she  
pities the town and wives and little children  
of holy Troy and keeps away the son  
of Tydeus, the fearsome Diomedes,  
whose spear can turn his enemies to flight.  
Go on now to the temple of Athena,  
goddess of looting and the spoils of war.



280 And meanwhile, I will go and summon Paris  
to come with me, if he will hear my words.  
I wish the earth would gape and swallow him!  
Olympian Zeus protected him and raised him  
as a catastrophe for all the Trojans,  
including valiant Priam and his children.  
If I saw Paris going down to Hades,  
my mind could start forgetting grief and pain.”

380

When Hector finished speaking, Hecuba  
went in the house and shouted to her slaves  
to go through town and call the older women,  
and then she went inside her fragrant storeroom.  
In it, she kept her fine embroidered robes,  
made by the women of Sidonia,  
whom godlike Paris Alexander brought  
290 to Troy across the wide back of the sea,  
on that same journey when he brought back Helen,  
the daughter of the mightiest of fathers.  
From all these garments, Hecuba selected  
the robe with the most beautiful adornments,  
the biggest one, which shone as bright as starlight,  
to bring it to Athena as a gift.  
It lay there underneath the other clothes.  
Then she set out, and many older women  
came with her. When they reached Athena’s temple  
high on the city’s peak, bright-faced Theano,  
horse-lord Antenor’s wife, the child of Cisses,  
opened the doors for them. She was appointed  
300 as priestess of Athena by the Trojans.  
All of the women wailed and raised their hands  
towards the goddess with the braided hair,  
Athena. Beautiful Theano took  
the robe and set it in Athena’s lap,  
and to the daughter of great Zeus she prayed.

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“Goddess Athena, savior of the city,  
shatter the spear of Diomedes! Grant  
that he may fall before the Scaean Gates.

410

We will immediately dedicate  
twelve yearling heifers, perfect offerings,  
whose backs have never felt the goad before,  
if you have pity on the town of Troy,  
310 the Trojan women, and the little children.”

She prayed, and yet Athena, child of Zeus,  
refused to grant her prayer. She shook her head.

While they were praying, Hector went towards  
the splendid house of Paris, which he built 420  
himself, assisted by the finest builders  
in fertile Troy. They made the house for him,  
with bedroom, hall, and court, near Priam’s house  
and Hector’s, on the city’s peak. And Hector,  
favored by Zeus, went there. He held his spear,  
which was eleven cubits long. Its tip  
of bronze shone bright, attached onto the spear  
320 with golden wire that ran around the shaft.  
Hector found Paris in his inner chamber,  
fiddling with his beautiful equipment, 430  
his spear and breastplate, and his hands were stroking  
his curving bow. With him sat Argive Helen,  
among her slave girls. She was telling them  
to manufacture splendid thread and cloth.  
Seeing his brother, Hector scolded him  
with words to bring him shame.

“You are so strange!  
It is not right for you to be so angry.  
The troops around our city and high wall  
are dying! War is raging round this town  
because of you! And you yourself would challenge 440  
and fight with anyone you saw hold back  
330 from hateful war—as you are doing now!  
Come on, get up, or very soon our city  
will burn with blazing fire.”

And godlike Paris,  
great Alexander, answered, "Hector, yes,  
you scold me just enough and not too much.  
So let me tell you something. Listen please  
and pay attention. I do not sit here  
inside my bedroom out of irritation  
or anger at the Trojans. I was grieving.  
I tried to turn myself entirely over  
to sadness. But just now, my wife was saying  
gently, persuasively, that I should go  
back to the war. And I myself believe  
that that will be the better choice for me.  
Victory favors one man, then another.  
340 Just wait for me while I put on my armor,  
or go ahead and I will catch you up."

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He spoke, but bright-helmed Hector made no answer.  
Then Helen spoke and tried to make him stay.

460

"Brother-in-law, I am a source of fear  
and source of evil strategy— a dog.  
I wish that at the start, right when my mother  
gave birth to me, a cruel gust of wind  
had borne me to the mountains, or the waves  
of loud-resounding sea, and swept me off,  
before all this could happen. But the gods  
ordained these troubles as they came to pass.  
350 I wish I shared a bed with someone better,  
a man who understood the condemnation  
his actions would incur from other people.  
This man has no good sense, no self-control,  
and no capacity to change. One day  
he surely will receive his retribution.  
But come now, brother, sit down here with me.  
You have endured the greatest pain and grief  
because of us—because of me, a dog,  
and Paris with his folly and delusion.  
Zeus set an evil lot upon us all,  
to make us topics of a singer's tale

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480

for people in the future still unborn.”

360 Then mighty Hector of the flashing helmet  
replied, “You must not make me sit down, Helen,  
despite your love for me. I will not do it.  
I feel already such a strong desire  
to go protect the Trojans. In my absence  
they miss me terribly. What you should do  
is rally this man. Let him rouse himself  
and reach the battlefield before I do,  
while I am here inside the town of Troy.  
I must go see my family at home—  
my darling wife and little baby son.  
You see, I do not know if I will ever  
return to them again. This time the gods  
may crush me underneath the hands of Greeks.”

490

370 Then Hector in his flashing helmet left her,  
and quickly reached his own fine, well-built home.  
But in the hall he did not find his wife,  
white-armed Andromache. She had gone up  
onto the city wall and stood there grieving  
and sobbing. She was with her well-dressed slave,  
who held the baby. And when Hector saw  
his noble wife was not inside the house,  
he stood just in the doorway, on the threshold,  
and called out to the women slaves,

500

“Come here,  
and talk to me. You have to tell the truth.  
Where is Andromache? Why is she out?  
Where did she go? To visit with my sisters,  
or to my brothers’ wives who wear fine dresses,  
or to the temple of the fearsome goddess,  
Athena, where the other Trojan women,  
380 whose hair is finely braided, say their prayers?”

510

The capable chief house slave answered him,

“Hector, since you have asked us for the truth,  
your wife has not gone out to see your sisters,  
or to your brothers’ wives who wear fine dresses,  
or to the temple of the fearsome goddess,  
Athena, where the other Trojan women,  
whose hair is finely braided, say their prayers.  
She rushed towards the wall, because she heard  
the Trojans have been losing and the Greeks  
have gained enormous power. She ran off  
as if beside herself with manic frenzy.  
The nurse slave went with her and brought the baby.”

520

390 The woman finished speaking. Hector dashed  
out of the house and back the way he came,  
through the great town, along the well-kept streets,  
and when he reached the Scaean Gates, which led  
out to the battlefield, she ran to meet him—  
Andromache, the wife for whom he gave  
so many gifts to take her as his bride.  
She was the daughter of King Eetion,  
who lived beneath the woodland of Mount Placus,  
in Thebe, ruling the Cilicians.  
This daughter of a king was now the wife  
of Hector, in his armor made of bronze.  
She ran to meet him, and the slave came too,  
bringing the baby cuddled in her arms.  
400 He was so little still—an innocent.  
Hector adored this baby boy, his son,  
who was as beautiful as a bright star.  
Hector called him Scamandrius, but others  
called him Astyanax, the city’s lord,  
because his father, Hector, was the one  
who kept Troy safe. Now Hector saw his child,  
and smiled at him in silence, saying nothing.  
Andromache stood next to him in tears,  
grasping his hand, and spoke his name and said,

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“What are you doing, Hector? You strange man!  
Your will to fight will kill you! Do you feel

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no pity for your little baby son,  
or my unhappiness, my life of loss?  
Soon I shall be your widow. Soon the Greeks,  
all of them rushing at you all at once,  
will kill you. Then for me, when I have lost you—  
410 better that I sink down below the earth.

There can be no more comfort afterwards  
for me when you are dead, but only pain.  
I have no father and no noble mother,  
because godlike Achilles killed my father.  
He breached the towering gates and sacked my city,  
Thebe, where we Cilicians once lived  
in peace. Achilles killed the king, my father,  
560 but did not strip the armor from his corpse.

He felt compunction. So he burned the body,  
along with his ornate, well-fashioned weapons,  
and heaped a mound to mark the place. Around it,  
the oreads, the mountain goddesses,  
children of Zeus who wears the goatskin aegis,  
420 made elm trees grow. And I had seven brothers.

All of them went to Hades on one day.  
Swift-footed Lord Achilles killed them all,  
amid their bright white sheep and shambling cattle.  
My mother, who had ruled so long as queen  
beneath the shady woodlands of Mount Placus,  
was brought here by Achilles as a slave,  
along with all the other looted treasure.

But he accepted ransom from her father  
to set her free, and in her father's house  
Artemis with an arrow struck and killed her.

Hector, you are my father and my mother.

430 You are my brother, and the vigorous man  
whose bed I share. Please think of me, have pity,  
and stay here on the wall. Please do not make  
your son an orphan and your wife a widow.  
Line up the troops beside the wild fig tree,  
the place the enemy might scale the wall  
and strike the town of Troy. The Greeks have come  
to try that very spot three times already.

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Brave Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
 both sons of Atreus, the two named Ajax,  
 and famous Idomeneus attacked  
 right there with all their other finest fighters.  
 Perhaps someone who knew divine intentions  
 told them, or their own impulse led them there.”

440 Great Hector in his flashing helmet answered,  
 “Woman, I care about all these things too.  
 But I feel overwhelming shame in front of  
 the Trojan women in their trailing dresses  
 and Trojan men, if I shrink back from war  
 as if I were a coward. And my spirit  
 tells me I must not stop, for I have learned  
 always to be a warrior and fight  
 among the frontline champions of Troy,  
 to win great glory for the king my father  
 and for myself. You see, my heart and mind  
 know this for sure—that there will be a day  
 when holy Troy will be destroyed, and Priam,  
 lord of the ash-wood spear, and all our people.

600

450 But no one matters more to me than you.  
 No pain that anyone in Troy will suffer,  
 not even Hecuba or high king Priam,  
 not even all my many noble brothers,  
 who will be slaughtered by our enemies  
 and fall amid the dust in days to come—  
 no pain of theirs affects me more than yours.  
 One day some bronze-armed Greek will capture you,  
 and you will weep, deprived of all your freedom.  
 Then you will weave to serve another woman  
 in Argos. You will have to carry water  
 from River Hyperea or Messeis,  
 entirely against your will, but forced  
 by strong necessity. And sometimes people  
 will see you weeping there and they will say,  
 460 ‘That woman used to be the wife of Hector,  
 who was the greatest champion of Troy  
 during the Trojan War.’ When they say that,

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your pain and grief will feel brand-new again,  
because you do not have a man like me  
to save you from the day of your enslavement.  
But as for me, I hope I will be dead,  
and lying underneath a pile of earth,  
so that I do not have to hear your screams  
or watch when they are dragging you away.”

630

Then noble Hector reached towards his son.  
The baby wailed and wiggled back to snuggle  
into his well-groomed nurse’s lap and dress.  
The child was scared by how his father looked,  
shocked at the terrifying horsehair plume  
that nodded at the top part of his helmet.  
His loving father and his mother laughed.  
Hector immediately took off his helmet  
and put it on the ground. It glittered brightly.  
Then glorious Hector kissed his darling son  
and took him in his arms to rock and cuddle  
and prayed to Zeus and all the other gods,

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“Zeus and you other gods, please let my son  
be just like me—admired among the Trojans,  
strong and successful on the battlefield,  
and powerful enough to rule in Troy.  
I hope they say when he comes back from war,  
‘This man is so much better than his father.’  
I hope he kills an enemy of ours  
and brings his bloodstained arms and armor back,  
and makes his mother happy.”

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With these words,  
he gave his son to his beloved wife.  
She let him snuggle in her perfumed dress,  
and tearfully she smiled. Her husband noticed  
and pitied her. He took her by the hand  
and said to her,



“Strange woman! Come on now,  
you must not be too sad on my account.  
No man can send me to the house of Hades  
before my time. No man can get away  
from destiny, first set for us at birth,  
however cowardly or brave he is.  
490 Go home and do the things you have to do.  
Work on your loom and spindle and instruct  
the slaves to do their household work as well.  
War is a task for men—for every man  
born here in Troy, but most especially, me.”

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When he had finished speaking, glorious Hector  
picked up his helmet with its horsehair plume.  
His loving wife set off for home, but kept  
twisting and turning back to look at him.  
More and more tears kept flooding down her face.  
Quickly she reached the rich and well-built house  
of Hector, killer of men, and there she found  
a multitude of women slaves inside.  
500 She prompted all of them to start lamenting,  
and so they grieved in his own house for Hector  
while he was still alive. They knew that he  
would never come back home again from war.  
He would not get away from fierce Greek hands.

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And meanwhile, Paris did not dawdle long  
in his high house. He put his armor on,  
a splendid set of finely fashioned bronze,  
and hurried through the center of the city,  
letting his quick feet carry him along.  
Just as a stallion, who has been standing  
confined to munch his barley at the manger,  
breaks through his harness and at top speed gallops  
across the plain with clattering of hooves,  
down to his usual spot beside the river  
to wash himself—he is all confidence,  
and holds his head up high—his mane is streaming  
510 across his back and shoulders—he is conscious

690

of his own beauty, and his galloping legs  
carry him to the pasture of the mares—  
so Paris, son of Priam, sauntered down  
from the high peak of Pergamum. He shone  
with glittering arms and armor like the sun,  
and grinned in joy. His quick feet carried him.  
And soon he reached the spot where glorious Hector  
had had the conversation with his wife.  
The brothers met as Hector turned to leave.  
First godlike Paris Alexander spoke.

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“Brother, am I too late? Did I not come  
on time just as you ordered me to do,  
as you are in a hurry to be off?”

And Hector of the flashing helmet answered,  
“Strange man! No one of any sense would ever  
disparage your performance in a battle.  
You are a brave man. And yet you hold back.  
You choose to dawdle and refuse to fight.  
My heart is very troubled and upset  
when I hear Trojans criticizing you,  
because you caused them so much suffering.  
But now we have to go. In future times  
we shall make all this turn out right, if Zeus  
one day allows us to set out the cup  
of freedom in our halls and lets us pour  
libations to the everlasting gods  
who live in heaven—after we have driven  
these strong, well-armored Greeks away from Troy.”

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## BOOK 7



## A Duel

Then glorious Hector sprinted from the gates  
as did his brother, Paris Alexander,  
both hankering to fight and join the battle.  
Just as when sailors feel their bodies failing,  
worn out from pushing wooden oars through water,  
and in the midst of their despair, some god  
sends them fair wind—so was it for the Trojans,  
when those two warriors appeared to help them.  
They both began to kill and Paris slaughtered  
Menesthius, who used to live in Arne.

10

10 Phylomedusa with the oxen eyes  
bore him to lord Arethous, club-bearer.  
And Hector's sharp spear pierced Eioneus  
right through the neck, beneath his fine bronze helmet.  
His limbs unknotted. Then the Lycian leader,  
Glaucus, the son of lord Hippolochus,  
attacked, and through the chaos of the battle  
skewered the shoulder of Iphinous,  
the son of Dexias, who had been trying  
to mount his chariot. Iphinous

20

fell backward from the carriage to the ground.  
His limbs untied. With sparkling eyes, Athena  
saw Trojans killing Greeks in furious fighting,  
so down she swooped and came from Mount Olympus  
20 to holy Troy. Apollo rushed to meet her.  
He saw her from the Pergamum and wanted  
a Trojan victory. They met beside  
the oak tree. Lord Apollo, son of Zeus,  
was first to speak.

“Why have you come down here  
from Mount Olympus, child of mighty Zeus? 30  
Some strong desire must have brought you here.  
You seem intent on something. Do you want  
to turn the tide of battle and to grant  
a victory to the Greeks? You surely feel  
no pity for the Trojans who are dying.  
Do as I say—that will be best. We must  
suspend the fearsome fighting for today.  
Tomorrow, they will start the war again,  
30 until they find the final end of Troy.  
Both of you deathless goddesses, I know, 40  
have set your hearts on this beloved goal—  
the total devastation of the city.”

Bright-eyed divine Athena answered him,  
“Aloof Apollo, yes, let it be so.  
That is exactly what I had in mind  
when I left Mount Olympus and came here  
to join the Trojans and the Greeks. But come,  
how do you mean to pause the human battle?”

And Lord Apollo, son of Zeus, replied,  
“Let us arouse a strong desire to fight 50  
in Hector, lord of horses. Let him challenge  
40 one of the Greeks amid the strife of battle  
to fight him face to face in single combat.  
And let the bronze-armed Greeks be aggravated

and urge a champion to fight alone  
with famous Hector.”

Eyes ablaze, the goddess  
Athena listened and concurred with him.  
And Helenus, beloved son of Priam,  
intuited the plan the scheming gods  
had chosen, so he went and stood by Hector  
and told him,

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“Hector, son of Priam, listen!  
You are as good at strategy as Zeus,  
but I am your own brother. Heed my words.  
Command the Greeks and Trojans to sit down.  
Challenge the best Greek warrior to fight you  
in brutal single combat face to face.  
It is not yet your fated time to die  
and meet your destiny. So spoke the voice  
that I have heard from the eternal gods.”

50

Hector was very glad to hear these words.  
He strode among the troops and calmed them down,  
grasping the center of his spear. He made  
the Trojans all sit down, and Agamemnon  
ordered the well-armed Greeks to sit down also.  
And then Apollo of the silver bow  
and great Athena went to perch like vultures  
high in the oak tree sacred to their father  
who bears the aegis, Zeus. They took delight  
in watching men. The massive crowd of fighters  
rippled with helmets, spears, and shields, as when  
a ripple spreads across the sea, while Zephyr  
begins to stir the water, which grows dark  
beneath the rising wave—so were the troops  
of Greeks and Trojans gathered on the plain.  
Hector addressed both sides.

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“Now listen, Trojans

and well-armed Greeks, let me explain to you  
the promptings of my heart. The son of Cronus,  
who sits on high, has not fulfilled our oaths.

70 He looks unfavorably on both sides,  
portending trouble for us all, until  
you Greeks break down our walls and capture Troy,  
or else until you are yourselves defeated  
beside the ships in which you crossed the sea.  
But on your side, there are distinguished fighters  
from all the areas that Greeks inhabit.

90

Let one of you, whoever feels the urge  
to fight with me, step out from all the rest  
to be your champion against glorious Hector.  
And I declare these terms—let Zeus be witness!

If that man kills me with his piercing bronze,  
let him strip off my armor and my weapons  
and take them to your hollow ships, but send  
my body back to my own home again,

100

80 so that the Trojan warriors and wives  
may grant me after death my share of fire.

And if I kill him, if Apollo grants  
success to me, I shall strip off his armor  
and carry it to holy Troy to hang

before the temple of the god who strikes  
from far away, Apollo. I shall give

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his body back and send it to the ships,  
so that the long-haired Greeks can honor him  
with funeral rites and build a mound for him  
above the spreading Hellespont. One day,

someone who will be born in future times  
will pass that way across the wine-dark sea  
upon a ship with many banks of oars

and say, 'That mound memorializes someone  
who died in the distant past, when famous Hector  
killed him in glorious combat long ago.'

90 120

People will say these things in times to come,  
and so my fame and name will never die."

When Hector finished speaking, all the others

stayed silent, too embarrassed to refuse,  
and too afraid to take him up on it.  
Time passed. Then Menelaus stood and spoke.  
“You useless show-offs! Not Greek men, but women!  
It will be terrible humiliation  
if none of us will take up Hector’s challenge.  
I hope you all turn into earth and water,  
just sitting there, no life or courage in you!  
But I will arm myself to fight with him.  
The final limits of the victory  
lie with the everlasting gods above.”  
With this, he strapped his glorious armor on.  
And surely at that moment, Menelaus,  
you would have seen your life’s end, at the hands  
of Hector, because he was so much stronger,  
had not the leaders of the Greeks rushed in  
and seized you. Agamemnon, your own brother,  
the influential son of Atreus,  
grabbed your right hand and spoke to you and said,

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“Stop! You are acting crazy, Menelaus!  
You are a king, a favorite of Zeus.  
You must avoid such folly and hold back,  
however troubled you may feel. Do not  
pursue the quarrel and attempt to fight  
a better man, Hector, the son of Priam.  
Everyone fears him! Even great Achilles  
shrinks from encountering this man in combat,  
and he is far superior to you.  
You should sit down, go join your group of comrades.  
The Greeks will tell another champion  
to fight with Hector. Even one who lacks  
all fear and hungers endlessly for war  
will certainly be glad to sit and rest,  
if he survives this terrifying duel.”

150

With this well-judged advice, the great man changed  
his brother’s mind, and Menelaus yielded.  
His stewards happily took off his armor.

160

Then Nestor stood up and addressed the Greeks.

“Ruin is coming to the land of Greece!  
How the old horseman Peleus would grieve  
if he heard all of you were cowering  
for fear of Hector! Noble Peleus,  
senior advisor of the Myrmidons,  
questioned me when I visited his house  
and was delighted at the news I gave him  
about the lineage and parentage  
of all the warriors from Greece. But now,

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130 surely he would lift up his arms and beg  
the deathless gods to let his spirit sink  
out of his body to the house of Hades.  
By father Zeus, Athena, and Apollo,  
if only I were young and strong again,  
as when beside the Celadon’s swift streams,  
the Pylians assembled and then fought  
the spearmen from Arcadia, beneath  
the walls of Pheia, near the Jardan River.

Then Ereuthalion stood up to fight  
on their behalf, a godlike man who carried  
the club of godlike Lord Arethous,  
whom men and well-dressed women dubbed ‘the clubman,’  
140 because he did not fight with bow and arrows,  
nor with a long spear, but broke through front lines  
using his iron club. Lycurgus killed  
Arethous by tricks, not force of arms.

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He ambushed him inside a narrow passage,  
so that his iron club could not protect him.  
Lycurgus speared his midriff, and he toppled  
backward and fell, splayed helpless on the ground.

190

Lycurgus took away from him the club  
given by brazen Ares. When Lycurgus  
grew old inside his house, he passed it on  
to Ereuthalion, his dear attendant,  
to carry. With this weapon in his hands,  
150 he challenged all the finest champions.  
But everyone was terrified and trembled,



and no one dared to fight with him but me.  
Although I was the youngest of them all,  
my fearless spirit urged me, and I fought him.  
Athena gave the victory to me.

200

I killed that man—the tallest, strongest man,  
whose massive corpse lay sprawled, limbs splayed akimbo.  
I wish I were that young and had that strength!  
Then Hector in his glittering bronze helmet  
would get his fight! But now, not one of you,  
the finest fighters in the whole Greek league,  
will volunteer to come and challenge Hector.”

160

This was the way the old man scolded them.  
Nine men leapt up. The first by far to stand  
was Agamemnon, lord of men, and next,  
strong Diomedes, son of Tydeus.

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Then the two warriors named Ajax stood,  
wearing the armor of their fearless courage.  
After them, Idomeneus stood up,  
as did Meriones, his comrade, equal  
to murderous Ares, and Eurypylus,  
Euaemon’s splendid son, and Thoas, son  
of Andraemon, and fine Odysseus.

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All of them hoped to fight with noble Hector.  
Again Gerenian Nestor, lord of horses,  
addressed them.

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“Each of you must now place lots  
to cast for who will be our champion.  
That man will benefit the well-armed Greeks  
and benefit himself if he survives  
the dangers of this dreadful, lethal conflict.”

So Nestor spoke, and each man marked a lot,  
and threw it into Agamemnon’s helmet.  
The people prayed, hands lifted to the gods.  
They looked towards the wide expanse of sky  
and said, “Great father Zeus, may it be Ajax,

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180 or Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
or Agamemnon, king of rich Mycenae.”

Gerenian Nestor, horse-lord, shook the helmet.  
Out jumped the lot they hoped for—that of Ajax.  
The steward brought it through the group and showed it  
to each Greek champion. He walked along  
from left to right, and no one recognized it.  
They each rejected it. But after passing  
all of the other men, he reached the one  
who marked the lot and threw it in the helmet.  
Glorious Ajax reached his hand out for it.  
The steward came in close and gave it to him.  
Ajax examined it and knew his mark.  
He was delighted, tossed it down again  
190 onto the ground beside his foot, and said,

“My friends, this is my lot and I am glad,  
because I think I can defeat great Hector.  
While I put on my armor for the fight,  
250 you must all pray to Zeus, the son of Cronus,  
in silence, so the Trojans will not hear,  
or openly, as we are not afraid  
of anyone! No one can make me run  
by forcing me away against my wish,  
nor by superiority of skill.  
I have not lacked for talent, I believe,  
ever since I was young on Salamis.”

200 At this, they prayed to Zeus, the son of Cronus.  
They looked towards the wide expanse of sky,  
and said,

“Great Zeus, majestic, mighty father,  
grant victory to Ajax, let him win  
triumphantly and boast of his success.  
And even if you also care for Hector,  
give them both equal strength and equal glory.”

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So spoke the people. Ajax armed himself  
in glittering bronze armor, which he strapped  
around his body, and with all his weapons  
he lunged ahead—as massive Ares strides  
to war with human warriors whom Zeus  
has set to fight in life-devouring conflict—  
so massive Ajax, bulwark of the Greeks,  
hurtled ahead. His face was terrifying,  
fixed in a grin. His feet took mighty strides.  
He grasped his spear that cast a lengthy shadow.  
Looking at him, the Greeks were glad. The Trojans  
shuddered and every one of them was quaking,  
and even Hector’s heart was beating fast.  
But even so, he could not turn around  
away from battle back to his own comrades,  
because the will to fight was calling him.  
Ajax drew closer with his towering shield  
of bronze and oxhide seven layers thick,  
made by the craftsman Tychius, the best  
at leatherwork, who had his home in Hyle,  
who made that flashing shield of seven oxhides,  
from strong and sturdy bulls, and over them  
added a final layer made of bronze.  
Such was the shield that Telamonian Ajax  
bore at his chest. He came up close to Hector,  
and threatened him.

“Now, Hector, you will learn  
in single combat what impressive fighters  
our army still contains—although we lack  
Achilles, breaker of the ranks of men,  
the lion-heart. He lies beside the ships  
that cross the sea on curving prows, because  
he feels such furious wrath at Agamemnon,  
the shepherd of the people. But there are  
plenty of others on our side, who are  
quite capable of standing firm to face you.  
Come on now, start the fighting in this duel.”

Great Hector of the flashing helmet answered,  
“Lord Ajax, son of Telamon, great leader,  
commander of the troops, whom Zeus has favored,  
you must not treat me like a weak young child  
or like a woman ignorant of war.

You should not test me. I already know  
the work of warfare, massacres, and fighting.  
I know the proper way to hold a shield,  
turning the dry ox-leather left and right—  
to me, this flexibility is crucial

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in shieldsmanship. And I know how to charge  
into a galloping clash of chariot horses.  
And in close combat, I know how to fight  
on steady feet and dance for cruel Ares.  
I would not want to strike a man like you  
by sneaking up and taking you by surprise.  
I want to try to hit you in fair fight,  
openly, face to face.”

With that, he swung  
and hurled his spear that cast a long dark shadow,  
and hit the mighty seven-oxhide shield  
of Ajax, on the eighth and outmost layer,  
the bronze that coated all the leather skins.  
The tireless spear of bronze pierced through six folds,  
but on the seventh skin it stopped. And then  
Ajax, a leader in the line of Zeus,

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let fly his long dark spear at Priam’s son.  
It struck his shiny, balanced shield, and pierced  
through it, and through his decorated breastplate,  
and through his tunic at his side. But Hector  
swiveled and managed to avoid black death.  
Then each with two hands tugged their spears back out  
and fell to fighting, like flesh-eating lions  
or like wild boars whose passion never tires.  
The son of Priam struck the shield of Ajax  
again right in the center, but he failed  
to penetrate the bronze—his spear-tip bent.

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Then Ajax leapt and stabbed through Hector’s shield.

The weapon went right through. He staggered back.  
It sliced his neck and black blood spouted out.

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But Hector, in his brightly flashing helmet,  
never stopped fighting, even with this wound.

He took a step back, and his sturdy hand  
picked from the ground a big black jagged boulder  
and hurled it straight at Ajax, and it struck  
his seven-layered shield, on the boss  
right in the center, and the bronze resounded.

Then Ajax grabbed an even bigger rock,  
whirled it around then tossed it, and it smashed

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Hector's strong shield with full force, like a millstone,  
and dented it, and Hector's knees gave way.

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Knocked back, he lay prostrate beneath the shield.

But soon Apollo got him up again.

They would have moved in close to fight with swords,  
but then the heralds came, the messengers

of Zeus and men, one from the Trojan side,  
the other from the Greeks bedecked in bronze—

Idaeus and Talthybius, both wise.

They held their staffs between the pair of fighters,  
and sensible Idaeus said,

“Stop fighting!

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Dear sons, we care about you both, and Zeus,  
the god who musters clouds, loves both of you,  
and both of you are wonderful at fighting.

All of us recognize it. But now night  
has come and it is good to yield to night.”

Ajax, the son of Telamon, replied,

“Idaeus, you should say all this to Hector.

He was the one who challenged us to fight.

Let him decide and I shall yield to him,  
whichever choice he makes.”

Then mighty Hector,

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nodding his flashing helmet, said, “Indeed,

some god has given Ajax size and strength  
and judgment. With his spear he is the best  
of all the Greeks. So let us pause the fighting  
290 and cruel conflict now, just for today.  
Tomorrow, we will fight again, until  
some deity decides between us two  
and grants the victory to one of us.  
Night has arrived already. It is good  
to yield to night. Ajax, when you return, 380  
the Greeks beside the ships will be delighted,  
especially your own relatives and comrades.  
I will bring joy throughout the town of Priam  
to all the Trojan men and Trojan women.  
The women in their trailing robes will hold  
a holy festival to pray for me.  
Now, Ajax, let us trade some precious gifts.  
300 Then people on the Greek and Trojan sides  
will say we fought in life-devouring combat,  
but then we separated as good friends.” 390

With that, he gave a silver-studded sword,  
complete with scabbard and well-fashioned strap.  
Ajax gave him a belt, bright red with dye.  
And then they went their separate ways, and Ajax  
rejoined the army of the Greeks, while Hector  
returned to the noisy clamor of the Trojans,  
who were delighted when they saw him safe,  
alive and well, having escaped the danger  
of Ajax, whose indomitable hands  
310 they never thought he could survive. They took him 400  
back into Troy. Meanwhile, the Greeks escorted  
Ajax, delighting in his victory,  
back to the noble son of Atreus,  
Lord Agamemnon. When they reached his tent,  
he sacrificed for them and mighty Zeus  
a bull of five years old. They stripped its hide  
and got the meat prepared. They chopped it up,  
skillfully carved it, skewered it on spits,  
then roasted it with care, then served it all.

They finished cooking and the food was ready,  
and then they feasted, and no man was lacking  
320 an equal portion of the banquet meat.

But Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
lord of a wide expanse of land, awarded  
the strips of meat from near the spine to Ajax,  
to honor him. At last they set aside  
desire for food and drink. The old advisor,  
Nestor, whose counsel pleased them in the past,  
was first to speak and weave a plan of action.  
He stood addressing them with all goodwill.

420

“Now Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
and all you champions from the whole Greek world,  
we know that many long-haired Greeks are dead.  
Sharp-slicing Ares spilled their dark-red blood  
330 beside the flowing streams of the Scamander.  
Their spirits have descended into Hades.

At dawn, you have to make the troops stop fighting.  
Then we shall go with carts and mules and oxen  
to drag away the corpses to be burned  
beside the ships, and we will take their bones  
back to their children when we reach our homes  
in our own fatherland. Here we will heap  
a single burial mound around the pyre,  
scooping the earth to build a common grave.  
Beside it, we should quickly build high walls,  
protection for the ships and for ourselves.

430

We must put fitted gates inside the wall  
340 to let the chariots go to and fro.

Close by, around the outside of the wall,  
we have to dig a deep surrounding trench,  
to keep our horses and our people safe  
when noble Trojan warriors attack us.”  
He finished speaking, and the leading Greeks  
all praised the words of Nestor.

440

And meanwhile  
the Trojans gathered on the top of Troy

beside the doors of Priam's house—a wild,  
chaotic gathering. And wise Antenor  
was first to speak among them.

“Hear me, Trojans,  
Dardanians, and allies. I will speak  
as I am prompted by my inmost heart. 450  
350 Bring Argive Helen and her treasure here.  
Let us return it all to Menelaus  
and Agamemnon, sons of Atreus.  
We are the ones who broke the solemn oaths  
before the fighting started up again.  
I do not think things will go well for us  
unless we do as I suggest.”

Antenor  
finished his speech and sat back down again.  
Then godlike Paris Alexander, husband  
of Helen with the braided hair, stood up 460  
to answer him with words on wings.

“Antenor,  
these words are not the kind I like to hear.  
You know how to come up with better speeches.  
If you are serious in saying this,  
360 the gods themselves must have destroyed your mind.  
I shall speak out among the Trojan horsemen  
and tell them quite explicitly I will not  
give back the woman—though I am quite willing  
to give them back the treasure that I took  
from Greece and brought to my house. And, moreover,  
470 I can add other items of my own.”

He finished speaking and sat down. Then Priam,  
whose acumen was equal to the gods,  
the heir of Dardanus, addressed them all,  
hoping to help them.



“Listen to me, Trojans,  
Dardanians, and allies. I will speak  
as I am prompted by my inmost heart.  
370 Go now and have your dinner in the city  
as usual, but be careful, keep good watch,  
and stay awake tonight. At dawn, Idaeus 480  
must go down to the hollow ships and tell  
the sons of Atreus the words of Paris,  
the man who is the cause of this whole conflict.  
And let him make this sensible suggestion—  
to please delay the dreadful noise of war  
until we burn the corpses. Then tomorrow,  
we fight until some god decides between us  
and gives the victory to Greece or Troy.”

So Priam spoke. They eagerly obeyed him,  
and ate their dinner with the fighters gathered 490  
380 battalion by battalion. Then at dawn  
Idaeus went down to the hollow ships.  
He found the Greeks, henchmen of Ares, gathered  
beside the stern of Agamemnon’s ship.  
The herald stood among them and called out,

“Great Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
and all you other fine Greek warriors!  
Priam and all the other Trojan leaders  
have ordered me to bring this message to you,  
if you would like to hear it, if you wish. 500  
Paris, because of whom the conflict started,  
says that he is quite willing to give back  
all of the treasure that he brought to Troy  
inside his hollow ships. If he had only  
390 died before he did that! And he will also  
offer you other treasures from his home.  
But he refuses to give back the woman,  
the lawful wife of splendid Menelaus,  
although the Trojans say he ought to do so.  
They also ordered me to ask you this— 510  
stop, if you will, the dreadful noise of war

until we burn the corpses. Then tomorrow,  
we fight until some god decides between us  
and gives the victory to Greece or Troy.”

He finished speaking and they all kept quiet.

Finally, Diomedes shouted out,

400 “Nobody should take anything from Paris!

Do not accept the treasure back, not now,

nor Helen. It is obvious by now,

even to fools, the Trojans are already

entangled tightly in the ropes of ruin.”

520

At this, the Greeks all shouted out in triumph,

praising the words of horseman Diomedes.

Then mighty Agamemnon said,

“Idaeus,

you must have heard the answer of the Greeks.

I share their views. But we can burn the dead.

Of course I could not possibly object.

No man should grudge the bodies of the dead

410 the comfort of immediate cremation.

Let Zeus the thunderlord, the spouse of Hera,

be witness to our oaths.”

530

With this he raised

the speaking staff to all the gods. Idaeus

returned to holy Troy, where all the Trojans

and all Dardanians were sitting gathered,

packed close together, waiting for Idaeus.

He came into the center of the crowd

and shared the news. At once, they fell to work.

Some went to gather wood, and others brought

the bodies of the dead. Meanwhile, the Greeks

had left their fleet of galleys. Half of them

420 gathered the corpses and the rest fetched wood.

Helioid surfaced from the gentle streams

of Ocean’s depths and rose into the sky,

540

and struck the fields just as the two sides met.  
They found it hard to recognize the bodies.  
They washed them clean of blood and pus, and piled them  
into the wagons, as they shed hot tears.  
But mighty Priam would not let his people  
wail for the dead. With grieving hearts but silent,  
they piled the corpses on the pyre and burned them.  
Then they went back again to holy Troy.

550

430 Meanwhile, the well-armed Greeks were piling up  
their corpses on the pyre, with grieving hearts.  
After the bodies of the dead were burned,  
they went back to the hollow ships again.  
While it was still not dawn but half-lit night,  
the specially chosen group of Greeks assembled  
and built a single mound around the pyre,  
scooping the earth to form a common grave.  
They raised high towers and a wall beside it,  
protection for the ships and for themselves.  
They put well-fitted gates inside the wall,  
to let the chariots go to and fro.  
Close by, around the outside of the wall,  
440 the long-haired Greeks dug out a great big trench,  
both wide and deep, and stuck sharp stakes inside it.

560

And sitting beside Zeus, the lord of lightning,  
the gods were watching as the bronze-clad Greeks  
labored to make this marvelous creation.  
Poseidon, shaker of the earth, began.

“Great father Zeus, will any mortals bother  
to tell their plans and schemes to deathless gods  
in any place across the boundless world?  
Do you not see? The Greeks have built a wall  
around their ships to keep them safe from harm,  
and dug a trench along this wall—and yet  
they have not given any hecatombs  
450 to us—the gods! The glory of this work  
will spread in fame as far as dawn extends,  
and people will forget the wall of Troy,

570

built with great effort for Laomedon  
by Phoebus and myself.”

580

Cloud-gathering Zeus,  
deeply disturbed, said, “What is this, Poseidon?  
What have you said, almighty god of earthquakes?  
Certainly, other gods may fear this structure—  
the gods whose hands are not as strong as yours.  
But your fame surely spreads as far as dawn.  
Come on then, when the long-haired Greeks have sailed  
460 back in their ships to their dear fatherland,  
tear down their wall and hurl it in the sea  
and cover this long beach with sand again.  
You can obliterate this great Greek wall.”

590

This was the way they talked. The sun went down.  
The Greeks were finished with their building work.  
Returning to the camp, they killed some cattle  
and had their dinner. Many ships from Lemnos  
were docked there, bearing wine sent by Euneus,  
the son of Jason, shepherd of the people—  
his mother was Hypsipyle. Euneus  
470 had sent a separate batch for Agamemnon  
and Menelaus, sons of Atreus—  
some unmixed wine, a thousand servings of it.  
The long-haired Greeks made trades to get that wine.  
Some traded bronze for it, some gleaming iron,  
some cattle hides and some, whole living cows,  
and others traded wine for human captives,  
taken in war. They made a lavish feast.  
All night the long-haired Greeks were banqueting.  
The Trojans and their allies did the same  
inside the town. And all night, clever Zeus  
was plotting pain for them, and thundering,  
and rumbling with a terrifying noise.  
Pale fear seized hold of them. They splashed some wine  
480 out of their cups and spilled it on the floor.  
Nobody dared to drink before they poured  
libations to the mighty son of Cronus.

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Then they lay down and took the gift of sleep.

## BOOK 8



# The Scales Tip

In saffron robes Dawn spread across the world,  
and Zeus who loves the thunder called the gods  
to an assembly on the topmost peak  
of rocky Mount Olympus. He addressed them  
and all the gods paid heed to him.

“Now hear me,  
all gods, all goddesses, and let me speak  
the promptings of my heart inside my chest.  
Let none of you—no goddess and no god—  
try to defy my orders. You must all  
accede to me so I can quickly finish  
this enterprise of mine. And if I see

any of you attempt to go and help  
the Greeks or Trojans, I will pummel you  
and push you back again to Mount Olympus,  
or grab and hurl you even further off,  
all the way down to shadowy Tartarus,  
the deepest chasm underneath the earth,  
beyond the iron gates, beyond the threshold

of bronze, as far beneath the land of Hades  
as heaven is from earth. Then you shall see  
I am more powerful than all of you,  
stronger than any other god. Come on,  
try it, so all of you will know the truth!  
If all you gods and goddesses attached  
a chain of gold onto the sky and tried  
to drag me out of heaven to the earth—  
me, the great mastermind, the highest god—  
you could not ever move me from my place,  
however hard you tried. I am great Zeus.  
But any time I feel like doing so,  
I have the strength to pull up all of you  
and scoop the earth and sea up with you also,  
then tie a chain around the pinnacle  
of Mount Olympus and suspend it all,  
so earth and sea would dangle in midair.  
I am so much the greatest of you all,  
stronger than any other god or human.”

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30

Stunned by his words, the gods all held their tongues.  
His speech had been so forceful. But at last  
the goddess with the bright gray eyes, Athena,  
said,

40

“Mighty father, greatest son of Cronus,  
we do know that you are invincible.  
Yet we are sorry for the brave Greek spearmen,  
in so much pain and dying dreadful deaths.  
We will draw back from war, as you command.  
But we will give the Greeks some good advice,  
so that your rage will not destroy them all.”

Smiling at her, cloud-gathering Zeus replied,  
“Dear daughter, born of Triton, do not worry.  
I was not being serious. I love you.  
I want to treat you kindly.”

50

With these words,  
he yoked his horses to his chariot—  
a pair with hooves of bronze and long gold manes.  
He dressed himself in gold and seized a whip  
of well-wrought gold, mounted his chariot,  
and struck the horses. Eagerly they flew,  
and galloped between earth and starry sky.  
They reached the mountain brooks and rivulets  
of Ida, mother to wild animals,  
and Gargaron, his shrine and fragrant altar.  
There Zeus, the father of the gods and humans,  
halted his horses and unloosed their harness,  
and poured a massive cloud of mist across them.  
The god himself sat on the mountaintop,  
exultant in his glory as he gazed  
towards the Greek ships and the Trojan city.

60

The long-haired Greeks were eating in their tents  
hastily, then they put their armor on.  
In Troy, the Trojans also took up arms.  
Their warriors were fewer, but they yearned  
to fight in the intensity of war,  
forced by the present danger to take action  
to save their wives and children. All the gates  
opened and out they sped, on foot and horse,  
with deafening shouts and clattering of arms.  
The warriors met, bronze breastplates close together.  
Hides clashed, spears struck, and human wills collided.  
Shield bosses smashed together and created  
great rattling clangs and cracks and thunderous noise.  
Despair and triumph swelled among the killers  
and those they killed. The earth ran red with blood.

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While dawn and heavenly morning grew in brightness,  
the blades of both sides clashed. The people fell.  
But when the sun god, Helios, stood straddled  
across the middle of the sky, the father  
of gods and men stretched out his golden scales  
and placed in them two weights of destiny,

70



for death whose pain extends across the ages—  
one for the Trojans, skilled in breaking horses,  
one for the Greeks, in tunics forged of bronze.  
He grasped the middle of the scales, pulled up,  
and downward sank the doomsday of the Greeks—  
their fates were laid to rest on fertile earth.

90

The fortunes of the Trojans rose aloft  
towards the wide expanse of sky. From Ida,  
Zeus made reverberating thunder rumble  
a mighty boom, and hurled a flaming bolt  
into the army of the Greeks. The sight  
startled them and pale terror seized them all.

Then Idomeneus and Agamemnon  
fled with the two named Ajax, aides to Ares.

100

80 Only Gerenian Nestor stayed in place,  
the guardian of the Greeks—but not on purpose.

His horse was suffering from an arrow, shot  
by godlike Paris Alexander, husband  
of Helen with the lovely braided hair.

The arrow struck the horse's skull on top,  
right at the forelock of his sprouting mane—  
a deadly spot. In pain he reared. The weapon  
pierced through his brain. He whirled and spooked the pair  
of other horses harnessed to the chariot.

110

At once the old man leapt down with his sword  
to slice the reins that held the dying horse.

Then Hector's horses galloped through the throng  
of men retreating and in fierce pursuit,  
bearing brave Hector as their charioteer.

90 Old Nestor would have died right then and there,  
but Diomedes, master of the war cry,  
saw him and shouted to Odysseus  
for help.

“Odysseus, son of Laertes,  
favored by Zeus, you always have some scheme!  
Where are you running off to like a coward,  
a commoner who runs away in battle?  
You must not turn your back, or someone's spear

120

will stab between your shoulder blades. Stand firm,  
so we can drive this vicious brute away  
from poor old Nestor.”

So spoke Diomedes.  
Stubborn Odysseus refused to listen.  
Instead he dashed back to the hollow ships.  
Then Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
pressed through the throng to the front line of fighters,  
although he had to do it all alone.  
100 He reached old Nestor, son of Neleus,  
stood by his chariot and spoke winged words.

“These younger warriors are causing you  
terrible pain and danger, sir. Your strength  
is running out. Your old age weighs you down.  
Your charioteer is wobbly on his feet,  
your horses slow. Come, mount my chariot,  
and see the caliber of Trojan horses,  
able to gallop all across the plain,  
swerving at top speed in pursuit or flight.  
I took them from Aeneas a while ago.  
Our stewards can take care of your two horses,  
while you and I drive this team straight towards  
110 the Trojan wranglers, to make Hector learn  
whether the spear I hold is just like his—  
seething with rage.”

Gerenian Nestor, horse-lord,  
heard and concurred. The two strong charioteers,  
kindly Eurymedon and Sthenelus,  
took care of Nestor’s mares, while Diomedes  
mounted his chariot along with Nestor.  
Then Nestor’s hands took up the shining reins.  
He whipped the horses, and they soon reached Hector,  
who lunged towards them. Diomedes hurled  
his spear at him, but missed his mark and hit  
the charioteer, the son of brave Thebaeus,

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120 Eniopeus. As he held the reins,  
the weapon struck his chest, beside the nipple,  
and threw him off the chariot. The horses  
startled and shied. Their driver's life and spirit  
were instantly released. A desperate grief  
wrapped round the heart of Hector, but he left him  
to lie there, though he mourned for his companion.  
He sought another brave, strong charioteer.  
The horses were not long without a driver.  
He quickly found the son of Iphitus,  
bold Archeptolemus. He promptly made him  
climb up behind his swift-hoofed pair of horses,  
and gave the reins to him. There would have been  
130 unstoppable destruction, and the Trojans  
would have been trapped in Troy like sheep. But Zeus,  
the father of the gods and humankind,  
noticed and thundered terribly and sent  
a flashing thunderbolt that struck in front  
of Diomedes in his chariot.  
An eerie flame of burning sulfur rose.  
The frightened horses cowered by the carriage.  
The shining reins slipped out of Nestor's hands.  
Aghast, he said to Diomedes,

"Son  
180 of Tydeus, come on, you have to turn  
your horses' solid hooves to run away.  
140 Zeus has not granted you success today.  
Can you not see it? For today at least  
the son of Cronus gives success to Hector.  
Some other time he may grant us the same,  
if he so wishes. But no man can change  
the mind of Zeus—no man, however strong.  
The god has far more power."

Diomedes,  
190 the master of the war cry, said, "Old man,  
everything you have said is quite correct.  
But in my heart and soul I feel deep pain.

Hector will tell his people, ‘Diomedes  
was scared of me and ran back to his ships!’  
So he will boast. And on the day that happens,  
may earth gape wide enough to swallow me.”

150

Gerenian Nestor, horse-lord, answered him,  
“No, Diomedes, son of Tydeus!  
What you have just said is ridiculous.  
Even if Hector calls you cowardly,  
he will not sway the Trojans or the Greeks,  
and surely not the women who have lost  
brave warriors with shields, the healthy men  
who used to share their beds. You cut them down  
and laid them in the dust.”

200

With this, he turned  
the horses back amid the surging mob.  
Then Hector and the other Trojan fighters  
let out a preternatural yell and hurled  
a flood of painful spears and javelins.  
Hector, his helmet flashing, shouted loudly  
to Diomedes,

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“Son of Tydeus!  
The Greeks whose foals run fast have granted you  
the glory of a special seat of honor,  
and special meat and cups filled full of wine.  
Now they will lose all their respect for you.  
You always were no better than a woman.  
Be off with you, you silly little thing!  
You will not ever scale my city’s walls  
or take my women captive in your ships.  
I will prevent you. I will bring your doom.”

220

Then Diomedes pondered his two choices,  
and wondered if he ought to turn his horses  
and stand to fight with Hector face to face.  
Three times he thought it over in his mind,

170 and three times scheming Zeus made thunder rumble  
from Ida as a signal to the Trojans  
that victory in battle would be theirs.  
Then Hector called the Trojans, shouting loudly,

“Trojans and Lycians and Dardanian fighters,  
be men, my friends. Stay focused, brave, aggressive. 230  
I know that Zeus has nodded and decided  
to bless me in this battle with success—  
glory for me and trouble for the Greeks!

Poor fools! They worked so hard to build those walls—  
such feeble, worthless nothings, which will never  
withstand the force of my attack. With ease  
my stallions will leap across their trench.

180 But when I reach their hollow ships, you must  
remember how destructive fire can be.  
I shall burn up their fleet with deadly flames, 240  
and terrify the Greeks, and smoke them out,  
then slaughter all of them beside their ships.”

With this, he called his horses, saying to them,  
“Now Swiftfoot, Blondie, Flame, and godlike Sparkle,  
repay me for the food Andromache,  
daughter of Eetion, once gave to you  
in such abundance, feeding you on grain  
as sweet as honey. She mixed up some wine  
for you to drink whenever you desired—

even before she served my wine to me, 250  
190 although I am her husband. Gallop fast  
ahead and let me capture Nestor’s shield,  
whose fame extends to heaven. It is made  
of solid gold, the shield and both the handles.  
And let me strip away from Diomedes  
that marvelous corselet fashioned by Hephaestus.  
If I succeed in getting both these trophies,  
then I may hope to force the Greeks to climb  
back on their rapid ships this very night.”

The goddess Hera, outraged at his boasting, 260  
trembled upon her throne and shook the mountain,

200 high Mount Olympus. She addressed Poseidon,  
a mighty god.

“This is incredible!  
Powerful god of earthquakes, even you  
feel nothing in your heart for those poor Greeks,  
dying—although they always used to bring you  
numerous fine offerings in Aegae  
and Helice. You wanted them to win!  
If all of us who hope to help the Greeks  
agree to push the Trojans back and curb  
farsighted Zeus, then he can sit and suffer  
all by himself right there on top of Ida.”

270

The god of earthquakes answered, greatly troubled,  
“Hera, what are you saying? Take it back!  
210 I do not want the rest of us to fight  
with Zeus. He is by far the strongest god.”

So went their conversation. And meanwhile  
the Greeks were crammed in tightly and confined  
behind the trench and wall around the ships.  
Horses and men with shields were trapped by Hector,  
Priam’s son, pressing at the speed of Ares,  
now Zeus had given him the upper hand.  
He would have burned the ships with blazing fire,  
had not great Hera given Agamemnon  
the urge to take some action and make haste  
to rouse the other Greeks. He strode along  
220 beside their ships and cabins, holding up  
a big red cloth grasped firmly in his hands.  
He reached the midpoint of the line of ships  
and stopped before the black, capacious vessel  
belonging to Odysseus, which lay  
so that a shout could reach both ends of camp—  
in one direction, to the tents of Ajax,  
the son of Telamon, and in the other,  
to where Achilles slept. Those two had moored

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their steady ships out on the farthest ends,  
trusting their courage and their mighty hands.  
Now Agamemnon stood there and called out,  
raising his voice so all the Greeks could hear him,

“For shame, you cowards! This is a disgrace! 300  
You Greeks are only good at looking pretty!  
Where now are all the boasts you made at Lemnos?  
230 Your claims to be the best of men were empty!  
You gorged on carcasses of straight-horned cattle  
and glugged down punch bowls brimming full of wine,  
and claimed each one of you could stand and challenge  
a hundred or two hundred Trojan fighters.  
But now you cannot face a single one!  
Hector will soon destroy our fleet with fire!  
O father Zeus, when have you ever treated 310  
any almighty leader so unfairly?  
Has any other been so cursed, so tricked,  
deprived by you of such a massive win?  
During my journey here on my great warship  
propelled by many men at oar, I tell you  
I never skipped a single sacred altar  
240 of yours. I sacrificed on all of them.  
I burned the fat and thighs of many oxen  
as offerings, because I longed to sack  
the well-built town of Troy. Now grant me, Zeus, 320  
this wish at least—to let these men survive.  
Let them escape and do not let the Trojans  
annihilate the Greeks, as they are doing.”

He spoke through floods of tears, and father Zeus  
was sorry for him. Bowing down his head  
he granted that the army would be safe,  
not massacred. Immediately he sent  
an eagle, the most meaningful of birds,  
whose talons held a fawn, a swift deer’s child.  
The eagle dropped the fawn beside the altar 330  
on which the Greeks made sacrifice to Zeus  
250 from whom all holy voices come. The Greeks

recognized that the eagle came from Zeus.  
Their zest to fight in battle was renewed.  
They rushed with greater force against the Trojans.  
Numerous Greeks were driving their swift horses  
out of the trench to face the Trojan troops,  
but none of them could boast of overtaking  
the son of Tydeus, quick Diomedes,  
who dashed out far ahead of all the rest,  
and was the first to strike a Trojan leader.  
He took down Agelaus, son of Phradmon,  
who had already turned his horses round  
to canter in retreat. But Diomedes  
attacked him from behind and plunged his spear  
between his shoulder blades and pierced his back,  
drove through his chest, and threw him from the carriage.  
His weapons rang around him as he fell.  
Behind quick Diomedes, Agamemnon  
and Menelaus, sons of Atreus,  
rushed forward. After them, the two named Ajax,  
trusting their courage and their will to fight.  
After them, Idomeneus attacked,  
with fine Meriones, who was a match  
for murderous Mayhem. Then Eurypylus,  
Euaemon's noble son, arrived, and ninth  
Teucer appeared, his back-bent bow held ready.  
He took his stance behind the mighty shield  
of Telamonian Ajax, who would move it  
aside while Teucer scanned the crowd, then shot,  
and hit his mark. His victim would fall down  
and lose his life, then Teucer, like a child  
hiding himself beneath his mother's skirt,  
would duck back down again, and Ajax hid him  
behind his shining shield. Which Trojan fighter  
was first to die from glorious Teucer's arrows?  
Orsilochus was first, then Ormenus,  
and Ophelestes, Daetor, Chromius,  
then godlike Lycophontes, Melanippus,  
and Amopaon, son of Polyaeon.  
Teucer felled all of them in quick succession

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and laid them on the earth that feeds us all.  
And Agamemnon, lord of men, was glad  
to see him slaughtering the Trojan troops  
with his strong bow. He came to stand beside him  
and said,

“My good friend Teucer, lord commander,  
shoot on like that, and you will be a light  
for all the Greeks, and Telamon your father,  
who cared for you when you were just a baby  
and nurtured you and raised you in his house,  
although you were an illegitimate son.  
Bring fame to him, though he is far away.  
And I say this to you—so it will be!—  
if Zeus who bears the aegis and Athena  
grant that I sack the well-built town of Troy,  
I will set in your hands a fine reward  
as soon as I myself have got my spoils.  
I may give you a tripod, or two horses,  
complete with chariot, or else a woman  
to join you in your bed.”

Great Teucer answered,  
“Lord Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
why do you urge me? I am keen already.  
As long as I have strength, I never stop.  
Ever since we began to drive the Trojans  
back to the city, I have lain in wait  
to kill them with my bow. I have shot eight  
arrows with long barbs, all of which have pierced  
the flesh of ardent warriors. That man,  
that mad dog Hector, is the only one  
I cannot hit.”

And with this, he positioned  
another arrow on the string and pulled  
his bow and shot it, aiming straight at Hector.  
He longed to hit him, but he missed. He struck

a fine strong son of Priam in the chest—  
Gorgythion from Aesyme, whose mother,  
Castianeira, was as beautiful  
as any goddess in the way she looked—  
a married woman. Now Gorgythion  
slumped his head sideways—like a garden poppy,  
weighted with seed and springtime showers of rain—  
so drooped his head, weighed down by his heavy helmet.  
Then Teucer pulled his bowstring back and shot

410

310

another arrow, aiming straight at Hector,  
longing to hit him, but again he missed.  
Apollo foiled his aim. Instead he hit  
strong Archeptolemus, his charioteer,  
careening into battle. Teucer's arrow,  
piercing his chest beside his nipple, threw him  
out of his chariot. His horses shied,  
their quick hooves skittering away. At once  
the driver's life and spirit were released.  
Terrible grief wrapped round the heart of Hector  
for his dead charioteer. But then he left him,  
despite his sorrow for his lost companion.

420

320

Cebriones, his brother, was nearby,  
so Hector told him to take up the reins.  
Cebriones complied, and bright-helmed Hector  
leapt with a war cry from his chariot.

430

He seized a boulder in his hand then rushed  
at Teucer, desperate to hit him. Teucer  
took out a deadly arrow from his quiver  
and set it on the string and quickly drew  
the bow back past his shoulder—but then Hector  
struck him right on the collarbone that bridges  
the neck and chest—most dangerous of spots.

330

The jagged boulder made his bowstring snap  
and numbed his wrist. He could not move. He sank  
down to his knees and dropped his bow. But Ajax  
noticed his fallen brother, ran to him,  
stood over him, and covered him with his shield.  
Two other loyal comrades came to help—  
godlike Alastor and Mecisteus,

440

the son of Echius. They heaved him up  
and lugged him back towards the hollow ships.  
He groaned and cried in pain while being carried.

Then once again Olympian Zeus aroused  
aggression in the Trojans, and they drove  
the Greeks straight back towards their deep-dug ditch.

340 Among the foremost warriors was Hector,  
confident of his strength—as when a dog  
pursues a lion or wild boar—his paws  
are quick, he follows close behind, his teeth  
snap at his quarry’s flank and rump—he watches  
his victim’s every twist and turn—so Hector  
stalked close behind the long-haired Greeks and slaughtered  
numerous stragglers as they tried to run.  
Many were brought low by the hands of Trojans.  
When the survivors had got past the ditch  
and through the ramparts, they stopped by the ships,  
and stayed there, calling out to one another,  
and raised their hands in prayer to all the gods,  
each of them desperate for help, while Hector  
swiveled and spun his chariot back and forth.  
His horses whipped their graceful swirling manes.  
His eyes were like the Gorgon or like Ares  
who murders mortals.

450

460

350                               Hera, white-armed goddess,  
noticed the Greeks in danger, pitied them,  
and turned immediately to Athena  
and let her words take wing.

                                          “This is outrageous!”  
Athena, child of Zeus who bears the aegis,  
do we no longer care about the Greeks  
when they are dying, in their final hour?  
The Greeks are doomed! This massacre is caused  
by one man only—Hector, son of Priam.  
No one can stand against his manic rage!

470

He has achieved such massive devastation.”

Bright-eyed Athena said, “You are quite right.  
I truly hope that man will lose his life,  
killed by Greek hands in his own fatherland.

480

360 But now my father rages in mad fury,  
with evil in his heart. That cruel god  
is wicked, always keen to block my wishes.  
He has forgotten that I often saved  
that son of his, oppressed by all those Labors  
set by Eurystheus. He cried to heaven,  
and Zeus sent me down from the sky to save him.

If only I had known that this would happen,  
through intuition and perceptiveness,  
back when that son of his was sent to Hades—  
the watchful warden of the narrow gate—  
to fetch the dog out of the world of darkness.

490

He would not have escaped from hateful Hades  
or crossed the gushing waters of the Styx.  
370 Now Zeus hates me. He promised with his nod  
to bring fulfillment to the plans of Thetis.  
She kissed his knees and touched his chin and begged him  
to glorify Achilles, city-sacker.

One day, he will again tell me, ‘Bright Eyes,  
I love you.’ But meanwhile, prepare for us  
the hard-hoofed horses. I will go and enter  
the house of Zeus who bears the royal aegis,  
and arm myself for war, so I can see  
whether the son of Priam, bright-helmed Hector,  
is glad when we appear among the armies.

500

Perhaps the Trojans will begin to fall  
beside the Greek ships and fill full the bellies  
380 of dogs and birds with fat and human flesh.”

These were Athena’s words, and white-armed Hera  
immediately did as she had asked.

510

The goddess, firstborn child of mighty Cronus,  
harnessed the horses in their golden crowns.  
Athena, child of Zeus who bears the aegis,

shook off the flowy, soft, embroidered dress  
that her own hands had woven and created,  
and left it in her father's entryway.

Then she put on a tunic that belonged  
to Zeus who marshals clouds, and armed herself  
for war, the source of tears. She set her feet  
inside the chariot of fire, and grasped  
the big strong heavy spear with which she tames  
the ranks of warriors when she is angry,  
using the power of her father, Zeus.

Then Hera whipped the horses to a gallop.

The gates of heaven automatically  
groaned open. They are guarded by the Hours,  
the goddesses whose job is to protect  
Olympus and the mighty sky. They pull  
thick clouds away and set them back again.

The goddesses sped through these gates, their horses  
spurred on by Hera's whip.

520

530

When father Zeus  
looked down from Ida, he was furious.  
He summoned Iris on her golden wings  
and sent her as a messenger.

"Swift Iris,  
go turn them back! They must not come attack me!  
It is not right for us to join in battle.  
I tell you this, and it will surely happen—  
I will disable their swift galloping horses  
and hurl them both out of their chariot  
and smash it all to pieces, and the wounds  
my thunderbolt inflicts on both of them  
will take ten years to heal. So let young Bright Eyes  
see what it means to fight with her own father.  
But I do not blame Hera quite as much  
or feel so angry with her. After all,  
this is the way she normally behaves.  
She always thwarts whatever I decree."

540

410 Then Iris on her storm-feet leapt and swooped  
from Ida to the heights of Mount Olympus,  
where rocks are cleft and folded like a blanket, 550  
to bring the message. Right outside the gates  
she met the goddesses and made them halt  
and told them both what Zeus had said to her.

“Where are you going to in such a hurry?  
Why has this mania possessed your hearts?  
Zeus, son of Cronus, has forbidden you  
to help the Greeks. If you persist, he made  
this threat, which he will surely carry out—  
he will disable your swift galloping horses  
and hurl you both out of your chariot 560  
and smash it all to pieces, and the wounds  
his thunderbolt inflicts on both of you  
will take ten years to heal. So you, young Bright Eyes,  
420 see what it means to fight with your own father.  
But he does not blame Hera quite as much  
or feel so angry with her. After all,  
this is the way she normally behaves.  
She always thwarts whatever he decrees.  
But you, Athena, are impossible,  
most terrible, a dog who lacks all fear, 570  
if you dare raise your heavy spear at Zeus!”

Then Iris sped away on her quick feet,  
and Hera said, “Well now, Athena, child  
of Zeus who bears the aegis, I refuse  
to let us keep on making war with Zeus  
just for the sake of mortals. As for them,  
I do not care which human lives or dies.  
Let it be any of them. As for him,  
430 let him devise his plans in his own head  
and form his judgments for the Greeks and Trojans, 580  
as it should be.”

With these words, Hera turned

the fine-maned horses on their sturdy hooves  
back to Olympus, where the Hours unyoked them,  
and fastened them to mangers of ambrosia,  
and propped the chariot against the wall  
that glittered brightly. Hera and Athena  
sat with the other gods on golden couches,  
very upset and downcast. Father Zeus  
drove his own well-wheeled chariot and horses  
from Ida to Olympus and arrived  
at the assembly of the gods. Poseidon,  
the famous earthquake god, unyoked his horses  
and set his chariot upon a stand  
and draped it with a cloth. Farsighted Zeus  
sat on his golden chair. Beneath his feet  
mighty Olympus trembled. But Athena  
and Hera sat apart and kept their distance  
and would not talk to him. Zeus understood,  
and said,

590

“Why are you so upset, Athena  
and Hera? So you have not yet grown weary  
of battle where the humans win their glory?  
Have you not had enough of killing Trojans?  
You still retain such bitter hatred of them!

600

But even so, my spirit is so strong,  
my mighty hands are so invincible,  
that all you other gods on Mount Olympus  
could never turn me from my purposes.  
As for you two, your gleaming limbs were shaking  
even before you saw the works of war  
and all their ugliness. I will say this—  
a threat that surely would have come to pass—  
if I had struck you with my thunderbolt,  
your chariot could not have carried you  
back to Olympus, home of the immortals.”

610

At these words, Hera and Athena hissed.  
They sat beside each other, forming schemes  
for ruining the Trojans. But Athena

did not speak out against her father Zeus.  
She held her tongue, though she was furious  
and fearsome rage seized hold of her. But Hera  
could not contain her fury. She told Zeus,

“Most terrible of all our father’s children,  
what you have said is unacceptable!  
We know already that you are no weakling.  
But we feel pity for the Greek spear-fighters,  
doomed to fulfill a bitter destiny.  
We will draw back from war, as you command.  
But we will give the Greeks some good advice,  
so that your rage will not destroy them all.”

Then Zeus who folds the clouds together answered,  
“Hera, my ox-eyed goddess queen, you shall  
witness at dawn tomorrow, if you wish,  
almighty Zeus, the son of Cronus, kill  
yet more Greek warriors—mass casualties.  
Powerful Hector will not leave the fighting  
until Achilles, son of Peleus,  
rises on swift feet from beside his ships,  
the day the Greeks are trapped beside their fleet,  
desperately fighting for the dead Patroclus.  
Such is divine decree. I do not care  
how angry you may be. And even if  
you reach the lowest depths of earth and sea  
where Iapetus and Cronus sit deprived  
of all the pleasures of the wind and sun,  
the rays of Helios Hyperion,  
surrounded by the depths of Tantarus.  
Even if you go there, I shall remain  
indifferent to your discontentedness.  
No creature is more like a dog than you.”

To these words, white-armed Hera made no answer.  
The shining sunlight fell into the Ocean  
and drew black night across life-giving earth.



The Trojans mourned the sunset, but the Greeks  
welcomed dark night and blessed it three times over.

490 Then Hector led the Trojans from the ships  
and gathered them beside the swirling river,  
a clear spot where the ground was free from corpses.  
Dismounting from their chariots to the ground,  
they stood and listened to the words of Hector,  
whom Zeus loved. In his hand he grasped his spear,  
eleven cubits long, whose bronze tip shone, 660  
bound to the spear shaft with a ring of gold.  
Hector leaned on this spear as he addressed  
the multitude.

“Now hear me, all of you,  
Trojans, Dardanians, and allied forces.  
I thought I would destroy the ships today,  
and slaughter all the Greeks, and then go home  
500 to windy Troy. But darkness fell too soon.  
It saved the Argives and their fleet of ships  
moored in the breakers of the sea. So now 670  
we must submit to black night, and make dinner.  
Unyoke the horses from the chariots  
and brush their flowing manes and give them food.  
Bring us fat sheep and oxen from the city  
quickly, and wine whose heart is sweet as honey,  
and bread and more provisions from the storerooms,  
and gather ample wood, so we can burn  
numerous fires whose gleam will reach the sky,  
all night till early dawn, to make quite sure  
510 the long-haired Greeks cannot set sail away 680  
across the sea’s broad back. We must not let them  
embark so easily, without a struggle.  
Let some of them take wounds back home to feed.  
Struck by an arrow or a biting sword  
let them jump desperately on board their ships,  
so others will be loath to bring the tears  
of Ares to the Trojans, lords of horses.  
Let heralds, favorites of Zeus, tell all

the teenage boys and old men with gray hair  
to gather on the walls that gods constructed  
520 around our city, and let every woman  
burn a great hearth fire inside every home.  
We must keep careful watch, in case they ambush  
the city while the fighters are away.  
Brave-hearted Trojans, be it as I say.  
This speech will be enough for now. At dawn  
I will again address you, Trojan horsemen.  
I pray to Zeus and all the other gods  
to drive away those dogs brought here by doom,  
on black ships piloted by deadly fate. 700  
We must protect ourselves here for tonight.  
530 At dawn's first light tomorrow, let us arm,  
and rouse sharp Ares by their hollow ships.  
Then I will see if mighty Diomedes,  
the son of Tydeus, will have the power  
to drive me from the ships towards the wall,  
or I will slaughter him with bronze and strip him  
of bloodstained arms and armor. So tomorrow  
he will find out if he is good enough  
to stand against the arrival of my spear. 710  
I think that when the sun comes up tomorrow  
he will lie wounded on the battlefield  
with many comrades lying dead around him.  
I wish I could be deathless and unaging  
forever and receive as much acclaim  
540 as do the gods, Athena and Apollo,  
and this could be as sure as that tomorrow  
brings ruin for the Greeks!"

So Hector spoke.

The Trojans shouted loudly in approval.  
They freed the sweating horses from their yokes,  
and tied them to the chariots with reins. 720  
They brought fat sheep and oxen from the city  
quickly, and wine whose heart is sweet as honey,  
and bread and more provisions from the storerooms,  
and gathered ample wood, and breezes bore

549 the scent of burning fat into the sky.  
Hearts high, they sat in lines arranged for war  
all night and burned a multitude of fires,  
as when around a dazzling moon, bright stars  
shine in the sky when no wind moves the air—  
all the high lookout points and tall clifftops  
and valleys suddenly are visible—  
the vast expanse of upper air breaks open,  
and all the stars are seen—the shepherd's heart  
560 is glad—so many were the gleaming fires  
burned by the Trojans on the plain of Troy  
between the ships and streams of River Xanthus.  
A thousand fires were burning on the plain  
and by each fire sat fifty men, their faces  
lit by the gleam of burning wood. The horses  
stood by their chariots and chomped white barley  
and grain and waited for the goddess Dawn.

730

740

## BOOK 9



# The Embassy

The Trojans at their lookout points kept watch.  
The Greeks were seized by overwhelming panic,  
sister of icy fear. The finest fighters  
were struck by an unbearable despair,  
as when two winds stir up the fish-filled water,  
Zephyr and Boreas, who all at once  
appear from Thrace and blast the sea—black waves  
crest high and clash haphazardly, and pour  
masses of seaweed from the salty depths—  
so the Greeks' confidence was ripped apart.

10

Then Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
troubled by great anxiety, paced through  
the ranks of men and told the clear-voiced heralds  
to summon an assembly, not by shouting  
but calling each man quietly by name.  
He joined the work himself and walked among them.  
Deeply alarmed, they gathered and sat down,  
and Agamemnon stood to speak. He wept  
thick tears, like some black stream that pours dark water  
down a steep rock face where no goats can tread.

20

With deep groans he addressed the Greeks.

“My friends,  
Greek lords and captains! Zeus, the son of Cronus,  
has tied me to a terrible delusion.  
That ruthless god bowed down his head and promised  
20 that I would sack the well-built Trojan city  
and then sail home. But now he has devised  
a dreadful trick. He orders me to go  
back home to Argos in humiliation!  
I will have lost a monumental army.  
This must be what almighty Zeus has willed.  
He has decapitated many cities  
and will destroy yet more. He is the strongest.  
But come now, all of you, do as I say.  
We have to sail back to our native lands.  
We will not take the spacious streets of Troy.”

30

At this, they all fell silent. For a while,  
30 nobody spoke. The Greeks were devastated.  
Finally, Diomedes raised his voice.

“No, Agamemnon, you are talking nonsense,  
and I will be the first to challenge you  
in public for your folly, as is right.  
Do not get angry with me now, my lord.  
You started it, when you insulted me.  
You called me bad at fighting and a coward  
among the Greeks, both young and old. They saw it.  
But crooked Zeus gave you just half a blessing.  
You got the special status of the scepter,  
but not the greatest power, which is courage.  
40 Fool, do you really think the sons of Greece  
are craven cowards, as you say they are?  
If you are eager to go home, then go!  
Your path lies open. You have many ships  
beached by the sea, brought out here from Mycenae.  
We other long-haired warriors will stay

40

50

until we have annihilated Troy.  
Or let the others sail to their own homelands,  
and we two, Sthenelus and I, will fight  
until we find the final end of Troy.  
You see, a god accompanied us here.”

50 This speech from Diomedes, lord of horses, 60  
amazed the Greeks. They shouted their assent.  
Then horse-lord Nestor stood and spoke to him.

“Young son of Tydeus, you have great strength  
in war, and you are also good in council,  
the very best of all the boys your age.  
No Greek will criticize this speech of yours  
or make you take it back. But you have not  
arrived at everything that should be said.  
If you were one of my sons, you would be  
the youngest of them all. But even so, 70  
you have provided excellent advice  
to all the leaders of the Greeks. You spoke  
60 extremely sensibly. But I am older.  
I shall confirm and reassert your claims.  
No one will disrespect my words, not even  
powerful Agamemnon. Any man  
who wants cold conflict among his own people  
is outcast from our tribe, our hearth, our laws.  
But now we must submit to night and darkness  
and make the dinner ready. Guards must lie 80  
along the ditch we dug beside the wall.  
For the young warriors, these are my orders.  
But Agamemnon, you should take the lead.  
You are the most important of the leaders.  
70 It is appropriate for you to host  
the top-ranked men and hold a banquet for us.  
Our tents are full of wine, brought here from Thrace  
by ships that daily cross the broad-backed sea.  
The task of hospitality belongs  
to you, because you rule so many people. 90  
When many have assembled, you must follow

whoever offers us the best advice.  
We are in urgent need of wise suggestions,  
because the enemy are near our ships.  
They are igniting watch fires all around us.  
Who could be happy in our situation?  
This night will save our army or destroy it.”

80 The people listened and obeyed. The guards  
armed and dashed off, led by a son of Nestor,  
a shepherd of the troops named Thrasymedes, 100  
and by Ascalaphus and Ialmenus,  
both sons of Ares, and Meriones,  
and fine Deipyrus, Aphareus,  
and Lycomedes, godlike son of Creon.  
These seven leaders of the watch each led  
a hundred warriors with spears in hand.  
They reached the space between the ditch and wall,  
and lit their fires, and each man cooked his dinner.  
And Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
summoned the senior leaders to a meeting 110  
90 inside his tent and laid a feast before them.  
They reached their hands to take the food provided  
and when their hunger and their thirst were sated  
old Nestor, whose ideas had seemed to them  
best in the past, began to weave his thoughts.  
He made his speech with every good intention.

“Most honorable son of Atreus,  
Lord Agamemnon, I will start and end  
with you, because you rule so many people,  
and Zeus has granted you the laws and scepter 120  
to legislate for them. So you especially  
100 must speak and listen and fulfill the plans  
of others when they share a good idea.  
The right is yours because you are the ruler.  
So I shall tell you what seems best to me,  
and no one will improve upon my views.  
This is what I have thought from the beginning,  
and what I still believe—what I thought when

you went, my lord, to take away the woman,  
Briseis, from Achilles in his tent,  
and he was furious. And none of us  
agreed with what you did. I spoke against it,  
firmly and frequently. But you gave in  
to your own arrogance, and disrespected  
a great man whom the deathless gods have honored.  
You took and kept his trophy for yourself.  
Now we must work out how to make amends  
with gifts and gentle words to win him round.”

130

Then Agamemnon, lord of men, replied,  
“Old sir, you are not wrong when you describe  
all my delusional behavior.

140

I was deluded. I do not deny it.

A man whom Zeus particularly loves  
is worth a multitude of other men.

So now the god has glorified that man,  
by ruining the army of the Greeks.

I know I was deluded when I yielded  
to my destructive impulse. So I want  
to make amends with lavish gifts of friendship.

I shall enumerate for all of you

my generous and splendid gifts to him.

Seven new tripods and ten pounds of gold,  
twenty bright cauldrons and twelve racehorses,  
strong stallions whose speed has won great prizes.

Their winnings by themselves would make a man  
wealthy in treasure, rich in glorious gold.

And I will also give him seven women,  
skillful in all the crafts, brought here from Lesbos  
when he himself destroyed their well-built home.

I chose them as my trophies from the spoils

because they conquered every other woman  
in beauty. With these others, I will give  
the one I took away from him—Briseis.

And I shall swear a mighty oath, declaring  
that I have never gone to bed with her  
as is the normal way for men and women.

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160



I shall give him all this immediately,  
and in the future, if the gods allow us  
to sack and spoil the mighty town of Priam,  
when we Greek warriors divide the loot,  
let him pile high his ship with gold and bronze,  
then choose another twenty Trojan women,  
whichever are the very most attractive,  
only surpassed in looks by Argive Helen.

170

140 And if we ever reach the land of Argos,  
the teat that feeds the earth, he shall become  
my son-in-law and I will cherish him,  
just as I do my own dear son Orestes,  
raised up in luxury and dearly loved.

I also have three daughters in my house,  
inside my well-built hall— Chrysothemis,  
Iphianassa, and Laodice.

180

Let him choose one of them and take her back  
without a bride-price to his father's house.

And I will give him lavish wedding gifts,  
such as no father ever gave his daughter.

And I shall give him seven well-built towns—

150 Cardamyle, Enope, grassy Hire,  
the pasturelands of Anthea and sacred  
Pherae and Pegasus, where vines grow thick,  
and beautiful Aepea. All these lands  
are by the sea and close to sandy Pylos.

190

The people there are rich in sheep and cattle.

They will make offerings and honor him  
as if he were a god. Beneath his scepter  
they will fulfill his laws and pay rich dues.

And I shall give him this if he gives up  
his anger. Let him bow down and submit.

Hades will not submit or be persuaded,  
and therefore Hades is the god most hated  
by mortals. Let Achilles bow before me,

200

160 because I have more power as a leader,  
and I am proud to be the older man.”

Gerenian Nestor, horse-lord, answered him,

“Most honorable son of Atreus,  
great Agamemnon, you are offering  
gifts that Achilles, son of Peleus,  
ought not to scorn. Come on then, let us choose  
a group of men to hurry to his tent.

The man I shall select must follow orders.

210

Let Phoenix be their leader first of all—  
he is well loved by Zeus—and mighty Ajax,  
and great Odysseus. With them should go

170 their men, Eurybates and Odius.

Bring water for our hands and give the order  
for holy silence so that we can pray  
to Zeus, the son of Cronus, to have mercy.”

His words pleased all of them. At once the stewards  
poured water on their hands and boys filled full  
the bowls with drink and poured the first libations  
in every cup. They made their offerings.

220

When they had drunk as much as they desired,  
the group of emissaries left the tent  
of Agamemnon, son of Atreus.

Gerenian Nestor scrutinized their faces,  
looking especially at Odysseus,  
and gave them many pieces of advice  
for how to sway the son of Peleus.

180

They walked beside the loud-resounding sea  
along the shore, with many fervent prayers  
to great Poseidon, who holds up the earth,  
the lord of earthquakes, that they might with ease  
persuade the haughty heart of great Achilles,  
grandson of Aeacus. When they had reached  
the area in which the Myrmidons

230

had beached their ships and pitched their tents, they found him  
cheering himself with music. He was playing  
a well-tuned lyre of ornate craftsmanship,  
whose bridge was silver, which he got as war loot  
when he destroyed the town of Eetion.

240

It brought him joy. He sang heroic stories  
of famous men. The only person with him,

190 Patroclus, faced him quietly and waited  
for him to cease his singing. Then the guests  
went in—godlike Odysseus went first—  
and stood in front of him. Amazed, Achilles  
leapt to his feet, his lyre still in his hand,  
and left the stool he had been sitting on.  
At the same time, Patroclus saw the men,  
and stood. Swift-footed Lord Achilles  
greeted them kindly, saying,

250

“Welcome, guests.  
You must have some great mission. You are friends,  
the ones I love the best of all the Greeks,  
although I am so furiously angry.”

200 With this, Achilles led them in and sat them  
on chairs with crimson throws and told Patroclus,  
who was beside him,

“Get a bigger bowl,  
son of Menoetius. Mix some stronger wine,  
and get them all some food. My dearest friends  
have come into my home.”

Patroclus heeded  
his dear companion, and Achilles put  
a mighty roasting tray upon the fire  
and in it set a plump goat’s back, a chine  
of mutton and a chine of fatty pork,  
shining with grease. Automedon held them steady  
and great Achilles carved the meat. He sliced it  
210 with care, then put the pieces on the skewers.  
Godlike Patroclus made the fire blaze high.  
Then, when the flame died down, he spread the ashes  
and set the spits on top, fixed on their props,  
and sprinkled holy salt upon the food.  
After he roasted and set out the meat  
on plates, Patroclus fetched the bread and put it

260

270

in pretty baskets on a little table.

Achilles served the meat and sat to face

godlike Odysseus, across from him

220 against the wall, and told his friend Patroclus  
to make the sacrifices to the gods.

Patroclus threw the offerings on the fire.

They reached their hands to take the food before them.

280

And when their hunger and their thirst were sated,

then Ajax gave a nod to Phoenix, but

Odysseus observed him doing it

and filled a cup of wine and raised a toast,  
saying,

“To you, Achilles! We enjoyed  
abundance at the banquet in the tent

of Agamemnon, son of Atreus,

and here with you. You laid a lavish spread.

But we did not come here with thoughts of dinner.

230 My lord, we see great danger. We are frightened.

290

Our ships may be destroyed—the odds are even—  
unless you dress yourself in will to fight.

The valiant Trojans and their famous allies

have pitched their tents beside our ships and wall.

Their base is bright with campfires and they think  
nothing can stop them. They will storm our ships!

Zeus, son of Cronus, gave them lucky omens.

He made bright lightning strike. And Hector now  
is full of confidence in his own strength.

He rages wildly, like a maniac.

300

He puts his trust in Zeus and pays no heed

to other gods or men. A rabid frenzy

240 consumes him. He is praying for bright dawn

to come as soon as possible. He swears

that he will slash the ships' high sterns and burn

our fleet with deadly fire, and we will panic

under the smoke, and he will kill us all.

I am extremely frightened that the gods

may make his threats come true. Perhaps it is

fated for us to die at Troy, so far

310

from Argive fields where horses feed. Get up!

It is not yet too late to change your mind  
and save the sons of Greece, who are in danger  
from the cacophonous onslaught of the Trojans.

One day you will experience the pain,

250 but there will be no cure for past mistakes.

While there is time, consider how to save  
the Greeks from ruin. Peleus, your father,  
advised you well, dear boy, when you were leaving  
Phthia with Agamemnon. He said this—

320

‘You will get strength from Hera and Athena,  
if they so wish, my child. But you must curb  
your arrogance, the pride that swells inside you.  
Better to have a heart that thinks of others.  
Hold back from conflicts that bring only trouble,  
so that the Greeks, both old and young, respect you.’

Your father gave you this advice, but you  
neglected it. Yet it is not too late.

260 Stop it. Release the rage that hurts your heart.

If you give up your anger, Agamemnon  
will give you all the gifts that you deserve.

330

Listen to me and I will list for you  
the things he promised in his tent to give you—  
seven new tripods and ten pounds of gold,  
twenty bright cauldrons and twelve racehorses,  
strong stallions whose speed has won great prizes.  
Their winnings by themselves would make a man  
wealthy in treasure, rich in glorious gold.

270 And he will also give you seven women,  
skillful in all the crafts, brought here from Lesbos  
when you yourself destroyed their well-built home.

340

He chose them as his trophies from the spoils  
because they conquered every other woman  
in beauty. With these others, he will give  
the one he took away from you—Briseis.  
And he will make a mighty oath and swear  
that he has never gone to bed with her  
as is the normal way for men and women.  
He will give you all this immediately,

and in the future, if the gods allow us  
 to sack and spoil the mighty town of Priam,  
 when we Greek warriors divide the loot,  
 you can pile high your ship with gold and bronze,  
 and you can go to him yourself and take  
 another twenty of the Trojan women,  
 whichever are the very most attractive—  
 only surpassed in looks by Argive Helen.  
 And if we ever reach the land of Argos,  
 the teat that feeds the earth, you will become  
 his son-in-law, and he will cherish you,  
 just as he does his own dear son Orestes,  
 raised up in luxury and dearly loved.  
 He also has three daughters in his house,  
 inside his well-built hall—Chrysothemis,  
 Iphianassa, and Laodice.  
 You can choose one of them and take her back  
 without a bride-price to your father's house.  
 And he will give you lavish wedding gifts,  
 such as no father ever gave his daughter.  
 And he will give you seven well-built cities,  
 Cardamyle, Enope, grassy Hire,  
 the pasturelands of Anthea and sacred  
 Pherae and Pegasus, where vines grow thick,  
 and beautiful Aepea. All these lands  
 are by the sea and close to sandy Pylos.  
 The people there are rich in sheep and cattle.  
 They will make offerings and honor you  
 as if you were a god. Beneath your scepter  
 they will fulfill your laws and pay rich dues.  
 He will do this for you, if you give up  
 your anger. If you feel too deep a loathing  
 for Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
 and for his gifts, at least you should have pity  
 on all the other people in the army.  
 The Greeks are desperate. If you do this,  
 they will adore you like a god. You will  
 gain huge renown. You can kill Hector now.  
 He has come very near the Greek encampment,

360

370

380

in a ferocious, homicidal frenzy.

He thinks no Greek who sailed to Troy can match him.”

390

Swift-footed Lord Achilles answered him,

“Son of Laertes, favorite of Zeus,

scheming Odysseus, I must speak out  
emphatically and unreservedly.

I must tell you exactly how I feel,

310 and what the future holds for us, or else  
the three of you will keep on sitting there  
and take turns chittering and clucking at me.

I hate like Hades’ gates the man who hides  
one thought inside his heart and says another.

400

So I will tell you what I think is best.

I do not think the son of Atreus

or any of the Greeks can change my mind,

because I got no thanks for all my labors,  
constantly battling the enemy.

A man who fights his hardest in the war  
gets just the same as one who stays behind.

Cowards and heroes have the same reward.

320 Do everything or nothing—death still comes.

I have endured great pain—I risked my life  
over and over in this endless war

410

but I got nothing for it. As a bird

brings little mouthfuls for her fledgling chicks

whenever she gets food and starves herself,

so I kept watch for many sleepless nights

and fought my way through many bloody days,

struggling with men to rob them of their women.

330 Near fertile Troy, I looted and destroyed  
twelve towns by ship, eleven more on foot.

From every one of them I seized a hoard

420

of marvelous treasure and I brought it all

back here and gave it all to Agamemnon,

the son of Atreus. He stayed behind,

beside his quick ships, taking everything.

He kept the most but shared a little out,

and handed trophies to the lords and leaders.

The others still have theirs but he took mine—  
just mine, from me, not anybody else's!

He has my woman, my own heart's desire.

Well, let him lie with her, let him enjoy her.

430

Why should the Greeks make war against the Trojans?

Why did he gather troops and bring us here?

Was it not to retrieve a woman, Helen?

340 Are they the only men who love their women,

those sons of Atreus? All good, fine men

love their own women and take care of them,

just as I loved that woman with my heart,

although she was a captive of my spear.

But now that he has robbed me of my trophy,

stolen my winnings from my grasp, and tricked me,

440

let him not try to sway me now. I know him.

He will not change my mind. Let him decide

along with you, Odysseus, and others,

how to protect the ships from deadly fire.

He certainly has worked quite hard without me.

He built a wall and dug a ditch around it,

350 so wide and deep, and fixed sharp stakes along it.

But even so, he cannot block the onslaught

of murderous Hector in his deadly strength.

When I was fighting alongside the Greeks,

450

Hector was never willing to incite

battle beyond the city wall. He ventured

just to the Scaean Gates, beside the oak tree.

One day when he was standing there to face me,

he scarcely got away from my fierce hands.

But now I do not wish to fight with Hector.

Tomorrow I will sacrifice to Zeus

and all the gods, and load my ships with goods,

and launch them on the sea. And if you wish,

if you have any interest in my actions,

460

early tomorrow morning you can watch

my ship set sail. My men will quickly row

360 my fleet across the fish-filled Hellespont.

And if the famous shaker of the earth,

Poseidon, grants fair sailing for my voyage,



on the third day I shall reach fertile Phthia.

I have great wealth there that I left behind  
when I came here and I will bring home more—  
red bronze and gold and women wearing sashes  
and hard gray iron, all my share of war loot.

470

But my own trophy, which he gave himself  
to me—he took it back from me again!

So he insulted me—that mighty leader,  
that son of Atreus, that Agamemnon.

370 Go tell him my whole answer. Let him hear it  
in public, so the other Greeks will also  
get angry with him, just in case he tries  
to trick another one of us in future.

He always dresses in his shamelessness.

He would not dare come look me in the eyes,  
the dog! I will not join his plans or actions.

480

He did me wrong. He cheated me. Enough!

Let him not trick me with his words again.

Be gone with him! Wise Zeus erased his wits.

I hate that man's gifts and I do not have  
even a scintilla of respect for him.

380 Not even if he gave ten times as much,  
or twenty times the wealth he now possesses,  
and even if he got yet more from somewhere—

the treasure that accrues to Orchomenus,

490

or all the riches of Egyptian Thebes,  
whose houses hold the richest stores, the city  
of seven gates, from each of which march forth  
twenty armed warriors with chariots!

Not even if his gifts to me could match  
the grains of dust and sand! Not even then  
would Agamemnon ever sway my heart,  
till he had paid me back for the abuse  
that caused my heart such pain. I will not marry  
the daughter of that son of Atreus,

500

390 that Agamemnon, even if her beauty  
rivals the golden grace of Aphrodite,  
and even if her skill in crafts could match  
gray-eyed Athena's. I would not take her.

He can pick someone else to marry her—  
someone more suitable, more like a king.  
And if the gods protect me and I reach  
my home, my father Peleus himself  
will find a wife for me. There is no shortage  
of women in the lands of Greece and Phthia—

510

daughters of leaders who protect their cities.  
I shall pick out whichever one I want  
to be my loving wife. My strong proud heart  
has often yearned to marry somebody  
at home in Phthia, as my bed partner,  
a proper wife, so that I can enjoy  
the legacy my father won for me.

400

To me, no wealth is worth a person's life.  
Not even all the treasure that they say  
the thriving town of Troy once held inside,  
in former days of peace, before we came—  
nor all the riches held in rocky Delphi,  
behind the doorstone of the archer god,  
Phoebus Apollo. You can raid fine cattle  
or well-fed sheep, and you can trade to get  
tripods and horses with bright golden manes.  
But human life does not come back again  
after it passes through the fence of teeth.

520

No trade or raiding can recover it.

My silver-footed goddess mother Thetis  
says that there are two ways my death may come.  
If I stay here and fight, besieging Troy,  
my chance of ever going home is lost,  
but I shall have a name that lasts forever.

410

530

Or if I go home to my own dear country,  
I lose my glory but I gain long life.

Death cannot run so fast to overtake me.

I would advise the rest of you as well  
to sail back home. You will not take tall Troy.

Far-seeing Zeus has stretched his hand across it.

540

The Trojan people have new confidence.

420

Go take my message to the Argive leaders.

Speak freely with the privilege of council,

so they devise a better strategy  
to save the hollow ships and all their crew.  
Their current plan, this embassy, has failed,  
because I am so furious, so wrathful.  
But Phoenix can remain and stay the night,  
and come with me tomorrow in my fleet  
back to our fatherland, if he so wishes.  
I will not take him there against his will.”

550

430 At this, they all kept quiet, flabbergasted  
by the intensity of his refusal.  
But finally the old horse driver Phoenix  
burst into tears because he was so frightened  
about the danger to the fleet. He said,

“Noble Achilles, if your mind is set  
on home and you have no desire at all  
to save the ships from devastating fire,  
because your heart is overwhelmed by rage,  
how could I let you leave me here alone,  
sweet child? Your father Peleus, the horseman,  
made me go with you on the day he sent you  
to Agamemnon from your home in Phthia  
when you were very young, still innocent  
of war and councils where men win acclaim.  
I was to teach you everything—to be  
an artful speaker and a man of action.  
So now, I love you, child, and I would never  
stay if you leave, not even if a god  
promised to scrape away my age and make me  
the strong young man I was when I first left  
Hellas, where women are most beautiful.

560

I ran away after I had a fight  
with Amyntor, the son of Ormenus,  
my father. He was furious with me  
about a woman with attractive braids,  
a prostitute my father fell in love with,  
and thereby brought dishonor to his wife,  
my mother, who implored me constantly,

570

450

580

grasping my knees, to take the prostitute  
into my bed before my father did,  
so she would find the older man disgusting.  
I did as she had asked. At once, my father  
suspected and invoked a dreadful curse.  
He called upon the horrifying Furies,  
and swore he would not let a son of mine  
sit on his lap. The gods fulfilled his threats—  
infernal Zeus and dread Persephone.

I almost drew my sharp bronze sword to kill him.

590

460 I wanted to. But some immortal stopped  
my anger, putting in my mind the thought  
of scandal and the judgment of the people,  
and all the criticism I would get  
if I were called among the men of Greece  
a father-killer. I paced round the house,  
and could no longer bear to stay cooped up  
at home with my infuriated father.

Kinsmen and cousins in our neighborhood  
begged me to stay there in his house. They butchered  
many fat sheep and ambling long-horned cattle.  
They singed the hides of many pigs and stretched  
the carcasses, that shone with fat, across  
the fire for cooking, sacred to Hephaestus.

600

They drank enormous quantities of wine  
from huge wine-jars belonging to my father.  
470 They spent nine nights with me and guarded me.

They took turns keeping watch and never let  
their fires go out—one on the portico  
that ran around the well-fenced outer courtyard,  
another on the porch, outside the doors  
leading to my room. On the tenth dark night,  
I broke my tight-shut bedroom doors and leapt  
over the courtyard wall, quite easily,  
in secret from the guards and women slaves.

610

I fled through Hellas, through the dancing-fields,  
and came to Phthia where the soil is rich,  
mother of sheep. I went to Peleus.

480 That leader welcomed me with care and kindness.

He loved me as a father loves his son,  
 his only son, full-grown, the heir to wealth.  
 He made me rich and put beneath my rule  
 a multitude—the Dolopes. I lived  
 out on the farthest boundary of Phthia.  
 And I made you the man you are, Achilles—  
 a godlike hero. I loved you so deeply.  
 You never wanted to go dine or feast  
 inside the hall with anybody else.

I put you on my lap and cut for you  
 mouthfuls of meat and gave you sips of wine.

630

490 You often got my chest and tunic wet  
 with spit-up wine—it hurt your childish stomach.

I worked and labored very hard for you  
 because I knew the gods would never give me  
 my own son. So, Achilles, godlike man,  
 I treated you as my own child, and hoped  
 one day you would protect me from the shame  
 of ruin in old age. Now please, Achilles,  
 subdue your pride. Your heart must not remain  
 forever unrelenting. Even gods

640

can change, although they are superior  
 in capability and strength and glory.  
 When humans overstep or fail somehow,  
 they pray forgiveness, and so turn aside  
 the anger of the gods with sacrifices  
 500 and fervent invocations and libations  
 and fat to make burnt offerings for them.

Prayers of Atonement are in truth the daughters  
 of mighty Zeus. With downcast eyes, all wrinkled,  
 with careful steps, they limp behind Delusion.

650

Delusion has great strength and sturdy feet,  
 and runs out far ahead of all of them,  
 and sprints across the world, and trips up humans.  
 The Prayers come after her and heal the damage.

When somebody responds to their approach  
 with reverence, they heed his supplications  
 and give him many blessings. But if someone  
 510 rejects these daughters of almighty Zeus

and stubbornly refuses them, they go  
to Zeus, the son of Cronus, and they pray  
that ruinous Delusion walk beside  
that man, until he trips and has to pay.

660

But you, Achilles, give these goddesses  
respect, which influences noble minds.

If Agamemnon had not sent these gifts  
and promised even more for you in future,  
and if he were still swollen up with rage,  
I would not order you to cast away  
your wrath, or come and save the Greeks, regardless  
of how much danger they were in. But now

670

he has already given many gifts  
and promised many more. And he selected  
the three of us, out of the whole Greek army,  
the best of men, the ones you love the most,  
to come to you and pray for your forgiveness.

520

You should not make our long walk out here futile,  
or disrespect our speeches. Earlier,  
you were not to be blamed for being angry.

We know the myths about the men of old  
swollen by anger. They accepted gifts  
and were persuadable. I call to mind  
how one old story went, and I will tell it  
to all of you, my friends. The Curetes  
were fighting with the brave Aetolians,  
during the deadly siege of Calydon.

680

530

The people of Aetolia defended  
the lovely city, and the Curetes  
were eager to destroy it in the war,  
with Ares' help. Then from her golden throne  
Artemis sent disaster to these men.

690

She was enraged because King Oeneus  
had failed to make a sacrifice to her  
of first fruits from the high ground of his orchard.  
The other gods had feasts of hecatombs,  
but Artemis, the daughter of great Zeus,  
was left without a sacrifice. Perhaps  
he just forgot or failed to understand.

His mind was seized by ruinous delusion.  
Angry, the huntress who delights in arrows,  
the child of Zeus, roused up a fierce wild boar  
with silver tusks, who did as boars will do.

700

540 He caused enormous damage in the orchard  
of Oeneus. He ripped the towering trees  
out by the roots and hurled them to the ground,  
along with all their branches, fruits, and blossoms.  
But Meleager, son of Oeneus,  
killed him. From many towns he gathered hunters  
and hounds. They needed numerous attackers,  
because the boar was huge and had already  
laid many people on their funeral pyres.

710

Then Artemis created a commotion.  
The Curetes and proud Aetolians  
shouted and yelled as everyone competed  
to get the boar's head and his shaggy hide.

550 While Meleager, loved by Ares, fought,  
the war went badly for the Curetes,  
and they could not remain outside the wall,  
although they were so very numerous.

Then Meleager felt the touch of anger  
that swells inside the hearts of many men,  
even the wisest. He was furious  
at heart with Althea, his loving mother.

720

He lay with Cleopatra, child of Idas,  
the strongest man of any in those times,  
and of Marpessa, daughter of Evenus.

560 Idas took up his bow against Apollo  
to save Marpessa with the pretty ankles.

And after that abduction, Cleopatra  
was nicknamed Kingfisher inside her house  
by both her father and the queen her mother,  
because, when she was kidnapped by Apollo,  
Marpessa suffered terribly and wailed  
just like a kingfisher—the halcyon.

730

Now Meleager lay with Cleopatra,  
fostering all the rage that hurt his heart,  
because his mother laid on him such curses.

Distraught about the killing of her brother,  
over and over she implored the gods  
and pounded on the earth that feeds us all,  
invoking dread Persephone and Hades.

740

570 Her dress was soaked with tears. She sat hunched over  
and called upon the gods to kill her son.

The pitiless Fury who has feet of mist  
heard her and rose up out of Erebus.

At once, the army of besiegers raised  
a din and clamor, battering the walls.

Inside the city the Aetolian leaders  
begged Meleager to go out and save them.

They sent the finest priests to him and promised  
a great reward. They said he could select  
the richest area of Calydon

750

580 and take a fine estate of fifty acres—  
half vineyard and the other half cut bare  
for arable. Old Oeneus the horseman  
stood on the threshold of his high-roofed home  
and knelt and shook the tightly fitted doors  
and desperately beseeched his son to yield.

His sisters and the queen his mother also  
implored him, but he kept on saying no.

His very dearest and most loving friends  
pleaded with him, but they could not persuade  
his stubborn spirit till his own bedroom  
was buffeted with blows. The Curetes

760

burst through the city walls and started burning  
the mighty city. Agonized, his wife  
590 begged Meleager to return to war,  
and told him all the horrors that afflict  
people whose town is sacked—the men are killed,  
the city burned, reduced to dust, the children  
and women in their beautiful long dresses  
are dragged away and claimed by other men.

770

When Meleager heard his wife describe  
these horrors, he was stirred, got up to go,  
and put his glittering arms and armor on,  
and yielded to his heart and saved his people,



rescuing the Aetolians from ruin.

They did not give him all those lovely gifts,  
but he still saved the city anyway.

600 So you must change your mind. You must not let  
a spirit turn you in the wrong direction.

780

Please reconsider! It will be much harder  
to save the ships once they are set alight.

Act, while the gifts are here and while the Greeks  
will honor you as if you were a god.

If you return without the gifts to war  
where men are killed, you will not have such glory,  
though you will struggle just as hard in battle.”

Swift-footed Lord Achilles said, “Sweet Papa,  
Phoenix, my lord, I have no need at all  
of payment to restore my damaged honor.

790

Zeus has already honored me, I think,  
allotting me a status that is mine  
as long as I have breath inside my chest,  
as long as there is vigor in my limbs,  
610 while I remain beside these curving ships.

But I will tell you something else. Take notice.

Do not confuse me with your tears and grief,  
in an attempt to help Lord Agamemnon.

You must not be his friend, or I will be  
your enemy, although I love you now.

800

Join me in hurting anyone who hurts me.

That is the proper way, and you will have  
half of my royal strength and half my glory.

These other men can take the message back.

You stay and sleep here on a good soft bed.

At dawn, we will decide if we should go  
back to our homeland or remain at Troy.”

620 With this, Achilles nodded to Patroclus,  
using his brows to signal silently  
that he should spread thick blankets on a bed  
for Phoenix, so the other men would hurry  
to leave the tent and go away again.

810

And godlike Ajax, son of Telamon,  
said,

“Favorite of Zeus, Odysseus,  
son of Laertes, clever strategist,  
come, let us go. We cannot, I believe,  
fulfill the purpose of our journey here.  
So we must hurry back and tell the Greeks  
the bad news. They are waiting for us now.  
Cruel Achilles has made his proud heart

820

630

ferocious. He refuses to change course  
or pay attention to his friends’ devotion,  
although we loved and honored him so much  
all through the Greek encampment by the ships,  
above all others. But he has no pity.

People accept a compensation payment  
for a dead child or for a murdered brother.

Killers remain in the community,  
once they have paid a generous amount.

830

The brother or the father of the victim  
restrains his feelings and his stubborn outrage  
and takes the offered compensation payment.  
But as for you—the gods have made your pride  
dangerous and unending. So much passion  
over a woman, and just one at that!

We offered you another seven women,  
and many other treasures in addition.

So put a gentle spirit in your heart.

Respect our presence underneath your roof.

640

We came as emissaries from the Greeks  
and out of all the Greeks, we hope to be  
the ones you care about and love the most.”

840

Swift-footed Lord Achilles answered, “Ajax,  
god-blest commander, son of Telamon,  
your speech seems mostly reasonable to me.  
And yet my heart is swollen up with anger  
whenever I remember what he did—  
how Agamemnon, son of Atreus,

humiliated me among the Greeks,  
and treated me like someone with no honor,  
an outcast with no place to call his home.

850

650 But all of you, go back and take the message  
that I will not return to bloody war  
until the son of Priam, splendid Hector,  
has slaughtered many Greeks and reached this place—  
the Myrmidon encampment and our ships—  
and set the fleet alight. And I predict  
that Hector, eager as he is for battle,  
will stop at my black ship beside my tent.”

Then each man lifted his two-handled cup  
and poured libations, and the group set off  
back to their ships, led by Odysseus.

860

Patroclus told his comrades and the women  
to speedily prepare a thick soft bed  
for Phoenix. As he ordered them, the women  
660 laid out a bed with fleece and woolen blanket  
and finely woven linen sheet. Upon it,  
the old man lay and waited for bright Dawn.

And in a corner of the sturdy tent  
Achilles slept with pretty Diomede,  
whom he had taken prisoner on Lesbos—  
her father’s name was Phorbas. And Patroclus  
lay by Achilles on his other side,  
and well-dressed Iphis lay beside Patroclus—  
whom glorious Achilles seized for him  
from lofty Scyros, when he sacked the city  
of Enyeus.

870

When the others reached  
the camp of Agamemnon, all the Greeks  
670 stood up and raised their golden cups to greet them,  
then asked them questions, and the first to speak  
was Agamemnon, lord of men. He said,

880

“Tell me, Odysseus, great storyteller,

glory of Greece. Will that man save the ships  
from deadly fire? Or did he turn us down?  
Does anger still possess his haughty heart?"

Tenacious lord Odysseus replied,  
"Great Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
most highly honored lord of men—that man  
refuses to put out his blazing anger.  
He is more full of fury than before,

890

680 He ordered you to gather with the Greeks,  
and make your own plans by yourself, to save  
the ships and army of the Greeks. He threatened  
to drag his agile ships equipped with benches  
down to the sea as soon as dawn appears.  
He also said that he advises others  
to sail back home, because you will not reach  
your goal of taking Troy. That hope is gone.  
Far-seeing Zeus has stretched his hand across it.  
The Trojan people now feel confident.  
Those were his words. These men who went with me—  
Ajax and both the heralds, thoughtful men—  
are also here and can confirm my words.  
The old man, Phoenix, stayed to sleep with him  
690 as he requested, so that he can go  
with him tomorrow to their fatherland,  
if he so wishes, though he will not force him."

900

At this, they all kept quiet. They were startled  
by the intensity of his refusal.  
Frustrated, they stayed silent for a while.  
Then Diomedes, master of the war cry,  
said,

910

"Honorable son of Atreus,  
great Agamemnon, lord of men, you should not  
have begged Achilles or sent all those gifts.  
He was already egotistical.

700 Now you have made his arrogance even greater.  
Forget him now. We should stop worrying  
if he will stay or go. He will join battle  
whenever his own heart decides to do so,  
or when a god inspires him. Come on,  
let us all do as I suggest. Tonight,  
enjoy your food and wine before you sleep,  
to feed your stamina and fortitude.  
When lovely Dawn reveals her rosy fingers,  
hurry and call the men and chariots.  
Gather the troops to stand before the ships,  
and you yourself must fight on the front line.”

920

710 All of the lords agreed, and praised the words  
of horse-lord Diomedes. Then they poured  
libations and returned to their own tents.  
They rested there and took the gift of sleep.

930

## BOOK 10



### Espionage by Night

The finest fighters from the whole of Greece  
slept through the night beside the ships. Soft sleep  
bound all of them—except Lord Agamemnon,  
the son of Atreus, the people's shepherd.  
Sleep's sweetness could not hold him while his mind  
was troubled by so many cares and worries—  
as when the spouse of finely braided Hera  
flashes the lightning and creates a storm,  
torrential rain or hail or snowflakes scattered  
across the fields, or makes the mighty mouth  
of piercing war begin to open somewhere—  
so from the very bottom of his heart  
deep in his chest Lord Agamemnon groaned.  
His inmost spirit trembled. Every time  
he gazed towards the Trojan plain, he marveled  
at all the fires that burned in front of Troy,  
and at the sound of flutes and pipes and shouting.  
But when he turned towards the Greek armada,  
he ripped great clumps of hair out of his head.  
Heartsick, he moaned to Zeus who sits on high.

10

10

20

Then he decided it was best to go  
first, to the son of Neleus, Lord Nestor,  
to see if he could find a strategy  
20 to save the whole Greek army. He stood up,  
pulled on his tunic, tied his handsome sandals  
onto his well-oiled feet, and round his body  
he wrapped a full-length, tawny lion's pelt,  
skinned from a massive golden animal.  
And last, he took his spear. And Menelaus  
was also seized by shivering and fear, 30  
and sleep refused to settle on his eyelids.  
He was afraid that something terrible  
might happen to the Greeks who came to Troy  
for him, and crossed so vast a stretch of water,  
and started this aggressive war for him.  
So first he wrapped a spotted leopard skin  
30 across his broad back and picked up his helmet  
of bronze and set it on his head, then seized  
his spear in his firm grasp. He went to wake  
his brother, who was lord of all the Greeks, 40  
honored among the people like a god.  
And Menelaus found Lord Agamemnon  
beside his ship's prow, putting on his armor.  
His brother gladly greeted his arrival.  
First, Menelaus spoke.

“Tell me, dear brother,  
why are you putting on your armor now?  
Will you send one of our troops out to spy  
among the Trojans? I am very anxious  
that nobody will undertake this quest,  
40 to go alone through the immortal night 50  
to investigate our enemies. The spy  
would need to have extraordinary courage.”

Powerful Agamemnon answered him,  
“Lord Menelaus, favorite of Zeus,  
both of us need to find a strategy  
to guard and save the Greek ships, now that Zeus

has changed his mind. He pays attention now  
to Hector's sacrifices more than ours.

I never saw or heard of any man  
achieving so much on a single day  
all by himself as Hector did. Zeus loves him,  
and he accomplished more against the Greeks  
than any cherished son of god or goddess  
has ever done. He did such deeds as surely  
will do us damage far into the future,  
causing such devastation to our army.

But hurry, run along beside the ships  
and summon Idomeneus and Ajax,  
and meanwhile, I shall go to noble Nestor,  
wake him and urge him to go supervise  
the watchmen in their sacred task. They will  
listen to him, the father of their leader.  
Nestor's son, Thrasymedes, leads the guards,  
as does Meriones, the dear companion  
of Idomeneus. We gave those two  
the most important task."

Then Menelaus,  
the master of the war cry, answered him,  
"Tell me exactly what I need to do.  
Should I stay there with them until you come,  
or give them their instructions, then run back?"

Lord Agamemnon answered him, "Stay there,  
in case we miss each other if we move.  
There are so many routes across the camp.  
And everywhere you go, tell everyone  
that they must stay awake. Speak loud and clear,  
and call to each man by his father's name,  
and show them all respect. Do not be proud.  
The two of us must do this work ourselves.  
Zeus laid this heavy suffering upon us  
from birth."



With these instructions, Agamemnon  
dismissed his brother. Then he went to Nestor,  
the shepherd of the people, whom he found  
beside his black ship just outside his tent,  
upon a soft bed, and beside him lay  
his finely decorated arms—a shield,  
a glittering helmet, and two spears, and also  
the dazzling metal belt that old Lord Nestor  
donned when he armed himself for deadly war.  
He led the troops to battle, still unbowed  
by harsh old age. Now propped up on one elbow,  
he raised his head and spoke to Agamemnon,  
the son of Atreus and asked him this.

100

“Who are you? Who goes there beside the ships,  
crossing the camp alone in pitch-black night,  
when other mortals are asleep? Are you  
searching for some lost mule or lost companion?  
Speak! Do not creep towards me silently!  
What do you need?”

Lord Agamemnon answered,

“Nestor, great glory of the Greeks, fine son  
of Neleus, the man you see before you  
is Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
on whom Zeus has imposed unending trouble,  
and harder work than any other man’s,  
which lasts as long as warm breath fills my lungs  
and fires my limbs with life. I came out here  
because sweet sleep refused to rest my eyes.  
The war endangering the Greeks concerns me—  
in fact, it terrifies me, and I cannot  
stay calm. My heart is agitated, jumping  
as if to leave my body, and my limbs  
tremble. But if you have the will to act,  
as sleep has also failed to visit you,  
come, let us go and check, in case the guards,  
worn out by their hard work and weariness,  
have gone to sleep, entirely forgetting

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120

100 to keep the watch. The enemy is near.  
We know no way to block a night attack.”

Gerenian Nestor, horse-lord, answered him,  
“Most noble son of Atreus, commander,  
Lord Agamemnon, I am sure that Zeus, 130  
the god of strategy, will not fulfill  
all Hector’s current hopes and dreams. In fact,  
I think he will endure far greater dangers  
than those we face, if great Achilles turns  
from bitter anger. I will come with you,  
and we must also wake up several others—  
the son of Tydeus, brave Diomedes,  
110 Odysseus, swift Ajax, and the brave  
Meges, the son of Phyleus. Now someone  
should go and summon them, and godlike Ajax, 140  
and Idomeneus. Their ships are farthest  
away from here. But I will not refrain  
from criticism, though you may resent it,  
of your own brother, whom we all respect  
and love. Lord Menelaus is asleep!  
He made you do this work all by yourself.  
He should be active with the warriors,  
begging them all to help. Our situation  
cannot be tolerated any longer.”

Then Agamemnon, lord of men, replied, 150  
120 “Sir, I have sometimes told you to reproach him.  
He often slacks off and refuses work,  
although he is not hesitant or stupid.  
He waits for me to take initiative.  
But this time, he was up before I was.  
He came to me and I sent him to summon  
the men you named. Come on then! We shall find them  
among the guards who watch the gates. I told them  
to gather there.”

Gerenian horse-lord Nestor

answered, "No Greek will disobey his orders,  
 or carp at him for rousing them like this."  
 So speaking, Nestor pulled his tunic on,  
 and tied fine sandals on his well-oiled feet,  
 and pinned his large red cloak of shaggy wool  
 around himself. He took his warlike spear,  
 tipped with sharp bronze, and went towards the ships  
 to meet the Greeks, who wore shirts forged of bronze.  
 Gerenian Nestor, horse-lord, first aroused  
 Odysseus, who matched great Zeus in cunning.  
 The rush of Nestor's voice broke through his sleep  
 into his consciousness. He left his tent  
 and spoke to them.

"Why have you come like this,  
 wandering alone through the uncanny night  
 across the army camp beside the ships?  
 What is the crisis?"

And Gerenian Nestor,  
 the horse-lord, answered him, "Odysseus,  
 son of Laertes, favored under Zeus,  
 master of strategy, do not reproach us.  
 The Greeks are in great danger. Come with me,  
 let us wake someone else to help decide  
 whether we need to flee, or stay and fight."

At this, intelligent Odysseus  
 went in and set his decorated shield  
 over his shoulders and with them went searching  
 for Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
 whom they discovered outside of his tent,  
 his weapons with him, while his comrades slept  
 around him with their heads upon their shields.  
 Their spears stood upright, shafts stuck in the ground,  
 and from afar, the bronze shone bright as lightning  
 sent by the father, Zeus. Lord Diomedes  
 slept on an oxhide spread beneath his body,

a brightly colored rug beneath his head.  
Gerenian Nestor, horse-lord, stood beside him,  
and woke him with a kick and scolded him  
to get him up.

“Wake up now, Diomedes!  
Why are you fast asleep the whole night long?  
Do you not understand? The Trojans sit  
on high ground in the plain, beside our ships!  
Only a narrow strip of land protects us.”

200

At these words, Diomedes woke up quickly,  
jumped up, and let his words take wing. “Old man,  
you are so tough! You never take a break.  
Are there no younger men among the Greeks  
who could rush round and wake up all the leaders?  
Old man, you are unstoppable!”

At this,  
Gerenian Nestor, horse-lord, answered, “Yes,  
all this is very true and right, my friend.  
I do indeed have many splendid sons,  
and there are also many other fighters.  
One of them could go summon everyone.  
But this is an emergency for us.  
Our future rests upon a razor’s edge.  
We Greeks may face a total massacre,  
or else we may survive. Go on and rouse  
swift Ajax and the son of Phyleus,  
Meges—if you are feeling bad for me.  
You are a younger man.”

210

So Nestor spoke.  
Then Diomedes wrapped around his shoulders  
a massive golden full-length lion skin  
and took his spear and went to rouse the men  
and brought them back. The group of chieftains gathered  
among the guards, whose leaders were not sleeping.

220

They all sat wide awake and fully armed.  
As in a courtyard dogs keep fearful watch  
on sheep when they have heard a fierce wild beast  
approaching from the mountain through the woods—  
around the animal, the dogs and humans  
raise a commotion and they cannot sleep—  
so sweet sleep perished from the watchmen's eyelids  
as they kept guard that dreadful night. They turned  
constantly to the plain, to listen out  
in case they heard the Trojans coming nearer.  
190 Old Nestor was delighted when he saw them,  
encouraging them with these words on wings.

230

“Dear boys, keep up the watch as you are doing.  
No one must fall asleep, or they will bring  
joy to our enemies.”

With this, he leapt  
across the ditch. The other Greek commanders  
who had been summoned to the council meeting  
followed. Meriones and Nestor's son,  
Lord Thrasymedes, also came with them,  
because the lords had asked them to the meeting.  
They crossed the ditch and sat down in a space  
200 empty of fallen corpses, where great Hector  
had turned back from his slaughter of the Greeks  
when night had wrapped around him. There they sat  
and spoke together, and Gerenian Nestor,  
the horse-lord, first addressed them.

240

“Now, my friends,  
can none of you discover in your heart  
the courage to approach our noble foes  
and kill some Trojan straggler? Or maybe  
eavesdrop among them, and find out their plans,  
and learn if they will stay beside our ships,  
far from their city, or go back to it,  
210 now that they have defeated us? A spy

250

could learn these things, then come back safe to us.  
His glory would be great across the world  
among all people, and he would receive  
a great reward. Each captain of a ship  
would give him a black ewe, each with her lamb.  
There is no better honor. He would join  
our banquets and our feasts forever after.”

260

220 After he said this, all of them kept silent,  
till Diomedes, master of the war cry,  
spoke up.

“My strong proud heart and spirit, Nestor,  
urge me to go inside the Trojan camp.  
Our enemies are very near at hand.  
But if some other man would go with me,  
my confidence and mood would much improve.  
When two men walk together, one may see  
the way to profit from a situation  
before the other does. One man alone  
may think of something, but his mind moves slower.  
His powers of invention are too thin.”

270

230 As soon as Diomedes said these words,  
many of them were keen to go with him—  
the two named Ajax, followers of Ares,  
Meriones, the noble son of Nestor,  
and Menelaus, son of Atreus,  
the famous spearman, and Odysseus,  
the adventurer, who longed to infiltrate  
the throng of Trojan troops. His inmost heart  
was always full of daring. Agamemnon,  
the lord of men, spoke up.

280

“Now Diomedes,  
great son of Tydeus, my own dear friend,  
choose your companion from the volunteers,  
whomever you prefer from this large group.

Do not defer to social niceties  
and leave a better man behind, to choose  
a weak companion through embarrassment,  
because of who his father was, not even  
if you reject a man of higher status.”

290

240 So Agamemnon spoke. He was afraid  
for Menelaus with the auburn hair.  
Then Diomedes, master of the war cry,  
spoke up again.

“If all of you command me  
to choose my own companion for myself,  
how could I overlook Odysseus?  
Pallas Athena loves him, and he has  
such energy, virility, and drive  
in every undertaking. If I go  
with him, we could emerge from blazing fire  
and come home safe, thanks to his cleverness.”

300

250 Stalwart Odysseus said, “Diomedes,  
you must not praise or blame me overmuch.  
Everyone here already knows these things.  
But let us go. The night is almost over  
and dawn is near. The stars have shifted onward.  
Two-thirds of night have passed, one-third remains.”

310

With this, the two men put on fearsome armor.  
Staunch Thrasymedes gave to Diomedes  
a shield and sword with both sides very sharp,  
as he had left his own beside his ship,  
and placed a bull-hide helmet on his head,  
without a plume or boss, a so-called skullcap,  
used to protect the heads of strong young men.  
Meriones gave to Odysseus  
260 a bow, a quiver, and a sword, and placed  
a leather helmet on his head, stretched tight  
with many straps inside, and on the outside,

320

numerous white boar's teeth were set upon it,  
arranged with skill at careful intervals,  
and on the inside, it was lined with felt.  
Autolycus had robbed the sturdy house  
of Amyntor, the son of Ormenus,  
in Eleon, and from there he had stolen  
the helmet, which he gave Amphidamas,  
to take to Scandea in Cythera.

270 Amphidamas then gave it as a guest-gift  
to Molus, father of Meriones,  
and Molus gave it to his son to wear.  
And now Odysseus was wearing it.  
Once they had put their fearsome armor on,  
they left the other leaders and set off.  
Pallas Athena sent a dark night heron  
to fly close by them on the right-hand side.  
They could not see it as the night was black  
but they could hear its cry. Odysseus  
was glad to hear this bird and said,

330

280 "Athena,  
hear me, great child of aegis-bearing Zeus!  
You stand with me through every undertaking.  
Wherever I may go, you think of me.  
And now, Athena, more than ever, show me  
your love, and let us come back to the ships  
with glory, having done some mighty deed,  
causing great damage to the Trojan side."

340

Then Diomedes, master of the war cry,  
prayed also. "Great Athena, child of Zeus,  
relentless goddess, come along with me,  
as when you went with Tydeus, my father,  
to Thebes, when he went there as messenger.  
He left the Greeks all dressed in bronze beside  
the River Asopus and brought from them  
a friendly message to the Cadmians.  
And when he left the town of Thebes, my father  
managed to massacre a multitude,

350



290 thanks to your presence at his side, great goddess.  
So now stand with me and take care of me,  
and I will sacrifice for you a yearling,  
a heifer with a broad brow, still untamed,  
whom nobody has forced beneath the yoke.  
I will adorn her horns with gold for you,  
and kill her in your honor.”

360

So they prayed.  
Pallas Athena, child of mighty Zeus,  
heard them, and on they traveled, like two lions  
prowling through black night, through the ghastly gore,  
amid the corpses, weapons, and black blood.

300 And meanwhile, Hector would not let the Trojans  
sleep. He had called the leaders to a meeting—  
all of the councillors and lords of Troy.  
He summoned them and shared his strategy.

370

“Who wants to promise me to undertake  
this quest and gain himself a great reward?  
There will be ample recompense. I promise  
to give a chariot and a pair of horses  
with sturdy necks, the finest stallions  
that we have captured from the swift Greek ships,  
to any man who wins himself great glory  
by daring to approach the foreign fleet  
to find out if those swift ships are still guarded  
just as they were before, or if we have  
310 already gained so firm an upper hand  
that they intend to leave, no longer keeping  
their watch all night, because they are exhausted.”

380

So Hector spoke, but none among the Trojans  
answered his challenge, except one named Dolon,  
son of Eumedes, an anointed herald.  
Dolon was rich in gold and rich in bronze,  
ugly in body, though he had swift feet.

390

He was the only son among five sisters.  
He spoke to Hector and the Trojans.

320                               “Hector,  
my brave heart urges me to go approach  
the swift Greek ships and find out everything.  
But raise your staff and promise me the horses  
and chariot inlaid with bronze that bore  
the mighty son of Peleus, Achilles.  
Then I shall spy for you. I will not fail you.  
I will perform as you expect of me.  
I will go through the Greek camp till I reach  
the ship of Agamemnon. Probably  
that will be where the leaders are debating  
whether to stay and fight or sail away.”

400

At these words, Hector raised his staff up high  
and promised him,

330                               “May Zeus himself be witness,  
husband of Hera, god of rumbling thunder,  
no other Trojan man shall ride behind  
those horses. I assure you, you shall have  
the joy of them forever.”

                                    So spoke Hector,  
swearing an oath that would not be fulfilled,  
and sent him forth. Immediately, Dolon  
fastened his curved bow to his back and wrapped  
a gray wolfskin around himself and put  
a cap of polecat skin onto his head,  
and picked up his sharp javelin, then left  
the Trojan army, heading to the fleet.  
Never again would he return or bring  
news from the ships to Hector. Off he went,  
and left the crowd of horses and of men  
and traveled eagerly along the road.  
Odysseus, a favorite of Zeus,

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340 noticed him coming and told Diomedes,

“Look, Diomedes, somebody is coming  
from the direction of the Trojan camp.  
Maybe he wants to spy upon our fleet  
or strip the weapons from a corpse. Let us  
allow him first to get ahead of us  
a little way across the open plain.  
Then we can pounce on him and quickly seize him.  
And if he runs off up ahead of us,  
keep forcing him away from his own camp,  
towards our ships. Hold your spear aimed at him,  
and do not let him get back to the city.”

430

350 With this, the two lay down beside the road  
among the corpses. Unaware of them,  
Dolon ran past them. When he was ahead,  
the distance that a pair of mules can drag  
a jointed plow across deep fallow fields—  
she-mules go farther with a plow than oxen—  
the Greeks ran after him. He heard their footsteps,  
and stopped. He hoped inside his heart it was  
some Trojan comrades sent to him by Hector  
to tell him he should turn round and come back.  
But when they were a spear’s throw distant from him,  
or even less than that, he realized  
the men were enemies. He started running,  
fleeing as fast as his quick legs could go.  
They hurtled after him, as when two hounds,  
360 trained hunters with sharp teeth, pursue their prey,  
a baby deer or hare, relentlessly  
chasing across the woodland in pursuit,  
their victim squealing as he runs ahead—  
so Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
and great Odysseus, the city-sacker,  
cut Dolon from his people and pursued him  
relentlessly. And as he ran away  
towards the ships, he almost reached the guards,  
but then Athena strengthened Diomedes,

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so that no other bronze-clad Greek could win  
the right to boast that he struck Dolon first.

460

With spear in hand, the son of Tydeus,  
strong Diomedes, ran in front of Dolon  
and said,

370

“Stop there, or else my spear will strike you.  
You cannot run for long from cruel death.  
I tell you, I will be the one to kill you.”

With this, he threw his spear, but missed on purpose.  
The polished tip flew over Dolon’s shoulder,  
his right, and sunk into the earth. And Dolon  
stood terrified and trembling. His teeth  
chattered, and he was pale with fear. The Greeks,  
panting, ran up to him and seized his hands.  
Through tears, he begged them,

470

“Please take me alive!  
I will pay my own ransom. We have gold  
and bronze and well-wrought iron in my house,  
from which my father will bestow on you  
a lavish ransom payment, if he learns  
that I am still alive beside your ships.”

380

Cunning Odysseus said, “Do not worry.  
Set thoughts of death aside. But tell me this,  
and tell the truth in every point of detail.  
Why did you leave the Trojan camp alone  
and come towards our ships? Where are you going,  
in pitch-black night when other mortals sleep?  
Did you come here to strip the arms and armor  
from one of these dead bodies? Or did Hector  
send you to spy on what is going on  
beside the hollow ships? Or were you prompted  
by your own impulses?”

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And Dolon answered.

390 His body trembled as he told them, “Hector  
misled my mind with numerous delusions.  
He promised with a nod that he would give me  
the firm-hoofed stallions of great Achilles  
and his fine chariot inlaid with bronze,  
and told me to go through the swift black night,  
approach the enemy, and try to learn  
whether the fleet is guarded as before,  
or if the Greeks already want to flee,  
brought low by our hands, and so terribly  
exhausted, they refuse to keep the watch.”

490

Odysseus, the master strategist,  
smiled and said, “What large gifts you set your heart on!  
The horses of the brilliant Achilles,  
grandson of Aeacus! They are too hard  
to tame or drive for any mortal man  
except Achilles, and he is the son  
of an immortal goddess. Come on now,  
answer my questions truly and completely.  
Where did you leave the people’s shepherd, Hector?  
Where are his warlike weapons and his horses?  
What is the setup for the other Trojans?  
Where do they sleep? How are the watchmen posted?  
What are their plans? To stay there near our ships,  
far from the city, or go back to town,  
now that they have defeated the Greek fighters?”

Dolon, the son of rich Eumedes, answered,  
 “Certainly, I shall tell you everything.  
 Hector is strategizing with the elders  
 in council by the tomb of godlike Ilus,  
 far from the hubbub. As for what you ask  
 about the keeping of the watch, my lord,  
 no special guards are present in our camp.  
 The men whose hearth fires burn in Troy keep watch  
 and stay awake and keep each other up.  
 For them, the watch is a necessity.  
 But all our glorious allies are asleep.

They leave it to the Trojans to stand guard.  
Their wives and children do not live near here.”

Odysseus the strategist responded,  
“And do the allies sleep among the Trojans,  
or separately? Tell me and let me know.”

530

430 Dolon, the son of rich Eumedes, answered,  
“I shall explain it all to you in detail.  
Towards the sea, these allies are encamped—  
Paeonians who carry curving bows,  
Carians, Leleges, godlike Pelasgians,  
and the Caucones. Towards Thymbre lie  
Lycians, fine Mysians, Phrygians with warhorses  
and the Maeonians, great charioteers.  
But why exactly do you ask me this?  
If you two really want to penetrate  
the Trojan camp, the Thracians are most distant  
from everybody else. They just arrived.  
Their leader is the son of Eion, Rhesus.  
He has the biggest, finest stallions  
that I have ever seen. Their coats are whiter  
than snow, and they can run as fast as wind.  
His chariot is set with gold and silver,  
and he has massive weapons made of gold,  
440 astonishing to see. He brought them here.  
They do not seem like weapons for a mortal,  
but such as the immortal gods would carry.  
Now please escort me to your nimble ships,  
or tie me up with tight and cruel bonds  
and leave me here alive, while you go there  
and find out if I told the truth or not.”

540

550

But mighty Diomedes scowled at him,  
and told him, “Dolon, you must clear your mind  
of any thought that you might get away,  
although you gave us useful information.  
You see, you came into our hands already.

560

450 So if we ransom you or let you go,  
you might come back to spy on the Greek ships  
or fight against us, whereas if my hands  
obliterate you now, and you are dead,  
you cannot be a bother to the Greeks  
ever again.”

At these words, Dolon tried  
to supplicate. He reached to grasp his chin.  
But Diomedes instantly attacked.  
He drew his sword and stabbed through Dolon’s neck  
and sliced both tendons. Dolon’s head, still speaking, 570  
rolled in the dust. And from his skull the Greeks  
pulled off the polecat cap. They also took  
his wolfskin cloak, long spear, and curving bow.  
460 Then Lord Odysseus held high these things  
to great Athena who delights in spoils.

“Goddess, enjoy these gifts. We dedicate them  
to you, before all other goddesses  
on Mount Olympus. And now send us onward  
to where the Thracians sleep and keep their horses.”

With this, he raised the spoils and set them down 580  
under a tamarisk. He gathered reeds  
and healthy shoots of tamarisk and set them  
to mark the spot, so they could find the spoils  
when they came back again through swift black night.  
Then on they went, through weapons and black blood,  
470 and soon they reached their goal—the Thracian camp.  
The men were sleeping, totally exhausted.  
The splendid weapons lay beside the sleepers,  
set tidily in three rows on the ground.  
Each fighter had his chariot beside him, 590  
and pair of horses. In the middle, Rhesus  
slept, with his fine quick horses at his side,  
tied by the reins onto the chariot rim.  
Odysseus was first to notice him,

and said to his companion,

“Diomedes,  
that is the man, those are the horses, look,  
described by Dolon right before we killed him.  
Come on now, show how strong and fierce you are!  
You must not stand there idle, in full armor.  
Untie the horses! Or else kill the men,  
and let me get the horses.”

480

600

So he spoke.

And then into the heart of Diomedes  
bright-eyed Athena breathed fierce fighting spirit.  
Methodically he massacred the men,  
and as his sword plunged into them, they screamed  
horribly, and the ground was red with blood.  
As when the herdsman is away, a lion  
leaps to attack a flock of sheep or goats,  
and pounces on them with intent to kill,  
so Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
slaughtered the Thracians and killed twelve of them.  
Canny Odysseus stood just behind him,  
and every time the son of Tydeus  
approached a man and killed him with his sword,  
Odysseus would grab the victim's foot  
and drag him to the side, because he wanted  
to make sure that the splendid long-maned horses  
would pass through easily and not be spooked  
by stepping on the corpses of the dead.  
They were not yet accustomed to dead bodies.  
Then Diomedes reached his thirteenth victim,  
the king, who gasped—that night he had bad dreams,  
of Diomedes standing at his head,  
through great Athena's cunning strategies.  
And Diomedes took his dear sweet life.  
Then staunch Odysseus released the horses,  
fastened their reins together, and then drove them  
out through the throng. He lashed them with his bow—  
he had not thought to take the shining whip

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500



out of the decorated chariot.

630

He hissed to Diomedes as a signal.

But Diomedes stayed and wondered how  
to keep on hunting, like a dog. Should he  
drag off the chariot by the pole or lift it  
and seize the splendid weapons it contained?  
Or take away the lives of yet more Thracians?  
As he was wondering all this in his heart,  
Athena stood by him and told him this,

510 “Think of your journey home now, Diomedes,  
back to the hollow ships. You must be careful  
in case you have to run away from someone.  
Another god might wake the Trojans up.”

640

The goddess spoke. He recognized her voice,  
and quickly mounted, and Odysseus  
struck at the horses with his bow. They flew  
back to the swift Greek ships. Meanwhile, Apollo,  
god of the silver bow, had kept close watch,  
and saw Athena follow Diomedes.

Enraged at her, he swooped and joined the throng  
of Trojans and woke up a Thracian leader,  
the noble cousin of the dead King Rhesus,  
Hippocoon, who woke and saw the place  
520 empty, where all the horses had been standing,  
and saw the men convulsing in their death throes,  
horribly massacred. He groaned in grief  
and called the name of his dear comrade, Rhesus.  
The Trojans started panicking and screaming.

650

All of them hurried to the place of slaughter  
and witnessed the abominations done  
by those two men before they headed back  
towards their hollow ships. And when the Greeks  
came to the spot where they killed Hector's spy,  
Odysseus, whom Zeus loved, held the horses,  
while Diomedes jumped down to the ground,  
picked up the spoils, all smeared with blood and gore,  
and passed them to Odysseus, and then

660

530 mounted again. He whipped the horses on,  
and eagerly they galloped to the ships,  
because that was the way they wished to go.  
Nestor was first to hear their clattering hooves,  
and said,

670

“My friends, Greek leaders and commanders,  
should I conceal the truth? My spirit prompts me  
to tell you that my ears can hear the sound  
of noisy clattering hooves from galloping horses.  
I hope Odysseus and Diomedes,  
the strong young warrior, have driven off  
some sturdy horses from the Trojan camp  
and they are galloping back here with them.  
And yet my heart is terribly afraid  
that those fine Greeks may have been hurt somehow,  
amid the throng of Trojans.”

680

540 At that moment,  
as Nestor was still speaking, they arrived,  
and jumped down from the horses. Overjoyed,  
the others grasped their hands and welcomed them.  
The first to speak, Gerenian horse-lord Nestor,  
said,

“Glory of the Greeks, Odysseus,  
great master storyteller, tell me  
how did you get these horses? Did you go  
inside the Trojan camp? Or did some god  
meet you and give them? They are quite uncanny—  
as dazzling as the sun’s rays. I am often  
among the Trojans. I do not remain  
beside the ships, though I am old in war.  
550 But I have never seen such steeds as these.  
I think some god met you and gave them to you.  
Cloud-gathering Zeus loves both of you, as does  
the child of Zeus who bears the goatskin aegis,  
bright-eyed Athena.”

690

But Odysseus,  
the cunning master strategist, replied,  
“Nestor, great glory of the Greeks, fine son  
of Neleus, if any god desired,  
they could have given even better horses,  
because the gods are far more powerful.

700

These horses, old sir, which you ask about,  
are Thracian. They have just arrived at Troy.  
And noble Diomedes killed their master,  
and twelve of his companions, all the best ones.  
Beside the ships we also killed a spy,  
our thirteenth victim. Hector and the Trojans  
had sent him to investigate our camp.”

710

With this, Odysseus triumphantly  
herded the horses on their sturdy hooves  
over the trench, and happily the others  
went with him. When they reached the well-built tent  
of Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
they tied the horses with the pliant reins  
beside the manger where the swift-hoofed horses  
of Diomedes stood, already eating  
honey-sweet wheat. And then Odysseus  
left Dolon’s bloody armor on the ship’s stern  
until they sacrificed to great Athena.

720

Both waded in the sea and washed away  
the sweat that drenched their ankles, thighs, and necks.  
After the waves had washed off all the sweat  
and cleaned their skin and cooled and calmed their hearts,  
they climbed into well-polished wooden tubs  
and washed and rubbed themselves with olive oil.  
Then both sat down and ate their meal, and drew  
honey-sweet wine out of the well-filled bowl  
to pour as a libation for Athena.

730

## BOOK 11



## Wounds

Then Dawn arose from bed beside Tithonus  
to bring new light to deathless gods and mortals,  
and Zeus sent Conflict to the swift Greek ships—  
a cruel goddess. In her hands she held  
the sign of war. She took her stance atop  
the fat black ship of Lord Odysseus  
that lay right at the center of the line,  
so that a shout could reach to both far ends—  
in one direction, to the tents of Ajax,  
the son of Telamon, and in the other,  
to where Achilles slept. Those two had moored  
their steady ships out on the farthest ends,  
trusting their courage and their mighty hands.  
As she stood there, the goddess gave a shriek,  
piercing and terrible and high. She struck  
each Greek heart with the strength and will to fight  
unceasingly. Now war to them became  
sweeter than sailing in their hollow ships  
home to the land they loved. Then Agamemnon,  
the son of Atreus, addressed the Greeks,

10

10

20

shouting that all of them must arm themselves.

And he himself put on his shining bronze.

He strapped fine greaves around his lower legs,  
fitted with silver shin-guards. Next, he fastened  
onto his chest the corselet that Cinyres

20 had given him to seal their bond of friendship  
when the important news had come to Cyprus—  
that Greeks were sailing in their ships to Troy.

Cinyres gave this gift to Agamemnon,  
the leader, in the hope of winning favor.

30

It had ten stripes of dark blue-black enamel,  
and twelve of gold and twenty made of tin.

And three dark snakes coiled up towards the neck  
on either side, like rainbows, which the son  
of Cronus sets in clouds as signs for humans.

30 Across his shoulders, Agamemnon strapped  
his sword, all shimmering with golden studs,  
held in a silver scabbard, which was set  
with golden rings. Then he picked up his shield,  
a splendid, deadly shield, strong on both sides,  
adorned with many splendid decorations.

40

Around it ran ten circles made of bronze,  
and it had ten white bosses made of tin,  
and one of blue enamel at the center.

The middle garland was a glaring Gorgon,  
whose gaze was terrifying, and around her,  
Panic and Fear. The strap was made of silver,

40 and round it coiled a blue snake with three faces,  
each turning different ways, grown from one neck.

Then Agamemnon put onto his head

50

his leather helmet, which had two bronze plates,  
four bosses, and a horsehair crest. The plume  
nodded ferociously right at the top.

Last, he picked up two warlike sharp spears, tipped  
with bronze, whose gleam shone far into the sky.

Then Hera and Athena made it thunder  
to glorify the ruler of Mycenae,  
a city rich in gold. And each Greek leader  
ordered his charioteer to halt the horses

there by the ditch, lined up in good formation,  
 while they themselves on foot, arrayed in armor,  
 plunged through the trench, and in the early light  
 deafening shouts arose as they ran forward.

50

They reached the other side in good formation,  
 earlier than the charioteers and horses,  
 who came a little way behind. Then Zeus,  
 the son of Cronus, roused a dreadful din.  
 From the high heaven he sent down thick drops  
 of gushing blood, because it was his will  
 to send so many living men to Hades.

70

The Trojans faced the Greeks on higher ground,  
 led by great Hector, fine Polydamas,  
 Aeneas, who was honored by the Trojans  
 as if he were a god among the people,  
 and Lord Antenor's three sons—Polybus,  
 splendid Agenor, and young Acamas,  
 who looked like the immortals. Hector bore  
 his round, well-balanced shield and charged ahead.  
 As from behind the clouds a deadly star  
 shines bright then disappears among the shadows,  
 so Hector sometimes became visible  
 among the fighters at the front, but sometimes  
 harangued the men who lingered at the back.  
 He shone from head to foot with dazzling bronze,  
 just like a flash of lightning sent by Zeus,  
 the father god, who bears the goatskin aegis.

80

As reapers in a line along a furrow  
 face one another as they move ahead,  
 gathering wheat or barley in a field  
 for some rich man—the sheaves fall thick and fast—

90

so did the Trojans and the Greeks line up  
 and spring at one another for the kill,  
 and neither side had any thought of flight.  
 The raging battle seized lives on both sides.  
 They fought like wolves, and as she watched them, Conflict,  
 the cause of so much misery, was glad.  
 She was the only god among the fighters.

70

The other gods were sitting far away  
in their own splendid houses, which were built  
among the gulfs and folds of Mount Olympus.  
All of them blamed the god of storm-dark clouds,  
the father of the gods, the son of Cronus,  
because he wished to glorify the Trojans.

100

80 But Zeus was unconcerned about their feelings.

He sat apart from all the other gods,  
exalting in his glory, gazing out  
towards the Greek ships and the Trojan city  
and flashing bronze, the killers and the killed.  
And while the holy light was growing stronger,  
throughout the morning, weapons hit their mark  
on both sides equally. The people fell.

110

But at the time when in the mountain glades  
a woodchopper stops work to make his lunch—  
his arms have had enough of cutting trees,  
his spirit is exhausted and his heart  
is seized by craving for delicious food—

90 at that same hour, the Greeks broke through the ranks  
of Trojans, by their courage and their skill,  
and urged their comrades onward through the fighters.

Among them, Agamemnon pushed ahead.

120

He killed Bienor, shepherd of the people,  
and then Oileus, his friend and driver.

Oileus jumped from the chariot  
and hurtled headlong straight at Agamemnon,  
who drove his sharp spear through his eager forehead.  
The thick bronze helmet could not stop the blade.  
It drove right through the metal to the bone.

Inside his skull his brains were turned to mush,  
despite his eager courage. Agamemnon  
the lord of men, destroyed them both, then stripped  
their armor and their clothes, then left them there—  
100 their naked chests shone bright. Then he attacked

130

Isus and Antiphus, two sons of Priam,  
one born in wedlock and the other not,  
both riding in a single chariot.

The illegitimate son, Isus, drove

and at his side stood famous Antiphus.  
Achilles had once captured both of them,  
when they were herding sheep among the foothills  
of Ida, and with willow twigs he bound them,  
then freed them for a ransom. Now the son  
of Atreus, the great Lord Agamemnon,  
speared Isus in the chest beside his nipple,  
and used his sword to strike at Antiphus  
beside his ear and shoved them from the carriage.

140

110 He came to strip their glorious armor off  
and recognized them—he had seen them once,  
beside the quick Greek ships when they were brought  
from Ida by swift-footed Lord Achilles.

Just as a lion with his strong teeth seizes  
the little babies of a nimble deer  
when he has found their nest, and easily  
rips them apart and takes away their life  
and even if the mother is nearby,

150

she cannot do them any good at all—  
terrible trembling seizes hold of her—  
she dashes through the forest and thick trees,  
sweating and scampering to get away,  
the strong fierce lion chasing close behind—

120 so nobody could save the Trojans' lives.

160

Their helpers also fled before the Greeks.  
Then mighty Agamemnon seized two sons  
of wise Antimachus, who eagerly  
had taken splendid gifts of gold from Paris,  
a bribe for his refusal to allow  
Helen to be returned to Menelaus.

So mighty Agamemnon seized his sons,  
who shared a single chariot. The reins  
had slipped out of their grasp. The two men tried  
to seize the horses, but they bucked and panicked  
and Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
confronted the two brothers, like a lion.

170

130 They knelt down in their chariot and begged him,

“Great son of Atreus, take us alive,



and you will get a very worthy ransom.  
Antimachus, our father, has at home  
masses of treasure—gold, bronze, well-worked iron.  
He will provide you with a lavish ransom  
if he finds out that we are still alive  
beside the Greek ships.”

So they spoke in tears,  
in gentle, pleading tones. But far from gently  
the king replied,

180

“If you two really are  
the sons of wise Antimachus—he once  
declared that Menelaus should be killed!  
My brother went as an ambassador,  
with godlike Lord Odysseus, to meet  
the Trojan council, and your father said  
that both of them should die right then and there  
and never go back to the Greeks. So now,  
you shall repay your father’s disrespect!”

190

With this, he speared Pisander through the chest,  
knocking him from the chariot to the ground,  
and he fell backward, splayed out on the earth.  
Hippolochus jumped down, and Agamemnon  
slaughtered him on the ground and used his sword  
to slash his arms off, sliced right through his neck,  
and sent his torso rolling through the crowd,  
just like a tree trunk used for grinding grain.  
He left those victims and ran on, towards  
the largest group of Trojans in retreat,  
and other Greeks, full-armed, attacked with him.  
The men on foot killed those who fled on foot,  
the charioteers killed charioteers, and dust  
rose from the plain around them and beneath them,  
kicked upward by the horses’ thunderous hooves.  
With bronze they slew, and mighty Agamemnon  
constantly killed and urged his comrades forward.

200

As when a deadly fire attacks a forest,  
wind spirals through and blasts it everywhere,  
and trees are battered, ripped up by the roots  
and felled by the fire's onslaught—so the Trojans  
who tried to flee were felled by Agamemnon,  
the son of Atreus. Now many horses  
rattled between the channels of the fighting.

210

Their sturdy necks pulled empty chariots.

160 They missed their drivers, who lay on the earth,  
more dearly loved by vultures than their wives.

And meanwhile, Zeus had carried Hector off,  
away from weapons, human slaughter, dust,  
blood, and the chaos of the battlefield.

220

Fervently Agamemnon urged the Greeks  
onward. They passed the ancient tomb of Ilus,  
the son of Dardanus, and rushed across  
the middle of the plain, beside the fig tree,  
heading towards the city. Agamemnon  
was always running with them, always shouting.  
His lethal hands were always drenched in gore.

170 But when they reached the Scaean Gates and oak tree,  
they halted, and the armies faced each other.

Meanwhile, across the middle of the plain,  
some Trojans were still running for their lives,  
as when at dead of night a lion comes  
and all the cattle run from him but one,  
who meets her death—between his jaws, he seizes  
her neck and snaps it and then gorges down  
her entrails and her blood—so Agamemnon,  
the mighty son of Atreus, pursued  
the Trojans, always slaughtering the hindmost.

230

They fled but many fell, face-up, face-down,  
out of their chariots, beneath the hands  
of Agamemnon, son of Atreus,

240

180 constantly surging forward with his spear.  
When he had almost reached the city wall,  
the father of the gods and humankind  
came down from heaven and took up his seat  
among the springs and mountain peaks of Ida,

holding his thunderbolt. He ordered Iris,  
who flies on golden wings, to take a message.

“Go swiftly, Iris, take these words to Hector.  
While he sees Agamemnon causing mayhem  
among the frontline fighters, killing men,  
let Hector keep his distance and hold back  
and let him tell the common Trojan troops  
to grapple with the enemy in combat.  
But when he jumps upon his chariot,  
struck by a spear or wounded by an arrow,  
I shall bestow the strength to kill on Hector,  
until he reaches the Greek ships at sunset  
when holy darkness comes upon the earth.”

250

Swift Iris heard him, and on feet of wind  
swooped down from Ida’s peaks to holy Troy,  
and found great Hector, prudent Priam’s son,  
standing upon his horse-drawn chariot.  
Swift-footed Iris stood near him and said,

260

“Great Hector, son of Priam, you are equal  
to Zeus in counsel. Zeus has sent me here  
to tell you this. As long as you can see  
that Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,  
runs riot at the front and slaughters men,  
hold back from battle. Tell the other troops  
to grapple with the enemy in combat.  
But when he jumps into his chariot,  
struck by a spear or wounded by an arrow,  
then you will gain from Zeus the strength to kill  
until you reach the Greek ships set with benches,  
at sunset, when the holy darkness comes.”

270

With this, swift-footed Iris flew away,  
and Hector jumped down from his chariot,  
and brandishing his two sharp spears he strode  
all through the army, urging men to fight.

280

He woke the deadly din of war. The Trojans  
turned round towards the Greeks, who closed their ranks,  
ready for battle. So they faced each other.  
The first to leap ahead was Agamemnon,  
eager to fight ahead of all the others.

Now tell me, Muses, dwellers on Olympus,  
who first came face to face with Agamemnon?  
220 Was it a Trojan, or a glorious ally?  
It was Iphidamas, Antenor's son,  
a strong and mighty man, who had been raised 290  
in fertile Thrace, the motherland of flocks.  
Cisses took care of him when he was young  
inside his house—he was his grandfather,  
the father of the beautiful Theano.  
But when the boy had reached the age to fight  
for glory, Cisses tried to keep him home,  
and gave him his own daughter as his bride.  
But from the marriage chamber he set forth  
with twelve curved ships at his command, to seek  
renown in battle with the Greeks. He left 300  
his steady ships in Percote and marched  
230 on foot to Troy. Now he came face to face  
with Agamemnon, son of Atreus.  
As they approached each other, Agamemnon  
attacked but missed—his spear went veering sideways.  
Iphidamas struck Agamemnon's belt  
under the breastplate and with confidence  
in his strong arm, he pressed in hard, but failed  
to pierce the shining belt. His spear-tip bent  
like lead against the silver. Agamemnon 310  
grabbed the spear from his hand, fierce as a lion,  
240 and with his sword, chopped off his head and killed him.  
So there he fell and slept the sleep of bronze.  
This poor man came to help his countrymen,  
and died a long way from his wife, his bride,  
and never lived to benefit from her,  
despite the marriage gifts he paid for her.  
He had already brought a hundred cattle,

and vowed a thousand other animals,  
mixed flocks of sheep and goats. His herds were countless.

320

But Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
slaughtered him, stripped away his splendid armor,  
and strode all through the Greek crowd wearing it.

250 And when Antenor's oldest son, fine Coon,  
saw him, great sorrow for his fallen brother  
covered his eyes. He took a sideways stance,  
so that his target would not notice him,  
then hurled his spear at noble Agamemnon.

The shining spear-tip struck him on the arm  
beneath the elbow. Great Lord Agamemnon  
shuddered, but kept on fighting even so.

330

He leapt at Coon with his wind-fed spear.

Hastily, Coon dragged Iphidamas,  
his brother, by the foot away from battle.

He shouted to his bravest friends for help.

260 But as he dragged his brother through the crowd,  
the polished bronze of Agamemnon's spear-tip  
struck him beneath the shield. His limbs unloosed.

Standing beside the dead Iphidamas,  
Lord Agamemnon cut off Coon's head.

340

Killed by the royal son of Atreus,  
Antenor's sons fulfilled their destiny,  
and both descended to the house of Hades.

Then, for as long as hot blood kept on spurting  
out of his wound, Lord Agamemnon strode  
among the ranks of men with sword and spear  
and massive rocks. But when the wound dried up,  
after the blood stopped flowing, Agamemnon,  
the son of Atreus, was pierced by pain.

As when a piercing, cruel arrow strikes  
a woman in the agony of labor,

350

270 shot by the goddesses of labor pangs,  
the Eileithuias, who are Hera's daughters,  
in charge of cruel birth-pangs—even so  
sharp pains pierced Agamemnon. He jumped up  
into his chariot and told the driver  
to take him back towards the hollow ships.

The wound was hurting him. He raised his voice,  
and shouted to the Greeks,

“My friends, lords, leaders,  
now you must keep the cruel noise of warfare  
far from our ships. Wise Zeus has not allowed me  
to fight the whole day long against the Trojans.”

360

280 The driver whipped the fine-maned horses onward,  
towards the hollow ships. They gladly flew,  
chest foaming, legs and bodies caked with dust,  
bringing the wounded leader from the battle.

When Hector saw Lord Agamemnon leave,  
he shouted to the Lycians and the Trojans,  
“Trojans and Lycians and Dardanian allies,  
be men, my friends! Do not forget your courage.  
The finest of our enemies is gone,  
and Zeus, the son of Cronus, gave great glory  
to me. Now drive your horses straight towards  
the valiant Greeks and win a mighty triumph!”

370

290

With these words, Hector stirred in every heart  
courage and eagerness to fight—as when  
a hunter sets his white-toothed hounds to rush  
against a lion or wild boar—just so  
the son of Priam set the valiant Trojans  
against the Greeks, and he himself, like Ares,  
destroyer of humanity, ran out  
among the frontline fighters, full of daring.  
Into the battle throng he plunged—like wind,  
which gusts up high, leaps down into the water,  
and roils the violet surface of the sea.

380

300

Then whom did Hector, son of Priam, kill,  
when Zeus had given him the upper hand?  
Who first? Who last? First Asaeus, Opites,  
Autonous the son of Clytus, Dolops,  
Opheltius, Aesymnus, Agelaus,

390

Orus, and valiant Hipponous.  
He killed these leaders, then attacked their troops,  
the multitude—as when the west wind, Zephyr,  
assaults and pummels with a hurricane  
the white clouds gathered by the south wind, Notus—  
the billowing waves are swollen to great height,  
foam spatters in the air above the sea,  
tossed up by the chaotic blast of air—  
so fast the people died at Hector’s hands.

310 It would have been a total massacre—  
carnage, Greeks falling as they tried to flee  
towards their ships—had not Odysseus  
shouted to Diomedes,

400

“Diomedes!

What is the matter with us? Have we both  
forgotten everything we know of courage?  
Come here now, comrade, come and stand beside me!  
It would be shameful if our ships were taken  
by Hector in his glittering bronze helmet.”

Strong Diomedes answered, “Yes, I will  
stand firm and face the enemy with you,  
although our joy will likely be short-lived.  
Zeus, who amasses storm clouds, wants to give  
the power to the Trojans, not to us.”

410

320 With these words, Diomedes speared Thymbraeus  
through his left nipple and so shoved him down,  
out of his chariot upon the ground,  
and Molion, his godlike charioteer,  
was taken by Odysseus. These men  
could fight no longer so they left them there,  
and onward through the throng they ran amok,  
as when two boars, with confident, proud hearts,  
attack a pack of hunting hounds—just so,  
they swiveled and attacked and slaughtered Trojans.  
The Greeks in flight from Hector were relieved

420

to have a time to breathe. Then those two fighters  
 pounced on another chariot, in which  
 the champions of Percote were riding—  
 the sons of Merops, who was highly skilled  
 330 in prophecy and tried to stop his sons  
 from going off to war where men are killed. 430  
 But they refused to listen to their father.  
 Their fates were leading them towards black death.  
 And now the famous spearman, Diomedes,  
 the son of Tydeus, deprived them both  
 of life and spirit, and then stripped away  
 their shining arms. Odysseus destroyed  
 Hippodamus and fine Hyperochus.  
 Then Zeus, the son of Cronus, looked from Ida  
 and stretched the battle tight and evenly.  
 The Greeks and Trojans massacred each other. 440  
 Then Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
 wounded Agastrophus, the son of Paeon.  
 He thrust his spear into this warrior's hip.  
 The victim had not kept his horses close—  
 340 a big mistake. He had no way to flee.  
 His driver held them a long way away.  
 On foot he stumbled through the frontline fighters  
 until he lost his life. Then Hector noticed  
 that those two Greeks were ranging through his troops.  
 He rushed towards them with a shout. The Trojans 450  
 ran with him, in formation for a fight.  
 The master of the war cry, Diomedes,  
 shuddered when he saw Hector, and at once  
 informed Odysseus, who stood beside him,  
  
 “Disaster rolls towards us—mighty Hector!  
 But come, stand firm, we must defend ourselves.”  
  
 With that, he aimed and threw his long dark spear,  
 350 and did not miss. The spear struck Hector's head,  
 the top part of his helmet. But it failed  
 to reach his handsome skin. Bronze beat back bronze— 460  
 the triple-layered helmet with its visor,



given to Hector by Apollo, saved him.  
He ran a very long way back, bowed low  
amid the throng and stopped there, kneeling down,  
leaning his strong hands on the earth. Dark night  
covered his eyes. While Diomedes sought  
his spear, cast far into the crowd of fighters,  
where it had stuck itself into the earth,  
Hector revived and jumped back up again  
into his chariot and drove it back  
towards the crowd. He had escaped black death.  
Then mighty Diomedes rushed towards him,  
holding his spear, and said,

470

“You have survived  
this time, you dog! It was a close escape.  
Phoebus Apollo rescued you again.  
Presumably you say your prayers to him  
before you face the clash of spears. I tell you,  
next time I meet you, I will finish you—  
if I have also got a god as helper.  
But in the meantime, I will lay my hands  
on any other Trojan I can find.”

480

With this, he stripped Agastrophus, the spearman,  
the glorious son of Paeon, of his weapons.  
But as he did so, Paris, Helen’s husband—  
Helen, whose hair was coiled in lovely braids—  
bending his bow, took aim at Diomedes,  
the shepherd of the people. Paris leaned  
against a pillar on the mound constructed  
for old King Ilus, son of Dardanus.

While Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
removed his noble victim’s arms and armor—  
the shining breastplate from his chest, the shield  
strapped to his shoulders, and the sturdy helmet—  
Paris drew back his bow and shot the arrow,  
which did not fly forth from his hand in vain.  
It hit the top of his right foot, drove through it,  
and nailed it to the earth. Then Paris chuckled,

490

jumped from his ambush spot, and boasted,

“Got you!

380 My arrow hit its mark. I only wish  
I could have plunged it deep into your belly  
and killed you. Then the Trojans would have had  
respite from suffering. You make them shiver,  
like goats that bleat and tremble at a lion.”

500

Strong Diomedes, unafraid, replied,  
“ You good-for-nothing archer! Sleazy flirt!  
So rude! So cocky in your silly hairstyle!  
If you tried fighting with me face to face,  
your bow and your swift arrows would be useless.  
You brag like this because you grazed my foot.  
I barely noticed it—as if a woman  
or foolish child had slapped me. Blows that come  
390 from nobodies and cowards do not hurt.  
Even a scratch from me cuts sharp and deep,  
and instantly, my enemy is dead.  
His grieving widow’s fingers tear her cheeks,  
his children have no father now. His blood  
reddens the earth. He rots and round his body  
more birds than women gather.”

510

So he spoke.

And then Odysseus, the skillful spearman,  
approached and stood in front of Diomedes,  
so he could sit and pull out the sharp arrow  
stuck in his foot. Then pain shot through his body.  
He climbed into the chariot and ordered  
the driver back towards the hollow ships,  
400 because he was in agony. He left  
the famed spear warrior, Odysseus,  
alone. No other Greek remained with him—  
terror had seized them all. Odysseus  
spoke to his own proud heart in his confusion.

520

“What will become of me? It would be awful  
to run away in fear from all these Trojans.  
But even worse if I am captured here  
alone! Zeus made the other Greeks take flight.  
Why does my spirit even ask this question?  
I know a coward leaves the battlefield.  
A champion must stand his ground and fight,  
ready to strike or suffer any blow.”

410

As he was thinking these things in his mind,  
the ranks of Trojan warriors with shields  
drew near him and surrounded him—and brought  
trouble upon themselves. As hounds and hunters  
surround a wild boar just as he emerges  
out of dense woodland with his jaws agape,  
gnashing his bright white tusks—on every side  
the hunters lunge at him and though they hear  
his grinding teeth, they face the fierce opponent—  
just so, the Trojan warriors surrounded

540

Odysseus, the leader loved by Zeus,  
who fought against them with his long sharp spear,  
and leapt at Deiopites and stabbed  
down through his shoulder, and then slaughtered Thoon,  
and Ennomos, and then Chersidamas  
as he was climbing from his chariot.

420

Odysseus thrust underneath his shield  
and speared his crotch. He fell down in the dust.  
His fingers clawed the earth. Odysseus  
left these to die and used his spear to strike  
Charops, the son of Hippasus, the brother  
of wealthy, godlike Socus. Socus hurried  
to help, stood near Odysseus, and said,

550

560

“Fabled Odysseus, insatiable  
in your desire for trickery and pain,  
today may be the day on which you kill  
both sons of Hippasus and take our arms  
and stand in triumph over both of us—  
or else my spear may strike and slaughter you!”

430

With this, he struck him on his balanced shield.  
The mighty spear went through the shining bronze  
and thrust into the decorated breastplate  
and sliced off all the flesh around his ribs.  
But then Athena stopped it going deeper,  
into his innards, and Odysseus  
realized that the wound had not been fatal.  
440 He stepped back and told Socus,

570

“You poor fool!  
You will die horribly. For now, you stopped me  
from fighting with the Trojans. But I tell you  
this very day, dark death is coming for you.  
My spear will conquer you and you will give  
your life to Hades, and success to me.”

Then Socus turned around to run away—  
but as he turned, Odysseus implanted  
his spear between his shoulder blades and drove it  
into his chest, and with a clash he fell.  
Godlike Odysseus cried out in triumph,

580

450 “Ah, Socus, son of Hippasus, the skillful  
tamer of horses—now your end, your death  
has overtaken you, with no escape.  
Poor fool! Your father and your royal mother  
will never close your eyes when you are dead.  
The birds of prey will flap their wings around you  
and rip your flesh. But when I die, the Greeks  
will honor me with proper funeral rites.”

590

With this, Odysseus pulled from his flesh  
and through his studded shield the sturdy spear  
cast by deft Socus. As the tip withdrew,  
blood spurted from the wound—he felt the pain.  
And when the Trojan fighters saw him bleeding,  
460 all of them shouted out and thronged around him.  
He drew back, calling to his friends three times,

600

as loudly as a man can shout. Three times  
brave Menelaus heard him shout, and quickly  
told Ajax, who standing was at his side,

“Ajax, commander of the troops, great son  
of Telamon, I heard a cry that came  
from brave, steadfast Odysseus. It sounds  
as if the Trojans, in the crush of battle,  
have hemmed him in and overpowered him.  
He is alone. We must push through the crowd  
to help him. That is best. I am afraid  
something may happen to that brave, strong fighter,  
left all alone, surrounded by the Trojans.  
The Greeks would miss him very much.”

With this  
he led the way, and godlike Ajax followed.  
They found Odysseus, whom Zeus had favored,  
pressed hard by Trojans who surrounded him—  
as spotted jackals on the mountainside  
surround a wounded stag, at whom a hunter  
aims with an arrow from his string and strikes—  
the stag sprints off, escapes the man, and while  
his blood runs warm, his long light legs keep running,  
but when the arrow overpowers him,  
the wild, flesh-eating jackals on the mountain  
devour him in the shadows of the grove,  
then some god sends a lion, who is starving—  
the jackals scatter, and the lion eats—  
so did the valiant Trojans cluster round  
clever, ingenious Odysseus,  
but he fought back, attacked them with his spear,  
and saved himself from death. Ajax approached,  
holding his towering shield, and stood beside him.  
The Trojans ran away in all directions.  
But Menelaus led Odysseus  
out of the throng. He held him by the hand  
until the driver brought the chariot.  
Then Ajax, leaping at the Trojans, killed

490 a bastard son of Priam, Doryclus,  
then wounded Pandocus, and then Lysander,  
Pyrrhus, and Pyrrhus. As a river,  
swollen with rain from Zeus in wintertime,  
floods and flows down the mountainside and carries 640  
numerous trees, dry oak and pine, and hurls  
the heaps of driftwood down into the sea—  
so glorious Ajax swept across the plain,  
slashing at men and horses, causing chaos.  
Hector was fighting on the field's far left,  
beside the riverbanks of the Scamander,  
and so he did not notice Ajax yet.  
500 There by the river, many lost their lives,  
and deafening screams arose around great Nestor  
and warlike Idomeneus, where Hector 650  
triumphed and dominated with his spear  
and skill in horsemanship, and wrecked the ranks  
of young Greek fighters. But the noble Greeks  
would not have given any ground to him,  
if Paris, Helen's husband, had not checked  
a Greek who had been fighting brilliantly—  
Machaon, shepherd of the people. Paris  
struck his right shoulder with a three-barbed arrow.  
The Greeks, whose breath was fury, feared the battle  
had turned and that Machaon might be killed. 660  
510 So Idomeneus told noble Nestor,

“Glory of Greece, great son of Neleus,  
come on, get up into your chariot,  
and let Machaon mount and stand beside you,  
and hurry your strong horses to the ships,  
because a doctor is as valuable  
as many other men. He knows the arts  
of cutting arrows out and of anointing  
a wound with healing drugs.”

And horse-lord Nestor  
heeded his words, immediately mounting 670  
his chariot, and in it climbed Machaon,

son of Asclepius, the splendid doctor.

520 They whipped the horses, who were keen to go  
back to the hollow ships, and there they flew.  
Cebriones then realized the Trojans  
were being routed, and he said to Hector,  
who stood beside him,

“Hector, you and I  
are on the outskirts of this deadly battle,  
fighting the Greeks out here. The other Trojans,  
both men and horses, are in turmoil, routed 680  
and forced to flee by Telamonian Ajax.  
I recognized him clearly by his shield,  
the huge one that he carries on his shoulders.  
We need to drive our chariot that way,  
where men on foot and men on chariots  
hurl cruel conflict and destroy each other,  
530 and screaming never ends.”

With that, he struck  
the thick-maned horses with the whistling whip.  
They heard it crack and quickly galloped off  
and pulled the chariot towards the armies. 690  
Beneath their hooves they trampled shields and corpses.  
The axle underneath the chariot  
and rails on top were drenched in drops of blood,  
some spattered from the harness of the horses,  
some from the chariot wheels. And Hector yearned  
540 to plunge amid the throng of men, attack  
and break them, and bring ruin to the Greeks.  
His spear was not long idle, and he ranged  
with sword and spear and large rocks through the lines  
of Greeks—yet he avoided doing battle 700  
with Telamonian Ajax. But then Zeus,  
the father god who sits on high, aroused  
panic in Ajax, and he stood stock-still,  
swiveled his seven-layered oxhide shield  
onto his back, then turned round and retreated  
towards the Greek troops, glancing all about,

like a wild animal. He stepped so slowly,  
his legs were barely moving—just as when  
farmers and dogs drive from a cattle pen  
a tawny lion, and stay up all night

710

550 in case he seizes some fat calf—the lion  
is yearning for some meat but cannot get it—  
javelins and blazing cudgels fly at him  
from brave strong hands, and make him turn away  
at dawn, despite his eagerness—he leaves,  
frustrated in his heart—just so, great Ajax,  
heartsick and disappointed, left the Trojans,  
against his will, afraid about the ships.

As when a donkey heads towards a field  
of crops, and children try to drive him back,  
but he is stubborn—many sticks are broken  
upon his back, but he gets to the field,  
enters, and devastates the thick tall grain,

720

560 while children keep on hitting him with sticks  
but very feebly though they try so hard,  
and when at last they make him leave the crop,  
he has already had his fill of food—

just so the valiant Trojans and their allies,  
gathered from far and wide, assailed great Ajax,  
constantly battering his shield with spears.

730

Ajax would sometimes swivel round and show  
his usual eagerness and will to fight  
against the phalanxes of Trojan horsemen,  
and sometimes turned around, retreating backward,  
but blocking all of them from making progress

570 towards the swift ships. He rushed in between  
the Trojans and the Greeks, and stood his ground.

Spears flew from bold hands and some pierced his shield.  
Others fell short, embedded in the earth,  
although they yearned to touch the man's white skin  
and sate their appetite for flesh. But when

740

Eurypylus, Euaemon's noble son,  
saw Ajax battered by so many blows,  
he came, stood at his side, hurled his bright spear,  
and struck Apisaon, the people's shepherd,



under his midriff, piercing through his liver.  
At once, his limbs were loosened and he died.

580 Eurypylus jumped on him and began  
to strip the arms and armor from his back.  
When godlike Paris saw him doing this,  
immediately he drew his bow—the arrow  
struck in his right thigh and the shaft broke off,  
and weighed his leg down heavily. In pain,  
he drew back to his group of battle comrades,  
and shouted loudly to the Greeks,

750

“My friends,  
leaders and chieftains of the Greeks, turn round!  
Stand firm! Save Ajax from a cruel death!  
Oppressed by such a battery of blows  
I tell you he will never get away  
from this disastrous battle, unless you  
gather together and stand firm around  
great Ajax, son of Telamon.”

760

590

So spoke  
the wounded warrior, Eurypylus.  
They came, stood near him, and held up their spears,  
leaning their shoulders on the shields. Great Ajax  
joined them, and when he reached the group of comrades,  
he turned and stood to face the enemy.  
So they did battle, like a blazing fire.  
Meanwhile, the sweating mares of Neleus  
bore Nestor from the battle, with Machaon,  
the shepherd of the people. And swift-footed  
Achilles saw him—he had gone to stand  
upon the prow of his big-bellied ship  
to watch the agonizing work of war,  
the speed, the rush of bodies, and the tears.  
At once, Achilles called out to Patroclus,  
his friend, who came out from the tent, like Ares—  
and that was the beginning of his ruin.  
Patroclus, brave son of Menoetius, asked,

770

600

“Why are you calling? What do you need from me,  
Achilles?”

780

Swift Achilles answered him,  
“Noble Patroclus, son of great Menoetius,  
you are the person dearest to my heart.  
I think the Greeks will gather round me now  
and supplicate me, clutching at my knees.  
610 They cannot bear it anymore. They need me.  
So now, Patroclus, favorite of Zeus,  
go and ask Nestor who that wounded man is,  
whom he has brought back from the battlefield.  
He looked to me exactly like Machaon,  
son of Asclepius. But I saw only  
his back—I did not see his face—the horses  
galloped so swiftly past me.”

790

Then Patroclus  
instantly did as his dear friend had asked.  
He ran beside the tents and huts of Greeks.  
And meanwhile, Nestor and Machaon reached  
the tent of Nestor, son of Neleus.  
They climbed down to the earth that feeds us all,  
620 and old Lord Nestor’s man, Eurymedon,  
released the horses from the chariot.  
The travelers both dried their sweaty tunics,  
by standing on the seashore in the breeze.  
They went inside the hut, sat on soft chairs,  
and Hecamede mixed them a concoction.  
Daughter of brave Arsinous, she was  
claimed as a prize of war by old Lord Nestor  
after Achilles had sacked Tenedos.  
The Greeks had given her to him because  
he was the very best of all in council.  
Now, with her hair arranged in braids, she set  
a fine, well-polished table out for them,  
whose legs were decorated with enamel,  
and on it placed a basket made of bronze,  
630 an onion, as a relish for the drink,

800

810

and yellow honey, and beside it laid  
the grain of holy barley. Next to these  
she set a cup of great magnificence,  
which old Lord Nestor brought with him from home,  
studded with golden rivets, with four handles,  
round each of which two golden doves were pecking,  
and on the bottom, it had two supports.

820

When it was full, it was extremely hard  
for anyone to move it from the table—  
except old Nestor, who could pick it up  
with ease. The woman, who was like a goddess,  
mixed a concoction with some Pramnian wine,  
and goat's cheese grated with a bronze cheese-grater,  
and then white barley, which she sprinkled in.

640

Once she had finished making the concoction,  
she told the men to drink it, and they did so,  
and quenched their desperate thirst. Then they enjoyed  
a conversation, and while they were chatting,  
godlike Patroclus stood beside the doors.

830

When old Lord Nestor saw that he had come,  
he jumped up from his decorated chair  
and took his hand and told him to sit down.  
But he refused and said,

“This is no time  
for sitting down, old king. I will not do it.  
The man who sent me here requires respect,  
and he is quick to anger. I was told  
to find out who you carried back with you,  
the wounded man. And I see who it is—  
Machaon, shepherd of the people. Now  
I shall go back and bring word to Achilles.  
Old king, you know yourself what he is like.  
The man is dangerous and quick to blame  
even the blameless.”

840

650

Then Gerenian Nestor  
answered, “Why is Achilles so upset  
about how many Greeks are being wounded?

He does not even know how bad it is  
or what disaster has beset the army.  
Our finest warriors lie in the ships,  
wounded by arrows and impaled by spears.

850

660 An arrow struck the mighty Diomedes,  
the son of Tydeus. Odysseus  
and Agamemnon, famous for his fighting,  
were stabbed by spears. Eurypylus is wounded,  
struck by an arrow to the thigh. I brought  
this other fighter from the field just now,  
hit by an arrow. And meanwhile, Achilles  
does not take care of us or pity us,  
despite his strength and skillfulness in war.  
Does he intend to wait till our swift ships  
blaze with destructive fire beside the sea,  
and none of us can stop it? Will he wait  
till we ourselves are slaughtered one by one?  
My body does not have its former strength.  
My limbs have lost their flexibility.

860

670 If only I were young and strong again,  
as when my people fought with the Epeans  
over a cattle raid, in which I killed  
brave Itymoneus, who lived in Elis,  
son of Hyperochus. And as I drove  
their cows that we had stolen as reprisal,  
he tried to get them back. He led the charge,  
and my hand hurled a javelin and struck him,  
and down he fell. The country people scattered,  
and from their fields we seized their animals—  
a valuable collection, fifty herds  
of cattle, and as many flocks of sheep,  
and just as many roving tribes of goats,  
and fifty droves of pigs. We also took  
680 three times as many chestnut mares, of which  
most had a foal at teat. We drove these herds  
at night towards the town of Pylos, ruled  
by Neleus, and Neleus was glad  
that I had taken such a massive haul  
when I had gone to fight in war so young.

870

880

When dawn appeared, the heralds called the men  
to whom a debt was owed by noble Elis.

890

The leaders of the Pylians assembled  
and shared the animals between them all.

Many of us had debts to be collected.

We Pylians were few and much oppressed,

690 because in former years great Heracles  
had come and killed our finest warriors.

Great Neleus once had twelve sons, of whom  
eleven died and only I survived.

Our losses stirred up the bronze-clad Epeans  
to arrogance and violence against us.

900

And from the spoils that we had won by raiding,  
old Neleus picked out a herd of cattle,  
and a large flock, three hundred sheep, with herders,  
because the splendid town of Elis owed him  
a very large debt of a chariot,

with four prize-winning horses, who had gone there  
to run a race, competing for a tripod,

700 but Augeas, the ruler, kept them there,  
and sent away the driver, who was heartsick  
to lose the horses. My old father felt

angry at this behavior and his words,

910

so he took many animals, and gave  
the others to the Pylians to share  
so nobody would lack an equal portion.

Thus we distributed the herds and flocks  
and offered sacrifices to the gods

throughout the town. But then on the third day  
the numerous Epeans all at once

came rushing forth, both men and strong-hoofed horses,  
galloping out together, and among them,

920

the sons of Molione put on armor,

710 although they were still boys, not yet familiar  
with battle rage. High on a rugged hill

there is a distant town named Thryoessa.

The River Alpheus runs through this town,  
right on the boundary with sandy Pylos.

They set up camp around it, keen to sack it,

and scurried all across the plain. But then  
Athena as a messenger came running  
at night from Mount Olympus, to command us  
to arm ourselves at once. She rushed through Pylos  
gathering troops, who were already eager.

930

But Neleus told me I must not fight,  
and hid my horses, because he believed  
I was not ready yet to fight in war.

720

I marched on foot, and even so, I fought  
better than any of the men with horses.

The battle went this way because Athena  
had made it so. There is a river flowing  
into the sea beside Arene. There

940

we waited for the shining Dawn—we horsemen,  
and crowds of foot soldiers who streamed behind.

By noon, we had assembled in full force,  
wearing our armor, carrying our weapons,  
beside the holy River Alpheus.

We made fine offerings to mighty Zeus,  
and sacrificed one bull for Alpheus,  
another for Poseidon, and a cow,

730

fresh from the herd, for great bright-eyed Athena,  
and then we had our dinner, in position,  
throughout the camp. Then each of us, still armed,  
lay down to rest beside the flowing river.

950

The brave Epeans had the town surrounded  
and hoped to sack it—but the mighty labor  
of Ares stopped them. Once the sun was spreading  
his shining rays across the earth, we prayed  
to Zeus and to Athena, then joined battle.

Of all the Pylians and the Epeans,

I was the first to kill a man—a spearman,  
Mulius, and I took his strong-hoofed horses.

960

740

He was the son-in-law of Augeas,  
the husband of the ruler's eldest daughter,  
blonde Agamede, who knew all the drugs  
nourished by broad earth. Mulius approached—  
I struck him with my bronze-tipped spear. He fell  
down in the dust. I jumped behind his horses,

and rode his chariot along the front.

The brave Epeans turned around and fled,  
scattered in all directions. They had seen  
their finest warrior, who led their horsemen,

970

fall. Like a black tornado, I attacked,  
and I took fifty chariots. From each,  
my spear subdued two men. They bit the earth.

750

I would have killed the sons of Actor's line,  
the sons of Molione, but their father,  
the lord of earthquakes, powerful Poseidon,  
saved them from battle, clouding them in mist.  
Then Zeus gave glory to the Pylians.

Across the many miles of plain we chased them,  
killing the men and taking their fine weapons,  
driving our horses onward, till we reached  
the fertile wheat fields of Bouprasion,

980

and came to the Olenian Rock, beneath  
the hill they call Alesion, which was where  
Athena blocked our people. So we turned

760

our galloping horses from Bouprasion  
and headed back to Pylos. All the people  
gave thanks. The god they glorified the most  
was Zeus. The man they glorified was Nestor.

That was the way I was among my people,  
if I remember rightly how it was.

990

And yet Achilles will enjoy his skill  
all by himself. He will regret it later,  
and weep for what has happened, I am sure,  
after our men are dead. Dear boy, your father,  
Menoetius, offered you some good advice,  
the day he said goodbye to you in Phthia,  
when you were coming here with Agamemnon.

Noble Odysseus and I had gone  
to visit Peleus inside his house

1000

770

while we were traveling through fertile Greece  
to raise an army. In the splendid palace,  
we found Menoetius, the brave warrior,  
and you beside Achilles. In the courtyard,  
old Peleus the charioteer was burning

fat ox-thighs as an offering to Zeus,  
the god who loves the thunder. He was holding  
a golden cup, from which he poured libations  
of flame-red wine, beside the flaming meat.  
You two were working to prepare the beef,  
and we stood in the doorway. Then Achilles,  
astonished, jumped up, took us by the hand,  
and led us to sit down, and welcomed us  
with lavish gifts of hospitality,  
which is the proper custom for a guest.

1010

780 After we had enjoyed the food and drink,  
I was the first to speak, and I told you  
to join our expedition. Both of you  
were eager, and your fathers gave advice.

Old Peleus advised his son, Achilles,  
always to be the best, outdoing others.

1020

Menoetius, son of Actor, said to you,  
‘My son, Achilles comes from higher birth,  
and he is stronger—but you are the elder.  
You must advise him, counsel him, direct him.  
It will be better if he yields to you.’

790 Your father told you this, but you forgot.  
Talk to Achilles now and make him heed you.

Who knows? Perhaps some god will bless your words,  
and you will touch his heart and change his mind.

1030

Persuasion from a friend can be effective.  
But if his goddess mother has advised him  
about the will of Zeus, and if his heart  
holds back because of some divine intention,  
go forth yourself, and let the Myrmidons  
march with you. Be a light to help the Greeks.  
And let him give you his own splendid armor.

800 The Trojans may believe that you are him  
and keep away from battle, and meanwhile,  
the weary sons of Greece can catch their breath.

1040

Respite in war is only ever brief.  
The Trojans are exhausted from the fighting,  
but you are all well rested and you can  
easily drive them back towards the city



and make them leave our ships and tents.”

So Nestor

stirred up the pride and courage in his heart.

Patroclus sprinted off beside the ships

to find Achilles, grandson of Aeacus.

But when Patroclus ran beside the fleet

of godlike Lord Odysseus, beside

1050

the place the Greeks assembled for discussion,

where they had built their altars for the gods,

he met Eurypylus, the wounded man,

810 Euaemon’s noble son, who limped from battle

because his thigh was injured by the arrow.

His head and shoulders were all drenched in sweat,

and dark blood trickled from his painful wound,

and yet his spirit was resilient.

When valiant Patroclus saw this man,

he pitied him and sorrowed for his pain.

1060

Sadly he spoke and let his words take flight.

“Poor leaders, lords and rulers of the Greeks!

It seems that you are set to die in Troy,

far from your fatherland and family,

to glut the swift dogs with your bright white fat.

But tell me, noble, brave Eurypylus,

820 will the Greeks still hold off gigantic Hector?

Or will they die, defeated by his spear?”

Eurypylus, the wounded fighter, answered,

“Noble Patroclus, now the Greeks have lost

1070

all opportunity to save themselves.

Beside the black ships, they will fall. You see,

all those who used to be our finest fighters

are lying wounded by the Trojans’ hands

inside their ships, while hour by hour the Trojans

are growing ever stronger. Help me, please!

Take me to my black ship and cut the arrow

out of my thigh, and with warm water wash

830 the black blood from the wound, and then apply  
some healing and effective medications. 1080  
They say you learned about them from Achilles,  
who learned from Chiron, the most righteous Centaur.  
Our usual doctors are not here, you see.  
One, Podalirius, is lying wounded  
inside his tent, I think—he needs a doctor  
himself. The other doctor, great Machaon,  
is waiting on the battlefield to meet  
sharp Ares in the conflict with the Trojans.”

Then valiant Patroclus answered him,  
“How can I help you, brave Eurypylus? 1090  
What shall we do? I have to go and take  
a message to magnificent Achilles  
840 from Nestor, guardian of the Greeks. And yet  
I will not leave you suffering like this.”

With this, he gripped him underneath his chest  
and took him to his tent. The steward saw them  
and spread oxhides out on the floor. Patroclus  
made him lie down and with a knife cut out  
the piercing arrow stuck deep in his thigh.  
He washed away the black blood from the wound, 1100  
using warm water, and between his hands  
he rubbed a painkiller, a bitter root,  
and smeared it on the leg. It stopped the pain.  
The wound dried up and no more blood flowed out.

## BOOK 12



## The Wall

While brave Patroclus stayed inside the hut,  
tending the wounded man, Eurypylus,  
the Greeks and Trojans clustered close and fought.  
One day, the wide wall of the Greeks would fall.  
They built it round their ships and dug the trench,  
but failed to give the gods fine hecatombs,  
so that they would be safe behind the wall—  
the men themselves, their ships, and all their spoils.  
The wall was built without divine consent,  
against the wishes of the deathless gods,  
and therefore it would not stay standing long.

10

10 While Hector was alive and while Achilles  
was wrathful, while the city of King Priam  
was not yet sacked, so long the Greek wall stood.  
But after all the finest Trojan fighters  
were dead, and many of the Greeks were killed,  
though some survived, when in the war's tenth year  
the city of King Priam was destroyed,  
after the Greeks had sailed back in their ships  
to their dear fatherland—that was the time

20

Apollo and Poseidon formed their plans  
to wipe the wall away by flooding it  
with all the energy of all the rivers  
that flow down from Mount Ida to the sea—  
20 Aeseus, Rhesus, Rhodius, Caresus,  
Heptaporus and Grenicus, and bright  
Scamander and Simoeis, where so many  
helmets and oxhide shields and demigods  
fell in the dust. Apollo moved the mouths  
of all these rivers so they flowed together 30  
and for nine days they flowed upon the wall.  
And all the while, Zeus rained, and soon the fragments  
were turned to jetsam floating on the sea.  
Poseidon, shaker of the earth, himself  
guided the waters, holding up his trident.  
With waves he pushed away the rocks and logs  
that formed the whole foundation of the wall  
on which the Greeks had labored long and hard.  
Beside the swirling Hellespont, the god  
30 flattened the land and coated the long shore 40  
with sand once more, and so wiped out the wall,  
then turned the rivers back around again.  
Their streams flowed smoothly down their former courses.  
Poseidon and Apollo would do this  
one day. But in the meantime, screams and fighting  
blazed round the well-built wall, whose wooden timbers  
resounded as the weapons clashed against them.  
Thrashed by the whip of Zeus, the Greeks were trapped,  
confined beside their hollow ships in fear  
of Hector, the commander of the rout. 50  
40 He fought like a tornado, fierce as ever,  
as when a lion or a wild boar whirls,  
surrounded by the hounds and human hunters,  
proud of his strength—they cluster close together  
and stand to face him like a wall and hurl  
a multitude of spears from many hands,  
but his heroic heart is unafraid,  
and his unflinching strong proud spirit kills him—  
he circles constantly around and lunges

towards the ranks of fighters, who give way  
 wherever he attacks—so Hector whirled  
 50 all through the crowd, exhorting his companions  
 to cross the wide trench. But their horses dared not.  
 They halted on the edge and neighed and snorted,  
 terrified. It was hard to vault across  
 from close range or to cross it on the ground.  
 The sides were both precipitously steep,  
 and on the upper edge, the sons of Greece  
 had planted huge sharp stakes, set close together,  
 to serve as a protection from their foes. 70  
 It was impossible for any horse  
 to pull a chariot with wheels across it.  
 The Trojans wondered if they could succeed  
 on foot. So then Polydamas approached  
 60 valiant Hector, and addressed him.

“Hector,  
 and leaders of the Trojans and our allies,  
 we would be fools to try to drive swift horses  
 over this trench. It is too hard to cross.  
 Sharp stakes are set along it, and beyond it,  
 the Greeks have built their wall. There is no way 80  
 to fight with chariots or to dismount  
 in such a narrow place. We would be hurt.  
 If Zeus who thunders from on high is planning  
 to help the Trojans and to crush the Greeks,  
 intending devastation for them all,  
 I hope he makes it happen right away,  
 70 and that they die here far away from Greece,  
 nameless. But if they rally and turn round,  
 leaving their ships, and push us in the trench,  
 and gain the upper hand on us, I think 90  
 none of us Trojans will escape the Greeks,  
 even to take the bad news back to Troy.  
 But come now, we must all do as I say.  
 The drivers need to hold the horses here  
 beside the trench, while we attack on foot,  
 all fully armed, all thronging around Hector.

The Greeks will not be able to withstand us,  
if they are shackled in the bonds of doom.”

80     So spoke Polydamas. His good advice  
pleased Hector, and at once, with all his weapons, 100  
he jumped out of his chariot. The others  
stopped standing at the ready, but leapt down  
when they saw mighty Hector doing it.  
Each leader had his driver hold the horses  
there by the trench, and then the fighters split  
into five groups to march behind their leaders.  
The finest fighters and the largest group  
were led by Hector and Polydamas.  
These men were keenest to destroy the wall  
90     and fight the Greeks beside the hollow ships. 110  
Cebriones went with them—Hector left  
a weaker warrior to guard his horses.  
Paris, Agenor, and Alcathous  
served as the leaders of the second group.  
Godlike Deiphobus and Helenus,  
two sons of Priam, led the third battalion,  
along with Asius, another leader,  
the son of Hyrtacus, whose big brown horses  
had carried him to Troy from his own homeland,  
Arisbe, by the banks of the Selleis. 120  
The leader of the fourth group was Aeneas,  
the fine son of Anchises. With him marched  
100     Antenor’s two sons, highly skilled in warfare—  
Archelochus and Acamas. Sarpedon  
selected Glaucus and Asteropeus  
to lead the glorious Trojan allies with him.  
They seemed to him by far the finest fighters,  
except himself—he was the best of all.  
These warriors all stood in close formation,  
fitting their well-wrought oxhide shields together, 130  
then eagerly attacked. They thought the Greeks  
could not hold out against them any longer,  
but soon would fall beside their own black ships.  
The Trojans and their famous allies acted

as wise Polydamas advised—except  
one of the leaders of the Trojan troops.

110 Asius, son of Hyrtacus, refused  
to leave his horses and his charioteer.  
He rode with them towards the swift Greek ships.

Poor fool! He was not destined to escape  
his own black doom or ever leave the ships  
or ride back home again to windy Troy,  
proud of his horses and his chariot.

The spear of splendid Idomeneus,  
Deucalion's fine son, would bring him down,  
and shadow him with death that dims men's names.

He headed to the left side of the ships,  
where the Greeks drove their chariots and horses  
120 back from the plain. He found the gates not bolted  
nor closed—the Greeks were holding them wide open,  
in case one of their comrades fled the field  
and ran towards the ships to look for safety.

He headed straight that way—the others followed  
with piercing cries, because they thought the Greeks  
could not hold out against them any longer,  
but soon would fall beside their own black ships.

Poor fools! They found two champions at the gate,  
proud sons of Lapith warriors—the strong  
son of Pirithous, Lord Polypoetes,

130 and fierce Leonteus, who was as deadly  
as Ares, curse of humankind. Those two

stood at the high gates, like two tall oak trees  
high on the mountains, which, day after day,  
withstand the wind and rain because their roots  
are thick and planted deeply in the earth—  
so these two, trusting in their hands and strength,  
stood firm while mighty Asius approached  
and did not run away. With noisy shouts  
the men rushed straight towards the well-built wall,  
holding their oxhide shields up high. Their leader

was Asius, with Iamenus, Orestes,  
and Adamas, the son of Asius,

140 Thoon, and Oenomaus. For a time,

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the Lapiths had remained in camp, exhorting  
the well-armed Greeks to fight and save their ships.

But when they saw the Trojans were attacking  
the wall, the Greeks began to shout in fear.

The Lapiths rushed outside the gates to fight,  
as when two wild boars on the mountains face  
a band of men and dogs—attacking slantways,  
they break the undergrowth and rip the trees  
up by the roots and gnash their tusks until

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some human hunter takes away their life—  
just so, the bright bronze clashed on those men's chests,  
struck as they faced the enemy. They fought  
bravely and hard, reliant on their strength  
and trusting in their comrades up above,

who pelted the attackers from the wall  
with rocks. They were defending their own lives,  
as well as the encampment and swift ships.

190

Rocks fell to earth, like snowflakes when strong wind  
propels the dark clouds—flurries fall to earth—  
so weapons poured forth from the hands of fighters,  
Trojan and Greek alike. Their knobbly shields  
and helmets clattered, battered by the stones.

Then Asius let out a hopeless groan,  
and struck his thighs and said in his despair,

“So, father Zeus, you must love telling lies!

I never thought the warriors of Greece  
would stand against our overpowering hands.

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But just as slender wasps or bees build houses  
upon a stony road and will not leave  
their hollow home but stand their ground, protecting  
their children from the humans hunting them—  
just so these men, though they are only two,  
refuse to draw back from the gate until  
either they kill us or we capture them.”

These words from Asius did not persuade  
the mind and heart of Zeus, who planned to give  
glory to Hector. Meanwhile, fighters fought

210



around the other gates—so many battles,  
 it would be difficult for me to tell  
 of every conflict, as a god could do.  
 Bright fire licked all along the wall of stone.  
 The Greeks were hard-pressed, but they had to fight  
 to save their ships. And all the gods who favored  
 180 the Greeks in battle were distressed at heart.  
 The Lapiths fought, engaging in the struggle.  
 And then the strong son of Pirithous,  
 Lord Polypoetes, hurled his spear and struck 220  
 Damasus through his helmet, which was set  
 with cheekpieces of bronze. The metal failed  
 to stop the bronze tip. It broke through his skull  
 and all the brains inside were turned to mush.  
 Damasus died, despite his eager courage.  
 Then Polypoetes slaughtered Ormenus  
 and Pylon. And Leonteus, a kinsman  
 of Ares, son of lord Antimachus,  
 speared great Hippomachus right through his belt.  
 190 He drew his sharp sword once more from his scabbard, 230  
 dashed through the crowd and struck Antiphates  
 and pushed him backward down upon the ground.  
 Then he felled Menon, Iamenus, Orestes,  
 each brought down to the earth that feeds us all.  
 And while they stripped these men of their bright arms,  
 the comrades of Polydamas and Hector,  
 the bravest and most numerous of them,  
 who yearned to break the wall and burn the ships,  
 still stood beside the trench, still hesitating,  
 200 because while they were yearning to cross over, 240  
 an eagle flew up high from right to left  
 and held the army back. His talons clutched  
 a huge red snake, still breathing and alive,  
 who had not given up the struggle yet.  
 The snake coiled back and bit the eagle's breast  
 under his neck. In agony, the eagle  
 let fall the snake upon the ground, among  
 the crowd of men, and with a screeching cry  
 he flew away upon the breath of wind.

210 The Trojans shuddered when they saw the snake  
 lying and writhing in their midst, an omen  
 from aegis-bearing Zeus. Polydamas  
 stood near brave Hector, telling him,

“You always  
 criticize me when I make good suggestions  
 in council meetings, Hector. I suppose  
 a common man must not speak out of turn  
 in the assembly or the battlefield.  
 We always have to magnify your power.  
 But I shall say what I believe is best.  
 We should not go and fight beside the ships, 260  
 because I think I know what will take place  
 now that this bird, the eagle, has appeared  
 when we were wondering if we should cross.  
 The eagle flew up high from right to left  
 and held the army back. His talons clutched  
 220 a huge red snake, alive, but let him go  
 and failed to bring the prize back to his home  
 to give it to his children. So we Trojans,  
 even if we break through the gates and wall  
 and make the Greeks give way to our great strength, 270  
 will then retrace our steps haphazardly,  
 with many of our number left behind,  
 slaughtered with Greek bronze as they fight to save  
 their ships. A prophet trusted by the people,  
 who clearly understood the signs of gods,  
 would surely offer this interpretation.”

230 But Hector, helmet flashing, scowled and said,  
 “Polydamas, your words no longer please me.  
 You know how to come up with better counsel.  
 If you are serious in saying this, 280  
 the gods must have deprived you of your wits.  
 You tell me to forget the guidance given  
 to me by Zeus himself, the god of thunder,  
 who bowed his head to promise me success!  
 You tell me to put all my trust in birds

who flutter by. But birds are meaningless!  
I do not worry about them at all,  
whether they fly towards the sun and dawn,  
240 eastward to right of us, or westward, left,  
towards the darkness. Let us trust instead 290  
the plan of mighty Zeus who rules us all,  
the lord of mortals and immortal gods.  
Patriotism is the one true bird.  
Why are you scared of war and violence?  
Even if all the rest of us are killed  
beside the Greek ships, there is still no danger  
that you will die—because you have no courage,  
and no capacity to stand and fight!  
But if you flinch from battle, or advise  
anyone else to turn back from the fighting, 300  
250 I shall immediately hurl my spear  
and slaughter you.”

So Hector spoke, then led  
the charge and with a cry his men surged forward.  
Then thunder-loving Zeus aroused a gust  
of wind that blasted from the peaks of Ida  
and hurled a dust-cloud at the ships, which baffled  
the minds of all the Greeks. Meanwhile, the god  
glorified Hector and the Trojans. Trusting  
the signs revealed to Hector, and their strength,  
the Trojans tried to break the great Greek wall. 310  
They worked to pull the ladders from the towers,  
knock down the battlements and used their crowbars  
to pry the buttresses the Greeks had set  
260 into the ground to form the firm foundations.  
They tried to tug them up and break the wall.  
But still the Greeks did not retreat—not yet.  
They used their oxhide shields to form a fence  
across the battlements on top. From there,  
they pelted missiles at the enemy  
who pushed against the wall from down below. 320  
The two named Ajax ranged across the top,  
commanding and encouraging the Greeks

with gentle coaxing—or with stern reproofs  
when they saw anyone hold back from fighting.  
They shouted out to all of them,

“Dear friends,  
men are not equally adept at warfare.  
270 But there is work for everybody here,  
the strongest, weakest, and those in between.  
You see the situation for yourselves.  
No one must turn back to the ships. Take heed  
of your commanders. Urge each other on.  
Push forward and may Zeus, the god of lightning,  
the great Olympian, let us drive off  
our enemies and chase them back to Troy.”

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With this, the two men urged the Greeks to fight.  
As snow falls thickly in a winter storm  
when Zeus creates a blizzard and reveals  
280 his weapons to humanity and lulls  
the winds to sleep and sends perpetual snow  
until the highest mountain peaks and rocks  
and fertile farms and meadows lush with clover  
are covered, and the snow is spread across  
the rocky shore, the bays, the gray salt sea,  
and blocks the waves from beating on the beach—  
everything everywhere is blanketed  
with snow, when Zeus on high weighs down the world—  
so thickly flew the stones that both sides hurled,  
the Trojans at the Greeks, the Greeks at Trojans.  
The din resounded all along the wall.  
290 And yet the Trojans, led by noble Hector,  
would not have broken through the wall—not yet,  
nor burst the long bolt that secured the gates,  
if cunning Zeus, the god of strategy,  
had not inspired his own dear son, Sarpedon,  
to rush against the Greeks, just as a lion  
pounces upon a herd of ambling cattle.  
He held in front of him his balanced shield  
beautifully hammered by a metalworker

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so that the bronze curved evenly. Inside it,  
the craftsman layered strips of oxhide leather,  
and stitched them round the rim with golden stitches.

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Sarpedon held this shield and two short spears,  
and lunged ahead, just like a mountain lion,  
who for a long time has not tasted meat—

300 his valiant spirit orders him to enter  
the safe home of the sheep to look for them,  
and even if he finds the herdsmen there,  
guarding their flocks of sheep with dogs and spears,  
still he refuses to be driven out

without a struggle—either he will leap  
among them and succeed in seizing one,  
or else he will be struck on the front line  
by some sharp weapon a quick hand has thrown—  
so then his brave heart urged godlike Sarpedon  
to rush towards the wall and try to break  
the battlements. At once, he said to Glaucus,  
son of Hippolochus,

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310 “Why is it, Glaucus,  
that you and I receive such lavish honors?  
Why do we get the finest seats at banquets,  
full cups of wine, the choicest cuts of meat?  
And why does everyone in Lycia gaze  
at both of us as if we were divine?  
Why was a large estate assigned to us  
beside the banks of Xanthus, lovely land  
of vineyards and of plowland thick with wheat?  
Because we have to stand beside our people,  
out on the front line and confront the heat  
of battle, so that any Lycian fighter,  
clad in thick armor, may declare, ‘Our rulers,  
the men who hold great sway in Lycian lands,  
are not dishonorable. They eat fat sheep  
320 and drink good vintage wine as sweet as honey,  
but they are also brave and strong. They fight  
among the Lycian fighters at the front.’  
You see, my brother, if we could escape

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this war and then be free from age and death  
forever, I would never choose to fight  
or join the champion fighters at the front,  
nor would I urge you to participate  
in war where men win glory. But in fact,  
a million ways to die stand all around us.  
No mortal can escape or flee from death.  
So let us go. Perhaps we shall succeed,  
and win a triumph from another's death,  
or somebody may triumph over us."

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330 So spoke Sarpedon, and without delay  
Glaucus agreed. The two plunged straight ahead,  
and led the company of Lycians forward.  
Menestheus, the son of Peteos,  
flinched as they came towards him, bringing death.  
He scanned along the wall for any Greek  
who could bring help to him and his companions.  
He saw the two named Ajax, standing strong,  
whose thirst for war was never satisfied,  
and Teucer, who had just come from his tent.  
They were quite near, but even if he shouted,  
they could not hear his voice, because the noise  
of battered horsehair helmets, shields, and gates  
was so loud that the clatter reached the sky.  
340 The racket rattled every gate. At each,  
men stood and tried to break their way inside.  
So then Menestheus told Thootes,  
his steward, to go run and summon Ajax.

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350 "Hurry, fine Thootes, call Ajax here,  
or rather, both of them. That would be best,  
because this will soon be a massacre.  
The Lycian lords are always fierce in combat,  
but now, they overwhelm us. If the struggle  
is equally intense where they are fighting,  
at least let Telamonian Ajax come,  
without the other Ajax but with Teucer,  
who is so talented at archery."

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The herald listened and obeyed. He sprinted  
beside the wall built by the bronze-clad Greeks  
and met the two named Ajax and at once  
said to them,

“Leaders of the bronze-clad Greeks,  
Ajax and Ajax, I was told to come here  
by Lord Menestheus, the well-loved son  
of Peteos, to ask you both to share  
our labor, even for a little while.

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It would be best if both of you could come,  
because there will soon be a massacre.

360 The Lycian lords are always fierce in combat,  
but now they overwhelm us. If the struggle  
is equally intense where you are fighting,  
at least let Telamonian Ajax come  
without the other Ajax, but with Teucer,  
who is so talented at archery.”

Great Telamonian Ajax heard his words  
and turning to the other Ajax said  
in words that flew on wings,

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“You stay here, Ajax,  
with Lycomedes. Stand and urge the Greeks  
to fight, while I go there and face the fighting.  
I will return as soon as I have saved them.”

370 With these words, Telamonian Ajax left,  
and Teucer, his half brother by their father,  
went with him, as did Pandion, who carried  
the curving bow of Teucer, and they went  
along the wall until they reached the tower  
where brave Menestheus and his companions  
strove with the valiant Lycian lords and leaders.  
They wrangled closely and their cries rang out.  
The first to kill was Telamonian Ajax,  
who struck Sarpedon’s friend, brave Epicles.

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He hurled at him a jagged heavy rock  
 of quartz, that lay on top of other stones  
 380 upon the wall, beside the battlements.  
 This stone was so enormous that a man  
 could scarcely lift it, even with both hands,  
 even a very sturdy, strong young man— 470  
 of modern times. But Ajax easily  
 lifted it high and hurled it at the Trojan  
 and smashed his helmet set with four fine plumes.  
 His skull completely shattered and he tumbled  
 down from the high wall, like an acrobat.  
 Life left his bones. Then Teucer saw that Glaucus,  
 as he was rushing to attack the wall,  
 had left his arm exposed. He aimed right there,  
 and shot him with an arrow, which cut short  
 his eagerness for battle. Glaucus jumped 480  
 390 back from the wall and slunk away in secret,  
 so that no Greek would see that he was wounded  
 and boast in triumph over him. Sarpedon  
 noticed immediately when Glaucus left  
 and grieved but did not lose his battle ardor.  
 He speared and slew Alcmaon, son of Thestor,  
 then drew his spear back out. His victim fell  
 face downward following the weapon's thrust.  
 The fine bronze armor clattered round the corpse.  
 And then Sarpedon, with his sturdy hands, 490  
 ripped off the battlement. That whole long segment  
 fell, and the wall was bare of its defenses,  
 creating room for many men to cross.  
 400 Ajax and Teucer both attacked Sarpedon  
 in tandem. Teucer hit him with an arrow,  
 which struck the shining strap across his chest  
 that held his rounded shield. But Zeus protected  
 his son from death. He would not have him killed  
 beside the ships' sterns. Meanwhile, Ajax pounced  
 and thrust his spear against Sarpedon's shield. 500  
 It did not pierce all through, although the blow  
 slowed his assault, and he withdrew a little,  
 back from the battlement—but not too far.



His heart still yearned for glory and success.  
He turned around and called the godlike Lycians,

“Lycians! Why have you ceased your zealous fighting?  
410 I am a strong man but it is too hard  
for me all by myself to break a path  
and reach the ships. Join me and fight with me!  
More hands make labor light.”

At this, his men  
were frightened, since their leader and commander  
was scolding them, and thronged to him again.  
Inside the wall, the Greeks consolidated  
their ranks. Both armies faced a massive challenge.  
The sturdy Lycians could not break the wall  
or make a pathway to the ships. Meanwhile,  
now that the Lycians had come near the wall,  
420 the warlike Greeks could not push them away.

As in a common field, when two men argue  
over the boundary stones, both holding sticks  
to measure, in their quarrel for fair shares  
within a tiny strip of land—just so,  
the battlements confined the warriors.

Here at the wall they hacked each other’s shields—  
circles of oxhide wrapped around their chests,  
and shaggy, feathery bucklers. Pitiless bronze  
pierced through the skin and flesh of many men—  
some who had turned around amid the fighters  
to run away, and so exposed their backs,  
and many who were stabbed right through their shields.

430 Everywhere, walls and battlements were wet  
with blood from both the Trojans and the Greeks.  
And yet the Trojans could not rout the Greeks.  
Still they held steady— as a careful woman,  
a worker skillful with her hands, holds steady  
a pair of scales and keeps the wool and weight  
evenly balanced on both sides, to earn  
a pitiful allowance for her children—  
so evenly the battle stretched between them,

510

520

530

until Zeus gave the very highest glory  
to Hector, son of Priam. He was first  
to leap across the Greek wall. Then he shouted,  
so that his voice was heard by all the Trojans,

540

440 “Hurry, horse-taming Trojans, break the wall,  
and set their ships ablaze with deadly fire!”

So Hector roused the Trojans. All gave ear,  
and rushed together at the wall, attacking  
the ladders, brandishing their pointed spears.  
But Hector grabbed a boulder, which was lying  
before the gates. Its base was huge, its top  
sharp—and two men, the strongest in the land,  
would have had difficulty lifting it  
up from the earth to load it on a wagon—  
at least as men are nowadays. But Hector  
lifted and wielded it all by himself.

550

450 The son of Cronus made it light for him.  
As when a shepherd easily picks up  
a ram’s fleece with one hand—the weight is small—  
so Hector bore the stone towards the gate,  
where lofty double doors secured the entry.

560

There were two bars crossed over one another  
inside the gate, and one bolt held them firm.  
Hector came near and took a firm position,  
legs spread apart. He aimed towards the center,  
so that his shot would have the greatest impact.

460 He broke both hinges, and the heavy stone  
crashed on the inside. Both gates groaned. The bars  
gave way and as the stone crashed into them  
the doors were were smashed and splintered into fragments.

Then glorious Hector leapt across, his face  
like sudden night, his body bright with bronze—  
a terrifying sight, and in each hand  
he held a spear. Once he had jumped across,  
no one could hold him back except a god.  
His eyes lit up with fire. He swiveled round  
amid the crowd and shouted to the Trojans

570

to cross the wall—and at his call, they came.

Some clambered over, others poured inside

470

through those well-crafted gates. The Greeks were routed.

They ran away towards their hollow ships,

580

with screams and shouts and never-ending noise.

## BOOK 13



## The Waves

When Zeus had brought the Trojans, led by Hector,  
up to the Greek ships, he abandoned them  
to endless suffering and misery.

He turned his shining eyes away and gazed  
towards the country of the Thracian horse-lords,  
the warlike Mysians and the Hippemolgi  
who live on mare's milk, and the Abii,  
most righteous human beings in the world.  
He did not turn to look to Troy at all.

His heart was sure no other deathless god  
would go to help the Trojans or the Greeks.

10

10 And yet the god of earthquakes, great Poseidon,  
was keeping watch. He sat high on the peak  
of wooded Samothrace that had a view  
of Ida, Priam's city, and the ships.

He came up from the sea, sat there and gazed  
with fascination at the war, and pitied  
the Greeks, so overpowered by the Trojans,  
and he became enraged with Zeus. At once,  
the god descended from the rocky mountain,

20

and underneath his quick, immortal feet  
the peaks and forests shook. He took three strides,  
20 and with the fourth, he reached his destination—  
Aegae, where deep down underneath the waves  
he had a shining golden palace, built  
to last forever. There he went and yoked  
his pair of horses to his chariot—  
their hooves were bronze, their manes were gold, their speed  
was swift as flight. He dressed himself in gold,  
then took his finely fashioned golden whip, 30  
climbed on his chariot, and drove away  
across the waves. The seals and dolphins surfaced  
and frolicked all around him as he went.  
They recognized their master. With delight  
the sea spread wide for him. The horses flew  
astonishingly fast across the water,  
30 which never touched the chariot's bronze axle.  
And so the nimble horses brought Poseidon  
near the Greek ships. There is a massive cave  
deep underwater between Tenedos 40  
and rocky Imbros. There the god of earthquakes  
halted his horses and unharnessed them  
and gave them some immortal food to eat.  
He fastened golden shackles on their legs,  
impossible to break or get away from,  
so they would stay there till their lord returned.  
He went to the encampment of the Greeks.  
Like flame or wind, the Trojans rushed together,  
40 clustered around the son of Priam, Hector,  
with unabating eagerness for battle, 50  
shouting and hollering in unison  
because they thought that they would take the ships  
and kill the best Greek fighters then and there.  
But Lord Poseidon, who surrounds the world,  
the earthquake god, emerging from the deep,  
offered the Greeks encouragement. He seemed  
like Calchas in his form and tireless voice.  
First he addressed the warriors named Ajax,  
who were already keen to fight. He said,

“Ajax and Ajax, you will save the Greeks  
if you remember courage, not cold dread.

60

I do not fear the Trojans’ deadly hands  
anywhere else, although they surged across  
the mighty wall. The Greeks will hold them back.

50

But I am terribly afraid that here  
we may experience catastrophe.

Here Hector, like a rabid dog, a flame,  
commands the Trojans, fancying himself  
a mighty son of Zeus. Now may some god  
inspire you also to stand firm and strong,  
and order others forward. You may drive  
Hector away from our swift seaborne ships,  
for all his eagerness, and even if  
the god of Mount Olympus spurs him onward.”

70

The god of earthquakes struck them with his staff,  
and filled them both with courage, strength, and drive,  
and added quickness to their hands and feet.

60

Then off he flew, as swiftly as a falcon,  
who hovers high above a lofty rock face,  
too steep for goats, then swoops across the plain  
to catch another bird—just so Poseidon,  
the god of earthquakes, swooped away from them.  
The first of them to recognize the god  
was swift Oilean Ajax, who at once  
said to the other Ajax,

80

“I am sure,  
Ajax, this was a god from Mount Olympus,  
who ordered us to fight beside the ships,  
disguised as Calchas. It was not in fact  
the prophet, the interpreter of birds.

70

I recognized him very easily  
once he had turned around to go away  
because of how he moved his feet and legs.  
The gods can easily be recognized.  
And now my spirit in my chest is feeling  
even more eagerness for war and battle.

90

My feet and hands are itching for a fight.”

And Telamonian Ajax answered him,  
“I feel the same. My deadly hands are eager  
to hold a spear. My energy is surging,  
my feet are fidgeting and keen to run.  
I long to fight all by myself with Hector,  
the son of Priam, in his ceaseless frenzy.”

80

100

They spoke to one another in this way,  
exhilarated by their zeal for combat,  
which Lord Poseidon put inside their hearts.  
Meanwhile, the god who wraps around the world  
roused up the Greeks who lingered at the rear,  
cooling themselves and resting by the ships.  
Their bodies were exhausted with hard labor,  
and they were downcast in their hearts, because  
the Trojans had transgressed the mighty wall.

110

They watched the crowd of enemies approach,  
and wept beneath their furrowed brows, expecting  
inevitable death. But then Poseidon,  
the god of earthquakes, lightly walked among them,  
inspiring them to line up in formation.  
First, he approached and gave commands to Teucer,  
Leitus, brave Peneleus and Thoas,  
Deipyrus, and those who roused the fighters—  
Meriones and fine Antilochus.

90

The god inspired them with these words on wings.

120

“For shame, young warriors of Greece, for shame!  
I trusted you to fight and save our ships.  
But if you give up on the pain of fighting,  
today we shall be vanquished by the Trojans.  
How shocking! What a terrible surprise,  
which I would never have believed could happen—  
my eyes have seen the Trojans reach our ships!  
They used to be like frightened deer, who skitter  
through forests in their vain attempt to flee

100

from jackals, wolves, and panthers, who will eat them.

130

Deer have no courage, no desire to fight.

Just so, the Trojans in the past refused

to stand and face Greek hands, Greek force, Greek strength—  
they could not bear it even for a moment.

But now they fight beside our hollow ships,  
far from their city, thanks to our commander's  
cowardice and the slackness of the troops,  
who are annoyed with him and so refuse

110 to save the swift ships, and are killed beside them.

Even if it is true that Agamemnon,  
the influential son of Atreus,  
is actually entirely to blame

140

because he disrespected swift Achilles,  
still we must not slack off from war at all,  
but fix it fast. Good people fix mistakes.

You are the finest fighters in the army.

Do not give up your valor or your zeal.

I would not quarrel with a common man  
who quit the battlefield. But you are noble,  
so I am furious with you. You weaklings!

150

120 Your cowardice will soon make things much worse.

Each of you must implant deep in your heart  
a sense of shame and fear of blame. The danger  
is very great. Their loud, ferocious leader,  
Hector, is making war beside our ships.  
He broke the bar and burst right through our gates.”

With this, the god who wraps around the world  
ordered the Greeks to fight. Beside their leaders,  
Ajax and Ajax, they formed strong battalions—  
so fierce that Ares or the rabble-rouser,  
Athena, would have praised their fine formation.

160

To face the Trojans and their leader, Hector,  
the finest handpicked warriors stood firm,  
130 forming a barricade of shield on shield,  
a fence of spear by spear and hide by hide,  
and helmet next to helmet, man by man.  
The fighters stood so close that when they moved,



their shining, crested helmets touched each other.  
One line of spears was layered on another,  
brandished in warlike hands. The fighters focused  
forward and longed to fight. The crowd of Trojans  
attacked with Hector always in the lead.

170

He pushed ahead, as when torrential rain  
dislodges the foundations of a stone,  
and from up high upon the rocky clifftop  
the river, swollen with the rainstorm, thrusts  
140 the shameless stone, which skips and leaps and flies—  
the woods resound around it, and it runs  
unstoppably on down and down, until  
it reaches level ground and spins no more,  
for all its eagerness to keep on moving—  
such was the threat that Hector posed. At first,  
it seemed that he would rush right through the camp  
and past the Greek ships, killing everyone,  
and reach the sea. But when he met the ranks  
of densely packed battalions, he stopped short.  
The sons of Greece, with swords and curving spears,  
thrust him away, and shaken, he drew back.  
But then he raised his voice and called the Trojans,

180

“Now Trojans, Lycians, and Dardanian fighters,  
150 stand firm! The Greeks will not stop me for long,  
despite their tight formation, like a wall.  
My spear will force them to retreat, I think,  
if it is true that I have been inspired  
by Zeus, the spouse of Hera, god of thunder,  
the best of gods.”

190

These words from Hector roused  
courage and will to fight in every heart.  
Deiphobus, a son of Priam, rushed  
ahead with confidence. He held his shield  
balanced in front of him and tiptoed lightly,  
crouching behind it. But Meriones  
160 took aim and hurled his shining spear at him,  
and did not miss—he hit his oxhide shield,

200

and yet the weapon did not pierce right through.  
It shattered at the shaft. Deiphobus  
threw down his oxhide shield—his heart was frightened  
of skilled Meriones and of his spear.  
Meriones drew back and joined his comrades,  
extremely angry about both his losses—  
the lack of victory and the broken spear.  
Back through the tents and ships he went to fetch  
the spear that he had left inside his hut.  
The others fought—the screaming never ceased.

210

170 Teucer, the son of Telamon, was first  
to kill a man—the spearman Imbrius,  
the son of Mentor, who was rich in horses.  
Pedaeum was the home of Imbrius,  
before the sons of Greece arrived. His wife,  
Medesicaste, was a child of Priam,  
born out of wedlock. When the nimble ships  
arrived from Greece, he left his home for Troy.  
The Trojans held him in the highest honor.  
He lived with Priam—Priam treated him  
like one of his own children. But now Teucer,  
the son of Telamon, drove his long spear  
beneath his ear then out again. He fell—  
as on a mountain peak that can be seen  
for miles around, an ash is cut by bronze—  
180 it falls, and rests its soft leaves on the earth—  
just so, his armor, finely made of bronze,

220

230

clattered around his body as he fell.  
Then Teucer darted up to strip the corpse,  
and Hector hurled his shining spear at him  
but Teucer, as he sprinted, saw the bronze  
hurtling towards him, so he ducked—it missed him,  
narrowly, but it struck Amphinachus,  
the son of Cteatus, the son of Actor,  
as he was running to the battlefront.  
The spear went through his chest. He thudded down.  
His armor rattled round him as he fell.  
Then Hector tried to quickly seize the helmet,  
which fitted snugly on the corpse's head,

240

190 but Ajax with his shining spear struck Hector  
as he was darting up—but failed to reach  
his flesh at all, because it was protected  
with terrifying armor made of bronze.  
He struck the boss of Hector's shield and shoved him  
roughly—he staggered backward and away  
from both the corpses, which the Greeks dragged off.  
Then Stichius and fine Menestheus, 250  
commanders of the troops from Athens, carried  
Amphimachus and laid him where the Greeks  
could care for him. And then the two named Ajax,  
their courage and aggression running high,  
seized Imbrius—as when two lions seize  
a billy goat from a pack of sharp-toothed hounds,  
and through thick undergrowth they carry him  
200 high above ground, clenched tightly in their jaws—  
so did the pair of warriors named Ajax  
carry the corpse of Imbrius up high, 260  
and then they stripped the armor off his body.  
Oilean Ajax sliced through his soft neck  
and cut his head off, because he was angry  
about Amphimachus. He swung and pitched  
the head across the crowd, just like a ball.  
It landed in the dust at Hector's feet.  
Poseidon's heart was also full of rage  
about his grandson's death in bitter battle.  
He went among the ships and tents and urged  
the Greeks to fight and brought the Trojans trouble. 270  
210 And Idomeneus, the famous spearman,  
had just been taking someone to the doctors—  
a friend who had been wounded in his knee  
by piercing bronze and carried from the battle  
by his companions. Idomeneus  
went to his tent to arm. He was still eager  
to fight. And there the mighty god Poseidon,  
the god of earthquakes, spoke to him and sounded  
like Thoas, son of Andraemon, who ruled  
in all of Pleuron and steep Calydon, 280  
over the people of Aetolia,

who honored him as if he were a god.  
Poseidon said,

220                   “Lord Idomeneus,  
great councillor of Crete, where are the threats  
the sons of Greece once made against the Trojans?”

And Cretan Idomeneus replied,  
“Thoas, as far as I can see, right now  
nobody is at fault or doing wrong.  
We are all highly skilled at war, and no one  
is seized by cowardice or fear, and no one 290  
yields to his doubts and backs away from battle.  
But I suppose this is the will of Zeus,  
almighty son of Cronus, that the Greeks  
should die out here at Troy so far from home  
and lose their names. But, Thoas, you were always  
stalwart in battle, always keen to urge  
the hesitant to forge ahead. So now,  
230 encourage them to fight unceasingly.”

Poseidon, god of earthquakes, answered him,  
“If anybody slackens off today 300  
and fails to fight, Lord Idomeneus,  
I hope he never gets back home from Troy,  
but stays here as a plaything for the dogs.  
Now come, take up your weapons and march forward.  
We have to try to save the situation,  
even if there are only two of us.  
Even the weak fight better as a team,  
and we are valiant and skilled at fighting.”

240                   With this, the god rejoined the human struggle.  
And Idomeneus reached his fine tent, 310  
and put his splendid armor on, and seized  
his pair of throwing spears, and dashed to battle,  
just like a bolt of lightning, which the son  
of Cronus, Zeus, takes in his hand and shakes

from radiant Olympus, as a sign  
for humankind—its rays are dazzling bright.  
So brightly shone the bronze that clothed his chest  
as he ran off to war. Meriones,  
his helpful steward, met him near the tent.  
The man was on his way to fetch a spear.  
And mighty Idomeneus addressed him.

320

250 “Meriones, swift son of Molus, dearest  
of all my comrades, why have you come here  
and left the conflict on the battlefield?  
Have you been badly wounded by a weapon?  
Or did you come to bring some news to me?  
I certainly have no desire to sit  
idle inside my tent. I want to fight.”

Then cautiously Meriones replied,  
“Lord Idomeneus, great councillor  
of all the bronze-clad Cretans, I am going  
to fetch a spear of yours, in case you left one  
inside the hut. I broke the spear I had  
against the shield of proud Deiphobus.”

330

260 The Cretan leader Idomeneus  
said, “If you need a spear, you will find plenty,  
stacked in the hut against the bright white wall—  
twenty or more that I have won at Troy  
from those I killed. You see, I have no wish  
to keep my distance when I fight the foe.  
And so I have collected spears and helmets  
and shields and breastplates shining bright with bronze.”

340

270 Canny Meriones replied, “I also  
have heaps of spoil I looted from the Trojans  
beside my black ship and my hut—too far  
for me to get them. I am certainly  
no coward, I assure you. I stand firm  
among the fighters at the very front

when men are winning glory in a battle,  
whenever any conflict has arisen.  
There may be other bronze-clad Greeks, perhaps,  
who do not know how I behave in war.  
But you have surely seen me fight yourself!”

350

The Cretan leader Idomeneus  
answered him, “Yes, I know how brave you are.  
Why do you need to talk to me about it?  
If, from the finest fighters by the ships  
we were selected right now for an ambush—  
the clearest test of courage, which reveals  
which man is cowardly, and which is brave—  
the coward’s color turns from flushed to pale,  
and he cannot control his inmost feelings—  
he squats and hops from foot to foot—his heart  
pounds in his chest as he imagines death—  
his teeth are loudly chattering—meanwhile,  
the brave man never changes in his color,  
and never feels excessively afraid  
when he first joins the ambush with his comrades—  
he prays to be immersed in dreadful fighting  
as soon as possible—not even then,  
if you were chosen for an ambush now,  
would anybody criticize your courage  
or doubt your hands’ ability to fight.  
While you are working on the battlefield,  
no blow or wound would strike behind your neck  
or hit you on your back. You would be struck  
upon your chest or belly as you charge  
forward among the fighters in the front.  
Come on now, we should not just stand here chatting  
like little children—or else maybe someone  
might scold us harshly. Go inside the tent  
and fetch a mighty spear.”

360

370

380

Meriones,  
who was as swift as Ares, quickly dashed  
inside the tent and fetched a spear of bronze,

then eager for the battlefield, he joined  
Lord Idomeneus. He looked like Ares,  
the god who ruins human lives, who goes  
to war along with his beloved son,  
indomitable Flight, who causes fear  
in even the most valiant of fighters.

300

390

That pair of gods march fully armed from Thrace  
to join the Ephyri or brave Phlegyaë,  
heeding the prayers of one side, never both—  
they only give the victory to one.

Meriones and Idomeneus,  
leaders of men, looked like this pair of gods,  
rushing to war bedecked in shining bronze.  
And then Meriones spoke up and asked,

“Lord Idomeneus, Deucalion’s son,  
where do you want to join the battle throng?

400

The right side, or the middle of the army,  
or on the left, which is the place, I think,  
the long-haired Greeks are weakest in the fighting?”

310

And Idomeneus, the Cretan leader,  
answered, “Around the middle of the fleet  
others are putting up a good defense—  
the pair of warriors, Ajax and Ajax,  
and Teucer, who is best of all the Greeks  
at archery and also strong in combat.

Those three will drive the son of Priam, Hector,  
till he is sick of war, however brave,  
however strong and eager he may be.

410

However ardently he longs to fight,  
it will be difficult for him to win  
against the forceful hands of those three fighters,  
or burn our ships—except if Zeus himself  
tosses a flaming brand on our swift fleet.

320

Great Telamonian Ajax can defeat  
anyone mortal, anyone who eats  
Demeter’s grain, or can be crushed by bronze  
or broken by great rocks—and he would even

420

defeat Achilles, who cracks men apart,  
if they were in a combat close at hand,  
though nobody runs faster than Achilles.  
So we should head towards the left of battle,  
and soon find out if we can win some glory  
or if somebody else will conquer us.”

At this Meriones went first and hurried  
as fast as Ares to the battlefield,  
towards the left side, as his friend had said.

430

330 The Trojans, seeing Idomeneus  
arrive with force and courage like a flame—  
along with his companion, arms ablaze—  
shouted to one another through the throng,  
and all at once advanced on him. They fought  
closely together by the ships’ black sterns.  
As when the dust lies thickest on the roads,  
a day when gusts of piercing wind amass  
a huge dust-cloud—so massed the throng of fighters,  
desperately yearning in their hearts to gather

440

The deadly conflict bristled with long spears,  
340 held to slice flesh. Eyes dazzled at the gleam  
of shining helmets, freshly polished breastplates,  
and glimmering shields, as all of them collided.

Only a person with the toughest heart  
could look at so much suffering with joy  
rather than sorrow. So the two strong sons  
of Cronus disagreed and caused great pain  
to human warriors. Zeus wished to give

450

victory to Hector and the Trojan people,  
and glory to swift-footed Lord Achilles.  
He did not want the whole Greek army slaughtered  
in front of Troy, but meant to magnify

350 Thetis and her courageous son. Meanwhile,  
Poseidon rose in secret from the sea  
and went among the Greeks to urge them on,  
because he was so troubled they were losing,  
and that the Trojans had the upper hand,



and he was furious with Zeus. These two  
had shared their parentage and native land,  
but Zeus was older and he knew much more.  
So Lord Poseidon would not help the Greeks  
openly. He went in among the troops  
secretly, in the semblance of a man.

460

These two gods tugged the rope of cruel conflict,  
pulling it tight to one side and the other.

360 This rope, which could not be untied or broken,  
untied the limbs of many living men.

Though he was half gray, Idomeneus  
summoned the Greeks to come with him and leapt  
among the Trojans, forcing them to flee.

470

He slaughtered Othryoneus, who had  
only just heard the news about the war,  
and come from Cabetes to Troy. He sought  
Cassandra, Priam's daughter, as his bride—  
the loveliest of all of them. He brought  
no bridal gifts, but swore he would perform  
a mighty deed to win her hand—to drive  
the Greeks away from Troy against their will.

480

370 Old Priam promised with a solemn nod  
that he would give his daughter to this boy.  
Trusting these promises, he rushed to fight  
and skipped towards the battlefield and met  
Lord Idomeneus with his bright spear,  
who aimed at him and struck. The boy was wearing  
a breastplate made of bronze, which did no good.  
The spear pierced through the middle of his belly.  
His armor clattered round him as he fell.

Triumphant Idomeneus declared,

490

“Congratulations, Othryoneus!  
You certainly must be the very best,  
better than any other mortal man,  
if you are really going to keep your word  
and do exactly what you promised Priam.  
He promised you his daughter. And in fact,  
we Greeks would promise and provide the same—

the loveliest of Agamemnon's daughters,  
whom we will fetch from Argos and give you  
to marry, if you sack this town for us,  
the strong, majestic citadel of Troy.

500

Now follow me to our swift seaborne ships,  
so we can make arrangements for your marriage.  
We Greeks are good at welcoming our in-laws."

With these words, mighty Idomeneus  
dragged him across the battle by the leg.  
Asius came on foot to help the boy,  
running, his horses galloping behind him,  
constantly huffing at his back. His driver  
was hoping in his heart to strike the Cretan.

510

Great Idomeneus struck first and speared  
Asius underneath his chin and drove  
the bronze right through his neck and made him fall—  
just as an oak tree or a poplar falls,

or stately pine, which workers on the mountains  
cut down with newly whetted, sharpened axes  
to make the timber for a ship—just so,  
he lay before the chariot and horses,  
screaming and clutching at the bloody dust.

The driver, struck with terror, lost his wits,  
and did not dare to turn the horses round  
so that he might escape the enemy.

520

Stalwart Antilochus attacked and drove  
his spear right through the middle of this man.  
He wore a breastplate made of bronze, which failed  
to help him, and the spear transfixed his belly.  
Gasping, he tumbled from the chariot.

Antilochus, the son of noble Nestor,  
herded the horses from the Trojan side  
and drove them to the well-armed Greeks. Meanwhile,  
Deiphobus, enraged about the killing  
of Asius, approached and hurled his spear  
at mighty Idomeneus—but missed,  
because the Cretan saw the weapon coming  
and ducked behind his rounded, balanced shield

530

of oxhide leather covered with bright bronze,  
in spirals, with two cross-straps set inside.  
He crouched and hid himself completely under.  
The bronze spear flew above the shield and grazed it,  
harshly resounding as the metals clashed.

540

410 And yet the firm hand of Deiphobus,  
which hurled this spear, had not done so in vain.  
It hit Hypsenor, shepherd of the people,  
the son of Hippasus, beneath the midriff  
and pierced his liver and at once he died.  
Deiphobus was thrilled and shouted loudly,

“The death of Asius has been avenged!  
I tell you, as he travels down to Hades,  
into the kingdom where the gates shut fast,  
he will be happy in his heart, because  
I gave him someone else to guide his way.”

550

These boasts were agonizing to the Greeks,  
especially to Antilochus, whose heart  
was stirred by grief. But even in his sorrow,  
he still remembered to protect his comrade.  
He ran to him and stood astride his body  
420 and used his shield to cover him, and two  
loyal companions stooped to pick him up—  
Mecisteus, the son of Echius,  
and glorious Acastor. Those two brought him  
back to the hollow ships. He groaned in pain.  
Great Idomeneus did not stop fighting.  
He always yearned, with never-ending zeal,  
to wrap some Trojan in the black of night,  
or clatter to the ground in the attempt  
to save the Greeks from ruin. Then he met  
the loving son of Lord Aesyetes,  
the warrior Alcathous, who had  
married the eldest daughter of Anchises,  
430 Hippodamia, whom her parents loved  
because in beauty, attitude, and skill  
she was the best of all the girls her age,

560

570

and so the finest man in spacious Troy  
had married her. But then Poseidon crushed him  
beneath the hands of Idomeneus.

The god beguiled his shining eyes and bound  
his shining body so he could not move  
to run away or duck. He stood stock-still  
as if he were a pillar or tall tree,  
and through his middle, Idomeneus  
stabbed with his spear and broke his shirt of bronze,  
worn to protect his chest from death. It shattered,  
the metal screeching harshly at the blow.  
He fell, his armor clattering around him.  
The spear was planted deeply in his heart,  
which throbbed and made the wooden shaft vibrate,  
until strong Ares took away its power.  
In triumph Idomeneus cried out,

580

“Deiphobus, is it enough for us  
that we have slaughtered three men for your one?  
That was the kind of boast you made. But come,  
stand here and face me for yourself, and see  
that I have come to Troy as a descendant  
of Zeus, who fathered Minos, the protector  
of Crete. This Minos had a noble son,  
Deucalion, my father, and I rule  
numerous people there in spacious Crete.  
My ships have brought me here to bring disaster  
to you, your father, and the other Trojans.”

590

At this, Deiphobus was of two minds.  
Should he withdraw and search for a companion,  
one of the valiant Trojans? Or attempt  
to fight all by himself? As he considered,  
this plan seemed best to him—to go and find  
Aeneas, who was standing at the back,  
behind the other troops, because he felt  
angry with Priam, who had failed to show him  
respect, despite his courage on the field.  
Deiphobus approached and spoke winged words.

600

“Aeneas, lord and councillor of Troy,  
now is the time that you must save your kinsman,  
your sister’s husband, if you care at all.  
Come with me and protect Alcatous,  
who is your family and cared for you  
when you were very young inside your house.  
Now Idomeneus, the famous spearman,  
has slaughtered him.”

610

These words aroused the will  
inside the heart and body of Aeneas,  
and with enormous zeal for war he rushed  
at Idomeneus—who felt no fear,  
no urge to run off like a pampered child.  
He stood his ground, as when upon the mountains  
where humans rarely go, a lonely place,  
a wild boar meets a band of many hunters—  
remaining confident of his own strength  
he stands his ground—along his back, he bristles,  
his eyes shine bright as fire, he whets his tusks,  
eager to drive the men and hounds away—  
just so the fighter Idomeneus  
stood firm and did not waver when Aeneas  
rushed up to rescue and avenge his kinsman.  
Lord Idomeneus cried out to summon  
his comrades, looking to Ascalaphus,  
Aphareus, Deipyrus, and those  
who led the battle cry—Antilochus  
and fine Meriones. He spoke to them  
with words on wings to urge them into battle.

620

630

“Come here and help me, friends! I am alone,  
and endlessly afraid of swift Aeneas,  
running towards me. He is very strong  
and very good at killing men in battle,  
and still retains the bloom of youth, when strength  
is greatest. If I were as young as he is,  
and felt the same as I do now, then surely  
one of us soon would win a mighty triumph

640

over the other in a fight.”

At this,

with hearts as one, they all stood close together,  
their shields against their shoulders. Facing them,  
Aeneas called his friends, the Trojan leaders—  
490 Paris, Deiphobus, and fine Agenor. 650  
The troops came after, just like sheep who follow  
a ram from pasture to the watering place—  
the shepherd is delighted in his heart—  
just so Aeneas felt deep joy and gladness  
to see the mass of people follow him.  
Around Alcatraz the armies fought  
closely together with their polished spears.  
The bronze clashed horribly around their chests,  
as everybody in the throng attacked.  
Two fighters were the fiercest of them all— 660  
500 Lord Idomeneus and great Aeneas,  
equals of Ares. Each was keen to slice  
into the other’s flesh with cruel bronze.  
Aeneas first struck Idomeneus,  
who saw the bronze spear coming and ducked down.  
Aeneas hurled it from his sturdy hand  
in vain. It stuck and quivered in the earth.  
Lord Idomeneus struck Oenomaus—  
he broke his breastplate and pierced through his belly.  
The bronze spear poured the man’s intestines out. 670  
Down in the dust he fell and clawed the earth.  
Lord Idomeneus pulled his long spear  
out of the corpse, but could not strip the armor,  
510 the fine equipment on the dead man’s back,  
because he was exhausted by the weapons.  
His feet had lost the strength they used to have  
for rushing forward to attack and darting  
to fetch his spear and then sprint back again.  
He could no longer swiftly run from battle,  
but in close combat he could ward away 680  
the day of doom. But as he tiptoed back,  
Deiphobus took aim with his bright spear,

because he was still furious with him.

But yet again he missed him and instead  
his heavy spear impaled Ascalaphus,  
son of the war god, Enyalius.

520 It pierced right through his shoulder, and he fell  
down in the dust and clawed the earth. But Ares,  
the mighty, loud-voiced god, did not yet know  
his son had fallen in the fervent fighting.

690

He was confined on top of Mount Olympus  
beneath the golden clouds. The plans of Zeus  
kept him and all the other deathless gods  
away from battle. Now the humans fought  
closely together round Ascalaphus.

Deiphobus pulled off his shining helmet—  
Meriones, as swift as Ares, leapt  
onto Deiphobus and speared his arm—  
the helmet, set with plumes and visor, fell  
530 out of his hand and clattered on the ground.

700

And then Meriones again plunged forward,  
just like a bearded vulture on his prey,  
and pulled the heavy weapon from the arm,  
then darted back among his group of comrades.

The brother of Deiphobus, Polites,  
held him around the waist and helped him hobble  
away from all the ghastly noise of battle  
and combat to rejoin his own swift horses  
and decorated chariot and driver.

They took the wounded warrior to Troy  
moaning in agony. The blood was gushing  
out of his freshly injured arm. The others  
540 fought, and their screams and cries were never-ending.

710

Aeneas struck the son of Caletor,  
Aphareus, who had been turned to face him.  
The sharp spear pierced his throat. His head tipped backward.  
His shield and helmet fell on top of him,  
and death that breaks the spirit washed around him.

Antilochus had had his eye on Thoon,  
and pounced upon him when he turned away  
and sliced away the whole vein running up

720

the back, that reaches to the neck. He fell,  
face upward in the dust, with both his arms  
stretched out towards his loving friends. But then  
550 Antilochus jumped on him and stripped off  
his armor, keeping close watch as he did so.  
The Trojans had surrounded him, and tried  
stabbing with sharp bronze spears from all directions,  
aiming to pierce his broad and shining shield,  
but none of them could touch the man's soft flesh.

730

Even amid the multitude of weapons,  
Poseidon, god of earthquakes, was protecting  
the son of Nestor. Enemies assailed him  
constantly, but he whirled around among them.  
His spear was always moving, never still.  
He shook and turned it, pointing it, intending  
either to throw or thrust it at a foe.

560 But as he aimed it through the throng of fighters,  
the son of Asius, fine Adamas,  
noticed him and attacked from near at hand.

740

The sharp bronze struck the center of the shield,  
feebly. Its force was weakened by Poseidon.  
The blue-haired god would not allow the Trojan  
to kill the Greek, so half his spear stayed there,  
stuck, like a fire-charred thistle, to the shield,  
and half the spear was lying on the ground.  
Dismayed, he drew back to his group of comrades,  
but as he backed away, Meriones  
pursued, and struck him with his spear and pierced  
his navel, piercing through his genitals—  
the worst affliction that the war god gives  
to poor, unhappy mortals. In that spot  
Meriones stabbed Adamas, then tugged  
the weapon out again, as he was gasping.

750

570 The dying man was pulled back like an ox  
whom herdsmen on the mountains tie with twine  
and force to follow them against his will—  
so Adamas was gasping for a while  
after the blow was struck, but not for long,  
and then the warrior Meriones

760



came near and pulled the weapon from his flesh,  
and darkness veiled his eyes. Then Helenus,  
from close at hand, with his big Thracian spear,  
stabbed through the forehead of Deipyrus.  
His helmet broke and fell upon the ground  
and rolled beneath the fighters' feet—some Greek  
580 collected it and black night veiled his sight.

Then sorrow seized the son of Atreus,  
the master of the war cry, Menelaus.

He threatened Helenus with his sharp spear,  
and Helenus began to draw his bow.

Both aimed at once, one poised to hurl his spear,  
one with an arrow ready on the string.

And Helenus, the son of Priam, struck  
his target's plated corselet, on his chest.

But then the deadly arrow bounced right off.

As chickpeas or black beans jump off a shovel  
in some large threshing floor, tossed by the breeze  
590 and by the force and effort of the thresher—

just so the arrow bounced right off the breastplate  
of Menelaus, master of the war cry—

who struck the hand of Helenus, the one

holding the polished bow. The spear transfixed  
his hand and bow together, and in pain

he drew back to his group of comrades, dangling  
his arm beside him, with the ash-wood spear

still trailing from it. Brave Agenor pulled  
the weapon from the injured hand and bound it,

using a finely twisted sheep's wool sling

600 belonging to his servant. Then Pisander

dashed straight at Menelaus. Evil fate

was leading him towards his end, his death,

defeated in the bitter strife by you,

Lord Menelaus. When these two came close,

the son of Atreus, fine Menelaus,

missed, as his spear was turned aside. Pisander

thrust at the shield of noble Menelaus,

but could not drive the bronze right through. The shield

held firm against it, and the spear's tip broke.

770

780

790

And yet Pisander's heart was very glad,  
 believing he would win. But Menelaus  
 610 drew out his silver-studded sword and leapt  
 onto Pisander, and Pisander drew  
 a fine bronze axe, which had an olive handle,  
 out from behind his shield, and so they fought.  
 Pisander hacked at his opponent's helmet,  
 and struck the very top part of the crest,  
 beside the horsehair plume. But as Pisander  
 lunged forward, Menelaus stabbed his forehead  
 above his nose, right at the bridge, and broke  
 his skull, and popped his eyeballs out. All bloody,  
 they fell into the dust beside his feet.  
 Pisander doubled over and collapsed.  
 Then Menelaus, stomping on his chest,  
 stripped off his arms and triumphed over him.

810

620 "So this is how you high and mighty Trojans  
 will leave our ships! You never get enough  
 of terrifying war, which makes men scream!  
 You have no lack of shame or disrespect,  
 as when you injured me so shamefully,  
 you wicked she-dogs! Your hearts felt no fear  
 of ruinous wrath from Zeus, the god of thunder,  
 the god of hospitality! One day  
 surely he will destroy your lofty town.  
 You stole my lawful wife away from me,  
 and also took a large amount of treasure,  
 quite unprovoked, when she had given you  
 a loving welcome. Now you strive to set  
 our seaborne ships on fire and kill us all.  
 630 Eventually you will be stopped, despite  
 your zeal for Ares. Father Zeus, they say  
 you are the wisest of the gods and wiser  
 than any human—but you caused all this!  
 You show such favor to these arrogant people,  
 the Trojans, who are willful, uncontrolled,  
 and cannot sate their appetite for war.  
 A person can get tired of anything—

820

830

of sleep, of sex, of dancing, of sweet song,  
far better objects of desire than war.  
But Trojans are insatiable for battle.”

840

640 With these words, noble Menelaus stripped  
the bloody armor from the corpse and gave them  
to his companions. He himself went back  
and mingled with the fighters at the front.  
Harpalion, the son of Pylaemenes,  
who followed his dear father to the war,  
but would not ever go back home again,  
leapt towards Menelaus. With his spear  
he struck the middle of his shield, but failed  
to drive the bronze right through it. In distress,  
Harpalion slunk back towards his comrades,  
carefully glancing all around, in case  
some enemy might wound his skin with bronze.  
650 But as he moved away, Meriones  
struck his right buttock with a bronze-tipped arrow,  
which pierced below the bone and through the bladder.  
He slumped there, seated, and his loving comrades  
embraced him in their arms as he was breathing  
his life out. Then he lay down on the ground,  
stretched out, wormlike, and black blood poured from him  
and drenched the earth. And his brave-hearted comrades,  
the Paphlagonians, took care of him,  
and propped him in a chariot and took him  
to holy Troy, and all of them were grieving.  
Among them was his father, shedding tears  
because he could demand no compensation  
for his dead son. And Paris was enraged  
660 about the killing of Harpalion,  
since he had visited the many men  
of Paphlagonia, so he had been  
a guest-friend of Harpalion. In anger,  
he shot a bronze-tipped arrow at his killer.  
But there was someone named Euchenor there,  
son of the soothsayer, Polyidus,  
a wealthy, well-born man, who lived in Corinth.

850

860

870

Euchenor sailed in his fine ship to Troy  
knowing that it would mean his death. His father,  
noble Polyidus, had often said

that he would either waste away at home  
and die of painful illness, or sail off,

880

joining the other Greeks who went to Troy,  
and there be killed. So he chose not to suffer  
the cruel sickness, which would hurt his heart,  
and not to have to pay the Greeks' steep fine.

670

But Paris struck him underneath his ear,  
below the jaw, and then immediately  
life left his limbs, and hateful darkness took him.  
So both sides fought like blazing fire. But Hector,  
the favorite of Zeus, did not yet know

that on the left side of the ships, his people  
were losing to the Greeks, who would soon win  
a victory, because the god of earthquakes,  
the god who wraps around the world, Poseidon,  
inspired and strengthened and protected them.

890

Hector kept driving forward from the place  
where he had jumped across the gates and wall.

680

He broke the close-packed lines of Greeks with shields,  
and reached the ships brought by Protesilaus  
and those of Ajax, which were all drawn up  
along the shore, beside the gray salt sea.

900

The wall above these ships was very low,  
and there the men and horses fought most fiercely.

There the Boeotians, the Ionians  
in trailing tunics, and the Locrians,  
the Phthians and the glittering Epeans  
were fighting Hector, who was like a flame,  
and they could barely keep him from the ships.

They could not stop him from attacking them.  
The finest men of Athens fought with him.

Among them was Menestheus, the son

910

690

of Peteos, and following behind him,  
Phidas and Stichius and sturdy Bias.

The lords of the Epeans were great Meges,  
the son of Phyleus, and Amphion,

and Dracius. And to lead the men from Phthia  
were Medon and the valiant Podarces.

This Medon was a half brother of Ajax,  
born out of wedlock to Oileus.

But Medon lived in Phylace—he left  
his father's lands because he killed a man,  
a kinsman of Eriopis, the woman  
Oileus had taken as a wife.

920

Podarces was the son of Iphiclus,  
the son of Phylacus. Bedecked in armor,  
the leaders of the noble men from Phthia,  
along with the Boeotians, fought to save  
the ships. And from that moment on, swift Ajax,  
son of Oileus, kept standing near

700

the other Ajax, son of Telamon,  
and would not leave him even for a moment—  
as when a pair of wine-dark oxen strain  
to pull a plow across a fallow field,  
working with one accord—sweat bubbles up  
around the bottom of their horns—they work  
together all the way along the furrow,  
a team just separated by the yoke,  
and cut the field until they reach the headland—  
so those two men kept close to one another.

930

And Telamonian Ajax was the leader  
of many brave companions, who would take  
his shield and carry it for him, whenever  
sweat and exhaustion overcame his legs.

940

Oilean Ajax had no followers—  
the Locrians would not withstand close combat.  
They had no spears of ash, no rounded shields,  
and no bronze-plated helmets set with crests.  
But they had come to Troy with Ajax, trusting  
their bows and slings of twisted wool, with which  
they showered blows upon the Trojan lines  
and broke them. So the first group marched in front,  
and fought with bright-helmed Hector and the Trojans  
with well-wrought weapons, while the other group  
snuck up behind and made surprise attacks.

950

720

The Trojans lost their zeal for war—the arrows  
caused them to panic, and they would have run  
back from the ships and tents to windy Troy,  
in desperation, if Polydamas  
had not approached brave Hector, saying,

“Hector,  
you are impossible! You never listen!  
Some god has granted you great skill in battle,  
and so you also want to be the best  
at strategy. You cannot have it all!

960

730 A god gives one man skill to fight in war,  
another may be talented at dancing,  
another good at singing and the lyre,  
and in another’s heart, farsighted Zeus  
places good judgment, which can help and save  
numerous people, and the man himself  
best knows his own insightfulness. And now  
I tell you what I think we need to do.

970

The ring of battle blazes all around you,  
and now that we have crossed the wall, some Trojans,  
despite their courage and their arms, hang back,  
and those of us who fight against the Greeks  
are scattered thin among their ships, outnumbered.

740 Fall back and call the finest fighters here,  
and then we must discuss our course of action—  
whether we should attack their splendid galleys,  
and hope some god will grant success to us,  
or go back home while we are still uninjured.

980

I fear the Greeks may make us pay the debt  
of yesterday. Beside these ships there is  
a man whose thirst for war is never sated,  
and I do not believe that he will stay  
completely out of battle any longer.”

So spoke Polydamas. His words pleased Hector,  
and right away he jumped with all his weapons  
out of his chariot and let words fly.

750

“Polydamas, keep all the best men here,  
and I will go towards the battlefront,  
and give instructions to the men out there,  
and soon I will be back.”

990

So Hector spoke,  
and like a snowy mountain, he strode off,  
shouting as he went flying through the crowd  
of Trojans and their allies. When they heard  
the voice of Hector, everybody rushed  
towards the friendly son of Panthous,  
Polydamas. And meanwhile, Hector ranged  
among the champion fighters. He was seeking  
Deiphobus and Adamas, the son  
of Asius, and Asius, the son  
of Hyrtacus, and noble Helenus.

1000

He found them all, but they had not remained  
immune from injuries or casualties.  
Some lay beside the ships' sterns, having lost  
their lives at Greek hands. Others had been stabbed  
or wounded on the wall. And soon he found,  
towards the left side of the painful battle,  
Paris, the husband of fine-braided Helen,  
coaxing his comrades to the fight. And Hector  
stood near and spoke to him with words of shame.

1010

“ Pathetic Paris! Womanizer! Cheat!  
You are the very best at looking pretty!  
Where are Deiphobus and Helenus  
and Adamas, the son of Asius,  
and Asius the son of Hyrtacus?  
And where is Othryoneus? Tall Troy  
is totally destroyed from top to bottom!  
Now certainly your death is guaranteed!”

And godlike Paris answered, “You are wrong  
to blame me, Hector. Sometimes in the past  
perhaps I tended to hold back from war.

1020

But I was certainly not born a coward.  
Our mother gave me birth to be a hero,  
and since the time you roused our men to fight  
beside these ships, we have remained right here,  
engaged in constant conflict with the Greeks.

780 The men you ask about have all been killed  
except Deiphobus and Helenus.

Long spears struck both, but in the arm and hand—  
they left the battle and Zeus saved their lives.

1030

Now lead us onward where your heart commands,  
and we will gladly follow you. I promise  
that we will show no lack of martial valor  
as long as we have strength. No man can fight  
beyond his strength, however fierce he is.”

With these words, Paris changed his brother’s mind.

They went to where the fighting and the battle  
was most intense, around Cebriones,

790 noble Polydamas, Phalces, Orthaeus,  
Palmus, and Polyphetes, who was godlike,  
and also Morus and Ascanius,

1040

the sons of Lord Hippotion, who had come  
from rich Ascania the day before,  
when Zeus had stirred them up to fight in Troy,  
and serve as troop replacements for the dead.

Onward they surged—like bitter winds, a tempest,  
surging towards the shore beneath the rumble  
of thunder sent by father Zeus—the noise

is terrifying as the hurricane

1050

commingles with the water, and the waves  
are flecked with bright white foam, and more and more  
curve upward from the loud-resounding sea  
and crash—one breaks, another, and another—

800 just so the Trojans, joining close together,  
pushed forward, line by line, behind their leaders  
all glittering with bronze. Their foremost fighter  
was Hector, son of Priam, who resembled  
Ares, the ruin of humanity.

Great Hector held his shield in front of him—

1060



a finely balanced, rounded shield, made firm  
with strips of leather and a thick bronze coating.  
His shining helmet sparkled on his head.  
He strode around behind his shield and tested  
the lines of Greeks in every area  
to see if they would yield to him. But still  
the Greeks held firm. Their hearts were not dismayed.  
Then Ajax marched ahead and challenged Hector.

810 “Come nearer, sir! Why do you try so hard  
to scare the Greeks? It is a waste of time. 1070  
We do not lack experience of battle.  
It is the whip of Zeus that brought us down.  
Presumably you think you can destroy  
our ships. But we have hands enough to save them,  
and long before you manage anything,  
our hands will capture Troy, your well-built city,  
and tear it down. And as for you, I tell you,  
soon you will flee and pray to father Zeus  
for fine-maned stallions to carry you  
faster than falcons from the plain to town, 1080  
820 kicking the dust beneath their galloping hooves.”

As he was saying this, upon the right  
an eagle flew up high. The Greeks, emboldened,  
shouted in gladness at the bird, the sign.  
But noble Hector, glittering in bronze,  
answered him,

“Ajax, you are such a peasant!  
Your words are always wrong. A stupid speech!  
If only I could be a son of Zeus,  
the god who bears the goatskin, and if only  
the queen of heaven, Hera, were my mother, 1090  
and all my life I could receive such glory  
as great Athena and Apollo have,  
as surely as this very day will bring  
trouble for all the Greeks, especially you!

Among your people you will die today,  
if you are brave enough to stand and face  
my long spear, which will feast and have a banquet  
upon your lily skin, and you will feed  
the dogs and birds of Troy with fat and flesh  
when you have fallen dead beside your ships.”

With these words, Hector led his people forward.  
They followed with a terrifying roar,  
and all the troops who marched behind him shouted.  
And on the other side, the Greeks responded  
with roars and shouts. They had not lost their courage.  
They stood their ground against the Trojan champions,  
advancing, and the noise from both the armies  
rose up towards the shining rays of Zeus.

## BOOK 14



### An Afternoon Nap

Nestor was drinking, but he heard the noise,  
and let his words take wing. He said,

“Machaon,  
what do you think is happening? The shout  
of fighters by the ships is growing louder.  
You should sit here and drink the bright red wine,  
till Hecamede with the well-coiled braids  
heats up a bath for you and washes off  
the blood and gore, while I must hurry out  
to find a place where I can see the action.”

With this, he took the well-constructed shield  
of shining bronze that horse-lord Thrasymedes,  
his son, had left there when he took his father's.  
And Nestor also took a bronze-tipped spear,  
and stood outside the hut, and soon he saw  
the whole humiliating situation—  
the Greeks in panic, trying to escape,  
the dauntless Trojans chasing after them.

The wall the Greeks had built was broken down.  
As when the deep sea swells with silent waves  
and surges, seeking out the sudden courses  
of whistling winds, but stays in place for now,  
not rolling forward nor retreating back—  
20 so Nestor was divided in his mind,  
unsure if he should go and join the crowd  
of Greeks, who trained swift horses, or go find  
the son of Atreus, the people's shepherd.  
When he had thought about it, he decided  
it would be best to go to Agamemnon.  
The fighters went on killing one another.  
30 Their armor made of bronze that never wearied  
clattered around their bodies as the men  
struck one another with their swords and spears.  
Then the divinely favored rulers met  
Nestor as they were coming from their ships—  
the son of Atreus, Lord Agamemnon,  
and Diomedes and Odysseus,  
the three who had been injured by sharp bronze,  
30 who moored their ships a long way from the battle  
upon the shore, beside the salty sea.  
These were the first ships dragged towards the plain,  
40 and at their sterns, the Greeks had built the wall.  
The beach was large and yet could not contain  
the quantity of ships—the troops were crowded.  
They lined the ships up row by row, and filled  
the whole long shore along the bay—the mouth  
contained between the headlands at each end.  
So now the three of them arrived together,  
limping with spears as crutches, to find out  
about the war and conflict, and their hearts  
were full of grief. The old man, Nestor, met them.  
40 They were dismayed to see him. Agamemnon  
addressed him.

“Nestor, son of Neleus,  
pride of the Greeks, why have you come here, leaving  
the deadly battlefield? I am afraid

that mighty Hector may have kept his word.  
He threatened in the council of the Trojans  
that he would stay beside the ships, and not  
return to Troy until he burned the fleet  
and killed the Greeks. That man said this, and now  
all of his threats are coming to fruition.  
Disastrous! Now the other well-armed Greeks  
are struck with rage against me in their hearts,  
just like Achilles! They refuse to fight  
beside our ships' sterns."

60

And Gerenian Nestor,  
the lord of horses, answered him, "Indeed,  
these things are very near at hand, and Zeus,  
the god who thunders from on high, could not  
construct a different plan. The wall is ruined—  
the wall we thought would be unbreakable,  
the wall we trusted to protect our ships  
and save our own lives. Now our enemies  
make war unstoppably beside our ships.  
However hard you looked, you could not tell  
the source or the direction of the rout—  
the panic of the Greeks is so intense,  
the slaughter so haphazard, so extensive.  
Their cries rise upward to the sky. We must  
think of a way to help our friends in danger.  
But I do not suggest that we rejoin  
the battle. Injured people cannot fight."

70

Then Agamemnon, lord of men, replied,  
"Nestor, the Trojans fight beside our ships.  
The wall and ditch we built have done no good,  
although the Greeks endured so much for them,  
and hoped with all their hearts the wall would stand  
unbroken, to defend both ships and men.  
But I suppose almighty Zeus decided  
we Greeks should die here, far away from Greece,  
and lose our names. I knew it even when  
the god was kind to us and kept us safe.

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90

I know it now, when he is glorifying  
our enemies and blessing them like gods,  
binding our hands and limiting our power.  
Come on then, everyone, do as I say.  
We need to drag the ships that are arranged  
the nearest to the sea, the first in line,  
into the shining water. Moor them there  
with anchor-stones and let them float, until  
the holy night arrives, and then the Trojans  
may pause the battle. Then we can drag down  
the other ships and launch them all to sea.  
80 There is no shame in fleeing from disaster,  
even by night. You see, when things go wrong,  
escape is better than captivity.”

100

Odysseus, the master strategist,  
scowled as he answered him. “Lord Agamemnon,  
what have you said? What words have now escaped  
out of your mouth and past your fence of teeth?  
Curse you! I wish you led some other army,  
a low, dishonorable one, not ours.

110

Great Zeus has granted us, from youth to age,  
a life that loops from war to painful war,  
till each of us lies dead. But are you really  
eager to leave the wide-wayed town of Troy,  
for which we have endured so much, so long?

90 Hush! Or some other Greeks may hear these words  
that no man ought to let pass through his mouth—  
no man who knows the proper things to say,  
no man who holds a scepter, and commands  
as many troops as you. What you have said  
is utterly contemptible. You tell us,  
when war and battle are well under way,  
to drag our splendid galleys back to sea,  
and when the Trojans are already winning  
you want to make their every wish come true,  
and let catastrophe descend on us—

120

100 because while we are dragging ships to sea,  
the Greeks will not stay focused on the battle.

Distracted, they will lose their will to fight.  
Your strategy will ruin us, commander.”

130

Then Agamemnon, lord of men, replied,  
“Odysseus, the harshness of your scolding  
touches me deeply, in my very heart.  
I shall not tell the sons of Greece to drag  
the galleys to the sea against their will.  
But now let somebody articulate  
a better plan than mine. I would be glad  
to hear it, from a young or older man.”

Then Diomedes, master of the war cry,  
told them,

110                    “I am the man! We do not need  
to keep on looking round for someone else,  
if you are willing to defer to me,  
without resentment at my tender years,  
because I am the youngest of you all.  
My ancestry is just as good as yours,  
and I am proud to say my noble father  
was Tydeus, now covered by a mound  
of Theban earth. You see, there were three sons  
of Portheus, who made their home in Pleuron  
and rocky Calydon. Their names were Melas,  
120                    Agrias, and the horseman Oeneus,  
my father’s father, bravest of them all.  
Oeneus stayed there in Aetolia,  
but Tydeus, my father, went in exile  
to Argos. I suppose that was the will  
of Zeus and other gods. And there he married  
a daughter of Adrastus, and he had  
a wealthy household, orchards full of trees,  
flourishing fields of wheat, and herds of sheep,  
and with his spear he was the best of all.  
You surely must have heard that this is true.  
So do not say that I am cowardly

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by birth or born a commoner, and do not  
dismiss my ancestry, or disrespect  
the things I say, if I am speaking well.

Despite our injuries, we must return  
to battle. There is nothing else to do.

From now on, we ourselves must keep away  
from combat, out of range of all the missiles,  
so none of us receives a second wound.

But we should join the battle to encourage  
the men who have been holding back till now—  
the self-indulgent ones who failed to fight.”

They did as Diomedes said and left.

The high commander, Agamemnon, led them.

The famous god of earthquakes, Lord Poseidon,  
had watched with keen attention as they spoke,  
and now he joined them, as an older man,  
and took the hand of Agamemnon, son  
of Atreus, and spoke these words on wings.

“Achilles must be very happy now,  
rejoicing in his homicidal heart  
to see the rout and slaughter of the Greeks.  
He has no common sense, no, none at all.  
I hope he dies! Let some god wipe him out!  
But as for you, the gods who live at ease  
do not resent you or despise you yet.  
I still believe the Trojan lords and leaders  
will raise the dust upon the spacious plain  
and you yourself will see them run away  
towards their city, from our ships and huts.”

With these words, sprinting off across the plain,  
the god let out a mighty cry, as loud  
as when nine thousand or ten thousand men  
join battle in the conflict set by Ares—  
so loudly roared the mighty god of earthquakes.  
His voice inspired the heart of every Greek



with never-ending strength and will to fight.

And then the goddess of the golden throne,  
Hera, who stood up high on Mount Olympus,  
looked down, and saw Poseidon right away—  
her brother and her husband's brother too—  
laboring in the war, the field of glory,  
and she was glad at heart. She also saw  
that Zeus was sitting on the highest peak  
of Ida, home to many creeks and springs,  
and in her heart, she hated him. So then  
the goddess, ox-eyed Hera, formed a plan  
to trick the mind of aegis-bearing Zeus.

200

And this idea seemed the best to her—  
to make herself look beautiful and go  
to Ida, so that Zeus would feel desire  
to lie beside her and make love with her,  
then she would pour untroubled, balmy sleep  
onto his eyelids and his clever mind.

210

She went into her chamber, which her son  
Hephaestus built for her. He fitted doors  
onto the doorposts with a secret bolt—  
no other god could open it. There Hera  
entered and shut the shining doors. And first,  
the goddess used immortal stuff, ambrosia,

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to cleanse all dirt from her attractive skin,  
and then she rubbed herself with olive oil—  
ambrosial, sweetly scented perfumed oil,  
and when she moved, its fragrance filled the house  
of Zeus, with its foundation built of bronze,  
and reached the earth and sky. She spread this oil  
over her gorgeous skin, and combed her fingers  
into her hair, and braided it in locks—

glistening, beautiful, immortal braids  
descending from her deathless head. And then  
she dressed herself in her immortal garment,  
which had been worked and woven by Athena,  
and patterned with ornate embroidery.

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She pinned it at her breast with golden brooches.

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She tied a belt that had a hundred tassels  
around her waist, and in her well-pierced lobes  
she placed a triple-clustered set of earrings,  
with drops like mulberries, and the effect  
was dazzling. The majestic goddess spread  
a beautiful, fine veil atop her head,  
new made and shining like the sun. She tied  
beautiful sandals to her oil-soft feet.  
After she had adorned herself completely,  
she left the room and summoned Aphrodite.  
Away from all the other gods, she said,

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190 “My darling child, will you do something for me?  
Or will you turn me down out of resentment,  
because I help the Greeks and you the Trojans?”

And Aphrodite, child of Zeus, replied,  
“Great goddess, eldest child of mighty Cronus,  
Hera, please tell me what you have in mind.  
My heart impels me to fulfill your wish,  
if it is possible and if I can.”

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The goddess Hera said deceitfully,  
“Give me attraction and desire, with which  
you subjugate immortal gods and humans.  
200 You see, I am about to go and visit  
the limits of the earth where food is grown,  
to see the origin of all the gods,  
Ocean and Mother Tethys. Rhea sent me  
to live with them and they took care of me  
and nurtured me while great far-seeing Zeus  
was pushing Cronus down below the earth  
below the fruitless sea. Now I am going  
to visit them and stop their ceaseless quarrel.  
They have been holding back from one another  
and for a long time, they have not made love.  
Anger has fallen on their hearts. If I  
can speak to both of them and change their minds

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210 and bring them back together and unite them  
in bed and lovemaking, they will express  
love and respect for me forever after.”

Then Aphrodite, who loves smiles, replied,  
“It would be quite impossible, and wrong,  
to turn you down, because you spend your nights  
wrapped in the arms of Zeus, the greatest god.”

Then she unfastened the embroidered strap  
she kept between her breasts, on which was worked  
every seductive spell. It had lovemaking,  
intimacy, desire, and flirty talk—  
flirtation makes the wisest lose their minds.  
She handed it to Hera, and then said,

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220 “Now tuck this decorated strap between  
your breasts. Embroidered onto it, it has  
every seductive spell, and I assure you  
that what you have in mind will be fulfilled.”

So Aphrodite spoke, and ox-eyed Hera  
smiled, and amid her smiles she tucked the strap  
between her breasts. Then Aphrodite, daughter  
of Zeus, went home, while Hera swiftly left  
the peak of Mount Olympus. And she crossed  
Pieria and lovely Emathia  
and swooped across the snowy mountaintops  
where Thracian horse-lords roam. The goddess Hera  
skated across the very highest peaks  
and with her feet she never touched the ground.  
She hovered at Mount Athos and then plunged  
into the billowing sea and out at Lemnos,  
the town of godlike Thoas. There she met  
Death’s brother, Sleep. She took him by the hand  
and spoke these words and said to him,

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300

“Great Sleep,

master of every god and every human,  
if you have ever heeded me before,  
do as I ask you now, and I will show you  
favor forever. Lull the shining eyes  
of Zeus, as soon as I have lain with him,  
when we have finished making love, and then  
I shall provide you with a golden chair,  
a beautiful and everlasting gift.

310

240

My son, Hephaestus, who has curving limbs,  
will work to fashion it, and place beneath it  
a stool on which to rest your oil-soft feet  
when you are banqueting.”

But soothing Sleep

replied and said to her, “Majestic Hera,  
respected goddess, child of mighty Cronus,  
with any other ever-living god,  
even the flowing streams of River Ocean,  
who is the origin of everything,  
I could sedate them very easily.

320

But I will not go near the son of Cronus.  
I will not lull great Zeus to sleep, unless  
he is the one who orders me to do it.

250

You told me I should do it once before,  
and I have learned my lesson. It was when  
the son of Zeus, heroic Heracles,  
left Troy, when he had sacked the Trojan city.  
I gently wrapped around and lulled to sleep  
the mind of Zeus, the god who wears the goatskin,  
while you were plotting trouble for his son.

330

You roused the blasts of harsh winds on the sea  
and pushed him far from all the ones he loved  
to Cos, a fine, well-populated island.

But Zeus was furious when he woke up,  
and flung the gods around inside his house.

The one he most desired to find was me.

He would have thrown me from the sky and into  
the deep sea never to be seen again,  
if Night, who overcomes both gods and men,

260 had not protected me. I ran away  
 and begged her help, and Zeus gave up his anger,  
 because he has respect for swift strong Night.  
 He had no wish to cause offense to her.  
 What you are asking me to do for you  
 is quite impossible.”

The ox-eyed goddess,  
 Hera, replied, “Why do you worry, Sleep,  
 about these things? Do you believe that Zeus,  
 the god whose voice extends around the world,  
 who got so angry about Heracles,  
 his son, will feel the same about the Trojans,  
 or wish to help those people? Come on now.  
 I will provide you with a bride to marry—  
 one of the fresh young Graces will be yours,  
 Pasithee, whom you have always longed for.”

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270 These words delighted Sleep, who answered her,  
 “Come on then, swear to me, invoke the waters  
 of Styx, the great, inviolable oath,  
 and place one hand upon the fertile earth,  
 the other on the glittering sea, so all  
 the gods below the earth, the friends of Cronus,  
 be witnesses for us that you will give me  
 one of the fresh young Graces as my bride—  
 Pasithee, whom I have always longed for.”

360

280 So Sleep declared. The white-armed goddess Hera  
 complied and swore as he had asked, and named  
 all of the deities in Tartarus,  
 known as the Titans. After she had sworn  
 and finished with her oath, the two of them  
 together went from Lemnos, and then left  
 the town of Imbros, wrapped in mist, and swiftly  
 they traveled on their way and came to Ida,  
 mother of animals and many springs.  
 They left the sea and landed upon Lecton,

370

then journeyed on dry land. The topmost leaves  
trembled beneath their feet, and in the forest  
Sleep stopped, in case the eyes of Zeus should see him,  
and perched inside the tallest tree on Ida,  
a fir that reached up through the mist to heaven.  
He sat there hidden in the fir tree's branches,  
just like a screeching owl, a mountain dweller,  
which gods call Chalcis, Bronze Bird—humans call her  
Cymandis.

290

380

Meanwhile, Hera quickly came  
up to the peak of Ida—Gargaron.  
And Zeus who gathers clouds together saw her,  
and at the sight of her, desire enfolded  
his cunning mind, as when they first made love  
and went to bed together secretly,  
so that their loving parents would not know.  
He stood in front of her and said to her,

“Hera, what do you want? Why have you come  
down from Olympus to this place? You brought  
no horses and no chariot to ride.”

390

300 Deceitfully the goddess Hera answered,  
“Husband, I am about to go and visit  
the limits of the earth where food is grown,  
to see the origin of all the gods—  
Ocean and Mother Tethys. In their house,  
they cared for me and nurtured me, and now  
I plan to visit them and stop their quarrel.  
They have been holding back from one another,  
and for a long time, they have not made love.  
Anger has fallen on their hearts. My horses  
are standing at the foothills of Mount Ida,  
where many creeks and fountains flow. They will  
carry me over land and over water.  
But I have come out here from Mount Olympus  
because you would be angry with me later

400

310 if I had failed to tell you I was going  
to visit Ocean where the streams run deep.”

Then Zeus, who gathers clouds together, answered,

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“You can go later on that journey, Hera,  
but now let us enjoy some time in bed.

Let us make love. Such strong desire has never  
suffused my senses or subdued my heart

for any goddess or for any woman  
as I feel now for you. Not even when

I lusted for the wife of Ixion,

and got her pregnant with Pirithous,

a councillor as wise as any god.

Not even when I wanted Danae,

420

the daughter of Acrisius, a woman

with pretty ankles, and I got her pregnant

320 with Perseus, the best of warriors.

Not even when I lusted for the famous

Europa, child of Phoenix, and I fathered

Minos on her, and godlike Rhadamanthus.

Not even when I wanted Semele,

or when in Thebes I lusted for Alcmene,

who birthed heroic Heracles, my son—

and Semele gave birth to Dionysus,

430

the joy of mortals. And not even when

I lusted for the goddess, Queen Demeter,

who has such beautiful, well-braided hair—

not even when I wanted famous Leto,

not even when I wanted you yourself—

I never wanted anyone before

as much I want you right now. Such sweet

desire for you has taken hold of me.”

Deceitfully the goddess Hera answered,

330 “Terrible, terrifying son of Cronus,

440

what have you said? You want to make love now

upon the peaks of Ida, in a place

where everything is visible all round?

But what if one of the immortal gods

witnesses us up there in bed together,  
and goes away and tells the other gods?  
I could not get up from the bed and go  
back to your house—it would be very shameful!  
But if this really is your heart's desire,  
you have a chamber, which our dear son built.  
Hephaestus fixed strong doors onto the frame.  
Let us go lie down there, if you are really  
so tempted by the thought of making love.”

450

Then Zeus, the god who gathers clouds, replied,  
“Do not be frightened that some god or human  
might see us, Hera. I will wrap around us  
a golden cloud, so we cannot be seen,  
even by Helios, the Sun, whose vision  
is sharpest and whose light sees everything.”

With this, the son of Cronus took his wife  
into his arms, and underneath them both  
the bright earth grew fresh grass and dewy clover  
and thick soft hyacinth, which kept them up  
above the ground. On this plant bed they lay,  
surrounded by the lovely golden cloud,  
which sprinkled shining drops of dew upon them.  
Then Zeus, the father, slept in peace, up high  
on Gargaron, subdued by sleep and sex,  
and held his wife enfolded in his arms.  
And gentle Sleep rushed down to the Greek ships  
to bring the message to the god of earthquakes,  
the god who wraps around the world, Poseidon.  
He stood beside him and his words took flight.

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“Poseidon, you should now feel free to help  
the Greeks and give them glory for a while,  
as long as Zeus is still asleep. I have  
enshrouded him in soft, deep slumber. Hera  
tricked him to go to bed with her.”



With this,

360 Sleep passed among the noble tribes of humans.  
 Poseidon was encouraged all the more  
 to help the Greeks, and with a mighty bound  
 he joined the fighters at the front and asked them,

480

“Greeks, are we giving up again? And will we  
 let Hector win the victory? Let him take  
 the ships and get the triumph? I am certain  
 he thinks he will, and boasts of his success,  
 because Achilles stays beside the ships,  
 enraged at heart. But we will not need him,  
 if all the rest of us protect each other  
 and urge each other on. So come on now!

490

370 Everyone, do exactly as I say!  
 Take up the best and biggest shields we have,  
 put shining helmets on your heads, and seize  
 the longest spears, and charge! And I will lead you,  
 and I believe that Hector, son of Priam,  
 however eager he may be to fight,  
 cannot withstand us. Any man whose shield  
 is small, although his will to fight is great,  
 should give his little shield to someone weaker,  
 and take a larger one.”

So spoke the god.

500

The people heard and eagerly obeyed.  
 Despite their injuries, the wounded leaders—  
 Lord Diomedes and Odysseus  
 380 and Agamemnon, son of Atreus—  
 marshaled the men, and ranging through the ranks  
 they switched the weapons, so the finest men  
 carried the finest arms, the worst, the worst.  
 When every man was dressed in shining bronze  
 they charged ahead, led by the god of earthquakes,  
 Poseidon. In his sturdy hand he held  
 a deadly sharp-edged sword that shone like lightning.  
 It is decreed that nobody may fight  
 this terrifying blade in bitter battle.

510

Fear seizes every man when it appears.  
 And meanwhile, on the other side, great Hector  
 marshaled the Trojan troops. Blue-haired Poseidon  
 390 and noble Hector pulled the rope of war,  
 creating an intense and dreadful conflict.  
 One led the Trojans and one helped the Greeks.  
 The sea surged up towards the huts and ships. 520  
 The armies clashed with a tumultuous cry.  
 Louder than roaring of the waves on shore,  
 when cruel blasts of Boreas have stirred  
 the deepest water, louder than the rumble  
 of blazing fire that leaps to burn a forest  
 within the thickets on the mountainside,  
 louder than wind that shrieks through lofty oak trees,  
 which roars the loudest when it rages most—  
 louder than all of these, the Greeks and Trojans  
 400 let out their terrifying screams and cries 530  
 as they attacked each other. Shining Hector  
 aimed with his spear at Ajax, who had turned  
 to face him head-on. Hector did not miss—  
 he struck the straps across the chest of Ajax,  
 which held his shield and silver-studded sword.  
 The son of Telamon had tied them on  
 and they protected his soft flesh. Then Hector  
 was angry that his sharp spear caused no damage.  
 Frustrated, he rejoined his group of comrades.  
 But mighty Ajax, son of Telamon, 540  
 hit him as he retreated, with a stone.  
 410 Numerous rocks, the swift ships' anchor-stones,  
 rolled at the fighters' feet, and Ajax seized  
 one of these stones and hurled it straight at Hector  
 over his shield-rim, and it hit his chest  
 under his throat, and sent him whirling round,  
 just as a spinning top is struck and spun—  
 as when the father, Zeus, strikes down and fells  
 an oak tree by the roots, and as it falls  
 there is a strange, uncanny smell of sulfur, 550  
 and anyone who sees it is afraid—  
 so swiftly Hector tumbled to the ground,

the mighty fighter fallen in the dust.

His spear fell from his hand. His shield and helmet  
crashed down on top of him, and round his body

420 his fine bronze armor clattered. Then the Greeks  
shouted and ran towards him, in the hope  
that they could drag him off. Their spears flew fast.

But nobody could wound or strike at Hector,  
the shepherd of the people. They were blocked  
by champion fighters on the Trojan side—

Polydamas, Aeneas, fine Agenor,

Sarpedon, the commander of the Lycians,  
and noble Glaucus—all surrounding Hector.

All of the other Trojans helped protect him,  
holding their rounded shields across his body.

And then his comrades picked him up and took him  
out of the struggle of the battlefield

to where his decorated chariot

430 and driver waited, with his fine, swift horses,  
keeping their distance from the scrum of war.

Swiftly they bore him back towards the city,  
groaning in pain. But when they reached the ford  
across the softly flowing River Xanthus,

who was the son of deathless Zeus, they halted,  
lifted him from the chariot to the ground,

and rinsed him off with water, and he gasped,  
opened his eyes, kneeled up, and vomited

dark blood. Then he collapsed back on the ground  
and black night veiled his eyes, because the blow

still overwhelmed him. When the Greeks saw Hector

440 retreat, they charged ahead against the Trojans  
all the more fiercely, with their zeal renewed.

The quickest to attack was agile Ajax,

son of Oileus, with his sharp spear,

who leapt at Satnius and wounded him.

The father of this Satnius was Enops.

His mother was the noble river goddess

encountered by his father while he herded

his cattle by the River Satnioeis.

Oilean Ajax, the impressive spearman,

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drew up to Satnius and struck his side  
and knocked him back. Around him, Greeks and Trojans  
gathered and fought with all their might and main.

450 Polydamas, the son of Panthous,  
defended him and speared Prothoenor,  
the son of Areilycus. He drove  
the weapon all the way through his right shoulder.  
He fell to earth and dying clutched the dust.  
Polydamas exalted over him  
and loudly boasted,

600

“Yes, another triumph!  
The son of Panthous is brave and strong!  
The spear that leapt out of my mighty hand  
has met its mark again, I do believe!  
One of the Greeks received it in his flesh,  
and leaning on it, as a walking stick,  
I think that man will hobble down to Hades.”

This boast upset the Greeks, especially Ajax,  
the son of Telamon. It stirred his heart,  
460 because the man had fallen right beside him.  
So Ajax quickly hurled his shining spear  
towards Polydamas as he retreated.  
Polydamas himself avoided death  
by jumping sideways, but Archelochus,  
Antenor’s son, received the blow. The gods  
had planned his doom. The spear went through his neck,  
just at the very top part of his backbone,  
and sliced through both its tendons—and his head  
flew off, face-down, nose down, and hit the ground  
before his legs collapsed on top of it.  
Then Ajax shouted to Polydamas,

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620

470 “Tell me, Polydamas, and speak the truth,  
was this man a good trade for Prothoenor?  
He seems a noble warrior to me,  
descended from a noble line—perhaps

a brother or a son of great Antenor,  
the horse-lord. He resembles him quite closely.”

In fact, he knew exactly who he was.  
Then sorrow seized the Trojans. Acamas  
straddled the body of Archelochus,  
his brother. As Boeotian Promachus  
grabbed at the dead man’s feet to drag him off,  
Acamas stabbed him with his spear and boasted,

630

480 “You never get enough of making threats,  
you loudmouthed Greeks! But suffering and sorrow  
do not belong exclusively to us!  
Soon you will suffer slaughter just like this.  
Look how your Promachus lies fast asleep,  
defeated by my spear—to pay the price  
for my dead brother, not long unavenged.  
This is the reason that men pray to have  
a kinsman left behind, to save their house  
from ruin.”

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So he spoke, and at his boast,  
the Greeks were devastated, and especially  
it stirred the heart of fine Peneleus.  
He rushed at Acamas, who did not wait  
to meet the thrust of Lord Peneleus,  
which wounded Ilioneus, the son  
490 of Phorbas, who had many flocks of sheep.  
Hermes loved Phorbas best of all the Trojans,  
and gave him wealth, but Phorbas was the father  
of only one son—Ilioneus,  
born as his mother’s only child. But now,  
Acamas stabbed him underneath his brow,  
drove deep into the socket of his eye  
and popped the shiny eyeball out. The spear  
passed through the skull and out behind his neck,  
and stretching out both hands, the man collapsed.  
Peneleus drew out his strong, sharp sword

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and drove it through the middle of his neck,  
and cut the head, complete with helmet, off.  
The strong spear was still stuck inside his eye.  
Peneleus held up the spear and head,  
500 just like a poppy, showed it to the Trojans,  
and boasted,

“Trojans! Go and tell the parents  
of Ilioneus, who loved him dearly,  
to grieve and weep for him inside their halls.  
Moreover, Promachus, Algenor’s son,  
will never give his loving wife the joy  
of welcoming him home again. Meanwhile,  
we warriors of Greece will leave this city  
and sail our ships back home.”

At this, they trembled.  
Their bodies shook and they were looking round  
for any way to get away from death.

Now, Muses, who inhabit Mount Olympus,  
tell me which Greek first seized his bloody spoils,  
510 after the god of earthquakes turned the battle?  
Ajax, the son of Telamon, was first,  
striking the leader of the valiant Mysians,  
Hyrtius, son of Gyrtius. And then  
Antilochus, who killed and stripped the spoils  
from Phalces and from Mermerus. And then  
Meriones killed Morus and Hippotion.  
Teucer killed Prothoon and Periphetes.  
The son of Atreus, Lord Menelaus,  
killed Hyperenor, shepherd of the people.  
Stabbing his side, the bronze drew forth his bowels.  
His spirit hurried through the open wound  
520 and darkness veiled his eyes. But agile Ajax,  
son of Oileus, killed most of all.  
Nobody was as fast as him at running  
to catch his enemies when Zeus aroused

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panic and fear and made the Trojans flee.

## BOOK 15



### Fire at the Ships

The Trojans fled and Greek hands slaughtered many.  
Those who survived had crossed the stakes and ditch,  
and stopped their chariots, remaining there,  
pallid with fear and forced into retreat.  
Then on the peaks of Ida, Zeus woke up  
beside great Hera of the golden throne.  
And jumping quickly to his feet, he saw  
the Trojans fleeing and the Greeks behind them—  
a scattered and chaotic rout. Among them,  
he saw Poseidon, and upon the plain,  
Hector, with his companions sitting round him.  
He lay unconscious, taking painful breaths,  
vomiting blood, because he had been struck  
by Ajax—not the weakest of the Greeks.  
And Zeus, the father of mankind and gods,  
pitied him and scowled furiously at Hera,  
and said to her,

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“You are impossible!  
Hera, your wicked, lying trick has stopped



Hector from fighting, and has forced his troops  
to flee. I think you ought to profit first  
from this disgusting patchwork of deceit—  
when I give you a whipping! Do you not  
remember when I hung you in the sky  
and clipped two anvils to your feet, and bound  
a golden chain around your hands and wrists  
that could not be untied? You dangled there,  
suspended in the air amid the clouds.

20

All of the other gods on Mount Olympus  
stood round appalled but could not set you free.  
And anyone I caught, I grabbed and hurled  
over the threshold of the sky and down  
to earth debilitated. Even so,  
my constant grief for godlike Heracles  
still pained my heart. With Boreas, the north wind,  
you swayed the storms and schemed against my son  
and sent him on the fruitless sea to Cos,  
a beautiful, well-populated island.  
I rescued him from there and brought him back  
to Argos, where the horses graze in pastures,  
after he had completed many labors.  
I want to make you mindful of these things  
to make you stop your trickery and schemes.  
See if it did you any good at all  
to fool me with seduction, when you left  
the other gods and came to bed with me.”

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At this, the ox-eyed goddess Hera shuddered,  
and spoke to him in words on wings. “I swear,  
by Earth and by the spacious Sky above,  
and by the waters of the Styx below,  
which is the greatest and most fearsome oath  
for all the gods who live at ease, and by  
your holy head, and by the bed we share,  
our lawful marriage bed, which I would never  
betray—it is not by my will, I promise,  
that Lord Poseidon, shaker of the earth,  
is harming Hector and the Trojan people

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and helping their opponents. I suppose  
his own desire is prompting him to do it,  
because he saw the Greeks in mortal danger  
beside their ships, and pitied them. But I  
would certainly advise him to comply  
like me, and follow anywhere you lead,  
god of the dark clouds.”

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So spoke Hera. Zeus,  
the father of the gods and humans, smiled  
and answered her and let his words take flight.  
“If you align your thoughts with mine in future,  
majestic ox-eyed Hera, as you sit  
among the everlasting gods, Poseidon  
will quickly change his plans and follow ours,  
however much he wished for something else.

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If you are being honest with me now,  
and telling me the truth, go join the gods  
and summon Iris. Let her go among  
the army of the Greeks bedecked in bronze  
and tell Poseidon he must quit the war  
and go back to his own house. Also call  
Phoebus Apollo, god of archery,  
and let him stir up Hector to rejoin  
the battle. Let him breathe new courage in him.

Let him enable Hector to forget  
the agonies that now afflict his mind.  
Let Hector turn the Greeks around again  
and make them panic, lose their will to fight,  
and run away until at last they fall  
amid the mighty galleys of Achilles,  
the son of Peleus. He will send forth  
his friend Patroclus, who will slaughter many,  
including my own noble son, Sarpedon.

80

Then glorious Hector, out in front of Troy,  
will kill Patroclus with his spear, and then,  
enraged at this, Achilles will kill Hector.  
And after that has happened, I shall cause  
the Greeks to drive the Trojans from the ships,

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70 and force them to retreat continuously  
until, through great Athena's strategies,  
the Greeks have seized the lofty town of Troy.  
Until that time, my anger will not cease.  
No other deathless god will be allowed  
to help the Greeks until I have fulfilled  
the wishes of the son of Peleus,  
Achilles, as I promised I would do,  
and nodded with my head to make it certain,  
the day the goddess Thetis touched my knees  
imploping me to glorify Achilles,  
the city-sacker."

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80 So he spoke, and Hera,  
the white-armed goddess, did not disobey.  
She went from Ida up to Mount Olympus,  
moving as quickly as the mind—as when  
a person who has traveled many places  
across the world imagines and reflects,  
"If only I were there again! Or there!"  
and forms innumerable dreams and wishes—  
so eagerly, so fast, majestic Hera  
flew through the mountain peaks to high Olympus,  
and joined the deathless gods, who were assembled  
inside the house of Zeus. On seeing her,  
they all jumped up and offered her a drink  
in welcome. She ignored the other gods,  
but took a cup from fresh-faced Themis, Custom,  
who ran to her and met her first and spoke  
with words on wings.

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90 "Why have you come here, Hera?  
You seem disturbed. I think the son of Cronus,  
who shares a bed with you, has frightened you  
and made you run away."

At these words, Hera,  
the white-armed goddess, answered, "Goddess Themis,

you should not question me about these things.  
You know how harsh and arrogant he is.  
Begin the feast, let all the deathless gods  
enjoy an equal share. Then you shall hear  
what terrible intentions Zeus has formed.  
Very few gods or mortals will be pleased,  
even if some of you are happy now,  
enjoying this fine feast.”

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100                               The goddess Hera  
finished her speech and took her seat. The gods  
were troubled in the house of Zeus. Great Hera  
smiled with her lips, but under her dark brows  
her face was cold, and angrily she spoke  
to all of them.

                                  “We must have lost our minds!  
So foolishly we struggle against Zeus.  
And even now, we still intend to stop him,  
to go and challenge him with words or force.  
But he sits far away from all of us  
and does not care about what we may do.  
No doubt he calls himself the very best  
of all the deathless gods in strength and power.  
So you must suffer any harm he causes  
to any one of you. In fact, already  
110 I think he has devised great grief for Ares,  
whose son, Ascalaphus, has died in battle—  
the man whom mighty Ares called his son,  
the man he loved the most of all.”

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                                  At this,  
Ares slapped both his sturdy thighs in grief,  
and said, “You must not criticize me now,  
divine inhabitants of Mount Olympus,  
for going to the Greek ships to avenge  
the killing of my son. I have to go,  
even if I am fated to be struck

by thunderbolts from Zeus, and so to lie  
among the corpses, with the blood and dust.”

120 With this, he told his henchmen, Fear and Panic,  
to yoke his horses, and he dressed himself  
in shining armor. Then the wrath and rage  
of Zeus against the ever-living gods  
would have grown even greater and more bitter,  
had not Athena, who was terrified  
for all the gods, jumped up and left the chair  
on which she had been sitting, hurried out,  
found Ares, pulled the helmet off his head,  
and took his shield and grabbed the spear of bronze  
out of his sturdy hand and spoke to him,  
scolding impetuous Ares with these words.

130 “You must have lost your mind, you maniac!  
Apparently, your ears do not hear well.  
Your brains and sense of shame are also dead.  
Did you not hear what white-armed Hera said?  
That goddess just arrived from Zeus himself!  
Or do you want to get your fill of trouble  
and then be forced back here to Mount Olympus  
to grow more grief for all the rest of us?  
You see, as soon as Zeus has left the humans—  
the overweening Trojans and the Greeks—  
he will come here to us on Mount Olympus  
to wreak destruction. He will seize us all,  
whether we are responsible or not.  
Therefore, I tell you now, forget your anger  
about your son. There have been and will be  
140 others whose strength and skill are more than his,  
and it is difficult to save all humans,  
no matter what their lineage or birth.”

With this, she made fierce Ares sit back down.  
Then Hera called Apollo from the hall  
and Iris, messenger of the immortals,

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and said to them in words that flew on wings,

“Zeus summons you to Ida right away.  
When you arrive and look him in the eye,  
do everything he orders you to do.”

150 The goddess Hera spoke and hurried back,  
and sat upon her chair. Those two flew off.  
They reached Mount Ida, mother of wild beasts,  
watered by rivulets and springs and creeks. 200  
They found the god whose voice booms far and wide,  
the son of Cronus, on the very top  
of Gargaron. A fragrant cloud was wreathed  
around the god who gathers mist and clouds.  
The visitors approached and stood before him.  
Zeus was not angry at the sight of them,  
because they had so quickly followed orders  
from his most loving wife. He first addressed  
Iris with words that flew on wings.

“Go now,  
swift Iris, give this message to Poseidon. 210  
Convey it all, be no false messenger.  
160 Command him to withdraw from war and battle.  
He must rejoin the company of gods,  
or plunge beneath the shining salty sea.  
If he refuses and ignores my words,  
he should consider in his mind and heart  
whether he has the stamina to face me  
when I attack directly. He is strong,  
but I am older and more powerful.  
And yet he does not hesitate to claim 220  
that he is just the same as me—the god  
who causes hate and fear in other gods!”

Swift Iris listened and on feet of wind  
swooped from the mountain peaks of Ida down  
170 to holy Troy. As when cold hail or snow

flies from the clouds, when Boreas, the north wind,  
the son of upper air, assails the sky,  
so fast swift Iris flew, and soon she stood  
beside the god of earthquakes, Lord Poseidon,  
and told him,

“I have come here with a message  
for you, blue-haired enfolder of the world,  
from Zeus who wears the goatskin. He commands you  
to stop participating in the war.  
You must rejoin the company of gods,  
or plunge into the shining salty sea.  
If you refuse, ignoring what he says,  
he threatens he will come down here and fight you.  
180 He says that you should steer clear of his hands,  
because he is more powerful and older.  
And yet you do not hesitate to claim  
that you are just the same as him—the god  
who causes hate and fear in other gods!”

But angrily the god of earthquakes answered,  
“This is outrageous! He is powerful,  
but he has spoken too presumptuously  
if he asserts that he can hold me back  
forcibly. I refuse! I am his equal  
in rank. All three of us are sons of Cronus,  
and birthed by Rhea, all of us three brothers—  
Zeus and myself, with Hades as the third,  
who is the ruler of the ones below.  
Everything was divided into three,  
and each of us received his share of honor.  
The lots were shaken out and I was granted  
190 the salt gray sea as my domain forever,  
and Hades got the misty world of darkness,  
and Zeus the spacious sky amid the clouds,  
up in the air. But all of us still share  
the earth and Mount Olympus. For that reason,  
the thoughts of Zeus do not control my life.  
He must forbear and stay within his portion,

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however strong and powerful he is.  
He should not try to scare me with his hands,  
as if I were a weakling or a coward.  
Better for him to save his threats and scolding  
for his own sons and daughters. They will listen  
to his commands because they have no choice.”

200 Swift Iris, poised on feet of wind, replied,  
“Blue-haired enfolder of the world, Poseidon,  
is this your final answer? Should I take  
these harsh, aggressive comments back to Zeus?  
Or will you modify them in some way?  
A mind that can be changed is always best.  
Remember that the Furies always serve  
the senior members of a family.”

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Poseidon, lord of earthquakes, answered, “Iris,  
goddess, the things you say are sensible.  
It is a good thing when a messenger  
knows how things ought to be. But bitter pain  
afflicts the mind and heart whenever someone  
decides to blame and criticize an equal,  
who shares the same allotment as himself,  
210 in angry words. But even so, for now,  
despite my indignation, I will yield.  
But let me tell you something else. This is  
a heartfelt threat. If he opposes me  
and great Athena, driver of the spoil,  
and also Hera, Hermes, and Hephaestus,  
and spares the rugged town of Troy, despite  
our opposition, if he will not sack it,  
and if he will not give the Greeks great power,  
let him know this—that he will always be  
my enemy. My rage will never die.”

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220 With this, the god of earthquakes left the army,  
and plunged into the sea. The fighters missed him.  
Then Zeus, the god of clouds, addressed Apollo.



“Dear Phoebus, you must go to Hector now,  
the warrior who wears the bright bronze helmet,  
because the god who shakes and holds the earth  
has plunged into the salty shining sea  
escaping from my incandescent rage.  
Indeed, the other gods, the ones below,  
the Titans, the companions of old Cronus,  
have had experience of fighting me.  
It is far better both for me and him  
that he has yielded to my strength, my hands,  
despite his indignation. Open conflict  
between us would have surely not occurred  
without some sweat. But now take in your hands  
my tasseled goatskin aegis. Brandish it  
and force the warriors of Greece to flee.  
Far-shooter, care for Hector, and arouse  
a surge of courage in him, till the Greeks  
flee to their ships and reach the Hellespont.  
Then I shall work out what to say and do  
to give the Greeks some breathing space again.”

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Apollo listened and obeyed his father.  
Descending from Mount Ida like a hawk—  
the fastest, swiftest bird, the doves’ destruction—  
he found bright Hector, son of noble Priam,  
no longer lying down but sitting up.  
His consciousness had recently returned,  
and he could recognize his friends around him.  
He was no longer breathless, drenched in sweat,  
because the will of Zeus, who bears the aegis,  
had woken him. The distant god, Apollo,  
stood close and asked him,

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“Hector, son of Priam,  
why are you far away from all the others,  
in such a weakened state? Have you been hurt?”

Then feebly Hector of the flashing helmet

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answered, "Which god are you, my lord? You face me  
and question me. Do you not know already?  
Loud Ajax hurled a stone and struck my chest  
as I was slaughtering his friends and comrades  
beside the Greek ships, and so made me stop.  
In fact, I thought I would gasp out my life  
today, and join the dead men down in Hades."

Apollo, god of distances, replied,  
"Now do not worry. Zeus, the son of Cronus,  
has sent a helper to you from Mount Ida,  
to stand beside you and to keep you safe—  
Phoebus Apollo of the golden sword.  
I have protected you in former times,  
you and your rocky city. But now come,  
exhort a multitude of chariot drivers  
to drive swift horses to the hollow ships.  
And I shall go ahead of them and smooth  
the path completely for the chariot wheels,  
and turn the warriors of Greece around."

With this, Apollo breathed great strength and courage  
into the shepherd of the people, Hector.  
Just as a stallion, who has been standing  
confined to munch his barley at the manger,  
breaks through his harness and at top speed gallops  
across the plain with clattering of hooves,  
down to his usual spot beside the river  
to wash himself—he is all confidence,  
and holds his head up high—his mane is streaming  
across his back and shoulders—he is conscious  
of his own beauty, and his galloping legs  
carry him to the pasture of the mares—  
so Hector, once he heard the god's voice, sprinted,  
moving his legs and feet with ease and speed,  
to tell the chariot drivers they must rally.  
As when the country people and their dogs  
pursue a wild goat or a stag with horns,  
who hides amid the thickets and the woodland

high on a rocky crag—they are not destined  
to capture him, and yet their shouting rouses  
a lion, with a massive beard and mane,  
who blocks their way and quickly turns them all  
to flee, despite their eagerness to hunt—  
just so, the Greeks had crowded close together  
and constantly pursued their enemies,  
attacking them with swords and curving spears.  
But seeing Hector range among the troops,  
the Greeks were terrified, and each man's heart  
suddenly sank, descending to his feet.

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Then Thoas, son of Andraemon, addressed them.  
He was the best of the Aetolians,  
skillful at throwing javelins and strong  
in fighting at close quarters hand to hand.  
Few Greeks could rival him in public speaking,  
whenever men competed in debates.  
Hoping to help, he spoke to them and said,

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“This is astonishing! My eyes have seen  
something incredible—that once again,  
Hector has risen up. He has survived!  
Everyone surely hoped that he was dead,  
killed at the hands of Telamonian Ajax.  
Some god has rescued Hector, who has loosed  
the limbs and lives of many Greeks, and now  
I think he will kill more. It must be Zeus,  
the god of rumbling thunder, who empowered  
Hector to stand forth as their champion  
with so much strength and vigor. But now come,  
all of us have to do as I suggest.

390

Let us command the common troops to go  
back to the ships, but we who proudly claim  
to be the finest fighters in the army  
should stand and wait for him with spears in hand,  
and try to ward him off. I think this man  
will be afraid to plunge amid the throng  
of Greeks, for all his eagerness to fight.”

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300 The leaders heard and did as he advised.  
 Ajax, Lord Idomeneus, great Teucer,  
 Meriones and Meges, match for Ares,  
 and all their comrades called the finest fighters  
 to pack the front and face the Trojan army  
 and Hector. But the common troops, the masses, 410  
 stayed back and fought behind them, by the ships.  
 The Trojans clustered close and marched ahead,  
 and Hector led them with a long, proud stride.  
 Phoebus Apollo moved in front of him,  
 wearing a cloud around his back and shoulders,  
 and carrying a fearsome warlike aegis,  
 shining and shaggy, with a fringe around it,  
 which had been given by the smith, Hephaestus,  
 310 to Zeus, to wear while putting men to flight.  
 Apollo bore it now and led the troops. 420  
 The Greeks stood firm, arranged in close formation.  
 Sharp cries arose from both sides, and from bowstrings  
 arrows leapt forward. Many spears went flying  
 from sturdy hands and some lodged deep inside  
 the flesh of quick young warriors, while others,  
 hungry to sate themselves on human flesh,  
 fell short and stood between the pair of armies,  
 fixed idly in the earth. And while Apollo,  
 holding the aegis, kept it still, the weapons  
 of both sides hit their mark and fighters fell. 430  
 But when he gazed directly at the Greeks  
 320 and shook the aegis, and began to scream,  
 he mesmerized their spirits in their chests,  
 so they forgot their courage and their zeal.  
 As when, amid the gloomy black of night,  
 suddenly two wild beasts appear and chase  
 a herd of cattle or a flock of sheep  
 whose herdsman is not there—just so the Greeks  
 were chased and put to flight. They lost their courage.  
 Apollo routed them and gave the glory 440  
 to Hector and the Trojans. Man killed man  
 amid the scattered fighting. Hector slaughtered  
 Stichius, leader of the strong Boeotians,

330 who marched to war in tunics forged of bronze,  
and Lord Arcesilaus, trusty comrade  
of brave Menestheus. Aeneas killed  
Medon and Iasus. Medon was a son  
of great Oileus, born out of wedlock,  
and brother on his father's side of Ajax.  
But Medon lived in Phylace—he left 450  
his father's lands because he killed a man,  
a kinsman of Eriopis, the woman  
Oileus had taken as a wife.  
And Iasus was appointed as the leader  
of the Athenians. He had been called  
the son of Sphelus, son of Boucolus.  
Polydamas then killed Mecisteus.  
Polites, at the front, killed Echius,  
340 and fine Agenor slaughtered Clonius.  
And Paris struck Deiochus, and hit him 460  
under his shoulder as he ran away  
amid the fighters at the front. The bronze  
drove through him. While these Trojan victors stripped  
the weapons from the men whom they had killed,  
the Greeks were running off in all directions  
and stumbling in the ditch against the stakes,  
forced back against their wall. And Hector shouted  
to all the Trojans,

“Quick, attack the ships!  
Just leave these blood-soaked spoils! And if I see  
anyone holding back, I will myself 470  
ensure that he will die right then and there.  
No men or women from his family  
350 will burn him on the pyre once he is dead.  
The dogs will tear him up in front of Troy.”

With this, he raised his whip and thrashed his horses,  
and shouted orders to the Trojan troops.  
They called aloud together, with one voice,  
then drove their horses and their chariots forward,  
with otherworldly cries. In front of them,

Apollo easily kicked down the banks  
 along the deep ditch, pushed the earth and stones  
 into the middle, and so formed a bridge,  
 as long and broad as one can throw a spear,  
 testing one's strength. Across this bridge they surged,  
 maintaining their formation. And Apollo  
 held his majestic aegis as he led them.

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With total ease, the god pushed down the wall,  
 as when a child beside the sea scoops up  
 a mound of sand for fun and then in play  
 pushes and kicks it down again—so you,  
 great Lord Apollo, instantly erased  
 the labor and the suffering of the Greeks,  
 and forced them to retreat. The Greeks were trapped  
 beside the ships. They shouted to each other  
 and every man held up his hands and prayed  
 to all the gods. The savior of the Greeks,  
 Gerenian Nestor, made this heartfelt prayer,  
 raising his hands towards the starry sky—

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“Great father Zeus, remember long ago,  
 in Greece, amid the fertile fields of wheat,  
 if any one of us made prayers to you,  
 and burned fat thighs of cattle or of sheep,  
 and asked you for a safe return from war,  
 and you agreed, and promised with your nod,  
 remember those things now, Olympian,  
 and save us from the day of devastation,  
 and do not let the Trojans beat the Greeks  
 as they are doing now!”

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Such was the prayer  
 of old Gerenian Nestor, Greek defender,  
 and Zeus, the cunning god of strategy,  
 listened to him and thundered loud and deep.  
 The Trojans heard the thunderclap of Zeus,  
 and rushed against the Greeks with greater vigor,  
 remembering their eagerness for battle.  
 As when upon the vast, far-reaching sea,

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the force of wind lifts high the waves and drives  
the billowing water till it crosses over  
the walls around the ship—so with a cry  
the Trojans crossed the wall then drove their horses  
close to the sterns and fought with curving spears—  
the Trojans fighting from their chariots,  
the Greeks from up high on their swift black ships,  
using long pikes, tipped at the point with bronze,  
which lay aboard. And while the Greeks and Trojans  
390 fought at the wall, a distance from the ships,  
Patroclus sat with kind Eurypylus  
inside his tent and kept him company  
with pleasant conversation, rubbing ointment  
over his tender wound to salve his pains.  
But when Patroclus heard the Trojans surging  
530 across the wall, and heard the Greeks run screaming  
amid the chaos of disordered flight,  
he groaned and slapped both thighs with his flat palms  
and spoke in grief.

“Eurypylus, I know  
you need me here, but I can stay no longer.  
400 The conflict has intensified too much.  
Your man must care for you. I have to hurry  
to coax Achilles to rejoin the war.  
Who knows? My words may stir his angry heart  
perhaps, if some divinity is with us.  
540 Persuasion from a friend can be effective.”

As soon as he had said these words, he ran.  
The Greeks stood firm against the Trojan onslaught,  
but could not drive them from the ships, despite  
their smaller numbers. And the Trojans could not  
break through the lines of Greeks and force their way  
among the ships and huts. As tight as when  
410 a skillful carpenter who knows his craft,  
thanks to the inspiration of Athena,  
pulls taut a cord to cut the timber straight  
550 to build a ship—so evenly the rope

of battle stretched between the warring sides.  
At various ships the various forces fought,  
and Hector made directly for great Ajax.  
Around a single ship these two men struggled,  
Hector unable to push Ajax off  
or set the ship on fire, and Ajax failing  
to drive his enemy away, because  
a god had brought him near. Then splendid Ajax,  
hurling his spear, struck Calytor, the son  
of Clytius, who had been carrying  
a burning torch towards the ship. The spear  
impaled his chest and with a clash he fell.  
The brand fell from his hand. When Hector saw  
his cousin die before his very eyes,  
laid in the dust in front of the black ship,  
he shouted to the Trojans and the Lycians,

560

“Trojans and Lycians and Dardanian allies,  
hold fast, do not give ground in this tight spot.  
Save Calytor, the son of Clytius,  
killed in the battle for the ships. Do not  
allow the Greeks to strip away his arms.”

570

With this, he hurled his shining spear at Ajax,  
and missed, but hit his steward, Lycophron,  
the son of Mastor, a Cytherian,  
who killed a man in holy Cythera  
and came to live with Ajax, and in battle  
stood firm beside him. Now the sharp bronze struck  
Lycophron on his head below his ear.  
He toppled backward from the ship’s high stern  
into the dust. His limbs untied in death.  
Shuddering, Ajax told his brother, Teucer,

580

“Brother, our loyal comrade has been killed!  
The son of Mastor came from Cythera  
and lived with us and was as dear to us  
as our own parents. Now proud-hearted Hector



440 has slaughtered him. Where are your deadly arrows,  
and bow, which Lord Apollo gave to you?"

590

He spoke, and Teucer heard and ran to join him,  
holding his curving bow and case of arrows,  
and swiftly showered weapons at the Trojans.  
He struck Pisenor's son, majestic Clitus,  
the comrade of Polydamas, the son  
of noble Panthous, as he was holding  
the reins and working to control the horses,  
driving them to the center of the rout  
to help the Trojans and their leader, Hector.  
But soon harm came to him, and nobody  
450 could help him, though they would have wanted to.

A cruel arrow struck him from behind,  
piercing his neck, and from the chariot  
he fell. The horses swerved aside and rattled  
the empty carriage. Lord Polydamas  
noticed at once and rushed towards the horses,  
and gave them to Astynous, the son  
of Protiaon, and instructed him  
to hold them near and watch him all the while,  
and he rejoined the mass of frontline fighters.

600

And Teucer took another arrow out  
to shoot at Hector in his bright bronze helmet.  
He would have stopped him fighting by the ships  
460 if he had struck him in his time of glory  
and robbed him of his life. But watchful Zeus  
knew, and protected Hector, and prevented  
the win that Teucer, son of Telamon,  
might otherwise have had. As Teucer aimed  
at Hector with his splendid bow, Zeus snapped  
the twisted bowstring, and the bronze-tipped arrow  
flew wide, and Teucer dropped the bow, and shuddered,  
and told his brother,

610

"This is terrible!  
Some god is ravaging our battle plans.  
A god has made my bow fall from my hand

620

470 and snapped the fresh new string, which I tied on  
only this morning, so it would be ready  
to shoot a multitude of leaping arrows.”

Great Telamonian Ajax answered, “Brother,  
just leave your bow and arrows on the ground.  
Some deity has jinxed them, in resentment  
against the Greeks. Instead, pick up a shield  
and long dark spear, and grapple with the Trojans  
and urge the other Greeks to do the same.  
We may be beaten, but we shall not let them  
capture our splendid ships without a fight.  
We shall retain our valor, zeal, and courage.”

630

480 So Ajax spoke, and Teucer laid the bow  
down in the hut, and strapped around his shoulders  
a shield of four-fold hide. On his strong head  
he set his helmet, and its horsehair crest  
was terrifying as it bobbed on top.  
He took a sturdy spear with sharp bronze tip  
and quickly sprinted off, and stood by Ajax.  
When Hector saw that Teucer’s bow was broken,  
he shouted to the Trojans and the Lycians,

640

490 “Trojans and Lycians and Dardanian allies,  
be men! Retain your fervent zeal for battle  
beside the hollow ships. With my own eyes  
I saw the weapons of a champion fighter  
broken by Zeus himself. The aid of Zeus  
can easily be recognized by humans.

We see to whom he grants the greatest glory,  
and whom he brings down low and will not save.  
So now, the god is weakening the Greeks  
and helping us. Now all of you together  
keep fighting by the ships. If you are wounded  
by flying arrows or a thrusting sword  
and meet your death and destiny—so be it!  
Die! You will suffer no disgrace in dying

650

to save your fatherland. In future times,  
your wife and children will be safe, your household  
and land will be undamaged—if the Greeks  
sail home to their own country.”

660

With these words  
500 he stirred each fighter’s heart with zeal for battle.  
And on the Greek side, Ajax called his comrades.

“Shame on you, Greeks! It is a certainty  
that we must either die or find salvation  
by pushing this disaster from our ships.  
If Hector in his shining helmet captures  
our ships, do you think any one of us  
will come home safely to our native land?  
Do you not hear how Hector stirs his army?  
How eagerly he yearns to burn our fleet?  
He is not calling them to dance, but fight!  
There is no better option for us now  
510 than combat, with our hands and hearts engaged.  
Better to live or die in one quick fight  
than slowly suffocate in long contention  
squeezed by a lesser foe, as we are now  
beside our ships.”

670

With these words, Ajax rallied  
the spirit and the zeal of every fighter.  
Then Hector killed the son of Perimedes,  
Schedius, leader of the Phocians. Ajax  
slaughtered the leader of the troops on foot,  
Laodamas, Antenor’s noble son.  
Polydamas killed Otus of Cyllene,  
a leader of the valiant Epeans,  
the comrade of the son of Phyleus,  
520 Meges, who saw him die, and leapt to kill  
Polydamas, the son of Panthous,  
who ducked aside, and Meges missed his mark,  
because Apollo would not let him die

680

690

amid the fighters at the front. Instead,  
the spear thrust through the middle of the chest  
of Croismus, and he clattered down, and Meges  
stripped off his armor. As he did so, Dolops,  
a skillful spearman, bravest son of Lampus,  
a valiant son of King Laomedon,  
attacked him from nearby and drove his spear  
at Meges, in the middle of his shield,  
but he survived, thanks to his sturdy breastplate,  
fitted with metal pieces round his body.

700

530 In days of old, in Ephyra, his father  
Phyleus had received this piece of armor  
by the Selleis River. And Euphetes,  
a lord of men, a friend and host of his,  
gave it to him to wear as a protection  
against his enemies in war. And now  
it saved the body of his son from death.

Then Meges thrust his sharp strong spear at Dolops  
and struck the very top of his bronze helmet  
and sliced the horsehair crest away. It fell  
into the dust, still bright with fresh red dye.  
Dolops did not withdraw—he stayed to fight,  
still hopeful he could triumph over Meges.

710

540 But as he lingered, warlike Menelaus  
ran up to help the Greek, and sneaking in  
struck Dolops on the shoulder from behind.  
The hungry spearpoint pushed right through his chest,  
eager to drive in deeper. Down he slumped,  
falling face forward on the ground. The two,  
Meges and Menelaus, came to strip  
the bright bronze armor from the dead man's body.

720

Then Hector spoke to all his relatives  
and scolded them, especially Melanippus,  
strong son of Hicataon. Long ago,  
he used to care for shambling herds of cattle  
in Percote, when war was far away.

550 But when the curving ships of Greeks arrived,  
at once he came to Troy. Among the Trojans  
he had great honor, and he lived with Priam

who treated him the same as his own children.  
Now Hector scolded Melanippus, saying,

730

“Will we give up as easily as this?  
Do you not care about our slaughtered cousin?  
Do you not see the Greeks are working hard  
to take the weapons and the arms of Dolops?  
Follow me, Melanippus! This is not  
the time to keep on fighting from a distance.  
Either we kill our enemies, or else  
tall Troy will soon belong to them. The people  
who live inside the city walls will die.”

740

560 With this he led the way and Melanippus,  
a godlike man, accompanied great Hector.  
And Telamonian Ajax urged the Greeks,

“My friends, be men, and place inside your hearts  
respect and reverence for one another,  
no matter how intense the fighting gets.  
Those who respect and care for one another  
are usually not killed. They may survive.  
But those who run away receive no glory,  
and no assistance on the battlefield.”

750

Already eager to defend themselves,  
they took his words to heart and barricaded  
the ships with weapons, like a fence of bronze.  
And meanwhile, Zeus was riling up the Trojans.  
Then Menelaus, master of the war cry,  
addressed Antilochus and urged him on.

570 “Antilochus, you are the youngest Greek,  
the fastest on your feet, the finest fighter.  
If only you would leap and strike some Trojan!”

So speaking, he drew back. Antilochus,  
inspired, dashed out beyond the frontline fighters,

760

and glancing carefully around him, threw  
his shining spear. The Trojans scurried back,  
and struggled to avoid the hurtling spear,  
and yet the cast was not in vain. It struck  
proud Melanippus, son of Hicataon,  
as he was moving forward into battle.  
It struck him on the chest beside the nipple.  
He clattered down and darkness cloaked his eyes.

580 Antilochus pounced on him—as a dog  
leaps on a wounded fawn, who has just skittered  
out from his hideaway, and by some chance  
a hunter shoots him and his limbs unravel—  
so fearlessly Antilochus attacked  
you, Melanippus, to strip off your arms.  
But Hector noticed. Through the throng he sprinted  
to face Antilochus, who ran away,  
although he was a brave and eager fighter.  
He ran away like some wild animal  
who has performed a dreadful deed and killed  
a dog or herdsman in a cattle herd,  
and flees before the crowd of men arrive—  
just so Antilochus, the son of Nestor,  
ran off, and Hector and the Trojans hurled  
590 a mass of cruel weapons after him  
with shouts and war cries. When he reached his comrades,  
he turned around again and stood to face them.

The Trojans, like devouring lions, rushed  
against the ships, fulfilling the behests  
of Zeus, who constantly aroused in them  
intense desire for war and pushed them forward,  
and lulled the fighting spirit of the Greeks,  
and robbed them of their chances to succeed.  
The god's heart wished to give success to Hector,  
the son of Priam, and to let him burn  
the hook-prowed ships with tireless, ravenous fire  
and to fulfill the fatal curse of Thetis  
completely. So the god of plans was waiting  
600 to see with his own eyes the flash of fire—  
a ship aflame. Thereafter, Zeus intended

770

780

790

800

to make the Trojans turn and flee the ships  
and grant the Greeks success. With this in mind  
he roused the will of Hector, son of Priam,  
who was himself already keen to fight.

He raged like Ares brandishing his spear,  
or deadly fire that rages in the mountains,  
across the brush and thickets of a forest.

His mouth was foaming and his eyes were bright  
beneath dark brows, and as he fought his helmet  
quivered with menace, because Zeus himself

810

610 had come to be his helper from the sky.

He gave him glory and success and honor,  
enabling him to fight all by himself  
against a multitude, because he was  
destined to be alive so short a time.

Pallas Athena was already bringing  
his day of death beneath Achilles' hands.

He strove to break the ranks of troops and pushed  
wherever he could see the finest weapons  
and thickest crowd of fighters. But he failed  
to break their ranks, however hard he struggled.

820

They stuck together and resisted him  
as firmly as a wall, or sheer, steep cliff

620 beside the gray sea, which withstands the blasts  
of piercing winds and swelling waves that crash  
constantly onto it—just so, the Greeks  
stood firm against the Trojans and refused  
to flee. But Hector, dazzling as fire,

leapt in among the crowd, as when a wave  
is fed by wind beneath the clouds, and growing  
violent, crashes on a sailing ship,

830

which is all covered in the frothing water—  
a dreadful blast of wind shrieks through the sail—  
the sailors tremble and are terrified—  
their chances of survival seem so slim—  
so low Greek hearts sank, full of fear and dread.

630 And as a lion, eager for a kill,  
invades a massive herd of many cattle,  
grazing upon the flatlands of a marsh,

whose herdsman has not learned to fight against  
 wild beasts who come to kill his ambling cows—  
 the herdsman always walks beside the cows  
 in front or at the rear—the lion leaps  
 into the middle, and devours a cow,  
 and all the other cattle run away—  
 just so, amazingly, the Greeks all fled,  
 routed by Hector and the father, Zeus.

The only one he killed was Periphetes,  
 a Mycenaean, the beloved son

850

640

of Copreus, who used to take instructions  
 from King Eurystheus to Heracles.

The son was far superior to the father,  
 and good at everything. At running, fighting,  
 and strategy, he was among the best  
 of all Mycenae. Now he gave to Hector  
 a splendid triumph. He had turned to flee,  
 but tripped up on the rim of his long shield,  
 which he was carrying to protect himself  
 from darts and arrows. It went down to his feet.

He stumbled on it and fell back, face upward.

860

His helmet clattered loudly as he fell,

and Hector noticed, ran and stood beside him

650

and plunged his spear into his chest and killed him,  
 although his loving friends were very near.

They could not help him though they wanted to,  
 because they were so terrified of Hector.

The Greeks were trapped among the outer ships  
 that had been drawn up highest on the beach.

The Trojans pressed them, and the Greeks gave way,  
 forced to abandon the first line of ships.

870

They huddled by the tents and did not dare  
 disperse through camp, because they were so frightened.

But Nestor, guardian of the Greeks, implored them

660

and begged them and invoked their homes and parents.

“My friends, be men, and let your hearts take care  
 of one another, and remember also  
 your children, women, property, and parents,



whether they are alive or dead. I beg you,  
stand firm and do not turn and run away—  
fight for your absent families!”

880

With this,  
he roused each heart with will to fight. Athena  
pushed from their eyes the magic cloud of mist.  
Strong light poured down on them in both directions—  
670 towards the battle and towards the ships.  
They saw loud whooping Hector and his comrades—  
those who were hanging back and would not fight,  
and those who battled by the swift Greek ships.  
Brave Ajax was dissatisfied with standing  
aloof, beside the other sons of Greece.  
Instead, he strode along the ships’ top decks, 890  
holding a massive polished wooden pike  
designed for naval battles, set with rings,  
twenty-two cubits in its length—as when  
a man with special talent at horse riding  
680 selects four horses from a larger herd,  
harnesses them together, and then gallops  
towards the mighty city from the plain  
along a highway—many people watch him,  
women and men—he always keeps his balance,  
leaping across from one horse to another 900  
as they are flying forward—just so, Ajax  
strode across many decks atop the ships,  
and in a voice that reached the sky he shouted  
in terrifying tones and told the Greeks  
to save their ships and huts. And meanwhile, Hector  
rushed from the throng of well-armed Trojan fighters—  
690 just as an eagle, with his wings aflame,  
attacks a flock of long-necked swans or cranes  
or geese, as they are feeding by a river,  
so Hector rushed towards the dark-prowed ship. 910  
Zeus drove him forward with his mighty hand  
and urged the Trojan troops to follow after.  
Then bitter battle started up again  
beside the ships. The men fought so intensely,

you would have thought they could not tire of battle,  
they stood so strong, so firm against each other.  
And yet the fighters' attitudes were different.  
The Greeks expected death. They did not think  
700 they could survive this terrible disaster,  
while every Trojan in his heart believed 920  
that they would burn the ships and kill the Greeks.  
And with these thoughts, they faced and fought each other.  
Then Hector touched a fine ship's stern—the ship  
Protesilaus brought by sea to Troy  
but never took back to his fatherland.  
Around this ship, the Greeks and Trojans struggled  
and grappled hand to hand, no longer using  
710 arrows or javelins, but clustered close,  
united in their eagerness to fight  
with mighty swords and hatchets and sharp axes 930  
and double-sided thrusting-spears. And many  
fine swords with dark hilts fell as they kept fighting,  
some from their shoulders and some from their hands.  
The ground ran dark with blood. But Hector held  
fast to the ship and would not let it go,  
holding the stern's post tightly in his hands.  
He told the Trojans,

“Bring me fire! Come on,  
all of you, gather here and fight together!  
This is the most important time of all.  
Now Zeus whose voice extends around the world 940  
has given us the chance to take the ships  
720 that came against the wishes of the gods,  
and brought us years of suffering and pain,  
due to the cowardice of Trojan elders,  
who would not let me fight beside the ships.  
They held me back although I longed for battle,  
and kept the troops confined inside the city.  
But though Zeus crushed our spirit in the past,  
the god himself now stirs and spurs us forward.”

At this, the Trojans surged against the Greeks,

950

and Ajax could no longer stand to face them,  
assailed by weapons. He drew back a little,  
because he thought he was about to die.  
He left the foredeck of the steady ship,  
moved to the seven-foot-long mid-ship bench  
730 and stood there keeping watch, and with his spear  
kept on repelling Trojans from the fleet  
as they brought brands of fire. He kept on shouting,  
telling the Greeks in deep, commanding tones,

“My friends, Greek fighters, deputies of Ares,  
be men, my friends! Remember all your valor!  
Do we believe that there are reinforcements  
coming to help us? Do we have a wall  
to save us all from death—except ourselves?  
We have no city built with towers around it,  
containing people who could turn the tide.  
740 Trapped by the sea, upon the plains of Troy,  
surrounded by the well-armed Trojan fighters,  
we are a long way from our fatherland.  
Salvation lies in our own hands alone.  
If we are lax in battle, we are lost.”

960

970

With this, he ardently attacked and thrust  
his sharp spear into any Trojan fighter  
who brought a firebrand to the hollow ships,  
as Hector urged his men to do. And Ajax  
impaled them with his massive spear, and slaughtered  
twelve Trojans in close combat by the fleet.

## BOOK 16



## Love and Death

So fought the Greeks around the mighty galley.  
Patroclus stood beside his friend Achilles,  
the shepherd of the people, letting fall  
hot tears, like some black stream that pours dark water  
down a steep rock face where no goats can tread.  
Swift-footed Lord Achilles looked at him  
and pitied him, and let his words take flight.

“Why have you started crying now, Patroclus,  
just like a silly little girl, who runs  
beside her mother begging, ‘Pick me up!,’  
and tugs her dress and gets under her feet?  
Patroclus, you are like that little girl,  
with these thick tears of yours. Do you have something  
to tell the Myrmidons or me? Some news  
which you alone have heard from back in Phthia?  
I think they say Menoetius, son of Actor,  
is still alive, and Peleus, my father,  
the son of Aeacus, is living also  
among the Myrmidons. If either died,

we would be devastated by the loss.  
 Or are you feeling sorry that the Greeks  
 are being killed beside their hollow ships,  
 because they overstepped? Speak up! Do not  
 conceal your thoughts. We ought to share our knowledge.”

- 20 With deep sighs you replied, horseman Patroclus,  
 “Achilles, son of Peleus, by far  
 the greatest of the Greeks, please do not blame me.  
 The Greeks are suffering so terribly.  
 All those who used to be our finest fighters  
 are lying hurt and wounded in the ships. 30  
 Strong Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
 Odysseus, the celebrated spearman,  
 and Agamemnon—all of them are injured.  
 An arrow hurt Eurypylus on his thigh.  
 Doctors are laboring with medicines  
 to heal their injuries. But you, Achilles,  
 you have become impossible! I hope  
 30 the kind of anger you are fostering  
 never takes hold of me—you monstrous hero!  
 How can a person in the future learn 40  
 anything good from you, if you refuse  
 to save the Greeks from this catastrophe?  
 You have no pity. Peleus the horseman  
 was not your father, Thetis, not your mother.  
 Gray sea and soaring rocks gave birth to you,  
 and so you have an unrelenting heart.  
 But if your instinct tells you to avoid  
 some prophecy, and if your goddess mother  
 has shared some news of this with you from Zeus,  
 then send me out there right away. Send with me 50  
 a band of Myrmidons, and let me be  
 a light to save the Greeks. And let me wear  
 40 your armor on my body, so the Trojans  
 believe that I am you, and keep themselves  
 back from the battle, so the warlike sons  
 of Greece may catch their breath. They are worn out.  
 Respite in war is only ever brief.

The Trojans are exhausted from the battle  
and we are rested, so it will be easy  
to rout and drive them from our ships and tents,  
back to their city.”

60

So he spoke and prayed.  
Poor fool! His wish would bring him doom and death.  
Disturbed, swift-footed Lord Achilles answered,

“Patroclus! What is this? What do you mean?

I do not care about a prophecy.

50 I know of none. My goddess mother, Thetis,  
has not revealed a plan to me from Zeus.

But agony afflicts a person’s mind  
whenever somebody with greater power  
wants to deprive an equal of his trophy.

70

That is the pain, the horror I endure,  
because my heart has suffered from this anguish.

The woman whom the sons of Greece selected  
for me, to be my trophy, whom I won  
by my own spear when I sacked her walled city,  
was stolen from my arms by Agamemnon,  
the son of Atreus, the mighty lord,  
who treated me like someone with no honor,  
an outcast with no place to call his home.

60 But this is in the past. We must forget it.

80

There is, I realize, no way to rage  
with furious anger in one’s heart forever.  
I planned to cease my wrath, but not until  
the cries of war had reached my ships. Now you,  
Patroclus, put my famous armor on.

Lead the war-loving Myrmidons to battle,  
if this dark cloud of Trojans has encircled  
and overwhelmed our ships and if the Greeks  
are cramped into a little piece of land,  
pushed back towards the swelling of the sea.

90

70 All of the Trojans march with confidence  
to battle now—because they do not see  
my helmet flashing near them. They would quickly

run and fill every ditch with their dead bodies,  
if mighty Agamemnon treated me  
kindly. But now the enemy surrounds us.

No frenzied spear held by fierce Diomedes  
will save the Greeks from ruin. I have heard  
nothing from Agamemnon's hateful mouth.

100

The shouts of murderous Hector still resound  
across the field. The place is full of Trojans  
whooping triumphantly against the Greeks.

80 So now, Patroclus, despite everything,  
protect the ships from ruin, and attack  
at full strength. Do not let their blazing fire  
ignite the fleet and steal our precious chance  
of going home again. Do as I say,  
remember my instructions and obey them.

Then you will win great glory and respect  
for me from all the Greeks and they will send  
the lovely woman to a different home,  
and give me splendid gifts. But once you have  
driven the Trojans from the ships, come back.

110

If Zeus, the spouse of Hera, god of thunder,  
gives you the chance to win triumphant glory,  
do not attempt to fight the warlike Trojans  
90 without me, or you will reduce my status.

Do not take joy in violence and war  
and killing Trojans. Do not lead the men  
to Troy, or one of the immortal gods  
may come from Mount Olympus to attack you.

120

The god who works from far away, Apollo,  
adores the Trojans. Turn around again  
after you bring salvation to the ships.

Let others keep on fighting on the plain.

By father Zeus, Athena, and Apollo,  
if only the whole multitude of Trojans  
would die, and all the Greeks, and we alone,  
the two of us, survived the devastation,  
so we alone together could destroy

130

100 the sacred crown of Troy.”

They spoke like this.

Meanwhile, a blast of weapons pounded Ajax,  
so he could not stand firm. He was forced back  
by Trojan fighters and the will of Zeus.

His shining helmet, pummeled by the blows,  
clanged horribly around his battered skull.

The blades kept hammering the ornate plates.

His left arm wearied of the constant effort

of holding up his flashing shield. But still

the Trojans could not knock down his defense,

hard though they pressed him with their constant strikes.

His breath was labored and a flood of sweat

110      drenched his whole body, and he could not rest.

Danger was everywhere, pain piled on pain.

Muses who live on Mount Olympus, tell me  
how fire first fell upon the Greek armada.

Hector came close to Telamonian Ajax,  
and with his mighty sword, smashed through his spear  
behind the socket, at the tip, and sliced

right through the ash-wood shaft. Ajax was left  
clutching the fractured stump. The bronze point fell  
away from him and clattered on the ground.

Then Ajax recognized inside his heart

120      the work of gods and shuddered. Zeus on high,  
the thunderlord, had severed all his plans,  
and wanted victory for the other side.

Ajax retreated from the blows. The Trojans  
set the swift ship ablaze. At once, fierce fire  
consumed it and the blaze licked round the stern.

Achilles slapped his thighs and told Patroclus,

“Hurry, Patroclus, on your chariot!

I see the flash of fire on the fleet.

Do not allow them to destroy the ships,

and make escape impossible. Now quickly

put on my armor. I will call the troops.”

140

150

160



130 Patroclus armed himself in shining bronze.  
Around his legs he clipped fine greaves adorned  
with silver clasps, then fastened on his chest  
Achilles' breastplate, decked with stars. He slung 170  
the silver-studded bronze sword on his back,  
and then picked up the heavy shield. He put  
onto his sturdy head the shapely helmet  
set with a horsehair crest, which dipped and bobbed  
menacingly on top. Then he picked up  
the two strong javelins that fit his grasp.

140 Only the weighty, massive, powerful  
spear of the grandson of great Aeacus  
he did not take. No other Greek could hold it.  
Only Achilles knew how to control it. 180  
Chiron had given it to Peleus,  
Achilles' loving father. It was made  
of ash wood from the peaks of Pelion  
to cause the violent deaths of warriors.  
Once armed, Patroclus told Automedon  
to quickly yoke the horses in the harness.  
Patroclus loved Automedon the most,  
after Achilles, the demolisher  
of men. Dependable Automedon  
always stood firm and listened for his orders. 190  
Automedon tacked up the horses for him,  
Dapple and Bay, who flew as fast as breezes.

150 Zephyr, the west wind, fathered them. Their mother,  
Brightfoot the Harpy, birthed them in the meadow  
where she was grazing by the streams of Ocean.  
Next to them, as a trace-horse, he attached  
marvelous Jumper, whom Achilles took  
when he destroyed the town of Eetion.  
Mortal, he ran beside immortal horses.

Meanwhile, Achilles hurried through the camp, 200  
past every tent, and urged the Myrmidons  
to arm themselves. As wolves who crave raw meat,  
with boundless courage surging in their hearts,  
rip up a massive antlered stag and eat him—

the face of every wolf is red with blood—  
 160 the pack runs down together to the spring—  
 their slim tongues lap black water, and its surface  
 is smeared with blood—they belch from all the flesh,  
 the spirits in their chests are still undaunted,  
 their bellies full to bursting—like these wolves, 210  
 the leaders of the Myrmidons surrounded  
 the loyal follower of swift Achilles.  
 The mighty grandson of great Aeacus,  
 stood in their midst, encouraging the horses  
 and warriors behind their shields. This leader,  
 favored by Zeus, brought fifty ships to Troy.  
 170 In each were fifty rowers on the benches.  
 He set five leaders as their overseers,  
 and he himself ruled over all of them.  
 Menesthius, his breastplate flashing bright, 220  
 the son of Spercheus, the rain-fed river,  
 was leader of the first platoon. His mother,  
 beautiful Polydore, was a daughter  
 of Peleus. His father was a river,  
 unwearying Spercheus. They had made love,  
 woman and god, and she conceived the baby.  
 But Borus, son of Periereus,  
 became in name the father. He provided  
 limitless bride-gifts and a public marriage.  
 The warlike leader of the next platoon, 230  
 Eudorus, was a child born out of wedlock,  
 180 to Polymele, an attractive dancer,  
 daughter of Phylas. Mighty Hermes, killer  
 of Argos, lusted for her when he saw her  
 with others in a group of women dancing  
 for Artemis, who holds the golden arrows,  
 goddess of hunting cries. As soon as Hermes  
 of Acacesion, set his eyes upon her,  
 he went into her upper room, her bedroom,  
 and lay with her in secret, giving her 240  
 a splendid son, Eudorus, who excelled  
 at sprinting and at fighting. When the pains  
 of Eileithuia had brought forth the child

to see the sunlight, Polymele married  
strong, sturdy Echeclus, the son of Actor.  
190 He paid a lavish bridal-price and took her  
to his house and old Phylas loved the baby.  
He cuddled him, took care of him, and raised him  
as if he were his son. The third platoon  
was led by militant Pisander, son  
of Maemalus. He was the best of all  
the Myrmidons at fighting with a spear,  
after Patroclus, comrade of Achilles.  
The charioteer, old Phoenix, led the fourth.  
The fifth was governed by Alcimedon,  
son of Laerces. Finally, Achilles  
had marshaled all his troops in good array,  
and shouted in a strong voice,

250

“Myrmidons,  
200 none of you must forget the threats you made  
against the Trojans in my time of wrath,  
beside these ships, when all of you reproached me.  
You said, ‘Achilles, you are pitiless  
and harsh! Your mother raised you to be angry.  
You keep your comrades trapped against our will  
beside these ships. Let us launch out to sea,  
and sail in our swift fleet back home again,  
because such bitter rage has seized your heart.’  
You often crowded round to scold me so.  
Now the great military quest is here,  
the battle you were longing for before.  
270 So now each one of you must fight the Trojans  
with courage in your hearts.”

260

270

With this, he spurred  
210 the will to fight in every Myrmidon.  
The troops stood even closer to each other,  
when they were listening to their commander.  
As when a man, building a high house wall,  
fits stones together closely to keep out  
the blasts of wind, so were the soldiers’ weapons

clustered together closely, shield by shield,  
helmet by helmet, one man by another.

280

The horsehair plumes on top of their bright helmets  
touched one another as they swayed and bobbed,  
so closely did they stand beside each other.

In front of all of them stood two armed men,  
Patroclus and Automedon, whose hearts  
were one in eagerness to fight and lead

220

the Myrmidons to battle. But Achilles  
went to his tent, and lifted off the lid  
of an ornately crafted special box,  
given to him by silver-footed Thetis.

290

She put it in his ship and filled it full  
of tunics, windproof cloaks, and woolen rugs.

He had a special cup inside this box,  
from which no man or god drank any wine.

He used it only to pour out libations  
for father Zeus, no other god. And now  
he took this cup out of the box and cleaned it  
with sulfur first, then washed it in fresh water,

230

and washed his hands, then filled it with bright wine.

At last he stood in the center of his courtyard,  
and prayed, and poured the wine as his libation,  
and looked towards the sky. He paid full heed  
to Zeus who loves the thunder.

300

“Great Lord Zeus,  
whose home is far away, Pelasgian ruler  
of stormy, bleak Dodona! All around you  
the Helli, your interpreters and priests,  
sleep on the ground and never wash their feet.  
In former times, you heard my prayer and gave me  
glory, and struck the army of the Greeks.

So now, fulfill my prayer. I will remain  
behind, where all the ships have been assembled,  
but I will send my friend to fight in battle,  
accompanied by many Myrmidons.

240

Far-seeing Zeus, may victory march with him,  
and grant him courage in his heart, so Hector

310

will find out that my friend can fight with him  
even alone. When I go out with him  
into the wilds of Ares, my companion  
rages with hands that cannot be defeated.  
After he drives the battle from the ships  
and stills the cries of war, let him come back  
safely to me and my swift fleet again,  
with all my weapons and my Myrmidons.”

320

250 He prayed, and Zeus, the god of strategy,  
heard him. He granted half, and half refused.  
The father granted that Patroclus would  
drive battle from the Greek ships, but refused  
to let him come back safe again from war.  
After Achilles prayed and poured libations  
to father Zeus, he went inside the tent,  
and put the cup back in the box, then went  
to stand outside, because he yearned to see  
the dreadful fighting of the Greeks and Trojans.  
The Myrmidons were lined up in full armor  
with brave Patroclus. They swarmed out—like wasps  
260 when children make them angry, as they do—  
poor fools, they keep on teasing them and poke  
the nest beside the road—the wasps emerge,  
and cause the multitude a common pain,  
and if some traveler who passes by  
disrupts their home by accident, they all  
fly forth with warlike hearts to save their children—  
such was the spirit of the Myrmidons  
as they marched forth, away from shore and ships.  
Their shouting filled the air. Patroclus called  
loudly to his companions.

330

340

“Myrmidons!  
Friends of Achilles, son of Peleus!  
270 Be men, my friends! Remember all your courage.  
So we shall glorify the great Achilles.  
He is by far the best of all the Greeks,  
and his subordinates are best as well.

350

Let Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
that influential ruler, see his own  
deluded folly, that he disrespected  
the best of all the Greeks.”

With this, he roused  
courageous will in each of them. Together  
they rushed against the Trojans, and the ships  
resounded with the shouting of the Greeks.  
The Trojans saw Patroclus and his driver,  
both glittering with armor and with weapons. 360  
280 All of them panicked and the troops broke rank.  
The Trojans thought swift-footed Lord Achilles,  
the son of Peleus, had cast away  
his wrath and chosen gentleness and love.  
Each man looked round for how to save his life  
from total ruin. Then Patroclus hurled  
a bright spear in the midst of the stampede,  
where most were gathering behind the ship  
of brave Protesilaus. And he struck  
Paeonian Pyraechmes, who had led 370  
his skillful charioteers from Amydon  
beside the spreading River Axios.  
The spear struck his right shoulder and he fell  
down in the dust and screamed. His comrades round him  
290 were terrified. Patroclus made them flee  
by killing their best fighter and their leader.  
He drove them from the ships and quenched the fire.  
The ship was left half burnt as Trojans ran,  
howling in fear. The Greeks poured in and seized  
the hollow ships and screamed incessantly. 380  
As when the god who gathers lightning, Zeus,  
moves thick fog from the high peak of a mountain—  
the rocky cliffs and lookout points and valleys  
all become visible, and boundless sky  
300 breaks open wide—just so, the Greeks dispelled  
the deadly burning from the ships, and took  
a little time to breathe, although the war  
did not abate. The Trojans were not yet

turned round and driven back from the black ships  
by Greeks devoted to the work of Ares.

390

They still stood firm, although they had to yield  
possession of the ships. And then the fighting  
spread out, and man killed man. First brave Patroclus,  
son of Menoetius, with his sharpened spear,  
skewered the thigh of Areilycus

310

after he turned to run away. The bronze  
drove through and broke the bone. He fell face forward  
onto the ground. Then warlike Menelaus  
struck Thoas where he left his chest exposed,  
uncovered by his shield. His limbs untied.

400

Meges, the son of Phyleus, observed  
Amphiclus ready to attack, and stopped him,  
hitting the top part of his meaty thigh,  
the thickest muscle on a human body.

The spearpoint sliced apart the ligaments,  
and darkness veiled his eyes. One son of Nestor,  
Antilochus, hit with his sharpened spear  
Atymnius. The bronze drove through his flank.

Maris, the brother of Atymnius,

320

was close at hand and in a rage he rushed  
towards Antilochus with spear held high  
and took his stance above his brother's corpse.

410

But godlike Thrasymedes stopped his spear—  
his blow was quick and true. He hit his shoulder.  
The spear's tip hacked his arm off, slicing through  
the muscles, shattering the bone. He groaned  
and fell, and darkness covered up his eyes.

The two of them went down to Erebus,  
a pair of brothers slaughtered by two brothers.

They had been noble comrades to Sarpedon,  
the warrior sons of Amisodorus,  
who long ago fed the gigantic monster,  
Chimera, who had threatened many people.

420

330

Oilean Ajax rushed at Cleoboulus,  
and captured him alive. He had tripped over,  
shoved in the mêlée. Ajax took his life.  
Seizing the handle of his sword, he struck

his victim's neck. The blade was hot with blood.

Powerful fate and red death closed his eyes.

Peneleus and Lycus rushed together.

430

Their spears had missed each other—both had hurled wide, so they ran together with swords drawn.

Lycus attacked the horsehair helmet crest,

but shattered his fine sword. Peneleus

340

hacked at his neck below the ear. The sword sunk almost through completely—only skin attached the dangling head. His knotted limbs unraveled. Then Meriones ran fast,

discovered Acamas about to climb

into his chariot behind his horses,

440

and hit him on the right side, by his shoulder,

and knocked him from the chariot, and fog

flooded his eyes. Then Idomeneus

struck Erymas across the mouth. The spear

of pitiless bronze drove right up through his brain

and shattered his white skull, shook out his teeth,

and filled both eyes with blood. His mouth gaped wide

and spurted blood. Blood gushed out of his nostrils.

350

Then death's black cloud wrapped round and covered him.

So each Greek leader killed a Trojan man.

450

As hungry wolves attack young lambs and kids,

seizing them from the flock of sheep or goats—

their foolish herdsman fails to pay attention,

and they are scattered all across the mountain—

the wolves see them exposed and right away

pounce on the ones who are the most afraid—

just so Greek warriors pounced on the Trojans,

who dreamed of running, screaming, from the battle.

Their thoughts of battle lust had disappeared.

Great Ajax always aimed his spear at Hector,

460

360

armored in bronze. But Hector well knew war.

He used his oxhide shield to cover up

his strong broad shoulders, constantly observing

the hiss of arrows and the thud of spears.

He saw the battle turn but still stood firm



to save his comrades. As when bright air fades,  
and clouds move from Olympus to the sky,  
when Zeus is stirring up a storm, so grew  
the screams of terror from the ships. The Trojans  
jostled and struggled to recross the ditch.

470

Hector's swift horses carried him away  
with all his weapons, and he left behind  
the Trojan masses, stuck behind the ditch  
against their will. Their horses cantered down

370

into the trench, but on the way back up  
most of the front poles of the chariots broke.

The horses ran and left their lords behind.

Patroclus followed closely after, shouting  
urgent commands to Greeks and threats to Trojans,

who filled the area with frightened cries,

480

their ranks fragmented. Underneath the clouds,  
a dust storm spread above them, and the horses  
strained to return to Troy and leave the ships.

Patroclus, calling to his comrades, went  
to where he saw the largest group of Trojans  
struggling beneath their wheels, fallen face-first  
out of their chariots, which bounced and crashed.

But in his heart, Patroclus longed to strike

380

Hector. The deathless horses, whom the gods  
gave as a splendid gift to great Achilles,  
leapt straight across the ditch and pulled him over.

490

As when in summertime, the whole black earth  
is battered by a storm—torrential rain  
gushing from Zeus, when he is furious  
with men who force false judgments at a council,  
and drive out justice, and ignore the eyes

of gods—the rivers all begin to flow

390

in full flood—rushing streams of water cleave  
the hills and slopes and with a mighty roar  
burst out and join the glittering salty sea,

500

cascading headlong from the mountain peaks—  
the work of human beings turns to nothing—  
so loudly cried the Trojan mares in flight.

Patroclus intercepted the front line

of warriors and forced them to turn back  
towards the ships. He blocked the men from running  
back to the city, keeping them confined  
between the ships and river and high wall,  
and there he swooped and slaughtered them and made them  
repay a multitude of earlier deaths.

510

400 His bright spear first struck Pronous, whose chest  
was unprotected by his shield. His limbs  
untied in death. He fell, his weapons clanging.

Next, he attacked the son of Enops, Thestor,  
who crouched inside his polished chariot.

His wits had left his mind—the reins, his hands.

Patroclus came in close, speared his right jaw  
and drove the wooden spear shaft through his teeth,  
to hook and drag him over the chariot rail,

as when a man sits on a jutting rock,

520

and hooks a holy fish with shining bronze  
and fishing line, and drags it from the sea—

just so he dragged him from the chariot,

mouth gaping round the shining spear, and hurled him

410 face downward on the ground and as he fell,

life left him. Then Patroclus used a rock

to strike Erylaus as he attacked,

smashing the center of his head. Inside

his sturdy helmet, his whole skull was broken.

He fell down forward on the ground. Around him

530

flowed death that crushes human hearts and lives.

Then Erymas, Amphoterus, Epaltes,

Echius, Ipheus, Euippus, Pyris,

Damastor's noble son Tlepolemus,

and Polymelus, son of Argeas—

Patroclus laid them all in quick succession

down on the earth that feeds the world. Sarpedon

saw his companions in their flowing tunics

420 slaughtered and overpowered by Patroclus,

son of Menoetius. He called out and told them,

540

“Lycians, for shame! Where are you running off to?

Stay sharp! I will myself go face this man,

and find out who is dominating us,  
who made so many noble Trojan fighters  
collapse, their limbs undone.”

With this, he leapt  
down from his chariot with all his weapons.  
Patroclus saw him and jumped out to meet him.  
As on a high rock when two vultures fight  
with crooked beaks and curving talons, screeching  
their noisy cries—so loudly those two men  
screamed as they rushed together. At the sight  
the son of crooked-minded Cronus, Zeus,  
spoke up and told his wife and sister, Hera,

550

“What a disaster this will be for me!  
The man I love the most of all mankind,  
my son Sarpedon, is assigned to die,  
killed by Patroclus. I am of two minds,  
wondering if I ought to lift him up  
alive and take him from the battlefield,  
the source of tears, and carry him away,  
and set him in the fertile land of Lycia—  
or kill him now beneath Patroclus’ hands.”

560

Hera, the ox-eyed goddess, answered, “What?  
What have you said, disastrous child of Cronus?  
You want to free from painful death a mortal  
whose lot was dealt out long ago? Then do it!  
But none of us Olympians supports you.  
Now let me tell you this. Take it to heart.  
If you convey Sarpedon to his home  
alive, watch out! Some other gods may also  
decide to take their offspring from the battle.  
Around the mighty town of Priam fight  
numerous sons of other deathless gods,  
who may do likewise—and incur your rage.

570

If your heart grieves for him, because you love him,  
let him be killed in battle by Patroclus,

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440

450

son of Menoetius, and when life and spirit  
have left him, then send Death and gentle Sleep  
to take him to his spacious Lycian homeland  
and there his brothers, family, and neighbors  
can mourn him with a funeral mound and gravestone.  
This is the prize of honor due the dead.”

580

The father of the gods and humankind  
obeyed. He rained down drops of blood to earth  
to glorify the son he loved, Sarpedon,  
460 who would be killed upon the fertile field  
of Troy, far from his homeland, by Patroclus.  
When the two fighters had drawn close together,  
Patroclus stabbed Sarpedon’s noble driver,  
Thrasymelus, right in his lower belly.  
His limbs unraveled and he died. Sarpedon  
threw his bright spear in turn, but missed and wounded  
Jumper, the trace-horse, upon his right shoulder.  
He whinnied, panting out his final breaths.  
Moaning, he rolled onto the dust. His spirit  
470 flew and was gone. The other horses bolted,  
rattled the yoke, and tangled up their reins.  
Seeing the trace-horse lying in the dust,  
warlike Automedon soon solved the problem.  
He drew his sharp sword from his sturdy thigh  
and quickly cut the dead horse from the harness.  
The two remaining horses straightened out  
and pulled ahead inside their straps and tackle.  
The two men came together once again  
for conflict, which devours human hearts.  
Sarpedon’s shining weapon missed Patroclus.  
Its sharp point hurtled over his left shoulder  
and did not hit him. Then Patroclus threw  
480 his spear of bronze again, and did not miss.  
It struck Sarpedon’s lungs and throbbing heart.  
He fell—just like an oak tree or white poplar  
or stately pine, which woodsmen on the mountain  
cut with new-sharpened axes for a ship—  
so fell Sarpedon, lying there stretched out

590

600

610

beside his horses and his chariot,  
and howled and clutched the dust, soaked with his blood.  
As when a lion leaps into a herd  
of ambling cattle, and among them kills  
a brave red bull, who groans and grieves and dies,  
clutched in the lion's jaws—just so, Sarpedon,  
leader of Lycian warriors with shields,  
490 defeated by Patroclus, struggled hard  
against his death, and told the friend he loved,

620

“Sweet Glaucus, best of warriors, you must,  
now more than ever, be a brave, strong fighter.  
Now you must go in search of evil war,  
if you are quick and keen. Rush round and gather  
the Lycian leaders, urge them all to fight  
for me, Sarpedon. Fight for me yourself,  
with your bronze spear, or it will cause you shame  
forever, if the Greeks despoil my armor  
500 now I have fallen near their ships in battle.  
Be strong, be brave, and urge the others on!”

630

These were his final words. Death veiled his eyes  
and blocked his nose. Patroclus set his foot  
onto the dead man's chest and tugged his spear  
out of the flesh, and with it came the lungs.  
He pulled out both the weapon and the life.  
Sarpedon's snorting horses had escaped  
their masters' chariot and tried to flee.

640

The Myrmidons restrained them. Glaucus felt  
anguish about Sarpedon's final words,  
and deep distress that he could not protect him.  
510 His arm was hurting from the wound that Teucer,  
defending his companions from disaster,  
inflicted when he shot him with an arrow,  
when Glaucus tried to scale the lofty wall.  
He took his own hand, squeezed his arm, then prayed  
to the god who strikes from far away, Apollo.

“Hear me, my lord, in Troy if you are here,  
or in the fertile territory of Lycia.

You can hear anyone from anywhere  
in trouble, and I am in trouble now.

This wound is serious. Sharp shooting pains  
run through my arm, and my blood cannot clot.

The injury afflicts my shoulder too.

520 I cannot grasp my spear or fight the foe.

And now the best man in the world is dead,

Sarpedon, son of Zeus. That god did not

protect his child. But you, my Lord Apollo,

660

please cure this bitter wound and soothe my pain.

Grant me the strength to rouse my Lycian comrades  
to war, and let me fight for my dead friend.”

So Glaucus prayed and Phoebus heeded him.

He stopped his agony immediately,

and staunched the black blood in the dreadful wound

and put more strength and courage in his heart.

530 Glaucus could feel the change. His heart was glad  
because the god had heard his prayer so quickly.

He rushed around and urged the Lycian leaders

to fight and guard the body of Sarpedon.

670

Then with great strides he marched among the Trojans.

He reached godlike Agenor and Aeneas,

Polydamas, the son of Panthous,

and Hector in his armor made of bronze.

He stood among them and his winged words flew.

“Hector, have you forgotten all about us,

your allies, who are giving up our lives

for your sake, far away from our own people

540 and homeland? You are failing to protect us.

680

Sarpedon, leader of the Lycian fighters,

who guarded Lycia with his strength and judgment,

is lying dead, defeated by Patroclus,

who speared him with the help of brazen Ares.

Stand with us, friends! You ought to feel ashamed

to let the Myrmidons despoil his corpse

and strip his weapons in their rage because  
so many Greeks have died beside their ships,  
struck by our spears.”

At these words, desperate grief  
engulfed the Trojans, and they could not bear it.

690

550 Although he was a foreigner, Sarpedon  
had been the guardian of Troy, commanding  
so many troops to fight in Troy’s defense,  
while he himself fought hardest of them all.  
They rushed directly at the Greeks. Their leader  
was Hector, outraged at Sarpedon’s death.  
Meanwhile, the Greeks were urged on by Patroclus,  
son of Menoetius. From his hairy chest,  
he called out to the sons of Atreus,  
who were already hankering for battle.

700

“Now, sons of Atreus, fend off the foe!  
Act with the courage you have shown before,  
or even greater zeal. The man who first  
leapt at the ramparts of the Greeks, Sarpedon  
lies dead. We need to seize him, mutilate him,  
560 strip from his back his armor and his weapons,  
and kill with pitiless bronze those friends of his  
who guard him.”

So he spoke. They were already  
eager to fight. Both sides made strong their ranks—  
Trojans and Lycians, Myrmidons and Greeks.  
Then, with unearthly screams, the two sides met  
around the body of the dead Sarpedon.  
Their weapons clashed and clanged, and Zeus spread out  
sinister night across the grappling fighters,  
so that the battle for his precious son  
would cost great pain and massive loss of life.  
At first, the Trojans had the upper hand  
over the bright-eyed Greeks, because they lost  
570 one of their finest men, a Myrmidon,

710

son of brave Agacles, fine Epigeus,  
 who once was ruler of rich Budium,  
 but then he killed his cousin and ran off  
 to beg for help from silver-footed Thetis  
 and Peleus. They sent him with Achilles,  
 breaker of men, to Troy where foals run free,  
 to fight the Trojans. As he touched the corpse,  
 glorious Hector threw a stone at him,  
 and hit his head. Inside the sturdy helmet  
 his skull was smashed and he fell down, face-first,

580

onto the corpse, and death that shatters life  
 flooded across him. Deep grief seized Patroclus  
 for his dead comrade, and he rushed ahead  
 through the front line of fighters—like a falcon  
 whose swift attack scares off jackdaws and starlings—  
 just so, Patroclus, lord of horses, you  
 dashed straight towards the Lycians and the Trojans,  
 heartsick with fury at your comrade's death.

730

Patroclus hurled a stone at Sthenelaus,  
 Ithaemenes' dear son, and hit his neck  
 and crushed the tendons. Then the foremost fighters,  
 including glorious Hector, yielded ground.

740

590

As far as a long javelin can travel,  
 cast by a man competing in a contest  
 or hurled in war against his murderous foes,  
 so far the Trojans moved back in retreat,  
 pressed by the Greeks. But Glaucus, the commander  
 of Lycian warriors equipped with shields,  
 turned round and killed brave Bathycles, dear son  
 of Chalcon, who had made his home in Hellas,  
 the wealthiest of all the Myrmidons.

Bathycles had been chasing after Glaucus,  
 but when he reached him, Glaucus quickly swiveled  
 and plunged his spear in his pursuer's chest.  
 The dead man's armor clattered as he fell.

750

600

At such a brave man's fall, the Greeks were seized  
 by overwhelming sorrow, while the Trojans  
 rejoiced and clustered round his corpse. The Greeks  
 did not forget their courage. They pushed forward



against the enemy. Meriones  
attacked Laogonus, a Trojan leader,  
bold son of Onetor, a priest of Zeus  
on Ida, who was honored by his people  
as if he were a god. But now the Greek  
struck him beneath his jaw, below his ear.

760

At once life left his limbs and cruel darkness  
seized him. Aeneas threw his spear of bronze  
towards Meriones. He hoped to hit him  
beneath his shield as he advanced. But seeing  
the spear of bronze, Meriones ducked down,  
bending his body forward, and the weapon  
stuck in the ground behind him. Its long shaft  
quivered, and there great Ares quelled its force.  
The shivering spear-tip of Aeneas went  
inside the earth. It flew from his strong hand  
in vain. Aeneas was enraged at heart  
and said,

770

“Meriones, my spear would soon  
have put a stop to you if I had hit you,  
though you are certainly quite good at dancing.”

The warrior Meriones replied,  
“Aeneas, it is difficult for you  
to quench the life in all your enemies  
if they defend themselves. You are a mortal.  
Were I to hurl my sharp bronze spear at you  
and strike, you would soon give your life to Hades,  
the god of death, the lord of famous foals,  
and give me victory, despite your strength,  
despite your confidence in your own hands.”

780

Then valiant Patroclus scolded him.  
“Meriones, why are you saying this?  
You are a warrior, so you know better.  
The Trojans will not leave the corpse alone,  
no matter what you say against them, brother.

790

630 Words are for council meetings. War needs hands.  
This is no time to talk. We need to fight.”

With this, he led his godlike comrade onward.  
As loud as when, high in the mountain glens,  
woodchoppers cut down trees and noise is heard  
even from very far away—so loud  
the crash and rumble on the wide-wayed earth  
of bronze and hide and well-formed ox-skin shields.  
With swords and pliant spears, men stabbed each other.  
Sarpedon had become invisible  
even to someone with the keenest sight.

800

640 From head to toe the noble man was covered  
in weapons, blood, and dust. Around the corpse  
they clustered—as when flies buzz round the milk pails  
in springtime on a farm, when milk aplenty  
drenches the barrels—so around the corpse  
they swarmed. Zeus never turned his shining eyes  
away from the bitter fighting. Constantly  
he kept his gaze upon them and considered  
how to arrange the slaughter of Patroclus.

810

Should glorious Hector kill him then and there  
in the fierce battle for godlike Sarpedon,  
650 and strip the arms and armor from his body?  
Or should more people suffer, toil, and grieve?  
After consideration, he decided  
that fine Patroclus, comrade of Achilles,  
should drive the Trojans, led by bronze-armed Hector,  
back to the city and take many lives.

First Zeus put fear in Hector’s heart, and Hector  
jumped in his chariot and turned to flee,  
and called the other Trojans to retreat.

820

He recognized the sacred scales of Zeus.  
None of the warlike Lycians stood their ground.  
660 They saw their leader wounded in the chest,  
then lying dead beneath a pile of corpses.  
Many had fallen on Sarpedon’s body,  
when mighty Zeus, the son of Cronus, tugged  
the sturdy rope of war. Now all of them

turned round and ran away. Meanwhile, the Greeks  
stripped off Sarpedon's glittering bronze weapons,  
and brave Patroclus gave them to his comrades  
to carry to the hollow ships. Then Zeus,  
who forms the clusters of the clouds, addressed  
Apollo.

830

670           “Come now, Phoebus, my dear son,  
remove Sarpedon far from all the weapons  
and clean the storm-black blood away from him.  
Wash him with streams of water from the river,  
anoint him with immortal oil, ambrosia,  
and put immortal clothing on his body. 840  
Then let the twins, swift Sleep and swifter Death,  
carry him speedily to his own homeland,  
the fertile countryside of spacious Lycia,  
and there his brothers, family, and neighbors  
can mourn him with a funeral mound and gravestone.  
This is the prize of honor due the dead.”

Apollo listened to his father's orders.  
He went down from the mountaintop of Ida  
into the battlefield, and instantly  
lifted godlike Sarpedon from the fighting, 850  
washed him with streams of water from the river,  
680   anointed him with deathless oil, ambrosia,  
and put immortal clothing on his body.  
And then the twins, swift Sleep and swifter Death,  
carried him speedily to his own homeland,  
the fertile countryside of spacious Lycia.

Patroclus called Automedon to drive  
the chariot and horses close behind him,  
as he pursued the Trojans and the Lycians.  
In this, he made a terrible mistake, 860  
poor fool! If he had followed the advice  
Achilles, son of Peleus, had given,  
he would have managed to escape the doom

of death and darkness. But the plans of Zeus  
are always stronger than the plans of men.

690 With ease, he makes a brave man run away  
and so deprives him of his victory,  
or motivates another man to fight.  
So now he made Patroclus yearn for battle.  
Patroclus, when the gods began to call you  
to death, whom did you kill? Whom first, whom last?  
Adrastus first, Autonous, Echeclus,  
Perimus son of Megas, and Epistor,  
Pylartes, Melanippus, Mulius,  
and Elasmus. He killed all these. The others  
turned all their thoughts to flight. Then would the Greeks  
have taken high-walled Troy—Patroclus rushed  
with such firm purpose in his hands and spear—  
700 had not Apollo taken his position  
high on the sturdy watchtower to defend  
the Trojans and bring danger to Patroclus.  
Three times Patroclus reached the high tower's edge.  
Three times Apollo pushed him back again,  
nudging his bright shield with immortal hands.  
But when the godlike hero tried a fourth time,  
the god's voice rumbled with a dreadful warning.

870

880

“Give up, Patroclus. It is not your fate  
to make the Trojans fall beneath your spear.  
Even Achilles will not take this city,  
although he is superior to you.”

890

710 Patroclus yielded to avoid the wrath  
of Phoebus, who can strike from far away.

Hector meanwhile restrained his hard-hoofed horses  
beside the Scaean Gates. He was unsure  
if he should drive them on into the tumult  
and fight, or call his people to retreat  
back to the city wall. As he was thinking,  
Phoebus Apollo came and stood beside him,

in human form. He looked like Asius,  
the fine, strong uncle of horse-taming Hector,  
brother of Hecuba, and son of Dumas,  
who lived in Phrygia by the flowing River  
Sangarius. This was the form Apollo,  
720 the son of Zeus, took as he spoke to Hector.

900

“Hector, why are you holding back from battle?  
You must not. How I wish my strength outmatched  
yours by as much as yours outmatches mine!  
Then I would make you pay a costly price  
for this retreat. But come now, drive your horses  
towards Patroclus. Maybe you will kill him.  
You may be granted victory by Apollo.”

910

And then the god went back amid the mêlée.  
Glorious Hector told Cebriones,  
his skillful driver, to whip on the horses  
towards the battle. In the throng, Apollo  
caused panic and confusion for the Greeks,  
730 and triumph for the Trojans led by Hector.  
But Hector did not kill the other Greeks.  
He let them go, and made his strong-hoofed horses  
seek out Patroclus. For his part, Patroclus  
leapt from his chariot, stood on the ground,  
and held a spear in his left hand. His right  
picked up a jagged, glittering stone of quartz.  
He wrapped his fist around it, took his stance,  
and did not hesitate for long—he threw it.  
The sharp stone did not miss. It struck the driver,  
Cebriones, a bastard son of Priam,  
right on his forehead as he held the reins.  
740 It crushed both brows and broke his skull. His eyes  
fell on the dusty ground before his feet.  
He plunged out of the chariot like a diver.  
Life left his bones. And you, horse-lord Patroclus,  
mocked him.

920

930

“My goodness, you are quite the gymnast!

What a fine somersault! If he were sailing  
the fish-filled sea, I think this man would leap  
out of the boat, however bad the weather,  
and catch sea squirts to feed a multitude.  
Even on dry ground, he can tumble nimbly  
out of his chariot. Among the Trojans  
there certainly must be some acrobats.”

750

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With this, he pounced on fierce Cebriones—  
as when a lion pounces on a farmstead,  
and wrecks the stables, but his chest is wounded,  
and his own courage kills him—with that fervor,  
Patroclus, you attacked Cebriones.

Then Hector jumped out of his chariot  
down to the ground. The two of them contended  
around Cebriones—as hungry lions  
fight on the mountaintop for a dead deer—

so those two lords, the masters of the war cry,  
Menoetius’ son Patroclus and bright Hector,  
fought for Cebriones, and each man tried  
to slice the other’s flesh with pitiless bronze.

760

Hector grabbed hold of his opponent’s head  
and did not let it go. Patroclus seized  
his enemy’s foot. The other Greeks and Trojans  
joined the fierce fighting also—as when winds  
from east and south, Eurus and Notus, clash  
in mountain glens and batter forest trees—

the oak, the ash, the smooth-barked cornel tree  
strike one another with their slim, sharp branches  
and snap with creaks and otherworldly groans—

770

so did the Greeks and Trojans swoop together  
and kill each other. No one thought of flight.  
Around Cebriones the weapons clustered—  
sharp spears drove deep inside their targets, arrows  
flew forth from bowstrings on their restless wings,  
and big stones thudded against shields. They fought  
around the monumental man, who lay  
in whirling dust, his horsemanship forgotten.

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While Helius bestrode the middle sky,  
weapons struck both sides and the troops were dying.  
But when the sun god turned, about the time  
that plowmen free their oxen from the harness,  
780 the Greeks were stronger than their fate decreed.  
They dragged the warrior Cebriones  
out of the range of weapons and away  
from Trojan shouting, and stripped off his armor,  
and then Patroclus rushed against the Trojans  
with murder in his heart. Like rushing Ares, 980  
three times he leapt at them with dreadful cries,  
and every time he swooped, he killed nine men.  
But on your fourth attempt, godlike Patroclus,  
your life was finished. In the cutthroat combat,  
amid the chaos of the battlefield,  
Phoebus Apollo came to meet Patroclus.  
The human failed to see the eerie god,  
790 cloaked in thick mist. Apollo stood behind  
Patroclus, and with one flat palm he patted  
his back and sturdy shoulders, so his eyes  
swiveled. Apollo nudged his helmet off. 990  
It clattered underneath the horses' hooves.  
The crest of horsehair sprouting from its tip  
was soiled with blood and dust. Before this moment,  
it was against the norms of proper custom  
for any dust to smirch that horse-plumed helmet,  
when it protected the fine head and temples  
of godlike Lord Achilles. But now Zeus  
let Hector wear this helmet on his head,  
800 which brought his own destruction closer to him. 1000  
The big, long, thick, and sturdy spear Patroclus  
held in his hands was shattered all to pieces.  
His fine-fringed shield and sword-belt slipped and fell.  
Apollo, son of Zeus, unclipped his breastplate.  
Confusion seized his mind. His splendid body  
undone, he stood stock-still, in bafflement.  
And then a sharp spear struck him from behind,  
between the shoulders. A Dardanian,  
Euphorbus, son of Panthous, had hurled it

from very close at hand. He was the best  
of all the men his age at throwing spears  
and horsemanship and sprinting on quick feet.

1010

810 That very day Euphorbus had arrived  
at Troy behind his horses, and first learned  
the ways of war. He had already pushed  
twenty men off their chariots. He hit you,  
horse-lord Patroclus, but he did not kill you.  
He tugged the ash spear from your flesh, then ran  
back to the crowd. Although Patroclus was  
disarmed, Euphorbus would not wait to fight him  
in deadly combat, and he fled. Patroclus,  
struck by the god and wounded by the spear,  
drew back into the huddle with his comrades,  
to save his life and shun his fate. But Hector  
saw brave Patroclus wounded and retreating.

1020

820 He muscled through the crowd, got near Patroclus  
and speared him underneath the ribs, and drove  
the bronze point through his body. With a thud  
he fell. The army of the Greeks lamented.

Just as a lion bests a tireless boar,  
when on the mountainside they fight together,  
both spirited, majestic warriors,  
because both want to drink from a small stream—  
the boar pants hard, defeated by the lion—  
so Hector, son of Priam, standing close,  
stabbed with his spear and took away the life  
of brave Patroclus, who had killed so many.  
Then Hector boasted and his words took wing.

1030

830 “Patroclus, I suppose you thought you would  
destroy my city and enslave the women  
of Troy and rob them of their day of freedom,  
and take them in your ships to your own homeland.  
Fool! Hector’s horses galloped to protect them.  
Their hooves were eager for the battlefield.  
I am the finest of the valiant fighters  
of Troy, and I defend the Trojan women  
from slavery, the day they lose their freedom.

1040



But as for you—vultures will eat you up!  
You are a weakling, and your great Achilles  
did you no good at all. He stayed behind.  
I bet he told you, when you left for battle,  
'Patroclus, do not drive your chariot back  
here to the hollow ships until you slice  
right through the bloody tunic to the chest  
of murderous Hector.' So he spoke, I think,  
and you, poor fool, attempted to obey him."

1050

Though little strength remained to you, Patroclus,  
you answered, "Hector, you make big boasts now.  
Zeus, son of Cronus, and Apollo gave you  
victory, and with ease the gods have crushed me.  
They took the arms and armor from my body.  
If twenty men like you had challenged me,  
all of them would have died beneath my spear.  
But cruel destiny, and Leto's son,  
Apollo, killed me, and my human killer,  
Euphorbus. You were third to slaughter me.  
But I will tell you this—take it to heart.  
You surely have not long to live. Your death  
and overwhelming fate stand near you now.  
The hands of great Achilles will defeat you."

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1070

His death wrapped round him as he spoke. His spirit  
flew from his limbs to Hades, and she mourned  
his fate, and left his manhood and his youth.  
Great Hector spoke to him though he was dead—

"Patroclus, why do you foretell for me  
a bitter end? Who knows if great Achilles,  
the son of Thetis with the braided hair,  
may fall beneath my spear and lose his life?"

With this, he set his foot onto the corpse  
and tugged his spear of bronze out of the wound,  
and shoved him down again onto his back.

1080

At once he hurtled at Automedon,  
the godlike charioteer of swift Achilles,  
the grandson of great Aeacus. And Hector  
leveled his spear and hoped to hit that driver,  
Automedon. But he was carried off  
by the swift immortal horses, who were given  
as splendid gifts to Peleus by the gods.

## BOOK 17



# Battle for a Dead Man

Amid the throng of battle, Menelaus,  
the son of Atreus, the friend of Ares,  
had seen Patroclus slaughtered by the Trojans.  
Dressed in his shining armor made of bronze,  
he rushed between the fighters at the front  
to stand astride the dead man—just as when  
a mother cow who has just given birth,  
a first-time mother with her firstborn child,  
straddles her little calf and moos above him,  
so Menelaus stood astride Patroclus.  
He held his finely balanced shield, and brandished  
his spear in front of him, prepared to kill  
anyone who approached him. And Euphorbus,  
the son of Panthous, had also seen  
noble Patroclus fall. He came up close  
and said to warlike Menelaus,

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“Yield!  
Commander of the troops, king under Zeus,  
great son of Atreus, Lord Menelaus,

draw back and leave this corpse and let me seize  
the bloody spoils. I was the first of all  
the Trojans and the famous Trojan allies  
to strike Patroclus with the spear I threw  
amid the violent fighting. Let me win  
glory in Troy! Or I will hurl my spear,  
strike you, and rob you of your precious life.”

20

Angrily, ruddy Menelaus answered,  
“By Zeus! It is not good to boast too much.

20 No panther, lion, or destructive boar,  
the proudest and most spirited of creatures,  
matches the sons of Panthous in pride.

30

Your brother, Hyperenor, was the same—  
a strong young horse-tamer, whose youth was wasted  
when he faced me, insulted me, and called me  
the weakest of the warriors of Greece.

I doubt he managed to walk home again  
to make his loving wife and parents happy.

Now, in exactly the same way, I shall  
destroy you, if you stand there and confront me.

30 I tell you now, go back into the crowd,  
rejoin your comrades, do not challenge me,  
or else you will be very badly hurt.

40

Fools understand too late, when done is done.”

Euphorbus did not listen. He replied,  
“Now, Menelaus, noble high commander,  
you pay the price for slaughtering my brother!  
You boasted over him and made his wife  
a widow in her new-built bridal chamber,  
causing unspeakable distress and pain  
and cries of lamentation for our parents.

But I can soothe their sorrow if I place  
your head and armor in my parents’ hands—  
40 poor grieving Panthous and noble Phrontis.  
The fight will not remain untried for long,  
whether I win or force you to retreat.”

50

With this, he struck him on his round bronze shield,  
which did not break—instead, it bent the spear.  
Euphorbus stepped back, and great Menelaus,  
the son of Atreus, with prayers to Zeus,  
skewered his lower throat and confidently  
pushed with his firm hand, so the bronze tip pierced  
right through his soft neck, and he clattered down,  
his weapons clashing round him as he fell.  
His hair, pinched into locks adorned with spirals  
of gold and silver, lovely as the Graces',  
was soaked with blood. As when a man has grown  
an olive sapling in a lonely place—  
plentiful water bubbles up around it,  
and it is fine and flourishing and strong—  
nodding and quivering amid the breezes  
and thick with bright white blossom—suddenly  
amid a massive storm, a blast of wind  
uproots it from its trench and lays it low  
onto the ground—just so, great Menelaus  
slaughtered Euphorbus, son of Panthous,  
and took his armor and his spear of ash.  
As when a lion, mountain born, who trusts  
his strength and courage, finds a herd of cattle  
grazing, and pounces on the finest cow  
and grasps her in his jaws and snaps her neck,  
rips through her flesh and gulps her blood, devouring  
her entrails—and the dogs and herdsmen gather  
around him, shouting, but they keep their distance,  
unwilling to approach and pale with fear—  
just so, no Trojan dared approach to challenge  
glorious Menelaus, and with ease  
he would have stripped away the splendid arms  
of dead Euphorbus, son of Panthous,  
but great Apollo would not let him do it.  
The god spurred Hector, who was fierce as Ares.  
Apollo made himself look like a human,  
Mentes, who led the great Ciconians,  
and in this guise his words took wing.

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“Now, Hector,  
you chase the unattainable, pursuing  
the horses of Achilles. They are hard  
for mortal men to tame or break or drive—  
except the grandson of great Aeacus,  
who is the son of an immortal goddess.  
And meanwhile, Menelaus, warlike son  
of Atreus, bestraddling Patroclus,  
has killed the finest fighter of the Trojans,  
Euphorbus, son of Panthous, and quelled  
his eagerness to fight.”

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With this, the god  
drew back again towards the toiling fighters.  
Terrible grief wrapped round the heart of Hector.  
He scanned the warriors and saw at once  
the victor stripping off the splendid armor,  
the victim lying on the ground, as blood  
seeped from his open wound. Then Hector strode  
amid the champion fighters at the front.  
He shone like an unquenchable bright flame  
lit by Hephaestus, as he ran bedecked  
in shining bronze and bellowed cries of war.  
The son of Atreus, Lord Menelaus,  
heard Hector’s noisy war cries, was dismayed  
and asked his own brave heart,

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“What shall I do?  
If I abandon these fine arms and armor  
and leave Patroclus, who is lying here  
because he fought to claim back what I lost,  
then any warrior who sees me do it  
will surely blame me. But if I should fight  
alone against great Hector and the Trojans,  
because I am ashamed to run away,  
then I will be outnumbered and surrounded  
by many warriors, out here alone.  
But why does my mind even ask this question?  
If anyone defies divine intentions

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and tries to fight a man a god has honored,  
immediately disaster rolls towards him.

100 No Greek should blame me if he sees me yield  
to Hector, who makes war with help from gods.  
But if I find the master of the war cry,  
great Ajax, anywhere, then we could both  
fight bravely, with our minds intent on courage,  
even against a god, and try to save  
the body for Achilles. That would be  
the best of outcomes in this worst of times.”

130

As he was pondering in heart and mind  
the Trojans were advancing, led by Hector,  
and Menelaus moved back from the body,  
constantly turning round and glancing backward—  
just like a thick-maned lion, who is driven

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110 out of a barnyard by the dogs and men  
with spears and shouts and barks, and his hot courage  
freezes—against his will, he leaves the farm—  
so ruddy Menelaus left Patroclus,  
then reached his comrades, stopped, and turned around,  
seeking the mighty son of Telamon,  
Ajax—and very soon he spotted him,  
upon the left flank of the battlefield,  
encouraging his men to join the fighting,  
and reassuring them, because Apollo  
had cast uncanny terror in their hearts.  
Then Menelaus quickly ran to him  
and stood beside him and said,

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“Ajax, come!

120 Hurry, my friend! We must save dead Patroclus,  
and bring at least his body to Achilles,  
without his arms, which bright-helmed Hector took.”

With this, he roused the spirit of great Ajax,  
who hurried with him through the frontline fighters.  
Hector had stripped Patroclus of his armor,

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and then he tried to drag the corpse away,  
to cut the head off with his sharp bronze sword  
and give the body to the dogs of Troy.

Ajax approached him with his towering shield,  
and Hector drew back to his group of comrades,  
and jumped into his chariot and gave

130 the splendid arms and armor to the Trojans  
to take to Troy so he would win renown.

But Ajax laid his broad shield on Patroclus  
and stood to guard him—as a lion leading  
her young ones through the forest meets with hunters  
and stops to guard her cubs—she trusts her strength,  
and scrunches up her face to veil her eyes—  
so Ajax stood astride the dead Patroclus.

Beside him, warlike Menelaus stood,  
fostering pain and grief inside his chest.

140 Then Glaucus, leader of the Lycians, son  
of Lord Hippolochus, glanced with a frown  
at Hector, and reproached him with harsh words.

“Hector, you look so pretty, but you lack  
any ability in war. You have

a splendid reputation but you run  
away from battle like a little girl!

But now consider how to save your city  
with just the fighters who were born in Troy  
and no more allies. You will be alone.

None of the Lycian warriors will fight  
to save your city from the Greeks, because  
we got no benefit from constant battle  
against your enemies. Why would you save  
a man of lower rank amid the throng,

150 you coward, when you left your guest and comrade,  
Sarpedon, for the Greeks as spoil and prey?

Sarpedon helped your city and yourself  
while he was still alive, but even so  
you did not dare protect him from the dogs.

So if the Lycians listen to me now,  
we shall go home, and there will surely be

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total destruction for the town of Troy.

But if the Trojans had the steady courage

and dauntless spirit that infuses men

who strive and struggle with an enemy

to save their homeland, we would quickly drag

Patroclus into Troy, and if this corpse

160 came to the mighty city of King Priam,

drawn from the battle, then the Greeks would soon

give up the splendid armor of Sarpedon,

and we could bring him also into Troy.

This dead man was the comrade of the best

by far of all the Greeks beside the ships,

and their battalion is the best as well.

But you did not dare stand and face brave Ajax

and look him in the eyes and fight with him,

because he is superior to you.”

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Then, with his helmet glinting, Hector scowled,

and answered, “Why would somebody like you

170 say something so absurdly arrogant,

Glaucus? This is ridiculous! I thought

that you were the most sensible of all

the people who inhabit fertile Lycia.

But now I think you must be very stupid

for saying this. You claim I failed to stand

and face gigantic Ajax. But I never

shudder at battle or the noise of horses.

And yet the will of Zeus who bears the aegis

is always greater than the will of humans,

and he can make a brave man run away

and rob him of his victory with ease,

or urge us into battle as he wishes.

So come and stand with me, my friend, and watch

my work the whole day long, and you shall see

180 if I am cowardly, as you have said,

or if I stop the brave and eager Greeks

from fighting to defend the dead Patroclus.”

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With this, he shouted loudly to the Trojans.

“Trojans and Lycians and Dardanian allies,  
be men, my friends! Remember all your courage!  
Let me put on the splendid arms and armor  
of glorious Achilles, which I took  
from strong Patroclus when I slaughtered him.”

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190 With this, great Hector in his flashing helmet  
ran from the battlefield on nimble feet  
after his comrades, who were carrying  
the armor of Achilles back to Troy.  
He soon caught up—they had not gone too far—  
and standing at a distance from the fighting,  
the source of tears, he changed into this armor.  
He gave his own equipment to the Trojans  
to carry back with them to holy Troy,  
and armed himself in the immortal armor  
of great Achilles, son of Peleus.  
The gods on Mount Olympus gave this armor  
to Peleus, Achilles’ loving father.  
When he grew old, he gave it to his son,  
who wore it, but would never reach old age.  
When Zeus, the god who gathers clouds together,  
saw from a distance Hector putting on  
the arms and armor of godlike Achilles,  
200 he shook his head and told himself,

250

“Poor fool!

You are not thinking about death at all,  
but death is near you. You are putting on  
the deathless armor of the best of men,  
at whom all others tremble. You have killed  
the brave and gentle comrade of this man,  
and you have wrongly taken up his arms  
and dressed your head and body in his armor.  
For now, I plan to grant you great success  
as compensation, because you will never  
go home from battle, and Andromache  
will never take from you the splendid arms  
of great Achilles, son of Peleus.”

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270

With this, the son of Cronus bowed his head,  
nodding with darkened brows. He made the armor  
210 fit close to Hector's body. Dreadful Ares,  
the god of mayhem, entered him and filled  
his limbs with strength and courage. With a war cry,  
he dashed amid the leaders of the allies,  
so all of them could see that he was wearing  
the shining arms and armor of Achilles.  
He went among them and encouraged them—  
Thersilochus, Hippothous, Disenor,  
Asteropeus, Glaucus, Medon, Mesthles,  
Chromius, Phorcys, Ennomus the seer—  
and urged them all with words that flew on wings. 280

220 "Listen to me, great tribes of allied neighbors!  
I gathered each of you from your own towns  
and brought you here to Troy, not out of need,  
and not because I wanted a large army,  
but so that you could willingly protect  
the wives and little children of the Trojans 290  
against the warlike Greeks. This is my reason  
for keeping my own troops on such short rations,  
so I can give the food and gifts to you  
and help you all grow strong and proud. So now,  
all of you, turn and face the enemy,  
and live or die in the caress of war.  
Although Patroclus is already dead,  
whoever drags him to the Trojan horsemen  
230 and forces Ajax to submit to us  
shall share the spoils with me in equal part, 300  
and gain an equal share of fame and glory."

At this, they pushed ahead with all their might,  
brandishing spears, and in their hearts they longed  
to drag the corpse from Telamonian Ajax—  
poor fools! As they were fighting for the body,  
Ajax took many lives. But then he said  
to Menelaus, master of the war cry,

“Dear Menelaus, leader loved by Zeus,  
now I no longer think the two of us  
can get away from battle and go home.

310

240 I am not so afraid for dead Patroclus,  
who soon will glut the dogs and birds of Troy,  
as for my own life and for yours. I worry  
that we may suffer something terrible  
because a cloud of war veils everything—  
Hector, and ruin is revealed to us.  
Summon the finest fighters of the Greeks,  
and see if anyone will hear our cries.”

At this, loud Menelaus raised his voice  
and shouted to the Greeks, “My friends! Greek leaders,  
250 who drink beside my brother and myself  
at public cost! Commanders of the troops!  
You have respect and privilege from Zeus.  
I cannot pick out individual leaders  
because the conflict rages so intensely.  
Come of your own accord. Your hearts should feel  
shame, if you let Patroclus be a plaything  
for Trojan dogs.”

320

Oilean Ajax heard him,  
ran swiftly through the mêlée, and approached.  
And Idomeneus came with his herald,  
Meriones, as fierce as murderous Ares.

330

260 Who could remember all the other names  
of those who followed them and roused the Greeks  
to war? The Trojans surged ahead to meet them.  
As at the outlet of a river, swollen  
by rain—huge waves resound against the current,  
the salt sea sputters out beyond its bounds,  
and at the farthest reaches of the shore  
the headlands echo with the sound—so loudly  
the Trojans shouted as they marched. The Greeks  
stood firm around Patroclus with one purpose,  
fenced firm with bronze shields. Round their shining helmets  
Zeus, son of Cronus, cast thick mist, because

340

270 Patroclus had been dear to him before,  
 in former times, when he was still alive,  
 when he had been the comrade of Achilles.  
 The god refused to let him be the plaything  
 of Trojan dogs, among his enemies,  
 and so he roused his comrades to protect him.  
 The Trojans forced the bright-eyed Greeks to flee, 350  
 leaving the corpse behind. And yet the victors  
 did not pursue and kill their enemies  
 with spears, although they wanted to. Instead,  
 the Trojans started dragging off the body.  
 The Greeks held back for just a little while.  
 Soon they were turned around again by Ajax,  
 who was the very best of all the Greeks  
 in his appearance and accomplishments,  
 280 after Achilles, son of Peleus.  
 He flew straight through the champions at the front, 360  
 just as a wild boar in the mountain glens  
 wheels round and scatters strong young men and dogs  
 easily—so the son of Telamon,  
 glorious Ajax, plunged amid the ranks  
 of Trojans. Easily he put to flight  
 the warriors assembled round Patroclus,  
 who struggled mightily to drag him back  
 to Troy and win a triumph for themselves.  
 Hippothous, who was the noble son  
 of Lethus, the Pelasgian, dragged away 370  
 the body through the fighting by the foot,  
 using his baldric tied about the ankle,  
 290 around the tendons of the leg. He hoped  
 to benefit the Trojans, led by Hector,  
 but soon disaster came to him, and no one  
 could save him from it though they longed to do so.  
 Ajax pushed through the throng, came close, and struck  
 his bronze-cheeked helmet with its horsehair plume,  
 which shattered at the impact of the blow  
 dealt by his strong hand and his sharp-tipped spear. 380  
 Around the socket of the blade, the brains  
 erupted, bloody, from the open wound.

His spirit left him, and he dropped the foot  
of brave Patroclus on the ground, and lay  
300 face-down beside the other slaughtered man,  
far from Larissa where the fields are fertile,  
and failed to recompense his loving parents  
for raising him. His life was very brief,  
cut short by valiant Ajax with his spear.  
Then Hector hurled his shining spear of bronze 390  
at Ajax, but he saw it coming at him,  
and moved a little, so instead it struck  
Schedius, son of Iphitus, the best  
by far of all the Phocians. He had lived  
in famous Panopeus and was lord  
of many people. But the spear's bronze tip  
went through the middle of his collarbone  
310 and out the other side, below his shoulder.  
His weapons clattered round him as he fell.  
Then Ajax struck the skillful fighter Phorcys, 400  
the son of Phaenops, piercing through his belly  
as he was straddling Hippothous.  
His breastplate shattered, and the bronze sucked out  
the entrails. Down he fell and clutched the dust.  
Then glorious Hector and his champion fighters  
drew back. The Greeks let out a mighty cry,  
and dragged away the bodies of the dead—  
Hippothous and Phorcys—and stripped off  
the weapons from their bodies. Then the Trojans  
would have been driven back to Troy, defeated 410  
320 by their own cowardice, and thus the Greeks  
would have achieved a victory beyond  
the will of Zeus, through their own strength and courage.  
But then the god Apollo intervened,  
encouraging Aeneas, in the guise  
of Periphas, the son of Epytes,  
a herald who had grown old in the service  
of old Anchises, father of Aeneas.  
He was a shrewd and kindly councillor.  
Looking like him, Apollo, son of Zeus, 420  
spoke to Aeneas.

“Can you not, Aeneas,  
protect tall Troy without divine assistance?  
I have seen other men put confidence  
in their own courage, diligence, and strength,  
and in their own troops, even if they have  
330 a weaker army. But Zeus wants to give  
the victory to us and not the Greeks.  
And even so, you Trojans are so scared  
you run away in fear! You will not fight!”

Aeneas looked Apollo in the face,  
and recognized the god of distances,  
and shouted, “Hector! And you other leaders  
of Troy, and leaders of the Trojan allies!  
It is a shame if we are driven back  
to Troy, defeated by our cowardice.  
One of the gods just came to me and said  
that Zeus on high, the god of strategy,  
supports us in this battle. So we must  
rush at the Greeks, attacking them head-on!  
340 We must not let them take the dead Patroclus  
down to their ships so easily.”

With this,  
he leapt ahead and stood right at the front.  
The Trojans turned around to face the Greeks.  
And then Aeneas hurled his spear and struck  
Leocritus, the son of Arisbas,  
the noble friend of warlike Lycomedes—  
who saw him falling, pitied him, and rushed  
to stand beside him, hurled his shining spear  
and struck Apisaon, the people’s shepherd,  
the son of Hippasus, beneath his midriff  
and through his liver, and his limbs untied.  
350 From lush Paeonia, Apisaon  
had come to Troy, and was the best at fighting,  
after the warrior Asteropeus,  
who saw him fall, and pitied him, and rushed  
to join the fight against the Greeks. And yet

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he could not do it, because they were standing  
around Patroclus with their shields as fences,  
holding their spears out. Ajax ranged among them,  
forbidding any of them to draw back,

460

or fight in front of all the other Greeks.  
He urged them to stay clustered round the corpse,  
prepared to fight in combat hand to hand.

360 Gigantic Ajax gave the troops these orders  
and soon the ground was wet with dark red blood.  
Packed closely side by side, the men fell dead—  
the Trojans, noble allies, and the Greeks.

The battle cost the Greeks some loss of blood,  
although far fewer died because they always  
kept close to one another in the throng  
and saved each other's lives. They fought like fire,  
and you would think the sun and moon were gone,  
because the battle of the finest fighters

470

370 around the dead Patroclus was so shrouded  
in fog. The other well-armed Greeks and Trojans  
fought unimpeded, beneath clear, bright skies,  
with dazzling sunlight shining down upon them.

There were no clouds across the earth and mountains.  
They stood at a great distance from each other,  
and often paused the fighting, to avoid  
the painful weapons of the other side.

480

But in the middle of the battlefield,  
the leaders had to fight amid the fog,  
constantly buffeted by cruel bronze,  
exhausted. And meanwhile, two great Greek leaders,  
Antilochus and noble Thrasymedes,  
did not yet know Patroclus had been killed.

380 They thought that he was fighting with the Trojans  
amid the chaos at the front, alive.

They were concerned about their own companions,  
who might be dead or routed, so they fought  
far from the rest, as Nestor had instructed  
when he had sent them forth from the black ships  
to war. So all day long the battle raged.

490

The conflict was intense, and constantly



the sweat of struggle drenched the hands and eyes  
and knees and legs and right down to the feet  
of every warrior who battled round  
the comrade of swift-footed Lord Achilles.

As when a man gives to his underlings

500

390

a mighty bull's hide that still drips with fat,  
to stretch, and they stand round it in a circle  
and pull in all directions, and the moisture  
soon disappears and the fat seeps in,  
as many men are pulling it at once,  
and thus the whole hide is completely stretched—  
just so, within that little space, the body  
was dragged in all directions by both armies.

Both sides were hopeful, and the Trojans thought  
that they could drag the body back to Troy.

510

The Greeks were confident that they could take it  
back to the hollow ships. The battle grew  
so wild, the sight of it would have impressed  
Athena and the rabble-rouser Ares,  
even if they were at their most enraged.

400

That day, Zeus stretched the painful work of war  
for men and horses, struggling for Patroclus.

But all the while, godlike Achilles still  
knew nothing of his death, because the battle  
was very far away from the swift ships,  
beneath the wall of Troy, and he had not  
expected in his heart his friend would die.

520

He thought Patroclus would approach the gates  
but then come safely home again, alive.

He certainly did not think he would try  
to sack the city on his own, without him,  
or even with him. Many times, his mother  
had talked to him in private, telling him

the plans of mighty Zeus. And yet his mother

410

had not revealed to him what had just happened,  
this terrible disaster—that his friend,  
the man he loved the most of all by far,  
was dead. And constantly around his corpse  
they pressed and killed each other with sharp spears.

530

The bronze-armed Greeks were saying to each other,

“My friends, we will receive no fame or glory  
if we retreat back to the hollow ships.  
It would be better if the black earth opened  
to swallow all of us right here and now  
if we allow the Trojans, skillful horsemen,  
to drag Patroclus back to their own town  
and win the victory.”

540

And the valiant Trojans  
420 were saying, “Even if it is our lot,  
my friends, that all of us should die together  
over this man, we must not shrink from war.”

These words made everybody keen to fight.  
The iron din reached through the barren air  
up to the sky of bronze. And far away  
from where they fought, the horses of Achilles  
wept. They had started weeping when they learned  
their charioteer had fallen in the dust,  
defeated at the hands of murderous Hector.

550

Automedon, the son of Diores,  
thrashed them and thrashed them with his pliant whip,  
430 and coaxed them many times with gentle words  
and threatened them with many bitter curses.  
But they would not move back towards the ships  
beside the spreading Hellespont, nor go  
back to the battle where the Greeks were fighting.  
They kept on standing still, just like a pillar  
set on a dead man or dead woman’s tomb—  
they held the splendid chariot so still,  
and bowed their heads towards the ground. Hot tears  
flowed from their weeping eyelids to the earth  
as they were grieving for their charioteer.  
Their thick manes, tumbling down beside the harness  
440 on both sides of the yoke, were soiled with dust.  
Seeing them crying, Zeus, the son of Cronus,

560

pitied them, shook his head and told himself,

“Poor things! Why did we give you to a mortal,  
King Peleus, though you are both immortal  
and free from age? Was it to make you suffer  
among unhappy humans? There is nothing  
more miserable than them, of all the creatures  
that breathe and move across the earth. But Hector  
shall never mount your splendid chariot  
or drive you. I forbid it. Is it not  
450 enough that he has seized Achilles’ armor,  
and boasts about it? I shall strengthen you  
and give you energy in heart and body,  
so you can save Automedon and take him  
out of the battle to the hollow ships.  
I want to grant more glory to the Trojans,  
and let them kill until they reach the ships  
at sunset, when the holy darkness falls.”

570

580

With this, he breathed keen courage into them.  
The horses shook the dust out from their manes  
onto the ground and galloped off and pulled  
the chariot between the Greeks and Trojans.  
Automedon, still grieving for his comrade,  
rode into battle and attacked, as nimbly  
460 as when an eagle swoops among the geese.  
With ease, he drew back from the noisy throng  
and easily attacked again, pursuing  
the Trojans through the massive crowd of fighters.  
But as he hurried in pursuit, he failed  
to kill a single man. He was alone  
inside the chariot, the gift of gods,  
so he could not attack them with his spear  
and, at the same time, hold the galloping horses.  
But then at last his friend Alcimedon,  
son of Laerces, son of Haemon, saw him,  
and stopped behind the chariot and said,

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470 “Automedon, which of the gods suggested  
this foolish plan and robbed you of good sense?  
To fight like this amid the foremost throng  
alone! Your comrade has been killed, and Hector  
carries the arms and armor of Achilles  
proudly.”

Automedon, Diores’ son,  
replied, “Alcimedon, what other Greek  
could manage to control immortal horses,  
except Patroclus while he was alive,  
whose judgment equaled the immortal gods’?  
Now death and destiny have come upon him,  
so you take up the whip and shining reins,  
480 and I will climb down from the chariot  
to fight.”

610

At this, Alcimedon leapt up  
into the swift war-chariot, and promptly  
took up the whip and reins. Automedon  
jumped out, and noble Hector saw them both.  
At once, he told Aeneas, who was standing  
beside him,

620

“Look, Aeneas! I can see  
the horses of swift-footed Lord Achilles,  
appearing on the battlefield, and driven  
by weak, unskillful drivers. I would like  
to capture them, if you are also willing,  
490 because they would not dare stand firm and fight us  
if both of us attack.”

So Hector spoke,  
and strong Aeneas did as he suggested.  
They rushed towards the enemy together,  
covered across their shoulders and their backs  
by sturdy, well-cured oxhide shields, encased  
in thick bronze, and beside them also marched

630

Chromius and Aretus, who was godlike.  
All of them hoped to kill the pair of Greeks  
and drive away their high-necked horses—fools!  
Before the Trojans left Automedon,  
blood would be spilled. And then Automedon  
prayed to the father, Zeus, and his dark heart  
was filled with strength and courage. And at once,  
500 he told Alcimedon, his loyal comrade,

640

“Alcimedon, do not allow the horses  
to move away from me, but keep them close,  
breathing right down my neck. I do not think  
Hector, the son of Priam, will hold back.  
He means to slaughter both of us and mount  
behind the fine-maned horses of Achilles  
and rout the ranks of Greeks—or he himself  
may meet his end among our finest fighters.”

With this, he summoned the two men named Ajax,  
and Menelaus. “Leaders of the Greeks,  
Ajax and Ajax and Lord Menelaus,  
let other warriors protect the corpse,  
510 surrounding him and fighting off the foe.  
Rescue the living from a dreadful death,  
or we shall die today. The finest fighters  
in all of Troy, great Hector and Aeneas,  
press hard against the two of us right here,  
upon the battlefield, the source of tears.  
The future rests upon the lap of gods.  
So I shall cast my spear but it is Zeus  
who will determine how all this will turn out.”

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660

With this, he aimed and hurled his long dark spear,  
and struck Aretus on his balanced shield,  
which did not stop the bronze—it pierced right through,  
under his belt and through his lower belly.  
520 As when a strong young man with a sharp axe  
cuts just behind the horns of a field ox

to slice right through the tendons, and the ox  
twitches and falls face-first—just so Aretus  
twitched and fell backward, and the sharp spear quivered,  
stuck in his stomach, and his limbs untied.

670

Then Hector hurled his shining spear again,  
aimed at Automedon, who saw the bronze  
and ducked, bent forward, and the weapon stuck  
into the ground behind him. Its long shaft  
trembled, and there great Ares quelled its force.

530 They would have moved in close and fought with swords  
had not the two named Ajax heard their comrade  
calling them through the throng. They went to help,  
and broke the fighters up, despite their zeal.

680

Hector, Aeneas, and great Chromius  
were frightened and drew back again, and left  
Aretus lying there, his core ripped open.  
Automedon, as swift as Ares, stripped  
the weapons from the body, and rejoiced.

“This comforts me a little in my grief  
for dead Patroclus, though the man I killed  
was not as brave as him.”

540 With this, he set  
the bloody weapons in the chariot  
and climbed inside it, with his feet and hands  
all bloody, like a lion who has eaten  
a bull. And then around the dead Patroclus  
the fighting became even more intense,  
and brought more cruelty and pain and tears.  
Athena came down from the sky and roused  
conflict. Far-seeing Zeus had sent her out  
to stir the Greeks, because his mind had turned.  
As when Zeus spreads across the sky a rainbow  
of vivid colors as a sign for mortals  
of war or bone-cold storms that stop the people  
550 from working on the land, and harm the flocks—  
just so, Athena wrapped around herself  
a cloud of vivid colors, and then joined

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the crowd of Greeks and urged each man to fight.  
First, she addressed the son of Atreus,  
valiant Menelaus, who was nearest.  
In body and in tireless voice the goddess  
resembled Phoenix as she said to him,

“It will be shameful and dishonorable  
for you, great Menelaus, if you let  
the swift dogs drag Achilles’ loyal comrade  
beneath the walls of Troy. Be strong. Hold firm.  
Encourage all the troops to do the same.”

710

560 Then Menelaus, master of the war cry,  
answered her, “Phoenix, father, grandpa, papa,  
I pray Athena gives me strength and guards me  
from flying weapons. I would like to stand  
beside Patroclus and take care of him.  
His death has touched my heart. But Hector has  
the force of fearsome fire, and his bronze spear  
slaughters unceasingly, because great Zeus  
is granting him success.”

720

At this, Athena,  
the goddess with the sparkling eyes, was pleased,  
because he named her first of all the gods.  
570 She made his arms and legs more powerful,  
and set in him the courage of a fly,  
who works so hard and so persistently,  
yearning to bite a human being’s flesh  
because she loves the taste of human blood.  
This was the boldness that the goddess put  
inside the inmost heart of Menelaus,  
and then he stood above the dead Patroclus  
and threw his shining spear. Among the Trojans  
there was a brave and wealthy man named Podes,  
a son of Eetion, whom Hector loved  
the most of all the people in the land,  
because he was his best friend and dear comrade.

730

Blond Menelaus struck him on his belt  
as he was turning round to run away.  
The bronze pierced through and with a clash, he fell.

740

580 And Menelaus, son of Atreus,  
dragged the dead body from the Trojans' reach,  
back to his own companions. Then Apollo  
stood next to Hector and inspired him,  
looking like Phaenops, son of Asius,  
the guest-friend whom he loved the most of all,  
who lived in Abydos. Resembling him,  
Apollo, the far-worker, spoke to Hector.

“Hector, what other Greek will scare you next?  
You even ran away from Menelaus,  
who used to be so soft and weak in war.  
Now he has got the body from the Trojans  
and taken it away, and killed your friend,  
your brave and loyal frontline champion fighter,  
590 Podes, the son of Eetion.”

750

At this,  
a thick black cloud of grief enveloped Hector.  
He set off through the fighters at the front  
wearing his bright bronze armor. And then Zeus  
lifted his glittering, tasseled goatskin aegis,  
and covered Ida up with clouds, and rumbled—  
a mighty thunderclap, and shook the aegis,  
and gave the Trojans victory in the battle,  
and forced the Greeks to flee. The first to lead  
the rout, Peneleus, the great Boeotian,  
had kept his body turned to face the foe,  
but on the very top part of his shoulder  
a spear had struck a glancing blow—imposed  
600 from close at hand by Lord Polydamas—  
the sharp tip grazed the skin and broke the bone.  
Then Hector, also at close quarters, struck  
Leitus, son of brave Alectryon,  
upon his wrist and quelled his zeal to fight.  
Looking around with watchful eyes, he fled,

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770



because he could no longer hold a spear  
and therefore could not hope to fight the Trojans.  
Then Hector rushed at Idomeneus,  
who struck him on the breastplate, by the nipple.  
The long dark spear was shattered in its socket—  
the Trojans whooped triumphantly. And then  
Hector took aim at Idomeneus,  
as he was standing on his chariot.

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610 He missed him, barely, and then struck Coiranus,  
the friend and driver of Meriones,  
who came to Troy with him from well-built Lyctus.  
Lord Idomeneus had come on foot,  
leaving the balanced ships to come to battle  
without a chariot, and so the Trojans  
would have destroyed him, and achieved a triumph—  
had not Coiranus quickly brought the horses  
near him, and saved his life, but lost his own,  
killed at the mighty hands of murderous Hector,  
who struck him with his spear below his ear,  
and drove it deep into his jaw, uprooted  
his teeth, and sliced his tongue in half. He fell  
out of the chariot and dropped the reins  
620 onto the ground. Meriones stooped down  
and picked them up himself and then addressed  
Lord Idomeneus—

790

“Whip on the horses  
until you reach the swift ships. Even you  
must understand the Greeks are losing now.”

800

Fear had already fallen on the heart  
of Idomeneus. When he heard this,  
he lashed the horses, and they galloped off  
back to the hollow ships, their fine manes flowing.  
And meanwhile, Menelaus and brave Ajax  
realized Zeus was granting to the Trojans  
a change of fortune and success in battle.  
Great Telamonian Ajax told the Greeks,

630 “Even a fool would see that Zeus is helping  
the Trojans! Whether weak or strong, they always  
achieve their aim with every spear they throw!  
Certainly, Zeus is guiding all their weapons,  
while ours fall useless to the ground. Come on,  
we have to strategize how best to drag  
the corpse away, and get back safe, and cheer  
our comrades, who are surely grieving for us,  
looking in this direction. By this time  
they must be worried we cannot hold out  
against the forceful hands of deadly Hector. 810  
They think that we will fall by these black ships.  
640 Some friend must hurry off and tell Achilles,  
the son of Peleus. I am afraid  
that he has not yet heard the dreadful news  
about the death of his beloved comrade.  
But I cannot see anyone to send  
among the Greeks, because of all this mist  
which spreads across the fighters and the horses.  
O father Zeus, release us from this fog!  
Grant us a bright sky! May our eyes see clearly! 820  
Destroy us if you wish, but in the light.” 830

He wept, and father Zeus had pity on him.  
At once he swept away the fog and darkness.  
650 The sun shone bright, and the whole battlefield  
was visible. Then Ajax spoke again  
to Menelaus, master of the war cry.

“King under Zeus, Lord Menelaus, now  
see if Antilochus is still alive—  
the son of valiant Nestor. If he is,  
urge him to run as fast as possible 840  
to tell the mighty warrior Achilles  
his dearest friend in all the world is dead.”

He spoke, and warlike Menelaus heard him,  
and rushed off, like a lion from a farmstead,

weary of challenging the men and dogs  
who have stayed up all night to stop him seizing  
660 the fattest of the cattle—he is hungry  
for meat, and constantly attacks, but fails—  
more and more javelins and burning torches  
fly at him from the farmers' sturdy hands  
and frighten him, despite his zeal to fight—  
at dawn, he slinks away, his spirit crushed—  
so Menelaus, master of the war cry,  
drew back unwillingly. He was afraid  
the Greeks would panic, run away, and leave  
Patroclus to their enemies. He told  
the leaders of the Greeks in urgent tones,

850

“Ajax and Ajax and Meriones,  
670 let everyone remember now the kindness  
of poor Patroclus, who was sweet and gentle  
to everybody when he was alive.  
Now death and doom have come to him.”

860

With this,  
blond Menelaus hurried off, and searched  
everywhere—like an eagle, which is said  
to have the keenest sight of any bird.  
Even when he is high up in the sky,  
the eagle spots the swift-pawed hare below him,  
huddling underneath a leafy bush,  
and swoops on him and quickly takes his life—  
so you, Lord Menelaus, turned your eyes  
680 everywhere, over all the throng of comrades,  
to see if Nestor's son was still alive.  
Soon, on the left side of the battlefield,  
he saw him urging and encouraging  
his men to fight. And ruddy Menelaus  
went up to him and said,

870

“Antilochus,  
my lord, come here and listen to sad news.

I wish it had not happened. I believe  
you know already, because you can see,  
some god has rolled disaster at the Greeks.

880

The Trojans triumph. And the very best  
of all the Greeks has now been killed—Patroclus.

690 The Greeks are devastated by his loss.  
So run down to the ships and tell Achilles,  
and he may come in time to save the body,  
although it is too late to save the armor,  
which Hector, in his flashing helmet, wears.”

At this, Antilochus was horror-struck.  
He could not speak. His eyes were filled with tears,  
his voice choked up. And yet he did not fail  
to do as Menelaus had instructed.

890

He gave his weapons to his loyal comrade  
Laodocus, who was beside him, turning  
the strong-hoofed horses and the chariot.  
700 Then off he ran, still weeping, from the battle  
to bring Achilles, son of Peleus,  
the dreadful news. And you, Lord Menelaus,  
felt in your heart you did not wish to help  
the comrades whom Antilochus had left,  
the Pylians, although they were hard-pressed  
and missed him very much. But Menelaus  
sent noble Thrasymedes to their aid,  
and he himself went back to great Patroclus.  
He ran and stood beside the two named Ajax  
and said to them at once,

900

“I sent that man  
to swift Achilles, by the nimble ships.  
And yet I do not think that he will come,  
710 although he will be furious with Hector.  
He cannot fight unarmed against the Trojans.  
We need to figure out the finest plan  
to drag away the body and survive,  
so that we can escape from death and doom  
amid the clash of battle with the Trojans.”

910

Great Telamonian Ajax answered him,  
“Glorious Menelaus, you are right.  
Meriones must work with you and quickly  
lift up the dead man. Take him from the field.  
We two named Ajax shall remain behind  
and fight against great Hector and the Trojans.  
We have one purpose, as we have one name,  
and we have often stood to face fierce Ares  
together, side by side.”

920

So Ajax spoke.

They lifted up the body from the earth  
into their arms and held him very high.  
The Trojan troops behind let out a war cry,  
because they saw the Greeks pick up the corpse.  
They rushed at them—as dogs who run in front  
of hunters and pursue a wounded boar,  
eager to rip him up, until he turns,  
confident of his courage, and they scatter  
in all directions—so the Trojans clustered  
around them, following them for a while,  
and hacked at them with swords and two-edged spears.  
But every time the two named Ajax turned  
and stood confronting them, their color changed,  
and none of them dared dart ahead or fight  
to seize the dead man. And the pair of Greeks,  
Meriones and Menelaus, focused  
on carrying the body from the battle  
back to the hollow ships. Meanwhile, the fighting  
grew wild as fire that suddenly consumes  
a city, and amid its blazing light  
houses collapse, and strong wind roars across it.  
So as they made their way, they were bombarded  
by the cacophony of chariots  
and men with spears. But just as mules exert  
great strength with their whole bodies as they drag  
down from the mountains on a rocky path  
a beam or massive log to form a mast,  
their hearts exhausted with the toil and sweat—

930

940

950

just so they labored, carrying the corpse.  
Behind them, the two warriors named Ajax  
held back the enemy, just as a ridge,  
extending all across the plain and topped  
with trees, holds back the water—cruel floods  
750 of mighty rivers, which it forces back,  
driving their currents down across the lowland—  
their surging strength cannot break down the ridge—  
just so, the two named Ajax constantly  
forced back the Trojan fighters, who pursued  
relentlessly, and two the most of all,  
glorious Hector and Aeneas, son  
of great Anchises. As a cloud of starlings  
or jackdaws, with a tangled cry of horror,  
screech, when they see a hawk come bringing slaughter  
to smaller birds—just so the young Greek fighters,  
screeching with fear and horror, ran away  
from Hector and Aeneas, and forgot  
their eagerness to fight, and as they fled,  
760 many fine weapons fell around the ditch.  
And yet there was no ending of the war.

960

970

## BOOK 18



## Divine Armor

So fought the armies, like a blazing fire.  
Antilochus on swift feet ran to tell  
Achilles, whom he found beside his ships,  
sterns straight as cattle horns. Achilles was  
imagining what had already happened,  
and anxiously, he spoke to his proud heart.

“Why are the long-haired Greeks so terrified,  
rushing across the plain towards the ships?  
I hope the gods have not fulfilled my fears!  
My mother told me something once. She said  
the best of all the Myrmidons would leave  
the sunlight, killed by Trojan hands, while I  
would stay alive. And surely now Patroclus,  
the brave son of Menoetius, must be dead.  
The stubborn fool! I ordered him to quench  
the fire the enemy had lit, then come  
straight back here to the ships, not fight with Hector.”

These thoughts were swirling through his heart and mind.

Antilochus, the son of great king Nestor,  
face hot with tears, arrived, approached Achilles,  
and shared the bitter news.

20

“Achilles, son  
of skillful Peleus, I need to tell you  
disastrous news. I wish it had not happened.  
Dead lies Patroclus and the armies fight  
20 around his corpse, stripped of your arms and weapons,  
which Hector in his flashing helmet wears.”

At this, a black cloud of despair engulfed  
Achilles. With both hands he scooped up fistfuls  
of soot and dust and poured it on his head,  
and rubbed the dirt across his handsome face.  
Black ashes settled on his scented tunic.  
He stretched his whole long body in the dust  
and lay there. With both hands, he tore his hair.  
The women whom Achilles and Patroclus  
had captured and enslaved were struck by grief.  
They screamed and wailed and ran outside, surrounding  
30 the warrior, Achilles. With their fists,  
they pounded on their breasts, limbs weak with shock.  
Antilochus was sobbing, shedding tears,  
and holding tightly to Achilles’ hands  
so that he could not use an iron knife  
to slit his throat. Achilles groaned, heartbroken.  
He howled in agony. His goddess mother  
heard him from where she sat beside her father,  
down in the hollow depths, and keened for him.  
All of the goddesses who live within  
the deep recesses of the salty sea,  
the Nereids, came gathering around her—  
Cymodoce, Thaleia, Actaea,  
Melite, Halia with ox eyes, Speio,  
40 Dyname, Glauce, Limnorea, Thoe,  
Cymothoe, Nesaia, Iaera, Doris,  
Amphinome, Agave, Doto, Proto,  
Dexamene, Amphithoe, Pherousa,

30

40

50



Maera, Ianeira, famous Galatea,  
Callianassa, Nemertes, Apseudes,  
Callianeira, Clymene, Ianassa,  
Panope, Oreithuia, and well-braided  
Amathea, and all the other daughters  
of Nereus within the salty depths.

60

50 They filled the shining silver cave and all  
pounded their chests and Thetis led the mourning.

“Listen, my sisters, fellow Nereids,  
so all of you may understand my grief.  
How I have suffered! What disastrous luck!  
Cursed with the best of sons, I bore a child  
who shot up like a sapling and became  
the strongest and the best of warriors.

I raised him like a young tree in an orchard,

then sent him in the curving ships to Troy

70

60 to fight the Trojans. But now I will never  
welcome him home again inside the house  
of Peleus. And while he sees the sun,  
while he is still alive, he is in pain.

I can do nothing for him, even if

I go to him. But I will go to see him,

because he is my child and I love him.

I will find out what suffering has reached him  
while he is staying back, away from war.”

With these words, Thetis left the cave. The others  
went with her, weeping, and around them crashed  
the waves. They swam to Troy, to solid ground,  
then each in turn emerged from sea to shore,  
amid the fleet moored by the Myrmidons,  
where swift Achilles lay and groaned in grief.

80

70 His goddess mother came to him. She wept,  
cradled her dear son’s head, and through her tears,  
her words flew out.

“My child, why are you crying?

What suffering has hurt your heart? Tell me,  
do not conceal it. Through the will of Zeus  
your earlier request has been fulfilled.

90

With arms raised high you prayed that all the Greeks,  
confined beside the ships' sterns, would endure  
terrible suffering and mortal danger  
and yearn for you. So it has been fulfilled."

Swift-footed Lord Achilles, groaning, answered,  
"Yes, Mother, Zeus has granted me that prayer.

But now what good to me is any of it?

80 My friend Patroclus, whom I loved, is dead.

I loved him more than any other comrade.

100

I loved him like my head, my life, myself.

I lost him, killed him. Hector slaughtered him,  
and stripped from him the marvelous magic armor,  
the lovely gifts the gods gave Peleus  
the day they led you, an immortal goddess,  
into a mortal's bed. If only you

had stayed among the deathless goddesses  
under the sea, and Peleus had taken

a mortal woman as his wife! Your marriage  
brought never-ending sorrow to your heart

110

90 for your dead child, whom you will never welcome  
home again now, because my heart forbids me  
to live or be with people anymore,

unless my spear can strike down Hector first  
and take his life away and make him pay  
because he killed and looted my Patroclus,  
son of Menoetius."

Thetis answered him,  
with tears still pouring down her cheeks, "My child,  
what have you said? How fast your fate runs out!  
As soon as you kill Hector, you must die."

120

Swift-footed Lord Achilles, in despair,  
told her, "I want to die right here and now,

because I could not save my slaughtered friend.  
He died so very far away from home.

100 He needed me to help him and protect him.

And I did not go back to my dear country,  
nor did I save Patroclus. I provided  
no light or help to him or anybody.

Many were overpowered by glorious Hector,  
while I sat here beside the ships, so useless,  
a burden on the earth, although I am  
superior to all the bronze-clad Greeks  
in war, though others may be better speakers.

130

If only conflict were eliminated  
from gods and human beings! I wish anger  
did not exist. Even the wisest people

are roused to rage, which trickles into you  
sweeter than honey, and inside your body

110 it swells like smoke—just so, Lord Agamemnon  
enraged me. But that happened in the past.

140

So let it go, though I am still upset.

I must control the feelings in my chest,  
and go to look for Hector, who destroyed  
the one I loved the most, my head, my life.

Thereafter, I will welcome death, whenever  
Zeus and the other deathless gods may wish  
to bring it. Even mighty Heracles

did not escape from death, although Lord Zeus,  
the son of Cronus, loved him most of all.

Fate and the cruel rage of Hera killed him.

150

120 If I am doomed to die like him, so be it.

I will lie dead, but let me win great glory.

Let me make Trojan women mourn forever,  
and let Dardanian women, thickly wrapped  
in folded fabrics, use both hands to wipe  
a ceaseless flood of tears from their soft faces.

Let them know how long I was gone from war.

And, Mother, do not hold me back from battle,  
despite your love for me. You will not stop me.”

Thetis, the goddess with the silver feet,

160

answered him, "Yes, my child, your words are sound.  
It is not wrong to save your friends from danger.  
130 But your majestic glittering bronze weapons  
were taken by the Trojans. Bright-helmed Hector  
struts with your armor strapped around his body.  
I think his arrogance will not last long.  
His violent death is very near at hand.  
But you must not rejoin the field of Ares  
until you see me come back here again.  
At dawn tomorrow, when the sun comes up,  
I will bring you a beautiful set of armor,  
forged by the god Hephaestus."

170

So she spoke,  
turned from her son to her sea goddess sisters,  
140 and said, "Now dive beneath the sea's wide folds.  
Go to the house of our old sea god father  
and tell him everything. And I will go  
to Mount Olympus. I will ask Hephaestus,  
the craftsman god, if he will give my son  
marvelous glittering new arms and armor."

At once, the goddesses sank down beneath  
the waves. The silver-footed goddess Thetis  
hurried to Mount Olympus, in her quest  
to get majestic arms for her dear son.  
Her light feet took her to the mountaintop.  
Meanwhile, the Greeks let out unearthly cries  
and ran from murderous Hector to their ships  
150 beside the Hellespont. They could not drag  
the comrade of Achilles, dead Patroclus,  
out of the weapons' range, because the Trojans,  
some in their chariots and some on foot,  
and Hector, son of Priam, blocked their way,  
his ardor burning like a flame. Three times  
bright Hector seized the dead man by the feet  
and tried to drag him, shouting to the Trojans.  
Three times the two named Ajax, clothed in courage,  
shoved him away from it. And sometimes Hector,

180

190

confident of his strength, charged through the throng.  
Sometimes he stood in place and shouted loudly.

160 He did not yield a single inch of ground.

As country farmers cannot drive away  
a ravenous lion from a fresh-killed corpse,  
so the two lords named Ajax could not scare  
Hector, the son of Priam, from the body.

He would have dragged it off and won great glory,  
had not swift Iris on her feet of wind  
sped from Olympus as a messenger  
to tell Achilles he must arm himself.  
Hera had sent her secretly, so Zeus  
and all the other gods were unaware.

200

“Rise up, Achilles, son of Peleus,  
Iris stood near Achilles. Her words flew.

210

170 the wildest, most aggressive man alive!  
Protect Patroclus, over whom the battle  
rages before the ships. Men kill each other.  
The Greeks are fighting to protect the corpse,  
the Trojans want to drag the body back  
to windy Troy, and glorious Hector strives  
with all his might to pull away the dead man.  
He yearns to slice his head from his soft neck  
and fix it on a stake. Stop lying there!  
Shame on you, if you let the dogs of Troy  
play with Patroclus like a toy. The fault  
180 is yours, if his dead body is despoiled.”

220

Swift-footed Lord Achilles answered, “Iris,  
which of the gods sent you to me?”

Swift Iris,  
the messenger with feet of wind, replied,  
“Queen Hera, wife of Zeus, sent me to you,  
but unbeknownst to Zeus who sits on high,  
or any other deathless god who lives

on snowy Mount Olympus.”

Swift Achilles

230

answered, “How can I go to join the battle?  
The Trojans have my arms, and my dear mother  
forbids me to put armor on again  
190 until my eyes see her return. She went  
to get me some magnificent new weapons  
forged by Hephaestus, and I do not know  
whose arms I could use now, except perhaps  
the shield of Ajax, son of Telamon—  
but I suppose he must be in the battle,  
wielding his spear among the crowd of fighters  
240 killing each other around dead Patroclus.”

Iris, whose feet are swift as wind, replied,  
“We know you will receive that fine new armor.  
But in the meantime, go up to the trench  
and show yourself to terrify the Trojans,  
so they will give some ground, draw back from battle,  
200 and grant the warlike Greeks some space to breathe.  
The fighters are exhausted from the fighting.  
Respite in war is only ever brief.”

With this, swift-footed Iris flew away.  
Up rose Achilles, dear to Zeus. Athena,  
the glorious goddess, wrapped round his strong shoulders  
a tasseled aegis. And she crowned his head  
with golden mist and made bright flame flash from him.  
As when smoke rises up into the sky  
from some far distant city on an island  
besieged by enemies—the townsmen fight  
all day beneath the hateful gaze of Ares—  
210 at sunset, they keep lighting beacon fires,  
to make the brightness visible on high  
to neighbors who might sail to help their fight—  
just so the brightness on Achilles’ head  
reached to the sky. He left the wall but stopped

250

260

before the trench, and did not join the Greeks.

He heeded the instructions of his mother.

Pallas Athena hovered over him

and screamed. He stood and shouted to the Trojans,

and roused in them an overwhelming panic.

Just as a trumpet sounds a clear, loud note

220 when murderous enemies besiege a city,

270

so loud rang out the war cry of Achilles,

the grandson of great Aeacus. His voice

of bronze roused fear in every Trojan's heart.

Their horses wheeled around the chariots,

their beautiful long manes flew forth. Their minds

foresaw disaster. And their charioteers

were horrified to see uncanny fire

blazing above the head of brave Achilles,

lit by divine Athena, bright-eyed goddess.

Three times Achilles screamed across the trench.

280

Three times the Trojans and their allies panicked.

230 Twelve fighters died amid their chariots,

spears falling, and the Greeks were glad. They dragged

Patroclus from the range of flying weapons

and laid him on a litter. His companions

wept as they stood around him. On swift feet

Achilles ran to join them, shedding tears

to see his loyal friend laid on a bier,

killed by sharp bronze—the friend whom he himself

had sent upon his chariot to war,

290

but never got to welcome home again.

The sun god, Helios, was not yet tired,

but ox-eyed Hera, queen of goddesses,

sent him away against his will to sink

240 into the streams of Ocean. The sun set.

The Greeks stopped fighting and held back from war.

The Trojans drew back from the battlefield,

unyoked their horses from their chariots,

and gathered for a meeting, with no thought

of dinner. They assembled standing upright,

300

and no one dared sit down, because Achilles

had shown himself after so long an absence  
from painful battle. They were all possessed  
by fear. The son of Panthous, the wise  
250 Polydamas, who was exceptional  
in knowing how to see the past and future,  
spoke first to them. He was a friend to Hector,  
and both of them were born on the same night,  
one excellent with spears and one with words.  
Intending well, Polydamas addressed them. 310

“My friends, we have two choices. Weigh them well.  
I think we should return now to the city,  
not wait for shining dawn beside the ships,  
out on the battlefield, far from our wall.  
While that man was enraged with Agamemnon,  
the Greeks were easier to fight. I felt  
happy to spend the night beside their fleet—  
260 I thought that we could take their quick curved ships.  
But now I feel most terribly afraid  
of swift Achilles, son of Peleus. 320  
His pride and his aggression know no bounds.  
He will not stay out here on neutral ground  
where Greeks and Trojans share the force of Ares.  
He will attack and try to take it all—  
the city and the women. This will happen,  
believe me, so we must go back to town.  
For now, immortal night constrains Achilles,  
the great swift-footed son of Peleus.  
But in the morning, if he finds us here,  
he will attack with all his arms and armor, 330  
and we will see what kind of man he is.  
270 Only a few will reach the holy city,  
relieved at their escape, while dogs and vultures  
devour a multitude of Trojan men.  
I hope my ears will never hear this news.  
Despite how painful this will be, you must  
listen to me. Tonight we must remain  
in the town square and gather all our strength.  
The city will be guarded by the walls,



high gates, and double doors of polished wood,  
fastened and fitted closely, like a yoke.

340

Early tomorrow, at first light, we will  
stand by the towers with our arms and armor.

If he attempts to leave his ships and come  
to fight outside our wall, the worse for him.

280 After he makes his strong-necked horses gallop  
around our town and tires them out with running,  
he will return to his own ships. Aggression  
will not succeed. He will not break inside,  
and he will never sack our town. Instead,  
swift dogs will eat him.”

350

Bright-helmed Hector scowled

and said to him, “Polydamas, your words  
no longer please me. You are telling us  
we must retreat, to be confined again  
inside the city walls. Are you not yet  
sick of captivity? In former times,  
everyone used to say that Priam’s city  
was very rich in gold and rich in bronze.

290 Now all the splendid treasure in our homes  
is gone. Our great wealth has been spent, dispersed  
in beautiful Maeonia and Phrygia,  
because great Zeus became enraged with us.

360

But now the son of double-dealing Cronus  
has granted me the chance to win a triumph  
and trap the Greeks beside the sea and ships.  
Fool! Do not share such thoughts as these in public.  
No Trojan will do this. I will not let them.

Come on now, all of you, and heed my words.

Tonight, have dinner in your army quarters.

Let every man keep watch and stay awake.

370

300 If any Trojan feels especially worried  
about his property, let him divide it  
and share it out among the population  
of Trojans. Better one of us enjoys it  
than any of the Greeks. First thing tomorrow,  
we will put on our armor, seize our weapons,

and rouse sharp Ares by the hollow ships.  
If it is true that glorious Achilles  
has truly risen up beside the fleet,  
the worse for him, if he tries anything!  
I will not run away from painful warfare.  
I will stand here and meet him face to face.  
He may achieve great victory, or I will.  
Ares is with us all, and kills the killer.”

380

310 So Hector spoke. The Trojans cheered approval.  
Poor fools! Athena took their wits away.  
All of them praised the bad ideas of Hector,  
and not the good plan of Polydamas.  
They ate their dinner in the army quarters.

All night the Greeks mourned for the dead Patroclus.  
Achilles led the bitter wails of grief.  
He laid his murderous hands on his friend’s chest  
and howled and roared—just like a thick-maned lion,  
whose cubs a man, a deer hunter, has taken  
out of their forest home—the lion comes  
320 too late, and in his desperate grief he tracks  
the footprints of the man and tries to find him,  
possessed by agonizing rage—just so  
Achilles roared with grief and rage and told  
the Myrmidons,

390

“I failed. I broke the promise  
that I made to Menoetius in his home  
the day we left for Troy, to comfort him.  
I told him I would bring his son back home  
famous and swathed in glory, and I said  
Patroclus would sack Troy and gain his share  
of loot and then return to Opoeis.  
But Zeus does not fulfill all human plans.  
Both of us have been fated to make red  
330 the same earth here in Troy. My own old father,  
the chariot driver Peleus, will never

400

410

welcome me home again, and nor will Thetis,  
my mother. Earth will cover me right here.  
But now, Patroclus, I am not yet with you  
under the earth. Soon I will follow you.  
I will not hold your funeral until  
I bring back here the armor and the head  
of high and mighty Hector, who killed you.  
And I will choose twelve lovely Trojan children  
and slit their throats above your funeral pyre,  
because I am so angry at your death.  
Till then, lie there beside the ships' curved beaks  
and wait for me. Around you, night and day,  
Trojan and Dardan women in rich dresses  
will weep and cry. The two of us together  
labored to capture them with spears and force,  
when we destroyed so many thriving cities,  
in which so many people used to live."

420

With this, godlike Achilles called his comrades  
to set a mighty cauldron on the fire,  
so that Patroclus could be quickly cleaned  
of blood and gore. They set it on the flames,  
poured water in, and piled up wood to burn.  
The fire licked round the belly of the pot,  
heating the water in the bright bronze cauldron,  
and when it boiled, they washed him, and then rubbed him  
with olive oil, and filled his wounds with ointment  
seasoned for nine whole years. They laid him down  
upon a bed and wrapped him in a sheet,  
covering him from head to toe, then spread  
a bright white blanket over him. All night  
the Myrmidons remained and gathered round  
swift-footed Lord Achilles, and lamented  
for dead Patroclus. Then Zeus spoke to Hera,  
his sister and his wife.

430

440

"So, ox-eyed goddess,  
Hera, you win again! You have succeeded  
in rousing up swift-footed Lord Achilles.

The long-haired Greeks must have been born from you.”

360 The ox-eyed goddess Hera answered him,  
“What have you said, disastrous child of Cronus?  
Even the humans try to help each other, 450  
though they are mortal and their schemes are weak.  
How then could I not stitch a quilt of ruin  
when I am so enraged against the Trojans?  
I am the best of all the goddesses,  
because I am the eldest and because  
I am your wife and you rule all the gods.”

These were their words. And meanwhile, silver-footed  
Thetis had reached the palace of Hephaestus,  
370 the starry, everlasting house of bronze,  
that even deathless gods would marvel at, 460  
that he had built himself. She found the god  
struggling, twisting, sweating at his bellows,  
to fashion twenty tripods, which he set  
along his sturdy chamber wall. He fastened  
gold wheels beneath the base of every tripod,  
so they could roll to councils of the gods  
and then come home again all by themselves,  
a marvel to behold. He had completed  
the wheels but had not yet put on the handles.  
He formed them handily and set them on, 470  
380 and forged the rivets. While he worked on this  
with close attention, silver-footed Thetis  
drew near him, and attractive, bright-veiled Charis,  
wife of the famous god whose legs are bent,  
saw her and took her hand and spoke to her.

“Thetis, my dear and most respected friend,  
why have you come out in your trailing dress  
to our house? You have never come before.  
Come in and welcome. You shall be our guest.”

With this, the goddess led the goddess in.

480

390 She sat her on a silver-studded chair,  
ornate and lovely, with a footstool under,  
then called the famous engineer and told him,  
“Quickly, Hephaestus, come here! Thetis needs you.”

The famous god whose legs are bent replied,  
“A special guest is visiting our house!  
I value this great goddess very highly  
because she saved me after my steep fall,  
when I was hurt by my own dog-faced mother,  
because I had a limp, and she was hoping 490  
to hide me. At that time I would have suffered  
a mortal injury, but I was rescued  
by Thetis and Eurynome, who held me  
enfolded safely in their secret places—  
Eurynome, the daughter of the Ocean  
that flows forever backward on itself.  
400 I stayed for nine years in their hollow cave  
and made them intricate accessories—  
brooches and necklaces and curly spirals  
and earrings, all of bronze. Around the cave 500  
the River Ocean gushed sublime and seethed  
with foam. No other god or mortal knew  
that I was there except the ones who saved me,  
Eurynome and Thetis. And now Thetis  
has come to our house and I must repay  
the goddess with the finely braided hair  
for everything she did to save my life.  
You must provide her with a lavish welcome  
while I pack up my bellows and equipment.”

410 With these words, the volcanic giant leapt 510  
on slender, limping legs and left his anvil,  
and hurried to complete his work. He moved  
the bellows from the fire, and put away  
all the equipment that he had been using  
into a silver chest. He used a sponge  
to wipe his face, thick neck, and hairy chest  
and both his hands. Then he put on a tunic,

and took a sturdy staff and limped outside.

Slaves hurried to assist their lord. They were  
made all of gold, but looked like living women.

520

420

They had a consciousness inside their hearts,  
and strength and voices. They had learned their skills  
from deathless gods. They sped beneath their master.  
He rushed to Thetis on her shining chair  
and took her hand and spoke to her and said,

“Thetis, my dear and most respected friend,  
why have you come here in your trailing dress  
to our house? You have never come before.  
What do you have in mind? Tell me. My heart  
prompts me to grant your wishes if I can.”

530

430

Then Thetis answered him through tears, “Hephaestus,  
has any goddess on Olympus suffered  
the agonies and bitter pain and grief  
that Zeus, the son of Cronus, has imposed  
on me alone? Of all the goddesses  
submerged beneath the salty seas, he chose  
me to be subjugated to a man,  
and I endured a marriage with a human.

Entirely against my own desires

I went to bed with Peleus, the son  
of Aeacus. He lies at home, decrepit  
and broken by old age, but Zeus imposed  
even more suffering on me. He granted  
that I would bear and raise a child, a son,  
who shot up like a sapling and became  
the strongest and the best of warriors.

540

440

I raised him like a young tree in an orchard,  
then sent him in the curving ships to Troy  
to fight the Trojans. But now I will never  
welcome him home again inside the house  
of Peleus. And even while he lives  
and sees the sunlight, he is suffering.  
I can do nothing for him, even if  
I go to him. The Greeks had given him

550

a girl, a trophy—whom great Agamemnon  
seized from his very arms! He wastes away,  
longing for her with all his heart. The Trojans  
kept the Greeks trapped beside the ships and blocked  
their exit. Envoys went to plead with him  
and vowed to give him many splendid gifts.

560

450 Still he refused to save them from disaster  
himself, but clothed Patroclus in his armor  
and sent him into battle, with a host  
of troops to follow him. Patroclus fought  
all day around the Scaean Gates, and surely  
he would have sacked the town that very day,  
had not Apollo seen the noble son  
of great Menoetius causing devastation  
and killed him on the front line of the fighters.  
Apollo gave the victory to Hector.

570

This is the reason I have come to you,  
to beg you, bowing down before your knees,  
to grant my son, whose life runs out so fast,  
a shield, a helmet, fine well-fitting greaves,  
and breastplate, because those he used to have  
460 were lost when his most loyal friend was killed  
by Trojans. Now Achilles lies stretched out  
upon the ground and grieves with all his heart.”

The famous god whose legs are bent replied,  
“Take heart, dispel these worries from your mind.  
I wish that I could hide him far away  
from cruel death when harsh fate comes for him  
as easily as I can make him armor,  
so marvelous that any human being  
would be astonished at the sight.”

580

With this,  
he left her there and went back to his bellows.  
He turned them to the fire and ordered them  
470 to work. The twenty pairs of bellows blew  
the melting pots and sent strong blasts of air  
all over them, at every moment ready

590

to help Hephaestus any way he wished.  
He labored quickly and the work progressed.  
He set the metals on the blaze—the tin,  
the tireless bronze, and precious gold and silver.  
Then on the mighty block he placed the anvil.  
He seized the sturdy hammer in one hand,  
and with the other hand he held the tongs.  
Then first he forged the strong and mighty shield  
and covered it with artful decorations.  
He put a shining, glittering triple border  
around it and attached a silver strap.  
Then on the center of the shield itself  
through his extraordinary skill he fashioned  
numerous images as decoration.

600

On it he made the earth, the sky, the sea,  
the sun that never wearies, the full moon,  
and all the wondrous stars that crown the sky—  
the Pleiades, the Hyades, Orion  
the mighty warrior, and the Great Bear,  
known as the Wagon, which revolves in place,  
the only constellation never washed  
by Ocean's streams.

610

And on the shield he set  
two cities full of people. Both were splendid.  
In one were weddings, feasts, and brides escorted  
out of their chambers through the town by torchlight  
with noisy wedding songs. The dancing boys  
were whirling round and round, and pipes and lyres  
were making music loudly for the dancers.  
Women stood in their doorways, marveling.  
The crowd assembled in the marketplace.  
And there a quarrel rose between two men  
about a payment for a murdered man.  
One made a public vow of full repayment,  
The other man refused to take the price.  
Both came before a judge to get a verdict.  
The crowd was helpful and supported both.

620



The clear-voiced heralds kept the crowd in order.  
The councillors sat on their polished stones,  
a holy circle. In their hands they held  
the heralds' staffs. Each councillor in turn  
leapt up with staff in hand and gave his judgment.  
Two pounds of gold lay in the midst of them,  
a gift for him whose judgment was the fairest.

630

510 Around the other city sat two armies  
in shimmering armor. The besiegers held  
divided views about their strategy.  
Some wanted to destroy the lovely city,  
others to share out all the wealth it held.  
The citizens had not surrendered yet.  
They planned to ambush the besieging army.  
Their little children and their loving wives,  
along with men whom age had overtaken,  
stood to defend the wall. The other men  
marched forward led by Ares and Athena,  
both made of gold and dressed in golden clothes,  
both beautiful and tall, as gods should be,  
equipped with arms and armor, fit for war.  
The human fighters under them were smaller.  
520 They reached the spot they thought the best for ambush,  
a river where the herds went down to drink,  
and waited there. Their bronze arms shone. They sent  
two scouts to look for sheep and ambling cattle,  
who soon arrived, led by two herdsman, piping  
happily, with no thought of any trick.  
The raiders saw their target and attacked  
from both sides and cut off the herd of cattle  
and fine fat flock of bright white sheep, and killed  
the herders. When their comrades, who sat gathered  
530 before the meeting place, heard the commotion  
among the animals, at once they mounted  
their chariots behind their high-hoofed horses  
and galloped to the riverbank, and there  
they fought each other, hurling spears of bronze.  
Mingled with them were Mayhem and Aggression

640

650

660

and deadly Doom, who held one man alive,  
fresh-wounded, and another still unharmed,  
and by his feet she dragged a third man, dead,  
through the cacophony. Around her shoulders  
she wore a cloak red with the blood of men.  
The mortals fought as if they were alive,  
and dragged away the bodies of the dead.

670

And on the shield he set a fallow field  
of soft, rich farmland, wide and triple-plowed.  
Numerous plowmen worked the field and drove  
yoked animals and turned them back and forth.  
Whenever they had circled round and reached  
the field's edge, someone came to them and set  
a cup of honeyed wine into their hands.  
They kept on trekking up and down the furrows,  
longing to reach the end of the deep field.  
The earth grew black behind them as if plowed,  
though it was made of gold. It was amazing.

680

And on the shield he put a master's precinct,  
where workers reaped the crop with sharpened sickles.  
Some armfuls fell together to the ground  
along the furrow, and some sheaves were gathered  
and bound with ropes by laborers. Three people  
were there to bind the sheaves, and children followed,  
scooped up the sheaves of corn and cradled them  
and gave them to the adults to bind up.  
The master stood in silence with the workers,  
straddling a furrow with his staff in hand.  
His heart was glad. Beneath a tree, the heralds  
worked to prepare a feast. They bustled round  
and butchered an enormous ox. The women  
mixed plentiful supplies of bright white barley  
to make a supper for the laborers.

690

And on the shield he set a spacious vineyard,  
heavy with clustering grapes. The fruit was black,

the vines, fine gold, staked all the way across  
 with silver posts. Around the vineyard ran  
 a ditch of blue enamel, and round that  
 he formed a fence of tin. A single path  
 ran through it, for the harvesters to use  
 when they were gathering the crop of grapes.  
 Unmarried girls and innocent young boys  
 carried the honeyed fruit in braided baskets.  
 Right in the middle of them all, a child  
 strummed on a well-tuned lyre—enchancing music—  
 and sang the Linus song in high, clear tones.  
 They clapped in unison and skipped behind him,  
 calling and dancing as they joined the song.

710

And on the shield he set a herd of cattle.  
 He forged the straight-horned cows of gold and tin.  
 Mooing, they lumbered from the yard to graze  
 beside the gurgling river and lush reeds.  
 Four golden herdsman went beside the cattle,  
 and nine swift dogs tracked closely at their heels.  
 Among the cattle farthest up ahead  
 two terrifying lions seized a bull,  
 who bellowed loudly as they dragged him off.  
 The dogs and men ran after, but the lions  
 ripped off the big bull's hide and ate his entrails  
 and gorged on his black blood. Too late, the herdsman  
 set on the dogs, who were afraid to bite  
 the lions. They came very near and barked  
 but kept away from them.

720

And on the shield  
 the famous god whose legs are bent created  
 a wide expanse of pasture for white sheep,  
 with shepherds' huts and sheds and roofed enclosures,  
 within a lovely valley.

730

And upon it  
 the famous god whose legs are bent created

570

580

590

a dancing area, like that once made  
by Daedalus in monumental Cnossos  
for Ariadne with the lovely braids.  
Handsome young men and pretty teenage girls,  
worth many oxen as their marriage price,  
were dancing, holding one another's hands.  
The girls wore silky dresses, and the boys,  
delicate tunics doused in olive oil.

740

600 The girls held lovely garlands and the boys  
had gold knives hanging from their silver belts.  
Sometimes they circled round on skillful feet,  
easily—as a potter sits and tests  
his wheel between his hands to make it run.  
Sometimes they moved in lines towards each other.  
Many spectators stood around and watched  
the dancing and enjoyed its charm and beauty.  
Two acrobats whirled in between the dancers  
and led them in the dance.

At last, he placed  
the mighty river Ocean all around  
the rim of that well-fashioned, sturdy shield.

750

610 When he had made the large and solid shield,  
he made for him a breastplate that shone brighter  
than blazing fire. He made him a firm helmet,  
ornate and beautiful, to fit his head,  
and put a golden crest on top of it,  
and made him greaves of finely beaten tin.

Now when the famous god whose legs are bent  
had worked to finish the whole set of armor,  
he picked it up and laid it down in front of  
the mother of Achilles. Like a falcon  
she swooped down from the snows of Mount Olympus,  
bearing the glittering armor of Hephaestus.

760

## BOOK 19



# A Meal Before Dying

Dawn in her saffron-colored dress arose  
out of the streams of Ocean to bring light  
to deathless gods and mortals. Thetis carried  
the god's gifts to the ships, and there she found  
her dear son sobbing desperately and lying  
wrapped round Patroclus. Many of his comrades  
sat weeping at his side. The glorious goddess  
joined them and took Achilles by the hand  
and spoke his name and said to him,

“My child,  
we have to let him lie despite our grief,  
because it is according to the will  
of gods that he is gone, once and for all.  
Now you must take this glorious set of armor,  
forged by Hephaestus, which no other man  
has ever worn.”

With this, the goddess laid  
the splendid, finely decorated armor

before Achilles, and it clanged and clashed.  
Terror and trembling seized the Myrmidons  
and no one dared to look—they turned away.  
But when Achilles saw the arms and armor,  
he was possessed by even greater rage.  
His eyes shone terribly, like fire. He felt  
joy as he took the god's gifts in his hands.  
When he had pleased and satisfied his heart  
with gazing at the marvelous decorations,  
he let his words take wing and told his mother,

20

“Mother, the god has made and given me  
weapons and armor that no mortal man  
could ever have created. This is truly  
immortal work. I shall put on this armor.  
But I am still most terribly afraid  
for brave Patroclus, son of great Menoetius,  
whose body has been hacked with so much bronze.  
Flies may get in his wounds and worms may grow there,  
dishonoring his corpse. His life is gone,  
and now his flesh may rot.”

30

The goddess Thetis,  
who walks on feet of silver, told him, “Child,  
your heart need not be troubled about this.  
I will protect him from the feral tribes  
of flies, who eat men killed in Ares' service.  
Even if he stays lying here a year,  
his flesh will still remain the same or better.  
Now call the leaders of the Greeks to council.  
Renounce the wrath you felt at Agamemnon,  
the shepherd of the people. Then at once  
put on your armor and put on your courage.  
Prepare yourself for war.”

40

With this, the goddess  
filled him with daring eagerness to fight.  
She dripped into the nostrils of Patroclus

40 red nectar and ambrosia, so his body  
 would be preserved. Then glorious Achilles,  
 striding along the seashore, shouted out  
 in thunderous and terrifying tones,  
 calling the leaders of the Greeks to council.  
 Even the pilots who controlled the oars,  
 even the stewards who dispersed the food,  
 who had before remained among the ships,  
 came to the meeting place, because Achilles  
 had reappeared after so long an absence  
 from cruel war. And two of Ares' comrades, 60  
 brave Diomedes and Odysseus,  
 limped to the meeting, leaning on their spears,  
 because their wounds were painful. When they reached  
 50 the meeting place, they sat down at the front.  
 The very last to come was Agamemnon,  
 the lord of men, because he had the wound  
 inflicted on him in the bitter battle  
 by Coon, great Antenor's son, with bronze.  
 And when at last the Greeks were all assembled,  
 swift-footed Lord Achilles stood among them 70  
 and said,

"Now, son of Atreus, did this  
 benefit either of us, you or me—  
 that we were so upset, so full of rage,  
 our hearts and minds so eaten up by conflict,  
 60 over a girl? If only Artemis  
 had killed her with an arrow by the ships,  
 the day I sacked Lyrnessus, and seized her.  
 Then many Greeks would not have died and taken  
 the boundless earth between their teeth, defeated  
 by enemies, while I was full of wrath. 80  
 All this was advantageous to the Trojans  
 and Hector. I believe the memory  
 of conflict between you and me will last  
 a very long time in the minds of Greeks.  
 But that is in the past now. Let it go,  
 despite our grief. We must suppress our feelings

inside ourselves, out of necessity.

I cease my anger now. It is not right  
for me to rage with never-ending fury.

Come on now, hurry, urge the long-haired Greeks

90

70 to war, so I may go and face the Trojans  
and see if they are keen to spend the night  
beside our ships. I think they will be glad  
to bend the knee if they survive this battle,  
if they escape from slaughter by my spear.”

The Greeks were glad the son of Peleus,  
noble Achilles, had renounced his wrath.

Then Agamemnon, lord of men, addressed them,  
remaining in his seat. He did not stand.

“My friends, Greek fighters, warriors of Ares,  
when somebody is standing up to speak,

100

it is the proper thing to listen to him,  
and not to interrupt—which makes things hard

80 even for skillful speakers. Who can speak  
or hear amid an uproar from a crowd?

Even the best of orators does poorly.

But now I shall explain myself quite clearly  
to Lord Achilles, son of Peleus.

You other Greeks must listen and attend  
to everything I say. The Greeks have often  
spoken to me about the things I said

110

and blamed me for them. It was not my fault!

The ones to blame are Destiny and Zeus

and the avenging night-walker, the Fury,

who set a wild delusion in my mind

during the council meeting on the day

when I removed the trophy from Achilles.

But what was I to do? It is a god

90 who carries everything to its conclusion.

Deadly Delusion ruins and deludes

120

all men. She is the eldest child of Zeus.

Her feet are soft—she never walks on earth.

She passes through the minds of human beings



and damages them all, and puts in shackles  
one man in two. And even Zeus, whom people  
say is the very best of gods and humans,  
was once deluded. Hera, being female,  
tricked him by sneaky schemes, the day Alcmene  
was due to give birth to strong Heracles  
in Thebes, the city with a crown of walls.

130

100 Boastfully Zeus declared to all the gods,  
'Listen to me, all gods, all goddesses,  
so I may tell the promptings of my heart.  
This very day, the goddess of the birth-pangs,  
the lady Eileithuia, she who comes,  
will bring a man to light who will be master  
of all the people living thereabouts.  
He will be from my lineage, my blood.'

The sneaky goddess Hera answered him,  
'You lie! The things you say will not come true!

140

But come now, swear to me, Olympian,  
a mighty oath that he will be the master  
of all the people living thereabouts,  
110 whoever falls between a woman's feet  
today, and is a male, born from your blood.'

Zeus failed to realize his wife's deception,  
and swore a mighty oath, which was his ruin.  
And Hera hurried down from Mount Olympus,  
and soon the goddess reached the land of Argos,  
where she already knew the noble wife  
of Sthenelus, the son of Perseus,

150

was pregnant with a precious son. It was  
her seventh month, and Hera brought him out  
into the light at least a month too soon.

She held Alcmene back from giving birth,  
and stopped the goddesses who bring the baby,  
the Eileithuias. Then she went herself

120 to take the news to Zeus, the son of Cronus,  
and said to him, 'Great god of flashing lightning,  
father-god Zeus, I have some news to tell you.

160

Listen. A noble man has just been born,  
who will be a commander of the Greeks—

Eurystheus, the son of Sthenelus,  
the son of Perseus, your own descendant.  
It is not inappropriate that he  
shall rule the Greeks.’ Sharp pain struck deep within  
the heart of Zeus. At once, enraged, he seized  
Delusion by her glossy braids, and swore  
a mighty oath that ruinous Delusion,  
who ruins everyone, would never come  
back to Olympus or the starry sky.

170

130 And with this oath, he swung her round and hurled her  
down from the starry sky, and soon she reached  
the farms and lands inhabited by humans.  
Then Zeus was always groaning at Delusion,  
whenever he would see his own dear son  
performing the dishonorable labors,  
the trials that Eurystheus imposed.

It is the same for me. When mighty Hector,  
wearing his shining helmet, slaughtered Greeks  
beside our ships’ sterns, I could not forget  
the ruinous Delusion that I suffered.

180

I know I was deluded, and Zeus took  
my common sense away. So now I want  
to make amends with lavish gifts of friendship.  
Prepare for war and urge the troops to fight!

140 Look at me! I am ready to provide  
all of the presents that Odysseus  
promised you when he visited your tent  
yesterday. Or if you prefer, stay here,  
however eager you may be for Ares,  
and let the stewards go and get the gifts  
out of my ship and bring them here for you,  
so you may see that I shall give you things  
to satisfy your spirit.”

190

Then swift-footed  
Achilles answered, “Agamemnon, son  
of Atreus, commander of the troops,  
if you would like to bring the gifts, go on,  
or keep them with you. Either way is fine.

But now at once we need to turn our minds  
to war. We must not sit inside here chatting  
150 and wasting time. There is important work  
still to be done. Soon you will see Achilles  
among the champion fighters at the front,  
slaughtering lines of Trojans. All of you,  
follow my lead, and fight as I shall do.”

But sensible Odysseus spoke up.

“Godlike Achilles, you are very strong,  
but do not urge the Greeks to fight the Trojans  
or make them march to Troy without a meal.

210

The battle certainly will not be short  
after the armies meet and once the god  
inspires both sides with eagerness to fight.

160 Tell them to sit beside the ships and taste  
some food and wine, the source of strength and courage.

No man can fight all through the day till sunset  
fasting. He may be eager in his heart  
to fight, but gradually his limbs grow heavy,  
and as he moves, his body starts to hurt,  
and thirst and hunger overpower him.

220

Someone who has his fill of food and wine  
can fight all day against the enemy.

170 His confidence stays high, his body tireless,  
till everybody leaves the battlefield.

Come on then, let the troops disperse, and tell them  
to make their meal. Let Agamemnon bring  
the gifts into the center of the circle,  
so that the eyes of all the Greeks can see them,  
and you can satisfy and please your heart.

And let him stand among the Greeks and swear  
a mighty oath to you, my lord, declaring  
that he has never gone to bed with her,  
as is the normal way for men and women.

230

Then no more anger—let your heart be calm.

180 Enjoy a fat feast in your hut. Do not  
miss out on any of your just reward.

And Agamemnon, son of Atreus,

you must treat people better in the future.  
A lord who picks a fight need not be blamed,  
if he can make amends.”

Then Agamemnon, 240  
the lord of men, replied, “I am delighted  
to hear you say these words, Odysseus.  
You have explained it all quite thoroughly  
and everything you say is fair. I want  
to swear the oath—it is my heart’s desire—  
and I shall call the god to be my witness.  
And while I do so, let Achilles stay,  
despite his eagerness to join with Ares,  
190 and all the rest of you should stay as well,  
until the gifts are brought from my own hut, 250  
and we have formed a pact, with sacrifices.  
And you, Odysseus—these are my orders—  
select the best young men among the Greeks  
and send them to my ship to fetch the gifts  
I promised to Achilles yesterday  
and let them bring the women here as well.  
And in the middle of the great Greek camp  
Talthybius should quickly carve for me  
a boar for Zeus and Helius, the sun god.”

Swift-footed Lord Achilles answered him, 260  
“Great Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
most highly honored lord of men, you should  
200 concern yourself with this another time,  
when there is some adjournment in the fighting,  
and when my fury is not so intense.  
But now the dead are lying on the field—  
those who were killed by Hector, son of Priam,  
when Zeus had granted him the strength to win.  
And yet you two are saying we should eat!  
I would command the sons of Greece to fight 270  
fasting, unresting, till the sun goes down,  
and make a mighty banquet only then,  
after we have avenged this foul disgrace.

210 Till then, no food nor drink will pass my lips  
because my friend is dead. He was cut down  
by sharp bronze weapons. Now he is laid out  
inside my hut, his feet towards the door.  
Around him, our companions weep and wail.  
These other things mean nothing to me now.  
My heart is set on slaughter and on blood  
and on the painful groans of dying men.”

280

Intelligent Odysseus replied,  
“Achilles, son of Peleus, you are  
the very finest fighter of the Greeks,  
much better and more skillful with a spear  
than me. But in a contest of ideas,  
I would defeat you, because I am older,  
220 and I know more than you. So let your heart  
submit. Be patient, listen to my words.  
Men soon grow sick of battle, wherein bronze  
cuts down so many stalks—so small a harvest—  
when Zeus, the steward of the wars of men,  
allows his scales to turn. The Greeks cannot  
grieve for the dead with endless empty bellies.  
Too many more are falling every day.  
When is there ever any rest from pain?  
When someone dies, we have to bury him  
with hardened hearts and weep for just one day.  
230 Those who survive the horrors of the war  
must satisfy their hunger and their thirst,  
so that we can continue in the battle,  
fighting the enemy unceasingly  
with even greater zeal and greater vigor,  
wearing unwearied bronze about our bodies.  
After the meal, let nobody hold back.  
Do not await another call to arms.  
This is your summons. And it will go ill  
for anyone who stays beside the ships.  
Assemble quickly and let us arouse  
sharp, cruel Ares, god of war, against  
the Trojans, lords of horses.”

290

300

310

So he spoke,  
and took with him the sons of noble Nestor,  
and Meges, son of Phyleus, and Thoas  
and Melanippus and Meriones  
240 and Lycomedes, noble son of Creon.  
They went to Agamemnon's hut from which,  
no sooner said than done, they carried out  
the seven tripods he had promised him,  
twenty bright cauldrons, and twelve stallions,  
and brought the seven skillful working-women 320  
and beautiful Briseis as the eighth.  
Odysseus weighed out ten pounds of gold,  
then led the way back to the camp, and with him,  
the other men came carrying the gifts.  
They set them in the middle of the council  
and Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,  
250 stood up. Talthybius, whose voice was godlike,  
carried the boar to him and stood beside him,  
and Agamemnon drew the knife that always  
hung by the scabbard of his sword, and cut 330  
the bristles of the boar— first sacrifice.  
Then all the Greeks, according to the custom,  
sat in their proper places silently  
and listened to the leader. And he prayed,  
gazing towards the sky.

“Now witness this!  
First Zeus, the highest, greatest of the gods,  
then Earth and Sun and Furies, who take vengeance  
260 on any human who forswears an oath—  
I never laid a hand upon the girl,  
Briseis, never used her for my bed, 340  
nor any other purpose. There she stayed  
inside my hut, but no one asked for her.  
If any of the things I say is false,  
may the gods give me all the pains imposed  
on anyone who wrongs them with false oaths.”

With this, he used the unrelenting bronze

to cut the boar's throat. Then Talthybius  
picked up the animal, took aim, and hurled him  
into the mighty gulf of salt gray sea  
to feed the fishes. And Achilles stood  
among the warlike Greeks, and spoke these words.

350

270 “Great father Zeus, what terrible delusions  
you give to men! Without you, Agamemnon  
would never have stirred up such rage in me,  
nor taken her from me against my will.  
He was so stubborn, and so powerless.  
Zeus wanted to bring death to many Greeks.  
Now go to dinner, so that soon we can  
join Ares for the battle.”

So he spoke,  
and quickly broke the meeting up. The men  
dispersed, each to his ship. The Myrmidons  
labored to get the gifts and carry them  
towards the ship of godlike Lord Achilles.  
They set the presents in his hut and brought  
280 the women there, and noble stewards drove  
the horses to the herd. And then Briseis,  
who shone as bright as golden Aphrodite,  
saw that Patroclus had been killed with bronze,  
and wrapped herself around him with a wail  
and scratched her breasts, soft neck, and pretty face.  
The woman, looking like a goddess, wept,  
and said,

360

290 “Patroclus, in my desperate plight  
I loved you most. I left you here alive,  
and I come back here now to find you dead,  
after you led the troops to war. For me,  
one trouble always follows on another.  
I saw the man to whom my parents gave me  
cut down before our city with sharp bronze,  
along with my three brothers, whom I loved.

370

All of us shared one father and one mother,  
 all of them slaughtered on a single day.  
 But you—when swift Achilles killed my husband  
 and sacked the city of divine King Munes,  
 you would not let me weep at all. You said  
 that you would make me be the lawful wife  
 of godlike Lord Achilles, and that you  
 would take me back to Phthia on his ship  
 and there among the Myrmidons arrange  
 a wedding feast to celebrate my marriage.  
 So I will weep for you unceasingly  
 now you are dead—because you always were  
 so kind to me.”

390

She spoke these words in tears,  
 and all the other women wailed in answer.  
 Using the lamentation for Patroclus,  
 each of the women wept for their own troubles.  
 The older Greek men gathered round Achilles,  
 and begged him to eat something. He refused,  
 groaning with grief, and said,

“I beg you, please,  
 listen to me, dear friends, and do not tell me  
 to satisfy myself with food or drink,  
 because I am too overwhelmed by grief.  
 Till sunset I will not eat anything.”

400

With this, he made the other leaders leave,  
 but the two sons of Atreus remained,  
 with Idomeneus, Odysseus,  
 Nestor, and Phoenix, the old charioteer.  
 They tried assiduously to comfort him  
 in his distress, but could not cheer him up.  
 The only comfort that his heart could feel  
 was entering the bloody mouth of war.  
 Remembering, he sighed and sobbed and said,

410



“My dearest love! My poor, unlucky friend!  
You used to make us such delicious food,  
preparing it yourself inside our hut  
quickly and competently, any time  
the Greeks were hurrying to bring the tears  
of Ares to the Trojans, lords of horses.  
But now you have been killed. You lie here, dead,  
so I cannot taste any food or drink,  
320 although there are such plentiful supplies,  
because I miss you. Nothing else could ever  
be worse for me than this. This is far worse  
than if I found out that my father died  
in Phthia—where he must be miserable,  
shedding soft tears and missing me, his son.  
And meanwhile, I am out here making war  
against the Trojans in a foreign land  
for Helen, who makes everybody shudder.  
The loss of you is far more terrible  
than if I learned that my dear son was dead,  
the boy whom they are bringing up for me  
on Scyros—godlike Neoptolemus—  
if he is still alive. Till now, I thought  
that only I would die out here in Troy,  
far from the lands of Argos, grazed by horses,  
330 and you would go back home again to Phthia,  
and fetch my son from Scyros in black ships  
and show him everything—the wealth I won,  
the captive women, and my high-roofed home.  
In fact, I think that Peleus has either  
already died, or barely clings to life,  
suffering from the miseries of age,  
and constantly expecting bitter news  
of me—the day he learns that I am dead.”

420

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440

He spoke in tears, and all the older leaders  
wailed in response, and each of them remembered  
what he had left behind in his own home.  
340 Then Zeus, the son of Cronus, saw them grieving,  
and pitied them, and right away his words

flew to Athena.

“Child, have you completely  
abandoned your own man? Or does your heart  
no longer care at all about Achilles?  
He sits before the tall ships’ sterns and weeps  
for his dear comrade. All the other men  
have gone to dinner, but he fasts, not eating.  
Go to him and drip nectar and ambrosia  
into his body, so he will not starve.”

450

Athena was already keen to go.

350 She leapt down from the sky and through the air,  
just like a shearwater with outstretched wings  
and shrill, clear cry. At once the Greeks in camp  
put on their armor and took up their weapons.

460

Athena dripped the nectar and ambrosia  
into Achilles, so that painful hunger  
would not afflict his body. Then she went  
back to the solid house of her strong father.  
The warriors poured out from the swift ships.

360 As thick and fast as when cold snowflakes fly  
from Zeus, impelled by Boreas, the child  
of upper air—so numerous, so fast,  
out of the ships poured forth the gleaming helmets,  
the shields with bosses, firmly fastened breastplates,  
and spears of ash. The glimmer reached the sky  
and all the earth around them seemed to smile  
with flashing bronze. The sound of marching feet  
reverberated. In their midst, Achilles  
put on his armor. And his teeth were clenched,  
his eyes shone bright as blazing fire, his heart  
was full of an intolerable grief.

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Enraged against the Trojans, he put on  
the gifts the god Hephaestus made for him.

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370 And first, he strapped the greaves around his legs,  
adorned with silver pieces round the ankles,  
and then he put the breastplate on his chest.  
He slung the silver-studded sword of bronze

over his shoulders, and then lifted up  
the massive, heavy shield, whose brightness shone  
into the distance like the moon. As when  
a blazing fire in a lonely farm,  
high on the mountains, becomes visible  
to sailors out at sea—but gusts of wind  
push them away against their will, across  
the fish-filled sea and far from all their loved ones—  
just so, Achilles' finely crafted shield

380 put forth a brightness that could reach the sky.

And then he picked the heavy helmet up  
and put it on his head. It shone like starlight,  
and all along the crest, the golden horsehairs,  
implanted thickly on it by Hephaestus,  
nodded. Godlike Achilles tried the armor  
around himself, to see if it would fit,  
and if his limbs could move around inside it.

And it became like wings that raised him up.  
And then Achilles, shepherd of the people,  
took from its case his father's massive spear.

No other Greek could wield it. He alone  
knew how to handle this enormous weapon,  
the spear of ash wood from Mount Pelion,

390 a Pelian spear that Peleus was given  
to ply by Chiron, to deal death to men.

Automedon and Alcimius worked hard  
to yoke the horses, fastening around them  
beautiful harnesses, and in their mouths  
they put the bits, from which they stretched the reins  
back to the chariot. Automedon  
picked up the shining whip that fit his hand  
and jumped into the chariot. Behind him,  
Achilles mounted, shining in his armor  
as brightly as Hyperion the sun.

He shouted in a terrifying voice  
and called out to his father's horses,

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400 “Children  
of Brightfoot, famous Bay and famous Dapple,

when we have had enough of war, remember  
to bring your driver back to the Greek camp,  
and do not leave him out there on the plain  
dead, as you did Patroclus.”

Bay, the horse  
with shining hooves, began to speak to him  
from underneath the yoke, his head bowed low,  
his mane all streaming out beside the yoke strap  
onto the ground. The white-armed goddess, Hera,  
had given him the power of speech. He said,

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410 “Certainly we shall save you for the moment,  
mighty Achilles. But your day of death  
is near you now. And we are not to blame.  
Blame the great god and mighty Destiny.  
No tardiness or laziness of ours  
allowed the Trojans to remove the weapons  
and take them from the body of Patroclus.  
It was the son of finely braided Leto,  
Apollo, best of gods, who killed Patroclus  
among the frontline fighters, and gave glory  
to Hector. We could run as fast as Zephyr,  
the wind they call the fastest of them all,  
but it is fated that you will be killed  
both by a human and a god.”

540

But as  
he spoke these words, the Furies stopped his speech.  
Swift-footed Lord Achilles answered him,  
deeply distressed and troubled,

420 “Bay, why do you  
prophecy death to me? You need not do so.  
I know all this already very well.  
It is my fate to die out here at Troy,  
far from my loving father and my mother.  
But even so, I shall not stop until

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I drive the Trojans to be sick of war.”

With this, he screamed a war cry and then drove  
the strong-hoofed horses through the frontline fighters.

## BOOK 20



## The Warrior's Return

Beside the curving ships, the Greeks strapped on  
their armor and prepared to follow you,  
Achilles, son of Peleus. Your thirst  
for battle was insatiable. The Trojans  
lined up to face them on the higher ground.  
Then from the peak of craggy Mount Olympus  
great Zeus told Themis she must call the gods  
to an assembly. She went everywhere,  
and summoned them up to the house of Zeus.  
All of the rivers came, except for Ocean,  
and all the nymphs who live in lovely groves  
and springs and creeks and grassy water-meadows.  
They reached the house of Zeus who gathers clouds  
and sat out in the polished colonnades,  
ingeniously constructed by Hephaestus  
for Zeus, his father. So the gods were gathered  
inside the home of Zeus. And even Lord  
Poseidon, god of earthquakes, did not fail  
to heed the summons of the goddess Themis.  
Emerging from the salty sea, he joined them,

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sat in the midst of them, and questioned Zeus  
about his plan.

“Why have you called the gods  
to an assembly, god of flashing lightning?  
Are you concerned about the Greeks and Trojans?  
Their battle is about to burn.”

20 And Zeus,  
the god who gathers clouds together, answered,  
“Great god of earthquakes, you already know  
my purposes in gathering you here.  
The dying human beings interest me.  
I shall remain on craggy Mount Olympus—  
I like to watch from here. The rest of you,  
go there, among the Trojans and the Greeks,  
and help whichever side you each prefer.  
If swift-footed Achilles fought alone  
against the Trojans, they could not withstand him  
for longer than a very little while.  
They used to shiver at the sight of him  
even before, and now he is consumed  
by furious anger for his dead companion.  
I am afraid he may destroy their wall,  
30 going beyond what is allotted him.”

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So spoke the son of Cronus, and aroused  
unceasing war. The gods set off to battle,  
with different purposes in mind. One group—  
Pallas Athena, Hera, Lord Poseidon  
who shakes and quakes the earth, and helpful Hermes,  
the wiliest of gods—approached the ships.  
And with them went Hephaestus, confident  
of his own strength, despite his halting stride.  
His slender legs moved easily along.  
The other group approached the Trojans—Ares,  
his helmet glittering, long-haired Apollo,  
the archer Artemis, their mother Leto,

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40 Xanthus, and laughter-loving Aphrodite.  
While the gods kept their distance from the humans,  
the Greeks were proud and joyful that Achilles  
had reappeared after so long an absence  
from cruel war and every Trojan quaked,  
terrified at the sight of the swift-footed  
Achilles shining in his dazzling armor, 60  
like Ares, ruin of humanity.  
But after the Olympians had come,  
Conflict, the powerful provocateur  
of armies, rose among them. And Athena  
howled—sometimes standing by the ditch  
beyond the wall, and sometimes down beside  
50 the loud-resounding headlands of the shore,  
shrieking and bellowing. And elsewhere, Ares  
howled as he hovered like a dark tornado  
right on the very pinnacle of Troy, 70  
and screamed commands, and sometimes sprinted off  
beside the broad Simoeis and across  
the hill of beauty— Callicolone.  
The gods who live at ease riled up both sides,  
and made harsh conflict break out in their midst.  
The father of the gods and humans thundered,  
a terrifying noise on high. Below,  
Poseidon shook the never-ending earth,  
and shook the highest mountain peaks. The foothills  
and crags and creeks and waterfalls of Ida, 80  
60 the Trojan city and the Greek armada  
all shook. Beneath the ground, the king of spirits,  
Hades, was terrified, jumped from his throne,  
and shouted to Poseidon, god of earthquakes,  
not to allow the ground above to break  
and show to mortals and the deathless gods  
his horrifying kingdom of decay,  
which is disgusting even to the gods.  
That was how loud the thunderous noise became  
as gods began opposing one another 90  
in conflict. And against Poseidon stood  
Phoebus Apollo with his flying arrows.



70 Bright-eyed Athena stood and challenged Ares  
and Hera was confronted by the goddess  
of rushing winds and murmuring streams and arrows,  
Artemis with her golden bow, the sister  
of Lord Apollo, to whom distances  
are nothing. Helpful Hermes stood and challenged  
Leto. Against Hephaestus rose the river,  
broad, deep, and eddying, whom gods call Xanthus—  
“Yellow”—but humans call him the Scamander.  
So the gods faced each other, while Achilles  
searched through the crowd for Hector, son of Priam.  
His was the blood Achilles longed to spill  
to satisfy the thirsty god of war.  
But then Aeneas was inspired to fight  
against Achilles, son of Peleus,  
by great Apollo, lord of hosts, who filled  
80 his heart with strength. Apollo, son of Zeus,  
spoke in the voice of Priam’s son Lycaon  
and said,

100

“Aeneas, councillor of Troy,  
where are the threats you always used to make  
among the Trojan lords when you were drunk?  
You vowed to fight Achilles face to face!”

Aeneas answered, “Son of Priam, no.  
Why are you telling me to fight Achilles,  
the proud, swift-footed son of Peleus?  
I will not. I have faced him once before.  
90 He chased me with his spear away from Ida,  
when he had come out there to steal our cows,  
and then he devastated Pedasus  
and great Lyrnessus. I was saved by Zeus,  
who gave me speed and strength to get away.  
Otherwise, I would surely have been killed  
both by Achilles’ hands and by Athena,  
who went in front of him, assisted him,  
and ordered him to use his spear of bronze  
to kill the Trojans and the Leleges.

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No man can fight Achilles face to face,  
because he always has a god beside him,  
protecting him from any harm. Moreover,  
his weapon always flies towards its target,  
not stopping till it pierces human flesh.  
But if a god arranged for a fair fight,  
stretching the rope of battle taut and true,  
he would not win so easily, although  
he loves pretending he is made of bronze.”

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The god Apollo, son of Zeus, replied,  
“Come on, my lord! You also have the power  
to pray to the eternal gods. They say  
you are the son of Aphrodite, daughter  
of Zeus! His mother is a lesser goddess.  
Zeus is your mother’s father, while his mother  
is just the daughter of an old sea god.  
Attack him head-on with your tireless bronze,  
and do not let him turn you back with threats  
or insults.”

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With these words, he breathed aggression  
into Aeneas, shepherd of the people,  
who set off through the fighters at the front,  
in glittering bronze armor. White-armed Hera  
noticed him running through the throng towards  
Achilles, son of Peleus. She gathered  
the gods and said,

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“Think hard and use your wits,  
Poseidon and Athena. What will happen?  
Aeneas, glittering in bronze, is rushing  
towards Achilles, son of Peleus.  
Phoebus Apollo urged him on. But come,  
we need to turn him back, or one of us  
should stand beside Achilles and provide him  
with power so his spirit never fails,  
and show him that the greatest of the gods

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love him, and that the gods who used to save  
the Trojans in the war are useless now.  
All of us have come down from Mount Olympus  
so that we can participate in battle,  
ensuring that Achilles will be safe  
among the Trojans for today. Thereafter,  
he has to suffer the allotted thread  
that Destiny first spun for him at birth  
the day his mother bore him. If Achilles  
is not informed about this by a god,  
he will be frightened later, when some god  
meets him in battle. It is hard for humans  
to face the gods when we reveal ourselves.”

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Poseidon, god of earthquakes, answered, “Hera,  
do not be angry or irrational.  
There is no need for that. I would not want  
conflict between the other gods and us,  
because we are much better than they are.  
Let all of us now leave the common track  
and go to sit up high where we can watch.  
War is a task for men. But if Apollo  
or Ares starts to fight and blocks Achilles  
and will not let him fight, we must at once  
challenge them on the battlefield. I think  
we shall soon separate the warring sides  
and make those gods rejoin the other gods  
on Mount Olympus, crushed beneath our hands  
and forced to flee the field against their will.”

180

With this, the god whose locks are dark as water  
led them towards the high wall that the Trojans  
and great Athena built for Heracles  
so that he could escape the sea monster,  
hurrying from the beach towards the plain.  
Poseidon and the other gods sat there  
and cast a misty cloud around themselves,  
thick and impenetrable. Facing them,  
the other gods, including you, Apollo,

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whom humans hail, and Ares, city-sacker,  
sat on the brow of Callicolone.

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In these positions the two groups of gods  
plotted—but all were hesitant to start  
war, which entails such misery and grief,  
though Zeus who sits on high had told them to.  
The plain was bright with bronze and full of men  
and horses, and beneath their feet, the ground  
shook as they dashed together. Keen to fight,  
two heroes came together in the middle  
between the pair of armies—Lord Aeneas,  
son of Anchises, and godlike Achilles.

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Aeneas first came forward, full of menace,  
his heavy helmet bobbing on his head.  
He held his mighty shield in front of him  
and brandished his bronze spear. Achilles, son  
of Peleus, confronted him and pounced,  
like a devouring lion, whom the people  
from all around are desperate to kill—  
they gather to confront him, but the lion  
ignores them and continues on his way  
till one of the young warriors attacks  
and hits him with a spear—he crouches low,  
jaws open and foam frothing on his teeth—  
his brave heart groans, and with his tail he lashes  
his flanks from side to side, and goads himself  
to battle, and with eyes ablaze, he hurtles  
straight at the enemy, to kill some man  
or else be killed himself amid the fray—  
just so, Achilles' bold, intrepid spirit  
goaded him forward to come face to face  
with valiant Aeneas. As these men  
advanced, when they had almost reached each other,  
swift-footed Lord Achilles said,

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“Aeneas,  
why did you make your way through such a crowd  
to face me? Does your spirit bid you fight me  
because you hope to rule the Trojan horse-lords,

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gaining the status that King Priam has?  
Even if you do kill me, Priam will not  
ever award that dignity to you.  
Remember, he has sons, and he is loyal,  
not as weak as wind. Or did the Trojans promise  
to give you fields and orchards to take care of—  
a beautiful estate as your reward  
if you kill me? I think it will be hard  
for you to manage it. Let me remind you  
what happened last time when I threatened you  
and made you run away to flee my spear.  
Have you forgotten that you were alone  
among the cattle and I made you run  
at topmost speed on hastening, scampering feet  
all the way down the mountain slopes of Ida?  
And as you fled, you never once looked back.  
You scurried to Lyrnessus, but I sacked it,  
advancing on the city with the help  
of great Athena and her father Zeus.  
And I enslaved the women as my trophies,  
and took away their day of being free.  
But Zeus and other gods protected you.  
I doubt you will survive on this occasion,  
as you may think. I tell you now, go back,  
rejoin your comrades, do not challenge me  
or you may suffer something very bad.  
Fools understand too late, when done is done.”

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Aeneas answered, “Son of Peleus,  
you should not try to scare me like a child.  
I am as good as you at giving speeches,  
using insulting and unpleasant words.  
We know each other’s ancestry and parents  
from hearing ancient tales from other people,  
although you never set your eyes on mine  
nor I on yours. They say you are the son  
of noble Peleus and that your mother  
is Thetis with her coils of lovely locks,  
the watery sea goddess. I am proud

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to be the son of valiant Anchises.

The goddess Aphrodite is my mother.

210 Tomorrow either yours or mine will weep  
for their dear son, because I do not think  
these childish words will make us quit the battle.

But if you want to know about these things

and understand about my ancestry,

280

it is well-known to many. Long ago,

Zeus, who amasses clouds together, fathered

Dardanus, founder of Dardania,

back when the holy town of Troy, our home,

was not yet built upon this plain. They lived

amid the creeks and springs beneath Mount Ida.

And then the son of Dardanus took over—

220 King Erichthonius, who was the richest  
of any human being in the world

because he had three thousand mares who grazed

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the water-meadows, and each proudly watched

a little filly skipping at her side.

The north wind, Boreas, desired them

as they were grazing, and transformed himself

into a stallion with a dark blue mane.

And they conceived and bore twelve foals, all fillies,

who pranced across the fields, the source of life,

skipping atop the topmost ears of grain

and never broke the stalks, and skimmed across

the sea's wide back, and scampered in between

300

the highest breakers of the salt gray sea.

230 The son of Erichthonius was Tros,  
king of the Trojans, and Tros had three sons,  
Ilus, Assaracus, and Ganymede.

No mortal was more beautiful than him,

and so, because of his attractiveness,

the gods abducted him and raised him up

to serve as cupbearer to Zeus, and live

among the deathless gods. The son of Ilus

was fine Laomedon. Laomedon

310

fathered Tithonus, Priam, Clytius,

Lampus, and Hicataon, friend of Ares.

Assaracus had Capys, who begat  
240 Anchises, my own father. Priam fathered  
glorious Hector. I am proud to be  
born from this bloodline and this ancestry.  
But Zeus increases and diminishes  
courage in human beings as he will,  
because he is the strongest one of all.  
Come on, let us stop chattering like children, 320  
standing here in the middle of a battle!  
Both of us can keep generating insults,  
so many that a massive merchant ship,  
a trireme with a hundred rowing benches,  
could never bear the weight of all our words.  
The tongues of human beings twist and turn  
and there are many different types of speech.  
The field of language spreads out far and wide.  
250 People will talk of you as you of them.  
Why do we need to quarrel with each other, 330  
like women who get angry and create  
a conflict that is eating at their hearts,  
who come out in the middle of the street  
and argue, slinging insults at each other,  
both true and false, as anger urges them?  
Nothing that you can say will turn me back  
from battle, now that I am keen to fight.  
Come on then, let us taste each other's spears."

With this, Aeneas drove his heavy spear  
into the formidable, daunting shield 340  
260 of his opponent, and the spear's tip clanged.  
Achilles held his shield on his firm arm  
a distance from himself. He was alarmed.  
He thought the long dark spear of brave Aeneas  
would easily pass through, because, poor fool!  
his heart and mind had failed to understand  
that splendid gifts from gods are hard for mortals  
to break or get away from. But the spear  
of great Aeneas did not pierce the shield.  
The gold the god had given kept it out. 350

270 The spear passed through two layers of the shield,  
but there were still three more, because Hephaestus,  
the god who walks on twisted feet, had used  
five layers, with the outer two of bronze,  
the inner two of tin, and in the middle  
one strip of gold, which stopped the ash-wood spear.  
And then Achilles hurled his long dark spear  
and hit Aeneas on his balanced shield,  
right on the rim, just where the bronze was thinnest,  
as was the oxhide used to back it up. 360

And as the Pelian ash-wood spear flew through,  
the shield let out a shriek. Aeneas ducked,  
and held the shield away from him in terror.  
The weapon soared above his back and stuck  
in earth, still ravenous, though it had broken  
280 two layers of the shield around the man.

Aeneas had evaded the long spear  
and he stood up again—still shocked and scared,  
with infinite sadness swelling in his eyes,  
because it came so close to him. Achilles 370  
drew his sharp sword and leapt at him and screamed  
a terrifying war cry, while Aeneas  
picked up a boulder—one that would have been  
too heavy for two men of modern times,  
and yet he brandished it with ease alone.

He aimed it at Achilles, and would surely  
have struck him on his helmet or the shield  
that had just saved his life—and great Achilles,  
the son of Peleus, would have moved close  
290 and struck Aeneas with his sword and killed him— 380  
had not Poseidon, god of earthquakes, noticed  
and told the deathless gods immediately,

“What a disaster! I am struck by grief  
for brave Aeneas, who will soon be killed  
by great Achilles, son of Peleus,  
and have to go to Hades, all because  
he trusted the far-shooting god, Apollo.  
Poor fool! Apollo will not save his life.



But why should innocent Aeneas suffer  
for troubles that do not belong to him?  
He always gave fine offerings to please  
the gods who own the spacious sky. So come,  
we need to carry him away from danger.  
Zeus may be angry if Achilles kills him.  
Aeneas has been fated to survive,  
so that the family of Dardanus,  
whom Zeus, the son of Cronus, loved the most  
of all the sons he had by mortal women,  
will not die out, forgotten, with no seed.  
But Zeus has come to hate the line of Priam.  
Therefore Aeneas and his children's children  
who will be born in future generations  
will rule the Trojans."

390

400

Ox-eyed Hera answered,  
"Poseidon, lord of earthquakes, you decide  
about Aeneas. Save him, or allow  
Achilles, son of Peleus, to kill him  
although he is a noble man. But we,  
Pallas Athena and myself, have sworn  
numerous oaths among the deathless gods  
never to save the Trojans from disaster—  
not even when the whole of Troy is burning,  
not even when the warlike sons of Greece  
ignite an all-consuming fire and burn  
the city to the ground."

410

And when Poseidon,  
the god of earthquakes, heard these words, he went  
into the battle through the throng of spears,  
and reached Aeneas and renowned Achilles.  
At once, he poured thick mist across the eyes  
of great Achilles, son of Peleus,  
and took the bronze-tipped ash spear from the shield  
of brave Aeneas, and then laid it down  
before Achilles' feet. The god scooped up  
Aeneas from the ground and raised him high,

420

making him fly across the gathered armies,  
across the horses and the chariots.

The god's hand held him till he set him down  
right at the raging battle's farthest edge,  
where the Caucones armed for war. Poseidon,  
the god of earthquakes, came towards Aeneas  
and spoke to him with words on wings.

“Aeneas,

which god has made you so delusional?  
Which god commanded you to fight against  
the haughty son of Peleus, who is  
much stronger than you are, and loved more dearly  
by the immortal gods? You must draw back  
whenever you encounter him, or else  
you may arrive inside the house of Hades  
before your proper time. But once Achilles  
has met his death, his destiny, take courage,  
and boldly face the fighters at the front,  
because no other Greek will slaughter you.”

When he had said all this, he left him there.  
And then the god dispersed the magic mist  
from great Achilles, and his eyes could see.  
Troubled, Achilles told his mighty heart,

“What an extraordinary sight! So strange!  
My spear is lying here upon the ground,  
and yet I cannot see the man at whom  
I aimed and hurled it, whom I hoped to kill.  
So after all, the deathless gods do love  
Aeneas, though I thought he was just bragging.  
Then let him go! He will not want to try  
fighting with me again. He will be glad  
that he has got away from death this time.  
But come, I have to rouse the warlike Greeks  
and face the other Trojans and attack them.”

With this, he bounded through the ranks and said  
to every man,

“Now noble, godlike Greeks,  
stop staying at a distance from the Trojans.  
Challenge them, man to man, and fight your hardest!  
Despite my strength and skill, it would be tough  
for me to chase so many men alone  
and fight against them all. Not even Ares,  
although he is a god and an immortal,  
or great Athena, could pursue the jaws  
of such a fighting force, or grapple with it.  
All that my hands and feet and strength can give,  
I tell you I shall give and never stop,  
not even for a moment. I will range  
all through their battle lines, and I will come  
near to the Trojans with my spear. I think  
not one of them will welcome my arrival.”

460

470

With this, Achilles spurred the Greeks to battle.  
Great Hector roused the Trojans with a war cry  
and told them he would fight against Achilles.

“Proud Trojan warriors, you need not fear  
Achilles, son of Peleus. I too  
could fight the deathless gods—with words at least!  
It would be hard to fight them with a spear,  
because they are much stronger. And Achilles  
will not make everything he says come true.  
He will do half of it, but not the rest.  
Now I will go and fight him face to face,  
even if he has hands like fire—like fire!—  
and fury like the glittering of iron.”

480

With this, he riled the Trojans up. They raised  
their spears. The eagerness of both the armies  
was intermingled and their screams grew loud.  
Phoebus Apollo came and stood by Hector

and said,

“Stop challenging Achilles, Hector.  
Wait for him at a distance from the battle,  
amid your troops, or else his spear may strike you  
or he may slash you with his sword.”

490

At this,  
Hector drew back amid his crowd of comrades,  
380 startled to hear a god addressing him.  
Achilles, with his spirit dressed in daring,  
dashed at the Trojans with a dreadful cry,  
and killed Iphition, the noble son  
of Lord Otrynteus, a great commander,  
a city-sacker with a mighty army.  
A water goddess bore him on the slopes  
of snowy Tmolus in the wealthy province  
of Hyde. Great Achilles charged straight at him  
and hurled his spear at him and struck his head  
right in the middle, so it split his skull  
and with a clatter, down he fell. Achilles  
boasted in triumph over him.

500

“Lie there,  
son of Otrynteus, Iphition,  
the wildest, most aggressive man alive!  
390 Here is your death! Your birth was by the lake,  
Gygaea, where your father’s province is,  
beside the River Hyllos, rich in fish,  
and eddying Hermus.”

510

So he spoke in triumph,  
and darkness covered up his victim’s eyes.  
Amid the chaos of the battlefield,  
Greek chariots sliced his body with their wheels.  
Atop this corpse, Achilles killed another—  
Demoleon, Antenor’s son, a brave  
defensive warrior. Achilles struck

his forehead through the helmet and the bronze  
 did not keep out the spear, which eagerly  
 flew in and smashed his skull. Inside, his brains  
 were scrambled and the zealous fighter fell.

400

And then Achilles killed Hippodamas  
 as he was jumping from his chariot  
 and trying to escape. Achilles' spear  
 impaled his back, and with his dying gasps  
 he bellowed, as when young men drag a bull,  
 bellowing, as an offering for Poseidon  
 in Helice—the god is pleased with them—  
 just so, the man's proud spirit left his bones.

530

Achilles with his spear chased Polydorus,  
 a godlike son of Priam, whom his father  
 forbade to fight, because he was the youngest  
 of all his children and his favorite one,  
 who always won footraces. Now, poor fool,  
 he showed his skill at sprinting with a dash  
 amid the frontline fighters, till he died.

410

Swift-footed Lord Achilles speared his back  
 as he was running past him, at his waist,  
 right by the golden buckles of his belt,  
 where the two layers of his jerkin met.

540

The spear's tip drove right out beside his navel.  
 He groaned and fell upon his knees. A cloud  
 of darkness covered him. And as he crumpled,  
 he clutched his spilling entrails with his hands.

When Hector saw his brother, Polydorus,  
 collapsing on the ground and bleeding out,  
 thick mist obscured his eyes, and now he could  
 no longer bear to range around elsewhere.

420

Grasping his sharp spear, like a flame he ran  
 straight at Achilles, who at once jumped forward  
 and said triumphantly,

550

“This is the man  
 who broke my heart, who killed the friend I loved.  
 At last we shall stop shrinking from each other  
 amid the channels of the battlefield.”

With this, he scowled and said to noble Hector,  
“ Come here at once and feel the ropes of death!”

430 But Hector in his flashing helmet answered  
angrily, “Son of Peleus, Achilles,  
you should not try to frighten me with words  
as if you think I am a little child.  
I am as good as you at giving speeches,  
using insulting and unpleasant words.  
I know that you are strong, and I much weaker.  
But everything is in the lap of gods.  
Though I am weaker, I may take your life,  
hurling my spear, whose tip is very sharp.”

560

With this, he whirled and threw his spear. Athena  
turned it away from glorious Achilles  
440 by blowing very lightly, very gently,  
making it land beside the feet of Hector.  
Frenzied Achilles was all agitated  
with desperate desire to kill. He pounced,  
screaming a dreadful war cry. But Apollo  
gathered up Hector and moved him away,  
easily—things are easy for a god—  
and covered him in dense fog. And three times  
swift-footed Lord Achilles rushed against him,  
aiming his bronze spear. But three times he struck  
nothing but air. And on the fourth attempt,  
godlike Achilles gave a furious scream  
and let his words fly forth and said,

570

580

450 “You dog,  
you got away from death again! But ruin  
was very near you. Once again, Apollo  
protected you. I bet you pray to him  
whenever you are going into battle  
amid the clash of spears. I promise you  
that when I meet you next, I will destroy you,  
if any of the gods is helping me.

590

Meanwhile, I shall seek out some other victims.”

With this, he threw his spear and pierced the neck  
of Dryops, who fell down before his feet.

He left him there, and threw his spear and hit  
the strong and mighty son of Philetor,  
Demuchus, on his knee, disabling him,  
then drew his massive sword and took his life.

460 Then he attacked two brothers, sons of Bias,  
Laogonus and Dardanus, and shoved them  
out of their chariot onto the ground, 600  
speared one, and struck the other with his sword.

Then Tros, Alastor’s son, approached and clasped  
Achilles by the knees because he hoped  
that he might spare his life and take him captive,  
not kill him, once he saw their ages matched.

The poor fool did not know he would not listen.

Achilles had no sweetness in his heart,  
no softness in his mind. He was riled up  
with frenzied eagerness to fight and kill.

The Trojan clasped his knees and tried to pray. 610

Achilles plunged his sword into his liver,  
470 which slipped out and the black blood drenched his belly.

The darkness veiled his eyes as he was losing  
his life. And then Achilles stood beside

Mulius, stabbed him through his ear, and drove  
the bronze right out the other ear. He used  
his hilted sword to strike Antenor’s son,  
Echeclus, through the middle of his skull.

Submerged in blood, the blade grew warm. Red death  
and strong fate seized the man and veiled his sight. 620

Achilles killed Deucalion. He struck  
his elbow, where the tendons meet, and sliced  
right through the arm with his bronze spear. The victim,

480 impeded by his injury, could not move  
out of his killer’s way, but looked directly  
towards impending death. Then with his sword  
Achilles struck his neck and chopped his head off  
and threw it far away, helmet and all.

The marrow burst out from the vertebrae.

The torso lay stretched out upon the ground.

630

Then he pursued the son of Piros, Rigmus,  
who came from fertile Thrace. Achilles threw  
his bronze spear at his middle, and it pierced  
his belly. From the chariot he fell.

The charioteer, Arethous, was turning  
the horses round, but with his sharp bronze spear  
Achilles struck his back and made him fall  
out of the chariot. The horses panicked.

490

As fire from heaven rages through deep glens  
on a parched mountainside and forests burn  
and wind whirls everywhere and whips the flames,  
Achilles with his spear swept everywhere,  
pursuing those he killed. The ground flowed black  
with blood. As when a farmer yokes two oxen  
with flat, broad faces, so that he can garner  
white barley in a well-built threshing floor—  
they bellow as they work, and soon the grain  
is turned to husks beneath their hooves—just so  
the strong-hoofed horses driven by Achilles  
trampled the shields and corpses, and the axle  
beneath the chariot was doused in blood,  
as were the rails around it. They were spattered  
by droplets from the wheels and horses' hooves.  
Achilles, son of Peleus, still yearned  
to win himself more glory and success.  
His lethal hands were always drenched in gore.

640

500

650



## BOOK 21



## The River

After they reached the ford of flowing Xanthus,  
the eddying river, son of deathless Zeus,  
Achilles forced the Trojan troops apart,  
pursuing half out to the open plain  
towards the city where the Greeks had fled  
in terror on the day before, when Hector  
raged on the battlefield. They rushed that way,  
routed, and Hera spread thick mist before them  
to block their path. Achilles trapped the others  
inside the silver-swirling river's depths.

10

They tumbled in the water with loud splashes.  
The billowing streams were roaring and the banks  
resounded all around them as they screamed  
and swam about in all directions, pulled  
by currents. As when locusts flee a blast  
of fire and fly away towards the river,  
and at the sudden onslaught of unwearied  
burning, they cower underneath the water—  
just so, the streams of murmuring, eddying Xanthus  
were full of men and horses intermingled.

10

20

Divine Achilles left his spear to lie  
among the tamarisks on the riverbank.  
With just his sword he leapt into the river,  
his heart intent on ruin, like a god.

Whirling around, he hacked and slashed and struck them,  
and from the victims of his blade arose  
20 desperate, agonizing wails. The water  
ran red with blood—just as when other fish  
flee from a massive, monstrous dolphin, filling  
the nooks and hiding places of a harbor  
in terror, and he gulps the ones he catches—  
so did the Trojans cower and shrink back  
within the currents of the fearsome river  
beneath the overhanging banks. Achilles,  
after his hands grew tired from all the slaughter,  
picked out twelve boys alive, as recompense  
for dead Patroclus. And he drove them out,  
as dazed as hunted fawns, and tied their hands  
30 behind their backs with finely fashioned cords  
that they themselves had worn around their tunics.

He gave them to his comrades to escort  
back to the hollow ships and leapt again  
into the river, eager for more slaughter.  
He found Lycaon, one of Priam's sons,  
trying to clamber out and flee the river.  
Achilles had already caught him once  
against his will. Lycaon had been using  
a sharp bronze blade to cut some fresh fig branches  
to make a chariot rail—but as he came  
out of his father's orchard in the night  
godlike Achilles caught him unawares.

40 He took him on his ship to well-built Lemnos  
and sold him as a slave to Jason's son.  
But then a guest-friend came and set him free—  
Imbrian Eetion, who paid his price  
with many gifts, then sent him to Arisbe.  
He fled from there and reached his father's house.  
And after he had come back home from Lemnos  
he spent his time with family and friends,

30

40

50

happy and joyful for eleven days.

60

But on the twelfth, a god sent him again  
into the hands of swift-footed Achilles,  
who meant to send him to the house of Hades  
despite his great unwillingness to go.

50 Achilles saw him there unarmed—no helmet  
or shield, and with no weapon in his hand,  
since he had thrown it all away from him  
onto the ground, when he became exhausted  
and drenched in sweat as he was struggling  
to get out of the river—and Achilles,  
very disturbed, addressed his own brave heart.

70

“My eyes are seeing something very strange!  
Will the brave Trojans I have killed already  
rise up again out of the murky darkness,  
if this one, whom I captured and enslaved,  
has now escaped his cruel day of doom  
and come back here again from holy Lemnos?  
Even the deep and salty sea cannot  
restrain him, though it holds so many others  
against their will. But come now, he shall taste  
60 my spear, so I may see with my own eyes  
whether he can come back like this from death,  
or if the earth, the source of life, will hold him,  
which holds so many men, however strong.”

80

Thinking these thoughts, he waited, and the other  
approached him in a daze and tried to grasp  
his knees, in desperate eagerness to escape  
from death and black destruction. Great Achilles  
brandished his long spear and prepared to strike.  
Lycaon ran beneath it, stooping down,  
and grabbed Achilles by the knees. The spear,  
longing to sate itself on human flesh,  
70 flew past his back and stood fixed in the earth.  
Lycaon clutched Achilles with one hand,  
and with the other, clutched the pointed spear  
and would not let it go. He spoke winged words.

90

“Achilles, please, I beg you by your knees  
to pity me, do right by me, and spare me.  
I have already been your suppliant,  
deserving grace from you, my lord, because  
it was with you that I first tasted bread,  
Demeter’s grain, the day you captured me,  
when you had found me by the well-built orchard,  
and took me as a slave to holy Lemnos,  
far from my father and my family,  
and sold me for a hundred head of cattle.

100

80 But after I had paid three times that price  
I was set free, and it has been twelve days  
since I returned to Troy. I have endured  
terrible things, and now destructive fate  
has brought me to your hands again. It seems  
I must be hated by the father, Zeus,  
because he gave me over to you twice.  
My mother bore me for so short a life!  
My grandfather is Altes, lord of rugged  
Pedasus by the River Satnioeis.

110

He rules the warlike Leleges. His daughter,  
Laothoe, was one of Priam’s women,  
along with many others, and she bore him  
two sons—and you will butcher both of us.

120

90 You have already killed my godlike brother  
amid the well-armed champions at the front—  
fine Polydorus, whom your sharp spear struck.  
Soon you will cause more pain to me as well.  
I do not think I will escape your hands,  
now a divinity has brought me here.  
But I will say one final thing to you.

Consider this, I beg you. Do not kill me,  
because I did not share a womb with Hector,  
who killed your friend, who was both strong and kind.”

130

This was the plea of Priam’s noble son.  
The answer he received was far from gentle.  
“Fool, do not talk to me of ransom. Hush!  
100 Before Patroclus died and met his fate,

I was a little more inclined to spare  
the Trojans. I took many of them prisoner  
and sold them off alive as slaves. But now,  
no Trojan will escape from death, whenever  
a god casts one of you into my hands  
in front of Troy—especially sons of Priam.

140

So die, my friend. Why are you so upset?  
Patroclus has already died as well,  
and he was far superior to you.

Do you not see how tall and fine I am?

My father was a noble, handsome man,  
my mother was a goddess. Even so,

110 death and strong destiny will come for me.

And there will be some dawn or noon or evening  
when somebody will take away my life  
in battle with a spear's throw or an arrow."

150

At this, his victim's heart and body sank.

He dropped the spear, knelt down, spread out his arms  
and then Achilles drew his sharpened sword  
and struck his neck above the collarbone  
and drove the two-edged blade in all the way.

He lay stretched out face-down upon the ground.

Black blood dripped out of him and wet the earth.

120 Achilles grabbed him by his foot and threw him  
into the river to be swept away,

and triumphed over him with these winged words.

160

"Lie there among the fishes, who will lick  
blood from your wound. They will not care for you.

Your mother will not lay you on a bier  
or offer ritual cries of grief for you.

Instead, Scamander's eddying streams will bring you  
down to the sea's broad lap. A fish will leap  
beneath the darkening ripples, through the waves,  
to eat Lycaon's bright white shining fat.

Die, all you Trojans! All of you must die,  
until I reach the holy town of Troy.

And you will run, but I will be behind you,

170

130 slashing and slaying. You will get no help  
from this fair river with its silver streams,  
to whom you sacrificed so many bulls  
and horses, cast alive into the currents.  
Despite all that, you Trojans have to die  
by dreadful deaths, until you have repaid  
the slaughter of Patroclus and the ruin  
you brought upon the other Greeks you killed  
beside the swift Greek ships while I was gone.” 180

At this, the river grew yet more enraged,  
wondering in his heart how best to make  
Achilles stop his deadly work, and how  
to save the Trojans from destruction. Meanwhile,  
the son of Peleus was brandishing  
140 his long dark-shadowed spear. Intent to kill,  
he leapt upon Asteropeus, son  
of Pelegon, the son of Axius,  
the broadly flowing river with deep eddies,  
by noble Periboea, eldest daughter 190  
of Aecessamenus. The whirling river  
mingled with her and she bore Pelegon,  
whose son, Asteropeus, was the one  
on whom Achilles pounced. Asteropeus  
had climbed out of the river and now stood  
holding two spears and Xanthus gave him courage,  
because he was so angry at the slaughter  
of all the young men whom Achilles killed  
amid his streams, to whom he showed no pity.  
As they drew close, swift-footed Lord Achilles 200  
150 asked him,

“Who are you? Where do you come from?  
And do you dare to challenge me in battle?  
When sons encounter me, their parents weep.”

The glorious son of Pelegon replied,  
“Proud son of Peleus, why do you ask

about my ancestry? Paeonia,  
a fertile country far away from here,  
is where I come from, and I brought with me  
Paeonian warriors with spears. It is  
eleven days since I arrived at Troy.  
I am the grandson of a flowing river—  
broad Axius, the most magnificent  
and loveliest of waters on the earth.  
He fathered Pelegon, the famous spearman,  
who was my father, so they say. And now,  
famous Achilles, let us fight.”

210

He made  
these threats, and great Achilles aimed his spear  
of Pelian ash. Asteropeus threw  
both spears at once, as he was ambidextrous.  
One struck Achilles’ shield but did not break it,  
blocked by the gold the god had forged for him.  
The other spear just grazed Achilles’ arm.  
Black blood gushed out. The weapon sailed right past him  
and fixed itself in earth, although it longed  
to sate itself on flesh. Achilles, eager  
to kill Asteropeus, hurled his spear  
of ash, which usually flew straight, but missed,  
and hit the riverbank up high, implanted  
to half its length. The son of Peleus  
drew out his sharp sword from beside his thigh  
and pounced in fury, while Asteropeus  
struggled to pull the spear out of the bank.  
Three times he tugged and twisted it. Three times  
his efforts failed. The fourth time, he intended  
to bend and snap the ash-wood spear, but then,  
before he managed it, Achilles came  
near him and swung his sword and took his life.  
He slashed his belly underneath the navel  
and all his bowels spilled out. He gasped, and darkness  
covered his eyes. Achilles jumped upon him,  
stood on his chest and stripped his arms and armor,  
and spoke triumphantly.

220

230

240

“Lie there! It is  
difficult, even for a river’s grandson,  
to grapple with the sons of mighty Zeus.

You claimed to be descended from a river,  
but I am proud to claim my ancestry  
from Zeus, the son of Cronus. And the man  
who fathered me was Peleus, the king  
of many Myrmidons. He was the son  
of Aeacus, who was the son of Zeus.

250

190 Zeus is more powerful than any river  
that gurgles on its journey to the sea.  
You have a fine big river with you now.  
See if he does you any good. There is  
no way to fight with Zeus, the son of Cronus.  
Not even the majestic Achelous  
competes with him, nor even the great might  
of fathomless, immeasurable Ocean,  
from whom flows every river, every sea,  
all springs and fountains and all deep dark wells.  
Yes, even he is frightened of great Zeus  
when crackling thunder rumbles from the sky.”

260

200 With this, he drew his bronze spear from the bank  
and left the dead man lying on the sand,  
robbed of his precious life. Dark water lapped  
around the body, soaking it, and soon  
the fish and eels were busily at work,  
nibbling at the fat around his kidneys.  
Achilles then pursued his victim’s comrades,  
the drivers from Paeonia, who fled  
along the eddying river, when they saw  
their finest champion fallen in the fighting  
beneath the hands and sword of great Achilles.  
He killed Thersilochus, Astypylus,  
210 Aenius, Ophelestes, Thrasius,  
and Mydon. Then swift-footed Lord Achilles  
would have killed even more Paeonians,  
but then the swirling river, in a fury,  
spoke to him, taking on a human form,

270



and from his eddying depths called out,

280

“Achilles,

you are more powerful than other men,  
more capable of doing dreadful harm.  
The gods are constantly protecting you,  
but even if great Zeus, the son of Cronus,  
enables you to slaughter all the Trojans,  
at least drive them away from me. Perform  
your horrifying actions on the plain.  
My lovely streams have been clogged up with corpses.  
I cannot freely pour my waters down  
into the shining sea, because the bodies  
choke me, yet you keep killing even more,  
220 annihilating everyone. Come on,  
leader of troops, stop now! This is too much.”

Swift-footed Lord Achilles answered him,  
“It will be as you say, divine Scamander.  
But I will massacre these arrogant Trojans,  
not stopping till I trap them in their city  
and fight with Hector, man to man, and see  
if he defeats me or I conquer him.”

300

Then like a god he rushed against the Trojans.  
The eddying deep river told Apollo,  
230 “God of the silver bow, offspring of Zeus,  
you failed to implement your father’s plans.  
The son of Cronus earnestly advised you  
to stand beside the Trojans and protect them  
until at last the sun begins to set  
and spreads its shadows on the fertile fields.”

But then the famed spear warrior, Achilles,  
jumped off the bank and plunged into the water.  
The river surged and swelled and rushed against him,  
swirling and gathering his streams together  
to sweep away the multitude of corpses

310

that blocked his waters, from the many people  
killed by Achilles. Roaring like a bull,  
the river hurled them out onto the land.

He saved the people who were still alive,  
hiding them underneath his lovely streams  
among the whirling eddies of his depths.

240 Gurgling horribly, a wave rose up  
around Achilles, and the blast of water  
battered against his shield and thrust him back.  
He lost his footing, and his hands reached out  
to clutch a stately, well-grown elm, and ripped it  
out by the roots, and the whole riverbank  
fell with the fallen tree. Thick branches blocked  
the fresh, free-flowing waters, and the trunk,  
completely fallen in the riverbed,  
dammed up the current. And Achilles rose  
out of the swirling stream and sprinted off  
across the plain, quick as his feet would go,  
terrified. But the great god did not stop.

250 His surface water darkened as he surged  
and swelled towards Achilles, in his effort  
to stop him and to save the Trojans' lives.

The son of Peleus went dashing back,  
as far as spears can fly, as fast as when  
the swift black eagle swoops to catch his prey—  
the strongest and the swiftest of all birds—  
like this, Achilles darted back, his armor  
clashing and clattering around his body.

He fled, bent down beneath the rushing river,  
flooding behind him with a mighty roar.

As when, to make an irrigation channel  
by guiding water from a deep, dark spring  
onto his plants and trees, a worker uses  
a mattock to remove the obstacles—

260 the water gushes forth and all the pebbles  
are swept away, and gurgling as it goes  
the stream flows down the slope, soon overtaking  
the man who made it—so the flooding river  
kept catching up, however fast he ran.

320

330

340

350

Gods are superior to human beings.  
And every time Achilles tried to stand  
and face the river and find out if all  
the deathless gods were forcing him to flee,  
including the inhabitants of heaven,  
a billowing deluge of the Zeus-fed river  
battered against his shoulders from above.

Over and over, he jumped up again  
onto his feet, frustrated in his heart.

360

270 Cascading under him, the surging river  
wore out his body and defeated him,  
nibbling the dust away beneath his feet.  
Achilles, son of Peleus, looked up  
towards the spreading sky and groaned aloud.

“Pity me, father Zeus! See how no god  
is willing to defend me from the river!  
After this, anything is bearable.

And yet I blame no other god in heaven  
as much as my own mother, who deceived me,  
bewitching me with her delightful lies.

370

She promised I would die beneath the walls  
of Troy, surrounded by the well-armed Trojans,  
struck by the agile arrows of Apollo.

If only I could die at Hector’s hands!

He is the finest fighter born at Troy.

280 The killer and the killed would both be heroes.

But as things are, it is my lot to die  
a terrible, humiliating death

trapped in a river, like a swineherd boy  
trying to cross the water in a storm.

380

The mighty torrent washes him away.”

As soon as he had finished saying this,  
Poseidon and Athena stood beside him,  
looking like men. They took him by the hand  
and reassured him with their words. Poseidon  
spoke first.

“Achilles, son of Peleus,  
you need not be afraid. Do not draw back.  
With the approval of great Zeus, we two—  
290 Pallas Athena and myself, both gods— 390  
are here to help you. It is not ordained  
that you should be defeated by a river.  
Soon he will quit, as you yourself will see.  
We have some good advice for you, so listen.  
Your hands must not stop grappling in battle  
until you have confined the Trojan troops  
behind the famous city walls of Troy—  
at least the ones who still survive. And then  
take Hector’s life and go back to the ships.  
We grant you the ability to win 400  
this glorious success.”

And with these words,  
the two rejoined the other deathless gods.  
Greatly encouraged by the gods’ advice,  
300 he dashed towards the plain, which was all flooded.  
Many fine weapons floated on the water  
from those who had been killed, and many corpses.  
Leaping up high, Achilles pushed against  
the surging river, whose wide streams could not  
restrain him any longer, now Athena  
was giving him such energy and strength. 410  
But still Scamander did not cease his fury.  
The river god grew even more enraged  
against Achilles, son of Peleus.  
Raising his crested wave up high, he called  
Simoeis,

“My dear brother, we must join  
together to ward off this man’s attack!  
He is so strong, it will take both of us,  
or he will soon sack Priam’s mighty city.  
310 The Trojans cannot block him in the battle.  
So hurry, brother, help me, fill your streams 420  
with water from your springs. Rouse all your currents.

Stir up a mighty wave, like a tsunami.  
Raise up the stones and rocks and make them roar.  
Together, we shall stop this fearsome man  
who is so powerful for now, whose rage  
is godlike. I believe he will not profit  
from his good looks, his strength, or his fine armor,  
which very soon will lie beneath our water,  
right at the bottom, covered by the mud,  
so that the Greeks will never find his bones,  
when I have covered him with heaps of silt.  
And I shall wrap the sand around him, pouring  
numberless shingles, rocks, and stones upon him,  
so that he will not need a burial mound  
when the Greeks hold his funeral.”

430

With this,  
he surged towards Achilles, swelling, swirling,  
twisting up high, and roaring as he seethed  
with foam and blood and corpses. And the wave  
of glinting water from the Zeus-fed river  
hovered above Achilles, set to seize him—  
but Hera screamed in terror. She was frightened  
that the great river with its eddying depths  
would wash the man away. At once she called  
her loving son Hephaestus, and addressed him.

440

“Get up, my little twisty-foot, my son!  
We thought you were the one to challenge Xanthus,  
the eddying river. Hurry, save Achilles,  
flash with a massive blast of blazing flame!  
And meanwhile, I shall hasten to arouse  
a violent wind from out at sea, a gust  
of Notus, who can clear the sky, and Zephyr,  
to burn the Trojan corpses and their weapons  
by driving the destructive blaze towards them.  
Burn up the trees along the banks of Xanthus  
and set the god himself on fire. Do not  
let him discourage you or turn you back  
with threats or gentle coaxing. Do not stop

450

340 your furious attack until I call,  
and then you have to cease your tireless burning.”

Hephaestus readied the immortal blaze, 460  
and first he set the plain alight, then burned  
the multitude of corpses in the river,  
the victims of Achilles, and the plain  
grew parched. The shimmering water was held back—  
just as at harvest time, when Boreas,  
the north wind, suddenly appears and dries  
the freshly watered garden, and the worker  
who rakes the beds is happy—so the plain  
was all dried up, and all the corpses burned.

Hephaestus turned his bright blaze to the river, 470  
and all the trees and plants were soon on fire—  
350 tamarisks, willows, elm trees, celandine,  
rushes and galingale, which grew along  
the lovely riverbanks—all burning up.  
The eels and fish beneath the swirling depths  
suffered and somersaulted here and there,  
because the blast of wily Lord Hephaestus  
was causing them such suffering and pain.  
Even the mighty river burned, and spoke.

“No god can ever rival you, Hephaestus, 480  
and even I refuse to fight you now,  
when you are blazing hot with fire like this.  
So stop this conflict. Let Achilles drive  
the Trojans from their city right away.  
360 Why should I help or hinder anyone?”

He spoke through flames, his lovely streams ablaze.  
As when a cauldron on a blazing fire  
boils as it melts a plump pig’s fat, and bubbles  
all over, resting on the dry firewood—  
so his fine streams were blazing with the fire, 490  
his water boiling. He could not flow forward,  
blocked by the painful blast of wise Hephaestus.

So he appealed to Hera with winged words.

“Why does your son attack my river, Hera,  
and hurt me more than any other god?  
370 Yet I did nothing wrong! The other gods  
who help the Trojans should be blamed, not me.  
But I will stop, if you command me to,  
if he will also stop. And I shall swear  
a mighty oath as well, that I will never  
protect the Trojans from their day of doom,  
not even when the whole of Troy is burning  
with deadly fire, lit by the sons of Greece.”

500

The white-armed goddess Hera heard his words.  
Immediately she told her loving son,

“Hephaestus, my magnificent son, stop.  
It is not proper for one deathless god  
380 to tussle with another, for mere mortals.”

At this, Hephaestus quenched his holy fire.  
The waves coursed back along their lovely streams.  
The rage of Xanthus was subdued, and so  
both gods stopped fighting in response to Hera,  
who held them back despite her furious anger.  
But then a violent, momentous conflict  
fell on the other gods and goddesses,  
whose spirits blew in opposite directions.  
Thunderously they clashed. The wide earth rumbled,  
the mighty heavens trumpeted around them.  
Zeus, who was sitting on Olympus, heard them.  
390 He laughed with joy to see the gods start fighting.  
They did not stay apart for long. Great Ares,  
the god who pierces leather shields, began  
by rushing at Athena with his spear.  
He spoke abusively to her.

510

520

“ Dog-fly!

Why are you making the gods fight again?  
Are you so very reckless, so inspired  
by fury? Do you not remember when  
you set the son of Tydeus to wound me,  
and you yourself, in front of everyone,  
took up his spear and guided it at me?  
It bit my handsome flesh! Now I believe  
that you will pay for all your wicked deeds.”

530

400 With this, he struck her on the tasseled aegis,  
a terrifying object that withstands  
even the thunderbolts of Zeus. And yet  
the long spear of the bloodstained god of war  
struck it. Athena started back, but grasped  
a big black jagged rock in her strong hand.  
It had been lying on the plain, set there  
by men of old, as a boundary for a field.  
She hurled it at impetuous Ares, striking  
his neck, and he collapsed. The fallen god  
extended over seven thousand feet.  
His hair was sullied by the dust, his weapons  
rattled around him as he crashed to earth.  
Pallas Athena laughed. Triumphant  
she let her words fly forth to him.

540

“You fool!

410 You did not realize, not even now,  
how far superior I am to you!  
You thought that you could fight me as an equal!  
You will be punished by your mother’s Furies.  
Hera is furious, and she is plotting  
to do you harm because you have abandoned  
the Greeks, and now you help the arrogant Trojans.”

550

With this, she turned her shining eyes away.  
But Aphrodite took him by the hand,  
and tried to lead him off, still semiconscious  
and groaning heavily. When white-armed Hera



noticed, she told Athena right away  
with words that flew on wings.

“This is appalling!

560

420 Untiring child of Zeus who bears the goatskin,  
look! She is doing it again, that dog-fly,  
leading the ruin of humanity,  
Ares, from deadly battle through the throng.  
Go after her!”

At this, Athena's heart  
was glad. She hurried after and attacked her,  
and with her strong fist, punched her in the chest,  
and Aphrodite's limbs and heart collapsed.  
She lay with Ares on the fertile earth.  
Athena gloated over both of them  
and spoke with words on wings.

570

“May all the helpers  
of Trojans, when they fight with well-armed Greeks,  
be just as unsuccessful as these two.  
May they be just as full of confidence and daring  
as Aphrodite, when she came to help  
Ares, and had to face my might and fury!  
If all of them had been as weak as this,  
we could have stopped the conflict long ago,  
and sacked the well-built town of Troy.”

At this,  
the white-armed goddess Hera smiled. But then  
Poseidon, god of earthquakes, asked Apollo,

580

“Phoebus, why are we standing back? It is improper when the others have begun. It will be even more embarrassing if we have not done any kind of fighting when we go back again to Mount Olympus into the house of Zeus, all paved in bronze.

440 Begin! You are the younger. It is wrong  
for me to start, because I was born first  
and I know more than you. You little fool!  
You seem to have no wits or brains at all.  
Have you forgotten everything we two  
suffered at Troy—just us, no other gods—  
when we were sent by Zeus to come and labor  
for proud Laomedon for one whole year  
to earn a specified amount as pay?  
That man bossed us around and threatened us!  
I built a wall around the town of Troy,  
thick and magnificent, to make the city  
impregnable, while Phoebus, you were herding  
the shambling cattle with long curly horns  
among the foothills, glens, and woods of Ida.  
450 But when the hours grew old and brought the time  
of payment, then that brute Laomedon  
cheated us of our wages and dismissed us!  
He threatened to chain up our hands and feet  
and sell us to the islands far away.  
He lunged towards us both with his bronze blade  
to slice our ears off, so we ran away,  
with angry spirits, tricked out of our wages,  
which he had promised us but had not paid.  
Now you are giving help to that man's people!  
And you refuse to join us in our effort  
to utterly destroy the haughty Trojans,  
460 the men, the children, and the lawful wives.”

Apollo, god of distances, replied,  
“Poseidon, lord of earthquakes, you would think me  
lacking in self-restraint if I made war  
with you because of feeble, wretched mortals.  
Like leaves, they flourish for a little while,  
flaming with life and eating crops from fields,  
but soon they fade and shrivel up and die.  
So let us stop our quarrel right away,  
and let the mortals fight among themselves.”

470 With this, he turned away. He was ashamed  
to wrestle with his uncle. But his sister,  
the goddess of the wild, the queen of creatures,  
Artemis, scolded and berated him.

“So you absent yourself, great lord of distance.  
You let Poseidon claim complete success,  
by giving him an easy, futile win.  
You fool! Why do you even have a bow?  
It is completely pointless, never used!  
I will no longer listen to you boast  
among the deathless gods in Father’s halls  
that you will fight Poseidon face to face.”

630

480 The distant god Apollo did not answer.  
But angrily, the noble wife of Zeus  
reproached the goddess who delights in arrows  
with bitter reprimands.

“You fearless dog!  
How can you try to stand against me now?  
I will be difficult for you to challenge,  
despite your skill in archery. Zeus made you  
a lion among women, and he lets you  
kill any girl you like. It would be better  
for you to slaughter deer and mountain creatures  
than try to fight with your superiors.  
But if you want to learn the truth of war,  
when you have challenged me, you will soon see  
how much superior I am to you.”

640

490 Then with her left hand Hera seized the wrists  
of Artemis, and with her right pulled off  
her victim’s bow and quiver from her back,  
and smiling as she did so, used these weapons  
to box her ears—while Artemis kept trying  
to turn away. Her arrows clattered down.  
At last she ran away from her, in tears—

650

just like a dove escaping from a hawk  
into a hollow crevice in a rock,  
when she has not been destined to be seized—  
so Artemis, in floods of tears, escaped  
and left her bow and arrows there. The guide,  
the giant-slayer, Hermes, said to Leto,

660

500 “Leto, I shall not fight you. It is hard  
to bandy blows with wives of Zeus, the god  
who gathers clouds together. Off you go,  
and make loud boasts among the deathless gods  
that you have conquered me by strength and force.”

So Leto gathered up her daughter’s weapons—  
the curving bow and arrows that were scattered  
across the ground amid the whirling dust—  
and went to find her. Artemis had gone  
to Mount Olympus, to the home of Zeus,  
all paved in bronze. The weeping girl was sitting  
upon her father’s lap, and all around her  
her deathless dress was quivering. Her father,  
the son of Cronus, hugged her with a chuckle  
and asked her,

670

510 “Which of the Olympians  
has done these things to you, my darling child?  
It is outrageous to have treated you  
as if you had been doing something wrong  
in public!”

680

And the goddess of the hunt,  
whose cries are loud, whose crown is lovely, answered,  
“Your wife has hit me, Father! White-armed Hera,  
who caused the deathless gods to fight and quarrel!”

This was their conversation, and meanwhile,  
Apollo entered holy Troy, concerned  
about the wall around the well-built town,

if on that very day, before due time,  
the Greeks sacked Troy. And all the other gods

690

520 some angry, some triumphant. But Achilles  
continued in his slaughter of the Trojans,  
killing the people and their strong-hoofed horses.

As when smoke rises to the open sky  
up from a burning city set on fire  
by wrathful gods, which causes suffering  
and pain to all the people in the town,  
just so, Achilles made the Trojans suffer.

Old Priam stood upon the god-built wall  
and looked at the enormity—Achilles.

700

The Trojans fled before him and there was  
no help for them. He groaned in grief and climbed  
down from the wall and called the fine gatekeepers  
530 from all along the wall and ordered them,

“Open the gates up wide and hold them open  
until the fighters get inside the city.

Look at Achilles! He is almost here,  
driving our warriors in flight before him.

I think a massacre is imminent.

710

But when they can relax inside the wall,  
shut tight the closely fitted double doors.

I am afraid that deadly man may leap  
inside the city past the wall.”

At this,

they thrust the bolts aside and spread apart  
the gates, which opened wide and brought salvation.

540 Apollo leapt in front to save the Trojans  
from ruin. And they fled inside the city,  
beyond the high wall. They were parched with thirst  
and dusty from the plain. Achilles chased them,  
hard on their heels and lunging with his spear.

720

Obsessive, crazy fury gripped his heart.  
He yearned to win the victory, and the Greeks  
would then have seized the high-walled town of Troy,

had not Apollo roused up brave Agenor,  
Antenor's noble, valiant son. The god  
put courage in his heart and stood beside him,  
leaning against the fig tree, to protect him  
from the oppressive goddesses of death.

Thick fog was wrapped around the god. But when

730

550

Agenor saw Achilles, city-sacker,  
he stopped and pondered in his churning mind,  
and deeply troubled, asked his own brave heart,

“What ever will become of me? If I  
take flight and run away from strong Achilles,  
the same direction that the others fled,  
I will be killed, and I will die a coward.

He will still catch and butcher me. What if  
I let Achilles, son of Peleus,

pursue the others, and with my swift feet  
run off the other way and leave the wall—

740

sprinting towards the plain until I reach  
the lower slopes of Ida, and hide there  
beneath the bushes? And when evening comes,  
then I can wash my sweat off in the river,  
and then at last go home again to Troy?

560

But why am I imagining all this?

What if he sees me scuttling from the city  
towards the plain and dashes after me

on his swift feet and catches me? And then  
there will be no escaping death and doom.

750

He is the strongest man alive by far.

What if I go in front of Troy and face him?

The man has flesh that can be pierced by bronze.

He only has one life and he is mortal—

570

so people say, though Zeus is giving him  
such great success.”

With these words, he crouched down  
and waited for Achilles. His brave heart  
felt stirred to fight. As when a leopard moves  
out of the undergrowth to face the hunter,

760

and feels no fear or trembling in her heart,  
even when she can hear the baying hounds,  
and even if the hunter gets in front  
and thrusts or hurls his spear at her—she struggles  
and will not stop and still retains her courage,  
till she can pounce on him or else be killed—  
just so, Antenor's noble son, Agenor,  
580 refused to flee before he tried to fight  
Achilles, and held up his balanced shield  
and aimed his spear, and shouted,

“Great Achilles!

770

You thought, I do believe, you would destroy  
the mighty town of Troy this very day.  
You fool! There will be much more pain inflicted  
for Troy. We men are numerous and brave,  
and ready to defend the town and save  
our loving parents, wives, and sons. But you  
will meet your destiny right here, although  
you are so violent and bold a fighter.”

590 With this, he flexed his sturdy hand and hurled  
his sharp spear, and it did not miss. It struck  
Achilles on the shin, below the knee.  
The shin-guard made of new-forged tin resounded—  
a dreadful sound. The bronze bounced off again,  
stopped by the armor that the god had given.  
And then Achilles, son of Peleus,  
attacked godlike Agenor—but Apollo  
did not allow him to gain any glory.  
He whisked Agenor off, veiled him in mist,  
and sent him peacefully away from battle.  
Apollo, god of distances, used tricks  
to keep Achilles distant from the Trojans.  
600 The god himself in all respects resembled  
Agenor, and stood right before Achilles,  
who ran to catch him, and while he was dashing  
across the plain and through the fields of grain,  
turning beside the eddying deep Scamander,

780

790

the god kept just a little way ahead.

Apollo was beguiling him with tricks,  
to make him always think he could catch up.

Meanwhile, the other Trojans fled and crowded  
inside the city walls, with great relief.

The town was full of people shut inside.

They could no longer wait outside the wall  
to see who might escape and who was dead.

610 All those whose feet and hands still had the strength  
hurried inside the town to save themselves.



## BOOK 22



# A Race to Death

So through the town the Trojans fled like fawns,  
and cooled their sweat and drank and slaked their thirst  
and paused to rest against the barricades.  
The Greeks drew nearer to the wall. They held  
their shields high on their shoulders, angled flat.  
But deadly fate bound Hector to remain  
outside the Scaean Gates in front of Troy.  
Phoebus Apollo spoke and asked Achilles,  
the son of Peleus,

“Why do you chase me  
on those quick feet, Achilles? You are mortal,  
and I am an immortal god. And yet  
you failed to recognize me, even now.

10

10

Relentlessly your fury presses on.  
You do not seem to care about the Trojans  
after you worked so hard to drive them back  
and trapped them in their city. You swerved round  
and ran to me. But you will never kill me.  
I am not subject to mortality.”

In deep frustration, swift Achilles answered,  
“You tricked me when you turned me from the wall!  
You are the one who works from far away,  
most cruel and destructive of the gods.  
Numerous men would not have reached the town,  
but would have seized the earth between their teeth  
if you had not deprived me of success.  
You saved them easily. You had no fear  
of any retribution in the future.  
But I would surely take revenge on you,  
if only I had strength to fight a god.”

20

And with these words, Achilles hurried back  
towards the city, confident and eager.  
Just as a horse who has won many prizes  
lengthens his body in an easy gallop  
pulling his chariot across the plain,  
so nimbly and so fast Achilles ran.  
Old Priam was the first to notice him  
sprinting across the plain. He saw the gleam,  
just like the star that rises in late summer,  
whose beams shine bright amid the constellations  
at dead of night—the people call it Dog Star,  
Orion’s dog, which flashes dazzling light,  
an evil omen bringing many fevers  
to poor, unhappy mortals—so the bronze  
shone on Achilles’ breastplate as he sprinted.  
The old man groaned in grief and struck his head  
then raised both arms up high and wailed and shouted  
and begged his dear son to come home again.  
But he remained outside the city gates,  
fixed in his firm intent to fight Achilles.  
Priam reached out to him and spoke to him  
in anguish.

30

40

50

“Hector, my dear child, do not  
wait for that man out there alone, I beg you,  
or you will fall and quickly meet your end,  
you stubborn fool! The son of Peleus,

40 Achilles, has far greater strength than you.  
 I wish the gods loved him the way I do!  
 Then dogs and vultures would soon eat his corpse.  
 Then this despair would leave my mind and heart.  
 Achilles has already taken from me  
 many fine sons. He slaughtered some of them 60  
 and captured others, selling them as slaves  
 on distant islands. And among the Trojans  
 confined inside the town, I cannot see  
 two others— Polydorus and Lycaon,  
 born to me by Laothoe, a princess.  
 If they are still alive, if they are held  
 as captives in the enemy encampment,  
 I will pay bronze and gold to get them back.  
 50 I have rich stores, because their grandfather,  
 the famous old King Altes, gave his daughter 70  
 a lavish dowry when she came to me.  
 If they are dead already and in Hades,  
 grief will afflict their mother's heart and mine,  
 because we are their parents. But the people  
 of Troy will only grieve a little while—  
 unless Achilles kills you also, son.  
 Come back inside the wall and save the Trojans,  
 both men and women. Do not give such glory  
 to great Achilles, son of Peleus,  
 and rob yourself of your own precious life! 80  
 And pity me—a poor, unlucky man,  
 allotted so much pain. The father, Zeus,  
 will give me a humiliating death  
 60 when I am on the threshold of old age.  
 And I will witness many horrors—sons  
 slaughtered and daughters dragged away as slaves  
 and houses ransacked and the little children  
 hurled to the ground amid the massacre  
 and my sons' wives seized by the deadly hands  
 of Greeks. And finally, myself—when someone 90  
 has thrown or thrust a sharp bronze spear at me  
 and stripped the spirit from my limbs, the dogs  
 who watched my doors, who fed beneath my table,

will hunger for raw meat and rip me open  
and drink my blood in front of my own house,  
and lie there in the doorway of the palace,  
70 rabid and frenzied with the glut of gore.

A young man killed in battle by sharp bronze  
looks glorious in every way. His body  
is fine and handsome even in his death.

But when the dogs despoil a gray old head  
and gray old beard, and shame his private parts,  
this is the most heartrending sight of all  
for poor unhappy mortals.”

100

So spoke Priam,  
ripping his gray hair from his head. And yet  
his words did not persuade the heart of Hector.  
Near Priam on the wall stood Hector’s mother.  
80 She wept, untied her dress, and lifted out  
one breast, and through her tears spoke words on wings.

“Hector, my child, respect a mother’s care,  
and pity me. I soothed you with my breast.  
Remember this, dear child, and come inside!  
Fight your opponent from behind our wall.  
Do not stand there outside and challenge him,  
you stubborn fool! If he kills you, I cannot  
weep for you on your bier, my baby boy,  
the child I birthed myself—nor can your wife,  
for whom so many bridal-gifts were paid.  
Beside the Greek ships, far away from us,  
swift dogs will eat you up.”

110

So both his parents  
90 wept and called out to their beloved son  
and pleaded with him to come back inside.  
But they did not persuade the heart of Hector.  
He waited for Achilles, who came nearer,  
massive and monstrous—as a mountain snake  
who has devoured poison and is seized

120

by bitter rage, and lurks inside his lair,  
coiled and entwined around himself, and waits,  
watching with deadly eyes to catch a man—  
so Hector waited, with undying fury.  
Keeping his shining shield propped up against  
a jutting bulwark of the wall, he stood—  
and anxiously addressed his own brave heart.

130

100 “This is impossible! If I go back  
inside the gates, behind the city wall,  
Polydamas will be the first to heap  
shame on my head. He told me I should lead  
the Trojans back to Troy that fatal night,  
when glorious Achilles had arisen.  
It would have been far better if I had,  
but I refused. And now I have destroyed  
my people by my recklessness and folly,  
and so I am ashamed to face the Trojans,  
both men and women in their trailing dresses,  
in case some man of lower rank than me  
says, ‘Hector trusted his own strength too much,  
and so destroyed his troops.’ They will say this.  
So it would be far better for me now  
to meet Achilles face to face and kill him  
before I go back home again, or else  
110 to die with glory, in defense of Troy.  
Or what if I set down my studded shield  
and sturdy helmet, and prop up my spear  
against the wall, and go unarmed, alone,  
to face Achilles? What if I could swear  
to give back Helen and the treasure with her,  
everything Paris took in hollow ships  
to Troy—the origin of this whole war?  
What if I promise we will give all this  
back to the sons of Atreus, and also  
120 provide more wealth for all the Greeks to share—  
everything that our citadel contains?  
What if I make the Trojans swear an oath  
not to hide anything, but offer all

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the wealth inside our lovely town to them?  
But no! Why did my mind suggest these things?  
I cannot face him as a suppliant.  
He will not pity me or show respect.  
He will kill me unarmed, just like a woman,  
if I set down my weapons on the ground.  
I think there is no way, from oak or rock,  
to chat with him as girl and boy might do,  
a girl and boy who chat and flirt together.  
Better to start the conflict right away,  
and we will soon see which of us is granted  
success by the Olympian, Lord Zeus.”

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With these thoughts, Hector stayed in place. Achilles  
drew near, like Ares Enyalios,  
the god of war, who wears a shining helmet.  
Achilles brandished over his right shoulder  
his terrifying spear of Pelian ash.  
The bronze around his body shone like lightning,  
or like a blazing fire, or setting sun.  
When Hector saw him, he began to tremble.  
He did not dare stay there. He left the gates  
and ran away. Achilles sprinted after,  
confident of his own quick feet. As when  
a hawk, the fastest bird upon the mountains,  
swoops easily to catch a trembling dove—  
she flutters underneath him to escape,  
but he stays close behind and keeps on lunging  
towards her with sharp shrieks, intent to seize her—  
so eagerly Achilles flew towards him,  
and Hector trembled underneath the wall  
of Troy and moved his legs at topmost speed.  
They dashed beneath the shadow of the wall,  
and kept along the wagon track, and passed  
the lookout area, the windswept fig tree,  
and reached the pair of beautiful clear springs,  
the sources of the eddying Scamander.  
Warm water flows from one of them, and steam  
arises from it as from burning fire.

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The other freezes even in the summer,  
and flows like hail, like frigid snow, like ice.  
Near them are two fine washing-pools of stone,  
where Trojan wives and pretty Trojan daughters  
laundered the shining clothes in former times,  
in peace, before the sons of Greece arrived.  
Past these they ran, in flight and in pursuit.  
In front, a fine man fled, but at his back  
a far superior athlete ran to catch him.  
Swiftly they sped because their competition  
was not to win a sacrificial bull  
or oxhide, normal prizes for footraces.  
Their race was for the life of horse-lord Hector.  
As when two champion horses on firm hooves  
gallop apace around the turning points—  
the prize laid out in honor of a dead man  
is valuable, a tripod or a woman—  
so those two whirled around the town of Priam  
on quick feet, and the gods all watched the race.  
The father of the gods and men spoke first,  
and said to them,

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“Look at this dreadful scene!  
I see a man I love chased round the wall.  
I pity Hector in my heart. He burned  
numerous cattle thighs as offerings  
to me upon the peaks and glens of Ida,  
and also in the citadel of Troy.  
Now glorious Achilles chases him  
on quick feet all around the town of Priam.  
So come now, gods, consider and decide  
whether to save this man from death, or crush him,  
a fine man though he is, beneath the hands  
of great Achilles, son of Peleus.”

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Athena, gray-eyed goddess, answered him,  
“God of the brilliant lightning and dark clouds,  
father, what have you said? This man is mortal!  
He has long since been doomed by fate to die.

And yet you want to set him free from death,  
 whose name is pain? Then go ahead and do it!  
 But none of us will praise what you have done.”

Then Zeus who gathers clouds together answered,  
 “Dear daughter, child of Triton, do not worry.  
 I did not mean it when I said those things.  
 I want to treat you kindly. So go on,  
 do as your heart desires. Stop holding back.”

With this, he urged Athena, who had been  
 eager to go already, and she hurtled  
 down from the mountain peaks of high Olympus.

Achilles with relentless speed pursued  
 Hector—as when a dog pursues a fawn,  
 and drives her from her mother’s lair and hunts her  
 across the hillside, through the glades and valleys,  
 and even if she crouches in the bushes  
 to hide, he runs and tracks her, till he gets her—  
 so Hector could not hide from swift Achilles,  
 the son of Peleus. Each time he tried  
 to dash towards the Dardan gates and seek  
 protection underneath the well-built walls,  
 hoping the Trojans on the top might save him  
 by hurling weapons at his enemy,  
 each time, Achilles got ahead of him,  
 and forced him to turn back towards the plain.

As in a dream, the chase goes on forever—  
 you never catch, you never get away—  
 so ran Achilles, always just behind,  
 feet pounding but unable to catch up,  
 and Hector was unable to escape.

But how could Hector ever have evaded  
 impending death, unless he had encountered  
 Apollo, for the last and final time?

The god approached and gave him strength and speed.  
 Meanwhile, godlike Achilles shook his head,  
 to tell the Greek troops not to shoot at Hector  
 with deadly spears, so no one else would get



the glory of a strike and make him second.  
But when they reached the springs the fourth time round,  
then Zeus, the father, held his golden scales  
up high and in them set two deadly weights,  
210 two dooms of death that stretches suffering— 280  
one for Achilles, one for horse-lord Hector.  
The god raised up the middle of the scales,  
and down the destined day of Hector sank  
and went to Hades. And Apollo left him.  
Athena, bright-eyed goddess, came and stood  
beside Achilles, son of Peleus,  
and spoke to him with words on wings.

“At last,  
splendid Achilles, favorite of Zeus,  
I trust the two of us will bring great glory  
back to the ships—an honor for the Greeks. 290  
The two of us will slaughter Hector now,  
although he is insatiable for battle.  
He can no longer run away from us,  
220 not even if aloof Apollo grovels  
before our father Zeus, who wears the goatskin.  
Stop there and catch your breath, and I will go  
persuade that man to fight you face to face.”

So spoke Athena, and Achilles listened,  
delighted in his heart. He stopped and leaned  
against his bronze-tipped spear of ash. She left him, 300  
took on the body and the tireless voice  
of great Deiphobus, and went to Hector,  
and stood beside him and spoke words on wings.

“Dear brother, you are certainly hard-pressed  
by swift Achilles. He is chasing you  
230 on such quick feet around the town of Priam.  
But come on, let us stand together here  
and wait for him and ward him off together.”

And mighty Hector in his flashing helmet  
replied, "Deiphobus, you always were  
the brother that I loved the most by far,  
of all the sons of Hecuba and Priam.  
But now your worth to me is even higher,  
because you dared to come outside the wall  
when you saw me out here, although the others  
are still inside."

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And then the bright-eyed goddess,  
Athena, spoke to him a second time.  
"Dear brother, certainly our parents begged me  
to stay. Our noble mother and our father  
took turns imploring me, as did our comrades.  
All of them were so terribly afraid.  
But my heart deep inside me was afflicted  
by terrible anxiety for you.  
So let us rush to battle, spare no spear,  
and find out if Achilles will destroy us,  
and strip our bloodstained armor and our weapons  
and take them to the hollow ships with him,  
or if your spear may conquer him."

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Athena  
said this and guided him with clever tricks.  
When the two enemies were near each other,  
great Hector in his flashing helmet spoke.

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"I shall no longer run from you, Achilles,  
in fear, as I have done three times already,  
around the great and splendid town of Priam.  
I did not dare stand still and wait for you.  
But now my spirit urges me to stand  
and face you. I may kill you or be killed.  
Let us invoke the gods. They are the best  
as witnesses and guardians of contracts.  
I shall not mutilate you or disgrace you,  
if Zeus grants me the stamina to take

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your life away, Achilles. I will strip  
your famous armor, but I will give back  
your body to the Greeks. You do the same.”

260 Swift-footed Lord Achilles scowled at him  
and answered, “Hector, do not speak to me  
of contracts. Fool, forget about agreements.  
Lions do not swear solemn oaths with humans,  
and wolves and lambs do not share common feelings.  
Their enmity endures forevermore.

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Just so, there is no way for you and me  
ever to love each other or be friends,  
and there can be no oaths between us two,  
till one man falls and slakes the thirst of Ares,  
the warrior, the god who bears the shield.  
Remember all your skill and all your courage.  
Now is the time for bravery in battle.  
Now you must be a warrior, a fighter.

Now all your chances to escape are gone.  
270 Pallas Athena, through this spear of mine,  
will soon destroy you. In a single instant  
you will soon pay me back for all my pain,  
my grief for my companions, whom you killed  
when you were running riot with your spear.”

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With this, he aimed his great long-shadowed spear  
and hurled it. Glorious Hector stayed alert,  
eyes straight ahead, and saw the bronze spear coming,  
and ducked—the weapon flew above his head  
and was embedded in the earth. Athena  
grabbed it and gave it back to great Achilles.  
Hector, the people’s shepherd, did not notice.  
Then Hector spoke to marvelous Achilles.

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280 “You missed, godlike Achilles! You knew nothing  
from Zeus about my destiny or death,  
although you thought you knew it all. You were  
just speechifying, fitting words together,

and all this cleverness was meant to scare me,  
so I would lose my courage and my strength.  
I will not turn and run away from you.  
You will not fix your weapon in my back.  
Drive it straight through my chest as I attack you,  
if some god grants the victory to you.  
Now try to get away from my bronze spear!  
I hope you offer it a gentle welcome  
and let its whole length rest inside your flesh.  
The war will lie more lightly on the Trojans  
after your death. You were our greatest curse.”

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290 With this, he aimed his great long-shadowed spear  
and hurled it, and it did not miss. It struck  
the middle of Achilles’ shield, then bounced  
and fell far back from it. And Hector, angry  
that his swift spear had left his hand in vain,  
stood there dispirited because he had  
no other ash-wood spear. He raised his voice  
and called and shouted to Deiphobus,  
the warrior whose shield was white, and asked him  
for his long spear. But he was nowhere near.  
Then Hector understood inside his heart,  
and said,

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300 “The gods have called me to my death.  
I thought Deiphobus was at my side.  
But he is on the wall. Athena tricked me.  
The horror of my death is near me now,  
not far away, and there is no way out.  
Zeus and the son of Zeus, the distant archer,  
must have decided all this long ago—  
the gods who used to be so kind to me,  
who helped me in the past. And now my doom  
has come at last. But never let me die  
without a struggle and without acclaim.  
Let me achieve some greatness and be known  
to people in the days to come.”

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With this,  
he drew the sharp sword fastened at his hip,  
a big, strong blade, and gathered all his strength,  
and swooped—just like an eagle, who soars high  
then plummets through the dark clouds down to earth,  
310 to snatch a tender lamb or cowering hare—  
so Hector brandished his sharp sword and swooped.  
Achilles rushed towards him, spirit full  
of fearsome eagerness to kill. He held  
his finely fashioned shield to hide his chest, 420  
and shook his head, so that his shining helmet  
bobbed and its four horns swayed, and all around it,  
the fine gold horsehair plumes, set by Hephaestus  
thickly along the crest, were all aquiver.  
Just as at dead of night among the stars  
the Evening Star shines bright, most beautiful  
of all the constellations in the sky—  
so shone the bright point of Achilles' spear.  
320 He held this weapon in his right hand, hoping  
to strike great Hector, and he scrutinized 430  
his handsome flesh to see which area  
was easiest to pierce. The fine bronze armor,  
taken when he had killed Patroclus, covered  
most of his body, but his skin was bare  
just where the neck and shoulders are divided—  
the latches of the collarbone—the throat.  
There lies the fastest way to death. As Hector  
lunged forward, fine Achilles drove his spear  
right there. The point pierced through his supple neck.  
And yet the ash-wood spear of heavy bronze 440  
did not cut through his windpipe, so he had  
the power to speak in answer to his killer.  
330 He fell down on the dust, and great Achilles  
gloated above him.

“Hector, I suppose  
after you killed Patroclus, you imagined  
that you were safe. You paid no heed to me,  
because you knew that I was far away.

Fool! I am still his helper and avenger,  
stronger than him by far, although he left me  
beside the hollow ships. I am the one  
who caused your death and made your limbs unravel.  
The dogs and birds will mutilate and shame you.  
Patroclus will be buried by the Greeks  
with all due funeral honors.”

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Faint and feeble,  
Hector, his helmet flashing bright, replied,  
“I beg you, by your life, your knees, your parents,  
do not let dogs devour me by your ships.  
Accept the bronze and gold, the lavish gifts  
my noble parents will provide you with,  
and give my body back. Let me go home,  
so that the Trojan men and Trojan wives  
grant me my due in death—a funeral pyre.”

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Swift-footed Lord Achilles scowled and said,  
“Dog, do not beg or speak of knees or parents.  
If only I had will and heart to do it  
I would carve up your flesh and eat it raw,  
for the abominations you have done me.  
No one can save your body from the dogs,  
not even if they bring me as a ransom  
ten times or twenty times the usual rate  
and weigh it out and promise even more.  
Not even if Dardanian Priam promised  
to have you weighed and give your weight in gold.  
Not even so will your own mother ever  
lay you out properly upon a bier,  
and mourn and grieve for you, the child she birthed.  
The dogs and birds will eat you up completely.”

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Then Hector in his flashing helmet, dying,  
answered, “I see you and I understand you.  
There is no way for me to change your mind.  
The heart inside your chest is made of iron.

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Be careful now. I may become the cause  
of wrath against you from the gods, one day,  
when Paris and Apollo will destroy you  
360 beside the Scaean Gates, despite your strength.”

His death wrapped round him as he spoke. His spirit  
flew from his limbs to Hades, and she mourned  
his fate, and left his manhood and his youth.  
Achilles spoke to him though he was dead—

“So die! And I will welcome my own death  
whenever Zeus and other deathless gods  
decide to end my life.” 490

With this, he pulled  
the bronze spear from the corpse, set it aside,  
and stripped the bloody armor from his body.  
The other sons of Greece ran up, stood round him,  
370 and marveled at the size and handsomeness  
of Hector. As they stood there, each of them  
stabbed him and told each other, “Look at this!  
Hector is so much softer to the touch  
than when he burned our ships with blazing fire.” 500

They said this as they stood around and stabbed him.  
After swift-footed glorious Achilles  
had stripped the arms of Hector, he stood tall  
among the Greeks and spoke winged words to them.

“My friends, Greek lords and councillors, the gods  
have granted me the chance to kill this man,  
380 who caused more harm than all the rest of them.  
Let us surround the city, fully armed,  
to learn about the Trojans’ state of mind.  
How are they feeling now? Will they abandon  
their citadel, now that this man is fallen?  
Or are they eager to remain and fight,  
even though Hector is no longer with them? 510

But why am I considering all this?  
He still lies there beside the ships, a corpse,  
unwept, unburied. I will not forget  
Patroclus, never, while my body moves,  
while I am still among those still alive,  
and even if the dead forget each other  
in Hades, even there I will remember  
my friend, the man I love. But, warriors,  
come on, let us sing loud the victory song,  
and carry this man to the hollow ships.  
We have achieved great glory. We have killed  
Hector, whom Trojans honored as a god.”

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So spoke Achilles, and then he committed  
shameful atrocities on noble Hector.  
He pierced the tendons behind both his feet  
from heel to ankle, threaded leather straps,  
and bound them to his chariot, and let  
the head loll backward as he drove. He mounted,  
bringing the famous armor. With the whip,  
he made the horses go. With no reluctance  
they flew. A cloud of dust rose up round Hector  
as he was dragged along, his dark hair flowing,  
with his whole face, which used to be so handsome,  
down in the dust. On that day, Zeus allowed  
his enemies to mutilate and shame him  
in his own fatherland. So Hector’s head  
was caked with dust all over. Then his mother  
flung off her shining headdress, ripped her hair,  
and keened in anguish when she saw her son.  
His father gave an agonizing groan.  
Around them, all the people in the city  
began to keen and groan. It was as if  
the whole of dark-browed Troy was set ablaze  
up to its highest peak. The people scarcely  
restrained old Priam in his eagerness  
to rush outside through the Dardanian Gates.  
He rolled around in dung and begged them all,  
calling each man by name,

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“Let me go, friends.

Let me go out of Troy to the Greek fleet,  
and supplicate this wicked, violent man.  
He may perhaps feel shame or even pity  
420 for my old age. He also has a father,  
Peleus, who is old and weak like me,  
who fathered and brought up this son of his  
to be the ruination of the Trojans,  
and most of all, of me. He has inflicted  
such pain, such loss on me. He killed so many  
fine, healthy, handsome sons of mine.  
I weep and mourn for all of them, but none  
as bitterly as this one. My sharp grief  
for him will lead me to the house of Hades.  
I wish my son had died in my own arms!  
His poor, unhappy mother and myself  
could then have slaked our thirst for tears and grief,  
crying together for the son she birthed.”

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He spoke through tears. The people of the city  
moaned in response, and Hecuba began  
430 to lead the Trojan women in lament,  
and throbbing cries of pain.

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“My child, my child!  
How can I live with so much suffering?  
How can I live on, now that you are dead?  
You were my pride and joy throughout the city,  
a blessing to the Trojan men and women  
by day and night. They all looked up to you  
as to a god. You brought them so much glory  
while you were still alive. Now death and doom  
have overtaken you.”

She spoke through tears.  
The wife of Hector so far still knew nothing.  
No messenger had come to bring the news  
that he had stayed outside beyond the gates.

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440 Up in an inner chamber of the house  
she wove a double-layered purple cloth,  
and in it stitched elaborate designs.  
She called the house slaves with their braided hair  
to heat a mighty tripod on the fire,  
so that the washing water would be hot  
for Hector when he came back home from battle.  
Poor fool! She did not know that very far  
from any bath, he was already dead.  
Bright-eyed Athena, through Achilles' hands,  
had brought him down. Then from the wall she heard  
keening and groans of grief. Her body trembled.  
She dropped her shuttle to the ground, and called  
again to the women slaves with braided hair  
450 and told them,

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“Hurry, two of you come with me  
so I can see what happened. I just heard  
the voice of noble Hecuba. My heart  
is jumping through me to my mouth. My legs  
are paralyzed. Some trouble must be near  
the sons of Priam—let my ears not hear it!  
I have a dreadful fear that great Achilles  
has intercepted Hector by himself  
and driven him from the city to the plain,  
and robbed him of the ruinous rash courage  
that once possessed him, that caused so much pain.  
He never stayed among the mass of troops.  
He always hurtled far ahead, aggressive  
and giving way to no one.”

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460 So she spoke,  
and dashed all through the palace, like a maenad,  
with pounding heart. Her women slaves ran with her.  
She reached the wall and crowd of men, and stood  
high on the battlements to look for him.  
She saw him being dragged before the city,  
dragged to the hollow ships by running horses  
who took no care to tend him properly.

Then black night veiled her eyes. She toppled backward,  
and breathed her spirit out. She tossed away  
the shining knotted headdress from her head—  
the circlet, veil, well-braided band, and scarf  
470 that golden Aphrodite gave to her  
the day that Hector of the glittering helmet  
paid lavish bridal-gifts to lead her off  
in marriage from the house of Eetion.  
Andromache was stunned as if to death.  
The women of her husband's family  
clustered around and held her in their midst.  
When she had caught her breath and woken up,  
she raised her voice to sing in lamentation  
among the women and the girls of Troy.

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“Hector, my life is over. You and I  
were both born for this self-same destiny.  
You were born here in Troy in Priam's house,  
but I was raised in Thebe, underneath  
the forests of Mount Placus, and my father,  
480 Eetion, cared for me when I was little.  
His luck was bad and mine was ruination.  
If only he had never had a daughter!  
Now you have gone beneath the depths of earth  
into the house of Hades and you leave me  
in bitter grief, a widow in your halls.  
Our son is still a little baby, born  
to such unlucky parents—you and me.  
You will not help him now that you are dead,  
Hector, nor will he you. If he escapes  
this world of tears, this war against the Greeks,  
trouble and pain will be with him forever.  
Others will seize his lands. A father's death  
490 deprives a child of all companionship.  
In need he will approach his father's comrades,  
and tug one by the cloak or by the tunic.  
They will feel bad for him, and one may give him  
a tiny sip, enough to wet his lips  
but not his throat. A boy with living parents

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will drive the orphan from the feast, and use  
his fists to strike him and his tongue to curse—  
‘Get out! Your father does not dine with us!’

Back to his widowed mother comes the child,

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Astyanax, who once, in earlier times,  
sat on his father’s lap and only ate  
marrow and luscious mutton fat, and when  
he finished with his fun and games, and sleep  
seized him, he used to sleep on a soft bed,  
held in his nurse’s arms, with his heart full  
of happiness. But now he will endure  
terrible suffering without his father—  
the boy to whom the Trojans gave the title  
Astyanax, ‘the master of the city.’

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You were the only one who could protect  
the gates and towering walls of Troy for him.  
Far from your parents now, beside the ships,  
the writhing worms are nibbling you. The dogs  
will soon be gluttoned with your naked body.

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Naked—although at home you have so many  
beautiful, delicate clothes, the work of women.  
I will burn all of them on blazing fire.  
They are no good to you, you cannot wear them.  
But this will bring you glory from the people  
of Troy, both men and women.”

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So she spoke  
and wept. The other women wailed in answer.

## BOOK 23



# Funeral Games

The Trojans grieved throughout the town. The Greeks  
had reached the fleet beside the Hellespont,  
and most dispersed to their own ships. Achilles  
would not allow the Myrmidons to leave.  
He told his warlike comrades,

“Loyal friends,  
Myrmidons, masters of swift steeds, do not  
release the horses from the chariots yet.  
We must ride near Patroclus and lament.  
This is the prize of honor due the dead.  
When we are satisfied with tears and grief  
let us unyoke the horses and have dinner,  
all of us here together.”

So he spoke.  
They wailed together, guided by Achilles.  
Weeping and sorrowful, they led the horses  
three times around the body, and among them  
Thetis aroused desire to tell their sorrow.

Wet was the sand and wet their arms and armor  
with tears because they missed their friend so much,  
the router of their enemies. Among them  
Achilles, son of Peleus, began  
to lead the lamentation as he laid  
his murderous hands upon his comrade's heart.

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20 “Patroclus! Even in the house of Hades,  
greetings. Be well, my friend. I am already  
fulfilling all the things I swore to you.  
I promised to drag Hector here and give him  
to dogs to share among themselves as meat.  
I swore to take twelve lovely Trojan children  
and slit their throats above your funeral pyre,  
because I am so angry at your death.”

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With this, Achilles did degrading things  
to noble Hector—stretching him face-down  
upon the dust beside the funeral bier  
on which the son of Lord Menoetius lay.  
Each of the warriors removed his armor  
of shining bronze, unyoked the whinnying horses,  
and sat around the ship of swift Achilles,  
grandson of Aeacus. And he set out  
a funeral feast to feed the crowd of men.  
30 Many sleek cattle bellowed, struck by iron,  
and many sheep and bleating goats were slaughtered,  
and many fine fat pigs with silver tusks  
were singed and stretched across the burning flame  
of Lord Hephaestus. All around the corpse,  
blood flowed and was collected into cups.  
Meanwhile, the Greek commanders led the son  
of Peleus, swift-footed Lord Achilles,  
to noble Agamemnon. They had trouble  
persuading him to come, because he was  
so angry and so heartsick for his friend.  
And when they reached the hut of Agamemnon,  
they told the clear-voiced heralds to set out  
40 a mighty cauldron on the fire, to try

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persuading great Achilles to wash off  
the blood and gore. He steadfastly refused,  
and swore an oath.

“I swear I will not do it,  
by Zeus, the best and highest of the gods.  
It is not right for me to wash my head  
until I place Patroclus on his pyre  
and build a mound for him and cut my hair. 60  
No grief like this will ever touch my heart  
as long as I am still among the living.  
For now, we must endure this hateful feast.  
But in the morning, high King Agamemnon,  
order the men to gather wood and bring  
50 everything that a dead man ought to have  
to make the final journey to the shadows,  
so tireless fire may burn him up and take him  
out of our sight as quickly as may be,  
and then the troops can turn back to their work.” 70

He spoke. They listened and obeyed and promptly  
prepared the food and each man ate his share  
and nobody went hungry at the feast.  
When they had satisfied their thirst and hunger,  
the others went to rest, each in his hut,  
but great Achilles lay out on the beach  
beside the loud-resounding sea and groaned,  
60 amid his Myrmidons but set apart,  
where waves were washing up against the shore.  
At last sweet sleep surrounded him and seized him 80  
and freed his heart from all his pain and sorrow.  
His body was exhausted from the effort  
of chasing Hector towards windy Troy.  
And then the shade of poor Patroclus came,  
looking just like him, with his lovely eyes,  
his height, his voice, clothes like the ones he wore.  
The spirit stood above his head and said,

“Are you asleep? Have you forgotten me,  
 Achilles? When I was alive, you never  
 70 failed to take care of me—but not in death. 90  
 Please hurry, bury me and let me pass  
 the gates of Hades. I am all alone.  
 The spirits of the dead, whose toils are over,  
 will not allow me yet to join with them,  
 and they refuse to let me cross the river.  
 I wander, lost and aimless, through the halls  
 of Hades where the gates are always open.  
 Give me your hand, Achilles, please, I beg you!  
 Never shall I come back from Hades’ house  
 after you grant me my due share of fire. 100  
 Never again will we sit down together  
 alive, apart from all our dear companions,  
 and form our plans together. Hateful doom,  
 the lot that I have had since I was born,  
 has opened wide to swallow me at last.  
 80 Godlike Achilles, even you are fated  
 to die beneath the wealthy Trojans’ wall.  
 And I have something else to ask of you,  
 if you will listen. Do not put my bones  
 apart from yours, Achilles, but together, 110  
 as we were raised together in your house.  
 When I was just a very little boy  
 back home in Opoeis where I was born,  
 Menoetius brought me from our land to yours  
 because of a disastrous homicide.  
 I killed the son of Acamas that day.  
 I was a fool. I did not mean to do it,  
 but I got angry at a game of dice.  
 The horse-lord Peleus accepted me  
 into his house and brought me up with kindness, 120  
 90 and named me as your steward and companion.  
 So let a single urn hold both our bones,  
 the golden vessel with the double handles  
 which you were given by your goddess mother.”

Swift-footed Lord Achilles answered, saying,



“My darling friend, why did you come to me?  
Why did you tell me all these things? I will  
do everything exactly as you said.  
But please, come nearer and stand next to me,  
and let us put our arms around each other,  
for just a little while, and have the joy  
of grief and lamentation.”

130

100                               With these words,  
he reached his hands to him but could not grasp him.  
The spirit vanished underneath the earth  
like smoke, with just a little squeaking cry.  
Achilles was astonished and jumped up  
and clapped his hands and shouted out in sorrow,

“So there are shades and spirits down in Hades!  
And yet they have no substance, none at all.  
All night the spirit of poor, dead Patroclus  
stood over me and wept and wailed and gave me  
detailed instructions, and it was astounding  
how much it seemed like him.”

140

110                               These words aroused  
yearning for lamentation in them all.  
Until the rosy-fingered Dawn appeared  
they wept and wailed around the poor dead man.  
Then mighty Agamemnon urged the men  
from all the huts to go with mules and bring  
the wood. Meriones watched over them,  
the steward of kind Idomeneus.  
They went with strongly twisted ropes and axes  
to chop the wood, the mules in front of them.  
They traveled uphill, downhill, crossways, slantways,  
and everywhere until they reached the foothills  
of Ida, with its many creeks and springs.  
And there they labored hard with slim sharp bronze  
to cut the towering leafy oaks. The trees  
began to fall with thunderous thuds and crashing.

150

120 The Greeks split up the trunks and bound the wood  
 behind the mules whose hooves stirred up the earth 160  
 as they were trekking through the undergrowth  
 eagerly back again towards the plain.  
 All of the woodchoppers brought logs as well,  
 just as Meriones instructed them—  
 the steward of kind Idomeneus.  
 They lined the timber up along the shore.  
 Achilles planned a mighty burial mound  
 for Lord Patroclus and himself. And when  
 the limitless supply of wood was laid  
 around in heaps and ready to be used, 170  
 the men all stayed there, sitting in a huddle.  
 Achilles told the warlike Myrmidons  
 130 to gird themselves in bronze and yoke the horses  
 onto the chariots. They rose and armed,  
 and climbed upon the chariots in pairs,  
 a driver and a rider on each one.  
 The chariots went in front of the procession,  
 a cloud of countless men on foot came after,  
 and in the middle, comrades bore Patroclus.  
 They blanketed the corpse with their own hair 180  
 which they cut off and threw on top of him.  
 Godlike Achilles walked behind the bier,  
 cradling his innocent companion's head,  
 grieving that he had sent him down to Hades.  
 When they had reached the designated place,  
 just as Achilles had instructed them,  
 they laid Patroclus down and quickly heaped  
 abundant wood to form the funeral pyre.  
 140 Swift-footed Lord Achilles thought of something,  
 and standing at a distance from the fire 190  
 he cut his chestnut hair, which had grown long  
 beside the River Spercheus. He gazed  
 miserably out across the wine-dark sea,  
 and shouted,

“Spercheus, this is not what  
 my father, Peleus, once asked you for.

He wanted me to come back home again.  
He promised I would cut my hair for you,  
and dedicate a holy hecatomb,  
and slaughter fifty uncastrated rams  
beside your waters in the place you have  
your holy sanctuary and fragrant altar.  
These were the vows that my old father made  
but you did not fulfill his wish for him,  
and I will never go back home again.  
So I would like to dedicate my hair  
to noble Lord Patroclus to take with him.”

200

With this, he placed his hair into the hands  
of his dear friend, the one he loved, and roused  
the yearning to lament in all of them.  
They would have mourned until the sun went down  
had not Achilles said to Agamemnon,  
who stood beside him,

210

“Son of Atreus,  
you have the greatest power to sway the troops.  
The Greeks will listen and obey your orders.  
We can be satisfied with lamentation  
later, but let them leave the pyre for now.  
Command them to disperse and make their meal.  
And we who love and care for him the most  
will make the preparations for the dead.  
Only the leaders should stay here with me.”

220

When Agamemnon, lord of men, heard this,  
he made the troops disperse among the ships.  
The dead man’s intimate companions stayed  
and heaped the wood and made a funeral pyre  
a hundred feet in width, a hundred high.  
They put the dead man on the very top  
with heavy hearts, and then before the pyre  
they flayed and butchered many fine fat sheep  
and shambling cattle with their crumpled horns.

And great Achilles took the fat from all  
and covered up the corpse from head to foot,  
and heaped the skinless carcasses around him.

170 Against the bier he propped two-handled jars  
of honey and of oil. Then groaning deeply  
he cast four strong-necked horses on the pyre.  
Patroclus had nine dogs that shared his table.

Achilles cut the throats of two of them  
and threw them on the pyre. Then with his bronze  
he slaughtered twelve fine sons of valiant Trojans.

His heart was contemplating wicked things.

240

And then he lit a fire as tenacious  
as iron, and encouraged it to spread.

He moaned, and called the friend he loved by name.

180 “Patroclus! Even in the house of Hades,  
greetings, be well! I have done everything  
just as I promised you before. This fire  
devours twelve noble sons of valiant Trojans  
along with you. But I shall not give Hector,  
the son of Priam, to the fire to eat,  
but to the dogs.”

These were the threats he made.

250

And yet the pack of dogs did not maul Hector.

The goddess Aphrodite, child of Zeus,  
kept them away both day and night and used  
immortal rose oil to anoint the body,  
so that Achilles, when he dragged it round,  
would cause no lacerations to the skin.

Phoebus Apollo sent a dark dense cloud  
from heaven to the plain and covered up  
190 the area where Hector’s body lay,  
so that the power of the sun would not

260

shrivel the skin around his limbs and sinews.  
Meanwhile, the funeral pyre of dead Patroclus  
refused to light. Swift-footed Lord Achilles  
had to devise a different plan. He stood  
a distance from the pyre and said a prayer

to Boreas and Zephyr, the two winds,  
and vowed to give them splendid sacrifices.  
He poured libations from a golden cup  
beseeching them to come, so that the corpses  
would soon be burning and the wood catch fire.

270

200 Instantly, Iris heard his prayers and went  
to take the message to the winds, who were  
gathered inside the house of stormy Zephyr,  
having a banquet. Iris ran and reached it  
and stood upon the threshold made of stone.  
And when they saw her, all of them jumped up,  
and every wind asked her to sit beside him,  
but she refused and said,

“No time to sit!

I am returning to the streams of Ocean.

I visited the Ethiopians,

280

who offer hecatombs to deathless gods,

so that I also might receive my share

of sacrifices. But Achilles prays

for you to come—both Boreas, the north wind,

and blustering Zephyr, the west wind. He vows

210 fine sacrifices, if you light the pyre

on which Patroclus lies, whom all the Greeks  
are mourning.”

With these words, she flew away.

The winds rushed forth with an unearthly roar

and drove the clouds in front of them, and reached

290

the sea and blew the waters and aroused

the waves beneath their whistling breath. They reached

the fertile fields of Troy and fell upon

the pyre. The supernatural fire was lit

and gave a mighty roar. All night the winds,

huffing and hissing at the pyre together,

blasted the flame. And all night, swift Achilles

refilled his double-handled cup of wine

out of the golden wine-bowl, and kept pouring

220 libations on the ground to wet the earth,

300

calling the spirit of poor dead Patroclus—  
just as a father grieves when he is burning  
the bones of his dear son, who just got married,  
whose death brings pain to his unhappy parents—  
just so, Achilles grieved as he was burning  
the bones of his companion. He was pacing  
around the funeral pyre with sad, slow steps,  
sobbing and crying inconsolably.

But when the Morning Star foretold the light  
and Dawn in saffron robes spread out across  
the salty sea, the funeral pyre died down,  
the blazing ceased. The winds went home again  
across the Thracian Sea, which swelled and groaned.  
Achilles drew back from the funeral pyre,  
sank down, exhausted, and sweet sleep took hold.  
But Agamemnon and his followers  
crowded around him and the sound of voices  
and clatter of their coming woke him up.  
He sat up straight and said to them,

310

“Great son  
of Atreus, and all you other fighters  
gathered together from all over Greece,  
extinguish this whole pyre with shining wine,  
dousing the area the fire’s force touched.  
I shall collect the bones of dead Patroclus,  
son of Menoetius, and it will be easy  
to recognize them plainly. He was lying  
right in the middle, while the other dead—  
horses and humans mingled up together—  
burned at the edges of the funeral pyre.

320

Then lay his bones inside a golden bowl  
and place two strips of fat on top of them,  
until I too am hidden down in Hades.  
And I do not command you to construct  
a massive mound—make it the normal size.  
Later, you Greeks can build it wide and high—  
those of you who remain among our fleet,  
ready to row away when I am gone.”

330

They did as swift Achilles had commanded.  
250 They quenched the pyre with shining wine, wherever  
the flames had gone and where the ash was deep. 340  
They gathered up their gentle friend's white bones,  
weeping, and put them in a golden bowl  
and covered them with fat, two layers thick,  
and set them in the tent and wrapped across them  
a delicate fine cloth. They measured out  
the space to build the mound and set the stakes  
around the pyre, then poured the mass of earth  
to form his monument, then made to leave.  
But great Achilles had the people stay,  
and told the large assembly to sit down. 350  
He brought the contest prizes from the ships—  
the cauldrons and the tripods and the horses,  
260 the mules, the sturdy oxen, and the women  
in lovely dresses, and the cold gray iron.  
First came the chariot race, for which he set  
magnificent prizes, with the winner getting  
a talented craftswoman and a tripod  
with handles, holding two and twenty measures,  
and for the second prize, he gave a horse  
six years of age, unbroken, who was pregnant, 360  
having a baby mule. And as third prize,  
a cauldron that had never touched the fire,  
still beautiful and white, that held four measures.  
And as fourth prize, he gave two weights of gold,  
270 and fifth, a bowl with handles on both sides,  
also untouched by fire. He stood up straight  
and told the Greeks,

“Now, son of Atreus,  
and all you other warriors in arms,  
here are the prizes for the charioteers.  
And if these games were being held in honor 370  
of anybody else, I would receive  
first prize and take it with me to my tent.  
You know my horses are the very best.  
They are immortal and Poseidon gave them

to Peleus, my father, who bestowed them  
on me. But I shall not participate,  
nor shall my strong-hoofed horses. They have lost  
280 their charioteer—so brave, so good, so kind,  
who often rubbed their manes with olive oil  
after he washed them clean in shining water. 380  
Now they both stand and grieve for him, heads down,  
their long manes trailing so they reach the ground,  
sorrowful in their hearts. But all you others,  
if anybody else in the Greek camp  
trusts in his horses and his chariot,  
come on, get ready for the race!”

So spoke

Achilles, and the charioteers assembled.  
Eumelus, lord of men, dashed forward first—  
a skillful charioteer, the well-loved son  
290 of Lord Admetus. Next came Diomedes, 390  
strong son of Tydeus, who yoked and drove  
the pair of Trojan horses he had taken  
from great Aeneas, whom Apollo rescued.  
And Menelaus, favorite of Zeus,  
the light-haired son of Atreus, arrived  
with two swift horses harnessed to one yoke—  
Flame, Agamemnon’s mare, and his own horse,  
the stallion Swiftfoot. Agamemnon got  
Flame from Echepolus, Anchises’ son,  
as payment to evade the expedition 400  
to windy Troy, so that he had the pleasure  
of staying home in spacious Sicyon,  
where Zeus had blessed him with enormous wealth.  
Now Menelaus had her in the yoke,  
300 despite her great unwillingness to race.  
The fourth who harnessed up his thick-maned horses  
was glorious Antilochus, the son  
of valiant Nestor, son of Neleus.  
His chariot was drawn by swift-hoofed horses  
who had been born in Pylos. And his father 410  
stood near him and provided good advice,



though he already knew what he was doing.

“Antilochus, though you are very young,  
Zeus and Poseidon love you and have taught you  
everything that a driver needs to know.

I need not teach you anything. Already  
you know how best to wheel around the post.  
And yet you have the slowest horses here.

310 I am afraid that they may let you down.

The other men are driving faster horses,  
but they are not more competent than you.

So come, dear boy, use all your skill and wits  
and do not let the prizes pass you by.

Wits help a woodcutter far more than strength.

Wits help a captain on the wine-dark sea  
to steer the ship through buffeting winds and storms.

Wits make one driver better than another.

Someone who trusts his chariot and horses  
may make the turning inattentively,

320 wheeling too wide and veering every which way.

The horses fail to keep along the track,  
the driver fails to keep control of them.

But somebody who drives inferior horses  
with knowledge and intelligence keeps watching  
the turning post, and steers them tight around it,  
never forgetting how to hold the reins  
firmly and steadily, eyes on the track.

And I will tell you an important sign,  
an easy thing to see. You cannot miss it.

There is a dry wood-stump, a fathom high,  
of oak or pine, not rotted by the rain,

with two white stones, one on each side of it,  
right where the outbound and the inbound tracks  
meet one another and the ground is smooth

330 for driving round it. It may be the tomb  
of somebody who died here long ago,  
or else the post that ancient people used  
for races. Now swift-footed Lord Achilles  
has specified that this will mark the turn.

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You have to drive your chariot and horses  
 as close to it as you can and lean your body  
 a little to the left as you are riding  
 inside the woven carriage, and encourage  
 the right-hand horse and whip him on and give him  
 free rein, and let the left horse graze the post,  
 so that the wheel's hub seems to touch the trunk,  
 340 but do not graze the stone, in case you hurt  
 your horses and smash up your chariot.  
 That would delight the other chariot drivers,  
 humiliating you. Dear boy, be careful  
 and smart. If you can pass them at the post  
 and get in front, no one can overtake you,  
 not even if the horse he drove behind you  
 was swift Arion, offspring of the gods,  
 the stallion of Adrastus, and not even  
 if they were King Laomedon's fine horses,  
 both raised in Troy."

With these words, Nestor coached  
 350 his son about the way to win the race,  
 then sat back down again. Meriones,  
 the fifth contestant, brought his thick-maned horses.  
 Mounting their chariots, they cast the lots.  
 Achilles shook. The first lot that jumped out  
 was for Antilochus, the son of Nestor.  
 Next was the lot of noble Eumelus,  
 then Menelaus, son of Atreus,  
 the famous spearman, then Meriones.  
 The one who had to drive his horses last  
 was Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
 the finest of the charioteers by far.  
 They lined up side by side. Achilles showed them  
 the distant turning post on the smooth plain.  
 He set beside it, as the godlike judge,  
 360 Phoenix, the old attendant of his father,  
 so he could mark the laps and tell the truth.  
 All of them raised their whips above their horses  
 and struck them with the reins and shouted "Go!"

Swiftly the horses raced across the plain  
and soon the ships were far behind. The dust  
flew up and gathered underneath their chests  
like clouds or like a whirlwind, and their manes  
trailed in the gusts of air. The chariots bounced,  
and sometimes rested on the fertile earth,  
and sometimes hurtled up into the air.

490

370 The heart of every man was thumping fast,  
and all of them were hoping they would win.  
All of them urged their horses ever onward.  
They flew and raised the dust across the plain.  
But when the galloping horses were completing  
the final lap towards the gray salt sea,  
each of the men revealed his skill and courage.

500

The horses ran full tilt. The galloping mares  
of Eumelus were first, and just behind them,  
the Trojan stallions of Diomedes,  
not far behind but almost at their tails,  
so that they always seemed about to mount  
the chariot in front. And Eumelus  
380 felt their hot breath huff on his back and shoulders.

They stretched their heads towards him as they flew.  
Now Diomedes would have passed him by  
or forced a draw, but Phoebus, Lord Apollo,  
was angry with him, so he knocked his whip  
out of his hands, and Diomedes wept  
in anger and frustration, when he saw  
the mares still galloping onward, ever faster,  
while his own stallions' chances had been blighted,  
now they were galloping without a whip.

510

But then Athena noticed how Apollo  
had cheated Diomedes, and at once  
she hurried after him and gave him back  
390 his shining whip and energized his horses.

520

The goddess in a rage chased Eumelus,  
and broke his yoke. His mares ran off the track,  
the chariot pole slipped down upon the ground,  
and he himself went somersaulting out,  
hurled from the chariot beside the wheel,

skinning his elbows and his mouth and nose,  
bruising his forehead just above his brows.  
His eyes were full of tears, his voice choked up.  
Then Diomedes, son of Tydeus,  
turned his strong stallions and made them gallop  
ahead of all the rest. Athena gave them  
energy, and to him, she gave success.  
The son of Atreus, blond Menelaus,  
was after him, but then Antilochus  
ordered his father's horses,

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400

“Faster, faster!  
Gallop ahead at top speed, both of you!  
I do not say you should attempt to challenge  
the stallions of skillful Diomedes,  
whose speed Athena has increased, while granting  
success to him. But catch up with the horses  
of Menelaus, son of Atreus.  
Hurry and do not let them stay ahead.  
Flame is a female, which will bring you shame  
if she defeats you. Why are you behind,  
excellent stallions? I promise you,  
this is the truth. You will lose all the care  
that Nestor, shepherd of the people, gives you,  
and he will slaughter you immediately,  
using a sharp bronze blade, if you slack off  
and win the lesser prize. Go after them,  
gallop as quickly as you can! Go on!  
I shall devise a clever strategy  
to pass them in the narrow bit of track.  
I will not miss my opportunity.”

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Their master's warnings terrified the horses,  
who galloped faster for a little while.  
But valiant Antilochus soon saw  
a narrowing in the hollow track. There was  
a dip where pent-up stormwater had broken  
the path and made its surface fall away.  
Then Menelaus drove along the track,

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560

trying to keep the chariot wheels apart.  
Antilochus steered off the path and leaned  
a little to the side, and tried to catch him.  
And Menelaus, son of Atreus,  
was frightened and called out,

“Antilochus!  
Your driving is too reckless! Hold your horses!  
This track is narrow. It will widen soon  
and then the chariots can pass. Do not  
smash into me or you will hurt us both.”

570

430 At this, Antilochus drove even faster,  
pretending not to hear and whipped his horses.  
As far as a young man can throw a discus,  
testing his strength and pitching from the shoulder,  
so far the horses of Antilochus  
galloped ahead. The mares of Menelaus  
fell back behind, because their driver chose  
not to keep pushing them, in case the horses  
crashed on the track, and tipped the chariots over,  
and both the drivers, in their haste for glory,  
fell in the dust. Then ruddy Menelaus  
reproached Antilochus.

580

“Antilochus!  
You are the worst! Reckless endangerment!  
440 Curse you! The Greeks are wrong to call you smart!  
But you will win no prize without an oath  
about your conduct!”

With these words, he urged  
his horses on, and spoke to them.

“Do not  
hold back or stop, despite your pain and grief.  
His horses will be tired before you are.  
Both of them are well past their youth and prime.”

590

They feared their master's words and galloped faster,  
and soon came near the others. And meanwhile,  
the Greeks were sitting in the meeting place,  
looking towards the horses flying forward,  
raising the dust along the plain. The first  
to see them come was Idomeneus,  
450 the leader of the Cretans. He was sitting  
outside the council, on the highest point.  
He heard a distant shout and recognized  
the voice and saw the stallion at the front—  
a noticeable horse, all bay except  
a white mark on his forehead, like a moon.  
He stood up straight and told the Greeks,

600

“My friends,  
leaders and councillors of Greece, am I  
the only one to see the horses coming,  
or can you also make them out? It seems  
a different pair of stallions has the lead.  
460 I see a different charioteer as well.  
The mares who were in front on the way out  
must have been injured out there on the plain.  
I saw them in the lead towards the turn,  
but now I cannot see them anywhere  
and I have looked across the Trojan plain.  
Maybe the driver dropped the reins and lost  
control around the post and could not turn.  
I guess he fell out, broke his chariot,  
and probably his mares swerved off the course  
because their spirits were so agitated.  
Stand up and look! I cannot see too well.  
470 I think that man is the Aetolian,  
a leader in the army of the Greeks,  
the son of Tydeus, the horse-tamer,  
powerful Diomedes.”

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620

But swift Ajax,  
son of Oileus, reproached him harshly.  
“Lord Idomeneus, why are you always

blathering on like this? Those high-hoofed mares  
are still a long way off, and they still have  
a lot of ground to cover on the plain.  
Certainly you are not the youngest Greek.  
Your eyes are not the sharpest. Yet you always  
babble! You should not be a blabbermouth.  
You are surrounded by superior men.  
The mares are in the front just as they were.  
Eumelus holds their reins and drives them onward.”

630

At this, the leader of the Cretans answered  
angrily, “Ajax, you are excellent  
at quarreling, but terrible at thinking,  
because you are so stubborn in your mind.  
But come on now, we ought to make a bet  
for a tripod or a cauldron. Let us set  
Lord Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
as arbiter to say which pair of horses  
is in the lead—so you will have to pay,  
and that will teach you!”

640

At these words, swift Ajax  
jumped up in fury, ready to reply  
with bitter words. The quarrel would have grown  
even more acrimonious between them,  
had not Achilles risen to his feet  
and said,

“Stop trading insults back and forth,  
Ajax and Idomeneus. It is  
nasty, and both of you would speak against it  
if anybody else behaved like this.  
Sit down and watch the horses in the race.  
All of them want to win and they are running  
fast. They will soon be here. Then you will see  
who is behind and who is in the lead.”

650

And as Achilles said this, Diomedes,

the son of Tydeus, came into view,  
 swinging his whole arm back to lash his horses.  
 500 He kept on urging them to gallop forward. 660  
 They flew above the earth and sped ahead.  
 The dust was always spattering the driver.  
 The chariot of gold and tin was flying  
 behind the horses' galloping hooves. The wheels  
 left barely any tracks in the light dust.  
 The stallions dashed ahead, and soon he halted  
 right in the middle of the meeting place.  
 The horses' necks and chests were dripping sweat  
 down to the ground. And Diomedes leapt  
 out of his glittering carriage to the ground 670  
 510 and leaned his whip against the yoke. At once,  
 without a single moment's hesitation,  
 Sthenelus seized first prize and gave the winnings  
 to their exaltant friends. They took the tripod  
 with handles and they led the woman off.  
 And Sthenelus himself released the horses.  
 As he was doing so, Antilochus,  
 the son of Nestor, son of Neleus,  
 drove to the finish. He had got in front  
 of Menelaus, not by speed but cunning. 680  
 But even so, Lord Menelaus brought  
 his galloping horses close behind, as near  
 as lies between a chariot wheel and horse—  
 a stallion who pulls the car and driver  
 across the plain—the bottom of his tail  
 520 touches the wheel's tire as it runs so close  
 that there is scarcely any space between  
 the wheel and horse, who gallops on and on  
 across the vast expanse—that was how close  
 the distance was between Antilochus 690  
 and Menelaus. Earlier, the gap  
 between them was much more, a discus throw,  
 but Menelaus soon caught up to him,  
 thanks to the growing eagerness and strength  
 of Flame, the thick-maned mare of Agamemnon.  
 If both of them had gone on racing further,



then Menelaus would have overtaken,  
not merely forced a tie. Meriones,  
the stalwart friend of Idomeneus,  
finished a spear's throw after Menelaus,  
530 because his thick-maned horses were the slowest  
and he was the worst driver in the race.  
The very last of all was Eumelus,  
who dragged his splendid chariot himself,  
driving his horses up ahead of him.  
Swift-footed Lord Achilles pitied him  
and stood among the Greeks and spoke winged words.

700

“The best man has come last! Look, here he is,  
driving his strong-hoofed horses. Come on now,  
we ought to give the second prize to him,  
as is appropriate. But Diomedes,  
the son of Tydeus, should get first prize.”

710

The others all agreed with his commands.  
Achilles would have got the mare for him  
540 as they agreed, but then Antilochus,  
the son of noble Nestor, stood and answered  
Achilles, son of Peleus, demanding  
justice.

“I will be furious with you,  
Achilles, if you do as you have said.  
You plan to take away my prize, because  
his horses and his chariot were damaged,  
and he is an important noble man.  
He should have prayed to the immortal gods!  
Then he would not have finished last of all.  
And if you pity him and favor him,  
you have a heap of gold inside your hut,  
550 and bronze and sheep and women slaves and horses.  
Take something from your store to give to him  
later, perhaps a better prize than this.  
Or do it now to gain the Greeks' approval.

720

730

I will not give her up. But any man  
can try to fight me for her, if he wants to.”

At this, swift-footed Lord Achilles smiled,  
pleased with Antilochus. He loved his friend.  
He answered him with words that flew on wings.

“Antilochus, if you are telling me  
to give an extra prize to Eumelus,  
taking it from my hut, I will do that.

560 I shall give him the breastplate that I took  
from Lord Asteropeus, of pure bronze  
with shining tin poured over and around it.  
It will be worth a lot to him.”

740

With this,  
he told Antilochus, the friend he loved,  
to fetch it from the hut. He went and brought it,  
and handed it to Eumelus, who took it  
gladly. But then among them, Menelaus  
stood up. His heart was troubled, and his anger  
against Antilochus was unabated.  
The steward put the staff into his hand  
and told the Greeks to quiet down, and then  
the godlike leader said,

750

570 “Antilochus,  
you used to be considered smart. But now,  
what have you done? Humiliating me!  
You made me look incompetent! You blocked  
my horses, and you shoved your team in front,  
although your horses are much worse than mine.  
Come on now, lords and leaders of the Greeks,  
pass judgment on us both impartially,  
and do not offer help to either of us,  
so none of the bronze-armored Greeks will say,  
‘This Menelaus beat Antilochus  
by lies, and won a mare, because he was

760

more powerful in rank and strength and status,  
although his horses were inferior.’

But I shall offer a proposed solution.

580 I doubt that anybody here will find  
fault with it. It is fair and reasonable.

Antilochus, come here now, sir. This is  
the pious and appropriate thing to do.

Stand up before your chariot and horses,  
and hold the pliant whip with which you drove,  
when you were driving earlier, and touch  
your horses, and declare by Lord Poseidon,  
the god of earthquakes, who surrounds the world,  
a mighty oath, that you did not impede  
my chariot on purpose, by a trick.”

770

Intelligent Antilochus replied,

“Hold on now, Menelaus. I am, sir,  
younger than you by far. You are my senior,  
and my superior. You understand  
how younger people overstep the mark.

590 Young minds are hasty and their judgment feeble.  
You must be patient, and then I will give you  
the mare I won. And if you also want  
another, better item from my house,  
I would prefer to give it you at once,  
my lord, than fall forever from your favor,  
and be a sinner in the eyes of gods.”

780

With this, Antilochus, brave Nestor’s son,  
led out the horse and put her in the hands  
of Menelaus, who was overjoyed—

600 just as the dew on ears of grain grows warm,  
when crops are growing and the farmlands bristle,  
just so, your heart inside your chest grew warm,  
Lord Menelaus, and you spoke to him  
with words that flew on wings.

790

“Antilochus,

I shall stop being angry with you now,  
because you never used to be deranged  
or volatile. Your immaturity  
bested your wits this time. But never try  
to outwit your superiors again.

800

No other Greek would have persuaded me  
to yield so fast. But you have worked so hard,  
enduring so much toil and pain for me,  
you and your noble father and your brother.  
So I shall listen to your plea, and give you  
the mare, though she is mine, so that these men  
will know my spirit is not harsh or proud.”

610

With this, he gave the mare to Lord Noemon,  
a comrade of Antilochus, to take.  
And he himself received the shining cauldron.  
Meriones picked up the two gold talents,  
because he came in fourth. One final prize,  
the fifth, was left, the double-handled bowl.  
Achilles took it through the Greek assembly  
and handed it to Nestor, stood beside him  
and said,

810

“This treasure is for you, old sir,  
as a memento of the funeral  
in honor of Patroclus. You will never  
see him again among the Greeks. I give you  
this prize for free, because you will not fight  
during the boxing or the wrestling matches,  
or hurl a javelin or run the footrace.  
You are too heavily constrained by age.”

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820

He handed him the bowl, and Nestor took it  
gladly, and spoke these words on wings.

“My child,  
everything you have said is quite correct.  
My limbs and feet are wobbly, dear boy,

my arms and shoulders cannot punch or throw.

If only I were young and strong again,

830

as in Bouprasion, where long ago

630 the fine Epeans held a funeral

for mighty Amarynceus. His sons

created contests honoring their father.

There was no other man as good as me

among the Pylians and the Epeans

and proud Aetolians. I beat them all.

In boxing, Clytomedes, son of Enops.

In wrestling, I was challenged by Ancaeus,

from Pleuron. In the footrace, I outran

840

Iphiclus, though he was a splendid athlete.

And when we cast our spears, I cast mine farther

than Phyleus or Polydorus did.

I only lost the chariot race because

the sons of Actor beat me by sheer numbers,

forcing their way in front. They were so eager

640 to win the race and get the biggest prizes.

They were twin brothers and they rode together,

one driving with calm and steady hand,

the other giving orders with the whip.

850

That is the way I used to be. But now

I have to yield to miserable old age.

I used to be a star among the fighters.

But come now, give more honor to your friend

with competitions at his funeral.

I am delighted to accept this prize.

My heart is glad, because you think of me

and see me as a friend, and you have not

forgotten how much honor I deserve

among the Greeks. I pray the gods repay you

860

650 with favors that will satisfy your heart.”

And when Achilles, son of Peleus,

had listened to the whole of Nestor’s story

and heard his praise, he went back through the crowd,

and set the prizes for the painful boxing.

He led a mule who could endure hard work

into the meeting place and tied her up.  
She was unbroken still at six years old—  
mules are the hardest animal to break.  
And for the loser of the boxing match  
he brought a double-handled cup. He stood  
and made a declaration to the Greeks.

870

660 “Now son of Atreus, Lord Agamemnon,  
and all you other Greeks bedecked in armor,  
we bid two men to fight to win these prizes—  
the finest boxers must raise up their fists.  
The one Apollo gives the stamina  
to stick it out for longer and endure,  
whom all the Greeks perceive to be the winner,  
will get the sturdy mule and take her home.  
The loser gets the double-handled cup.”

880

At this, a tall impressive man jumped up,  
a skillful boxer named Epeus, son  
of Panopeus, and he touched the mule,  
and said,

670 “Come here, if anybody wants  
to win the double-handled cup! I think  
no other Greek will beat me at the boxing  
and take the mule, because I promise you  
I am the best. I am not great in battle.  
I have enough shortcomings, I admit it.  
No man can be the best at everything.  
But I can promise you that I will punch  
right through his skin and flesh and break his bones.  
Let my opponent’s kinsmen stay to help,  
gathered around right here, so they are ready  
to carry him away when he has been  
defeated by my hands.”

890

At this, they all  
kept quiet. But there was one volunteer.

Euryalus, a godlike man, stood up.

Grandson of Talaus, he was the son

of King Mecisteus, who long ago

went to the funeral they held in Thebes

when Oedipus had fallen. In those games,

680 Mecisteus defeated all the Thebans.

The son of Tydeus, Lord Diomedes,

the famous spearman, coached Euryalus,

and got him ready and encouraged him

because he really wanted him to win.

He put the belt around him first, then gave him

some well-cut oxhide leather thongs. Both fighters

were girded up and came into the circle,

and raised their fists and flexed their brawny arms,

then fell together, battering each other

with heavy blows. There was a dreadful noise

of cracking, crunching jaws, their bodies drenched

in sweat all over. As Euryalus

690 glanced to the side, Epeus punched his cheek,

so hard that he could not stay standing long—

his sturdy legs gave way. As when a fish

beneath the ripple caused by Boreas

leaps upward through the seaweed by the shore

then down, and dark waves cover him again—

so did Euryalus leap up when struck.

But brave Epeus pulled him up again

and got him to his feet. His loving friends

gathered around and dragged him through the circle,

legs trailing, spitting clotted lumps of blood,

head lolling to one side and semiconscious.

They set him down among them, and went back

to get the double-handled cup for him.

700 And then Achilles, son of Peleus,

set out the prizes for the third event—

the painful wrestling. For the winning man,

a massive tripod, ready for the fire,

valued at twelve good oxen by the Greeks.

And for the losing man, he gave a woman,

skillful in many tasks. They valued her

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at four good oxen. And Achilles stood  
amid the Greeks and said,

“Let two of you  
get up if you would like to try this contest.”

940

At this, great Telamonian Ajax rose,  
and smart, intelligent Odysseus.

710 They strapped their belts on, came into the middle,  
and gripped each other in their firm, strong arms—  
like rafters that a carpenter has fixed  
onto a lofty house to block the wind.  
Their backs were cracking as their brawny hands  
grasped them and squeezed them, and the sweat dripped down.  
Their shoulders and their sides were soon all covered  
with blood-red welts, but they kept struggling  
to win the tripod. And Odysseus  
could not trip Ajax up or throw him down,  
and Ajax could not fell Odysseus,  
720 because Odysseus stayed strong. But when  
the Greeks were growing weary of the contest,  
great Ajax, son of Telamon, called out,

950

“Cunning Odysseus, king under Zeus,  
son of Laertes, lift me, or I you.  
But all the consequences lie with Zeus.”

With this, he picked him up. Odysseus  
did not forget his tricks. He found a way  
to strike at Ajax right behind his knees,  
so that his legs gave way and he fell backward.  
Odysseus fell clinging to his chest.  
The people were astonished and amazed.  
Then resolute Odysseus attempted  
to pick up Ajax, but he only moved him  
730 a little from the ground, not fully off it.  
He crooked his leg around the knee of Ajax  
so both of them fell sideways on each other,

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970



and both of them were sullied by the dust.  
They would have jumped back up and tried again  
to wrestle, but Achilles came and stopped them.

“Quit now. Do not exhaust yourselves with pain.  
The victory belongs to both of you.  
Take equal prizes and be off with you,  
so that the other Greeks can now compete.”

They listened and were eager to comply.  
They wiped the dust off, and put on their tunics.

740 Achilles, son of Peleus, laid out  
the prizes for the footrace. For the winner,  
a finely crafted silver mixing bowl,  
which held six measures, and which was by far  
the finest in the world. It had been made  
by highly skilled Sidonians, then carried  
across the misty deep by the Phoenicians,  
who anchored in a harbor and then gave  
the bowl to Thoas, as a gift. His grandson,  
Euneus, son of Jason, gave the bowl  
to Lord Patroclus as the price to save  
Lycaon, son of Priam. Now Achilles  
laid out this bowl belonging to his comrade  
as first prize for the man who ran the fastest.  
750 He gave a large fat ox as second prize,  
and offered for the man who came in last  
half of a talent’s weight in gold. Achilles  
stood up among the Greeks and shouted out,

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“Get up if you would like to join this race!”

And swift Oilean Ajax right away  
leapt up, as did astute Odysseus,  
and then Antilochus, the son of Nestor.  
Of all the younger men, he ran the fastest.  
The three of them lined up, and then Achilles  
showed them the place to turn, and off they went,

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sprinting at top speed from the starting point,  
and Ajax took the lead, but close behind him  
was godlike Lord Odysseus, as near

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as when a woman pulls a weaving rod  
close to her chest to pass the spool of thread  
between the warp—so close Odysseus  
sprinted behind, and in the tracks of Ajax  
he set his feet before the dust had settled.  
Ajax could feel his breath behind his head.

1010

Odysseus kept running faster, faster,  
trying to win, and all the Greeks were yelling  
and telling him to keep it up. But when  
they reached the final stretch, Odysseus  
prayed in his heart to flashing-eyed Athena,

“Hear me and help my feet run faster, goddess!”

Athena heard, and made his legs more nimble,  
and sped up both his feet and arms and hands.

1020

And when they were about to win the prize,  
Ajax slipped over as he ran—Athena  
had tripped him up. He tumbled in the dung  
from all the bellowing bulls Achilles slaughtered.  
The cattle dung filled up his mouth and nostrils.

So then resilient Odysseus  
received the mixing bowl—he came in first.

And glorious Ajax got the ox. He stood,

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holding it by the horns, and spitting out  
the dung, and told the Greeks,

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“ This is outrageous!

The goddess tripped me up! She always stands  
beside Odysseus and gives him help  
as if she were his mother!”

At these words,  
the Greeks all laughed at him. Antilochus  
took the third prize and smiled and told the Greeks,

“I tell you, friends, though you already know it,  
the deathless gods still favor older men.  
Ajax is just a little bit my senior.  
But this man here is from a bygone era,  
the older generation, and they say  
that he is on the edge of elderly.  
Yet it is difficult for any Greek  
to beat him in a race, except Achilles.”

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These words were flattering to swift Achilles,  
who answered him,

“Antilochus, your praise  
will not go unrewarded. I shall give you  
another half a talent’s weight in gold.”

With this, Achilles handed it to him.  
He took it gladly. Then Achilles brought  
and set down in the place of the assembly  
a spear that cast long shadows and a shield  
and helmet—all the arms of great Sarpedon,  
stripped from him by Patroclus. He stood up  
and spoke to all the Greeks.

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“I call two men,  
the best of all, to fight to get these prizes.  
This pair must put their armor on and seize  
their weapons made of bronze that cuts through flesh,  
and duel here before the crowd. The first  
who reaches his opponent’s handsome flesh  
and pierces through the armor and dark blood  
into his insides will receive this sword,  
a splendid Thracian blade with silver studs,  
stripped from Asteropeus when I killed him.  
Both champions will also get his armor  
to share between them, and I shall provide  
a splendid feast for them inside my hut.”

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Great Ajax, son of Telamon, leapt up,  
and Diomedes, son of Tydeus.

On either side of the immense assembly  
they armed themselves, then strode into the middle,  
eager to fight and glaring at each other.  
The Greeks were all amazed. And when they met,  
three times they rushed, three times they clashed together.  
And Ajax struck the round, well-balanced shield  
of his opponent, but he did not reach  
the flesh, because the breastplate blocked the blow.

And Diomedes tried repeatedly

810 to thrust above the massive shield of Ajax  
so that his bright spear's tip would slice his neck.

At last, the Greeks were terrified for Ajax,  
and told them both to stop and share the prizes.  
Achilles gave the sword, with belt and scabbard,  
to Diomedes, son of Tydeus.

And then Achilles, son of Peleus,  
laid out a self-cast massive weight of metal,  
which strong Lord Eetion once used to throw.  
But when swift-footed Lord Achilles killed him,  
he took this treasure with him on his fleet,  
along with all the dead king's other wealth.

820 Achilles stood up straight and told the Greeks,

“Now rise and try this competition also.  
The winner will receive this weight and use it.  
However far his fertile fields may lie  
away from town, his shepherds and his plowmen  
will never lack for iron for five years.  
They will not have to travel to the city,  
because this weight will give them all they need.”

The men who stood were valiant Polypoetes,  
godlike and strong Leonteus, great Ajax  
the son of Telamon, and fine Epeus.

830 All four lined up. Epeus seized the weight  
and whirled it round and cast. The Greeks all laughed.  
The warrior Leonteus threw next.

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1100

The third to throw was Telamonian Ajax,  
who hurled it from his sturdy hand, and reached  
far past the marks of all the other athletes.

But when brave Polypoetes lifted up  
the weight, he made it fly across the circle,  
as far as when a herdsman hurls his staff  
which spins and flies across the herd of cattle.

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The people shouted, and the winner's comrades  
stood up and took their leader's prize away  
back to his hollow ships. And then Achilles

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set out the prizes for the archery—  
ten double- and ten single-headed axes,  
all forged of purple iron. And he planted  
a ship's mast at a distance in the sand,  
and used a slender cord to tie a dove  
onto it by the foot, and told the archers  
to shoot her, saying,

1120

“Anyone who strikes  
the dove will win the double-headed axes.  
If someone misses her but strikes the cord,  
he gets the second prize, the single axes.”

At this, strong noble Teucer volunteered,  
as did the friend of Idomeneus,  
Meriones. They cast and shook the lots  
inside the helmet, which was tipped with bronze,  
and Teucer's lot fell first. He shot his arrow  
with all his might, but failed to make a vow  
to sacrifice a glorious hecatomb,  
a hundred newborn lambs for Lord Apollo.  
He missed the bird because the god begrudged him  
any success. Instead, his cruel arrow  
cut through the cord by which the dove was tied,  
and up she flew towards the sky. The rope  
dangled towards the earth. The Greeks applauded.

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Meriones soon grabbed the bow from him.  
He had already got an arrow ready  
while Teucer shot. At once, to Lord Apollo,

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the god who strikes from very far away,  
he vowed a hecatomb of newborn lambs.  
He saw the dove up high among the clouds,  
and as she turned, he shot her through the middle,  
beneath her wing, and pierced right through her body.  
The arrow fell to earth again and landed  
fixed in the ground before Meriones.

The bird alighted on the dark ship's mast,  
but hung her neck down low, and her thick plumage  
flopped and drooped downward. The swift spirit flew  
out of her body, and she tumbled down.

1150

The people were astonished and amazed.  
Meriones picked up the ten best axes,  
and Teucer took the others to his ships.

And then Achilles, son of Peleus,  
brought out and laid before them in the circle  
a spear that cast long shadows, and a cauldron,  
embossed with flowers, worth a single ox,  
that had not yet been placed upon a fire.

The javelin throwers stood—Lord Agamemnon,  
the son of Atreus, the mighty king,  
and excellent Meriones, the steward  
of Idomeneus. But swift Achilles  
said,

1160

“Son of Atreus, we know you are  
superior to everybody else.  
You are the best at power and at throwing.  
So take this prize back to your hollow ships  
and we shall give the spear, if you are willing,  
to Lord Meriones. I think we should.”

And Agamemnon, lord of men, agreed,  
and gave Meriones the spear of bronze,  
giving his own majestic, lovely prize,  
the cauldron, to Talthybius, his herald.

1170

## BOOK 24



## A Time to Mourn

The men dispersed and went their separate ways  
beside the ships and turned their minds to dinner  
and took the pleasure of sweet sleep. Achilles  
wept as he thought about the friend he loved.  
All-conquering sleep did not take hold of him.  
He rolled around this way and that, and missed  
Patroclus—his lost youth, his manly strength,  
their numerous shared adventures and achievements,  
and all the troubles they endured together  
in deadly battles and across the waves.

10

The memories made his tears fall thick and fast.  
Sometimes he lay down on his side, sometimes  
face-down, or on his back. And then at last  
he would stand up and wander on the seashore,  
out of his mind with grief. But every time  
Dawn shone along the beach and salty sea,  
he always noticed, and when he had yoked  
the lithe, quick horses to his chariot,  
he fastened Hector, to drag him behind.

Three times around the tomb of dead Patroclus

20

he rode, then stopped again at his own tent.  
There he untied the fastenings from Hector  
and lay him stretched out face-down in the dust.  
But even now in death, Apollo pitied  
Hector, and kept his body free from taint.

20 He wrapped a golden cape, an aegis, round him,  
to ensure the dragging never scratched his skin.  
The happy gods looked down and saw Achilles  
seething with rage, dishonoring great Hector.  
They pitied him, and urged farsighted Hermes,  
the giant-slayer, to go steal the body.  
This plan pleased all the other gods, but not  
Poseidon, Hera, and bright-eyed Athena.  
They still retained the same hostility  
to holy Troy and Priam and his people,  
because of the deluded recklessness  
of Paris Alexander, who insulted  
those goddesses when they came to his paddock,  
and praised the other goddess, Aphrodite,  
30 who gave him catastrophic lustfulness.  
But when the twelfth dawn came, Apollo told  
the other deathless gods,

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“You are destructive,  
cruel and heartless! Do you not remember  
how Hector burned for you fat thighs of cattle  
and goats unblemished for the sacrifice?  
Yet now you have not deigned to rescue him,  
dead though he is, to let his wife and mother  
and child and father, Priam, and his people  
see him and burn him on his funeral pyre  
with funerary offerings and rites.  
50 Instead, you want to help his murderer,  
40 Achilles, who lacks any sense of justice,  
whose mind and inmost heart refuse to bend,  
whose thoughts know only wildness—as a lion  
yields to his power and his strong proud heart,  
and pounces on the mortal flocks to feast—  
just so, Achilles has destroyed all pity.

50



He has no shame, which hurts and helps mankind.  
Others, presumably, have lost someone,  
and mourned an even greater love—a brother,  
born from the same womb, or even a son.  
And yet they set their grief and tears aside.  
The Fates gave humans an enduring heart.  
50 But this Achilles has already robbed  
great Hector of his precious life, and now  
he ties him to his chariot and drags him  
around the burial mound of his dear friend.  
This will bring him no honor, no reward.  
Watch out! Our righteous anger may condemn him,  
however fine and glorious he is.  
His seething fury shames the poor, mute earth.”

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Angrily, white-armed Hera answered him,  
“God of the silver bow, what you have said  
might have been perfectly appropriate  
if Hector and Achilles were the same  
in rank. But Hector is a mortal man,  
who suckled at a mortal woman’s breast.  
Achilles is the offspring of a goddess,  
Thetis, whom I myself cared for and raised.  
60 I gave her as a wife to Peleus,  
who is a special favorite of the immortals.  
All of you gods were present at their wedding,  
and at the feast with us you played your lyre,  
Apollo—friend of evildoers! Traitor!”

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But Zeus who gathers clouds together answered,  
“Hera, calm down. Do not be so enraged  
at other gods. These men will not be given  
identical rewards of rank and glory.  
But of all mortals in the town of Troy  
the gods love Hector most—at least I do.  
He never failed to lay upon my altar  
fat and libations as my banquet portion.  
70 We gods receive this as our prize of honor.  
But still, let us give up our plan to steal

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brave Hector from Achilles secretly.  
It is impossible. His mother, Thetis,  
is always at his side by day and night.  
Instead, let some god summon her to me,  
so I can tell her my judicious plan  
to cause Achilles to accept a ransom  
from Priam and set Hector free.”

100

At this,  
Iris leapt up as messenger, on feet  
of wind, and swooped down, between Samothrace  
and rocky Imbros, into the dark sea.  
The water groaned, and down she plummeted  
like a lead weight fixed on a piece of oxhorn,  
which brings their doom to flesh-devouring fish.  
Thetis was in a hollow cave. Around her,  
other sea goddesses were sitting clustered,  
and in the middle of them all, she wept,  
because her perfect son was going to die  
in fertile Troy, so far away from home.  
Swift-footed Iris stood near her and said,

110

“Thetis, wise Zeus whose plans are fixed forever  
calls you. Get up!”

The silver-footed goddess,  
Thetis, replied, “Why does that mighty god  
tell me to come? I am ashamed to join  
the deathless gods, when in my heart I feel  
a never-ending grief. But I will go.  
His summons shall not be in vain.”

With this,  
the goddess took a veil of indigo,  
made of the very darkest cloth, and went.  
Swift Iris led the way on feet of wind.  
The waves gave way to them and let them pass.  
They reached the shore, then flew into the sky,

120

and found far-seeing Zeus, the son of Cronus,  
and all the other gods who live forever  
gathered around him. Thetis sat beside  
her father, Zeus. Athena moved away.

Then Hera handed her a golden cup  
and greeted her with kind words. Thetis drank,  
and gave it back to her. And Zeus, the father  
of men and gods, began the conversation.

“Goddess, you came up here to Mount Olympus  
despite your sorrow. In your heart you hold  
an ever-present agony. I know it.

But I will tell you why I called you here.

There was a disagreement for nine days  
among the deathless gods about the corpse  
of Hector, and Achilles, city-sacker.

They urged farsighted Hermes, giant-slayer,  
to steal it. But instead, I fixed this glory

onto Achilles, so I would retain  
your love and your respect in future times.

Go quickly to the army. Tell your son  
the deathless gods are furious with him,  
and I am angriest of all by far,  
because in his insanity he keeps  
Hector beside his hook-beaked ships, refusing  
to let him go. So I will send down Iris  
to tell brave Priam that he has to ransom  
the son he loves so much. He needs to go  
down to the Greek ships, taking gifts to please  
the spirit of Achilles.”

So he spoke.

The silver-footed goddess Thetis heeded  
and swooped down from the peaks of Mount Olympus  
and came to her son’s tent. She found him sobbing,  
groaning with grief. Around him, loving comrades  
labored to make a meal. Inside the tent  
a big sheep with a thick fleece had been butchered.  
His mother sat down close beside Achilles

and took his hand and spoke his name and said,

130 “My child, how long will you devour your heart  
with grief and sorrow, and not think of bread  
or bed? It is a good thing, even with a woman,  
to join in love. I know quite well, you see,  
that you will not live long. Death stands already  
close at your side, and overwhelming fate.  
Now listen. I bring news to you from Zeus.  
He says the gods are furious with you,  
and he himself is angriest by far  
because in your insanity you keep  
Hector beside your hook-beaked ships, refusing  
to let him go. But come on now. Release him.  
Accept a ransom for the dead man’s body.”

170

140 Swift-footed Lord Achilles said, “So be it.  
Let someone bring the ransom here, and take  
the corpse, if Zeus himself on Mount Olympus  
commands it and desires it in his heart.”

So by the ships the mother and her son  
spoke many words on wings to one another.  
Then Zeus, the son of Cronus, sent down Iris  
to holy Troy. He said,

180

“Go swiftly, Iris,  
from Mount Olympus into holy Troy,  
and tell brave Priam that he has to ransom  
the son he loves so much. He needs to go  
down to the Greek ships, and take gifts to comfort  
the spirit of Achilles. He must go  
alone, and take no other Trojan with him,  
except an older man as his attendant,  
to drive a trundling wagon pulled by mules,  
in which he can bring back to town again  
the dead man killed by glorious Achilles.  
No fear, no thought of death should trouble him.

190

We shall send as his guide the giant-slayer,  
Hermes, who will escort him to Achilles.  
And when he has been brought inside the tent,  
Achilles will not kill him, nor allow  
anyone else to come inside. You see,  
he is not mindless, heedless, or ungodly.  
He will be kind and spare a suppliant.”

200

At this, wind-footed Iris took the message.  
She came to Priam’s house and there she found  
150 laments and cries of grief. Out in the courtyard  
the sons sat round their father, and their clothes  
were wet with tears. The old man in the middle  
was bundled like a statue in his cloak,  
covered in dung across his head and neck.  
He had rolled round in it and with his hands  
smeared it across upon himself. Inside the house,  
his daughters and his sons’ wives screamed and wept  
as they remembered all the good strong men  
who lost their lives at Greek hands and lay dead.  
The messenger of Zeus stood next to Priam,  
160 who trembled as the goddess softly whispered,

210

“Be brave, Dardanian Priam. Have no fear.  
I come here with no evil prophecy,  
but good intentions. I have come from Zeus  
to bring his words to you. From far away  
he greatly cares for you and pities you.  
Zeus orders you to ransom noble Hector  
and bring Achilles gifts to please his heart.  
You have to go alone. No other Trojan  
may go with you, except one old attendant,  
to drive the trundling wagon pulled by mules  
in which you can bring back to town again  
170 your dead son, killed by glorious Achilles.  
No fear, no thought of death should trouble you.  
The giant-slayer god will be your guide,  
Hermes, who will escort you to Achilles.  
And when you have been brought inside the tent,

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Achilles will not kill you, nor allow  
anyone else to come inside. You see,  
he is not mindless, heedless, or ungodly.  
He will be kind and spare a suppliant.”

With that, swift-footed Iris sped away.  
Then Priam told his sons to harness up  
the mules and strap them to the trundling wagon,  
and tie the hamper onto it. He went  
down to his cedar-scented high-roofed storeroom,  
which housed a multitude of precious things.  
He called to Hecuba, his wife, and told her,

“Darling, a messenger has come to me  
from Zeus on Mount Olympus, and she told me  
to go down to the Greek ships to pay ransom  
for our dear son by taking to Achilles  
gifts that may please his heart. So tell me this.  
How do you feel about this new idea?  
My spirit and my heart are strongly moved  
to go there—to the Greek camp by the ships.”

At this, his wife let out a cry and answered,  
“Where have your wits gone? You were once renowned  
for wisdom among strangers and your subjects.  
How could you even want to go alone  
down to the Greek fleet to meet that man’s eyes,  
who killed so many of our noble sons?  
Certainly you must have an iron heart.  
If he sets eyes on you and seizes you—  
that treacherous and flesh-devouring man!—  
he will not show you pity or respect.  
We sit here in our great hall far away,  
mourning our son, for whom strong Destiny  
assigned this ending when she spun his thread,  
when he was born, when I gave birth to him—  
that he would fall beneath some forceful man  
and glut the hunger of the swift-pawed dogs

far from his parents. I wish I could latch  
my teeth into the center of his liver  
and eat it! Only then would I have vengeance  
for what he did to my son, whom he killed  
but never made a coward. Hector stood  
unwavering to save the Trojan people,  
both men and women in our folded garments.  
He never thought of flight.”

270

Godlike old Priam  
answered her, “Do not try to hold me back.  
I want to go. You must not be a bird  
of evil omen in my house to me.  
You will not sway me. If this mission came  
210 from some mere mortal who lives here on earth,  
a sacrificial prophet or a priest,  
we would reject their words and call them false.  
But I myself heard all this from a goddess.  
I saw her face to face. So I will go.  
I will fulfill the quest that she described.  
And if it is my destiny to die  
beside the ships brought by the bronze-clad Greeks,  
I want that death. Indeed I hope Achilles  
kills me as soon as I have held my son  
in my own arms and had my fill of mourning.”

280

With this, he took the fine lids off the chests,  
and took out twelve extraordinary cloths,  
220 twelve single-layered cloaks, as many blankets,  
twelve bright white tunics and as many mantles.  
He weighed ten pounds of gold and added it,  
two gleaming tripods, four bowls, and a cup  
of special beauty, which the Thracians gave him  
when he had gone there on an embassy—  
a precious treasure. And old Priam spared  
nothing from his whole house, because his heart  
so yearned to ransom his beloved son.  
The Trojans clustered at his porch. He sent them  
away and scolded them with words of shame.

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300

230 “Be gone, you scum! You ought to be ashamed!  
Do you not have enough grief back at home  
that you decided to come trouble me?  
Or is it nothing to you that I lost  
my best son? Zeus has given me such pain!  
You will soon understand this loss yourselves.  
You will be easier for Greeks to kill  
now that this man is dead. I hope to go  
to Hades’ house before my old eyes see  
the city sacked and ruined.”

310

So he spoke,  
and with his scepter drove the men away,  
briskly, despite his age. They left his house.  
Then Priam called his sons and scolded them—  
Helenus, Paris, noble Agathon,  
240 Pammon, Antiphonus, strong-voiced Polites,  
Deiphobus, Hippothous, and Dios.  
The old man bitterly reproached all nine,  
and gave them orders.

“Get to work for me,  
bad children! You are an embarrassment.  
If only you had died instead of Hector,  
all of you, dead beside those quick Greek ships!  
A curse has ruined me. In spacious Troy  
I was the father of magnificent sons,  
and now, I tell you, none of them survive—  
Troilus who loved his horses, godlike Mestor,  
and Hector. Among men, he was a god.  
He was not like the son of some mere mortal,  
250 but of a god. Those sons were killed by Ares,  
and only trash is left—you tricksters, dancers,  
superb at tapping rhythms with your feet,  
thieves of your neighbors’ lambs and baby goats.  
Come on now, will you not prepare the wagon,  
and load these things upon it? Hurry up,  
so I can start my journey!”

320

330



So he spoke.

Scared by their father's scolding, they brought out  
the fine new trundling wagon drawn by mules  
and bound the hamper onto it and lifted  
the mules' yoke from the peg. The yoke was boxwood,  
set with a central boss and steering loops.

340

260 They also brought out the nine-cubit yoke strap.  
They set the yoke onto the polished pole  
correctly, on the front end, fixed the ring  
onto the peg, and wound three times around  
the boss, then wound the strap around the shaft,  
then tucked the strap's end underneath. They fetched  
out from the storeroom to the polished wagon  
the countless ransom for the head of Hector,  
then yoked the sturdy-hoofed hardworking mules,  
given to Priam by the noble Mysians  
as glorious gifts. They also yoked for Priam  
270 the horses he had reared at their fine manger  
and kept as his own steeds. Attentively,  
Priam and his companion oversaw  
these preparations in the lofty house.  
Hecuba, heartsick, came to them. She held  
in her right hand a golden cup of wine  
as sweet as honey, so that they could pour  
libations for the journey. By the horses  
she stood and spoke these words.

350

360

“Take this and pour  
an offering to father Zeus and pray  
that you come home safe from our enemies.  
Your spirit urges you towards those ships,  
although I wish you would not go. Now pray  
280 to Zeus, the son of Cronus, god of dark clouds,  
who watches over all of Troy from Ida.  
Ask him to send a quick bird messenger,  
his favorite bird, the strongest in the sky,  
to fly across our right, so you can see him  
with your own eyes and trust in him, then go  
down to the Greek ships where the foals run fast.

370

But if far-seeing Zeus sends you no message,  
then I would certainly not recommend  
that you approach the massive Greek armada,  
however eager you may be to go.”

290 Then godlike Priam answered her, “Yes, wife,  
I will not disregard your good advice.  
I know that it is good to raise one’s hands  
and pray to Zeus for mercy.”

With these words,  
the old man ordered the attendant slave girl  
to pour clean water on his hands. Beside him  
she stood and held the washing bowl and pitcher.  
He washed, then took the goblet from his wife,  
and went into the middle of the courtyard,  
and prayed and poured the wine as offering,  
and looked up to the sky and called aloud,

300 “Almighty Zeus, our father, lord of Ida,  
grant that I find, in visiting Achilles,  
kinship and pity. And send me a bird,  
as your swift messenger, your favorite bird,  
the strongest in the sky, to fly across  
my right, so I may see him with my eyes,  
and put my trust in him before I go  
down to the Greek ships where the foals run fast.”

So Priam prayed and wise Zeus heard his prayer.  
At once he sent an eagle, the dark hunter,  
known as the dappled bird. Of all that flies,  
this is the most effective, perfect sign.  
His wings stretched out on either side as far  
as an enormous treasure-chamber door,  
fitted with bolts, inside a rich man’s house.  
This eagle darted on the right of them  
310 and swooped all through the town and everyone  
was glad to see it and their hearts were joyful.

380

390

400

The old man climbed into his chariot  
and drove out through the gate and echoing porchway.  
Skillful Idaeus drove the mules, who pulled  
the four-wheeled wagon as they traveled onward.  
The horses, whipped and guided by old Priam,  
trotted behind the mule cart through the city.  
His friends and all his kinsmen followed with him,  
and wept for him as if he went to death.  
But when his sons and sons-in-law had left  
the city and come near the plain, they turned  
and traveled back to Troy. Far-seeing Zeus  
did not forget the two left on the plain.  
He saw old Priam there and pitied him,  
and quickly spoke to Hermes, his dear son.

410

“Hermes, you are the god who most enjoys  
befriending humans, and you choose to listen  
to anyone you please. Go now, take Priam  
down to the curved ships of the Greeks. Ensure  
that no one sees or notices his presence,  
until he meets the son of Peleus.”

420

Hermes, the guide, the giant-slayer, listened.  
At once, he fastened on his feet the sandals  
of fine, immortal gold, which carry him  
across the waters and the boundless earth  
as swift as breath of wind. He took his staff,  
with which he charms men’s eyes as he desires,  
and wakes them up from sleep. And holding this,  
strong Hermes flew. He reached the Hellespont  
and Troy. He touched down in a human guise.  
He looked like a young man, a magistrate,  
with beard first sprouting, the most handsome age.  
The humans drove beside the tomb of Ilus,  
then at the river made the mules and horses  
halt for a drink. Dark night already covered  
the earth. Idaeus looked around and noticed  
Hermes right next to them, and said to Priam,

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440

“Be careful, son of Dardanus! This is  
a time for cautious planning. I can see  
a man who may soon slaughter us! Come on,  
we have to mount the chariot and escape,  
or touch his knees and beg him to have mercy.”

So spoke Idaeus, and the old man’s mind  
melted, and he was terribly afraid.

The hairs stood upright on his bent old limbs.

350 He stood there, petrified. The helper, Hermes,  
came close and took the old man’s hand, and asked him,

450

“Where do you drive those mules and horses, father,  
through deathless night when other mortals sleep?

Are you not frightened of the threatening Greeks,  
your enemies, who are so near you now?

If one of them, despite the swift black night,  
sees you with all that wealth, how would you feel?

You are not young yourself, and your companion  
is far too old to ward off an attack.

360 But I will do no harm to you at all,  
and I will keep you safe from other men,  
since you remind me of my own dear father.”

460

Godlike old Priam answered, “My dear child,  
it is as you have said, and even now,  
some god has stretched his hand to save and bless me.

A god has given me the luck to meet  
so marvelous a traveler as you.

You are so handsome, wonderfully good-looking,  
intelligent, and born of lucky parents.”

The guide, the giant-slayer answered him,

470

370 “Old man, all this is true. But come, explain  
and tell me everything in every detail.

Are you transporting all this splendid treasure  
to foreigners somewhere to keep it safe?

Or are you all abandoning the city

of holy Troy, in fear because your son,  
your very finest fighter, has been killed?  
He never flinched from battle with the Greeks.”

Godlike old Priam answered, “Who are you,  
my lord? Who are your parents? You have spoken  
so beautifully about my poor son’s fate.”

480

380 The guide, the giant-slayer, answered him,  
“Sir, you are testing me. You ask these questions  
to learn from me about your noble Hector.  
I saw him often during glorious battle  
with my own eyes, and when he drove the Greeks  
back to their ships and slaughtered them and slashed them  
with sharp bronze weapons. We stood still and marveled.  
You see, Achilles did not let us fight,  
because he was enraged with Agamemnon.  
I came here with Achilles, in his ship.  
I am a Myrmidon. My father is  
wealthy Polyctor, who is old like you,  
who has six other sons. I am the seventh.  
When all of us were casting lots together,  
390 I was assigned to come here with Achilles.  
I left the ships and came out to the plain  
tonight, because the bright-eyed Greeks will start  
fighting around the city at first light.  
They are fed up with sitting doing nothing.  
400 They yearn for war. The leaders cannot stop them.”

490

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Godlike old Priam answered, “If you serve  
Achilles, son of Peleus, in war,  
tell me the whole truth. Come on. Is my son  
still by the ships, or has Achilles chopped him  
already into pieces limb by limb  
and fed him to his dogs?”

400 Hermes, the guide,  
the giant-slayer, told him, “No, old sir,

the dogs and birds have not yet eaten him.  
He lies unchanged inside Achilles' tent,  
beside the ship. He has lain there twelve days,  
and yet his flesh has suffered no decay,  
and worms, who eat men slain in war, have not  
devoured him. Achilles drags him round  
the tomb of his beloved friend each dawn,  
showing no care for him, and yet this treatment  
does not disfigure him. If you came there  
you would soon see how dewy-fresh he lies,  
his blood quite washed away. There is no taint.  
His wounds from all the blows are quite closed up,  
though many drove bronze weapons into him.  
The gods who live at ease protect your son,  
though he is dead. They love him very dearly."

510

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Joyful to hear these words, the old man answered,  
"My child, then it is good and right to give  
gifts to the deathless gods, because my son,  
if ever he existed, always kept  
the gods of Mount Olympus in his mind.  
So even after death they think of him.  
But come now, take this splendid cup from me  
and keep me safe. Escort me, with the gods,  
until I reach the tent of Lord Achilles."

530

The guide, the giant-slayer, answered him,  
"You must be testing me, because you are  
older than I am. But you will not make me  
accept your gifts without Achilles' knowledge.  
I am afraid of him and I respect him  
too much to rob him, in case something bad  
happens to me in future times. But if  
I guide you carefully on my swift ship,  
even as far away as famous Greece,  
or if I walk beside you, surely no one  
will underestimate your guide and fight you."

540

430 Then helpful Hermes leapt behind the horses  
into the chariot and promptly seized  
the reins and whip and breathed new strength and vigor  
into the horses and the mules. They reached  
the walls and ditch around the ships, and found  
the guards had just made dinner, and the guide,  
Hermes, the giant-slayer, flooded sleep 550  
over them all. Then quickly he thrust back  
the latches, opened up the gates and guided  
both Priam and the gifts atop the wagon  
inside the camp. They reached Achilles' hut,  
made by the Myrmidons for their commander.  
440 They cut down fir trees for the hut's high walls,  
then gathered bristly rushes from the meadow  
to thatch the roof on top. Round it they made  
a mighty court, marked out with thickset stakes.  
One latch of fir secured the gate. Three Greeks 560  
were needed to drive home this massive bolt,  
and three to push it open—normal Greeks.  
Achilles moved the latch all by himself.  
Then helpful Hermes opened it for Priam,  
and brought inside the presents for Achilles,  
swift-footed son of Peleus. The god  
dismounted from the chariot to the ground,  
450 and said,

“Old man, I am a deathless god,  
Hermes. My father sent me as your guide.  
Now I am going back. I will not come 570  
inside to meet Achilles face to face.  
It is forbidden for mere mortal men  
to host a deathless god. But you go in,  
and take Achilles by the knees. Beseech him,  
by his well-braided mother and his father,  
and his son also, to stir up his heart.”

With these words, Hermes left for Mount Olympus.  
Priam jumped from the chariot to the ground,  
460 and left Idaeus, who stayed there and kept

the mules and horses safe. The old king went  
 onward, inside the house. There sat Achilles,  
 a favorite of Zeus. And Priam found him  
 alone, without his comrades, who sat elsewhere,  
 except the fighting man Automedon  
 and Alcimus, a follower of Ares,  
 who kept Achilles company and served him.  
 He had just finished with his food and wine.  
 The table was still at his side. Great Priam  
 came in unnoticed. He stood near Achilles,  
 and touched his knees and kissed his hands—the terrible,  
 murderous hands, which killed so many sons.  
 As when delusion seizes hold of someone  
 who kills a man in his own fatherland,  
 and comes to a community of strangers,  
 and goes inside the house of a rich man,  
 and everyone who sees him there is shocked,  
 so was Achilles shocked when he saw Priam  
 appearing like a god. So were the others.  
 Startled, they glanced at one another. Priam  
 spoke to Achilles, and this was his prayer.

590

600

“Godlike Achilles, think of your own father,  
 who is as old as I am, standing over  
 the final threshold between age and death.  
 The people in the neighboring estates  
 probably threaten him, and there is no one  
 to save him from the danger of destruction.  
 And yet at least he hears you are alive,  
 and so his heart is glad, and every day  
 he hopes to see his own beloved son  
 come home from Troy—while I have been the most  
 unlucky man alive. In spacious Troy,  
 I had the finest sons, of whom not one  
 is left. I once had fifty, in the days  
 before the Greeks arrived. And from one womb  
 nineteen were born to me. My household women  
 bore me the others. Most of them were killed  
 by furious Ares, who undid their limbs.

610



490 I had just one who kept our town and people  
safe, and you killed him a short while ago,  
while he was fighting for his fatherland—  
Hector. I came here to your ships for him,  
to ransom him from you. I brought with me  
a countless ransom. Please, Achilles, show  
reverence towards the gods and pity me,  
remembering your father, Peleus.  
I am more pitiable than him. I have  
endured what no man yet on earth has done—  
I pressed my mouth into the hand of him  
who killed my son.”

620

This made Achilles yearn  
to mourn his father. With his hand, he gently  
took hold of the old man and pushed him back.  
Then both remembered those whom they had lost.  
500 Curled in a ball beside Achilles’ feet  
Priam sobbed desperately for murderous Hector.  
Achilles wept, at times for his own father,  
and sometimes for Patroclus. So their wailing  
suffused the house. But when godlike Achilles  
had had his fill of tears and his desire  
to weep had left his body and his mind,  
he jumped up from his chair and with his hand  
lifted the old man to his feet, in pity  
for his white hair and his white beard, and spoke  
winged words to him.

630

640

“Poor man! Your heart has suffered  
so much. How could you bear to come alone  
here to the Greek fleet to face me, who slaughtered  
510 so many of your fine and noble sons?  
Your heart is surely made of iron. Come,  
sit on a chair, and let us hide our grief  
inside ourselves, despite our bitter sorrow.  
Nothing can be achieved by cold lamenting.  
The gods have spun for all unlucky mortals  
a life of grief, while nothing troubles them.

650

Two jars are set upon the floor of Zeus—  
from one, he gives good things, the other, bad.  
When thundering Zeus gives somebody a mixture,  
520 their life is sometimes bad and sometimes good.  
But those he serves with unmixed suffering  
are wretched. Terrible starvation drives them  
across the shining world. They have no honor  
from gods or mortals. Even so, the gods  
gave splendid gifts to Peleus from birth.  
He was more fortunate than anyone,  
the wealthiest, most prosperous of men.  
He was the ruler of the Myrmidons,  
and though he was a mortal man, the gods  
gave him a goddess as a wife. And yet  
the god laid suffering on him as well.  
He did not father any sons as heirs  
530 inside his halls, except one short-lived child.  
I will not care for him in his old age,  
because I sit so far away from home  
at Troy. My sole concern is causing pain  
to you and to your children. And we hear  
that even you were lucky once, old man.  
From Lesbos out to sea, the land of Macar,  
to Phrygia and the boundless Hellespont,  
you were, they say, supreme in wealth and sons.  
But ever since the gods who live in heaven  
brought you this pain, your town has been surrounded  
by constant carnage and unending warfare.  
You must endure it. Do not let your heart  
540 lament forever. You will do no good  
by grieving for your son. You cannot raise him  
to life again, and death will overtake you  
before you save your son.”

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Godlike old Priam  
answered him, “Favorite of Zeus, do not  
ask me to sit down yet, while Hector lies  
neglected in your dwelling. Quickly, hurry,  
release him, let me see him with my eyes!

And take the countless ransom I have brought you.  
I wish you joy of it and hope you reach  
your fatherland, because you spared my life  
and let me live and see the sun's bright light."

690

550 Swift-footed Lord Achilles scowled at him,  
and said, "Do not enrage me now, old man.  
I had myself already planned to give you  
Hector. A messenger was sent by Zeus  
to me— my mother, who gave birth to me,  
the goddess daughter of the old sea god.  
Moreover, Priam, I know who you are,  
and it does not escape me that some god  
escorted you towards the swift Greek ships.  
No mortal man, however young and healthy,  
would dare to venture to the enemy camp.  
No mortal man could have got past the guards  
nor pushed the latch back from our gates with ease.  
Do not stir up my grieving heart too much.  
Stop now, old man, or else I will not spare you,  
although you are a suppliant in my tent,  
560 and I would violate the laws of Zeus."

700

710

So spoke Achilles. The old man was frightened,  
and did as he was told. Achilles leapt  
up like a lion and dashed out the door—  
not by himself but with his two attendants,  
warlike Automedon and Alcimus,  
the comrades whom he held in greatest honor  
after Patroclus died. Then they unyoked  
the horses and the mules, and led inside  
the herald who accompanied old Priam,  
and seated him. Then from the polished wagon  
they brought the boundless ransom for the head  
570 of Hector. But they left a fine-spun tunic  
and two cloths, so Achilles could wrap up  
the corpse before he gave it to the Trojans  
to take back home. He called his women slaves  
and ordered them to wash and oil the body.

720

He brought it to the women privately,  
so Priam would not see his son, in case  
the sight of him might make his grieving heart  
unable to contain his rage, and then

730

Achilles would himself be roused at heart,  
and kill him, and transgress the laws of Zeus.  
The women washed him and anointed him  
with olive oil and dressed him in the tunic  
and wrapped him in a fine cloth. Then Achilles  
lifted him up himself and set him down  
upon a bier, and with his comrades raised it  
onto the polished wagon. Then he groaned,  
and called his friend, the man he loved,

580

“Patroclus,  
do not be angry with me if the news  
reaches you even in the house of Hades  
that when his loving father offered me  
a proper ransom, I gave Hector back.  
I will divide the ransom gifts with you,  
and you shall have fair shares.”

740

Then great Achilles  
went back inside the hut and sat back down  
upon his well-wrought chair by the far wall,  
and spoke to Priam.

“Now your son has been  
released to you, just as you asked. He lies  
upon a bier, and when Dawn shows her light,  
you will see him yourself and take him home.  
But now we need to turn our minds to dinner.  
Remember, even noble Niobe  
took thought of food, although she lost twelve children—  
six daughters, six strong sons inside her house.  
Apollo shot his silver bow and killed  
the sons in anger at the woman’s boasting,  
while Artemis, who takes delight in arrows,

590

750

destroyed the daughters, because Niobe  
compared herself to Leto, who, she said,  
gave birth to only two, while she herself  
had mothered many children. Then those two,  
small as their number was, destroyed them all.

760

600 Nine days the children lay besmeared in blood,  
with nobody to bury them, because  
Zeus turned the population into stone.

But on the tenth day, the Olympian gods  
buried them. And then Niobe took thought  
of eating. She was tired of shedding tears.

770

Now on the lonely peaks among the rocks  
upon Mount Sipylus, where goddesses  
have their abodes, or so they say—the nymphs  
who dance around the River Achelous—  
great Niobe, although she is a rock,  
consumes the sorrows sent her by the gods.

Come then, my lord, let us remember also  
to eat. Then later, you will take to Troy  
the son you loved so much and weep for him.

610 Certainly he will cause you many tears.”

Then swift Achilles leapt up. And he slaughtered  
a white sheep, which his comrades skinned and butchered  
carefully, sliced it up with skill and stuck it  
on skewers, roasted it painstakingly,  
then pulled the pieces off. Automedon  
brought bread and set it out in pretty baskets  
onto the table, while Achilles carved  
the meat. They reached their hands to take the food.

780

But when their hunger and their thirst were sated,  
Dardanian Priam marveled at Achilles—

620 his size, his beauty. He looked like the gods.

790

Achilles marveled at Dardanian Priam—  
his fine appearance and the words he spoke.  
They gazed at one another in surprise.  
Then first, godlike old Priam spoke.

“Now quickly

lay me in bed, my lord, so we may rest,  
and take the pleasure of sweet sleep at once.  
My eyelids have not closed my weary eyes  
since my son lost his life, killed by your hands.  
I have been groaning constantly, consuming  
infinite sorrows. I rolled round in dung,  
inside the inner quarters of my courtyard.  
Now I have had my fill of food, and swallowed  
this bright-faced wine, although, before this time,  
I tasted nothing.”

630

800

Then Achilles ordered  
his comrades and his women slaves to lay  
beds on the porch, spread with fine purple blankets,  
and lay out quilts across, with woolen cloaks  
to cover them on top. The women went  
out of the room with torches in their hands  
and working hard, they soon prepared two beds.  
Swift-footed Lord Achilles spoke to him  
ironically and said to him,

810

“Sleep there  
outside, old friend, in case some Greek comes here,  
a councillor. They always sit with me  
and form their plans with me, as is correct.  
But if, despite the darkness of swift night,  
one of them saw you, he would go at once  
and tell the people’s shepherd, Agamemnon.  
The ransom of the corpse would be delayed.  
But come now, tell me this and tell me truly—  
how many days do you intend to mourn  
during the funeral for noble Hector?  
For that duration, I will not make war,  
and I will hold the army back from battle.”

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Godlike old Priam answered, “If you let me  
arrange a proper funeral for Hector,  
Achilles, I would certainly be grateful.

650

You know we are besieged inside the city.  
We have to gather wood from far away  
upon the mountain, and the Trojans are  
frightened to leave the town and go and get it.  
So let us mourn him in our home nine days,  
and on the tenth we hold his funeral,  
and let the people feast. On the eleventh  
we make a mound in memory of him.  
Then on the twelfth day, we will fight again,  
if that must be.”

830

660                                Swift-footed Lord Achilles  
answered him, “Old King Priam, this will happen  
as you request. I will hold back the war  
as long as you have asked.”

                                         With this, he took  
the old man’s right hand by the wrist, to calm  
his heart, so that he would not be afraid.  
Then Priam and his herald went to bed  
out on the porch, their minds concocting plans.  
Achilles slept inside the well-built hut,  
and with him lay the beautiful Briseis.

840

670                                The other gods and men who marshal horses  
slept through the night, subdued by gentle sleep.  
But sleep did not take hold of helpful Hermes.  
His mind was mulling over how to bring  
King Priam back in secret from the ships,  
without the knowledge of the hallowed guards.  
He stood at Priam’s head and said to him,

850

“Old man, you seem to sleep without a care  
amid your enemies, now that Achilles  
has spared your life. You ransomed your dear son,  
and paid a lavish price. But soon your sons  
who still survive will pay three times that ransom  
to get you back alive, if Agamemnon,

the son of Atreus, and other Greeks  
discover you are here.”

860

At this, old Priam  
was frightened and he woke up his attendant.  
680 And Hermes yoked their horses and their mules,  
and swiftly drove them through the camp himself,  
and no one saw them. When they reached the ford  
of the smooth streams and swirls of River Xanthus,  
who had been fathered by immortal Zeus,  
there Hermes left and went to high Olympus,  
while in her saffron-colored garments, Dawn  
spread out across the world. They drove the horses  
to Troy with tears and groans of grief. The mules  
carried the corpse. Of all the men and women,  
the first to see them coming was Cassandra,  
golden as Aphrodite. She had gone  
690 up to the Pergamum. From there, she saw  
her father in the carriage, with the herald,  
the city messenger. She also saw  
him on the mule cart, lying on the bier.  
She shrieked and shouted out through all the city,

870

“Come, Trojans, look at Hector, if you ever  
rejoiced to see him coming home from battle  
alive! He was a joy to all our people.”

880

At this, no man or woman stayed in Troy.  
Intolerable grief possessed them all.  
They clustered at the gates and there met Priam,  
bringing the corpse. Two women were the first  
700 to mourn for Hector, tearing out their hair—  
the queen his mother, and his loving wife.  
They hurled themselves against the trundling wagon,  
reaching to touch his head. The crowd stood round  
and wept. The whole day long they would have stayed  
beside the entryway of Troy till sunset,  
grieving for Hector, had not old king Priam

890



addressed the people from his chariot.

“Give way and let me drive the mules inside.  
You can lament till you are satisfied  
once I have brought him home.”

They stood aside  
and let the wagon pass. The two men drove  
towards the palace, where they laid him out  
upon a bedstead pierced with crisscross ropes  
and set beside him singers to begin  
the songs of lamentation. These men sang  
the mournful dirge. The women wailed in answer.  
White-armed Andromache, among the women,  
began the keening, cradling in her arms  
the head of murderous Hector.

900

“You died young,  
husband, and left me in your house a widow.  
Your boy is still a little child, a son  
born from unlucky parents—you and me—  
and I do not believe he will grow up.  
Before that time, this town will be destroyed  
from top to bottom, because you are dead,  
the one who guarded and watched over Troy,  
and kept the wives and little children safe.  
In hollow ships the women will be soon  
taken as slaves, and I along with them.  
And you, my child, will either come with me,  
and do humiliating work, enslaved  
to some harsh overlord, or else a Greek  
will grab your arm and hurl you from the wall—  
a dreadful death—in anger because Hector  
had killed perhaps his brother, son, or father.  
Numerous Greeks were seized by Hector’s hands  
and took the boundless earth between their teeth.  
Your father was not gentle in grim battle.  
Therefore the people in the city mourn him,

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and you piled grief and sorrow on your parents,  
Hector, and left me the worst pain of all.  
In death, you did not reach your arms from bed  
to me, or leave me with some final words  
that I could have forever kept in mind  
while crying night and day.”

930

In tears she spoke.  
The women wailed in answer. Then among them  
Hecuba sobbed and led the lamentation.

740 “Hector, by far the dearest to my heart  
of all my children, when you were alive  
the gods loved you, and even in your death  
they care for you. Swift-footed Lord Achilles  
enslaved and sold the other sons he captured,  
in lands beyond the unrelenting sea,  
Samothece, Imbros, and volcanic Lemnos.  
He took your life with his sharp bronze and dragged you  
despoiled around the tomb of his companion,  
Patroclus, whom you killed. But even so  
he could not raise him back to life again.  
Now you lie here at home in dewy freshness,  
as if Apollo shot his silver bow  
and with his gentle arrows took your life.”

940

750 In tears she spoke and roused unending mourning.  
And Helen was the third to lead the women  
in lamentation, and she spoke among them.

950

“Hector, by far the dearest to my heart  
of all the brothers of my husband, Paris,  
the godlike man who brought me here to Troy.  
I wish that I had died before that day.  
It has been twenty years since I came here  
and left my fatherland. But all that time  
I never heard an insult or bad word  
from you. If any kinfolk in the house

spoke unkind words to me—my husband's sisters,  
 or brothers, or their wives in pretty dresses,  
 or even my mother-in-law—my husband's father  
 760 treated me like a daughter of his own—  
 you talked them out of it, protecting me  
 with your sweet kindness and your gentle words.  
 So I am sick at heart with grief, and mourn  
 for you and for my own bad luck. No other  
 in spacious Troy was kind to me like you.  
 All of them shudder in disgust at me.”

She spoke in tears. The countless crowd of people  
 wailed in response. Old Priam told the Trojans,

“Now gather wood and bring it to the city,  
 and fear no ambush from the Greeks. Achilles  
 promised me, when he let me go away  
 770 from his black ships, that they will not attack us  
 until the twelfth dawn comes.”

At this they yoked  
 oxen and mules to carts and soon assembled  
 in front of town and for nine days they gathered  
 abundant wood. But when the tenth bright Dawn  
 brought light to mortals, they brought out brave Hector,  
 with tears and weeping, and they laid his body  
 upon the towering pyre and lit the flames.  
 When newborn Dawn appeared with rosy fingers,  
 the people gathered round the funeral pyre  
 780 of famous Hector. Once they were assembled  
 they quenched the pyre with shining wine, wherever  
 it smoldered. Then his brothers and companions,  
 their faces soaked with tears, still sobbing hard,  
 collected up his white bones, which they carried  
 and laid inside a golden chest and set  
 soft purple cloths to cover them and quickly  
 lowered the chest into a fresh-dug grave  
 and heaped large stones on top, set close together.

Soon they piled high the mound and round about it  
stood guards on every side, in case the Greeks  
attacked too soon in all their splendid armor.  
After the mound was built, they went back home,  
then came together for a glorious banquet  
inside divine King Priam's house. And so  
they held the funeral for horse-lord Hector.

## NOTES

*All line-number references are keyed to the lineation of the translation, except where I indicate specifically that the reference is to the Greek (as in “see Greek line xxx”).*

### BOOK 1 SUMMARY

The allied Greek armies have been encamped on the shore of Troy for just over nine years, besieging but failing to capture the city, and sacking neighboring towns, killing the men, looting, and enslaving the women. The most valuable items of loot, including the most highly prized enslaved women, are shared out among the most powerful warriors in the Greek alliance. One of these enslaved women is the daughter of a priest of Apollo, who prays to the god to get his daughter back. The god responds by sending plague to the Greek camp. The prophet Calchas explains to the Greek leaders that the priest's daughter needs to be returned to her father. Agamemnon, the most powerful member of the Greek alliance, agrees to return her, but insists on taking another trophy woman for himself from Achilles. Achilles, robbed of his trophy and dishonored, is furious, and complains to his mother, Thetis, a sea goddess. The goddess asks Zeus to restore her son's honor by ensuring that, as long as Achilles absents himself from battle, the Greeks will lose in battle, and vast numbers of Greeks will die—thus demonstrating that the Greeks need Achilles to win. Zeus agrees with a nod. The gods on Olympus enjoy a feast, and a squabble between Zeus and Hera is quickly resolved, thanks to the intervention of their son, Hephaestus.

- 1.1 *Goddess* : The goddess, *thea* , is unnamed but is presumably the Muse of epic poetry, Calliope.
- 1.1 *cataclysmic wrath* : “Wrath,” *mēnis*, is an especially intense and destructive kind of anger; the word is usually used only for gods. This translation distinguishes between *mēnis* , “wrath,” and its cognates, and the various other words for “rage,” “anger,” or “fury” (such as *cholos* ).

- 1.4** *noble souls* : The narrator contrasts the “souls,” *psychai* , with the living men (*autous* ), because the person is identified with the physical self; only a shadow survives in the underworld. The identification of the corpse with the person may help to explain the crucial importance of proper burial in the world of this poem.
- 1.6** *a banquet for the birds* : An alternative ancient textual reading of this line, followed in the Oxford Classical Text, reads, “for all the birds” (*oionoisi te pasi* ) rather than “a banquet for the birds” (*oionoisi te daita* ), but I follow the reading *daita* , “banquet,” because the idea of the anthropomorphic banquet of birds parallels the “spoils” gathered by the dogs. Thanks to the infighting of Greek leaders, the animals gain what the humans hope for—to despoil their enemies and celebrate victory with a triumphant banquet.
- 1.6** *the plan / of Zeus* : It is unspecified and unclear what exactly the plan of Zeus entails; it must include, at a minimum, the plan formed between Zeus and Thetis later in Book 1, but it may also include the whole plan of the Trojan War. The verb *eteleieto* , “was moving to its end,” in the imperfect tense, suggests that the process of moving to an end or fulfilment (*telos* ), whether in the poem’s plot or in the plans of Zeus, is ongoing and perhaps never-ending. There may be a veiled reference to a myth (not told in the poem but referenced in the *Cypria*, a lost poem of which a summary and some fragmentary quotations survive) of Zeus’ plan to reduce the human population by a massive war. Homeric syntax is usually fairly straightforward, but this poem begins with an unusually long, circuitous sentence, which creates ambiguity about where one action ends and another begins.
- 1.12** *Furious at the son . . . disrespect* : The “son of Atreus” is Agamemnon. This sentence illustrates a pattern in Homeric narrative technique that will become familiar as the poem continues, but is likely to feel alien on first encounter and appears here in a particularly compressed form. Events are told out of chronological order, so that the listener is invited to think backward through time, rather than in the linear fashion that may be expected by the literate reader. Chronologically, the events described are: Agamemnon dishonored the priest of Apollo (the scene that is about to be described); the god was angry; the god aroused plague in the Greek camp; the plague, and the need to placate the angry god, led to the conflict between Agamemnon and Achilles.
- 1.19** *his daughter* : For the past nine years, the Greek invading army has been sacking the cities adjacent to Troy, which presumably have less sturdy defensive walls. These sacks of other cities are the source of the wealth and food supplies in the Greek camp, and of the enslaved women claimed by the various Greek warriors. Chryses’ daughter, Chryseis, is one of the women from the region around Troy who has been abducted and enslaved by the Greek troops. She is a high-status trophy because she is the daughter of a priest, and she is unusual among the captive women

because she has a surviving male family member to rescue her, who also has the support of a powerful deity. The normal practice during the sack of a town is to enslave all the women and slaughter all the men, so there is usually nobody left to rescue captive women.

**1.20** *his sacred diadem* : The diadem is a thin cloth headband that signifies the priest's religious position and sanctity. He wraps it around the staff to appear bareheaded, as a gesture of supplication. Gold, the most precious of metals, suggests the priest's exalted status, and his association with the shining god of the sun.

**1.25** *the sons of Atreus* : The two sons of Atreus are Menelaus of Sparta, husband of Helen, over whom the war is being fought, and Agamemnon of Argos, his brother, who leads the largest contingent of warriors. In a coalition of forces with many co-equal leaders, these two are special in that they are the initiators of the expedition to Troy.

**1.57** *Mouse Lord* : This rare epithet of Apollo as the god of mice (*Smintheus* , probably from *sminthos* , “mouse”) may hint at the association between small rodents and plague; Apollo is the god of both plague and healing. Alternatively, the title might refer to a place named Sminthos or Sminthe, where Apollo perhaps had a cult.

**1.62** *Phoebus* : Phoebus is a common title of Apollo.

**1.100** *favorite of Zeus* : It is a common formula for male leaders in Homer to be described as “favorite of Zeus,” “loved by Zeus,” or “Zeus-born” (*Dii philos* or *diotrophos* ), even if Zeus is not showing them any particular favor at that moment, and even if they are not in fact related to Zeus. This formula underlines the close association between Zeus and mortal men who hold positions of authority.

**1.137** *a hecatomb to Chryse* : A hecatomb is a large animal sacrifice (literally a hundred animals, or by extension, any large number). The place where the priest Chryses lives is called Chryse; his daughter is called, after him, Chryseis.

**1.141** *his black heart* : The interior of the body is generally represented as “black,” because there is no light inside, but the color also connotes fury (as if a black cloud is inside the person).

**1.176** *brave and skillful* : Agamemnon's language acknowledges Achilles' prowess as a warrior and raider (he is “brave and skillful,” *agathos* ) but also conflates those skills with trickery; he cannot “rob” a prize from Agamemnon (as he has done so often from non-Greek opponents) or “get ahead” of him in an argument, despite his quick mind and quick feet.

**1.197** *the wildest, most aggressive man alive* : Agamemnon uses the superlative of an adjective (*ekpaglos* ) that can connote excess, violence or shock, although in post-Homeric usage it is often positive, suggesting “extraordinary” or “amazing.”

**1.214** *compensation . . . dog-face* : In Greek the same word, *timē*, connotes compensation or payback (in this case, for the abduction of Helen by Paris) and

glory. The Trojan War is represented as motivated by a desire both to restore or reclaim lost property and to generate more status for the Atreid brothers. The word translated as “dog-face” is *kunopa* (from *kunops*), a compound from “dog” (*kuo<sup>-</sup>n*) and “face” or “eye” (*ops*). The same term is used by Helen of herself at 3.223 and in *The Odyssey* (4.145).

**1.221** *sack any wealthy Trojan town* : The towns adjacent to Troy, in the region known as the Troad, are also described as “Trojan.”

**1.229** *serving up wealth* : “Serving up” echoes the slightly odd usage of the original verb *aphusso* : the language suggests that Achilles sees himself as a cupbearer (a menial role often performed by enslaved people), serving the wine of wealth for Agamemnon.

**1.257** *hairy chest* : The “hairy” or “woolly” chest (*lasios*, a word also used of sheep, goats, and bushes) is a mark of warrior strength. The Homeric poems tend to imagine emotional states as localized in particular parts of the body.

**1.273** *the royal aegis* : Zeus is regularly described as “aegis-bearing,” *aigiochoios*, although Athena and Apollo also bear, carry, or wear the aegis at times. The aegis functions as a symbol of Zeus’ authority over the sky and the other gods. The object seems to be originally imagined as a goatskin. It is derived etymologically from *aix/aigos*, “goat,” and is also equated with a storm cloud; presumably the goatskin cape of Zeus causes clouds and storms, when he shakes it across the sky. An aegis could be either a skin worn alone as a sash or wrap, or a skin stretched over a solid shield.

**1.274** *cruel violence* : The Greek word *hybris* suggests an illegitimate or wanton kind of violence, motivated by arrogance. The modern English word “hubris,” a loanword from ancient Greek, is different in its connotations, because it suggests pride but not necessarily abusive action.

**1.310** *nonentities* : The Greek word for “nonentities,” *outidanoi*, sounds like the title of one of the groups of Greek warriors, the Danaans; Achilles is mocking the forces led by Agamemnon, implying that if they were somebodies, not nobodies, they would have challenged his abuse of power.

**1.314** *this staff* : The staff is a speaking stick, held in turn by the members of the elite warrior council when they address the crowd, and used as a mark of legitimacy in trials. Achilles’ oath creates an analogy between the stick—which loses its home in order to serve the assembly meeting—and the experiences of warriors such as himself, who leave their home and family to gain honor in war.

**1.338** *he ruled the third* : I.e., he ruled the third generation, having outlived the first two. A generation is usually calculated as twenty or thirty years—the length of time for babies to grow up and have their own babies.



- 1.357** *the strongest mountain beasts* : A reference to the Centaurs, the wild half-man, half-horse beings who lived in mountains and fought against the Thessalian men named Lapiths at the wedding feast between Pirithous, king of the Lapiths, and Hippodamia. All the guests drank too much, and the Centaurs tried to abduct Hippodamia; when the fight broke out, other Greek allies, including Theseus, were involved on the Lapith side. The idea that Nestor's diplomacy ended this mythical battle may be an invention specifically for this poem; it is not attested elsewhere.
- 1.359** *and alone I went* : Nestor was "alone" in the sense that he had not brought troops or a chariot and charioteer with him from Pylos when he came to join the wedding party. He was fighting on the Lapith side against the Centaur.
- 1.378** *the great defense* : The metaphor of Achilles as a "defense," *erkos* , suggests that he is functionally comparable to the walls of Troy, which provide a semimagical barrier against the enemy.
- 1.387** *must his insulting slanders sprint ahead* : Agamemnon is suggesting that "swift-footed Achilles" is going too far in using his ability as a sprinter as grounds to win a metaphorical "race" of words.
- 1.388** *interrupted him* : The abrupt tone of the speech is underlined by the unusual fact that Achilles includes no title or term of address for Agamemnon, not even his name.
- 1.396** *to fight with you / about a woman* : Achilles is refusing to fight physically (as opposed to verbally) "about a woman" in two senses: he will not fight with Agamemnon about Briseis, and he will not fight the Trojans about Helen.
- 1.418** *to cleanse themselves* : The language suggests both literal and spiritual cleansing; the men are purifying themselves from pollution as well as getting clean.
- 1.422** *the barren sea* : The sea is usually barren (a formulaic epithet), because no crops grow there.
- 1.423** *the savor* : The "savor," *knisē* , refers both to the burnt fat of the animal and its smell, which is imagined to rise up to the gods.
- 1.474** *her father* : Thetis' father is Nereus, a sea god.
- 1.483** *We went to Thebe / . . . looted everything* : It is peculiar to mention the sack of Thebe when Chryseis was supposed to come from Chryse. The discrepancy reminds us of something unusual about Chryseis: like Helen, but unlike all other abducted women in the poem, she still has a home to go back to.
- 1.512** *rage seized Agamemnon* : Whereas Achilles' "wrath" of the opening line of the poem is described as *mēnis*, Agamemnon is seized by anger that is not extraordinary or divine: *cholos* (the word from which we get the English "choler" and "choleric").
- 1.516** *offerings for the god* : I.e., the hecatomb of sacrificial animals to be killed for Apollo.

- 1.528** *tried / to bind him* : The story here is not referred to elsewhere and seems to be an invention for the purpose of this scene. The implied backstory is that there was a coup by the Olympians against the authority of Zeus, which Zeus resisted with the help of Thetis and the giant Briareus. Hesiod (*Theogony* 617ff.) tells a more conventional story of conflict between Zeus and the other Olympian gods against the Titans. The gods who are said to have tried to bind Zeus—Poseidon, Hera, and Athena—are Zeus’ opponents in *The Iliad* , favoring the Greek side against the Trojans.
- 1.533** *name him Aegeon* : The idea that gods and humans use different names for things occurs several times in Homer.
- 1.543** *all of them can profit* : The use of *epaurontai* , “profit,” here is ironic: the result of having Agamemnon as leader is death.
- 1.561** *Yesterday, Zeus went off* : The absence of Zeus is surprising since Thetis has just implied that she will go directly to Zeus on Olympus. The inconsistency may be the result of oral composition.
- 1.622** *cables of the ship* : The cables are used to moor the ship to the beach. The men sleep on the beach beside these ropes.
- 1.638** *where men gain / glory* : The epithet rendered “where men gain glory” (*kudianeiros* ) is elsewhere used exclusively for battle, the primary sphere for winning social status. The variation offered here reminds us that Achilles’ alienation from his own allies and comrades cuts him off from a crucial mechanism for attaining honor.
- 1.651** *her left hand grasped / . . . beneath his chin* : This is the traditional posture of supplication, touching the knee and the chin (or beard, if available).
- 1.659** *Wise Zeus* : Zeus is regularly “wise” or “associated with *mētis*, [cunning intelligence, wisdom, strategic thinking].” The children of Metis, a Titan, were foretold to be very powerful, so when Zeus got her pregnant, he swallowed her and possessed her power. Athena, their daughter, sprang directly from his head.
- 1.738** *noble feasting. Baser things* : There are connotations of class hierarchy in the distinction between the “noble” feast and the “baser” quarrel over humans.
- 1.759** *on Lemnos* : The island of Lemnos was the main cult center for the god Hephaestus, because its volcano, Mount Moschylus, emitted fiery asphaltic gas (as if a god were practicing metallurgy inside the mountain). The Greeks colonized the area in the ninth century BCE; the Sintians are the pre-Greek native inhabitants.
- 1.763** *poured it left to right* : The cupbearer pours the wine for each god in turn, from the left to right side of the room.
- 1.765** *Ebullient laughter* : Ancient commentators explained that the laughter is prompted by watching the awkward movements of Hephaestus, who is alone among the Olympians in having a distinctive body and gait. The scene creates a ring

composition in Book 1, which begins with a human conflict and ends with a divine one.

**1.770** *exchanging lovely voices* : I.e., antiphonal singing.

## BOOK 2 SUMMARY

Zeus sends a personified dream to Agamemnon, to tell him he can take the city of Troy. Agamemnon tests the troops' morale by telling them to sail home—which they try to do. Odysseus and Nestor help rouse the men for war, and Odysseus beats a subordinate warrior named Thersites, who speaks out against the expedition and Agamemnon's leadership. Athena rouses the fighters. The narrator catalogs the leaders of the Greek ships assembled at Troy, as well as the most prominent horses, and the Trojan leaders and their allies. The scene echoes a mythical event not told directly in the poem: the beginning of the Greek expedition, when the ships gathered at Aulis to set sail for Troy.

**2.18** *Disaster has been fastened* : The metaphor of fastening disaster or suffering onto the Trojans suggests that trouble is now inevitable. Ancient critics worried that Zeus is outright lying here; Aristotle quotes a different version of this line that reduces the theological problem: “and we give glory for her to take” (*Poetics* 25.1461a22).

**2.60** *The goddess Dawn / . . . portending light* : Dawn appears many times in both *The Iliad* and *The Odyssey*, but this is an unusual variation on the more usual “rosy-fingered Dawn.”

**2.91** *as is the custom* : There is no evidence that there was ever such a custom. Agamemnon is borrowing language from true customs (such as the custom to pour libations or swear an oath for an important agreement), and transferring it to his bizarre new “custom” of testing troops before battle by ordering them to give up—a notably ineffective strategy.

**2.120** *the staff / . . . Hermes, lord and guide* : This passage describes the history of Agamemnon's special “ancestral” staff. Hermes is the “guide” because he is the messenger of the gods and the escort of gods and humans from one realm to another. At the bequest of Zeus, Hermes killed the giant Argos, who had been appointed by Zeus' wife Hera to guard Io, with whom Zeus wanted to have sex.

**2.126** *Pelops* : Pelops won his wife, Hippodamia, by cheating in a chariot race. All those listed here are known for deceit and treachery: Zeus usurped his father Cronus; Hermes stole Apollo's cattle; Pelops won his bride by trickery; Thyestes usurped the throne of Atreus; Atreus killed his brother Thyestes' children and fed them to him.

**2.128** *rich in lambs* : The epithet “rich in lambs” suggests wealth. It may also refer to the specific source of wealth and power in Mycenae: a golden lamb, used by

Thyestes to legitimate his usurpation of the throne.

**2.130** *to hold and rule* : The inherited staff establishes Agamemnon's ancestral power—contrasting with the staff held by Achilles in Book 1 (1.314), which is not an heirloom.

**2.135** *That cruel god* : No mortal elsewhere in Homer calls Zeus “cruel,” *schetlios* . Agamemnon's self-aggrandizement skates close to impiety.

**2.135** *gave his nod* : As in 1.167 and elsewhere, the nod of Zeus is supposed to bind him to his oath.

**2.154** *to pour our wine* : Wine pouring was a servile task, usually performed by underlings, boys, or slaves. Agamemnon insults the Trojans at the same time as attacking his own side.

**2.159** *preventing me* : Agamemnon uses the first-person singular, suggesting that success or failure in taking Troy belongs to him alone, not the collective Greek forces.

**2.171** *at sea / beside Icaria* : The sea south of Icaria (modern-day Ikaria), a Greek island in the Aegean, is particularly rough.

**2.178** *drag / the ships* : During the siege, the ships are left dragged up high on the beach, beyond the waterline; the men have to dig furrows in the sand to make it easier to get them back into the sea. They also have to remove the props under the ships that keep them upright on dry land.

**2.223** *A spirit has possessed you* : Odysseus addresses both the elite and nonelite warriors with the same word, *daimonie* , “spirit-possessed” (*daimon* is a word for an unknown divine force). The word is used only to speak to somebody in the second person, to express a sense that the person's behavior has gone beyond human norms and can be explained only by divine possession.

**2.224** *a coward or a peasant* : Odysseus tactfully avoids spelling out the threat that is explicit when he talks to the lower-class fighters.

**2.236** *shouting* : As described above, the men are shouting to one another to launch the ships.

**2.240** *unfit for battle* : Paradoxically, telling the men they are unfit for battle is a way of pushing them to fight.

**2.243** *It is not good for many to share power* : The original uses a single compound noun, *polykoirane* , for “the rule of many” or polycracy. This word appears in Homer only here.

**2.247** *the ruler makes the plans for other men* : I translate the emended text from the Oxford Classical Text, reading *bouleueisi* (“makes plans”) instead of the unmetrical manuscript reading, *basileuei*, “rules.”

**2.248** *masterfully* : Having just said that only one man must be “master” (*koiranos* ), Odysseus himself is said to command the army “masterfully” (*koiraneo* ).

- 2.259** *the ugliest man who marched on Troy* : Ugliness is both a physical and moral or social quality. Thersites seems to pose a critique of heroic epic from the perspective of other archaic Greek poetic genres, such as comedy and iambos (a satiric genre centering on blame and criticism).
- 2.267** *blamed him inside their hearts* : The common soldiers may be angry that their lives are in the hands of an incompetent leader, or they may blame Thersites. The scene is ambivalent about whether Thersites is an outlier, or a representative of the ordinary oppressed majority.
- 2.281** *Sweethearts* : Thersites uses a term that literally suggests “ripe ones” (as if the addressees were sweet, ripe fruit), and is used elsewhere always as an endearment—for instance, in Polyphemus’ address to his beloved ram in *Odyssey* Book 9. Here, it is clearly being used as an insult.
- 2.308** *You sit there* : Strictly speaking, Thersites was standing, not sitting, while he talked. “You sit doing that” may be a metaphorical way of expressing the idea of continuous action.
- 2.318** *the father of Telemachus* : In general, warriors in the Homeric poems define themselves as the sons of their fathers; Odysseus is unusual in defining himself as the father of his son.
- 2.330** *The men were troubled* : There is ambiguity about what exactly troubles the men. The most common interpretation is that they are, as they declare, bothered by Thersites’ behavior and happy to see him silenced and humiliated. An alternative possibility is that they are troubled by Odysseus’ brutal treatment of a whistleblower, which they must then effusively praise for their own survival.
- 2.337** *his strong proud heart* : A “strong proud heart,” a gendered quality in the language of the original, is usually associated with elite warriors. Thersites, whose objections to Agamemnon’s leadership echo those of Achilles, has the psychological characteristics of the most elite fighters, but without the physical abilities, good looks, and social connections to support his self-assertion.
- 2.340** *straightened up* : This sentence could suggest that Odysseus stood up, but we have not been told that he sat down after the previous speech.
- 2.368** *lately* : Literally, “yesterday and the day before”: a common idiom in later Greek to mean “recently.”
- 2.387** *converted him / into a sign* : I follow the manuscript reading (and the Oxford Classical Text). However, some editors believe that this line should instead say that Zeus, who made the snake visible, then made him invisible, or inconspicuous (*aizelos* , not *arizelos* ).
- 2.429** *to pay for Helen’s sufferings and struggles* : As ancient scholars noted, the line is ambiguous. It seems to suggest the sufferings of Helen herself; but most modern

commentators, and Aristarchus in antiquity, take it that the line refers to the sufferings caused by Helen, not experienced by her.

**2.437** *so tribe helps tribe and kinsmen help their kinsmen* : The language here is unusual: the idea of a grouping by kinship or “brethren,” *phrētrē*, became important in some parts of the Greek-speaking world in the seventh century BCE but may not have existed earlier. It is of course implausible that the troops should be radically reshuffled after the war has already been going on for over nine years.

**2.462** *prepare for Ares* : Ares, god of war, is used metonymically to refer to war.

**2.476** *to save himself from hungry dogs and birds*: I.e., any man who shirks battle will be killed and left unburied, to be eaten by wild dogs and birds—the most shameful of deaths, worse even than drowning.

**2.487** *five years old* : The detail of the bull’s age emphasizes that it is in its prime.

**2.490** *the two Ajaxes* : *The Iliad* features two characters named Ajax, who are usually together. They are Telamonian Ajax, the son of Telamon, also known as Ajax the Great or Ajax of Salamis, who carries a big, heavy shield and specializes in defensive fighting, and the light-armed, quicker Oilean Ajax, son of Oileus, also known as Ajax the Lesser or Locrian Ajax. The relationship of these two is confusing and perhaps confused by the tradition. In the Catalog of Ships, later in Book 2, the Oilean (“Lesser”) Ajax is described as leading an entirely different contingent from that of Telamonian (“Greater”) Ajax, from a different part of the Mediterranean world; by contrast, in Book 4 (4.360) their troops seem to be combined. The phrases “two Ajaxes” or “the two named Ajax” may sometimes refer not to the homonymic warriors, but to Telamonian Ajax and his half brother Teucer. There may have been originally only one mythic warrior named Ajax, who became associated with two different locations and therefore had to become two different people.

**2.493** *took some barley grains* : Sprinkling barley over the victim is a traditional element in animal sacrifice.

**2.507** *He took the offering, / but magnified their pain* : This is the only moment in Homer where a god accepts the sacrifice while refusing a prayer. Perhaps double-dealing Zeus is still tricking Agamemnon. It is unclear how, in the absence of signs, the humans would know whether or not the god accepted the offering.

**2.513** *leafless twigs* : The leafless twigs are wooden spits which are burned in the fire along with the fat—in contrast to the metal spits in the following line, used for meat that the humans will eat.

**2.515** *the fire, Hephaestus* : Just as Ares is used as metonymy for war, Hephaestus is used to refer to fire, and Aphrodite as metonymy for sex.

**2.551** *through air to sky* : The ancient Greeks imagined the upper portion of the air or atmosphere, *aithēr* (from which we get “ether”) as something distinct from the



uppermost sky, the *ouranos* (= Uranus, the father of Cronus and the grandfather of Zeus).

**2.554** *around the streams of Cayster* : The Cayster (in modern Turkish, Küçükmenderes) is a river in Anatolia. The birds, like the armies, are assembling along the coast near the Troad.

**2.571** *And powerful Agamemnon / . . . like Poseidon's* : Agamemnon is the most powerful of the commanders in that he brings the largest army with him to Troy. Just as the Catalog of Ships shows many forces joined together for one purpose, so their leader, Agamemnon, is presented as a conglomeration of divine attributes coming together in one human body.

**2.579** *tell me, Muses* : The poem began with one invocation, to a singular goddess; now we have a second invocation, to a plurality of Muses. Through the pair of invocations, the smaller-scale conflict between Agamemnon and Achilles is made to mirror the large-scale conflict between the Greeks and Trojans.

**2.584** *we have seen nothing and we do not know* : These lines create a contrast between the autopsy of the goddesses, who witnessed the Trojan War with their own eyes, and the poet, who relies on storytelling (*kleos*) about the famous events of the past.

**2.593** *Those from Boeotia* : The long list that begins here is known as the Catalog of Ships. It cites twenty-nine Greek contingents, coming from most of the archaic Greek-speaking world, although with some omissions and peculiarities. The Catalog defines the Trojan War as a collective, pan-hellenic enterprise, even in an era before Greece existed as a political entity. Listeners to *The Iliad*, in almost any part of the Greek-speaking world, would hear familiar place-names and could claim Homer as their own. A particular puzzle is that the Boeotians head the list and seem far more prominent here than they do elsewhere in the poem, perhaps because the present list is based on an account of the ships that gathered at Aulis, in Boeotia, before sailing to Troy. A further puzzle is that the list does not mention Thebes or Orchomenus as central settlements in Boeotia, although they became the most important cities in the area later. The exact location of some of the places mentioned in the Catalog is unknown; those whose location is secure are represented on the map on [here](#). If the list of names makes the reader's eyes glaze over, I recommend reading this section out loud, paying attention to the sonic and emotional power of this list as a memorial for the numberless dead—so many young men from so many distant homelands and so many families left to grieve.

**2.605** *Hypothebae* : The name means “Under Thebes.” The Mycenaean settlement of Thebes was destroyed and the name Hypothebae may have been given to the surviving settlement.

- 2.609** *a hundred twenty young Boeotian men sailed* : We are told only twice about how many men are on each ship: here, there are 120 per ship, and later, at 2.855, Philoctetes' ships have 50 per ship. Thucydides (1.10.4) suggests that these numbers are the maximum and minimum numbers of each. With an average of 85 men per ship, the total number of Greeks at Troy is around 100,000. This implausibly large number signals the monumental importance both of the Trojan War itself and of *The Iliad*'s own narrative.
- 2.611** *Ascalaphus* : Nothing much is known of Ascalaphus; his name later referred to a kind of bird, perhaps an owl.
- 2.633** *known also as the lesser* : Locrian Ajax, known as "Ajax the Lesser," : see note at 2.490 and Glossary.
- 2.644** *Abantes* : Abantes is a tribal name for the Euboeans, supposedly derived from their mythical founder, Abas.
- 2.651** *hair long behind them* : All the Greeks are described as having long hair; the distinctive feature of the Abantes' style seems to be that they have it cut short in the front, like a mullet.
- 2.654** *from mighty Athens* : Athens was a significant settlement in Mycenaean times, but not as important as it became after the time of the Homeric poems. In mythological tradition, Hermes ejaculated on Athena's thigh; she wiped it off with a rag, which she dropped on the earth, and Earth (the goddess Gaia) became the mother of Erechtheus, the first ruler of Athens. Athena, the ever-virgin goddess, fostered him and took a special interest in the life of the city.
- 2.661** *No man on earth matched him as marshal* : Menestheus never shows any special ability at marshaling troops in *The Iliad* itself.
- 2.665** *Ajax led twelve ships* : Telamonian Ajax, from Salamis, is one of the most important Greek warriors, known for defensive fighting; his shield is his most iconic attribute. He plays an important role in the central battle sequence of Books 11–15.
- 2.669** *deep bays* : These places have separate "deep bays": Hermione was on the south of the Acte peninsula, and Asine near the Argolic gulf, south of Nauplion.
- 2.680** *where first Adrastus ruled* : Adrastus, originally from Argos, was exiled and moved to Sicyon, first ruling there as husband of the king's daughter, before returning to Argos when Thebes was attacked.
- 2.692** *because he was the best and led by far / the greatest forces* : An ancient critic, Zenodotus, marked this claim for deletion, because it is apparently inconsistent with the claim at 2.913 that Achilles and after him Ajax are the best of the Greeks. These warriors are "best" in different respects: Agamemnon in wealth and number of followers, Achilles in speed, Ajax in courage and defensive fighting.



- 2.701** *were arming separately* : I.e., not with those of his brother, Agamemnon; the point is that Menelaus has military power of his own, rather than depending entirely on his wealthy brother.
- 2.704** *Helen's suffering and struggles* : This phrase is a repeat of the one at 2.429 (“sufferings and struggles”)—see the note to that line.
- 2.705** *Pylos* : A town in Messenia, Pylos was the location of a large Mycenaean settlement; the remains of the so-called Palace of Nestor have been excavated nearby.
- 2.710** *Thracian Thamyras* : The myth of Thamyras, a singer who made a doomed attempt to compete with the Muses, reflects a common motif of mortals making foolish boasts that they are better than gods. It is unclear why this tangent is included in the Catalog.
- 2.752** *in anger at his father* : Phyleus' father, Augeas of Elis, forced Heracles to clean out his stables, which had never been cleaned before (the messiest and smelliest of the hero's Twelve Labors). Augeas promised Heracles a tenth of the cattle as the reward if he succeeded in this massive cleanup operation, but then failed to keep his word. Phyleus sided with Heracles and went into exile, apparently to Dulicium. Heracles later killed Augeas and made Phyleus king.
- 2.758** *Samos, the mainland* : It is unclear what is meant by this; the mainland might be Elis or Acarnia.
- 2.760** *with red cheeks* : “Red-cheeked” perhaps implies that a face was painted on the front of the ship. Herodotus in *Histories* says (5.58.2) that in ancient times all ships were painted red. The epithet creates an imaginative association between the ships with their “red cheeks,” brought by men to wage war and the “fresh-faced” or “beautiful-cheeked” women, who are taken by men as trophies.
- 2.772** *the hundred towns of Crete* : Crete was an important cultural hub in Mycenaean times; perhaps its “hundred towns” are a reminiscence of an earlier era.
- 2.775** *Ares, god of war and god of fury* : In the original, Ares is referred to with a title, *Enyalios* , associated with his power to evoke frenzy in battle.
- 2.781** *white Cameirus* : Several locations in the Catalog are called white, presumably because they have white cliffs or chalky ground.
- 2.783** *The mighty Heracles* : The story alluded to here is otherwise unknown.
- 2.802** *But he was weak and few troops came with him* : Nireus is not mentioned again. The lines are a moving articulation of the central concerns of the poem: that young men often die too young, and that there are many incommensurable forms of excellence.
- 2.812** *Hellenes, Achaeans* : The names Hellene and Achaean came to be applied to all Greeks but are clearly used here as local tribal names. The Myrmidons are usually

represented as the special followers of Achilles; Myrmidon suggests “Antman” (*myrmex* = ant).

**2.829** *the warrior Protesilaus / . . . A Dardan* : Protesilaus was the first man to step out of the Greek fleet onto Trojan soil, and the first casualty of the war; his name suggests “first of the army.” The Dardans are allies of the Trojans, also living in the Troad region.

**2.862** *Lord Philoctetes* : There was a prophecy that Troy could be taken only with the help of Philoctetes and his bow, which had originally belonged to Heracles. The language creates an echo between Achilles (at 2.824 and 2.860, “lay there, suffering”), and Philoctetes: both “lay there, suffering” (*keit' acheo~n*), sidelined from the main military action and, arguably, betrayed by their fellow Greeks—and both are essential for the capture of Troy. The association encourages us to see Achilles’ feelings as a kind of wound.

**2.871** *Asclepius, the healer* : Asclepius was the god most closely associated with medicine.

**2.882** *Pirithous chastised the hairy Centaurs* : This is an allusion to the mythic battle of the Lapiths and Centaurs, which is usually said to have broken out at the wedding of Pirithous and Hippodamia, rather than on the day she gave birth. Pirithous, king of the Lapiths, drives the Centaurs from their usual territory on Mount Pelion, and west into Thessaly, home of the people named the Aethices.

**2.896** *the River Peneus / . . . the water by which dreadful oaths* : The Styx is a river in the underworld, Hades; the gods swear by Styx when their oaths are to be fully binding. In real life, the River Peneus is stagnant and muddy.

**2.915** *was wrathful* : The words used here to describe Achilles’ state are cognate with the first word of the poem, *mēnis*, evoking an abnormal, more-than-human type of anger.

**2.924** *The chariots were covered up and stored / inside the leaders’ huts* : This sentence seems to contradict the previous one: the chariots cannot be next to each horse, out on the turf where clover and parsley grow, and also inside the huts.

**2.932** *the land in Arimi / . . . the giant sleeps* : The giant, also named Typhoeus, was the last of the Titans who fought the Olympian gods for world domination. After Zeus defeated him and the others, the Titans were confined to the earth. Volcanic activity was caused by the movement of Titans beneath the earth. The location referred to here is apparently Cilicia in Anatolia.

**2.955** *languages of distant people differ* : The different languages of the Trojan allies is also mentioned at 4.583, although we are never shown any moments of linguistic incomprehension, and Greeks seem to be able to communicate with Trojans and Trojan allies without needing an interpreter. This detail may be included in order to create a parallel with the divisions of the Greek army by tribe, as advised by Nestor

(2.436), It reminds us that the Trojan forces are just as diverse a coalition as the Greeks. Both armies include men assembled at Troy from many different places, with different cultural and linguistic backgrounds.

**2.965** *the tomb of agile / Myrine* : An Amazon warrior, Batea fought against the Phrygians/Trojans. It is fairly common in Homer for places to have two names, divine and human.

**2.971** *Aeneas led the Dardans* : The term “Dardan” is sometimes seems to be treated as a synonym for “Trojan,” although here it clearly designates a separate group of people.

**2.978** *drink dark water* : Water in Homer, like blood, is often dark or black.

**2.989** *their destinies* : The word used here in its plural form for “destinies” is *kēr*, which connotes an individual’s fated moment of death; it is often figured as black, and as a weight that turns the scales towards death.

**2.1028** *Phrygians* : Although “Phrygian” is sometimes used as a synonym for “Trojan” in later texts, here they seem to be a separate, neighboring people.

**2.1035** *who spoke a foreign language* : The epithet *barbarophonos* , “foreign-language-speaking” or “non-Greek-speaking,” appears in Homer only here—strangely, because the area of Miletus was occupied by Greeks from the end of the Bronze Age onward.

### BOOK 3 SUMMARY

Paris challenges Menelaus to a duel, and the two sides agree that the winner of the duel will keep Helen as his wife, along with the treasure taken with her from Sparta. As the warriors prepare, Priam and Helen sit on the wall of the city, and Helen names and describes various Greek leaders (about whom Priam is suddenly curious, after they have been besieging his city for the last nine years). In the duel, Menelaus gets the upper hand, but Aphrodite rescues Paris, scoops him from the battlefield, and puts him in his bedroom. Aphrodite forces Helen to join him there against her will—a scene that echoes the original abduction of Helen by Paris, not told directly in the poem.

Agamemnon insists that the Trojans must return Helen, since Menelaus got the better of Paris.

**3.6** *streams of Ocean, / and bring destruction to the Pygmy people* : The Ocean is the mythical stream that runs all around the world. This is the earliest known reference to a mythic battle between the Pygmies and the cranes, which later became a popular subject for vase paintings. The word “Pygmy” probably comes from *pygmē* , “fist”: perhaps these people are imagined to be the size of most people’s fists. The Pygmy people were located in central Africa, according to Herodotus (2.32.6). The

simile emphasizes the Trojans' noisy clamor, in contrast to the unified, silent attack of the Greeks, and anticipates the exhibitionism of Paris in this book.

- 3.12** *a fog so thick* : The fog simile foreshadows the action of the end of this book, when Aphrodite will gather up Paris in mist and spirit him from the battlefield.
- 3.19** *Paris Alexander* : Alexander (*Alexandros* = “man-defender”) is used as an alternate name or title for Paris. In the early stories of Troy, these may have been two different characters.
- 3.48** *Pathetic Paris* : Hector addresses Paris as *Dyspari* , “Bad Paris” or “Subpar Paris,” perhaps playing on a possible association of the name Paris with excellence; in Sanskrit, *para* = “best one,” and in Thracian, *poris* = “fighter.” Hector is mocking his brother for failing to be the “best fighter” suggested by his name.
- 3.56** *despite your feebleness* : Hector is expressing outrage at his brother's lack of self-knowledge or prudence: Paris picked a fight despite the fact that he is not a natural fighter.
- 3.61** *relatives by marriage* : In the original, Helen is described as the “daughter-by-marriage-on-husband's-side” of warriors/spearmen. Greek has more terms for in-law relationships than English, so there is a single short word for this relationship (*nuos* ). The term here is used loosely, to refer to all the warriors within the Greek network of kinship and alliance.
- 3.69** *mingled with the dust* : The same verb, *misgo*, “ to mix,” is used to describe Paris' unwelcome choice to “intermingle” with foreigners (3.59), and his future “mingling” with dust; the verb is regularly used for sexual intercourse.
- 3.71** *a shirt of rocks* : Paris, who emerged in this book dressed in his handsome panther-skin cloak, is depicted as caring too much about outward appearances. “A shirt of rocks”— death by stoning—is, from Hector's perspective, the proper punishment for Paris' distorted values.
- 3.89** *all the wealth and treasure* : There are repeated references to “all the wealth and treasure,” presumably brought from Sparta to Troy by Paris along with Helen.
- 3.91** *get all the wealth* : The verb (a participle in the original) rendered “get,” *helon* , puns on Helen's name: she is closely associated with “getting”—i.e., with the acquisition or seizure of objects, including herself.
- 3.96** *women are most beautiful* : The designation of Greece (Achaiis) as the land of beautiful women (*kalligunaika* ) is used elsewhere, but has a special resonance in the mouth of Paris.
- 3.122** *must disperse* : The original is linguistically difficult and is often taken to mean “I think you are separated” or “I think you will be separated,” but it is hard to see why Menelaus would make either claim.
- 3.124** *which he started* : An alternative ancient reading had *atēs* instead of *archēs* , which would mean “because of Paris' crazy delusion,” rather than “because of Paris

starting [the war].” In either case, Menelaus defines the quarrel or dispute (*eris*) as belonging to himself, but at the same time, blames it all on Paris.

- 3.129** *Earth and Sun* : Earth and Sun, along with Zeus, often preside over the ratification of oaths. Some readers see a snub in Menelaus’ assigning the lesser, non-Olympian—though also more ancient—deities to the Trojans. Moreover, Zeus is the god of hospitality, which was violated by Paris (who took his host’s wife); and Menelaus thriftily makes the Trojans pay with twice as many sheep as the Greeks provide.
- 3.150** *her husband’s sister* : Helen’s relationship with Paris is represented as a marriage, with the network of kinship relationships entailed by that bond; Laodice, a legitimate daughter of Priam and the full sister of Paris, is hence Helen’s sister-in-law on her husband’s side (Greek has more distinct terms than English for different types of in-law relationships). Laodice’s husband, Helicaon, does not occur elsewhere.
- 3.176** *fresh white linen clothes* : White clothes mark an important occasion. In *The Odyssey*, Circe and Calypso dress in white to say goodbye to Odysseus; perhaps Helen imagines that this will be her farewell to Paris.
- 3.196** *like this* : The old men do not say that Helen is beautiful, nor do they specify what makes her seem more than human. In a poem where almost all the female characters are described in terms of beauty, the omission of any reference to Helen’s looks seems striking here. Helen’s godlike power is associated with her capacity to look at men and represent them within a large temporal and geographical context, rather than being herself the object of the male gaze.
- 3.206** *who is that / enormous man* : Since the Greeks have been at Troy almost a decade, it is implausible for Priam suddenly to take an interest in their names. But just as the Catalog allows the poet to present the gathering of ships at Troy as if at the very beginning of the war, at Aulis, so the Teichoscopia (“Wall Looking”) allows the poet to present this late moment in the war as if it were the beginning, and to introduce the listener to many of the characters who will prove important on the Greek side.
- 3.214** *my bedroom* : The bedroom stands in for the person Helen pointedly does not mention by name: Menelaus, her former husband. Helen and Menelaus had only one child, a daughter named Hermione; the term used by Helen for her daughter, *telugete* (probably suggesting “late-born” and therefore “precious”), is elsewhere used only for boy children. The trope of a woman leaving a beloved group of friends her own age is associated in other archaic poetry (such as Sappho) with marriage, which has social and emotional costs to women.
- 3.223** *dog-face self / . . . at all* : In the original, Helen describes herself as *kunops*, “dog-faced.” This rare compound word is also used by Hephaestus of his mother



Hera at 18.490 (“dog-faced mother”); Helen and Hera share a lack of loyalty to family members. “Dog” is used elsewhere as an insult, as when Achilles accuses Agamemnon of having the face or eyes of a dog (1.215, “dog-face”). But other compound epithets ending in *ops* do not seem to be negative (e.g., *bouops* , “ox-eyed,” is used regularly of Hera and beautiful mortal women; *glaukops* , “bright-eyed” or “owl-eyed,” is used of Athena).

**3.232** *when those troops were marching* : It is unclear what mythical battle Priam is referring to, although the overall point is clear: Priam, a veteran of conflicts in the Troad between the forces in the region, has never seen an army as large as the invaders brought by Agamemnon. The Phrygians are allies of the Trojans. The Amazons are described as *antaneirai* , which means “masculine,” “equivalent to men,” or “a match for men”; the word has often been interpreted to mean “hostile to men.”

**3.276** *we no longer thought / to notice his appearance* : The original could suggest “We were not [any longer] annoyed at his appearance” or “We were no longer surprised at his appearance.” I take the second as more plausible, given that an unprepossessing appearance in an ambassador is more likely to arouse puzzlement than anger. Odysseus is a surprising character, because he demonstrates an extraordinary capacity to bide his time; his eloquence is all the more impressive because he keeps his audience waiting. Odysseus’ rhetoric is subtle and insidious, like a gentle snow, which may not be noticed until the whole world is white.

**3.296** *already / they lay* : Castor and Polydeuces (also known as Pollux) were, like Helen, the children of Leda. Helen and Polydeuces were the children of Zeus, who raped Leda in the form of a swan. Castor, along with a fourth sibling, Agamemnon’s wife Clytemnestra, were the children of Leda’s mortal husband, Tyndareus (according to the poet Pindar). In some versions, one of the twin brothers is mortal, and the other immortal. The present passage seems to suggest that both brothers are fully mortal.

**3.307** *Laomedon* : Laomedon was the previous king of Troy, grandson of Tros and father of Priam.

**3.337** *the butcher’s knife* : In Homer, the butcher’s knife or dagger, *machaira* , is used only for ritual purposes, in oaths, not as a weapon on the battlefield.

**3.340** *shared the tufts* : The distribution of hair from the animals among the leaders marks their joint participation in the sacrifice; Agamemnon holds the knife, but all those who hold the hair have participated in the ceremonial killing.

**3.341** *Zeus . . . nursed on Ida* : Zeus was hidden on Mount Ida as a baby by his mother, Rhea, to protect him from his father, Cronus, who swallowed his other children.

**3.346** *Hades and Persephone* : The king and queen of the underworld, Hades and Persephone, are in charge of punishing the dead for crimes committed in life.

- 3.356** *appropriate compensation* : This additional payment has not been mentioned before and seems to be Agamemnon's own idea, in keeping with his interest in maximizing his wealth. The word for "compensation," *timē*, connotes honor, value, or punishment: it suggests material wealth as a marker of social status.
- 3.373** *just like / this wine* : Traditionally, a splash of wine was poured on the ground as a libation to the gods; this prayer suggests that that drink offering represents the blood of the speaker's enemies.
- 3.377** *Dardanian Priam* : Dardanus is a mythical son of Zeus, ancestor of the people of the Troad. He is a distant ancestor of Priam.
- 3.392** *took the lots* : Presumably the lots are sticks or stones, marked so that each man can recognize his own.
- 3.413** *a corselet, borrowed* : Paris usually fights as an archer, not a foot soldier, so he has no breastplate of his own.
- 3.435** *his spear of bronze* : As ancient critics noted, there is a narrative continuity problem here: Menelaus has already thrown what seemed to be his only spear, so it is unclear what weapon he intends to use to kill Paris.
- 3.487** *knotted bed* : The bed is described as "twisted" or "knotted" because it is formed of ropes or twines knotted between four bedposts, covered with mattresses.
- 3.493** *her feelings* : The original (*thymos*, the location in the chest for emotions such as anger, pride, and desire) is unclear on what these "feelings" are: she might be sexually excited by the alluring goddess, or angry at her, or both.
- 3.574** *Dardanians* : The Greek *Dardanos*, translated as "Dardanian," is sometimes apparently used as a synonym for Trojan. However, the Dardans sometimes seem to be a different group, those from Dardania. On Dardanus, see note at 3.377. Here there are apparently two different groups, but it is unclear what distinguishes them.

## BOOK 4 SUMMARY

The gods hold a banquet and watch the humans. Hera and Athena long for the destruction of the Trojans, and Hera promises Zeus that he can destroy three of her favorite cities if he permits the sack of Troy. They send Athena to spur the Trojans to violate the truce, which she does by encouraging Pandarus to try to shoot an arrow at Menelaus, which he does. The arrow strikes its target, but Menelaus' armor protects him, and Machaon, the doctor, tends his wound. Agamemnon, presenting the Trojans as treacherous oath breakers, rouses the Greeks to fight. Hostilities resume, and there are many gory deaths on both sides.

- 4.3** *poured . . . to drink like wine* : There is a single verb in the original, *oinochoein*, for "pour like wine"; it is usually used for serving wine at human banquets. The use

of this verb for a different beverage underlines the fact that the society of gods is both very similar to and very different from that of mortals.

- 4.7** *these insinuations* : Zeus speaks with “insinuations,” because he implies, but does not say explicitly, that Hera has been upstaged by her rival Aphrodite, and he conceals his ulterior motive to help Thetis.
- 4.10** *Alalcomenae* : Athena’s association with Alalcomenae, a place on the southern shore of Lake Copais in Boeotia, is attested in Homer only here; there was a temple to Athena in Alalcomenae by the time of Pausanias (second century CE). There was certainly an archaic cult of Hera near Argos; her temple, the Heraion, was the largest in the area.
- 4.40** *deeply troubled* : This is one of many moments in the poem where the feelings and intentions of Zeus are markedly ambiguous.
- 4.77** *I am the eldest of us all* : Cronus, the leader of the previous generation of deities (the Titans), was the father of six of the Olympian gods, with Hera the firstborn; the others were Zeus, Poseidon, Hades, Demeter, and Hestia. Cronus was prophesied to be defeated by his children, so he swallowed them as soon as they were born, with the exception of Zeus, the youngest, who was hidden, grew up, and managed to make his father disgorge his siblings, so that they could defeat their father and gain power in their turn. Hera emphasizes that by birth order, she has seniority over Zeus, although he holds more power as the male and as the one who was most instrumental in the overthrow of their father. Among gods, as among humans, there are several ways to determine who counts as the best.
- 4.89** *arrogant Greeks* : The Greeks are given an unusual epithet, *hyperkudantas* , meaning “proud,” or “vainglorious.” This word is found only here and in Zeus’ reply. Perhaps Hera is disguising her favoring of the Greeks by giving them a negative epithet.
- 4.109** *one who serves up* : The word for “one who serves up,” *tamiēs* , suggests a steward who distributes food supplies; it is here used in an extended sense, as if war were a substance that has to be dealt out fairly to various different populations.
- 4.117** *River Aesepeus* : The River Aesepeus is some seventy miles from Troy, although the people of Pandarus are also called “Trojans” at 2.976, There is some confusion in the poem about whether all the people of the Troad count as a single group.
- 4.129** *wolf-born Apollo* : The epithet given to Apollo here, *Lukegenēs* , is unusual and its meaning is debated. It was once thought to suggest Apollo’s role as a light-bringing sun god (*luk* = “light,” *genos* = “birth”), but this is no longer a standard view. Some think it has to do with wolves (*lukos* = “wolf”). The god’s fondness for lambs in sacrifice may make him wolflike. An alternative view is that the epithet refers to a cult of Apollo in a specific place, either Lycia near the Troad, or Mount Lycaon in Arcadia, Greece.



- 4.133** *mindless mind* : The wordplay in the original is on *phrenai* (the organs of sense, judgment, and thought, usually located in the chest) and *aphronos* (“foolish,” “lacking in *phrenae*”).
- 4.140** *sixteen palms* : A palm was a standard unit of measurement; presumably an adult man’s palm is implied, so the horn is about four feet long. The detailed narrative about how Pandarus’ bow was made creates suspense and demonstrates that what is about to happen is important.
- 4.142** *a golden hook upon the tip* : The bow has a curved hook to which the string is attached. The “master craftsman” is a specialist in horn (*keraxoos*).
- 4.151** *support for darkening pains* : The arrow is a ship’s prop or bolster or support (*herma*, the support used to keep a ship upright when drawn out of the water on shore) of (presumably = “for”) pains. A singular arrow is said to support, and hence presumably cause, multiple pains or agonies, perhaps because the wound inflicted will entail long-term or multiple injuries—as this wound does, for many different people. The image is strange because one would expect the arrow to cause pain, rather than only support it.
- 4.161** *twanged* : *Linxe* (“twanged”) is a *hapax*, a word that occurs only here in the Homeric poems, and in fact only here in extant Greek. The word conveys the sound rather than the movement, so that the arrow seems to fly forward of its own accord. At this crucial moment, the narrator maximizes ambiguity about the agent responsible for the resumption of the hostilities.
- 4.163** *Menelaus, you* : The narrator addresses several characters in the second person in *The Iliad*, most often Menelaus and Patroclus. In *The Odyssey*, only the enslaved swineherd Eumaeus is addressed in the second person by the narrator. Commentators often treat this trope as a formulaic element with no particular meaning. Alternatively, the address to these particular characters, who stand a little aslant from the main action of the poem, underlines the position of the poem and its listeners: we are allied with Menelaus, the wounded, cuckolded brother of the powerful rich king Agamemnon, not the great man himself, and with Patroclus, the friend of the great warrior Achilles, rather than the enraged, quick-footed killer.
- 4.177** *the band he wore against his skin* : The details of Menelaus’ outfit and the anatomical location of his wound are difficult to map. It is also unclear how an arrow from a distance could pierce through the belt at the waist, and end up wounding the thigh. As is characteristic of Homeric narrative, details increase our sense of the importance of this moment, without necessarily clarifying the action in a realistic way.
- 4.182** *Maeonia / or Caria* : It is unclear why these locations are specified. Elaborate ivory carvings and ivory with appliqué have been found in Mycenaean graves, some imported from Syria and Phoenicia.

- 4.190** *handsome thighs / . . . shapely ankles* : The body of Menelaus—unlike that of his former wife, Helen—is represented as an aesthetic and erotic object.
- 4.195** *binding strings and barbs* : The binding strings are presumably strings tying the arrowhead to the shaft.
- 4.223** *thirsty Argos* : Argos here seems to refer to the whole Peloponnese, not the specific city of Argos, ruled by Diomedes. “Parched” or “thirsty” (*polydipsios* ) is used only here; presumably it suggests a lack of irrigation, hinting at the barrenness of mainland Greece compared to the Troad.
- 4.244** *shimmering belt / . . . bronze* : The belt and strap seem to be both made of bronze; the waistband seems to be some kind of cloth wrapped around the torso.
- 4.286** *he sucked out the blood* : This detail suggests that the arrow could have been poisoned, although we are not told so.
- 4.288** *kindly Chiron* : Chiron the Centaur is the most famous mythic doctor; he taught the semidivine Asclepius (Machaon’s father) and Achilles.
- 4.303** *giving orders* : The verb translated as “giving orders” (*koiraneō* ) is used only of Agamemnon in *The Iliad* . The peculiar detail that Agamemnon does not ride his chariot but hops on it when tired is unparalleled in the behavior of other leaders.
- 4.317** *all talk* : The word translated here as “all talk,” *iomoroī* , is a term of abuse whose exact meaning was unclear to readers in antiquity. It may suggest “glorying (*moros* ) in the voice/cry (*ia* ),” a criticism of fighters who boast but fail to follow through.
- 4.324** *the sterns* : The ships are lying on the beach with their sterns towards Troy, their prows facing the open sea.
- 4.342** *bright-faced wine* : Just as the sea in Homer is often “wine-dark” or “wine-faced” (*oinops* , from *oinops* = wine, and *ops* = face or eye, as if the sea looks back at us), so wine itself is often “bright-faced” (*aithops* —from *aithon* = bright or gleaming, with the same suffix, as if wine, too, looks up at us).
- 4.345** *your cup is always full* : The high status of the most elite fighters is marked by their privileges, including unlimited amounts of wine and the best cuts of meat.
- 4.352** *made my vow to you* : At the time of the marriage of Menelaus and Helen, her other suitors, including Idomeneus, promised to go to war to recover her if she were ever abducted.
- 4.360** *two called Ajax* : See note at 2.490.
- 4.403** *remain in yours / and stretch your spears out* : Nestor’s advice suggests a different use of horse-drawn chariots from that generally employed in *The Iliad* ; usually, warriors ride in the chariot to the fight, and then get down to the ground for hand-to-hand fighting. This passage may articulate a garbled folk memory of the military tactics of Mycenaean or Near Eastern chariots in the second millennium BCE.

- 4.420** *I killed bright Ereuthalion* : Nestor tells a fuller version of the story of this duel at 7.174. It took place during a mythical battle in which Nestor's city, Pylos, was attacked by the Arcadians (in what is now the Peloponnese in Greece); Ereuthalion was an Arcadian.
- 4.494** *the channels in between the ranks of fighters* : A common Homeric metaphor treats the spaces between the lines of warriors as channels (*gephurai*), as if the human battle formation were an elaborate irrigation system.
- 4.498** *never met him* : Tydeus and the other warriors who first besieged Thebes are from the earlier generation of mythic heroes—Agamemnon did not meet him because Tydeus was much older than he was.
- 4.545** *comrade* : This term of address, *tetta* ("comrade"), occurs only here. Its precise shade of meaning is unknown, although it is usually interpreted as a friendly, familiar form of address.
- 4.563** *a crest of water* : The "crest" of water is in the original a verb, *korusso*, used of warriors arming, cognate with the noun *korus*, helmet: the water's cresting recalls the fighters, armed in crested helmets.
- 4.584** *they came from many different places* : The Greek-speaking troops are also represented as coming from multiple different places, where people would have spoken radically different dialects of Greek. The language of the poem itself is a mixture of different Greek dialects. It is rare for the poem to acknowledge that linguistic difference might make communication difficult; in general, the Trojans are represented as speaking the same Homeric Greek as their invaders.
- 4.679** *the Pergamum* : The Pergamum is the citadel of Troy, the highest point in the city and the location of Apollo's temple.
- 4.691** *Triton-born* : The epithet "Triton-born," *Tritogeneia*, is used only of Athena, and its meaning was much debated even in antiquity. It may reflect a legend that Athena was reared by the River Triton or Lake Tritonis—who, according to some versions of the myth of her birth, took the baby goddess to protect her after she leapt from her father's head; or it may be somehow related to the word *tritos*, meaning "third." It could suggest an association with Triton, a sea god, although Athena is not generally associated with water.
- 4.699** *The disrespectful stone* : The narrator notices the stone's indifference to the social distinctions that are so important in the human world.
- 4.715** *hair piled high* : The male Thracian hairstyle was supposed to be a bun or topknot high up on the scalp, with the rest of the hair shaved off.

## BOOK 5 SUMMARY

Athena inspires and strengthens Diomedes, who is one of the best Greek fighters, and tells him he can strike Aphrodite if he sees her on the battlefield. The Greek leaders kill a number of Trojans. Aeneas is almost killed, but is rescued by Aphrodite. Diomedes attacks Aphrodite and cuts her wrist, so she drops Aeneas, who is rescued by Apollo. Aphrodite goes sobbing to her mother, Dione. Dione and Zeus tell her to stay away from war. Paeon heals the scratch. Diomedes attacks Aeneas, but Apollo scolds him, saves Aeneas, and puts a phantom of Aeneas on the battlefield. Urged by Sarpedon, Hector rouses the Trojans to fight for the phantom. Apollo tells Ares to encourage the Trojans, which he does, and the Trojans slaughter Greeks. Athena and Hera ride in an impressive war chariot onto the battlefield to help the Greeks. Athena joins Diomedes on his chariot and urges him to attack Ares, and they wound him. He complains to Zeus, and Paeon heals his wound.

**5.6** *the star / that shines the brightest around harvesttime* : The star that appears at harvesttime is Sirius, the Dog Star. Ocean is the (personified and divine) river imagined to encircle the world.

**5.39** *Now Ares, Ares* : This attack on Ares is echoed later in this book (5.606), when Apollo scolds him using many of the same phrases. No other god is condemned by another like this. Ares is essentially destructive (whereas Athena, also a war deity, is both constructive and destructive). Ares and Aphrodite, the two deities who prove vulnerable to Diomedes in Book 5, are both much closer than any of the other gods to being allegorical representations of human impulses (aggression and sex, respectively).

**5.44** *avoid his wrath* : Zeus' "wrath" is *mēnis*, the same word as the "wrath" of Achilles.

**5.48** *each leader killed a man* : The listing of pairs of warriors—six Trojans killed by six Greeks—allows the narrator to individualize the general trend towards Greek dominance. Each victim is killed in a different way, through injury to a different body part. The list of mortals who kill mortals shows the extraordinariness of Diomedes, the seventh Greek warrior, who creates a general rout, rather than only killing a single victim, and who will soon confront the gods themselves.

**5.78** *the carpenter Harmonides / . . . Pallas Athena favored him so much* : Some readers have taken *tektōn*, "carpenter," as a proper name, in which case Phereclus is the son of Tekton, the son of Harmon. I follow the Oxford Classical Text (which prints lowercase *tektōn*). Athena is the goddess who presides over most crafts that require technical skill with wood or fabric; skill in shipbuilding is a mark of the goddess's favor. Pallas is a common title for Athena.

**5.185** *rushes to the paddocks to take cover* : This line is a little difficult to parse in the Greek. Some commentators take it that it is the sheep, not the shepherd, who are

fleeing from the lion here, but that would entail an awkward change of subject.

**5.186** *the ewes pour forth and huddle close together* : This line is sometimes taken to mean that the sheep are all dead, their corpses piled in a heap. But the lion is unlikely to have killed more than one, and the huddling suggests terrified living sheep, not dead ones. The lion, like Diomedes, remains dangerously riled up even after his first kill.

**5.190** *Diomedes mingled with the Trojans* : The earlier killings have been one against one. Diomedes' extraordinary prowess is shown by his ability to slaughter his opponents in groups of two, not one.

**5.219** *stripped them* : Presumably he kills them before stripping off the armor, but the actual slaughter is implied only by the simile.

**5.238** *The wrath of gods* : Aeneas uses the word *mēnis* , “wrath,” as in the first line of the poem.

**5.245** *his visor* : The word rendered “visor,” *aulopis*, is of uncertain meaning; it may refer to the eyehole in the visor of helmet, or a socket for the plume.

**5.266** *Trojan forces* : Pandarus' people are “Troades” or “Trojans” in that they come from around Zelea in the Troad, not from the city of Troy.

**5.353** *kidnapped son, / Ganymede* : Zeus abducted Ganymede, the young son of Tros, founder of Troy, to be his cupbearer and rape victim.

**5.361** *excellent at forcing men to flee* : There are two different textual readings attested in antiquity for the phrase translated as “excellent at forcing men to flee,” *mēstore phoboio*: the reading I follow here, adopted by the ancient Homeric scholar Aristarchus, makes the phrase describe the two horses, but an ancient alternative with the phrase in the singular (*mestori phoboio* ), attested in Plato's *Laches* (191b), associates the ability to force flight with Aeneas.

**5.385** *the tip / emerged again* : Scholars comment on the anatomical implausibility of this death: Pandarus, on the chariot, ought to be higher than Diomedes. Perhaps Athena is able to bypass normal aerodynamics. More important, it is appropriate that Pandarus, after his vainglorious boasting, has his tongue cut off.

**5.414** *while he was herding cows* : Encounters with goddesses or gods frequently occur out in the countryside or mountainside, as with Hesiod's encounter with the Muses in *Works and Days* , or Paris' meeting with Athena, Aphrodite, and Hera.

**5.432** *all their comrades* : The group of “comrades” are specifically young men of the same age; within this larger group, Deipylus and Sthenelus are special friends. Warriors in *The Iliad* are often presented as having particularly close, intimate friendships with a single other comrade or brother.

**5.440** *Cyprian Aphrodite* : Aphrodite had a major cult center on Cyprus in archaic times, but she is referred to as “Cyprian” (*Kypris* ) only here, not in other Homeric passages.



- 5.444** *Enyo* : Enyo is a non-Olympian warrior goddess, associated closely with Ares.
- 5.451** *the Graces* : The Charites (traditionally rendered as the Graces in English) are three goddesses who accompany Aphrodite; they are personifications of attractiveness or charm.
- 5.453** *not blood, but “ichor”* : The narrator seems keen to contradict a traditional Mesopotamian belief that gods actually consume the meat and wine offered to them in sacrifice. In the Homeric world, gods enjoy the savor of sacrifice, but their food and drink (immortal, ambrosial nectar) is unlike that of humans, and hence, the liquid that flows through Aphrodite and the other immortals (*ichor* , “serum” or “juice”) is not, strictly speaking, blood, but another substance.
- 5.474** *left side of the battle* : The left side is unlucky.
- 5.496** *her mother’s lap* : In Hesiod (*Theogony* 191–92) Aphrodite was born when the Titan Cronus, father of Zeus, cut off the genitals of his father, Uranus, and threw them into the sea; Aphrodite was born from the waves, and her name is associated with the foam or froth of the sea (*aphros* ). But here, she is the daughter of Zeus by a sea goddess, Dione.
- 5.502** *misbehaved / in public* : Dione assumes that the wounding must be an act of retribution for a perceived wrong. Aphrodite, as goddess of sex, usually does wrong in private.
- 5.521** *would have died* : Ares is presumably immortal, but this seems to hint that he could be in a state close to death.
- 5.523** *got Ares out* : This story is otherwise unknown. Ancient commentators tell us that the brothers tied up Ares in revenge for his killing of Adonis, son of Aphrodite, who had been placed under their care.
- 5.527** *struck her right breast* : The wounding of Hera by Heracles is also unknown beyond this passage. Ancient commentators say that Heracles fought the gods on Pylos, wounding Hera and Hades on the same occasion.
- 5.569** *scratched / her slender wrist* : Athena claims, offensively, that Aphrodite’s injury is trivial (as are all injuries to the wrist in Homer). She implies that Aphrodite could be involved in war only as a seductress, not a fighter.
- 5.589** *watch out and get out* : Apollo’s imperatives rhyme in the original: *phrazeo . . . chazeo*.
- 5.605** *bucklers* : The word translated as “buckler” is unusual and its exact meaning debated, although it seems to suggest a different type of shield.
- 5.648** *ensnared inside their net* : The Greeks are described as hunters, trying to cast a net over Troy, as if the enemy were a wild animal. It is relatively rare for a Homeric character, rather than the narrator, to use such metaphorical language.
- 5.658** *woke the dreadful noise / of war* : In a slightly bold personification, the noise of war (*phylops* ) is described as being woken by Hector’s activity.

- 5.661** *As wind blows chaff / . . . so then the Greeks* : The simile compares the white dust kicked by the horses' hooves to the chaff or husks that are separated from the darker grain by human laborers. The threshing floor is sacred because it is presided over by Demeter herself, the goddess of agriculture; she is blonde because it is the color of the grain. As so often, there is more than one point of comparison: the dust and the chaff are both white, but the scenes are also similar in the wild sprinkling of a light substance onto human bodies, and the dust/chaff is not the primary goal: the humans in the threshing floor are seeking grain (the source of life), while the warriors on the battlefield seek to kill each other.
- 5.687** *Conflict, who is always keen* : Conflict (Eris) is here personified as a goddess.
- 5.688** *both Ajaxes* : On the two Ajaxes, the son of Telamon and the son of Oileus, see note at 2.490.
- 5.830** *the son and grandson* : Tlepolemus is a grandson of Zeus, because Heracles was son of Zeus. Sarpedon is also a son of Zeus.
- 5.901** *Let it be later that I lose my life* : Sarpedon's courage is demonstrated by the fact that he prays not to avoid death entirely, but to avoid an unheroic death in which his corpse would be desecrated—a motif comparable to the famous moment in which Telamonian Ajax prays not for life, but to fight and die in the light (17.831).
- 5.911** *oak tree* : The oak tree is near the Scaean Gates. Oak trees are sacred to Zeus.
- 5.952** *The body of the chariot* : The details of this fabulous, unrealistic chariot are hard to reconstruct. Normal mortal chariots had only one rail in front; the inclusion of two is, along with the implausible building materials, a signal that this is a very special vehicle. The “pole” is the part at the front that links the chariot to the horses' yoke.
- 5.970** *on it was the head / of the . . . Gorgon* : On the *aegis* , see note at 1.273. The Gorgons were three divine sisters, daughters of sea deities, who had snakes for hair and the ability to turn anyone who looked at them to stone (although in the later version of the myth, found in Ovid's *Metamorphoses* , the snake hair is imposed by Athena after the Gorgon Medusa has been raped by Poseidon).
- 5.973** *her golden helmet* : The “plume” is apparently a socket into which a plume can be fitted; the four studs might be metal bosses or plates.
- 5.1021** *like trembling doves* : Athena frequently appears in the guise of a bird but it is usually a bird of prey. The goddesses here adopt a surprisingly gentle manifestation to enter the battlefield unnoticed, before they unleash their full strength.
- 5.1089** *shapeshifter* : The word translated as “shapeshifter,” *alloprosaillos* , occurs only here and at Greek line 5.888, also of Ares. It suggests, literally, “other-to-other”—i.e., Ares transforms himself depending whom he encounters.
- 5.1110** *Hades-helmet* : The Hades-helmet confers invisibility. The name “Hades” was associated etymologically in antiquity with *a-ides*, “unseen.”

**5.1163** *the gruesome corpses* : See note at 5.521 on Ares' immortality. There is irony in the distaste shown by the god of war for the effects of his own favorite action, slaughter.

**5.1184** *curdles bright white milk* : Acidic juice, probably from figs, was used to curdle milk to make cheese curds.

## BOOK 6 SUMMARY

The Greeks start to gain the upper hand. Hector, following the advice of his prophet brother, Helenus, returns to the city to urge the older women to pray to Athena at her temple and to say goodbye to his family. He visits his mother, Hecuba, and gives her the instructions but refuses to stay for a drink. He visits Paris and Helen, urging Paris to return to battle. Finally, on the city walls, he meets his wife, Andromache, along with the enslaved nurse and his baby son, Astyanax. Andromache begs her husband, on whom she depends for everything, not to return to the plain, but to adopt a safer strategy, remaining on the wall to defend against any possible Greek invasion. She reminds him that his death will lead to the fall of the city, the death of their son, and her own enslavement, along with that of all the other Trojan women. Hector rejects her suggestion on the grounds not of military strategy but of personal prestige, insisting that it will be humiliating for him to be seen by the Trojan public doing anything except leading the charge against the Greeks on the plain. The baby cries at his father's frightening war-helmet, and the parents laugh. Hector meets Paris at the gate, and the brothers go out to the plain.

**6.4** *Xanthus* : Xanthus, "Yellow," is another name for the River Scamander.

**6.5** *like a rampart* : Ajax is the best defensive Greek fighter, equipped with a special seven-layer shield. He defends his own body, but is also the best at defending his comrades.

**6.26** *Dresus was slaughtered* : After Ajax and Diomedes each kill their victims, we have a much briefer catalog of seven more killings. The sequence of nine successful kills emphasizes the success of the Greek forces at the start of this book, and the terrible loss of life among the Trojans and their allies, whose pathos is increased by details such as Arybas' generosity and Boucalion's illegitimacy and his idealized pastoral life. Many of those killed are identified by the places from which they come: they are not inhabitants of Troy itself, but neighboring regions in and around the Troad. The Trojan allied forces, like the Greek collective, come from many different places and cultures, and die far from their homes and their families. Another effect of the allusions to places far from battle is to create a terrible juxtaposition between the world of war and the world of peace. The sequence of



nine deaths, in which every main verb is a synonym of “kill,” increases the shock when the tenth Greek warrior, Menelaus, does not kill his opponent.

**6.42** *Percosian Pidytes* : The town of Percote was northeast of Troy.

**6.82** *no one left to care for them* : The lack of either memory or care for the dead men of Troy suggests a veiled allusion to what will happen to the women, who will be enslaved and taken to different parts of the Greek world, unable to provide funeral rites or ritual laments for the dead (the traditional tasks of women when there is a death).

**6.156** *battered against his ankles and his neck* : The detail draws attention to the speed of Hector’s motion, and to the vast size of the shield: it can strike his neck and ankles because it covers his whole body. The shield is imagined as constructed of metal, with bosses beaten into it; it is then covered with dark animal skin.

**6.172** *I am not one to fight the heavenly gods* : Diomedes fought gods and goddesses in Book 5.

**6.173** *strong Lycurgus, son of Dryas* : This is the earliest extant telling of the myth, but we learn from later versions that Lycurgus tried to ban the worship of Dionysus and imprisoned his female worshippers, who were known as maenads (“maddened ones”). The maenads were identified with the nature goddesses who cared for the god when he was an infant. The maenads carried a wand or stick, known as a *thyrsus* , to represent their devotion to the god.

**6.195** *The generations / of men* : This beautiful simile takes transience as its explicit premise: one human generation is no more permanent than the leaves on a deciduous tree. But Homeric similes often have more than one point of comparison. The new leaves that sprout in spring are connected to the same living tree as those that have died, and humans are connected to their past and to one another by bonds of ancestry. Glaucus implies that ancestry does not matter (“why do you ask . . . ?”); but he goes on to provide an extremely lengthy account of his ancestry—implying that it might actually matter a great deal. This episode is unrealistic, even by Homeric standards: fully armed men do not usually pause in battle to tell long, meandering stories about distant relatives. But it serves several important purposes. It forges a connection between Glaucus and his interlocutor, Diomedes.

Bellerophon, like other Iliadic heroes, risks death for honor, and like Diomedes, he risks the anger of the gods. Bellerophon’s sexual self-restraint echoes that of Hector, and contrasts with Paris. But this folkloric story of an evil seductress and combat against monstrous hybrids is different from the poem’s primary narrative, in which elite male warriors are almost always matched against opponents who are very much like themselves.

**6.203** *a city, Ephyra* : This Ephyra is usually identified as Corinth, which is “nestled” or “in a corner of” Argos because it is at the far end of the Peloponnese, on the

isthmus connecting it to the mainland. The specifics of actual geography are, as usual, not the poet's primary concern.

- 6.226** *dangerous and deadly symbols* : This is the only reference in the Homeric poems to writing. Presumably the symbols are inscribed on a tablet made of two pieces of wood hinged together, with wax for the writing, since it is “folded”—although there may also be a suggestion of the earlier technology of the inscribed clay tablet. The story serves to emphasize the importance of oral storytelling, and the anxiety of an oral culture about a new information technology: Bellerophon is suspected because he carries his story on a dangerous written “tablet”—a technology that he himself does not understand and is therefore not in control of—rather than telling it himself and creating his own narrative of self-recommendation (as Glaucus does).
- 6.240** *threatening Chimera* : “Chimera” means “she-goat.” In later versions of the story, Bellerophon kills the Chimera with the help of Pegasus, the winged horse, whom Athena helps him bridle.
- 6.247** *the famous Solimi* : The Solimi were the indigenous people of Lycia, who were, according to Herodotus (1.173), driven from the region by Cretan colonizers.
- 6.268** *Alone and lost* : The story of Bellerophon's death feels out of place in the narrative of his children's lives and deaths, and it is told in an obscure, allusive way. We learn from later sources that Bellerophon tried to fly on Pegasus up to the home of the gods, but was pushed back to earth by Zeus, to wander alone and insane. The story confirms that it is unwise to challenge the gods, and that there is a certain riskiness in being, like Diomedes or Bellerophon, a warrior who might be capable of doing so.
- 6.275** *the goddess was enraged* : Artemis' anger is not explained and this element of the story is otherwise unknown.
- 6.299** *the war at Thebes* : Tydeus, Diomedes' father, was one of the Seven Against Thebes in the generation before the Trojan War. They were led by Adrastus of Argos to help Polyneices regain control of Thebes from his brother, Eteocles.
- 6.316** *He traded / his armor* : The exchange of names and ancestry stories is followed by an exchange of armor, which many readers, ancient and modern, have found puzzling, because its social comedy seems to contrast with the relative seriousness of the Bellerophon story; Glaucus is generally presented as an honorable warrior, worthy of respect, but here he is shown making a silly mistake (trading valuable gold armor for mere bronze). *The Iliad* usually depicts a stronger fighter getting some compensatory treasure that ensures his honor is satisfied whenever he fails to kill a weaker opponent; the armor exchange confirms that Diomedes retains more honor than Glaucus.
- 6.326** *fastened tight* : The implicit metaphor is of a net or rope wrapped around them, like the kind of nets used for hunting birds.

- 6.388** *Sidonia* : Sidon was a wealthy city in Phoenicia, in modern Lebanon. Herodotus quotes these lines along with *Odyssey* 4.227–30 (in his *Histories* 2.116) as evidence that Homer knew the story that Paris and Helen were blown off course after leaving Greece. Herodotus argues that Helen never went to Troy at all.
- 6.392** *the mightiest of fathers* : Helen is the daughter of Zeus.
- 6.426** *eleven cubits* : Hector’s spear is also eleven cubits long at 8.426. A “cubit,” *pechus* , is literally a forearm. Eleven cubits is thus an implausibly long measurement for a spear, even a large thrusting-spear (as distinct from a light throwing-spear). Hector is equipped with this impressive weapon to underline the contrast between his commitment to war and that of his brother, Paris, who fights with a bow and arrows (which allow for a warrior to stay far from the enemy).
- 6.437** *be so angry* : Hector assumes that Paris is sulking out of rage that he looked bad in front of the Trojans when Aphrodite whisked him away from the duel with Menelaus in Book 3. The mention of Paris’ rage as cause of his absence from the battlefield creates an interesting parallel between handsome, swift-footed Paris and handsome, swift-footed Achilles.
- 6.452** *my wife* : The word used by Paris, *alochos* , is generally applied to unambiguously legitimate marital relationships.
- 6.462** *a dog* : Helen describes herself with three terms in the Greek original: *okruoesse* (“source of fear”), *kaikomēchanos* (“associated with evil strategy”) and *kuōn* , “dog”; see notes at 1.214 and 3.223 on the cognate word *kunops* , “dog-faced.” It is unclear whether Helen sees herself as the author of the evil strategy of the war, or merely as a crucial element within it; dogs are not known for their strategic thinking. In either case, Helen’s self-designations underline her acute awareness of her own ambivalent place in the whole mythical narrative. No other Homeric character describes themselves as a dog, although elsewhere the word often suggests disregard for proper boundaries of behavior (because dogs are usually indifferent to the rules of etiquette). Whenever Helen uses dog imagery of herself, she uses the same oblique (genitive) case that is used here (which says literally, “brother-in-law of me-dog”); it is therefore possible that she is a “dog” from her in-laws’ perspective rather than her own. Anglophone translators often translate “dog” as “shameless” or, when applied to Helen, “whore” or “slut”; different language is usually chosen when the same word is applied to Agamemnon.
- 6.478** *folly and delusion* : The original term for Paris’ foolish abduction of Helen, “delusion,” *atē*, is the same as that used of Agamemnon’s delusion in taking Briseis from Achilles.
- 6.531** *so many gifts* : Andromache’s home city, Thebe, was one of many sacked by Achilles. Andromache has already experienced one city sack, and now faces

another. She comes from a similar background to the enslaved Briseis, who is also the daughter of a king whose family and city have been obliterated by Achilles.

**6.543** *Astyanax* : The name suggests “master of the city” etymologically (*astu* = city; *anax* = master/lord).

**6.549** *strange man* : Hector uses the same word to address or dismiss the concerns of both Andromache and Paris: *daimonios*, which is fairly common as an address in Homer, and suggests that the person has been touched by a spirit, or *daimōn* , and is therefore strange or out of the ordinary.

## BOOK 7 SUMMARY

The arrival of Hector invigorates the Trojans, and killing intensifies. Athena and Apollo plan to slow the conflict by arranging for a duel between Hector and one of the Greeks. Menelaus volunteers but Agamemnon talks him out of it, and Telamonian Ajax is appointed by lot as Hector’s adversary. The fight is evenly matched. Night falls suddenly before either gains the upper hand, and the two exchange gifts of friendship. Nestor and Priam call for a pause in fighting to bury the dead. The Trojan Antenor tries for a diplomatic solution to the war—the return of all property, minus Helen, in exchange for peace—but the Greeks reject the offer. The Greeks begin building fortifications around their encampment to defend against Trojan attacks. Poseidon, who built the walls of Troy with Apollo, feels threatened by this ambitious project, but Zeus comforts him with a promise that, after the war is over, the gods will obliterate the wall.

**7.11** *oxen eyes* : “ oxen” is used of several goddesses, especially Hera, and more rarely of mortal women.

**7.15** *limbs unknotted* : It is common in the Homeric poems for death to be described as “untying” or “unloosening,” with variations of the verb *luō* , to “loosen,” “untie,” “unknot,” or “set free,” as here and (in a slightly different form of the verb) in the death of Iphinous, a few lines later. The language implies a conception of the living body as a system of limbs knotted together, which are loosed or untied at death.

**7.39** *the final end of Troy* : The language suggests that there is a temporal boundary point or end for the city, unknown to the humans until they discover it. It is unclear whether this end point is known even to the gods.

**7.40** *Both of you deathless goddesses* : The two goddesses are Hera and Athena, who have been working together against the Trojans.

**7.58** *Helenus, beloved son of Priam* : Helenus is the twin brother of Cassandra and shares some of her abilities to foretell the future and discern the will of the gods.

- 7.80** *rippled with helmets* : The crowd is seated, but the men's small, shuffling movements create the shimmering effect as their weapons catch the light.
- 7.88** *our oaths* : The oaths were taken in Book 3, between Agamemnon and Priam, before the earlier duel, between Menelaus and Paris. The two sides swore that if Paris killed Menelaus, the Greeks would give up Helen and leave Troy; if Menelaus killed Paris, the Trojans must hand over Helen, along with the property taken with her, and more treasure as reparations. Both sides invoked terrible curses on oath breaking. Since Aphrodite spirited Paris off the battlefield, neither scenario obtained, and the oaths were unfulfilled.
- 7.98** *glorious Hector* : This is the only moment in Homer where a character refers to him/herself with an honorific epithet (*Hectori diōi*). It may suggest Hector's overconfidence.
- 7.105** *my share of fire* : I.e., a funeral pyre, in a dignified burial.
- 7.108** *to hang / before the temple* : It was common practice throughout Greek and Roman antiquity to hang up spoils of war in temples, as an offering of thanks to the god. Apollo's relationship with the Trojans in general, and Hector in particular, is resonantly ambivalent in the poem; Hector tends to believe that both Zeus and Apollo are favoring him, which is only partially the case.
- 7.133** *The final limits* : The language suggests that there is a final result already set by the gods. Book 7 focuses on boundaries—physical, temporal, and metaphysical.
- 7.135** *he strapped his glorious armor on* : As an ancient commentator noted, Menelaus was already wearing armor. But the requirements of the narrative formula entail that a warrior must put armor on before a special act of combat.
- 7.137** *you would have seen your life's end* : In *The Iliad*, the narrator occasionally uses the second person to address a single character in a moment of crisis, most frequently Patroclus and Menelaus (see note at 4.163).
- 7.149** *Even great Achilles / shrinks* : This is presumably false; nothing elsewhere in the poem suggests that Achilles is afraid of Hector.
- 7.163** *Peleus would grieve* : Peleus is the father of Achilles by the sea goddess Thetis. Nestor invokes him as somebody who would expect all the Greek warriors to behave with the courage characteristic of his son—who is, at this point in the action, sulking in his hut.
- 7.176** *beside the Celadon's swift streams* : The mythic battle evoked here is not known from other sources. Nestor, king of Pylos, describes a conflict that took place when he was a young man, before he took over as ruler: when the Pylians fought off an attack from a neighboring tribe, the Arcadians.
- 7.179** *near the Jordan River* : The geography is vague. It is unclear why Nestor refers to two rivers, although perhaps one is a tributary of the other. Pheia may be a settlement near modern Katakolo, but that area in ancient times was not on any river,



let alone two. The Jordan River is in Crete in *The Odyssey* (3.292), and perhaps the phrase is imported from the Cretan context, even though this battle does not take place in Crete.

**7.180** *Ereuthalion* : Nestor tells a shorter version of this anecdote about killing Ereuthalion, the master of the club, in Book 4 (4.419). Here, the narrative takes the form of ring composition: Nestor mentions Ereuthalion, digresses to the story of Ereuthalion's club, and then resumes the tale of his own encounter with Ereuthalion. The story touches the important theme of the unpredictability of single combat: a fighter may win by superior strength or skill, but also by a superior weapon (the club) or superior tactics (the ambush).

**7.193** *given by brazen Ares* : Arethous got the club from Ares, presumably as a special favor. Ares is "brazen" because he is closely associated with warfare, which uses weapons and armor made of bronze.

**7.223** *place lots* : The lots are probably stones or potsherds; each man scratches his mark on his lot as identification.

**7.239** *from left to right* : The right-hand direction was considered luckier.

**7.299** *start the fighting* : Normally, Homeric warriors in single combat hurl their weapons at the same time. Ajax seems to be insulting Hector by offering him the chance to throw first, as if he might be a remedial fighter in need of a handicap.

**7.311** *this flexibility is crucial / in shieldsmanship* : The interpretation of this line is disputed, and the language is unusual. The main point is that Hector is taunting Ajax by claiming superior skill and knowledge of Ajax's own special area of expertise, which is the shield—as well as expertise in numerous other relevant areas.

**7.406** *a bull of five years old* : A five-year-old bull is fully grown and large enough to feed a big crowd. As is typical in Homeric scenes of sacrifice, the meat is imagined to be "for" the god, but at the same time, it is "for" the humans, in that they are the ones who will eat it.

**7.500** *if you wish* : The herald qualifies his message ("if you would like to hear it") in recognition that the words of Paris and Nestor may be controversial in the Greek camp, and that a herald among the enemy camp is vulnerable.

**7.521** *ropes of ruin* : The word *peirar*, "rope," also suggests "limit"; it can also be used for ropes or tackle—for instance, on a ship or in a net. Here it seems to be used metaphorically, to suggest the tight ropes of destruction cast around Troy by the Greek army—as if they were hunters and the human city were an animal prey.

**7.542** *Helios* : The sun god, Helios, is imagined to sleep in Ocean, the mythical river that flows all the way around the circular world.

**7.560** *high towers and a wall* : The Greek wall and trench are peculiar, from a purely realistic perspective: if the Greeks have been encamped at Troy for over nine years, they should have already built fortifications. The presence of the wall allows the

narrator to flip around the expected narrative tropes: it is not the Trojans but the Greeks who are besieged, with the Trojans as the besiegers. The building of the wall allows the poet to present this moment as the true beginning of the whole war, when diplomacy has decisively failed. The Trojan attempts to break through the wall and set fire to the Greek ships will be the focus of the poem's plot until Book 15 (when Hector succeeds in reaching the ships). The wall also plays an essential element in the poem's evocation of memory and landscape: it is an extraordinary human achievement, like the war itself, but one that (again, like the war itself) can be easily washed away by the gods.

**7.580** *Laomedon* : King Laomedon was the father of Priam. According to later accounts, Poseidon and Apollo had conspired to chain up Zeus, and as punishment, Zeus sent them to build city walls for Laomedon; Zeus owed a favor to the Trojans, because he had abducted a Trojan boy, Laomedon's uncle, Ganymede. Bizarrely, the gods regard the temporary defensive structure built in a few hours by the Greeks as equivalent to the divine defensive walls of Troy.

**7.596** *bearing wine . . . unmixed wine* : Jason is the Greek hero who went on a quest to get the Golden Fleece from Colchis, on the Black Sea; on the way, he stopped at various islands, including Lemnos, which was, according to myth, inhabited only by women who had killed their husbands; Hypsipyle was their queen. Euneus, Jason's son, sent the sons of Atreus a separate batch of wine in recognition of their status as the most important members of the Greek allied forces. Unmixed wine (*methu* ) was considered very strong and special in Greek antiquity; the norm was to drink wine mixed with water.

## BOOK 8 SUMMARY

Zeus holds up his cosmic scales, and the fortunes of the Greeks sink down. Hector dominates the battlefield and the Greeks are on the run, until Hera inspires Agamemnon to encourage the Greeks to fight back. Despite this, Hector drives the Greeks back to their ships. Hera and Athena want to interfere to help them but are restrained by Zeus, in accordance with his vow to Thetis. Only Achilles can stop the Trojan advance.

**8.35** *dangle in midair* : The mechanics of the chain are difficult to imagine. It is supposed to hang "from the sky," as if the sky itself could provide a material hook on which to attach a chain. Either Zeus, who sits atop Olympus (imagined as a floating location in the sky rather than a realistic mountain), will be dragged down from heaven, or he will instead pull the other gods, along with earth and sea, up to the sky.

- 8.49** *Triton* : The line uses the most mysterious of Athena's epithets, *Tritogeneia* , "Triton-born"; see also note at 4.691.
- 8.60** *Gargaron, his shrine* : Gargaron is imagined as a sanctuary of Zeus located on the highest peak of Mount Ida. There was a later settlement called Garara, located on a lower peak.
- 8.83** *The people fell* : This formulaic phrase (also used at 11.111) suggests that the battle is taking place almost without human or divine agency: the weapons attach themselves to one another, and the human casualties are a side effect of the activities of inanimate objects.
- 8.86** *golden scales* : The motif of the god holding up scales to determine human destinies, known as *psychostasia* , has North African and Near Eastern antecedents; it is a frequent subject of Egyptian art. The scales recur at other moments of the poem (16.823 and 19.293).
- 8.110** *the pair / of other horses* : The wounded stallion is a trace-horse, an extra horse harnessed to the side of the two horses pulling the chariot.
- 8.143** *a while ago* : In Book 5, when Diomedes almost kills Aeneas and Sthenelus takes his horses (5.428).
- 8.178** *The frightened horses cowered* : This is not realistic horse behavior, in that frightened horses would rear up or bolt, not cower. The horses are made to behave like deer. The narrator needs elegant variation, and for that reason, these horses must be made to act significantly differently from the wounded horse of Nestor, who reared up.
- 8.217** *Be off with you, you silly little thing! / . . . I will bring your doom* : The word translated as "silly little thing" literally means "bad eyeball," and probably hence implies something small or doll-like.
- 8.244** *Swiftfoot, Blondie, Flame, and godlike Sparkle* : Hector is the only warrior in *The Iliad* who seems to use four horses for his chariot rather than two; for that reason, many commentators suspect the naming line is a late addition. Linguistically, too, the passage is odd: the four horses are addressed with dual verb forms, as if they were only two. The horses' names reflect their qualities, like the names of Achilles' horses.
- 8.249** *for you to drink* : It is obviously unrealistic that the horses enjoy wine; the fiction underlines their heroic status.
- 8.257** *these trophies* : Presumably the trophies do not in themselves guarantee victory, but their acquisition would be a sign of success, and would damage Greek morale.
- 8.288** *a big red cloth* : Presumably to make himself visible to the whole army before he makes his announcement.
- 8.291** *belonging to Odysseus* : I.e., at the midpoint of the line of ships along the shore. The ships of Ajax lie to the east; those of Achilles, to the west. The positioning



marks Odysseus, as the cleverest strategist of the Greek forces, as both literally and metaphorically central in the council meetings of the Greeks. Old Nestor's ships are also in the center.

**8.330** *the fawn beside the altar* : The fawn or deer would normally be associated with Artemis, not Zeus, and the altar is not mentioned elsewhere.

**8.388** *give you a tripod* : A tripod is a cauldron with three legs attached, so that it can be placed over a fire to heat up whatever liquid is within. In this premonetary economy, tripods and cauldrons, frequently made of precious metals and often used for sacrifice or dedication to the gods, are important components of wealth.

**8.409** *a married woman* : According to some traditions, Priam had several legitimate wives. It is also possible that Castianeira is married to somebody else.

**8.466** *Gorgon* : The Gorgon is a frightening being represented as having large eyes and sometimes snakes for hair. Representations of Gorgons are common on archaic Greek temples and other buildings, presumably for protection, and also appear on shields: a Gorgon is depicted on Agamemnon's shield (11.45).

**8.481** *in mad fury* : Athena uses the same language of Zeus that Hera had used of Hector: *mainetai* ("he is manic," "he is acting insane").

**8.485** *all those Labors* : Heracles, a son of Zeus by a mortal woman, was hated by Hera and was forced by a human enemy, Eurystheus ("Widely Strong"), to undertake a set of twelve difficult tasks. These Twelve Labors mostly involved killing monstrous hybrid creatures, and also included bringing the three-headed dog, Cerberus, up from Hades. Athena plays no part in many versions of the Heracles myth. She speaks here in somewhat abstruse terms of Heracles, not naming him, perhaps because he might be a touchy subject for Hera.

**8.491** *the narrow gate* : Hades has narrow gates because it is hard to escape from the land of the dead.

**8.495** *hates me* : The original creates a punning connection between the River Styx—a river in the underworld—and the hatred of Zeus (*stugei*, "hates") and of "hateful Hades" (*stugeros*, "hateful").

**8.643** *Iapetus and Cronus / . . . Helius Hyperion* : Cronus, father of Hera and Zeus, and his brother Iapetus, are Titans who were overthrown by Zeus and shut up in the lowermost underworld, Tartarus. The implication is that Zeus might hurl Hera out of the sky to join these defeated foes. The sun god Helius ("Sun") is sometimes given the title Hyperion; sometimes Hyperion is the name of Helius' father.

**8.661** *eleven cubits long* : Hector's implausibly long spear was mentioned earlier (6.426).

**8.726** *into the sky* : Five lines, Greek lines 547 and 550–53, were inserted into the text by eighteenth-century editors, because they are quoted in the pseudo-Platonic

dialogue *Alcibiades* as Homeric (2.149d). Modern editors do not believe they belong in the text. The lines read:

They offered perfect hecatombs to the immortals . . .  
... [*the burning fat was* ] sweet, but the blessed gods did not feast on it,  
nor did they want to, because they despised  
the holy town of Troy and all its people  
and Trojan Priam of the good ash spear.

**8.733** *breaks open* : The image is a little unclear, because the verb (“breaks open”) suggests that there is a mass of clouds that part to reveal the bright stars—but we have not been told of any clouds. The lines fit better in their other location, at 16.385.

## BOOK 9 SUMMARY

Agamemnon tells the Greeks that the war is hopeless and they must sail home. Diomedes and Nestor oppose him. In a council meeting, Agamemnon acknowledges that he was “deluded” in dishonoring Achilles, and offers to give him many lavish gifts, and to return Briseis. On the advice of Nestor, the Greeks send Odysseus, Ajax, and Phoenix to convey the offer to Achilles. Achilles, who is singing and playing the lyre when they arrive, hosts them with a meal. Odysseus conveys Agamemnon’s offer, but Achilles vehemently rejects it. Phoenix pleads with him, tells the story of his own quarrel with his father, and reminisces about Achilles’ childhood with Phoenix himself as his caretaker. He goes on to tell of Meleager, who was angry because of a quarrel with his mother, and refused to help his community during a siege, but finally relented, and of the Prayers, goddesses who symbolize the importance of healing the damage done by anger and delusion. Achilles invites Phoenix to stay the night, saying he will postpone his final decision until morning. Ajax reminds Achilles that acceptance of inadequate compensation is normal even for the killing of loved ones, and implicitly reminds him how much the Greeks need him. Achilles says he will rejoin the war, but only once Hector begins to burn his own ships. Odysseus and Ajax return to the Greek camp, and Odysseus gives a gloomy report to Agamemnon. All sleep.

**9.23** *delusion* : The word translated as “delusion,” *atē* , suggests an overwhelming mental error sent by the gods.

**9.100** *Thrasymedes* / . . . *Lycomedes* : Thrasymedes, the brother of Antilochus, and Meriones, the comrade of Idomeneus, are familiar characters, but the other five are very minor characters.

**9.125** *I shall tell you* : Even for Nestor, this speech is long-winded: Nestor is nervous about making any kind of criticism directly to Agamemnon.

- 9.161** *they conquered* : The military language by which the enslaved women are said to have “conquered” less attractive women (and thereby gained the honor of being enslaved by Agamemnon) underlines the speaker’s focus on victory. Agamemnon acknowledges that the sack of Lesbos was achieved by Achilles, yet Agamemnon took the seven best women for himself.
- 9.180** *Chrysothemis, / Iphianassa, and Laodice* : The names differ from later traditions reflected in the tragic poets, by which Agamemnon’s children included Electra and Iphigenia (whom he killed, to appease Artemis—a story not told in Homer). The names cited here suggest allegorical attributes appropriate to a leader: Chrysothemis = “Golden Right”; Iphianassa = “Strong Lord”; Laodice = “People’s Justice.”
- 9.184** *bride-price* : The Homeric poems suggest a world in which payment is sometimes given by the bride’s family to the husband, sometimes the other way around, and sometimes both parties provide gifts or payment.
- 9.187** *seven well-built towns / . . . sandy Pylos* : The geography of this passage is puzzling. The seven cities offered are not in Agamemnon’s territory, Mycenae, but farther south, in Messenia, in an area that should belong to Nestor. Perhaps this is just a mistake. Or perhaps Agamemnon is giving away territory that does not belong to him.
- 9.196** *rich dues* : I.e. the people will pay large feudal dues to their overlord, Achilles.
- 9.198** *his anger* : Agamemnon describes Achilles’ feelings as *cholos* , a type of rage common to gods and humans, rather than as *mēnis* , “divine wrath.”
- 9.226** *especially at Odysseus* : Nestor seems to treat Odysseus as the primary ambassador, although he has little effect on Achilles. This detail may reflect an alternative version of the story of the embassy and/or it may suggest the other leaders’ fundamental lack of understanding of Achilles’ emotional state.
- 9.229** *They walked* : A puzzle of this sequence in the original Greek is that the verbs (such as the verb form of “they walked”) are dual, not plural, suggesting only two ambassadors—even though we have been told that there are three plus two attendants, for a total of five. It is likely that the verb forms reflect a version of the story in which Odysseus and Ajax were the only ambassadors.
- 9.253** *the ones I love the best* : There is no indication elsewhere that Achilles is particularly fond of Odysseus or Ajax.
- 9.271** *holy salt* : Salt is perhaps “holy” because of its close association with the rituals of hospitality.
- 9.288** *a lavish spread* : The meal is an essential element of hospitality and shows that Achilles is not so completely alienated from his fellow Greeks as to fail in his duties as a host; the guests are of course bound by etiquette (*xenia*, friendly guest-host relations) to accept the meal with gratitude. Ancient critics were disturbed by

the fact that the visitors eat two large dinners back to back, suggesting an unheroic gluttony.

- 9.302** *rabid frenzy* : Hector's state, *lyssa* , connotes the frenzy of a wolf or dog with rabies. All references to Hector's supposed insanity come from his enemies; his military exploits are not described in these terms by the narrator.
- 9.398** *and take turns chittering and clucking at me* : This verse does not appear in a quotation of the rest of these lines from Plato (*Hippias Minor* 365A, quoting 308–14); perhaps some ancient texts lacked the line. The Greek verb rendered “clucking” is used for the clucking of birds.
- 9.455** *he scarcely got away from my fierce hands* : This confrontation is referenced only here and is otherwise unknown.
- 9.486** *scintilla* : The original uses an unusual word, *karos* , which apparently suggests a cutting or shaving, such as a fingernail or a scrap of wood taken off during carving.
- 9.491** *Egyptian Thebes / . . . seven gates* : These lines seem to conflate two different cities named Thebes, one in Egypt and the other, with seven gates, in Boeotia. The conflation may be due to a later composer adding a line to the text.
- 9.513** *My strong proud heart* : Achilles describes his spirit, and by implication himself, as hypermasculine, *agēnor* (*ag-*, “ultra”; *anēr* , “man”); the word can carry negative connotations but can also suggest a positive kind of boldness (see note at 2.337 on the phrase applied to Thersites). Achilles sees his alternative life, as a husband, father, lord, and home owner back in Phthia, as another way of accruing the status available only to the most powerful and therefore most “masculine” men. This is the path to glory chosen by Odysseus.
- 9.522** *Delphi* : Referred to in the original as “Pytho,” Delphi was the location of a special oracle of Apollo. The doorstone is presumably the entrance of Apollo's temple.
- 9.567** *to teach you everything* : Phoenix adroitly summarizes the two sides of the Homeric warrior's skills: speech and action. The dominant mythological tradition suggests that Achilles' tutor was Chiron the Centaur. But the poet, in need of a parent figure who could plausibly offer Achilles advice, could not bring a Centaur into a human camp. The intervention of Phoenix is designed to create parallels with Achilles' own situation. Phoenix, like Patroclus, is forced to run away from home after a fight; Phoenix, like Achilles, has experienced a terrible quarrel over a woman with a more senior man whom he was tempted to kill, but restrained himself. Phoenix's account of his caretaking responsibilities in Achilles' childhood establishes that he has an intimate connection with him, and therefore it is psychologically plausible for Achilles to listen. Phoenix's history with Achilles helps make the point that Ajax will make more explicitly later: communities are not

just vehicles to generate individual status, but composed of people who love and care about one another.

**9.573** *Hellas* : This speech distinguishes between the realm of Hellas and that of Phthia; the terms are conflated elsewhere in the poem. In the Catalog of Ships in Book 2, Hellas is described as part of Achilles' realm (2.810).

**9.578** *prostitute* : This is the only moment where the word *pallakis*, "prostitute," appears in Homer, although it does occur in later Greek. In its later usage, the word suggests either a woman enslaved for sexual purposes or a sex worker associated with a temple.

**9.586** *the horrifying Furies* : The Furies—snake-haired underworld goddesses, often viewed as more ancient than the Olympians—avenge any violation of blood ties and respect within families.

**9.589** *infernal Zeus and dread Persephone* : Zeus is usually a sky god, but here he has a chthonic aspect that seems to equate him with his brother Hades, god of the dead. Persephone is the queen of the underworld, the rape victim niece, and part-time wife of Hades.

**9.590** *I almost drew / . . . father-killer* : This passage represents four lines that do not appear in the manuscript tradition of Homer, and are relegated to the apparatus in the Oxford Classical Text; however, they are cited by Plutarch in his *Moralia* (26). Plutarch says that the Homeric critic Aristarchus (who flourished in Alexandria in the second century BCE) removed the lines from the text because he was shocked at the idea of parricide. But there is no linguistic reason to doubt that the lines belong in the poem.

**9.604** *Hephaestus* : Hephaestus is the god of fire.

**9.616** *the dancing-fields* : "The dancing-fields" is a formula that may imply the presence of places in cities to perform ritual choral dances; it suggests a wealthy, Hellenized landscape.

**9.623** *Dolopes* : A hill tribe, who do not appear elsewhere in Homer but were apparently located to the west of Phthia.

**9.644** *pray forgiveness* : The word used for prayer here, *lissomai*, is cognate with the word used later in the passage for the abstract, divine Prayers, the *Litai*. These are not the usual terms for prayers to the gods, which are generally referred to with the verb *euchomai*. *Litai* and *lissomai* connote a subordinate position of supplication. This passage focuses, unusually for the Homeric poems, on prayers for atonement or forgiveness, rather than prayers for strength or glory or prayers in thanks for victory.

**9.650** *Delusion* : "Delusion," *atē*, is the same word used by Agamemnon earlier in this book (see note at 9.23) to acknowledge his disastrous mistake in quarreling with Achilles. Achilles never suggests that his own actions were caused by *atē*.

- 9.685** *siege of Calydon* : Phoenix here tells a peculiar version of a traditional tale, one that contradicts versions found elsewhere. The usual story is that Althea, wife of the king of Calydon, had a piece of wood on which depended the life of her son, Meleager. The goddess Artemis was angry with the king and sent an enormous boar to wreck his property. There was a dispute after the boar hunt, and Meleager killed his mother's brother. Althea was furious; she took revenge by burning the magic log and hence killing her son. In Phoenix's version, by contrast, Althea is Meleager's "loving mother" and there is no mention of the log burning, although her filicidal rage seems to be the cause of Meleager's own anger—which forms the focus here. Phoenix constructs a story about Meleager's renunciation of anger that is designed to align as closely as possible with the situation of Achilles. The name of Meleager's wife is apparently made up for this passage, to provide a clearer analogy between Meleager, who sleeps beside his wife Cleopatra, and Achilles, who sleeps beside Patroclus; Patroclus is, by analogy, Achilles' wife.
- 9.717** *outside the wall* : Phoenix's attempt to make the two sieges parallel here leads to some confusion: the Curetes are the besiegers, not the inhabitants of the town, so they ought to be outside the walls while fighting.
- 9.733** *kingfisher—the halcyon* : Idas rescued Apollo when the god tried to rape his wife, Marpessa. Idas is traditionally listed as one of the heroes who hunted the Calydonian boar. There is also a secondary allusion to the myth of Alcyone (Halcyon) and Ceyx, a husband and wife whose devoted love inspired the jealousy of the gods, who then caused Ceyx to drown at sea. Alcyone threw herself into the sea in grief, and they were both changed to kingfishers. Both these mythical stories are designed to remind Achilles that he should remember love, not rage.
- 9.743** *The pitiless Fury / . . . Erebus* : A Fury is a spirit of vengeance who takes a special interest in violence between family members. Erebus is a cavern between the world of the living and the world of the dead.
- 9.758** *his mother* : Unlike Agamemnon, Althea does not apologize or offer gifts from her personal treasure; also unlike Agamemnon, she implores the recalcitrant Meleager in person, rather than through an embassy.
- 9.775** *yielded to his heart* : At the start of the speech, Phoenix seemed to suggest that Achilles should subdue or repress the feelings in his heart (*thymos* : the heart or core of the self as associated with feelings of pride or self-confidence). Now, Achilles' proud heart is a good guide to action, insofar as it can lead him to reconnect with his social responsibilities.
- 9.777** *They did not give him all those lovely gifts* : This detail provides an extra, and quite different, kind of argument for why Achilles should accept Agamemnon's offer: lest he, like Meleager, rejoin the battle too late to get the lavish reward.



- 9.790** *payment to restore my damaged honor* : In Homeric society there is a conventional structure of reparation payment, *timē*. Achilles insists that he is beyond this human social structure of loss and reparations because he has a special relationship with the gods.
- 9.807** *remain at Troy* : Achilles has slightly altered his position at this point, in response to Phoenix's speech: leaving at dawn is now a possibility, not a certainty.
- 9.839** *Respect our presence / beneath your roof* : Even beyond his intransigence and rudeness, Achilles is also violating the norms of hospitality: he has offered his guests food and drink at his hearth but refused to accept their gifts, offered in friendship.
- 9.870** *Achilles slept with pretty Diomedes / . . . well-dressed Iphis lay beside Patroclus* : Lesbos is an island in the Aegean; Scyros is farther west. Perhaps we are supposed to imagine that Achilles sacked various Greek locations on his journey to Troy. Scyros is also the location where, according to a familiar myth not told in Homer, Achilles was hidden from the draft by his mother, in disguise as a woman. Nothing is known about Diomedes or Iphis, although their epithets ("pretty" and "well-dressed") suggest elite status. The scene underlines the intimacy of Patroclus and Achilles, who sleep side by side, each with a woman provided by Achilles.
- 9.883** *that man* : Odysseus, presumably stung by Achilles' vehement rejection of his diplomatic overture, avoids mentioning Achilles by name.
- 9.917** *his arrogance* : The terms used in the original for Achilles' egotism, *agēnor* and *agēnorie* , suggest an excess of masculinity; they are cognate with the word *anēr* , "man." See notes at 2.337 and 9.513.

## BOOK 10 SUMMARY

Agamemnon, troubled about the Greeks' military position, cannot sleep, and rouses the other leaders. They have a nighttime council meeting and agree that Diomedes and Odysseus will go on a spying mission into the Trojan camp. Meanwhile, Hector, who is also awake, calls the Trojans to a meeting; he sends an ill-favored but swift-footed man named Dolon ("Deceit") to spy on the Greek fleet, promising to give him Achilles' horses if he succeeds. Odysseus and Diomedes capture Dolon and question him. He gives them useful information about the layout of the Trojan camp and the presence of the Thracian King Rhesus, who has just arrived at Troy with valuable horses. Dolon begs for his life, but Diomedes slaughters him, and Odysseus dedicates his weapons to Athena. They reach the Thracian camp, and Diomedes slaughters a dozen men, finally killing Rhesus. They take the horses and chariot and gallop back, aided by Athena. Apollo alerts the Trojans to the Thracian massacre and the theft of the horses. Diomedes

and Odysseus return in triumph to the Greek camp with the chariot, horses, and spoils. They wash off the blood, sit down for dinner, and make thank offerings to Athena.

NOTE : Book 10 is different in several ways from the rest of the poem. A number of words and phrases in this book are more typical of *The Odyssey* than *The Iliad*, and the action—a night raid in which the victims are taken unawares—contrasts with the representation of battle in the rest of the poem, in which fighting generally takes place in daylight, between fully armed, wide-awake adversaries. The episode does nothing to advance the main plot, and we are told by an ancient commentator that the whole book was added by a rhapsode after the rest of the poem was complete. However, stories of raiding adventures are a very ancient element in the narrative and poetic traditions from which the poem draws. Moreover, the story of the murder of Rhesus as told here is carefully adapted for its position in *The Iliad*. The composer eliminates various features of the traditional story of this raid—which had existed in earlier mythic tradition—such as the heroic exploits of Rhesus in battle. This gripping episode increases our awareness of the Greeks’ desperation in the face of Hector’s advance. It recalls, but does not replicate, a more famous tale: when Diomedes and Odysseus crept into the temple of Athena in Troy and stole her statue, the Palladium, because there was a prophecy that the city would not fall while the statue was within the city walls.

**10.7** *as when the spouse / . . . Agamemnon groaned* : Ancient and modern commentators alike have found this simile puzzling and many have felt that it does not work. The groans of Agamemnon might be compared to the sound of thunder, but lightning seems like a stretch. Presumably, the point of the comparison, which is not made clear, is that the leader’s insomnia is a sign or portent of imminent disaster, just as lightning in the simile may suggest that Zeus is causing either bad weather or war. Nonetheless, Agamemnon’s sleeplessness is caused by imminent disaster, whereas Zeus’ actions are themselves the cause of them. The mouth of war opens when a war begins, but it is again a stretch for war to be “piercing” when it is also a mouth.

**10.19** *ripped great clumps of hair* : The language and action here is hyperbolic: hair pulling is a typical gesture of grief, but it is unprecedented for a Homeric character to pull hair out “in clumps” or “roots and all,” *prothelumnos*—a word related to *thelumna*, “foundation,” and used also of the Calydonian boar ripping out the trees in the forest by the roots.

**10.36** *a spotted leopard skin* : Menelaus’ cloak—leopard, not lion—marks his slightly inferior status in relation to his brother, Agamemnon.

**10.89** *heavy suffering* : The heavy suffering is the burden of elite leadership, laid on the sons of Atreus from the time of their royal birth.

**10.138** *swift Ajax* : “Swift” Ajax is Oilean Ajax; the other Ajax, son of Telamon, is the “godlike Ajax” mentioned in the next sentence. Telamonian Ajax moves slowly,



weighed down by his enormous shield.

**10.141** *Their ships are farthest* : The Greek ships are arrayed along the beach in a particular order. Nestor and Odysseus have their ships in the middle, and the ships of Ajax and Idomeneus lie on the far left; Achilles is on the far right.

**10.154** *He waits for me to take initiative* : This fraternal put-down is not borne out by other details in the poem: Menelaus frequently fights hard and volunteers for action, despite being conscious of his athletic inadequacies. But Agamemnon is clearly the primary instigator of the whole expedition to Troy to retrieve Menelaus' wife.

**10.213** *upon a razor's edge* : An ancient razor (*xuron*) was a single, very slim, ultrasharp blade, not the modern multiblade "safety" razor, which would provide a much less effective image for a moment of crisis.

**10.239** *across the ditch* : The meeting happens beyond the boundary of the Greek camp established by the wall and the ditch, in a clear area in front of the pile of Greek corpses generated by Hector's massacre the day before.

**10.286** *my own dear friend* : Agamemnon uses a useful formula to flatter Diomedes. Elsewhere, he expresses no affection for him, and Diomedes is critical of Agamemnon at the start of Book 9.

**10.293** *a man of higher status* : Agamemnon directly addresses the issue that was at the root of his quarrel with Achilles: the fact that athletic and military ability may not map precisely onto social status.

**10.316** *skullcap* : The term rendered "skullcap," *kataitux*, appears only here in extant Greek.

**10.320** *a leather helmet* : Helmets decorated with boar's teeth or tusks were apparently used in early Mycenaean culture, but fell out of favor by about the sixteenth century BCE; the poem seems here to suggest cultural memory of a military artifact that would have been many centuries out of date by the time of its composition. The boar's-tooth helmet was stolen by Autolycus, Odysseus' grandfather, and as we learn in *Odyssey* 18, Odysseus' first exploit as a very young man was killing a boar on a hunt while staying at his grandfather's house. The grandfather's skill in thievery is relevant for a book in which we will see Odysseus sneak into enemy terrain and steal some valuable property.

**10.355** *a friendly message* : Tydeus was sent into Thebes to appeal to the people there to reinstate Polyneices as king, over his brother, Eteocles. The Thebans refused. Tydeus was ambushed on the way back, by fifty Thebans, and slaughtered all but one.

**10.399** *as you expect of me* : There is a certain dramatic irony here: expectations of Dolon may be, rightly, rather low.

**10.439** *she-mules go farther with a plow than oxen* : The precise agricultural observation—praised by the ancient critic Aristarchus as a mark of the poet's

farming expertise—feels more typical of the Hesiodic corpus than the Homeric poems. The detail makes explicit that Dolon is a very long way ahead before Odysseus and Diomedes begin their deadly pursuit. The praise of mules is appropriate for a book whose plot centers on valuable equine animals.

**10.536** *Towards Thymbre* : The allied forces are arranged roughly from north to south, with some closer to the Hellespont, and others closer to Thymbre, a place on the Scamander River upstream of Troy. The Trojan allies cited here overlap with those cited in Book 2 (2.982ff.), although without the Thracians, who will have a particular role in the narrative of Book 10, and with the addition of the Leleges and Caucones, about whom little is known.

**10.570** *both tendons* : This presumably means the most prominent tendons in the back of the neck. Human necks actually have far more than two tendons, all of which would have to be sliced through for the complete decapitation, but strict realism is not the point.

**10.620** *They were not yet accustomed* : Another reminder that Rhesus and his horses are newcomers to the war. Both horses and humans become inured to horrors, such as stepping on dead bodies, which are initially unbearable.

**10.621** *thirteenth victim* : The tally is actually fourteen, with Rhesus.

**10.644** *mounted* : It is extremely rare for Homeric heroes to ride horses, rather than riding a chariot pulled by horses; it is a sign of desperate straits.

**10.677** *He whipped / . . . the way they wished to go* : These lines are generally taken as clumsy applications of formulaic language where it does not fit the context: despite having no whip, Diomedes whips Rhesus' horses.

## BOOK 11 SUMMARY

The armies prepare for battle. Zeus sends blood to rain from the sky. Agamemnon slaughters many Trojans, but then is wounded by Coon, the son of Antenor, and has to leave the battle. Hector rouses the Trojans, while Diomedes and Odysseus kill several Trojans. Diomedes attacks Hector but fails to kill him. Paris wounds Diomedes in the foot, and he has to leave the battle. Odysseus, alone among the Trojans, stands firm and succeeds in killing several, but is wounded by Socus. Menelaus and Ajax escort him from the battle. Machaon, the doctor, is wounded by Paris and rescued by Nestor. Ajax kills many Trojans and the Greeks gain ground, until Ajax, outnumbered, begins to withdraw, although he keeps the Trojans from the ships. Eurypylus joins him but is wounded by Paris. Achilles sees that the Greeks are being wounded, and sends Patroclus to find out whom Nestor is taking from the battlefield. Patroclus goes to Nestor's hut, and Nestor explains how badly the Greeks are doing, and how many are wounded. He then reminisces about his own military exploits, urging Patroclus to

counsel Achilles to rejoin the fighting at this crucial time—or, if Achilles still refuses, Nestor suggests that Patroclus should join the fighting himself, clad in Achilles' armor, to reduce Trojan morale and allow the Greeks some respite. On the way back to Achilles, Patroclus meets the wounded Eurypylus, takes him to his hut, and treats his wound.

- 11.9** *sign of war* : It is unclear what physical form this ominous sign (*teras*) is supposed to take. The horror of Conflict (Eris) is enhanced by the vagueness with which she is described.
- 11.11** *Those two / . . . their mighty hands* : These lines appeared earlier, at 8.295.
- 11.22** *his shining bronze* : Agamemnon's shield, armor, and weapons are particularly elaborate, reflecting his wealth and his high social status. Their multiplicity suggests the royal leader's control over multiple different people and factions.
- 11.25** *corselet that Cinyres / . . . winning favor* : This is a gift offered to secure Agamemnon's goodwill.
- 11.39** *golden rings* : The rings attach the scabbard to the sword-belt.
- 11.40** *a splendid, deadly shield* : The shield is heroically unrealistic. It is not clear whether the bronze circles are bands of decoration around the Gorgon face or, perhaps, circular layers of the shield itself. On Gorgons, see note at 8.466.
- 11.45** *The middle garland* : The face is a "garland" because it is round, like a garland or crown.
- 11.56** *made it thunder* : Elsewhere, it is Zeus and no other deity who creates thunder, although Athena also wears the goatskin aegis of Zeus.
- 11.66** *a little way behind* : This account has been criticized for the confusing lack of clarity about how the chariots and horses are transported across the ditch. Presumably there is a route at the side—a shallower area of the ditch—that is more readily crossed by wheels and horses, but the narrator does not say so.
- 11.125** *drove his sharp spear* : Agamemnon's victims during his period of battlefield glory (his *aristeia*) frequently suffer head wounds—as here, with the forehead skewering, or later, with decapitation. Agamemnon himself is the "head" of the Greek forces, and he has a keen interest in damaging or removing the heads of any possible rivals.
- 11.132** *their naked chests shone bright* : This line provides a touching twist on the usual formula: usually, it is armor that shines brightly on the Homeric warrior's body, but here, the gleam is of naked dead flesh.
- 11.140** *willow twigs* : The willow twigs are used as ropes to bind the captives during the ransom negotiations. The brothers have already had one narrow escape at Greek hands, only to be killed by Agamemnon.

- 11.185** *as an ambassador* : This embassy is also mentioned at 3.255. Presumably it was on the same occasion that Paris tried to bribe Antimachus to oppose the restoration of Helen to Menelaus, although this detail is not mentioned elsewhere. The story that Antimachus favored killing Menelaus and Odysseus occurs only here, and may be invented for the occasion, to motivate Agamemnon's slaughter of these sons.
- 11.198** *a tree trunk used for grinding grain* : A hollowed-out trunk of wood was used as a mortar to crush grain for baking. The same technology is mentioned in Hesiod's *Works and Days* (423). Agamemnon's behavior on the battlefield is particularly gruesome and violent: no other Homeric warrior cuts off the arms as well as the head of an enemy.
- 11.214** *channels of the fighting* : The metaphorical "channels," as at 4.494 (see note), are the narrow areas of space between the lines of fighters.
- 11.222** *tomb of Ilus* : Ilus is a forebear of the royal family of Troy, the grandfather of Priam (see *Genealogies*, p. 716). His tomb, next to the fig tree, marks the center point of the plain.
- 11.286** *tell me, Muses* : The new invocation to the Muses marks a momentous point in the narrative: the beginning of the sequence in which Agamemnon will be wounded and Hector will set fire to the ships.
- 11.297** *his own daughter* : Cisses' daughter would have been Iphidamas' aunt—an incestuous but not unparalleled marital relationship. Diomedes is also married to his aunt. "From the marriage chamber" implies "as soon as the marriage was consummated."
- 11.301** *Percote* : A town northeast of Troy.
- 11.309** *His spear-tip* : The tip of the thrusting-spear would be made of bronze, but it bends against the strong silver of Agamemnon's belt as if it were lead, a much softer metal.
- 11.326** *covered his eyes* : This may be literal—his eyesight is obscured by tears—and metaphorical—in his grief, he fails to recognize how great a risk he is taking in attacking Agamemnon.
- 11.353** *Eileithuias* : Eileithuia is more often a singular goddess, associated with labor and birth.
- 11.414** *Thymbraeus / . . . Molion* : These characters, presumably Trojans or Trojan allies, are otherwise unknown. The name Thymbraeus echoes the place-name Thymbre, a town on the Scamander River.
- 11.428** *the sons of Merops* : The sons of Merops were Adrastus and Amphius, as we learn from the Trojan Catalog at the end of Book 2; here, unusually, they are not named before their death, perhaps to focus attention on the pathos of the father, whose prophesies could not save his sons. An Adrastus is also killed at 6.85 and at 16.87, and another Amphius at 5.611.

- 11.439** *stretched the battle tight and evenly* : The implicit metaphor here is a little obscure: Zeus might be stretching tight a knot, a rope, or a hide. The main point is that the two sides are evenly matched for the time being.
- 11.462** *given to Hector by Apollo* : Hector's glittering helmet may not be literally a gift from Apollo—we are not told so elsewhere—but the claim emphasizes its superior craftsmanship and the wearer's close relationship, real or imagined, with this god.
- 11.479** *a god as helper* : Athena served as Diomedes' divine helper in Book 5. Hector consistently believes Apollo is his divine helper—although this god will eventually lead him to his death.
- 11.482** *Agastrophus* : The son of Paeon, Agastrophus was given his deathblow by Diomedes; now Diomedes takes the dead man's weapons.
- 11.505** *You good-for-nothing / . . . silly hairstyle* : Diomedes uses four terms of abuse. "Archer" is an insult in that it suggests the lack of courage required to fight face to face with swords or spears. "Sleazy flirt," *parthenopips*, suggests specifically "girl-ogler"; Paris' flirtiness is only with the opposite sex. Alternatively, the word could mean "girl-eyed." "Rude" (*lobētēr*) suggests that Paris is better at hurling insults than weapons. *Aglaos* suggests "cocky" or "proud," and *keras* seems to refer to an elaborate style of hairdressing: *keras* usually means "horn" in Homer, but other ancient sources suggest that it was used to refer to a spiraled or twisted hairstyle that was peculiar from a Greek perspective.
- 11.518** *more birds than women* : An honorable funeral for a Homeric warrior includes women gathered around the body, lamenting his death. These imaginary birds are presumably birds of prey who eat the dead man's flesh.
- 11.555** *crotch* : This rare word, *protmesis* (literally, "front-slit"), means either "navel" or "crotch" (the place where the legs divide), according to ancient commentators. It seems most plausible that a strike from below, under the shield, would reach the crotch first. Wounds in this area are rare in Homer and undignified; the detail underlines Odysseus' willingness to use any and all means to defend himself. A warrior who is surrounded and outnumbered usually retreats rather than going on the offensive.
- 11.591** *But when I die* : I follow the common manuscript reading *autar em' ei ke thanō*, "when I die," rather than the reading of Aristarchus, *autar epei ke thanō*, "if I die," which has been unnecessarily adopted by the Oxford Classical Text.
- 11.610** *something may happen to that brave, strong fighter* : "Something may happen to him" is a common euphemism for "he may die."
- 11.625** *the jackals scatter* : The simile turns out to anticipate the next stage of the action: the jackals (= Trojans) who assail the stag (= Odysseus) will be frightened off by the lion (= Ajax). Of course, Ajax does not eat Odysseus.

- 11.634** *the chariot* : The narrator does not specify whose chariot this is. Ancient commentators insisted that it must belong to Menelaus: Odysseus, as an inhabitant of an impoverished island, brought no chariot to Troy.
- 11.645** *the field's far left* : Probably "left" is defined from the Greek perspective, so "left" is east.
- 11.658** *a three-barbed arrow* : The "triple-barbed" arrow (*triglochis* ) is probably triangle-shaped.
- 11.669** *a wound with healing drugs* : Machaon is a doctor; he is valuable both as a fighter and as a healer.
- 11.675** *Cebriones* : Cebriones is standing beside Hector in his chariot as his driver; he took over after the previous two drivers of Hector were killed in Book 8.
- 11.700** *he avoided doing battle / with Telamonian Ajax* : Hector's intervention is rather pointless, in that he avoids the main combatant, Ajax, whom he has already proved unable to defeat in single combat (in Book 7). Aristotle and Plutarch quoted another line after this one: "because Zeus would be angry with him whenever he would fight a better man." This line is not printed in most modern editions because it does not seem to belong well.
- 11.705** *onto his back* : With the long "tower" type of shield, the wearer could swivel it to the back as protection in flight. This maneuver is less plausible for a round shield; the lines seem to reflect some confused melding of different techniques of warfare.
- 11.765** *leaning their shoulders on the shields* : Presumably this is a defensive formation to cover the wounded man with multiple shields, although the exact mechanics are unclear.
- 11.811** *a fine, well-polished table* : The table is a light, portable item of furniture on which the food can be placed near the chairs. Decorations with blue enamel (*kuanos* ) were a feature of Mycenaean material culture, and the cup mentioned a few lines later, with its elaborate decoration, also seems to be reminiscent of Mycenaean technology.
- 11.814** *an onion* : The onion is a rare detail—Homeric characters usually subsist on meat and bread, without the addition of vegetables. It is unclear whether both onion and honey are to be placed in the porridge drink (like toppings on congee) or eaten on the side.
- 11.817** *a cup of great magnificence* : The cup of Nestor has been extensively studied by archaeologists. The birds are reminiscent of a golden cup found at Mycenae, which has falcons around its handles. The double "supports" underneath the cup may be supports for the handles, legs to prop the cup on the table, or, perhaps less plausibly, a double false bottom such as is found in some pots from Crete. A two-handled ceramic cup found in Ischia, dating from the eighth century BCE, contains the



inscription “I am the cup of Nestor, good for drinking; desire for Aphrodite in her lovely garland will at once seize anyone who drinks.” This inscribed cup implies that a tradition of Nestor as the owner of a special item of drinkware was widely known in the Greek-speaking world. This need not imply that the whole *Iliad* in exactly its current form was known or existed at that place and time.

**11.824** *who could pick it up / with ease* : Heroes usually have special equipment that only they can handle: Hector has his extra-long spear, Odysseus his special bow (*Odyssey* 21), Achilles has divine horses, a special spear, and a bar to his hut that nobody else can lift. The aggrandizing trope is used here for a much more domestic object that has already been carried to the table without difficulty by an elderly woman.

**11.826** *Pramnian wine* : There is no evidence of a place called Pramnos; later sources identify Pramnian wine as a particularly high-quality kind of vintage. Circe makes a similar drink for Odysseus’ men in *Odyssey* 10 (234–35), although hers also contains honey; Nestor’s guests seem to have the honey served on the side, along with the onion. This cheesy wine-sludge, halfway between food and drink, is clearly supposed to be medicinal.

**11.857** *Eurypylus is wounded* : Nestor left the battlefield before the wounding of Eurypylus, so he ought not to know about it. For this reason, many manuscripts and editors omit this line. I include it because Homeric poetic and narrative technique does not imply complete realism about this kind of detail.

**11.869** *If only I were young* : Nestor’s long reminiscence of his youth focuses on his own participation in a raid of animals from a neighboring town, which triggers further hostilities between the people of Pylos and Elis. The geographical location of these places is disputed: Messenian Pylos is more than a hundred miles from Epáno, in Epean territory (not a night’s march, as the story suggests). Either the narrator is muddled about geography, or this Pylos is in a different location. This speech of Nestor’s presumably draws on traditional stories of cattle raids and of the exploits of the Pylians.

**11.874** *as reprisal* : The order of the narrative is slightly confusing: the animals are taken as reprisal for the earlier betrayal of the Pylians by the Epeans (= the inhabitants of Elis), narrated a little later. Nestor explains how the Epeans took advantage of the Pylians after the initial assault by Hercules; his own cattle raid is in retaliation for this earlier attack.

**11.889** *the men / to whom a debt was owed* : I.e., those who have had property stolen from them by the Epeans, as Nestor goes on to explain.

**11.895** *great Heracles / had come* : Ancient commentators were puzzled by this account of Heracles attacking Pylos, which is not one of his Labors. One theory connects this attack with Heracles’ journey to the underworld.

- 11.906** *four prize-winning horses* : Almost all Homeric chariots are drawn by two horses; this is a rare allusion to a four-horsed chariot. Four-horse chariots may have been used in athletic competitions before they were used in war.
- 11.911** *his words* : No insulting words have been cited; presumably this version of the story is missing a stage in which Augeas verbally insulted Neleus or the people of Pylos. Neleus takes some of the cattle and sheep raided by Nestor as compensation for his valuable racehorses.
- 11.921** *the sons of Molione* : The two sons of Molione are Cteatus and Eurytus; the same warriors are also identified as sons of Actor. “Molione” was believed in antiquity to be their mother’s name. Alternatively, it may be a title (“the Molions”). Actor is presumably their adoptive human father, and Poseidon, their divine biological father. These brothers were later killed by Heracles.
- 11.928** *across the plain* : The Epeans are crossing the plain in search of plunder.
- 11.940** *beside Arene* : This river and town are unknown.
- 11.942** *streamed behind* : The language (“streamed,” *epirreon* ) suggests that the foot soldiers are like the flowing river. Nestor seems to identify himself with the elite “horsemen” rather than the lowly men on foot, despite the fact that he has no horses.
- 11.948** *a cow, / fresh from the herd* : A herd cow (*agelaios* ) is one who has not yet been tamed or yoked to the plow—a valuable offering, because the animal’s potential value as a beast of burden is being wasted in honor of the goddess. The “dinner” is the meat from the sacrificial animals; gods are not big eaters.
- 11.982** *Bouprasion / . . . Alesion* : The location specified is not entirely clear, but probably Bouprasion is a district in Elis; the rock of Olen (the Olenian Rock) is probably on the coast of the Gulf of Corinth, with the hill of Alesion to the south.
- 11.991** *if I remember rightly* : The conditional—“if I remember rightly” or “if I really was”—suggests pathos and distance between the speaker’s current experience and his past. A similar idiom is used by Helen in Book 3 (3.224).
- 11.993** *all by himself* : The point is that it is obviously impossible to “enjoy” skill in battle all alone, because warfare is a communal activity.
- 11.1051** *the place the Greeks assembled* : Odysseus’ ships are located at the center of the line of ships along the beach; this is also the location for the Greek assembly.

## BOOK 12 SUMMARY

The narrator tells us that after the Trojan War is over, Apollo and Poseidon will knock down the Greek wall and restore the landscape of the plain as it was before. The trench and wall block the Trojan chariots, but Hector orders the Trojans to advance into the Greek camp on foot. An eagle flies from the left (the unlucky side) and drops a snake among them, which Polydamas tells Hector means that their mission will fail; Hector



dismisses his concerns and they charge ahead over the trench. Sarpedon and Hector break through the wall, and the Trojans surge through. The Greeks are routed and flee to their ships.

- 12.4** *One day, the wide wall* : This unusual passage suddenly shifts the temporal perspective, as the narrator looks ahead to the time after the war is over, when the great fortification wall built by the Greeks to protect their ships will be erased by the gods. It is presumably no coincidence that this passage comes at the center of the poem. The Greeks, like the Trojans in the walled city, are under siege and have protected themselves with a wall, as if the encampment were a second city. The walls of Troy were built by Poseidon and Apollo; the Greek wall is washed away by the same gods. Laomedon, king of Troy and father of Priam, failed to pay the gods for their work, and Poseidon sent a flood and a monster from the sea while Apollo sent plague to Troy; the present passage seems to transfer these myths about Trojan treachery and divine retribution to the Greeks, who are, in this story, the ones who fail to give the gods their due for a wall's construction, and who suffer both flooding and plague.
- 12.25** *Aeseopus, Rhesus / . . . Simoeis* : Of these eight rivers, five are not mentioned elsewhere in Homer, though all but the Caresus appear in Hesiod's *Theogony* (338–45).
- 12.28** *demigods* : This is the only moment in Homer where the warriors are called “demigods,” *hemitheoi* . This detail seems to hint that, from the perspective of the poem's future, the warriors who fight and die at Troy will be a different type and generation of humans from those who come later, the people who live in the time of the poem's singing.
- 12.35** *his trident* : This is the only moment in the poem where Poseidon is featured with a trident; the implement, so familiar from later iconography, is briefly mentioned in *The Odyssey* (4.506, 5.292).
- 12.46** *blazed* : The verb translated as “blazed,” *dedēei*, is a fairly bold metaphor, as if anticipating the later burning of the Greek ships.
- 12.55** *like a wall* : The warriors are in a formation that the narrator explicitly compares to a fortified wall (*purgēdon* , “wall-like,” a word formed from *purgos* , “wall”).
- 12.58** *strong proud spirit* : The word rendered “strong proud spirit,” *agenoriē* , often suggests an excess or extreme (the prefix *ag-* ) of the willfulness or rash egotism that the poem figures as masculine (*-enoriē* is cognate with *anēr*, “man”); see notes at 2.337 and 9.513. The word is slightly anthropomorphic when used of a male animal.
- 12.63** *their horses dared not* : This passage seems to suggest a confusion about the use of horses in war: in *The Iliad* , they are used to pull chariots, although in later

periods of Greek military history, warriors rode as cavalry. It would be reasonable to expect horses to leap across a deep and muddy trench if they were pulling nothing, but the move is much less plausible with chariots.

- 12.82** *such a narrow place* : It is unclear whether the narrow place is the trench itself or, perhaps more likely, on the other side of the trench, where there is no room for a chariot between the trench and the towering wall.
- 12.106** *five groups* : The division of the troops into five seems to be invented for this passage. It adds a sense of importance to the Trojan attack on the Greek wall.
- 12.112** *a weaker warrior* : This explains why Cebriones is joining the attack on foot, not staying with the horses like the other drivers; he is a superior warrior, and wanted at the front.
- 12.119** *his own homeland, / Arisbe* : Arisbe was on the southern shore of the Hellespont. The River Selleis seems here to have changed its usual location; in other instances (2.784 and 15.703), it does not flow into the Hellespont.
- 12.133** *fall beside their own black ships* : I take the Greek to mean that the Greeks will retreat and fall by the ships—i.e., die. But the original is ambiguous, and the ones who “fall” could be the Trojans themselves, with “fall” in the sense of “attack”: “they [the Trojans] will fall on the ships [i.e., attack them].” Part of these lines repeats at 12.156.
- 12.148** *drove their chariots and horses / back from the plain* : This must suggest that there is a side entrance to the Greek camp, presumably including a ford or bridge across the trench as well as a gate in the wall. One might think that “left” would here mean “from the Trojan perspective,” although the narrator’s use of “left” usually suggests the Greek perspective.
- 12.157** *two champions / . . . Lapith warriors* : The Lapiths are a Thessalian tribe, known for their strength; a famous legend told of their battle with the half-horse, half-human Centaurs at a wedding feast (a scene later depicted on the Parthenon at Athens). The two warriors who appear here are listed in the Catalog of Ships.
- 12.171** *Asius / . . . the son of Asius* : It is unusual that a son participates in warfare alongside his father, although the narrator makes nothing of it.
- 12.197** *struck his thighs* : Thigh slapping is a common gesture of emotional distress for Homeric warriors.
- 12.204** *hunting them* : Presumably the humans are hunting for honey—a futile quest in a wasp’s nest.
- 12.210** *Meanwhile / . . . distressed at heart* : These lines, which are peculiar in several ways (for instance, in the use of the first-person “me”), were absent from some ancient texts.
- 12.214** *Bright fire* : There is no other indication that the Trojans set fire to the wall, rather than the ships, and it is also peculiar that the wall is described as made of

stone just as it is burning.

**12.274** *A prophet* : Polydamas is not himself an officially appointed prophet or seer, although he shows an ability to interpret the sign correctly.

**12.289** *eastward to right of us* : The Trojans are facing north, towards the Hellespont and the Greek ships.

**12.293** *Patriotism is the one true bird* : I.e., a warrior guided by the single goal of patriotic fighting to save his country has no need of other signs, whether from birds or other auguries. This aphorism is a famous and much quoted line. Ironically, Hector's own zeal is partly motivated by a belief that the gods are helping him.

**12.303** *his men surged forward* : The narrator seems to forget about the troublesome trench; the Trojans pass over it without further comment. The following passage is the only moment in *The Iliad* that describes the mechanics of siege warfare.

**12.420** *The racket rattled every gate* : The text of this line is disputed. I follow here a manuscript reading, *pasas gar epochoito* , "it traversed all," which I take to refer to the noise that traverses all the gates along the wall. Some editors, including Monro and Allen (Oxford Classical Text) and Martin West (Teubner), follow some ancient critics (Aristarchus) in printing *pasai gar epochoichato* , which is generally taken to mean "the whole gate was closed."

**12.425** *both of them* : I.e., both the warriors named Ajax.

**12.465** *He hurled at him a jagged heavy rock* : This is a technique of siege warfare. The Greeks, standing on top of the wall behind their defensive battlements, have a store of heavy rocks to hurl down at the enemy; Ajax chooses the best and topmost of these stones.

**12.482** *so that no Greek would see that he was wounded* : Glaucus' fear of mockery seems to be greater than his fear of death, although a wounded warrior in enemy territory is likely to be killed.

**12.498** *He would not have him killed / beside the ships' sterns* : This sentence was omitted by some ancient papyri, though present in others. It may have been controversial because the location of the wall is not near the ships' sterns. The line is not to be taken too literally.

**12.519** *a common field* : "A common field" seems to imply that there is some land available to be divided up by common people—in contrast to an estate (*temenos* ) that is owned exclusively by a rich lord or temple. This common land is divided among a large population, hence the measuring sticks and the bickering. The ostensible point of the simile is that the battle is located in such a cramped space, with all the troops hemmed in by the wall. More broadly, the simile reminds us that the Trojan War itself is fought over a small strip of land, and it is, like the dispute in the simile, a conflict over territorial and economic resources that seem important to

the participants, but may seem smaller from a larger perspective (such as that of the gods, by whom this crucial wall can be treated like a sand castle).

**12.525** *circles of oxhide / . . . bucklers* : These lines repeat from Book 5 (5.604–5).

See the note there on the odd language, which represents two different types of shield.

**12.529** *exposed their backs* : The back is particularly vulnerable, because of lack of a shield and also because many Homeric warriors wear a breastplate that covers only their front.

**12.534** *as a careful woman* : This simile provides a rare glimpse of the life of a free (not enslaved) woman, who earns a living for herself and her family by spinning wool. She uses the scales to weigh out the wool required for a particular task or for the day. Spinning and weaving are usually depicted in the Homeric poems as tasks for elite women or goddesses, but they are clearly also practiced by women of much lower economic classes. In preindustrial societies, the construction of cloth and garments was extremely time-consuming, requiring the labor of many female hands.

**12.549** *grabbed a boulder* : Hector, who is repeatedly described as *koruthaiolos* , “with flashing helmet,” is a well-armed, well-equipped warrior and usually fights with bronze weapons. It is significant that at this crucial moment, the defender of Troy breaks the invaders’ wall not with a man-made artifact, but with a piece of his own homeland. The scene bears comparison with the end of *Odyssey* 9, where the Cyclops Polyphemus hurls a rock at the ship of Odysseus.

**12.571** *like sudden night* : Like the famous comparison of Apollo to night in Book 1 (1.67). this comparison gains its power from its brevity and sublime unwillingness to explain what Hector has in common with night.

**12.573** *he held a spear* : Homeric heroes use a pair of light throwing-spears. Hector must have transferred one of his spears to his right hand after hurling the rock, but the poet does not bother to clarify.

## BOOK 13 SUMMARY

Zeus turns his gaze away from the war, and Poseidon rushes to Troy to encourage the Greeks, first disguising himself as the prophet Calchas and then speaking directly to try to shame them into fighting. Hector fights with extraordinary zeal and rouses the Trojans. There is intense fighting, and Hector, aiming for Teucer, kills Amphinachus, grandson of Poseidon, rousing the god’s wrath. The god inspires Idomeneus, who, along with Meriones, attacks the Trojans and wounds Deiphobus. Menelaus kills several Trojans. The assault of the two Ajaxes diminishes Trojan morale. Hector summons Paris and tries to rouse the Trojans, but an eagle, flying on the right of the Greeks, suggests that they have the dominant position.

- 13.4** *He turned his shining eyes away* : Zeus is gazing to the north of Troy, at the territories of horse herders and nomads. “Hippemolgi” means “horse milkers.” The Abii seem to be another tribe, although some readers have treated the word as an adjective, “without violence,” describing the Hippemolgi. Presumably these nomadic peoples are kind because they do not have territorial wars, which makes a nice break for Zeus.
- 13.48** *like flame or wind* : This slightly unusual pair of comparisons may be hendiadys —i.e., perhaps they are like a flame whipped up by a wind.
- 13.54** *who surrounds the world* : Poseidon surrounds or holds the earth because the sea wraps around the land (especially when land consists largely of islands, as in the Greek-speaking world).
- 13.68** *a mighty son of Zeus* : Hector is not a son of Zeus, although he wishes for immortality and divine status at 8.714. The Greeks consistently present Hector as both presumptuous and rabid, like a mad dog. This dehumanizing trope always comes from Hector’s enemies, not the narrator.
- 13.91** *his feet and legs* : It is unclear what exactly is special about divine feet and legs (or, more literally, “shins”—the word *knēmē* suggests the lower leg). Perhaps the god’s enormous stride is the giveaway. It is peculiar that Ajax recognizes the god only “once he had turned around”—or “from behind,” *metopisthe* —as if a god striding towards a human would arouse no suspicion at all.
- 13.169** *One line of spears was layered on another* : I take it that the image is of multiple lines of spears, one behind another, which might look from the front like layers of cloth or hide.
- 13.177** *the shameless stone* : The stone is *anaideos* , “shameless,” because it takes no notice of anything in its way. Stones are shameless elsewhere in Homer. This stone is personified: it runs, leaps, and is eager to continue. Hector is associated with the rocky land of the Troad itself: he broke the Greek wall with a stone, and now is himself like the liveliest and most vigorous of stones, as he rushes against the invaders.
- 13.199** *with confidence / . . . tiptoed lightly* : It is peculiar that Deiphobus is both moving forward confident and tiptoeing. Presumably the light step and the crouch are not marks of lack of confidence, but of a particular military strategy, as he tries to advance cautiously on the enemy. Hector uses the same tactic a little later in this same book, with an equal lack of success.
- 13.217** *Pedaeum* : The location of Pedaeum is unknown; presumably it was somewhere near Troy. The name Medesicaste appears as a sister of Priam, not daughter, in Apollodorus’ *Epistome* (6.15c).
- 13.225** *his long spear* : There is a continuity error here; Teucer was holding a bow earlier, not a spear. The poet seems to have mixed up Telamonian Ajax, who is

fighting with a spear, with his half brother, Teucer, who is using a bow. Teucer's dash to strip the arms seems to suggest that he has killed from a distance (as with a bow); close combat, using a stabbing spear, should not require any further movement to strip the victim's armor.

**13.237** *the son of Cteatus, the son of Actor* : Amphimachus is also a grandson of Poseidon, a fact that will soon prove important.

**13.249** *both the corpses* : The corpses of Imbrius, the Trojan ally and kinsman of Priam, and Amphimachus, a Greek leader, are associated by the narrator but treated very differently by the Greeks: Amphimachus is carried back to camp for his funeral rites, whereas Imbrius is decapitated.

**13.251** *troops from Athens* : The forces from Athens are notoriously feeble in *The Iliad*. One ancient commentator mocked Stichius and Menestheus as mere "corpse-bearers," not blessed with any display of military prowess.

**13.253** *care for him* : These lines detail how each dead man is dragged back to be cared for by his people. The language, as is typical in this poem, presents the dead as still themselves—so that Amphimachus, for example, is still Amphimachus, not "the corpse of Amphimachus," and he requires care and honor, despite being dead. The dead enemy, Imbrius, is humiliated by the atrocities performed on him.

**13.265** *the head* : Decapitation is rare in *The Iliad* ; this desecration of a fallen enemy is shocking and extreme. Oilean Ajax has a pattern of abusive behavior. In a story that does not appear in *The Iliad* , he raped Priam's daughter, Cassandra, in the temple of Athena, arousing the anger of the goddess.

**13.287** *right now* : "Now" suggests a contrast: the Greeks were to blame earlier, when they ran away.

**13.328** *I want to fight* : This unusual scene creates social comedy out of the masculine warrior code: Idomeneus and Meriones are both embarrassed to be found by the other away from the battlefield, and Meriones is particularly embarrassed to have been caught borrowing Idomeneus' spear without asking. They resolve the situation by insisting on their unwavering eagerness to get back to the battle, and by joking about the phallic imagery of breaking or losing a spear.

**13.357** *If, from the finest fighters* : This is a long meandering sentence in which the apodosis of the conditional does not show up for many lines. But there is a point to the length of the sentence: it allows Idomeneus to tease Meriones by postponing the reassurance that he has asked for. The meandering discourse may be also a sign of Idomeneus' age; older men in Homer are prone to prolixity.

**13.389** *indomitable Flight* : Phobos (Flight) is named as a son of Ares along with Terror (Deimos) in the *Theogony* (934). The word suggests both the action of fleeing in battle, and the accompanying feelings of fear and panic, which can



overcome anybody on the battlefield, even somebody who may pride himself on his courage.

**13.392** *the Ephyri or brave Phlegyae* : The Ephyri and Phlegyae are fighting each other, and Ares and his son favor only one side, not both. The peoples named are both Thessalian tribes; the Phlegyae may also be equated with the Lapiths, known for their conflict with the Centaurs.

**13.424** *nobody runs faster than Achilles* : Telamonian Ajax, with his heavy shield, excels in close hand-to-hand combat, whereas swift-footed Achilles excels at the more open style of fighting in which one warrior pursues another across a large territory. Along with archery, represented by Teucer, these are the three main styles of Homeric warfare.

**13.425** *the left of battle* : The left is defined from the Greek point of view, as usual in the poem—i.e., east, which is “left” for someone looking from the sea towards the city.

**13.437** *As when the dust* : Similes are common before a major battle scene, increasing our awareness of the momentousness of the occasion. The image invites us to think of the armies as a collective, even though the men are united only for the purpose of killing one another.

**13.468** *This rope* : The image is of the divine brothers playing a game of tug-of-war. The “rope” cannot itself be “untied,” but it unties men’s limbs, i.e., causes their death—a common Homeric metaphor.

**13.470** *half gray, Idomeneus* : Idomeneus is represented as older than many of the warriors at Troy, although younger than Nestor.

**13.475** *to Troy* : There is a slight linguistic oddity in the original here: Othryoneus is described as “being inside” (*endon eonta*), which in context must mean that he has come “to Troy,” but the phrase “being inside” is always elsewhere used more literally. The location of Cadesus is unknown; several different places were proposed in antiquity, in Thrace, Lycia, Cappadocia, or around the Hellespont. It is not very plausible that the news of a ten-year-long war would have only just reached a nearby region, but realism matters less than the pathos generated by the romantic details: an aspirant, impoverished, inexperienced young man, with bright hopes for marriage and ridiculous overconfidence, dies within moments of setting foot on the battlefield.

**13.489** *His armor clattered as he fell* : Presumably, this phrase suggests that Othryoneus dies, or at least receives his deathblow; Idomeneus’ cruel jokes are addressed to a corpse.

**13.507** *Asius* : In Book 12, Asius was the only Trojan who insisted on bringing his horses and chariot across the Greek wall; his death was predicted at that moment (12.139–40).

- 13.527** *he tumbled from the chariot* : This is a rare instance of a battle death in which the victim is not named. Some critics have suggested that perhaps his name is Driver.
- 13.537** *in spirals* : The word rendered “in spirals” is cognate with *dineō*, “to go in circles,” and *dinē*, “an eddy.” It may simply suggest “decorated,” but it could also suggest the circles that decorated many shields in the eighth century BCE or the circular layers of leather and metal used in the shield’s construction. The “straps” are also debated; they may be handles for holding the shield or bars crossing on the inside to help it keep its shape.
- 13.555** *to protect his comrade* : Hypsenor seems to be dead at 13.545, once his liver is skewered, but he still requires care (so that his body is not defiled). This is a particularly lively corpse; as ancient critics commented, dead men usually do not groan. Presumably the poet has recycled the phrasing used to describe the carrying of the wounded Teucer, without troubling too much about its implausibility.
- 13.564** *to wrap some Trojan in the black of night* : The language used here to refer to death is somewhat unusual. When warriors die, darkness often covers their eyes, but nowhere else is killing described as “wrapping [the victim] with night.”
- 13.586** *made the wooden shaft vibrate* : This weird incident—the dying heart that is able to wiggle a spear—underlines an important theme: that ostensibly inanimate objects, such as weapons, dead bodies, and body parts, have a life and power of their own.
- 13.607** *angry with Priam* : There is no other reference to the quarrel of Aeneas and Priam, and presumably it is made up for this passage, as a convenient explanation for why Aeneas has not appeared until now. The trope also helps underline the similarities between Greeks and Trojans: both have walls and besieged cities, and now both also have a sulking warrior who refuses to fight because of his anger against the main leader.
- 13.611** *save your kinsmen* : As is typical, the language does not distinguish between the care and protection needed in life and in death. If anything, the dead are in even greater need of care than the living, because they can do nothing to help themselves.
- 13.613** *Alcathous, / who is your family* : Alcathous must be understood as much older than Aeneas. According to myth, Aeneas was conceived when Anchises had sex with Aphrodite. The human was supposed to keep his liaison with the goddess secret, but failed to do so, and was punished with disability (or perhaps death). Anchises is absent in *The Iliad*.
- 13.639** *endlessly afraid* : The word for “endlessly” in the Greek, *ainōs*, echoes Aeneas’ name.
- 13.643** *If I were as young as he is* : I.e., if Idomeneus were still young, he would be willing to face Aeneas in a one-on-one duel, rather than having to summon his



comrades to help.

**13.647** *they all stood close together* : The warriors are inclining their shields so they are all parallel to one another. Perhaps the reference to the shoulders indicates that these are large shields, carried with a strap over one shoulder.

**13.670** *poured* : The verb *aphusso* (“poured,” “siphoned,” “drew”) is normally used for drawing wine or water from a larger vessel.

**13.678** *then sprint back* : Homeric warriors hurl light throwing-spears across an open area at their opponents, dash to retrieve them, and then sprint back out of the enemy’s range—a technique that relies on fast sprinting, and is more difficult for a fighter laden with heavy armor. When warriors fight closer together, they use swords or the heavier thrusting-spear, relying more on strength than speed.

**13.686** *the war god, Enyalios* : Enyalios is an epithet of Ares.

**13.687** *his shoulder* : In Homer, shoulder wounds are always fatal.

**13.721** *the whole vein* : There is no such vein. Commentators have tried in vain to create an anatomically possible scenario. Ancient commentators identified this body part with the *vena cava* , and the spinal cord has also been suggested. It is not particularly likely that either one could be sliced off with a spear’s blow to the back. As so often, the central purpose is not anatomical realism but visceral excitement.

**13.745** *a fire-charred thistle* : The word translated as “thistle,” *skolos* , which appears only here, is identified by ancient commentators as a thistle or thorn. Modern commentators usually argue that the word must instead mean “stake,” because it is probably related to *skolops* , “stake,” and stakes were charred by fire to harden them. But “thistle” makes more sense of the simile, because a thistle might stick onto something (as the half-spear sticks to the shield), whereas there is nothing particularly sticky about a stake.

**13.758** *gasping for a while* : The temporal sequence is muddled, because the simile relates to the pulling out of the spear (which resembles the pulling of the ox), rather than the striking of the blow. When the spear is pulled out, Adamas is pulled with it for a moment, and then dies.

**13.789** *sheep’s wool sling* : The sling, a cheap, easily portable weapon, is used by the less wealthy warriors; the attendant has to give up his only weapon to tend his master’s injured hand.

**13.793** *you, / Lord Menelaus* : The narrator sometimes uses the second person to address particular characters, especially Menelaus and Patroclus (see note at 4.163).

**13.804** *a fine bronze axe* : Battle-axes are rare in Homer and usually seem to be a non-Greek type of weapon. In Homer, axes are usually used for chopping wood.

- 13.811** *popped his eyeballs out* : This thrillingly gruesome sequence is anatomically impossible, but clearly the popped eyeball move was an audience favorite; it recurs at 16.929–30.
- 13.828** *a loving welcome* : Dramatic irony: Menelaus does not consider that the love shown to a certain Trojan by Helen might have been part of the problem.
- 13.856** *through the bladder* : Like many of the goriest deaths in the poem, this is anatomically improbable, especially as the victim is then propped up on the wounded buttock. The point of the scene is to demonstrate the agonizing physical and social humiliations that are enabled by war. The son of a king receives a particularly embarrassing and painful death.
- 13.862** *took care of him* : The gruesome buttock wound might seem to have been fatal, but it is usually the wounded, not the dead, who are taken from the battlefield in chariots, and the action of sitting the injured man up does not suggest a corpse. The narrator is perhaps a little vague on the time of death.
- 13.866** *no compensation* : In peacetime, a bereaved family member could impose a compensation payment, *poinē* , for a violent killing—as in the scene on the shield of Achilles, where men are arguing about the proper price for a dead kinsman. In wartime, beloved family members and comrades are slaughtered, and there is no recompense for their loss (18.622).
- 13.871** *a guest-friend* : Ironically, Paris defends the norms and ideals of hospitality (*xenia* ), although his own violation of *xenia* —abducting his hostess—is what caused the war (and Harpalion’s death).
- 13.874** *Polyidus* : The name Polyidus, “Much-knowing,” is appropriate for the man’s profession.
- 13.884** *the Greeks’ steep fine* : This a rare moment when we are told that the Greeks who wished to fight at Troy levied a fine on those who refused to enlist. The detail helps explain how the sons of Atreus managed to gather such a large collection of forces and ships for a war to retrieve one man’s wife. The prophecy of Polyidus creates a parallel with Achilles, who has a similarly bifurcated destiny, and who will also (after the events of the poem) be killed by Paris.
- 13.899** *those of Ajax* : In the line of Greek ships, the first, farthest to the left (eastward) side and drawn up highest on the shore, belonged to Protesilaus, the first to set foot on Trojan land and the first to die in the war (2.829). Next farthest east are the ships of Oilean Ajax. The original text does not specify which Ajax is meant, but it must be Oilean Ajax, because the Locrians defend the area (13.904). This arrangement for the ships contradicts the order suggested elsewhere: in Books 10 (10.141) and 11 (11.11), it seems that Oilean Ajax has his ships near the center, near those of Odysseus, with the ships of Telamonian Ajax to the left (= east).

- 13.901** *The wall* : This low wall has confused commentators; some maintain that it is a different wall from the large, impressive wall breached by the Trojans in Book 12. More likely, it is the same wall, but it is relatively low at the very end of the line of ships, because either Sarpedon broke the battlements (as the ancient commentators suggested) or it was built that way, since the ends of the line require less defense.
- 13.915** *the men from Phthia* : Phthia is the home of Achilles, although his men are called Myrmidons. Perhaps the Myrmidons are imagined as one tribe among many, in a large territory; or perhaps the confusion about leadership in Phthia reflects uncertainty about the geography of northern Greece. The name of the ruler of the Phthians, *Podarces* (Swift-Footed) echoes one of Achilles' own standard epithets ("swift-footed Lord Achilles"). Podarces seems to have taken over from the dead Protesilaus, who originally led those from Phylace (2.825). Medon has taken over from Philoctetes, as we learned at 2.842.
- 13.931** *wine-dark* : The epithet "wine-dark" or "wine-faced" is often used of the sea; here it describes the color of these dark, perhaps reddish oxen.
- 13.937** *cut the field until they reach the headland* : The headland of the field is the part where the plow turns at the end of each furrow; this area is plowed last, so once it is cut, the oxen's work is done. The oxen are like the two Ajaxes both in their closeness and their capacity for hard labor.
- 13.941** *his shield* : Most Homeric warriors carry a light round shield (*aspis*), but Telamonian Ajax has a large, heavy shield (*sakos*) that covers his whole body and requires great strength and effort to carry. There are no other allusions in Homer to shield bearers; fighters with the lighter shield do not need a bearer.
- 13.943** *no followers* : The narrator first leads us to believe that Oilean Ajax is completely bereft of troops—until it is gradually revealed that his followers are skirmishers rather than heavy-armed combat fighters.
- 13.993** *like a snowy mountain* : This simile is surprising, because mountains do not stride, scream, or fly—but the oddity makes the image all the scarier. The points of comparison are Hector's size (he towers, mountainlike, above the other men) and his dazzling armor (which shines like snow).
- 13.1012** *Pathetic Paris! Womanizer! Cheat!* : Hector uses the same sequence of insults to his brother at 3.48.
- 13.1037** *changed his brother's mind* : The council discussion advised by Polydamas does not happen; instead, the Trojans rush ahead into battle.
- 13.1043** *the sons of Lord Hippotion* : In Book 14 (14.681–83), Phalces, Morus, and Hippotion all die. "Hippotion" in Book 14 may be a slip for Ascanius—the narrator may have forgotten that he gave the son a different name from the father. In the Catalog of Ships (2.1027), Ascanius is the leader of the Phrygians—and therefore

was at Troy from the beginning of the war; this is one of many minor inconsistencies around minor characters in the poem. Only the Trojans receive replacement troops.

**13.1070** *It is a waste of time* : I follow the Oxford Classical Text in adopting the text read by the ancient critic Aristarchus here: *autōs* —i.e., Hector’s attempt to scare the Greeks is “in vain.” An ancient papyrus and some medieval manuscripts read instead *outōs* (“like this”), in which case the line would mean “Why are you so scared of the Greeks?”

**13.1082** *upon the right* : A bird on the right signals a true sign—a hint that in Book 22, Hector will in fact be stranded on the plain, with no chariot or horses, and will flee from Achilles, who outruns him. Bird omens in Homer always come true.

**13.1088** *If only I could be a son of Zeus* : Hector’s impossible fantasy of his own divine birth suggests overconfidence; unlike Achilles, he is not of divine heritage—and unlike Achilles, he does not fully understand that he has chosen glory at the cost of his life.

**13.1108** *rays of Zeus* : The “rays of Zeus,” *augas Dios* , is an unprecedented expression, which suggests both the light of the upper air and the vision of Zeus, who may soon turn his attention back to the war at Troy—unless he is deliberately distracted by his clever wife.

## BOOK 14 SUMMARY

The Greek leaders scan the battlefield and realize how many are wounded or dead. Agamemnon wants to go home, but Odysseus scolds him. Poseidon inspires the Greeks. Hera forms a plan to distract Zeus. She dresses herself with maximum attractiveness through a visit to Aphrodite, then seduces him. Afterwards, he falls asleep. Hera tells Poseidon that the field is clear, and he gives further encouragement to the Greeks. Telamonian Ajax knocks Hector unconscious with a boulder. Greeks slaughter Trojans in large numbers, and they flee towards the city.

**14.1** *Nestor was drinking* : The action of this book begins with Nestor left as we last saw him, drinking in his hut with Machaon (11.803). The narrator manages multiple simultaneous time lines in these central books of the poem, increasing our sense of the scale and complexity of the action. The ancient commentators were worried by the undignified implication of the sentence, that Nestor might have been too distracted by his drinking to pay attention to the battle (“but,” *pinonta per empes* ). It is an appropriate opening for a book that centers on Zeus’ inability to concentrate on the war once pleasure gets in the way.

**14.12** *his father’s* : Thrasymedes borrowed his father’s shield at 10.312 and gave it to Diomedes for the night raid. The detail provides a glimpse of intimate community

and goods shared between kinsmen and comrades in the allied Greek forces, which contrasts sharply with the quarrel of Achilles and Agamemnon.

- 14.19** *the deep sea* : The sea is personified and the simile is very alliterative (*porphurei pelagos . . . kumati kophoi* ). Nestor's state of mind is like this sea, because he is confused and indecisive.
- 14.40** *the first ships dragged toward the plain* : This seems to mean that the ships of these leaders, the first to make landfall at Troy, are dragged highest up the beach from the sea (stern first, in position ready to leave again); at their sterns, the wall is built, while the ships that arrive subsequently are lined up below them, nearer the sea. But the lines are ambiguous for two reasons: because "first" could mean "first on shore," i.e., those which have been drawn up highest on the beach, or it could mean, "first in line next to the sea," i.e., the lowest on the beach; and the word rendered "sterns," *prumneisin* , could also mean "last" (although it does not have that meaning elsewhere in Homer). An alternative interpretation is therefore that the leaders' ships are "first" as in nearest to the sea, and the highest, "last" ships are nearest to the wall. At 14.96, the "first" ships must be those nearest the sea.
- 14.56** *He threatened* : Hector made this speech at 8.698 and shouted this threat to the Trojans at 8.238. Agamemnon was not, of course, present at the Trojan assembly, but the narrator feels no need to explain how he knows about the threat. Both Agamemnon and Nestor speak with a certain vagueness about whether Hector's threats are already fulfilled, or are in process of fulfillment; he has broken the wall and remains by the ships, but he has not yet set the fleet on fire.
- 14.68** *construct a different plan* : The verb *paratektenaito* , "construct," suggests that Zeus is a carpenter (*tektōn* ), whose materials are not wood but events. The metaphor leads to discussion of the wall, a material construction that turns out to have been more easily deconstructed than Nestor had hoped.
- 14.73** *However hard you looked* : This passage recalls the moment in Book 5 (5.110) where Diomedes fights so vigorously that, the narrator comments, you cannot tell what side he is on. Here, the Greeks are panicking and in such a state of confusion that they run in all directions.
- 14.102** *There is no shame in fleeing from disaster* : Agamemnon has a pattern of suggesting that the whole Greek fleet should give up and go home; his suggestion here echoes Book 2 (2.132) and the start of Book 9, where he makes the same suggestion.
- 14.108** *fence of teeth* : The idea that words, especially shocking or surprising words, are like fugitives who flee past the "fence" or "barrier" of the teeth (*herkos*— a defensive military structure, like the Greek wall) is a conventional metaphor in the Homeric poems. But the image takes on a special resonance in the context of a conversation about literal flight, when a literal barrier (the wall) has been breached.

- 14.112** *loops* : The implicit metaphor of the verb “to loop,” *tolupeuein* , is of winding wool, and hence, metaphorically, of winding the skein of life.
- 14.135** *against their will* : Odysseus was in fact not claiming that the Greeks would be unwilling to launch the ships, but that they would be all too willing to flee (and in battle, cowardice kills).
- 14.138** *a young or older man* : Diomedes is always characterized as notably young, as if he were constantly embarking on his first war and first council meeting. But he is also a veteran warrior, who sacked Thebes with the other “late-born” heroes (the Epigoni, sons of the Seven Against Thebes).
- 14.148** *three sons* : Diomedes here gives an account of his ancestry, explaining how his father, Tydeus, was descended from a noble Aetolian family (Pleuron and Calydon are the main cities in Aetolia), before leaving his home territory and marrying into a rich family in Argos. He omits mention of the Sack of Thebes, perhaps out of modesty.
- 14.157** *a daughter of Adrastus* : Like his father, Diomedes married a daughter of Adrastus, his aunt Aegialeia (5.553).
- 14.202** *her brother and her husband’s brother* : Hera, Poseidon, and Zeus, along with Hades, Demeter, and Hestia (deities who play a more minor role in *The Iliad* but were essential in Greek cult practice), were the children of Cronus and Rhea.
- 14.221** *ambrosia* : Ambrosia means “immortal stuff.” It is a multipurpose substance that can serve as divine food, skin cleanser, or a preserving agent for a corpse (16.839).
- 14.239** *drops like mulberries* : Earrings with three drops like a mulberry have been found in a grave at Lefkandi, a site in northern Greece. The language here probably suggests that they are made of granulated gold, a technique that dates from the mid-ninth century BCE.
- 14.244** *adorned herself completely* : This scene is a variation on the more usual trope of the arming scene, in which someone puts on and takes up a series of elaborately crafted items of armor and weapons. Hera’s arms and accessories are different, but they serve the same purpose: preparing her to defeat an opponent.
- 14.261** *Ocean and Mother Tethys* : Ocean is the great mythical river that wraps around the landmass of the world and the patriarchal deity of that body of water. Tethys, his wife, is a sea deity.
- 14.266** *ceaseless quarrel* : Hera creates a story about Oceanus and Tethys that echoes the central narrative of the poem: a quarrel between two allies.
- 14.278** *the embroidered strap* : It is unclear how this little accessory has all these things on it or in it. Presumably it is embroidered with erotic imagery, which serve as seduction spells.
- 14.288** *ox-eyed Hera / smiled* : The smile of Hera signals a funny reversal: the goddess who loves smiles is usually Aphrodite (*philommedes*, “smile-lover,” is one of her



standard epithets)—but now Hera has co-opted Aphrodite’s usual territory and goes, equipped with smiles and all the arts of seduction, to seduce and deceive her husband. As goddess of marriage, Hera is usually associated with public and institutionalized manifestations of sex and desire, whereas Aphrodite presides over illicit sexual urges.

**14.291** *Hera swiftly left* : Hera travels from Olympus down the Macedonian coast to Mount Athos, and then to Lemnos, then northeast to Imbros, south down the coast of the Troad, and east again to reach Mount Ida. The journey is not designed to reach the destination by the most efficient route, but to allow the narrator to cite some sonically beautiful place-names. Lemnos has a particular association with Hera’s son, Hephaestus, and hence with fire (a special area of expertise for Hephaestus); it is not elsewhere associated with sleep.

**14.299** *Lemnos* : Lemnos is the name of the whole island and also of its main town.

**14.301** *Death’s brother* : Death and Sleep are the children of Night.

**14.326** *heroic Heracles* : Heracles sacked Troy when Laomedon, father of Priam, was king, after Laomedon went back on his word; like the story of Paris and Helen, this Trojan legend trades on Greek prejudice against easterners as traitors. Heracles saved Troy from a sea monster, sent by Poseidon, but did not receive the horses that Laomedon had promised as a reward. The story that Sleep was persuaded by Hera to put Zeus to sleep on that occasion is probably made up for this context; it is not otherwise attested. The story is modeled on the traditional myth, told in Book 1 of *The Iliad* , that Hephaestus was thrown out of the sky by Zeus and survived only thanks to divine protection. Night is Sleep’s mother.

**14.360** *the gods below the earth* : The gods of the underworld, in a nether region called Tartarus, are traditionally the guarantors of oaths. They are here associated with the Titans, the earlier generation of deities overthrown by Zeus. Sleep, one of the most ancient powers in the world, respects the earlier generation more than the new.

**14.373** *Lecton* : A promontory at the foot of Mount Ida.

**14.380** *screeching owl* : This bird is some kind of raptor that frequents mountains and forests and is presumably nocturnal (as would suit Sleep), and it is described as “shrill” or “screechy.” Various species have been suggested: it might be a eagle owl, which is bronze-colored, a hawk owl, or a long-eared owl (which would be likely to be in a fir tree, since they frequent conifers). The claim that the bird has both a divine and human name echoes other moments when the Homeric narrator claims to have special knowledge of divine language. Here, the two names suggest a buried allusion to a myth of metamorphosis: a girl called Chalchis was transformed into this bird. The double names suggest that only gods can still recognize that the bird is actually the girl. The layers of disguise in this little incident set up the following scene of deceit.

- 14.388** *so that their loving parents would not know* : The detail about the divine couple's struggle to find a private place to have sex is one of many funny moments in this *epi* sode. It contradicts what we were told earlier—that Hera was sent away as a baby to be raised by Oceanus and Tethys, while Zeus was defeating Cronus.
- 14.417** *I lusted* : As ancient critics noted, this seduction speech by the clever god of strategy is not very seductive or very good strategy. The goddess is not likely to be aroused by a long list of her husband's sexual conquests and rapes. Hera's rage at her husband's philandering was a common trope in myth. Luckily, Hera needs no seducing, since she has other purposes in mind. The cluelessness of almighty Zeus adds to the humor of the scene; like numerous other powerful male characters, he fixates on his own accomplishments, and fails to consider other people's feelings. The passage echoes Paris' speech to Helen before their sex scene in Book 3 (3.549), although Paris—aided by Aphrodite—does not make the same tactical errors. Ixion and Pirithous were both rapists; Ixion tried to rape Hera and was punished in the underworld by being strapped forever to a wheel, and Pirithous tried to rape Persephone, queen of the underworld, with similarly poor results.
- 14.420** *Danae* : Danae's father, Acrisius, tried to protect her from would-be suitors and rapists by locking her in a high tower, Rapunzel-style, but Zeus descended through the window as a shower of golden rain. The myth was often interpreted as a metaphor for prostitution.
- 14.425** *Europa* / . . . *Rhadamanthus* : Zeus transformed himself into a bull to trick and abduct Europa, whom he carried from Phoenicia to Crete. Minos and Rhamanthus, lawgivers on Crete, became the lawgivers in the underworld. The union also produced Sarpedon.
- 14.427** *Semele* / . . . *Heracles* : Semele, daughter of Cadmus, and Alcmene, wife of Amphitryon, are both from Thebes. The mention of Heracles is particularly tactless (in many versions of the myth, it was Hera, enraged at her husband's infidelity, who imposed the Labors on Heracles). Dionysus is the joy of mortals because he is the god of wine.
- 14.432** *Demeter* / . . . *Leto* : Zeus' rape of Demeter begat Persephone, who was then raped by her uncle, Hades, and became queen of the underworld. Zeus' rape of the goddess Leto resulted in the twins Apollo and Artemis; Hera drove the pregnant Leto all over the Aegean to prevent or delay the birth, as told in the Homeric Hymn to Apollo. Again, the choice of examples is in comically poor taste.
- 14.466** *shining drops of dew* : This description evokes the mythical marriage of Gaia and Uranus, Earth and Sky, which produced the universe in the first place. The dew provides an elegant and funny way of describing Zeus' ejaculation—an event that is important for the plot (he is sleepy afterwards) but would be unsuitable for an epic poet to narrate directly.



- 14.479** *Sleep passed* : Sleep continues with his usual activities, sending humans to sleep.
- 14.499** *give his little shield* : The ancient critic Aristarchus thought this passage ridiculous, because the better warriors ought to have had good shields to start with. The exchange of armor signifies the Greek warriors' renewed zeal for battle and also anticipates the turning point of the poem: when Patroclus takes Achilles' armor in Book 16.
- 14.517** *rope of war* : The metaphor is common in the central books of *The Iliad* . It suggests that the two sides are playing a game of tug-of-war on the battlefield.
- 14.534** *straps* : There is a wordplay in the original: the straps are *telamone* , echoing the name of Ajax's father, Telamon.
- 14.556** *his fine bronze armor clattered* : The description allows the listener or reader to believe, for a moment, that Hector might be dead; the trope of the clattering armor is usually used for a death scene.
- 14.598** *His mother* : The unnamed mother is the goddess associated with the River Satnioeis; the son's name is taken from his mother as well as from his place of conception.
- 14.645** *fine Peneleus* : Peneleus is a kinsman of Acamas.
- 14.650** *Hermes loved Phorbas* : Hermes is associated with shepherds. Phorbas, otherwise unknown, has a name that means "fodder" (*phorbē* ). The suggestion of a pastoral beginning may hint back to the beginning of the Trojan myth, when Paris was a shepherd and encountered Hermes, who invited him to judge between three goddesses. The name of his son, Ilioneus, echoes the name of the city (and the poem): Ilium (Ilion). This whole grisly sequence anticipates the fall of Troy.
- 14.675** *Now, Muses* : This new invocation to the Muses marks a new phase in the war: now, thanks to Poseidon and Hera, the Greeks are triumphant over the Trojans, even in the absence of Achilles and even with many of the famous fighters out of action.
- 14.692** *Zeus aroused* : Zeus is in fact still asleep, but soon to wake; the reference to his agency in battle creates suspense. Oilean Ajax echoes Achilles in his military and athletic skills: like Achilles, he excels in running after an enemy in flight.

## BOOK 15 SUMMARY

Zeus wakes up and is angry, but reassures Hera that Troy is still destined to fall. Iris is sent to tell Poseidon to leave the battlefield. Apollo energizes Hector and the Trojans, and eventually joins them in the fight. The Greeks flee, and the Trojans beat down the ramparts. Intense fighting breaks out around the ships, defended by Telamonian Ajax and Teucer with his bow. Eventually Hector reaches the Greek ships.

- 15.1** *Zeus woke up* : Some ancient texts had an extra line here, to ensure that Zeus does not oversee battle operations in the nude: “He sat up straight, and put on his soft tunic.”
- 15.21** *this disgusting patchwork* : Zeus uses a word that is otherwise unparalleled, *kakorrhaphie* (from “evil,” *kak-*, combined with *raphie*, “stitching” or “plotting”). The imagery suggests that Hera has used something analogous to her feminine skills in needlework to put together her plot.
- 15.23** *I hung you* : In other versions of the myth, Zeus punished Hera for her persecution of Heracles; the reference may remind the audience that Hector likes to imagine himself as, like Heracles, a son of Zeus—but he is in fact completely mortal, the son of mortal parents. The myth also recalls earlier stages in the cosmological narrative, in which Zeus lashes the earth (with a lash or whip made of lightning). The anvils, *akmones*, were meteorites imagined as thunderbolts in earlier versions of the myth; thunder was believed to be the fall of meteoric stones hammering the earth. The myth of Hera’s punishment recalls the punishments inflicted on enslaved people, at least in later (Roman) periods.
- 15.30** *anyone I caught* : The only god hurled from the sky by Zeus in most versions of the myth (including the end of Book 1) is Hephaestus.
- 15.36** *to Cos* : This is the same episode referred to at 14.326 (see note there). Again, the references to Hera’s persecution of Heracles create a partial analogy between Heracles and Hector, both of whom suffer from Hera’s hostility. The comparison increases the pathos of Hector’s mortality, because Heracles, unlike Hector, was half divine and, according to many versions of the myth, he was eventually raised to Olympus.
- 15.49** *by the waters of the Styx* : The Styx is a river in the underworld, the most serious oath for gods. Humans sometimes swear by the head of Zeus; the oath acquires a layer of comedy when used in direct conversation with Zeus himself. The oath by the marriage bed also has a special layer of irony: Hera’s special province is marriage, and she has just demonstrated her ability to weaponize her sphere of influence, cleverly cheating Zeus despite not cheating on him.
- 15.61** *comply / like me* : Hera avoids actually saying that she herself follows Zeus’ lead. Instead, she slyly suggests that Poseidon should also follow Zeus, implying that she herself already does so—while also hinting that Poseidon might want to follow her own lead, and ostensibly follow Zeus, while indirectly continuing to work against him. “To comply like me” could imply “comply wholeheartedly, as I do,” or it could imply “combine apparent compliance with underhand subversion, as I do.” The subtlety is characteristic of Hera.
- 15.95** *Athena’s strategies* : An implicit allusion to the Wooden Horse, the stratagem put into the mind of Odysseus by his mentor, Athena, through which the Greeks will

finally manage to penetrate the city.

**15.97** *my anger* : The anger of Zeus against Hera parallels the anger of Achilles against Agamemnon. Both the rage of the god and the rage of the human work to delay, but not prevent, the fall of the city. This passage is unusual in that it looks beyond the scope of the poem itself.

**15.119** *fresh-faced Themis* : “Themis” means “custom,” “norm,” or “tradition,” a concept close to Hera’s heart as the goddess associated with marriage. In Hesiod, Themis is Zeus’ second wife (*Theogony* 901). The goddess’s name recalls that of Thetis, and in some versions of the myth, Themis worked with Zeus to plot the Trojan War, which entailed marrying Thetis to a mortal, to ensure the birth of Achilles (this story is known from an ancient summary of a lost Trojan War poem, the *Cypria* ). Themis seems to be well aware that Hera’s husband is regularly violent to her.

**15.131** *Very few gods or mortals will be pleased* : A way of hinting that everybody will be displeased, except Thetis and Achilles.

**15.139** *So foolishly* : Hera’s language could suggest that it is always foolish to oppose Zeus—or that it is foolish to do so in foolish ways (rather than using clever tactics, as she herself does).

**15.152** *his sturdy thighs* : Thigh slapping is a common gesture of male grief in Homer.

**15.202** *the very top / of Gargaron* : Gargaron is the highest peak of Mount Ida, and it is typically where Zeus sits (as at 8.59). The usual description of Zeus as the cloud-gathering god has a special point here because the fragrant cloud in which he sits is the one he gathered himself, at 14.465, to provide cover for his lovemaking with Hera.

**15.222** *hate and fear* : The verb *stugeo* (cognate with the River Styx) suggests both hatred and fear.

**15.274** *the Furies* : The Furies tend to favor parents over children, and here the principle is extended so that they favor older siblings over younger ones. Iris is tactful, as a smart messenger should be. Birth order is ambiguous in the family of Cronus: Zeus was the youngest sibling in order of conception, but his elder siblings were re-ingested and then reborn by being disgorged from their father’s belly—making them in another sense younger than Zeus. Zeus himself overthrew his father, Cronus, so Iris’ words could also be taken as a reminder of how fragile Zeus’ hold on cosmic power may be.

**15.281** *to blame and criticize an equal* : In several parallel quarrels—between Poseidon and Zeus, Zeus and Hera, Achilles and Agamemnon—one member of a group believes himself to be dominant, while the others believe that power is shared equally between them.

- 15.303** *the Titans, the companions* : Zeus fought the Titans (the deities who preceded the Olympians), including his father, Cronus, and won. This line is a reminder that Zeus has a history of subjugating and castrating family members who threaten his dominance.
- 15.309** *some sweat* : Using deliberate understatement (a trope known as litotes), Zeus offers a misty hint of the cosmic danger of war between the divine siblings, which would presumably entail the shedding of much blood, not merely sweat, and perhaps also the end of the current state of the world.
- 15.352** *Just as a stallion* : The same simile occurs at 6.659, referring to Paris as he emerges from the bedroom with Helen. Perhaps Hector and Paris are more alike than one might think: both are strong, attractive young men who place too much confidence in their own abilities and their apparently intimate relationships with ultimately fickle gods.
- 15.376** *range among the troops* : The phrasing of the original could suggest that Hector ranges among either his own troops or the Greek troops. It seems that it must be the former in context, because he is encouraging the charioteers, and the attack on the enemy does not begin until 15.422.
- 15.416** *a fearsome warlike aegis* : The normal aegis of Zeus seems to be a cloak, but this aegis is imagined as a kind of goatskin or a goatskin-covered shield, with a fringe around it.
- 15.439** *lost their courage* : The Greeks are temporarily lacking in courage because Apollo has taken it away. The lack of courage among the humans is analogous to the lack of a herdsman for the flocks: it makes them vulnerable to attack.
- 15.442** *scattered fighting* : The close initial formation breaks up because the Greeks are running away in all directions.
- 15.447** *Medon was a son* : Medon appears in the Catalog of Ships (2.864), and the story of his killing his stepmother's relative has been referenced at 13.917.
- 15.480** *the banks* : The Trojans broke through the wall of the Greeks in Book 12, creating access to the ships, but only for foot soldiers, not chariots (because the ditch was an impediment). Here, Apollo enables them also to cross the ditch, even with their wheeled chariots, by filling the trench with its own banks to form a bridge in one area of the fortifications. The ditch is not filled in along its whole length, a detail that will be important to the narrative later on.
- 15.490** *you, / great Lord Apollo* : Direct second-person addresses by the narrator to a character are rare, and the characters most commonly addressed in that manner are Menelaus and Patroclus; see note on 4.163. The direct address to a god is more characteristic of a hymn than an epic. Apollo is the only deity addressed in this way in the poem, which reinforces his special status within the plot, as the character who

causes the plague in Book 1, plays an essential part in the deaths of Patroclus and of Hector, and will speak out to enable the return of Hector to Priam in Book 24.

- 15.512** *thunderclap* : The Trojans interpret the thunder as encouragement for them, rather than as a response to Nestor's prayer. The narrator generates suspense by not clarifying the plans of Zeus.
- 15.518** *the walls around the ship* : The sides of the ship are described as "walls" to increase the association between the waves and the Trojans, both crossing a wall.
- 15.521** *the Trojans fighting* : This peculiar military episode, with one army fighting on chariot and the other on board ship, underlines the strangeness of the Trojan presence at the Greek ships: the Greeks are using equipment designed for a naval battle on sea, while beached on shore, while the Trojans are using chariots against a stationary enemy.
- 15.681** *Schedius* : At 2.620, there is a leader of the Phocians named Schedius, son of Iphitus, killed by Hector at 17.392. Perhaps these are different characters who happen to have the same name, or perhaps there is some confusion between the two.
- 15.694** *Dolops, / . . . bravest son on Lampus* : Dolops is therefore a cousin of Hector's, since they share a grandfather—Laomedon, the previous king of Troy, father of Priam and of Lampus.
- 15.703** *Selleis* : The location referred to here could be in Elis or Thesprotia; there are rivers called Selleis in both.
- 15.712** *he stayed to fight* : The normal technique on the Homeric battlefield is to strike the enemy with a throwing spear, run to collect it, and then run back to one's own comrades; the need to dash back and forth is one reason that Achilles' quick feet are such an important quality. Dolops fails to run back after his initial, futile strike, and suffers the consequences.
- 15.814** *because he was / destined* : The causative connective "because" (*gar*) suggests that for Hector, as for Achilles, it is those fated to die young who may also be fated to receive the greatest glory. Here Hector is described with a word that has previously been used of Achilles: *minunthadios*, "short-lifer."
- 15.850** *Copreus* : Copreus, whose name means "Shitty," was the lackey of Eurystheus, the tyrant who imposed the Twelve Labors on Heracles at the behest of Hera.
- 15.867** *the outer ships* : The ships placed highest on the beach, nearest to Troy, are those that landed first, including those of Protesilaus and Oilean Ajax. There are multiple lines of ships, and the Trojans have now breached the first line.
- 15.882** *magic cloud of mist* : We were not told that there had been a mist impeding the Greeks' vision of the battlefield, although mist in battle is a repeated trope in the poem.
- 15.891** *polished wooden pike* : This huge pike is formed of several smaller sections fastened together. The oddly specific length of twenty-two cubits (about thirty-two

feet) signals Ajax's extraordinary strength; real pikes were about half this length.

**15.894** *horse riding* : Riding on top of horses' backs is a rarity in Homer; horses are used for pulling chariots, not riding. Here, the performer leaps like a circus acrobat from one horse's back to another, like Ajax leaping across the ships from one deck to the next.

**15.931** *thrusting-spears* : Homeric warriors use both throwing-spears, for combat at a distance, and thrusting-spears, for hand-to-hand combat. The epithet "double-sided," *amphigues*, commonly applied to spears, may suggest that the blade is sharp on both sides, or that it curves on both sides in a leaf shape. Axes and hatchets are rare on the Homeric battlefield, and their inclusion marks the importance of this moment in the war.

**15.944** *Trojan elders* : Hector's narrative of events is significantly different from that which we have received elsewhere in the poem. Elsewhere, the arrival of the Greek ships is not said to be against the will of the gods, and we have had no other indication that Priam and the Trojan elders refused to let Hector and his comrades approach the Greek ships and camp; the gods and Achilles suggest that it was fear of Achilles that restrained them in the past.

## BOOK 16 SUMMARY

Patroclus begs Achilles to let him follow Nestor's suggestion from Book 11: to enter the battlefield dressed in Achilles' armor. Achilles agrees, on the condition that Patroclus must turn around once he has driven the Trojans from the ships. Patroclus arms while the ships begin to burn. Patroclus and the Myrmidons drive the Trojans back, and Patroclus slaughters numerous Trojans, many of whom are trapped in the Greek trench. Zeus pities his son Sarpedon and wants to save him, but Hera reminds him that none of the other gods would approve of saving a mortal. Patroclus kills Sarpedon, and both sides fight for his body and his armor. Zeus wants Patroclus to die for his son's death, but first allows him to slaughter many more Trojans. Patroclus ignores Achilles' advice and pushes to the gates of the city. Apollo pushes him from the gates. Patroclus kills Cebriones, Hector's charioteer, and amid the fighting for his body and armor, Apollo knocks Patroclus over, making the borrowed helmet fall off, breaking the spear and loosening the borrowed breastplate; a Trojan named Euphorbus spears the now unarmed Patroclus, and Hector makes the final kill. With his dying breath, Patroclus predicts the death of Hector at the hands of Achilles.

**16.1** *the mighty galley* : This specific ship is that of Protesilaus, the first to beach at Troy.



- 16.4** *like some black stream* : This simile is also used at 9.19, describing Agamemnon's grief at the Greek defeat.
- 16.23** *overstepped* : Achilles is hinting darkly that one particular Greek, Agamemnon, "overstepped" when he took Briseis, while also hinting that the collective Greek forces may have overstepped in coming to Troy at all.
- 16.25** *you replied* : Patroclus is addressed by the narrator in the second person repeatedly in *The Iliad* , including eight times in this book alone—a book focused primarily on him (see note at 4.163 on the narrator's use of the second person).
- 16.39** *monstrous hero* : Patroclus accuses Achilles of being a combination of ostensible opposites—both monster and hero. In the original, he does this by coining a compound word: *ainaretes* , "monster heroic."
- 16.52** *let me wear / your armor* : In language and strategy, Patroclus is echoing the suggestion made by Nestor in Book 11 (11.1037).
- 16.83** *not until / . . . reached my ships* : In Book 9 (9.857) Achilles said that he would end his wrath only when the ships were ablaze, which has not yet happened. Achilles here adopts a fatal compromise between a desire to hold on to his wrath and a desire to let it go.
- 16.104** *despite everything* : This vague phrase (*kai hōs* , literally "even so") presumably refers to Achilles' reasons for refusing to fight himself—i.e., his enduring rage against Agamemnon. Achilles' rhetorical lack of specificity makes clear his emotional ambivalence: he both is and is not willing to give up his anger to help his fellow Greeks.
- 16.112** *different home* : The restoration of Briseis to Achilles is usually referred to as if she were an object to be "given" to one man or another. Here Achilles uses a verb (*aponaio* ) suggesting a change of home, perhaps in recognition that the trophy is a person. The phrasing may also suggest that Achilles' priority is for Agamemnon not to have possession of Briseis, rather than to possess her himself.
- 16.132** *crown of Troy* : In a common image, the towers of the city are imagined as a crown. Achilles' romantic fantasy that he might be able to evade the irritations and rage entailed by cooperation with a larger community, and instead perform the ultimate heroic exploit with only his beloved friend at his side, echoes the moment in Book 9 when Diomedes (who parallels Achilles in several ways) expresses a similar wish to sack Troy with only his beloved friend Sthenelus at his side (9.57)—although Diomedes does not go so far as to wish all other members of his own side dead.
- 16.136** *shining helmet / . . . ornate plates* : The details of the helmet are disputed: *phalara* , "plates," is used in Homer only here, and is sometimes interpreted to mean bosses or metal discs attached to a leather helmet, but more likely metal plates used to piece together the bronze helmet.

- 16.146** *Muses* : The very brief new invocation of the Muses marks a turning point in the poem.
- 16.150** *socket* : The socket is the part attaching the metal tip to the wooden spear shaft.
- 16.180** *Only Achilles* : This special heavy thrusting-spear may reflect an early mythical tradition that the Centaur Chiron gave Peleus a magical set of armor and weaponry, which made the user invulnerable.
- 16.194** *Harpy* : The title given to Brightfoot, “the Harpy,” suggests “snatching” and is used in later mythology for a part-bird female creature, given to snatching food from humans. Brightfoot seems to be both a storm wind and a mare.
- 16.202** *As wolves who crave* : The wolves are first defined as different from humans in that they are eaters of raw meat (*omophagoi* ), but then they are anthropomorphized: like human warriors, they have “boundless courage” (*aspetos alkē* ).
- 16.223** *a daughter / of Peleus* : Polydore is thus at least the half sister of Achilles, although the narrator does not bother to mention it. Her mother must be Peleus’ first, human wife, not the goddess Thetis.
- 16.238** *Acacesion* : The epithet applied here to Hermes, *akaketa* , probably suggests “born on Mount Acacesion,” a mountain in Arcadia said to be the place of Hermes’ birth and childhood; other myths locate Hermes’ birthplace as Mount Cyllene.
- 16.297** *cleaned it / with sulfur* : Sulfur was treated as a religious substance that was incorporated into ritual cleansing.
- 16.300** *his courtyard* : The tent, like other elite Homeric houses, has a central yard with an altar and fire.
- 16.304** *Pelasgian ruler / . . . the Helli* : Pelasgians were apparently a prehistoric tribe who lived in the northeastern Aegean, viewed as indigenous to the region; they were said to have settled at Dodona, an area below Mount Tomaros, far from both Troy and Phthia. Dodona was a major site for the worship of Zeus and had an oracle claiming to be the oldest in the Greek-speaking world. The Helli seem to be Hellenes, despite living in the indigenous Pelasgian land. Dodona had a holy oak from whose leaves came the oracle; the Helli seem to be imagined as sleeping around the god’s tree. They are presumably ascetics who are unshod and unwashed as a gesture of piety.
- 16.335** *They swarmed out—like wasps* : The simile has several points of comparison. The Myrmidons are as riled up and eager to defend the ships as the wasps are to defend their home, and there are foreshadowings of Patroclus’ future in the childish folly of the children or the passersby, who get themselves into trouble by taking on an unexpectedly fearsome enemy.
- 16.351** *his subordinates* : The phrasing is formulaic but speaks to an important problem for Patroclus: Achilles’ subordinates and comrades, including himself, are not warriors of the same caliber as their leader. Patroclus’ emphasis on Achilles’



absolute superiority is not the best way to encourage the Myrmidons to march out under his own, weaker, leadership.

**16.363** *cast away / his wrath* : Wrath is imagined as something physical, which could be thrown away like a weapon or a burden. There is a dark paradox in the idea that “gentleness and love,” when shown by Achilles towards his fellow Greeks, will entail a massacre for the Trojans. There is a further paradox that Achilles has chosen to show love both to his fellow Greeks in general (by sending his comrade to help them) and to Patroclus (by giving him what he asked for)—and the result will be the death of his own dearest friend Patroclus, as well as of many other loved ones on both sides.

**16.404** *the thickest muscle* : The original refers to the leg part in question with *skelos* , a word that appears in Homer only here, and one that is used elsewhere for animal legs, or in comedy; the effect is to create some mockery of the victim as he dies. The severing of the femoral artery, located in the thigh, would indeed cause death. The next line is medically inaccurate: the gluteus maximus is actually the thickest muscle in the human body, but its severing would not result in death. The poet has not said that the victim turned around, so presumably the injury is in the front of the thigh, not the buttock. Homeric death scenes tend to value emotional vividness over anatomical accuracy.

**16.406** *son of Nestor* : Two sons of Nestor work in unison here: Antilochus and Thrasymedes.

**16.421** *Amisodorus / . . . Chimera* : This is a reference to an otherwise unknown myth. Amisodorus is said in later sources to have been the father of the princess who married Bellerophon. The Chimera was a hybrid monster, part-lioness/part-goat/part-snake, who was eventually killed by Bellerophon.

**16.434** *fine sword* : I here follow the reading *kalon* , “fine,” rather than the alternate reading printed in the Oxford Classical Text, *kaulon* , “hilt”—which would suggest that the sword broke just at the area where it is attached to the handle.

**16.492** *As when in summertime* : The simile presents the storm and consequent flooding as the result of Zeus’ anger against men who have run corrupt trials and have ignored the fact that gods are supposedly overseeing their actions and judging them. The primary point of comparison is between the noise and speed of the river in flood and that of the horses; there is a secondary suggestion that Patroclus, in crossing the ditch against Achilles’ instructions, has incurred divine anger.

**16.521** *holy fish* : Ancient and modern commentators alike are puzzled by the “holy” fish. Perhaps it is the dorado, believed to have magical properties.

**16.538** *flowing tunics* : The companions are described with an unusual epithet, *amitrochitonas* , “unbelted” or “in unbelted tunics,” perhaps a reference to some unknown peculiarity of Lycian dress.

- 16.556** *my son Sarpedon* : A son of Zeus, Sarpedon is the most eminent of Patroclus' victims; his killing increases Patroclus' glory. In earlier stages of myth, Sarpedon may have been a non-Greek god. He was the object of cult worship in Lycia; the need to acknowledge this cult is part of the background to the beautifully resonant metaphysical confusion in this passage, whereby Zeus, greatest of the gods, is tempted to alter a fate whose nature remains murky.
- 16.639** *escaped / their masters' chariot* : This detail is often seen as a minor narrative error, in that we have not been told that the chariot broke or that anyone released the horses from it.
- 16.647** *scale the lofty wall* : The wounding of Glaucus happened in Book 12 (12.476ff.). when he was trying to scale the wall fortifying the Greek camp. Glaucus carried on fighting without any apparent ill effects in Book 14, perhaps because the narrator temporarily forgot about the wound. Here, it serves the useful purpose of explaining why Glaucus, despite his military skill and courage, is unable to save his friend.
- 16.648** *squeezed his arm* : Presumably to reduce bleeding and pain, as a temporary tourniquet.
- 16.664** *heeded him* : Apollo is associated with medicine as well as with plague.
- 16.722** *killed his cousin* : The life story of this minor Myrmidon echoes those of Patroclus himself and Phoenix: all three kill family members, flee their homelands, and find themselves under the protection of Peleus. These lines seem to suggest that Peleus and Thetis remained together; other versions of the myth suggest that after her forced marriage and rape by Peleus, the goddess escaped back to the sea.
- 16.760** *a priest of Zeus / on Ida* : There was a cult to Zeus on Mount Ida near Troy.
- 16.777** *good at dancing* : Aeneas insults Meriones by describing his movement away from the weapon as a dance, an inappropriate action for the battlefield.
- 16.823** *the sacred scales* : Zeus is imagined as holding a set of weighing scales; the side which will lose the battle, or the person whose life is to be lost, tips downward. The motif of weighing souls appears in pre-Greek myth and was likely important in the story of Memnon, a semidivine Ethiopian hero whose story provides elements that are borrowed in the death of Sarpedon. See notes at 8.86, 19.290, and 22.278.
- 16.825** *their leader* : Some commentators have suggested that this "leader" is Hector, metaphorically "struck" by the enmity of Zeus, not Sarpedon, literally struck in the chest, because otherwise it is odd that the Lycians react only now to the death of Sarpedon. But Hector is not lying under a pile of corpses. Presumably this is simply a slight narrative awkwardness, caused by the composer's having forgotten to mention the Lycians earlier.

- 16.829** *rope of war* : A different metaphor from the scales, also traditional, in which Zeus is imagined as locked in a tug-of-war with the other gods over the outcome of battle. Here it is a little obscure, because the narrator does not make clear who or what holds the other end of the rope. Perhaps the obscurity speaks to the ambivalence of Zeus' preferences, such that the god tugs against himself: he, like the Trojans, wants to honor the dead Sarpedon.
- 16.839** *ambrosia* : Ambrosia suggests "immortal" (*brotos* = "mortal"). The clothes are also *ambrota* —i.e., deathless or immortal—presumably suggesting that they are suitable to be worn by immortal beings such as gods, but perhaps also that the clothing itself will never wear out.
- 16.973** *the time / that plowmen free* : Presumably early afternoon; oxen were released after a full morning of plowing.
- 16.975** *stronger than their fate decreed* : This is the only instance in the poem when humans move beyond their fated portion (*aisa* ).
- 16.995** *proper custom* : The narrator is conscious of the mythic tradition whereby the armor of Achilles conveys immortality on the wearer; Patroclus is stripped of the magical armor before he can be killed. But the narrator avoids explicit mention of this motif. "Proper custom" is *themis*, the sometimes personified idea of a proper, righteous form of traditional behavior.
- 16.1000** *brought his own destruction* : With this resonant phrase, the narrator hints that the killing of Patroclus will eventually bring about Hector's own death.
- 16.1008** *Dardanian* : Sometimes the poet seems to distinguish between the Dardanians and the Trojans, but some characters, such as Euphorbus and Paris, are both Trojan and Dardanian.
- 16.1013** *That very day* : Some editors read *pote* ("once") rather than *tote* ("then," "that day"). There is a particular pathos in the wounding of the older man, Patroclus, by an unknown youngster on his first day in battle.
- 16.1036** *took away the life* : The language suggests that Patroclus is already dead; his reply may come as a surprise—unless we remember that the boar of the simile is left panting his last gasp, rather than completely dead.
- 16.1043** *Hector's horses galloped* : Hector's boast elides the fact that he retreated.
- 16.1073** *his manhood and his youth* : The same phrase will be used for Hector himself in Book 22 (22.488). The spirit, *psychē*, is grammatically female, and performs the typically female task of mourning the dead. "Manhood and youth" can be taken as hendiadys (= "left his identity as a young man, to become a floating spirit and a corpse"). The combination of youth and manhood puts people at great risk of early death.

## BOOK 17 SUMMARY

The Greeks and Trojans fight over Patroclus' body and armor. Hector drives Menelaus back and strips the armor; however, with the help of Telamonian Ajax, Menelaus returns to stand guard over the body. Hector puts on Achilles' armor in triumph and fights Ajax. There is a long battle over the body. Apollo spurs Aeneas to rally the Trojans. Meanwhile, Achilles' immortal horses realize that Patroclus is dead and begin weeping; Zeus inspires them to run with their driver, Automedon, into battle.

- 17.8** *a first-time mother* : The simile is surprising both in its mixing of genders and in the use of human terms for the cow, who is a “mother,” experiencing birth, just like human women.
- 17.31** *Hyperenor / . . . insulted me* : Hyperenor was killed by Menelaus at 14.685. In that passage, Hyperenor does not insult Menelaus, but it suits Menelaus' rhetorical purposes here to conflate the two brothers.
- 17.35** *I doubt* : The ironic understatement casts further shade on the victim, who was unable to walk home due to being dead.
- 17.59** *lower throat / . . . soft neck* : Euphorbus' boasts are answered by a deathblow to his voice box.
- 17.128** *disaster rolls* : The implied image is of disaster as a great wave that “rolls” (*kulisthe*) over the opponent of divine will.
- 17.149** *left flank* : As at earlier moments in the poem, the battlefield is presented from a Greek's perspective, so that “left” means “east.”
- 17.171** *her young ones* : The word “lion,” *lis*, is generally gendered masculine in Homeric Greek, but as ancient and modern commentators have noted, male lions do not lead their cubs around; the simile is zoologically possible only if the lion is female.
- 17.208** *we could bring him* : This is the only instance of a proposed exchange of bodies in Homer. Glaucus does not know what we know, that Sarpedon's body was spirited away by Apollo.
- 17.273** *nodding with darkened brows* : The nod of Zeus makes his promise unbreakable. The darkened brows suggest Zeus' sorrow at the inevitable death of Hector.
- 17.296** *caress of war* : This striking phrase (“caress of war,” *poleμου oāristus*) does not occur elsewhere, but it must suggest that war embraces the warrior like a wife or girlfriend (*oār*). The result of their encounter is not children, but life or death.
- 17.315** *cloud of war* : This odd phrase (“cloud of war,” *polemoio nephos*) does not occur elsewhere. Hector, who is more commonly associated with brightness and flame, is here associated with an opposite set of imagery—a cloud or obscurity. The metaphor foreshadows the literal mist that later spreads over the battlefield. It also parallels the common metaphor whereby death is a “cloud,” darkening the eyes.

- 17.322** *public cost* : The leaders' wine and meat are provided for them at "public expense" (*dēmia*), whereas a lower-class working person would have to labor to pay for wine and food. Menelaus' point here is to remind the leaders that privilege entails certain responsibilities on the battlefield, as Sarpedon famously reminds Glaucus in Book 12 (12.377).
- 17.325** *conflict rages so intensely* : I.e., the battle is so frenzied that it is impossible to see, name, and shame particular individuals.
- 17.370** *Lethus, the Pelasgian* : The Pelasgians are cited as allies of the Trojans in the Catalog of Trojans (2.998). The geographical region referred to as Pelasgia is disputed; in the Catalog, it seems to be located on the southern border of Thrace, on the other side of the Hellespont from the Troad.
- 17.378** *his bronze-cheeked helmet* : Hippothous is bending down over the corpse, and hence suffers a blow to the head. The attempt to drag Patroclus' body by the foot with the baldric (a strap used to hold the sword) is paralleled only by what Achilles will later do with the body of Hector.
- 17.516** *stretched the painful work* : The metaphor of "stretched" picks up the simile of the two groups of warriors pulling the corpse like tanners stretching a hide, although the application seems to have shifted: Zeus stretches out the time and the intensity of this painful struggle.
- 17.527** *or even with him* : Achilles knows from Thetis that he himself will be dead before the sack of Troy. In Book 9, Diomedes articulated the ultimate warrior-romance fantasy: that he and his close comrade, Sthenelus, could sack the city together, without the rest of the army (9.56–57). Here, we are reminded that that dream can never come true for Achilles and Patroclus, and Achilles knows it.
- 17.547** *iron din / . . . sky of bronze* : "Iron" is metaphorical, because the warriors mostly fight with bronze weapons, not iron; iron is often used to signify harshness, cruelty, or lack of pity, because it is so hard. The sky is typically described as bronze because of its brightness, and the air, like the sea, is fruitless or barren because no crops grow there. This sentence combines formulaic images in a striking way that hints at a cosmic battle between heaven and earth, or at a clash between different metals, echoing the contemporary archaic Greek myth of the metallic ages of humanity, which degenerate from bronze to iron (Hesiod, *Works and Days* 109–201).
- 17.549** *the horses of Achilles* : Horses and chariots are often depicted on vases that have been found in tombs, and there may be a suggestion that this pair of horses are already creating a sepulchral monument to the dead Patroclus.
- 17.566** *Their thick manes* : The horses are bowing their heads so low that their manes trail on the ground.

- 17.613** *whose judgment equaled the immortal gods* : The description of Patroclus as one who had exceptional judgment explains how he managed to control immortal horses—although Patroclus died because he misjudged his own abilities.
- 17.632** *oxhide shields, encased / in thick bronze* : As ancient critics noted, this is a continuity error: Hector ought to be carrying Achilles' shield, which is made of gold, not hide and bronze like a normal shield. The shields are mentioned to underline the importance of the moment and increase the dignity of the advancing warriors, and the narrator has not troubled to adjust the weaponry to fit the story.
- 17.639** *his dark heart* : Hearts and other internal organs in Homer tend to be “dark” or “black” because they are inside the body (and therefore in the dark). There may also be a hint of Automedon's eagerness for slaughter, because anger or passion tends to be figured as “dark.”
- 17.675** *bent forward / . . . quelled its force* : Lines 17.675–77 repeat 16.769–71.
- 17.698** *his mind had turned* : This line is puzzling. It could suggest that Zeus has changed his mind and favors the Greeks—although later in this book, he seems to continue to favor the Trojans. Or it could suggest that he turns his mind to consider the battle, although this would be an unusual way of expressing that idea.
- 17.716** *father, grandpa, papa* : The sequence of three terms of address (*atta, geraie, palaigenes*) emphasizes Phoenix's age and suggests intimate affection and respect. Menelaus does not realize that he is speaking not to an old man, but a goddess—who is older than any human, but also ageless and deathless.
- 17.736** *Eetion* : This must be a different Eetion than Andromache's father, because she says that he and all her brothers are dead.
- 17.759** *bright bronze armor* : Again, Hector is conventionally dressed in bronze, although in theory, he should be wearing the gold armor of Achilles. The discrepancy has a certain narrative usefulness: it increases suspense, because the description of Hector as a wearer of bronze armor suggests that he is a mortal and vulnerable to attack, whereas the divine armor built for Achilles was traditionally supposed to make the wearer invulnerable.
- 17.831** *Destroy us if you wish, but in the light* : This line was much admired in antiquity; for example, it was treated as an example of “greatness of thought” in Ps-Longinus' *On the Sublime* (9.10).
- 17.870** *you, Lord Menelaus* : On the narrator's use of the second person, see note at 4.163.
- 17.898** *did not wish to help* : The point is not that Menelaus is eager to neglect the Pylians, who lack an important leader in the absence of Antilochus, but that he prioritizes the protection of Patroclus; this detail reinforces the strategic importance of the recovery of this dead man for both sides.



- 17.924** *very high* : It is a mark of great respect to Patroclus that he is lifted high and carried from battle by two warriors, rather than dragged away by one.
- 17.938** *carrying the body* : The recovery of the body of Patroclus from the battlefield probably draws on a more famous episode in the mythic tradition: the recovery of a different “best of the Greeks,” the dead Achilles, with his divine armor, by Ajax and Odysseus (who would later compete to inherit his special armor and weapons). The narrator assumes that the audience would find this sequence both partly familiar and surprising, as is typical for the poem’s technique.
- 17.941** *as fire that suddenly consumes / a city* : The simile hints at the fall of Troy, which is never narrated directly in the poem, although the image does not specify whether the fire is accidental or the result of war.
- 17.964** *tangled cry* : The birds are described as screeching “*oulon*”—a word whose meaning is disputed; the word *oulos* is used to describe wool, hair, and smoke and, hence, may suggest the “tangled” interlaying of multiple bird voices upon one another. Some commentators associate the word with a homonym, *oulos*, meaning “deadly” or “of horror,” and the narrator may have made this association, although linguistically, the two terms are distinct.
- 17.970** *many fine weapons fell* : Deliberately throwing away one’s heavy shield and weapons to flee unobstructed from the battlefield was often viewed as a mark of cowardice—it was the subject of a comic poem by the seventh-century Greek poet Archilochus, who boasts about discarding his shield behind a bush. Here, the narrator carefully avoids saying that the Greeks throw their shields away, although it is implied.

## BOOK 18 SUMMARY

Antilochus runs to tell Achilles about his friend’s death. He is devastated. Thetis and other sea goddesses emerge from the sea to mourn with him, both for Patroclus and for Achilles himself, who will soon die. Achilles insists that he is eager to die, but wants first to kill Hector. Thetis tells him to return to battle only once she has fetched a new, immortal set of armor for him. Achilles shows himself to the Greeks but does not fight. This is frightening enough for the Trojans that they flee, and the Greeks bring Patroclus’ body to safety. Polydamas advises Hector to withdraw, but Hector rejects this advice. The Greeks mourn Patroclus and Achilles says he will never go home again. Thetis goes to Hephaestus, the craftsman god, who makes a beautiful new set of armor for Achilles, including a marvelous shield that depicts two cities, one at war and one at peace.

- 18.4** *sterns straight as cattle horns* : Ships and horns in Homer are often curved, but here the ends of the ships are sticking straight upright like horns (*orthokrairos* ).
- 18.11** *best of all the Myrmidons* : These lines have been questioned because, strictly speaking, Patroclus is a Locrian, not a Myrmidon; but this seems pedantic, given that Patroclus died while leading the Myrmidons into battle. The phrase “best of the Myrmidons” (*aristos Myrmidonōn* ) might suggest simply that Patroclus counts as the “best” while he is leading the troops, or perhaps it suggests that in some sense, Patroclus is superior to Achilles himself. Patroclus, unlike Achilles, is characterized by a degree of kindness to his own people, which we see both in his willingness to help a wounded comrade, Eurypylus, and in Briseis’ testimony that he was kind to her. At the same time, Patroclus also demonstrates in Book 16 an impressive ability to massacre large numbers of Trojans and Trojan allies in quick succession; on the battlefield he is one of the “best” in the more usual sense of being skilled at killing.
- 18.33** *lay there* : The verb used of Achilles (*keito* , “lay”) echoes that used a few lines earlier of Patroclus (*keitai* , “lies”); Achilles’ posture in the dust, dirty and without armor, mirrors that of his beloved dead friend.
- 18.46** *goddesses who live within / . . . the salty sea* : The sea goddesses all have meaningful names, many of them suggesting their qualities as water deities, associated with welcome, fertility, and truth (for the transparency of water). The list of names provides soothing aesthetic pleasure before the listener returns again to the intense pain of Achilles’ grief.
- 18.73** *Peleus* : In most versions of the myth, the marriage of Peleus and Thetis was nonconsensual, and after the rape, the goddess returned to her home in the sea. Like several other passages in *The Iliad* , these lines seem to imply that Thetis still cohabits with Peleus some of the time, although during the poem’s action, she usually seems to be submerged in the water just offshore from Troy, sitting beside her father and listening for trouble that might befall her son.
- 18.101** *my head, my life* : The language suggests that in killing Patroclus, Hector has already killed Achilles.
- 18.188** *dead Patroclus* : A little while has passed since we last saw the corpse, at the end of Book 17, carried by Menelaus and Meriones; now the bearers seem to be gone, and the struggle continues.
- 18.212** *the wildest, most aggressive man alive* : The same phrase, already used scornfully by Agamemnon to Achilles (1.197), will be used again by Achilles to one of his victims (20.509).
- 18.220** *fix it on a stake* : The wall of Troy is fortified with stakes. Decapitating enemies is fairly rare in *The Iliad*, and the threat is meant to sound particularly brutal and horrifying. As an ancient commentator noted, we are given no indication



about whether Iris is right, or telling the truth, about Hector's intentions; perhaps she is goading Achilles with a worst-case scenario.

**18.238** *the shield of Ajax* : A more practical possibility would have been to use the armor of Patroclus, which has been left behind. But the poet wants the opportunity to describe the magical new armor made by Hephaestus. Ajax's shield is presumably mentioned because it is famous.

**18.282** *Twelve fighters died* : It is unclear whether these twelve die because they have been struck by Greek weapons or because of the power of the scream, which might be loud enough in itself to kill.

**18.338** *gather all our strength* : The original language in this line is hard to parse, and several different interpretations are possible. The ancient critic Aristarchus thought the line meant "In the assembly [i.e., by talking], we will find strength."

**18.360** *Our great wealth has been spent* : The war has been costly because of Greek raids, and the Trojans had to pay their allies in neighboring regions to join them in the fight.

**18.372** *his property* : Hector is implying that the only reason Polydamas, a rich man, is recommending the cautious approach is out of fear for his wealth—not because it is too dangerous to human life.

**18.436** *ointment / seasoned for nine whole years* : The vintage ointment is valuable, demonstrating the particular care afforded to Patroclus' body.

**18.463** *twenty tripods* : Wheeled tripods existed in the ninth and eighth centuries, although they usually were made of bronze, not gold, and they usually did not roll themselves automatically.

**18.473** *bright-veiled Charis, / wife* : The wife of Hephaestus is usually said to be Aphrodite, who cheats on him with Ares (as described by Demodocus in *Odyssey* 8.266–366). Here, Charis ("Grace," "Attractiveness") is his wife, probably because in this poem Aphrodite favors the Trojans, so would be unlikely to support the provision of new equipment for Achilles. The Graces (Charites), are usually a trio, often associated with Aphrodite; they, like her, have expertise in sexual attraction and personal adornment.

**18.510** *volcanic giant* : The phrasing here is obscure, because the word *aiētos* is used only here and its meaning is disputed. One possibility is that it is related to the verb *aēmi*, "to blow"; it could then suggest that Hephaestus is puffing as he completes his work. The word may identify Hephaestus as god of volcanoes, a massive being who tends to puff smoke, like a volcano blowing ash.

**18.523** *sped beneath their master* : The enslaved robot women seem to serve to carry the god when he needs an extra jolt of speed, like a motorized wheelchair.

**18.609** *the Great Bear* : The Great Bear is Ursa Major. The Bear is actually not the only constellation that does not sink below the horizon from the perspective of the

northern latitudes; Aristotle explained the false claim here by claiming that “only” means here “best known” (*Poetics* 25.1461a20–22).

- 18.613** *two cities full of people / . . . noisy wedding songs* : This marvelous set-piece description is the earliest example of an important type of scene in ancient literature: the vivid description of a work of art (a trope known by modern but not ancient scholars as *ecphrasis*), which explores the limits of what can be represented in a static visual medium. The shield, being magical, divinely manufactured, and the product of poetry rather than real metal, is able to include elements that might seem impossible to describe except through words—such as movement, sound, motivation, emotion, and change over time.
- 18.622** *payment for a murdered man* : The situation of the lawsuit is that one man has killed another, and a third man, the representative of the relatives of the murdered man, insists before a body of judges and a crowd of bystanders that the killer must pay compensation. The judges each propose possible payments, and the crowd votes on, or otherwise provides opinions about, which suggestion is best; the judge whose opinion is favored also receives a prize. The lawsuit clearly has a certain affinity with the main plot of the poem, but Achilles has refused to accept a penalty for the loss of Briseis and will accept none for the loss of Patroclus, and there are no neutral bystanders or judges.
- 18.634** *two armies* : The city at war resembles the besieged Troy, although the warfare seems to be practiced primarily through ambushes and cattle raids, rather than open combat.
- 18.670** *as if they were alive* : They are in fact neither alive nor dead, because they are only representations—a rare moment where the narrative describing the shield seems to break the representational frame and remind us that the illusion of life and motion is in fact an illusion.
- 18.673** *triple-plowed* : Other archaic Greek sources, such as Hesiod (*Works and Days* 462) recommend plowing three times. The number may have ritual significance, and it may also have had practical value in preparing the ground for vegetables as well as grains.
- 18.683** *precinct* : The precinct, *temenos* , is a specific area assigned as the private domain of an elite person.
- 18.694** *a feast / . . . a supper* : Two distinct meals are being prepared: beef for the master and his elite companions, and barley for the laborers. Barley, which is easy to grow in relatively barren land, was a major staple in archaic Greece; the women are presumably preparing it by mixing it with hot water to make a mash.
- 18.707** *honeyed fruit* : The grapes are “honeyed” in that they are as sweet as honey.
- 18.710** *Linus song* : The Linus song is a reference to an obscure tradition of singing laments for a dead hero, god, or demigod named Linus. The tradition was probably

an import from non-Greek cultures, where it was sung at harvest time; Herodotus (2.79) associates Linus with Egypt or the Phoenicians.

**18.734** *Daedalus / . . . Ariadne* : Daedalus is a mythical human craftsman, whose name suggests artful craft. He designed the Cretan Labyrinth, which housed the Minotaur, a cannibal half-bull, half-human hybrid, son of Minos. Ariadne is the mythical daughter of Minos; she was taken from Crete by the Athenian hero Theseus, after he killed the Minotaur. This is the only reference to Daedalus in Homer, who may be drawing on alternate traditions of these Cretan myths.

**18.740** *olive oil* : In a process apparently dating back to Mycenaean times, oil was used to give sheen to fabric.

## BOOK 19 SUMMARY

After Achilles puts on the new armor brought by Thetis, he calls an assembly. Agamemnon blames his previous behavior on Delusion, the daughter of Zeus, and on Zeus himself, but reiterates his willingness to give the lavish set of gifts to Achilles that he promised earlier (Book 9), and to return Briseis, all of which he does. Briseis mourns Patroclus, who was kind to her. Achilles refuses to eat, although Odysseus insists that the other troops need food before battle. The gods feed Achilles on ambrosia. Achilles mounts his chariot, and his horses speak to remind him that his death is near; Achilles angrily replies that he already knows.

**19.21** *rage / . . . joy* : Achilles' emotions are a complex mix of rage—against the Trojans and particularly Hector, as killer of Patroclus—and joy, because he now has the means to slaughter the objects of his rage. Rage (*cholos* here, not *mēnis*) increases on the battlefield, and the successful exercise of rage is a source of joy (*terpsis*).

**19.26** *mother, / “Mother”* : The original repeats the word “mother” in two successive lines (*mētera / mētēr emē*). Thetis plays a central role in all Achilles' major decisions in the poem, including his choice to withdraw from battle in Book 1 and this new expression of his wrath when he rises up to fight.

**19.39** *feral tribes / of flies* : The striking phrase “feral tribes of flies” (*agria phyla muias*) is not paralleled elsewhere.

**19.49** *dripped into the nostrils* : The goddess's technique of dripping the fluid through the nostrils seems to reflect practices of embalming, such as those used in Egypt; Herodotus (2.86) describes how Egyptian embalmers removed the brain through the nostrils. Ambrosia (cognate with *brotos*, “mortal,” with a negative prefix) is, like nectar, a mysterious substance closely associated with the gods. It is unclear why

the nectar is red; perhaps it replaces lost blood in the corpse, or feeds him like wine.

- 19.63** *their wounds were painful / . . . he had the wound* : Diomedes, Odysseus, and Agamemnon were all wounded in Book 11.
- 19.75** *Artemis / . . . Lyrnessus* : Artemis is the goddess who presides over the diseases and deaths of women by natural causes. Lyrnessus is the hometown of Briseis, sacked and destroyed by Achilles before the poem begins.
- 19.80** *full of wrath* : Achilles here uses the rare verb (*apomēnizo*) cognate with the noun for superhuman “wrath,” *mēnis*. He used the same phrase in Book 9 in his angry repost to Odysseus (9.547).
- 19.99** *He did not stand* : Presumably Agamemnon stays in his seat because of his wound, and perhaps also as a mark of disrespect to Achilles and to the council as a whole. As Agamemnon himself acknowledges, it is unusual for an assembly speaker in Homer not to stand up.
- 19.120** *Deadly Delusion* : Agamemnon ascribes his trouble to four divine agents: Zeus, Destiny (Moirai, literally the “part” or “share” received by every human being in life), a night-walking or dark-walking Fury (Erinys), and Delusion (*Atē*). The Fury is a somewhat puzzling inclusion, given that Furies usually pursue those who have broken oaths or betrayed or killed family members. Ruinous Delusion is Agamemnon’s normal explanation for problems that might otherwise be ascribed to his own poor leadership; he uses the same explanation at 9.21. The poem’s narrator never ascribes human decisions to this goddess-abstraction.
- 19.124** *shackles / one man in two* : The phrasing is slightly odd, perhaps because Agamemnon is darkly hinting at a narrative he does not spell out: Delusion shackles every other human being touched by her evil influence, and Achilles is the fortunate one who managed to evade her spell.
- 19.135** *the lady Eileithuia* : Eileithuia, goddess of childbirth, is sometimes pluralized, as later in this passage (presumably because birth-pangs are multiple). The name is derived from *eimi/ eluth-*, “to come,” because she is the goddess who causes contractions and makes the baby come (and she is also the goddess to whom laboring women call, asking her to come).
- 19.150** *the noble wife / . . . was pregnant with a precious son* : Perseus was a son of Zeus by a mortal woman (Danae), so his grandson, Eurystheus, is descended from Zeus. Hera’s trick relies on the ambiguity in Zeus’ oath: he declares that the child born that day and destined to power will be “from his lineage” and “blood”—which applies to his great-grandson, Eurystheus, as much as to his son, Heracles.
- 19.178** *the trials* : Eurystheus forced Heracles to complete twelve almost impossible tasks (known as the Labors of Heracles), mostly involving killing deadly monsters. There were several different mythic traditions about the reason for the Labors. No

other character repeatedly compares himself to any god, let alone the highest, most powerful god of all. Agamemnon's inset narrative about the birth of Heracles allows him to aggrandize himself and present himself as a victim simultaneously. The eviction of Delusion by Zeus echoes the scene in which Hephaestus is flung from Olympus (referenced at 1.766). Delusion seems to stand in for Hera, who is too powerful for Zeus to expel.

- 19.185** *lavish gifts* : The language partially repeats Agamemnon's previous promise to make amends with Achilles by providing gifts, at 9.149. Agamemnon, who was not present during the embassy, seems not to understand that the acquisition of large quantities of property, so attractive to himself, is not a primary motivation for Achilles, who knows that he will not have long to enjoy his numerous tripods.
- 19.189** *visited your tent / yesterday* : The embassy to Achilles, narrated in Book 9, actually took place two nights earlier, not the night before. Agamemnon's exaggeration is a jarring reminder of how little time has passed, while in the story time of the poem, that period—spreading across ten books and covering numerous deaths and changes of fortune—has felt enormous. Agamemnon is motivated to minimize the amount of time and the significance of the events that have passed since the embassy, because the massive effects of Achilles' absence redound to his glory, as his mother had hoped.
- 19.201** *chatting / and wasting time* : Achilles' language is characteristically unusual, and he has a characteristic intolerance for wasting time. The word translated as "chatting," *klotopeuein*, does not appear elsewhere in Homer; it is likely a colloquialism.
- 19.203** *Achilles* : It is unusual for Homeric characters to speak of themselves by name, although Achilles has done it before (1.323). Hector does it at 7.98, and Zeus at 8.29.
- 19.232** *gone to bed* : Odysseus' sensible suggestions include this public declaration, because if Achilles is perceived to be in possession of a woman who has already been raped by Agamemnon, her worth as the human property of Achilles would be diminished or lost, and his honor could not be properly restored. A similar logic operates in Book 22 of *The Odyssey*, where the twelve enslaved women who have been raped by the suitors are killed by Telemachus on the instructions of Odysseus, because they have been already claimed sexually by other men, and therefore their continued existence threatens the honor of the returning enslaver. Agamemnon has had plenty of time to rape Briseis since seizing her, but what matters pragmatically for the restoration of Achilles' place in his community is not the truth or falsehood of the declaration, on which the narrator does not comment, but its public performance. This is a moment where Odysseus shows how useful it can be to say

one thing and hide another in one's heart (a practice of which Achilles expresses his loathing at 9.399).

- 19.240** *make amends* : The Greek in this sentence is a little awkwardly expressed, perhaps as a mark of the rhetorical challenge of Odysseus' position here: he needs to assert that Agamemnon was indeed in the wrong, but without doing it so directly that this powerful colleague will again become enraged. The implication is that a leader who failed to make amends would indeed be worthy of blame.
- 19.259** *a boar for Zeus and Helios* : The boar is offered to the gods associated with the sky because they will witness the end of the quarrel between Agamemnon and Achilles.
- 19.264** *adjournment* : As is characteristic of this character, Achilles' language is somewhat unusual: the word translated as "adjournment," *metapausolē*, does not occur elsewhere.
- 19.266** *the dead are lying* : Achilles uses the plural, although presumably the primary referent is the singular Patroclus.
- 19.277** *feet towards the door* : This is the traditional position for a body awaiting burial, symbolizing their readiness to leave.
- 19.286** *contest of ideas* : Odysseus' language suggests that whereas Achilles can literally throw his spear farther, Odysseus can "throw further" (*probaloimen*) with his thinking or ideas.
- 19.290** *grow sick / . . . a harvest / . . . his scales* : Three distinct images, all related to food, are used in condensed fashion in this sentence, demonstrating Odysseus' intelligence. First, battle is implicitly compared to food, but of a non-nourishing kind: it is something that men soon grow "sick of" ("satiety," *koros*). Then the bronze that cuts men down in battle is implicitly compared to a sickle that cuts down crops at harvest time—but these "stalks" produce little or no harvest, because one cannot winnow grain from human corpses. Finally, Zeus is the "steward" who weighs out grains or other supplies, holds a set of scales, which shift downward to the heavier side—and the movement of the scales held by Zeus is commonly used to represent the turning point both of a battle and of an individual's life.
- 19.331** *first sacrifice* : Before drawing blood, it was traditional to make a "first offering" of the animal's hair.
- 19.349** *into the mighty gulf* : Usually the sacrificial animal is put on the fire (and then the meat is eaten by humans, with the gods receiving the inedible savor). In this case, there is no fire, and the victim is treated as a scapegoat: his casting out to sea represents the casting out of Agamemnon's state of delusion (*atē*), and the end of hostilities among the Greek leadership. Boars are associated with stubbornness.
- 19.356** *so stubborn, and so powerless* : The Greek word used of Agamemnon here, *amēchanos*, "without strategy/device/fix," can suggest both "stubborn" and



“helpless.” These concepts may seem quite different, but in the world of Homer, they are related. The word is cognate with one of the epithets of Odysseus, *polymēchanos*, “wily,” “adaptable,” “Mr. Fix-It”: unlike Agamemnon, Odysseus survives because of his ability to avoid both helplessness (he always has a solution for everything) and excessive stubbornness (he is able to adapt to every new situation). By contrast, Agamemnon’s helplessness is a central element in his characterization. Agamemnon is made particularly vulnerable by his high status as leader of the armies, whereas Odysseus has an ability, unparalleled among Homeric leaders, to bide his time and to pretend to be nobody.

**19.367** *as bright as golden Aphrodite* : The comparisons of Briseis to Aphrodite and unspecified goddesses are formulaic (elite women in Homer are generally like goddesses), but they also serve to remind us that, despite being enslaved, she is a worthy mourner for this important dead man, analogous in the narrative to Helen (the abducted woman favored and exploited by Aphrodite). The passage suggests a parallel with the laments of Thetis and the sea goddesses at the start of Book 18.

**19.383** *Munes* : Some commentators assert that Munes must have been the husband of Briseis, but this is not specified in the text.

**19.389** *celebrate my marriage* : Marriage to the enslaver and rapist who slaughtered her whole family and destroyed her home city might not seem like much of a happy ending for Briseis, but it is the only option that allows her to regain some measure of freedom—hence the insistence on the idea that she will be a “lawful wife” and that the marriage will be publicly recognized in Phthia with the feast. The fantasy acquires an extra layer of pathos from our knowledge that, as his mother has told him, Achilles himself will never return home, and Briseis will never regain her freedom.

**19.413** *such delicious food* : Patroclus was represented preparing and serving food to Achilles’ guests in Book 9. In the elite households represented in *The Odyssey*, it is usually enslaved women who prepare and serve food. The Iliadic Greek warriors do not have quite the same domestic luxuries available in their tents and huts on the beach, but they do have plenty of wine (delivered by ship), and food, and enslaved women, acquired from the sack of nearby towns. Patroclus’ role as the person who prepared all Achilles’ meals is a crucial element in their domestic and physical intimacy, unparalleled by the arrangements made by other Greek leaders (such as Nestor, whose cheesy drink is made by the enslaved Hecamede). Patroclus was like a wife to Achilles, whose refusal to eat is not merely a generalized gesture of grief, but a resistance to food prepared by anybody else.

**19.428** *who makes everybody shudder* : The phrasing here is unparalleled, but it echoes Helen’s own observation that everyone shudders or shivers at her (24.969). As the half-divine pretext of a massive war, and as a person of unusual insight who has

experienced both sides in the conflict, Helen arouses fear and a sense of the uncanny in ordinary and even extraordinary mortals.

**19.432** *Neoptolemus* : This is the only mention of Achilles' son in the poem, although from the larger mythological tradition, we are told that he was conceived when Achilles was en route to the war, when he stopped on the island of Scyros and met Deidamia. After the death of Achilles, Odysseus fetched the boy from Scyros and gave him his father's armor. These stories are attested in much later summaries of mostly lost texts. Neoptolemus was one of the warriors inside the Wooden Horse (as we are told in *Odyssey* 4) and was instrumental in the sack of Troy. It was Neoptolemus who killed Priam (as described in Virgil's *Aeneid* 2).

**19.436** *go back home again to Phthia* : The Greek includes a sonic wordplay on the name of Achilles' homeland, Phthia, and the verb he uses for "die," *phthisesthai* . Dying and going back to Phthia are presented as opposites, but they sound the same. Achilles does not name any of his "captive women": within his fantasy, there is no special mention of Briseis, presumably due to his lack of interest in her.

**19.446** *wailed in response* : Like the enslaved women, who answer Briseis' speech with ritual cries of lament, the Greek leaders respond to Achilles' speech with ritual cries of lament.

**19.457** *his body* : The intimacy between the bodies of Patroclus and Achilles is maintained even after they can no longer trade a single set of armor, and even once Achilles is no longer lying in the dust, like his dead friend: now both the comrades will have bodies resuscitated and preserved by the same divine substances, nectar and ambrosia.

**19.460** *just like a shearwater* : The comparison is to some kind of seabird, probably a type of shearwater, although the Greek word, *harpē* , does not occur elsewhere in poetry. Shearwaters hover over the sea and swoop suddenly down to the water to snatch their prey—and the word *harpē* is presumably related to the verb *harpazo* , "to snatch." Athena's action is like the bird's only in its swift, smooth descent: rather than taking food, she gives it.

**19.469** *Boreas* : The personified north wind, a divine being.

**19.474** *the earth around them seemed to smile* : Perhaps the earth is pleased to be so shiny, or it is as if the goddess (Gaia) opens her mouth to reveal her shining teeth.

**19.503** *like wings that raised him up* : It is unclear how literally we should take the idea that the divine armor provides magical assistance to Achilles, making him able to fly like a bird and invulnerable to injury. It is symbolically important that Achilles' most famous weapon, the spear with which he will kill Hector, belongs to his mortal father, rather than being made by Hephaestus.

**19.509** *a Pelian spear / . . . Chiron* : These lines contain wordplay on the similar-sounding names of Peleus and Mount Pelion, and also the verb for "ply," *pallo* .



Chiron is the Centaur who educated Achilles on Mount Pelion. The effect is to underline the importance of this weapon, and remind us of Achilles' complex ancestry, as the son of a mortal man as well as a goddess, and as a young man raised by the wild but civilizing Centaur. Hephaestus' elaborate metal shield signifies part, but only part, of Achilles' power.

**19.511** *Alcimus* : This is presumably the same character as Alcimedon, with his name shortened for metrical convenience in the Greek.

**19.519** *Hyperion* : See 8.645. Hyperion is a Titan, associated with the sun and usually represented as the father of the current sun god, Helios.

**19.531** *the power of speech* : This marvelous moment of magic sums up Achilles' unique position as a man who is closer to the gods than any other warrior, and yet mortal; his divine heritage helps him only in providing him with clear awareness of his own imminent death. Some versions of the myth defined Achilles primarily by his magical attributes and accessories: magically fast horses, invincible weapons, a body invulnerable in every spot except the heel. In *The Iliad* , by contrast, Achilles' magical, divine horses have the power of speech, but they use it only to warn him of his death, just as Thetis, even while comforting her son, reminds him of his mortality. In the world of this poem, even talking horses cannot prevent death.

**19.534** *not to blame* : The language of argument about who or what is to blame (*aitios* ) for a disaster echoes the language used by Agamemnon earlier in this book (19.112) when he asserts that the one "to blame" for the quarrel was not himself, but Zeus, Destiny, and the Fury.

**19.540** *best of gods* : At 13.126, the "best of gods" is Zeus. The surprising phrase may underline the fact that this may be surprising news to Achilles, who has not before been told that Apollo played a crucial part in his dear friend's death—and will in his own.

**19.545** *a human and a god* : Paris and Apollo—as Hector will foretell (22.484).

**19.546** *the Furies stopped his speech* : The Furies are rarely mentioned in Homer. Presumably they disapprove of talking animals because they violate the laws of nature, which are their special sphere. Another motive may be that the Furies do not want Achilles, a mere mortal, to know too much of the future.

## BOOK 20 SUMMARY

Zeus tells the gods to join the human conflict, to ensure that Achilles does not sack the city (which is more than he is destined to achieve). Gods of Olympus and of the waterways around Troy line up against one another. Achilles searches for Hector. Apollo urges Aeneas to attack Achilles; they taunt each other and fight. Achilles almost kills Aeneas, but Poseidon rescues him. Achilles kills many Trojans, including Hector's

brother Polydorus. Hector tries to battle Achilles and is almost killed, but is rescued by Apollo. Achilles rages and slaughters more Trojans.

- 20.2** *you* : The rare second-person address to Achilles by the narrator marks the importance of this turning point in the poem—the moment when Achilles at last returns to battle. See note at 4.163.
- 20.7** *Themis* : Themis means “righteousness” or “norm”; she is the goddess of proper, pious behavior. Her presence is significant at the start of a sequence in which Achilles will violate multiple norms of battlefield ethics.
- 20.14** *sat out in the polished colonnades* : Presumably they have to gather in the colonnades because the house of Zeus is not big enough to incorporate an assembly that includes not only the Olympians but all the deities of every river in the world (except Ocean) and every other sacred natural place. The water nymphs are goddesses associated with natural waters, such as springs, meadows, and creeks; they include the Nereids, the sisters of Thetis, associated with the sea. Other types of nymph not mentioned here include the tree goddesses (the dryads) and the mountain goddesses (the oreads). The gathering focuses on water deities, in preparation for the battle between Achilles and the river.
- 20.18** *Poseidon . . . did not fail* : Poseidon might be expected to have refused to come because he was angry with his brother, Zeus, in Book 15 (15.243–93). The presence even of Poseidon, as well as the non-Olympian deities, marks a significant shift in the divine action of the poem. Now that Achilles is back in battle, Zeus will no longer hold the gods back from the battlefield, as he did at the behest of Thetis. Thetis, an ocean deity, persuaded Zeus to restrain the others; now different water deities will flood the battlefield.
- 20.25** *about to burn* : I.e., the battle is about to begin again with new intensity; “burn” (*daiō*) is often used in a metaphorical sense.
- 20.41** *beyond what is allotted* : The cosmic “allotment” or “portion” of Achilles (*moros/moira*, often translated as “fate” or “destiny”) does not include sacking Troy, so it would be “beyond allotment” (*hypermoron*) if he were to break down the city wall. The gods are to return to the battlefield because some of them will help the Trojans, and therefore prevent Achilles from success beyond what he is supposed to achieve, according to the traditions of his mythic story, or his allotment.
- 20.54** *Xanthus* : Xanthus, the god representing the River Scamander, is a slightly surprising inclusion. But his presence has been anticipated by the inclusion of rivers at the divine council, and he will soon play an important role in the battle. Leto, mother of the archer twins Apollo and Artemis, is not a military goddess and seems to be included primarily to support her children, and underline their importance as supporters of Troy; Apollo plays a crucial role in the poem. Hermes has not before

been mentioned as a supporter of the Greeks, and his choice is not explained; perhaps he is here because he will play an important intermediary role in Book 24. Hephaestus takes his mother's side, perhaps to prepare for his vital role in helping Achilles in Book 21. Elsewhere, it is only Hector who is described as "wearing a flashing helmet," *koruthaiolos* ; the use of this descriptor for Ares underlines his current affinity with Troy. "Laughter-loving" Aphrodite is, as we have learned in Book 5, not likely to be much use in battle.

**20.73** *Callicolone* : Callicolone means "hill of beauty" or "beautiful mound." This hill is mentioned only here and a few lines later in this same book, and seems to be invented for the purpose; there is added pathos and horror in the image of Athena and Ares wrecking havoc in a beautiful landscape.

**20.83** *Hades was terrified* : This extraordinary detail underlines how shocking this divine battle is: it terrifies even the god of the dead, whose gates are open to everyone except the immortals. The possibility that Hades' realm could open suggests that this could become a cosmic battle between the gods that could destroy the current order of things, as when the Titans fought and were defeated by the gods of the current regime, the Olympians led by Zeus. The author of *On the Sublime* cites the passage as an example of sublimity veering into impiety, since it shows even gods subject to peril and terror (8.6).

**20.100** *Xanthus*— / "Yellow" : Xanthus means "yellow," a natural name for a river (or a horse; the color can also be "bay"). The idea that gods and humans sometimes have different names for things occurs elsewhere in Homer. It is possible that both names were in circulation; perhaps they are two different attempts by Greek speakers to interpret an originally non-Greek name. The mention of the two names may help prepare the reader for the surprisingly large role the river will take on, in moving from his role as perceived by humans, as a feature of the landscape, to his divine role as a fully personified god.

**20.132** *his weapon always flies* : The narrator has not told us that Achilles' weapons have magical powers, but some mythical traditions suggested that they did, and Aeneas seems to ascribe invincibility to his opponent's spear.

**20.167** *the allotted thread* : "Allotment" or "destiny" is *aisa* , a word originally connoting "measure" or "share," and hence, one's "share" or "measure" of good or bad luck in life. There was a common idea in archaic Greek culture that every human has a life-thread spun at birth by a goddess or trio of goddesses; the goddess is sometimes called Fate (Moiras, a word that also connotes allotment or portion) or Spinner (Klotho; see Hesiod, *Theogony* 218).

**20.179** *because we are much better than they are* : This line may be an annotation inserted into the text by mistake. If it belongs here, presumably the point is that so

far, there is no need to intervene, because only the inferior pro-Trojan deities have entered the battlefield.

**20.182** *War is a task for men* : Poseidon's line was used earlier by Hector (6.669). The line reads differently in the two contexts because Hector means "for men, as opposed to women," whereas Poseidon means "for men, as opposed to gods."

**20.188** *crushed beneath our hands* : Hands are often a synecdoche for action.

**20.191** *the high wall / . . . built for Heracles* : Heracles came to help the Trojans get rid of the monster sent by Poseidon to afflict the city, after the Trojan king Laomedon (father of Priam) failed to pay him for building the city walls. Heracles eventually managed to kill the monster, but the Trojans again reneged on the payment. This extra wall is presumably invented for this scene, to provide a convenient way for the gods to watch the battle from close quarters. The reference also reminds us that Poseidon has a long history of enmity towards Troy.

**20.198** *you, Apollo*: The narrator's second-person address to Apollo presumably underlines that god's importance in the narrative (see note at 4.163). Apollo is given an epithet of obscure meaning, *eie* , which is probably related to the ritual cry "*iē* ," associated with the god's worship.

**20.239** *he has sons* : Aeneas and Hector are distant (third-generation) cousins because both are descended from Tros, the eponymous founder of the city, great-grandfather of Priam and Anchises. Achilles seems to hint at a rivalry between the different branches of the Trojan royal family.

**20.259** *I tell you / . . . done is done* : This repeats 17.39.

**20.288** *King Erichthonius* : The name suggests "mighty one of the land" (*chthonus* = land or earth) and may have been used as a term for the indigenous people of the Troad. A legendary king of Athens has a similar name (Erichtheus), and some scholars believe that this passage suggests Athenian influence on *The Iliad* ; others suggest that these are two distinct but parallel myths about the presence of indigenous populations in colonized territories.

**20.304** *Ganymede* : In later versions of the myth, Ganymede is kidnapped specifically by Zeus, who wants to rape him. The story explains why Ganymede had no sons. The abusive attention paid by the gods to this Trojan ancestor sheds luster on the family and hints at a narrative in which Paris, like his forebears, was used by the gods because of his beauty. The reference to this ancestor who was lifted up from earth by a god also foreshadows what will happen to Aeneas later in this episode, and echoes what happened to Paris when he was to duel Menelaus in Book 3. There is a pattern in the royal house of Troy of beautiful young men who are lifted up by gods or goddesses, deities who are often motivated by desire; another example is Tithonus, who was lifted up to the sky by the goddess Dawn, to be her immortal—but not ageless—boyfriend.

- 20.317** *increases and diminishes / courage* : This is Aeneas' response to Achilles' earlier taunt (20.244ff.) about his cowardice, in fleeing the first time they met.
- 20.320** *let us stop chattering* : Both ancient and modern commentators have found it funny that Aeneas is so disparaging of long battlefield speeches, in the middle of making one—a joke of which the narrator is surely aware. Pious Aeneas, with his reverence for the gods, pride in his ancestry, and insistence on the proper way for men to behave, is lacking in self-awareness and prone to hypocrisy. Aeneas' prolix, meandering speech also throws into relief the brusque and innovative manner of Achilles' speech.
- 20.329** *People will talk of you as you of them* : This line sounds proverbial and presumably suggests that a person who bad-mouths others will be bad-mouthed in turn; cf. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 721, "If you say something bad, you'll soon hear worse yourself."
- 20.334** *slinging insults* : The language echoes the terms used for the original quarrel between Achilles and Agamemnon in Book 1, which was also motivated by "heart-devouring anger" and involved two people hurling both true and false insults at each other in a public place.
- 20.354** *five layers* : In real life, shields were constructed with layers of leather or animal hide, sometimes with a layer of metal over the hide. This shield has only metal layers, and the softest metal, the gold—which one might expect would have a purely ornamental function—is hidden inside, and is said, implausibly, to be capable of stopping the thrust of the bronze spear. Realism is not to be expected from a magical, divinely crafted artifact: the gold stops the bronze not because gold in real life is a smart choice for armor (it is not), but because gold is the most valuable metal and therefore the one most closely associated with gods. Achilles' shield stops Aeneas' spear because it comes from the gods, whereas the spear is an ordinary mortal piece of equipment.
- 20.359** *the bronze was thinnest* : The shield gets thinner at the edge; the middle is the thickest part.
- 20.390** *troubles that do not belong to him* : The extraneous troubles may include the betrayal of Poseidon himself and Apollo by Laomedon, when he failed to pay the gods for building the walls of the city: as Aeneas' genealogical speech made clear, Aeneas is not descended from Laomedon, and therefore is not subject to the hatred of Poseidon and Apollo, unlike Hector and the other children of Priam. But the language is vague enough that it could also cover the conflict on the human realm: Achilles' quarrel is with Hector, who killed Patroclus, not with Aeneas, who was not involved.
- 20.401** *Aeneas and his children's children* : This idea forms the basis for the notion, developed in Virgil's *Aeneid* , that the descendants of Aeneas are fated by



Zeus/Jupiter to survive forever and conquer the world; the Romans identified themselves as these descendants.

**20.428** *Caucones* : The Caucones are allies of the Trojans. The sense may be that this is the location of their camp, where they originally put on their armor, rather than that they are belatedly arming in the middle of the battle. In Book 10 Dolon said that the Caucones were stationed next to the sea (10.536), so presumably Poseidon, god of the sea, has chosen a location that suits himself.

**20.431** *delusional* : The rare verb *ateo* , “to be delusional,” occurs only here; it is the same root as the noun *atē* , “reckless/ruinous delusion,” on which Agamemnon blames his behavior in taking Briseis from Achilles.

**20.465** *jaws / of such a fighting force* : Achilles’ language is characteristically colorful and unusual. The idea of the “jaws of battle” occurs elsewhere, but here the metaphor is extended so that it sounds as if the warrior’s task is to bridle or plunge into the maw of a wild beast.

**20.478** *could fight . . . with words* : This refers back to Achilles’ boast (20.463), where he implicitly compares his own battle courage with Ares and Athena.

**20.499** *A water goddess* : Achilles’ first victim is, like himself, the son of a water goddess, although the mother of Iphition is not a sea goddess (an Oceanid) but a naiad, a lesser, local divinity associated with a specific freshwater source (presumably a mountain spring). The location of Hyde is unknown; we are told by Strabo that some identified it with Sardis, the capital city of Lydia, beneath Mount Tmolus (modern Bozdag).

**20.509** *wildest, most aggressive* : The unusual word translated as “wildest, most aggressive,” *ekpaglotatos*, is used elsewhere in the poem only twice, both times of Achilles himself (1.146 and 18.212). Achilles is taunting this other son of a water goddess by presenting him as someone who wanted to be like himself—extraordinary in terrifying ways—but who has failed to be anything but normal and dead. There is another kind of burn in Achilles’ taunting narrative of his victim’s whole life, which asserts his ability to claim control of the other man’s story.

**20.530** *Helice* : Helice was the site of a famous temple to Poseidon. Poseidon was particularly associated with bulls and liked bovine sacrifices.

**20.542** *his jerkin* : The victim seems to be wearing a leather vest, wrapped round the body with the opening in the back, with a belt around it to keep it on.

**20.556** *channels of the battlefield* : There is a conventional metaphor of the areas between rows of troops as “channels” or “dikes” running through the battle (as at 4.494—see note).

**20.558** *Come here* : In a poem full of very long speeches, the brevity of Achilles’ address—with no name or title for his addressee—is shocking in itself. The metaphor of death, ruin, or destiny as a rope or net is common in *The Iliad* ; it

suggests trouble from which the victim cannot escape, like an animal caught by a hunter or trainer, with rope or net.

**20.569** *threw his spear* : Presumably he has pulled the spear out of the corpse of Dryops, but the narrator is moving so fast that some steps are skipped.

**20.629** *The marrow burst out* : This is, of course, anatomically impossible, but evocative in its suggestion of how completely Achilles' violence can turn a human body inside out.

**20.649** *horses driven by Achilles* : We have not been told that Achilles mounted his chariot. This massacre, or *aristeia*, by Achilles is different from any other in the poem, not least because things happen so fast and much of the typical narrative connective tissue is omitted.

**20.656** *His lethal hands were always drenched in gore* : This line was used earlier of Agamemnon (11.227).

## BOOK 21 SUMMARY

Achilles forces half the Trojans into the River Scamander and clogs up the streams with corpses. He takes twelve boys alive. He encounters Lycaon, whom he captured on an earlier occasion and allowed to live; now, Lycaon again begs for his life but Achilles kills him, reminding him that Patroclus is already dead, and he himself will soon die. The River Xanthus/Scamander rises up against Achilles, forcing him to flee across the plain. Hera sends Hephaestus, god of fire, to fight the river in flood, and the river submits. The gods fight among themselves. Priam sees the carnage and orders the Trojans to come inside the city. Meanwhile, Apollo distracts Achilles, first by sending the Trojan Agenor and then by taunting Achilles himself in the guise of Agenor.

**21.6** *the day before* : The day of the "great battle," in which many Greeks were slaughtered, as described in Books 11–15.

**21.48** *fresh fig branches* : Fig branches, being pliant and tough, were used for items that needed to be curved, such as chariot rails or hoops or wheels. Lycaon is doing this work at night to avoid enemy capture; the time of day adds to the shock of Achilles' sudden visit.

**21.53** *Jason's son* : Euneus, son of Jason and Hypsipyle, is mentioned as the supplier of wine to the Greek troops (7.595–601). We learn later that the slave price of Lycaon, paid by Euneus, was a valuable silver bowl, given to Patroclus (23.989); the object creates a subtle link between Achilles' captive victim and his beloved friend.

**21.55** *Eetion* : Imbrian Eetion is a different man from the Eetion who was the father of Andromache.

- 21.86** *tried to grasp / his knees* : Grasping the knees is a traditional gesture of supplication, a way of putting oneself physically lower than another person to acknowledge their power. It is comparable to the modern gesture of raising empty hands in surrender as a display of vulnerability.
- 21.99** *your suppliant / . . . tasted bread* : Lycaon appeals to three distinct norms of conduct. One is showing mercy to suppliants. Another is hospitality (*xenia*) : because Achilles has shared bread with his captive, they could be seen as sharing a bond of guest-friendship. A third is that it would be paradoxical to take a life that the potential killer has already spared.
- 21.114** *so short a life* : The term used for “short-lifer” or “little-whiler,” *minunthadios*, has been used of Achilles (1.465) and Hector (15.815).
- 21.120** *butcher* : Lycaon uses a relatively unusual word for “kill” or “butcher,” *deirotomeo*, which literally connotes “slit the throat,” although this is not the method used. It can be extended from literal throat-slitting to any brutal form of killing.
- 21.126** *a divinity* : *Daimon*, the word translated as “divinity,” may suggest a lesser divine being, or a more vaguely imagined, less personified idea of divine agency.
- 21.150** *a spear’s throw or an arrow* : The various unknowns—time and manner of death—underline the certainty of the only important fact. Achilles knows that he will not be killed in hand-to-hand combat (with sword or thrusting-spear), because he is swift-footed enough to escape such attacks—but he will not be quick enough to escape the arrow shot by Paris, guided by Apollo, that will strike his heel (a story not told in *The Iliad*, but well-known to the audience).
- 21.158** *grabbed him by his foot* : The picking up of the victim by his foot is a (fairly implausible, but effective) mark of Achilles’ godlike physical superiority, and also of the swift-footed hero’s extraordinary abilities with feet in particular.
- 21.166** *the sea’s broad lap* : The sea, not his mother, will welcome Lycaon, and offer him not tears and a proper funeral, but drowning and the postmortem humiliation of being eaten by the fish.
- 21.174** *so many bulls / and horses* : Bulls are a common sacrifice to rivers or river gods. Horse sacrifice is elsewhere presented as a non-Greek custom, and ancient commentators seem to have found this line shocking.
- 21.187** *Asteropeus, son / of Pelegon, the son of Axius* : Asteropeus’ ancestry, as grandson of a river, makes him a natural ally of Xanthus against Achilles. The Axius is the modern Vardar, which flows through Macedonia.
- 21.244** *sons of mighty Zeus* : Achilles is a great-grandson of Zeus (his father’s father, Aeacus, was a son of Zeus by Aegina, a daughter of a river god, Asopus). “Sons,” *paisi*, is an exaggeration, perhaps hinting at the path not taken: if Achilles were really the son of Zeus by Thetis, he would be immortal and powerful enough to



overthrow the current ruler of Olympus, to become ruler of the universe (because it was prophesied that the son of Thetis would be more powerful than his father).

**21.256** *majestic Achelous / . . . immeasurable Ocean* : The Achelous is the largest river in Greece, on the border of Aetolia. The Ocean is the mythical divine river that flows all around the earth.

**21.304** *earnestly advised you* : Zeus told the gods in general to help both sides, to prevent Achilles from sacking Troy (20.31–41). No special instructions were given to Apollo, and no time limit was specified.

**21.356** *inhabitants of heaven / . . . Zeus-fed river* : The inhabitants of heaven are the Olympian deities, as opposed to the deities of waterways and other elements of the landscape. “Zeus-fed” is a conventional descriptor for rivers, because they are filled with rainwater (sent by Zeus, the god of precipitation). But the epithet acquires a particular resonance here, because Achilles is so eager to know whether Zeus is on the river’s side.

**21.362** *wore out his body / . . . nibbling* : The language of the original echoes terms used to describe death in battle, and the “nibbling” (*hyperepte*, cognate with *erepto*), a verb used commonly for animal eating, as for the eels at line 21.267) hints that Achilles here comes extremely close to the end most dreaded by Homeric warriors: to be defeated, slaughtered, and eaten.

**21.374** *struck by the agile arrows* : In most versions of the myth, Apollo guides the arrow of Paris, which kills Achilles. For a Homeric warrior, a good death—i.e., an honorable, not humiliating one—entails being killed in war by a noble human opponent of high status, rather than being killed by natural, nonhuman means (such as drowning, fire, starvation, or, as often happens in *The Odyssey*, being eaten).

**21.445** *my little twisty foot* : Hera does not use her son’s name but addresses him with a diminutive that refers to his unusually shaped feet. The term could indicate affection, or a dismissive, patronizing attitude, or both. Plutarch (*Moralia* 35c) insists that it is not a reproach, but presumably others in antiquity believed that it might be; the Homeric scholar Aristarchus felt it was inappropriate.

**21.450** *from out at sea* : Given the geography of Troy, it is somewhat surprising that a wind “from out at sea” (*ex halothen*, a term that appears nowhere else but clearly suggests movement from the sea) should include Notus, the south wind; there is no sea to the south of Troy. The winds are chosen for their metaphorical associations for an inhabitant of Greek-speaking regions, rather than geographical realism: Notus, the south wind, is warm and hence a more natural ally for the fire god Hephaestus than cold Boreas, the north wind.

**21.468** *rakes the beds* : The details of the horticultural narrative are not clear, and “rake” is just one possible interpretation of the unusual verb *etheirei*, which may be related to *etheira*, “hair” or “mane.”

- 21.477** *wily Lord Hephaestus* : Elsewhere, the epithet “wily,” *polymētis* , is used only of Odysseus.
- 21.524** *Dog-fly* : Dog-fly, *kunamuia* , is used only here and at line 21.562. Flies were proverbially associated with recklessness and persistence, as in Book 17 (17.727), where Athena inspires Menelaus with the “courage of a fly.” Like dogs (and women), flies share food and space with men, and are frustratingly persistent in pursuing their annoying goals.
- 21.543** *seven thousand feet* : The unit of measurement—*pelethron* —is a large number, either 100 feet or 1000 square feet.
- 21.610** *tricked out of our wages* : King Laomedon, the father of Priam, failed to pay Apollo and Poseidon for building the magically strong walls of Troy.
- 21.655** *wives of Zeus* : Both Leto and Hera are “wives” or “bed sharers” of Zeus (*alochos* ).
- 21.690** *sacked Troy* : Apollo, the archer god who always keeps his distance, is concerned not about the people of Troy, but the wall that he and Poseidon constructed. The poem often refers to the idea that there is a proper time for the city to fall.
- 21.701** *looked at the enormity* : The word *pelōrios* , “enormous” or “monstrous,” is also used at Greek line number 3.166, again in the context of Priam’s looking from the city wall at the Greeks, although there it is applied to Agamemnon.
- 21.729** *goddesses of death* : The word *kēr* , “goddess of death” or “Fate,” sometimes appears in the singular, sometimes in the plural, and may sometimes be more of an abstract idea than a divinity. *Kēr* represents not a large-scale metaphysical idea of destiny but the particular death or doom encountered by an individual mortal at the appointed time.
- 21.775** *save / our . . . sons* : The male babies and children, like Hector’s son, Astyanax, are more likely to be slaughtered in the sack of the city, because they are more likely to be a threat to their enslavers, and less useful to serve for domestic tasks and breeding more enslaved people. The poem more often refers to the death of the “children” of Troy (*paidia* ), but here it is specifically the sons (*huiēs* ).
- 21.781** *below the knee* : Achilles here comes close to death, given that the blow is just above his heel. *The Iliad* never tells us explicitly that Achilles is vulnerable only on his heel, but this part of the legend would have been familiar.

## BOOK 22 SUMMARY

With most of the Trojans safely inside the city, Achilles chases the false Agenor, until Apollo reveals himself. Hector is the only Trojan remaining outside the gates. Priam and Hecuba implore him to come inside, but to no avail. Achilles approaches and

Hector runs. They race around the city three times, until Zeus holds up his cosmic scales, and Hector's destiny sinks down. Athena appears, disguised as another of Hector's brothers, Deiphobus, to make him think he has a companion, and therefore a chance against Achilles. He stops running and the two warriors face each other. Hector asks Achilles to ensure that the victor return the victim's body to his loved ones, a suggestion that Achilles angrily rejects. Athena disappears, and Hector realizes that the gods have led him to his death. Achilles kills him and boasts over his corpse, which he drags back to the Greek camp. Andromache, who has been preparing a hot bath for her husband, sees him dragged dead in the dust, and wails for her husband, her freedom, and their baby son, who will soon be killed.

**22.5** *angled flat* : Probably they hold their shields horizontally to ward against weapons or rocks hurled from the city walls above them.

**22.21** *the one who works from far away* : Apollo is the far-working god of distance; Achilles identifies him by his traditional description but not by name. One could hear a kind of bite to the epithet in this context: Achilles views his own directness and speed as superior to the distanced tactics of Apollo, who relies heavily on intermediaries to kill his victims (such as arrows, plague, disguises, or prophecies).

**22.40** *Dog Star* : Sirius, the Dog Star, whose heliacal rising at dawn in mid-July marks the beginning of *opore* . The late summer period, which is the hottest season in Greece and Anatolia, is supposed to be the time of most infections.

**22.56** *loved him the way I do* : Priam wishes the gods loved Achilles as he himself does—i.e., not at all. The ironic rhetoric underlines Priam's rage at the unfair favoritism of the gods, who enable the pious Hector to be killed.

**22.64** *Polydorus and Lycaon* : Both have already been slaughtered by Achilles.

**22.70** *his daughter* : Laothoe, daughter of Altes, is described as a legitimate wife of Priam, who came to him with a rich dowry from her father. Priam's fifty sons are mothered by many wives, but Hector and Paris are apparently monogamous.

**22.84** *threshold of old age* : It is a common metaphor to describe old age as a threshold, because it is the final doorway between life and death. Violent death in old age is humiliating, because the old man cannot defend himself.

**22.89** *my sons' wives* : It may seem odd that the daughters-in-law are placed in the climactic final position in the list, until we remember that this group includes Helen, wife of Paris. Ancient listeners would have remembered that Hector's son, Astyanax, will be one of the little children massacred in the city's sack.

**22.97** *rabid and frenzied* : The dogs contract rabies from the excess of human blood they consume in the sack of Troy—an epidemiological impossibility, but evocative of the horror of the city's fall, in which even the beneficiaries, dogs and Greeks, are corrupted by the satisfaction of their desires.

- 22.98** *A young man / . . . a gray old head* : Priam imagines a young warrior's corpse treated with dignity on the battlefield—not anticipating the humiliation that Achilles will impose on the dead Hector. The horror of an old man dying by violence evokes the horror of civilian casualties more broadly, a shift from honorable combat between equals to the slaughter and pillage of defenseless noncombatants. The pathetic death Priam imagines for himself at the fall of Troy is told in *The Iliad* only here; Virgil expands on this passage in his own account of the fall of Troy (*Aeneid* 2).
- 22.102** *shame his private parts* : The dogs are imagined as eating the old man's genitalia. Hecuba shows her breast to Hector, which fed him as a baby; Priam makes a symbolically equivalent gesture by referring to the body part that beget the son.
- 22.115** *stubborn fool* : Priam and Hecuba both use the same word, *schetlios* , at the start of a line to reprove Hector for his stubbornness and folly.
- 22.118** *bridal-gifts* : Hector is wasting a valuable commodity and failing to make good on an economic investment that the family has already made: the wife's final duty, as mourner for her dead husband, is made impossible in the absence of a body.
- 22.126** *devoured poison* : Snakes were believed to gain their venom from food. The poison feeds the snake's venom and his rage or "choler" (*cholos* ), a semiphysical element in the body. The primary point of comparison for the simile seems at first to be Achilles, who lurks and watches his opponent, like the snake—but the narrator makes a further, more surprising comparison with Hector.
- 22.131** *propped up* : The shield is too heavy to keep holding upright during the long wait. The detail reminds us that Hector is right beside the city wall; at any moment, he could choose to reenter the city and reach safety, via the Scaean Gates, but he refuses to do so.
- 22.138** *back to Troy* : Polydamas recommended this sensible plan in Book 18, on the grounds that casualties would be too high with Achilles back on the battlefield. The Trojans instead followed the advice of Hector, who was focused on his own hopes for glory. This resulted in the Trojan massacre of Books 20–21.
- 22.171** *from oak or rock* : The phrase "from oak or rock" is presumably proverbial; it also occurs in Hesiod (*Theogony* 35), again in a context where the speaker is making a sudden switch away from a tangent. Ancient and modern commentators have been puzzled by the exact sense of the phrase. There is something also surprisingly intimate about Hector's romantic characterization of the conversation he cannot have with Achilles: a flirtatious chat between teenage lovers (the verb in the original for "chatting," *ōārizō* , is used elsewhere of lovers).
- 22.178** *Enyalios* : Enyalios is a title of Ares, because of his association with Enyo, goddess of conflict.

- 22.181** *spear of Pelian ash* : Achilles' spear was created on Mount Pelion by his Centaur tutor, Chiron. The detail reminds us that Achilles has several distinct elements of divine aid for his battle against Hector: the armor from Thetis and Hephaestus; the spear from Chiron; and the assistance of Athena.
- 22.194** *trembled* : The verb “tremble,” *treō* , is cognate with the word for “trembling dove,” *treron peleia* , used earlier in this book.
- 22.199** *beautiful clear springs* : Archaeologists and geographers have made many attempts, starting in the first century BCE, to discover hot and cold springs near the site of Troy, without success. It has often been suggested that the temperatures of springs on Mount Ida may have changed, perhaps as a result of volcanic activity, although this has not been proven with material evidence. Modern inhabitants of the region identify some springs as hot or cold, but scientific measurements have not been able to measure any difference in temperature. The detail suggests the plain of Troy is a semimagical place, blessed with extraordinary natural amenities.
- 22.243** *child of Triton* : On Tritogeneia (literally, “Triton-born”) as an epithet of Athena, see note at 4.691; the word also occurs at 8.49.
- 22.269** *But how could Hector* : These lines explain how it was that Hector, who is not renowned for speed, managed to keep ahead of Achilles for long enough to run three times around the city. The delay, which is ascribed to divine intervention, has obvious advantages for the narrative: it allows the poet to magnify this climactic killing by drawing it out, and to present the chase as happening as if in slow motion, as a momentous spectacle played out in front of multiple sets of spectators.
- 22.278** *his golden scales* : The scales of Zeus have appeared at several earlier points of narrative crisis, including 8.86, 16.823, and 19.293. The lost epic the *Aethiopis* , “The Ethiopian Poem,” told of the battle between Achilles and Memnon, the Ethiopian son of the goddess Dawn, and seems to have featured a scene in which Achilles and Memnon fought, and Zeus held up the scales; Memnon's weight fell and he was killed by Achilles. Many scholars believe that that mythical scene of psychostasia (the Greek literally means “soul-measuring”) was a model for *The Iliad* here—although Memnon, being the son of a goddess, was a more equal opponent to Achilles than the fully mortal Hector. The imagery of the scales implies that some element of divine action, or fate as it impacts human lives and deaths, might be impartial: Zeus measures, but does not determine the result. But the impartial scales of Zeus are counterbalanced by a very different image: Apollo and Athena trick Hector and lead him to his death. The poem insists on several distinct possibilities that are ostensibly incompatible: the gods are both partial and impartial; fate can and cannot be shaped by human and divine choices.
- 22.304** *Dear brother* : Hector and Deiphobus are full brothers. Athena here uses a term of address suggesting familiarity and affection: *ētheie*, “familiar one,” “accustomed



one.”

- 22.347** *Fool, forget about agreements* : The word Achilles uses to address Hector (*alaste*, from *alastos* ) is of uncertain meaning; it might suggest “accursed.” Or, as I take it, it may be related to the verb *lanthanō* , “to escape notice or be forgotten,” with the negative prefix, so Achilles is accusing Hector of an inability to forget social norms, even between enemies.
- 22.352** *love each other or be friends* : Both friendship and love are suggested by the Greek verb *philemenai* , which can also be used to connote a connection of kinship or a sexual one. Achilles makes the idea of showing mercy to Hector ridiculous, by suggesting that it would entail *philia* , the more intimate form of friendly connection or kinship. A more realistic possibility would have been for these enemies in war to form or recognize a connection based on the more distant relationship of guest-friendship, *xenia* —as is done between Glaucus and Diomedes in Book 6, when they meet on the battlefield and recognize that they are guest-friends, *xenoi*.
- 22.396** *whose shield was white* : The descriptive term “whose shield was white,” *leukaspis* , is very unusual, suggestive of Hector’s desperate scanning of his field of vision for a notable, familiar sight that is nowhere to be seen.
- 22.421** *his shining helmet* : The details of Achilles’ elaborate helmet are not entirely clear, but it seems to have four bosses or horns (or, possibly, four metal plates attached to a leather base), with a crest on top, featuring golden horsehair plumes.
- 22.436** *the latches of the collarbone* : The term for “collarbone,” *kleides* , is literally “latches,” with the suggestion that this death is like bursting through a door or gate; Hector’s body is like the city of Troy, which Achilles will never live to enter.
- 22.442** *the power to speak in answer to his killer* : The ancient critic Aristarchus rejected this sentence on the grounds that it is “ridiculous” for the spear to be so careful to serve the narrative necessity of providing Hector with a voice for the final conversation. Hector speaks not because someone with a spear through his neck could actually do so, but because we, the listeners to the poem, need to hear how much the proper treatment of his body matters, not only to his family but also to the dead man himself.
- 22.482** *the cause / of wrath* : The rare word *mēnima* , “a cause of wrath,” is related to the first word of the poem, *mēnis* ; the poem traces a line beyond its own action, from the initial wrath of Achilles, to his death through divine and human wrath.
- 22.487** *she mourned* : The word “mourn,” *goomai* , is repeated from the speech of Achilles: Hector’s spirit, *psychē* , provides what Hector’s body does not yet receive from his female family members. The lament of the spirit for “manhood and youth” echoes the death of Patroclus (see note at 16.1073)—although Achilles is unlike Hector in treating his own imminent death as inevitable.

- 22.542** *keened in anguish* / . . . *agonizing groan* : The language distinguishes between the noises of male grief, “groaning” (*oimogē*), and female grief, “keening” (*kokutē*).
- 22.546** *dark-browed* : This rare epithet, *ophruoessa*, suggests “eyebrowed”: the image is perhaps that the hills or ridges of the Troad look like eyebrows. The use of this word here may signify the city’s personification: Troy, always gendered as female, scowls in rage or grief at her own destruction.
- 22.607** *rash courage* : The word rendered “rash courage,” *agēnoriē*, suggests literally an excess of masculinity (*aga* = “excessive,” *anēr* = “man”); it implies the strand in Homeric masculine identity that seeks individual glory, in contrast to *ēnoriē* (also related etymologically to *anēr*), which connotes the positive quality of masculine heroism in service of a community (see notes at 2.337 and 9.513). Andromache comes close to blaming her husband for his own death.
- 22.612** *maenad* : A maenad is a “maddened woman,” such as the followers of Dionysus, who went into a ritual frenzy and worshipped the god in the wild places on the mountainside.

## BOOK 23 SUMMARY

Achilles tries to desecrate the body of Hector, but the gods keep it fresh. Achilles lets his men hold a funeral feast for Patroclus, but he himself refuses to wash off the blood from his body. When he falls asleep, the spirit of Patroclus appears to him and asks for their bones to be interred together. Achilles tries to embrace his beloved dead friend, but the insubstantial spirit slips away. The next day, the pyre burns, and Achilles burns the twelve Trojan captive boys, and dogs and horses, as well as the body of his friend. The day after that, Achilles holds a series of athletic competitions to honor Patroclus. The first is the chariot race, which Diomedes wins because Eumelus, who originally had the lead, gets his yoke broken by Athena (who prefers Diomedes); Antilochus, through some shady tricks, comes in second. Eumelus’ bad luck and Antilochus’ cheating arouse anger, but Achilles smooths things over, and everybody ends up with a prize, including the loser (Eumelus) and the ingenious cheat (Antilochus). The other events are boxing, wrestling, foot racing, weight throwing, and archery. In each case, all competitors receive prizes, of greater or lesser value. The games show that victory is the result not only of talent and training, but also luck and divine favor, and they offer a model for how a group of ultracompetitive people might be able to share wealth and power without deadly quarrels. The final competition, spear throwing, is due to include Agamemnon, but Achilles gives him the prize without asking him to compete.

- 23.8** *ride near Patroclus* : The location of the body is unspecified, but it must have been moved from Achilles' hut to the shore.
- 23.24** *I am already / fulfilling all the things* : Achilles promised to do these things at 18.415–20. Some of the promises will be fulfilled and some will not.
- 23.45** *collected into cups* : The action here is disputed. The point might be simply that there is enough animal blood to fill many cups, or it may be that the blood is collected and then poured onto the ground as a libation for the shadowy spirits of the dead in the underworld, who particularly appreciate being offered blood (as in *The Odyssey* , 10.535ff., where the dead are enabled to speak when they receive a drink of blood).
- 23.97** *gates are always open* : The gates of Hades are always open because all mortals, at any moment, can die.
- 23.122** *a single urn* : In *Odyssey* 24.73–74, this vessel is said to be the gift of Dionysus and the work of Hephaestus. The exact type of vessel is unclear; it might be an urn, a box, a coffin, or any container.
- 23.139** *they have no substance, none at all* : This line is strange and was much disputed in antiquity. The word *phrenes* (from *phrēn* ), rendered “substance” here, usually means “intelligence”—but it would be peculiar to say that the spirits of the dead have no intelligence right after the dead Patroclus has given a well-reasoned and articulate speech. But *phrēn/phrenes* can refer to a part of the physical body, the midriff (imagined as the seat of intelligence), so the word is probably used by metonymy to refer to the whole physical body, which the spirits lack.
- 23.180** *their own hair* : Cutting the hair is a traditional marker of grief.
- 23.192** *the River Spercheus* : The Spercheus runs through Phthia. It is obviously not realistic that Achilles' hair growth should have taken place only in Phthia, when he has been at Troy for almost ten years, but the purpose of the passage is pathos, not realism. The color of Achilles' hair, like other Homeric colors, does not correspond to modern English color terminology: the word *xanthos* is used of horses whom we might call “chestnut” or “bay,” or any human hair color other than black, gray, or white; Xanthus is also the alternative name of the River Scamander (literally, “Yellow River”).
- 23.237** *cut the throats* : As the narrator's mention of “wicked things” suggests, this is a shocking moment within the world of the Homeric poems. Nowhere else does anyone perform human sacrifice. Presumably these are the twelve boys whom Achilles captured alive in Book 21 (21.34).
- 23.264** *refused to light* : The failure of the pyre to light by natural causes allows for divine intervention, so that the last rites of Patroclus take on a superhuman quality. The difficulties in lighting the fire could be taken as an indication that nature may be



reluctant to go along with Achilles' extremism in sacrificing the twelve Trojan boys and in trying to desecrate the body of Hector.

**23.280** *I visited the Ethiopians* : Iris is presumably making up a polite lie on the spot, and she chooses one that conveniently explains why she does not need to join the predatory group of winds for dinner, having already enjoyed a large dinner with the generous Ethiopians. Ancient commentators plausibly suggested that the winds are hitting on Iris because they are drunk.

**23.300** *libations on the ground* : It is traditional to offer liquid sacrifices, libations, to the dead (of oil, blood, or wine). Achilles uses only wine, presumably because this serves as a way to have a final night of getting drunk with the man he loves, as he has done so many nights before but never again.

**23.303** *just got married* : The detail that the son is only just married adds pathos because there are not, and will never be, grandchildren. Patroclus and Achilles are repeatedly presented as like parent and child. They are chosen family, and their relationship recalls the most intimate and emotional family relationship in the social world of Homer. At 16.8, Achilles is like Patroclus' mother, with Patroclus as a whiny little girl; at 18.393, Achilles' grief is like that of a lion who has lost her cubs. There is another level of pathos in the awareness of the listener, and of Achilles himself, that neither Peleus nor Menoetius will see their sons again.

**23.334** *the normal size* : The "normal" size for a mound for Patroclus alone is much smaller than the size that will be built over this same mound for Patroclus and Achilles together. There is a mound on the plain of Troy traditionally identified as the mound of Achilles (the Achilleion), a landmark that was known to the poem's ancient audiences.

**23.358** *two and twenty measures* : The "measures" are unspecified, so it is impossible to tell how large this cauldron is supposed to be, but it must be enormous; the cauldron at 23.362 is less than a fifth as big.

**23.390** *Lord Admetus* : King of Pherae in Thessaly.

**23.393** *whom Apollo rescued* : Diomedes got these horses at 5.346, and Aeneas was spirited away by Apollo later in Book 5. This earlier history is important for the god's intervention in the chariot race, because Apollo tries to thwart Diomedes again and Athena, who has helped Diomedes before (for instance, in Book 10), helps him again. The funeral games showcase how the same narrative patterns and divine forces, and the same competitive social structures, can play out with less deadly results than in the rest of the poem.

**23.400** *payment to evade the expedition* : As at 13.884, this passage suggests that Agamemnon gained his enormous fleet to Troy by forced conscription and increased his wealth with buyouts from those who could afford the cost of not joining the expedition. At 24.495, there is a reference to conscription by lot.

- 23.405** *her great unwillingness* : The participle rendered “her great unwillingness,” *ischanōsan*, from *ischanō*, is usually interpreted to mean “to be eager for” or “to desire,” such that the horse is imagined to be very keen to run; this sense fits one occurrence, at *Odyssey* 8.288, where Ares is “eager” for sex with Aphrodite. But the verb normally means the opposite—“to hold back from.” I take it that the normal meaning is more likely here: the horse, like her previous human owners, is reluctant to follow the sons of Atreus. There is a pointed resonance with the main mythical plot, in Menelaus’ difficulties in retaining control and possession of female subordinates.
- 23.417** *wheel around the post* : The most difficult point in the race is the turn of horses and chariot around the post at the end, for the return lap.
- 23.464** *Arion / . . . Laomedon’s fine horses* : Arion and the horses of Laomedon were all immortal, divine horses.
- 23.471** *they cast the lots* : The lots—marked stones or sticks shaken in an urn or helmet—are used to determine the starting lineup. The first position is the one on the inmost side of the track, closest to the turn; the driver in this position has the shortest distance to circle around the turning post, and therefore an advantage. The lineup creates a kind of handicap because Antilochus, with his inferior horses, gets the best position while Diomedes, the best driver with excellent horses, gets the most disadvantageous.
- 23.484** *he could mark the laps* : The plural form *dromous*, “laps,” suggests that there will be multiple turns, but in fact the charioteers go around the post only once.
- 23.499** *the final lap* : The narrator maintains surprise by not describing the turn, which we have already heard about at length in Nestor’s speech. The racetrack is set up to run away from the fleet and the sea towards the plain, round the post, and back again.
- 23.571** *Antilochus drove even faster* : In the narrow spot on the track, the safety-conscious Menelaus slows down and warns Antilochus not to try to overtake, because they may both crash; Antilochus, pretending not to hear the advice, seizes the opportunity to force his way into the lead. This is mostly a comic sequence that engages in a lighter way with central themes of the poem, including the relationship of prizes and external honors to athletic and ethical worth, and the norms of competitive interactions between men. The sequence features Menelaus being deprived of a female whom he had regarded as his—although here, no war ensues. Antilochus follows his father’s advice, using his brains to squeeze out at least a partial victory. Menelaus picks up the threat of the oath at 23.768, when he asks Antilochus to swear that he did not deliberately cheat—a challenge, given that he obviously did.

- 23.625** *why are you always / blathering* : The harshness of Ajax's reproach is not explained, beyond that it illustrates his boorish character. The squabble between the spectators serves to remind us that in athletic competitions, humans get the chance to be like gods, picking favorites and quarreling over who will win.
- 23.629** *not the youngest Greek* : Idomeneus is more elderly than most of the warriors, although without the obsession with the past that characterizes Nestor.
- 23.712** *agreed with his commands* : The word *keleue* , "commands," suggests that Achilles is operating more like an authoritarian one-man ruler, a *tyrannos* , than like a member of an oligarchic council—but this same line suggests that the others "agree" (*epeineon* ), rather than "obey" (*peithesthai* ). The funeral games as a whole show the Greeks working towards a political model in which several powerful men who share no ties of kinship might be able to share power amicably together, using models of collective decision-making that need not result in violence or incandescent rage—as in nascent oligarchic and democratic Greek city-states.
- 23.731** *I will not give her up* : There is an echo here of Book 1 (1.44), where Agamemnon said of Chryseis, "I will not let her go" (*tēn d'egō ou lusō* ), placed in the same emphatic position at the start of the line as this phrase, "I will not give her up" (*tēn d'egō ou dōsō* ). The scene models the kind of cooperative problem-solving that did not happen in the earlier scene.
- 23.733** *Achilles smiled* : This is Achilles' only smile in the poem.
- 23.741** *shining tin poured over* : The technology is unclear. It may be bronze plated with tin, or bronze surrounded by a circle of inlaid tin.
- 23.773** *your horses . . . Poseidon* : Poseidon is associated with horses.
- 23.777** *Intelligent Antilochus replied* : The epithet *pepnumenos* , "intelligent" or "thoughtful," often used in *The Odyssey* for Telemachus, is apt here because Antilochus needs all his wits to mollify Menelaus, while also managing to avoid making a false oath.
- 23.788** *be a sinner in the eyes of gods* : Antilochus insists that he won the horse legitimately, but without actually swearing that he did not cheat. The word *aliteros* , "sinner"/"sinful," occurs in *The Iliad* only here; it suggests specifically religious transgression.
- 23.804** *enduring so much toil and pain for me* : Antilochus helped Menelaus at 5.741 and 15.755, and he took Achilles the news of Patroclus' death (17.837). The brother is Thrasymedes. Despite Menelaus' insistence that he yields only because Antilochus is a special case, he is repeatedly presented as a soft touch, and generally open to persuasion—as in the scene in Book 6 (6.68) where Menelaus wants to spare Adrastus but is persuaded by Agamemnon not to show mercy.
- 23.845** *sheer numbers* : This seems to mean that the brothers, with two of them riding the same chariot, had an advantage over Nestor, who rode alone. Realistically, the

opposite would be true, since a chariot with a lighter weight would go faster. The point is that Nestor was an underdog, competing alone and outnumbered. The confusion may be caused by a crucial difference between chariot races and the use of chariots in warfare: on the battlefield, a single charioteer is indeed at a disadvantage, because there needs to be one warrior to hold the horses steady while the other attacks the enemy.

**23.878** *stick it out* : Ancient Greek boxing did not have a fixed number of knockouts or rounds. Instead, the winner was the man who could keep fighting for the longest, until his opponent acknowledged defeat or was recognized by the crowd as incapable of further fighting.

**23.903** *when Oedipus had fallen* : Oedipus, king of Thebes, fulfilled a prophecy that he would kill his father, Laius, and marry his mother, Jocasta, which he did inadvertently. It is likely that the narrator assumes a different version of the Oedipus myth than the one found in Sophocles' two Oedipus tragedies, or the lost version by Euripides, in all of which the hero blinds himself (or in Euripides, is blinded by others): a blind Oedipus would be unlikely to be participating on the battlefield. There were clearly many quite different versions of this set of stories.

**23.910** *oxhide leather thongs* : In the archaic period, fighters wore leather thongs wrapped around their hands to protect them from the punches (as we know from visual sources). Later, in the classical period, hard gloves, more like modern boxing gloves, began to be worn.

**23.944** *strong arms— / like rafters* : This is the only instance in Homer of rafters on a roof. The wrestlers are locked like rafters because their arms intertwine, like the crossed beams of the gabled roof.

**23.958** *lift me* : There was apparently a convention that wrestlers could take turns giving their opponents a chance to lift them up. Ajax seems to resort to the lifting because he realizes that the audience is getting bored.

**23.976** *Take equal prizes* : It is not explained how the unequal prizes can be distributed equally. This sequence echoes (and, in terms of the chronology of myth, foreshadows) the much more famous conflict between Ajax and Odysseus, when, after the death of Achilles, they quarreled over which of them should inherit the dead hero's divine armor. Achilles' peaceful solution suggests a community in which both types of excellence—the brawn of Ajax and the intelligence of Odysseus—can be equally valued. As with the other contests, the games point to alternatives to the quarrel of Book 1, in which two warriors who excel in quite different ways, Agamemnon and Achilles, can find no peaceful resolution to their differences.

**23.982** *silver mixing bowl* : This mixing bowl is a *krētēr*, designed to be used for mixing wine with water before serving. It is therefore an artifact that would form the centerpiece for a drinking party, like an ornate punch bowl.

- 23.989** *Euneus . . . gave the bowl* : At 21.52 we had a different account of this trade, and at 21.106 Lycaon says he was bought for one hundred oxen, without mentioning the bowl. Euneus is the son of Jason and Hypsipyle; Hypsipyle is the daughter of Thoas, king of Lemnos, who first acquired the bowl from the Phoenician traders. The elaborate backstory given to this particular prize creates a clear connection between Patroclus and the athletic competitions in his honor, and reminds us of the many victims slaughtered by Achilles to avenge him. Achilles devotes extra care to the prize for the footrace, his own special talent.
- 23.996** *a talent's weight in gold* : A talent was the heaviest weight, whose exact measurement varied from place to place.
- 23.1008** *a woman pulls a weaving rod* : The woman stands at a vertical loom, pulling the horizontal rod towards her to separate the threads of the warp so that she can pass the spool through.
- 23.1031** *This is outrageous* : This comic sequence provides both light relief and a fresh perspective on an important theme of the poem: the presence of divine aid for some characters, but not others. Odysseus, like Achilles himself, has a goddess to help bring him honor; the suggestion that Athena is like Odysseus' mother underlines the connection with Thetis, although Athena has no literal children.
- 23.1042** *on the edge of elderly* : The exact age of Odysseus is unclear. *Omogeronta* , the word rendered "on the edge of elderly," appears only here, and suggests "unripe-old"—i.e., a man whose senility is not yet advanced.
- 23.1050** *He took it gladly* : Antilochus twice receives extra or more valuable prizes thanks to his rhetorical ability. There is no competition in rhetoric or debate included in the games, but the inclusion of these extra prizes for a slick talker is a way of acknowledging that speech is one of the many skills at which a person can excel (or show "excellence," *aretē* ), as in the famous summary of the educational skills provided to Achilles by Phoenix, who trained him "to be / an artful speaker and a man of action" (9.567).
- 23.1062** *into his insides* : This suggests that Achilles imagines a duel to the death, or at least disemboweling—which moves the duel beyond the usual norms of athletic games, to something more like real warfare. It is also peculiar that Achilles invites both duelists to a feast after the games—even though one will be eviscerated.
- 23.1064** *stripped from Asteropeus / . . . share between them* : Achilles kills Asteropeus in Book 21, and we were told there that he stripped his armor and weapons (21.241). It is unclear how one set of armor is to be divided among two, but Hector makes the same proposal about splitting a set of armor, with the armor of Patroclus (17.300).
- 23.1086** *massive weight of metal* : This object and the terms used to refer to it are unparalleled and have been debated. Some have thought it is a meteorite or, more



likely, a huge lump of iron, a commodity that was relatively rare in early Iron Age Greece. The weight is used for the throwing contest and also serves as the prize.

**23.1097** *travel to the city* : The “town” or “city,” *polis* (a word that later refers to the primary organizing structure for Greek communities, including the central town and the country around it), here suggests a central trading community, to which the rural population travel only if they need to stock up on a rare commodity such as iron.

**23.1103** *The Greeks all laughed* : Probably Epeus’ cast is laughably weak.

**23.1110** *hurls his staff* : The herdsman has a throwing-stick with a string or rope attached and a weight at the other end, which he uses to catch cattle or to separate the herd; the technology is similar to the *bolos*, two weights with a rope between them for catching animals, used by Indigenous and gaucho horse riders in Central and South America.

**23.1117** *purple iron* : The word rendered “purple,” *ioeis*, is not used elsewhere in Homer. It is probably related to *ion*, “violet,” and hence used for a dark purple or blue color. Alternatively, the word could be related to *ios*, “arrow,” in which case it would presumably mean “iron suitable for making arrows”—which would be appropriate for the archery contest, but a weird description for a material that has in fact been used to make axes, not arrows.

**23.1123** *misses her but strikes the cord* : As ancient commentators noted, it is implausible that Achilles should predict that anyone will make this unusual and difficult shot, given that the cord is presumably a smaller target than the dove herself.

**23.1166** *best at power and at throwing* : The zeugma of “at power and at throwing” connects Agamemnon’s supposed skill at throwing with his more characteristic claim to power. Here, Achilles may be finally acknowledging Agamemnon’s superior power; he may be saving face for Agamemnon (since there is no guarantee that he would actually win a javelin contest); or he might be implicitly humiliating him (because here, just as in Book 1, he gains a prize without working for it at all—and in any case, the prizes for this contest are much less valuable than for the earlier sports). The first prize is the cauldron.

## BOOK 24 SUMMARY

After the games, Achilles is still overwhelmed by grief for Patroclus. He continues to abuse Hector’s body, although the gods undo the damage he does. The gods debate whether to have Hermes steal Hector from Achilles, but Hera, still fuming about the Judgment of Paris, blocks the plan, because she wants to see the Trojans humiliated. Twelve days later, the gods agree that Achilles must give Hector back to the Trojans. Thetis goes to tell her son he must release the body. Iris tells Priam to travel through the

enemy camp at night to retrieve his dead son. He does so, with just one elderly companion. Hermes meets them on the way and guides them through the camp. Priam kisses Achilles' hands and begs for the return of his dead son. They weep together, Priam for his son, and Achilles for Patroclus and for his father, Peleus, whom he will not see again. Achilles tells the story of Niobe, and of the two jars of Zeus. Achilles agrees to give the body back, and they eat together. Priam asks for eleven days of truce, so that the Trojans can gather wood to cremate and lament for Hector. Achilles agrees. Priam sleeps outside Achilles' tent and is woken in the night by Hermes, who advises him to escape before dawn with the body, which he does. When Priam returns to Troy with the dead Hector, he is seen first by his daughter Cassandra. The Trojans prepare a funeral for Hector and three female family members mourn for him in turn: his wife, Andromache; his mother, Hecuba; and Helen, his sister-in-law. The poem concludes with the end of Hector's funeral rites.

**24.15** *every time / Dawn shone along the beach* : The appearance of multiple Dawns makes clear that this is a description not of a single day, but the twelve successive days following the funeral.

**24.30** *They pitied him* : "Him" is Hector: even in death, Hector is treated as a person, rather than as the corpse of a person.

**24.36** *deluded recklessness* : In the original, this is *atē*, the same term for reckless delusion that Agamemnon used of his own failure to honor Achilles. The term underlines the analogy between the main plot of *The Iliad*, the quarrel of Achilles and Agamemnon, with the backstory, a divine quarrel between goddesses and another woman taken from another man.

**24.37** *Paris Alexander, who insulted* : This passage is the only moment in the poem where we are given direct allusion to the Judgment of Paris, a story known to the audience and never narrated within the epic. The story goes that the goddess Eris (Conflict, or Strife) was not invited to the marriage of Peleus and Thetis. In her anger at being excluded, she crashed the party, having stolen a special golden apple from the Garden of the Hesperides, which was, in some versions, inscribed with "to the best [goddess]" or "to the most beautiful." As Eris intended, the apple caused a bitter argument among Hera, Athena, and Aphrodite, all of whom claimed the prize. Hermes led the three of them to Mount Ida, to be judged by Paris, son of Priam, who was taking care of his flocks or herds on the mountain. All three contestants tried to bribe the judge: Hera, by offering royal power; Athena, strategic intelligence; and Aphrodite, the most beautiful woman in the world, Helen. It is odd that the Judgment is referred to only here, at such a late point in the narrative. It is also strange that Paris seems to be offered not Helen herself but sexual desire. The word for "lustfulness" used here, *machlosunē*, is an unusual word used almost exclusively

for the desire of women for men, not the other way around—although this might fit with the ways Paris is presented as effeminate. A final peculiarity is that Poseidon is listed along with Hera and Athena, even though he was not present at the Judgment and had quite different reasons for hating Troy (namely, the failure of Laomedon to pay Poseidon and Apollo for their labor in building the city walls).

**24.55** *strong proud heart* : The language applied to this lion is normally used for male elite warriors; the animal, like Hector and Achilles, has a “manly” (or “too manly”/“macho”) spirit, a kind of arrogance or egotism that is coded as masculine in the world of the poem (*agēnor thymos* ). The lion’s desire for meat is also presented in human, elite warrior terms: he wants a “banquet” (*dais* ).

**24.56** *mortal flocks* : Apollo, who is not mortal, has flocks of his own. There is a suggestion that this humanlike lion might try to eat human beings—just as Achilles has expressed the wish to eat Hector raw (22.466).

**24.71** *poor, mute earth* : This is the only moment in Homer where “earth,” *gaia*, is used to describe a corpse, perhaps suggesting that Achilles is violating not only a single human being but the earth itself. Generally, the dead body is equated with the person, such that Hector’s corpse is described as “Hector.”

**24.79** *whom I myself cared for* : The tradition that Thetis was raised by Hera may have been invented for the purposes of this passage, because it gives Hera a motive for goodwill towards Thetis. In Book 1, Hera was far more hostile towards Thetis and made no mention of her quasi-maternal relationship with her.

**24.87** *These men will not be given* : Zeus’ plans are, as ever, misty, though he implies that Achilles will receive special rewards not afforded to Hector. Perhaps these rewards include not only the lavish ransom offered by Priam for the release of Hector, but also Achilles’ own funeral, at which he will be lamented by the Nereids and Muses (as told in *Odyssey* 24.36–38).

**24.103** *Samothrace / and rocky Imbros* : Samothrace (in modern Greece) and Imbros (in modern Türkiye) are islands to the northwest of Troy.

**24.107** *brings their doom* : The language presents the fish killings in heroic terms: the piscine victims suffer “doom,” *kēr*; a word usually applied to the death of warriors on the battlefield.

**24.142** *fixed this glory* : The glory consists in the gifts, but also in the opportunity offered to Achilles to be generous to a suppliant. The shameful treatment of Hector has created shame for Achilles himself, who transgresses the norms of human society in mistreatment of a corpse; after his excess of rage, he has the chance to behave with extraordinary restraint. The verb *protiaptō* (“I fix”) presents the opportunity not as a gift, which could be rejected, but as something that now is fastened to Achilles, regardless of his wishes.



**24.165** *even with a woman* : One ancient critic, Aristarchus, suggested that this sentence was improper for a mother to say to her son—presumably because he interpreted it as suggesting that Thetis thinks Achilles misses Patroclus as a sexual partner. Many modern scholars have argued that the word *per* —“even” or “indeed”—applies to the whole phrase, not to the word “woman” in particular. On this reading, Thetis is emphasizing her more general point: that the activities associated with life—e.g., eating and having sex—are preferable to eternal grief for the dead. But linguistically, it is more likely that *per* goes specifically with the word it follows (“woman”), rather than the whole clause. It seems therefore more plausible that Thetis is suggesting that intercourse with a woman is not Achilles’ preference. The verb translated as “to join,” *mignusthai* , is used both for sexual intercourse and for death: dying warriors are joined with the dust. Implicitly, Thetis is suggesting a pair of contrasts: rather than eating his heart, Achilles should eat bread; rather than mingling with dust, he should mingle with a living woman. The point is not necessarily that Achilles prefers men in general, but that he longs for one specific man, who is now ashes. The lines hint at the tragic compromise Achilles has to make: he must live a mortal life, eat bread, not ambrosia, and his sexual partners will also be mortal, and they may not be his first choice. Thetis used the same verb (“join,” *mignusthai* ) at line 91 (Greek)/ line 117 (translation), expressing her own reluctance to mingle with the immortals in her state of grief, touched by the taint of mortality. The narrator suggested at the start of Book 24 that Achilles is devastated by the larger loss of a whole life together with Patroclus (“their numerous shared adventures and achievements”).

**24.207** *like a statue* : “Like a statue” renders the doubtful word *entupas* , which occurs in Homer only here; it may suggest “in the manner of an impression beaten out” (from *tuptō* , “to beat”) or “like a molding/impression” (from the verb *entupoō* , “to mold”). I take it that the metaphor is of an image created by beating metal, such as bronze, to create a low relief picture—like the famous “mask of Agamemnon” on gold—or an impression or molding fashioned in wax or clay. Priam’s face and body are covered by the cloak so that the visitor can see only the lines of them. If this is the correct interpretation of this word, it creates an effectively jarring juxtaposition of Priam as a precious object covered with dung.

**24.269** *eat it*: Hecuba’s longing to eat her enemy echoes the flesh-devouring rage ascribed by Zeus to Hera (4.46). Hecuba is the only mortal female character in the poem who expresses rage as well as grief.

**24.274** *He never thought of flight* : Hecuba’s assertions are not, strictly speaking, true. They reveal her maternal pride in her son as the protector of Troy, and her deep adherence to the warrior code of honor. As ancient commentators remark, they also

create a sharp contrast between Hector's admirable control over his own body and the dishonorable treatment afforded it by Achilles.

**24.291** *twelve extraordinary cloths* : In Homer, special things often come in twelves; for instance, in Book 21 Achilles killed twelve Trojan boys as sacrifice by Patroclus' funeral pyre.

**24.338** *fine new trundling wagon* : The wagon has a detachable hamper, in which the cargo is transported, and a shaft to which a yoke for the mules is bound with a long cord. The yoke has a central boss, with loops or rings at each end for the reins to go through, and it is fitted onto the frame by a ring set onto a peg on the pole. The elaborate description of the wagon provides emotional relief from the intensity of Priam's expressions of grief and rage; it also serves, like arming scenes before a warrior or goddess enters battle, to emphasize the importance of the action to follow. Many of the words in this passage are found only here in the Homeric poems, though there are parallels with the scene in Book 6 of *The Odyssey* in which Nausicaa's parents pack a wagon with dirty clothes and a nourishing packed lunch, so that she can travel to do laundry—a journey that, like this one, results in a momentous encounter between a Greek and a non-Greek character.

**24.350** *sturdy-hoofed hardworking mules* : Mules are not generally as glamorous as horses, but the history of these animals dignifies them; they are no ordinary pack animals. The general area inhabited by the Mysians seems to have been associated with special donkeys or wild asses; the wild asses of the Mysians' neighbors, the Eneti, are mentioned in the Catalog of Ships (2.1011).

**24.353** *the horses he had reared* : The horses are to pull Priam's war-chariot, in which he rides while the attendant drives the wagon laden with gifts for Achilles. This impractical arrangement is chosen because it would be undignified for a king to ride in a wagon.

**24.369** *his favorite bird* : The eagle, imagined as the king of birds, is associated with Zeus.

**24.398** *the dappled bird* : The specific type of eagle mentioned here is unclear, but it might be the golden eagle, which is dark in color and has a large wingspan. It is described as *teleiotatos*, suggesting both most perfect and most efficient as an omen, capable of achieving the results signified. Priam's eagerness to receive a bird sign before making his dangerous journey to retrieve Hector acquires extra poignancy from Hector's famous dismissal of bird signs (12.293).

**24.420** *you are the god who most enjoys / befriending* : Hermes, a messenger god and go-between who provides special assistance to travelers, is distinguished from the messenger goddess Iris. She swoops down to bring specific news to humans and then quickly returns to Olympus, whereas he enjoys spending time as a companion to mortals.

- 24.464** *even now* : “Even now,” i.e., despite his grief and the imminent loss of his city, Priam feels blessed by the gods. The tendency to trust divine protection is more common among the Trojans than the Greeks; sometimes, as in the last moments of Hector, this trust is misplaced, and other times, as here, it is entirely justified. Priam’s words have dramatic irony: we know, as Priam does not, that Hermes’ parents are indeed “blessed,” *makaros* , a word often used of the immortal gods.
- 24.473** *treasure / to foreigners* : A myth explored in Euripides’ *Hecuba* told that Priam sent his gold in the keeping of his young son, Polydorus, to be kept safe during the war by Polymestor of Thrace; in Euripides’ version, the plan goes horribly wrong, because the Thracian king kills the boy and keeps the gold for himself (and Hecuba take violent revenge on him). Some version of this story was probably known at the time of *The Iliad* ’s composition.
- 24.496** *I was assigned to come here* : The line suggests that there was a kind of military draft, with one son from each elite family sent to Troy, selected by lot. Elsewhere, the poem is often more vague about whether compulsion or desire for gain and glory has motivated the various disparate chieftains of the Greek coalition to come to the war—although it is clear that the regular, nonelite fighters (the *laos* or “troops”) have been forced to come. See note at 23.400.
- 24.527** *if ever he existed* : The speaker’s grief makes him doubt whether his lost loved one really ever lived.
- 24.554** *Achilles’ hut* : Achilles’ hut or tent (*klisiē* ) is described in terms appropriate for a rich man’s homestead. Ancient critics found it ridiculous that a temporary encampment on the beach should be so magnificent. The hut’s splendor enhances Achilles’ glory, and the positioning of the description here, before Priam’s visit, makes clear that this is the most important and climactic moment of visiting and hospitality (*xenia* ) in the poem.
- 24.592** *delusion seizes hold* : *Atē* , “delusion” is the same quality of deluded, reckless folly that Agamemnon associates with his aggression towards Achilles, and that Phoenix suggests can be redeemed only by the Prayers. It seems natural at first to assume that the delusion caused the murder; but as the simile continues, it seems as if the killer’s attempt to take refuge might also be caused by delusion. The simile anticipates the partial intimacy between Priam and Achilles in the following scene: within the simile, the desperate visitor is a tainted killer, like Achilles, and the host is, like Priam, a rich foreigner.
- 24.615** *household women* : These are multiple subordinate women who have borne most of Priam’s children, while Hecuba is his primary wife. Hecuba’s sons seem to be treated as more important than those of the other women, and she, unlike these other women, has a voice in the poem (although two others are named: Laothoe and Castianeira. Priam and Peleus represent two distinct experiences of terrible

paternal grief, each devastating but in different ways: Priam's grief is multiplied—he has fifty sons, all of whom will die—while Peleus' is concentrated in a single short-lived son. But Priam's rhetoric presents Hector as if he were his last remaining son; the pathos would be reduced if he were to mention the large number of sons still remaining.

**24.653** *Two jars are set upon the floor* : Zeus serves the humans from these jars (jar = *pithos* ) as if he were serving wine, a drink usually mixed with water in Greek culture. The parable implies a distinction between privileged men like Priam and Peleus, as well as Achilles himself—men who have enjoyed enormous blessings before experiencing grief—and another class of men who are homeless, impoverished, and starving for their whole lives. The parable does not include women, in whose lives Achilles takes no interest. This story partly parallels the contemporary tale of Pandora's jar (also *pithos* in Hesiod, *Works and Days* 60–105), which is also a story about scarcity and precarity. Achilles' parable serves to contextualize Priam's grief for Hector, which Priam had treated as exceptional, within a larger cosmic context to show that it is less exceptional after all. Achilles' ability to invoke grand general frameworks serves, as it did in the embassy of Book 9, to create distance and undermine the perspective of his interlocutor. But whereas in Book 21, Achilles used the universality of death, including his own, as a motivation for violence and the violation of social norms, when he slaughters the suppliant Lycaon, here he suggests that recognition of the universality of suffering in human life might enable a brief, fragile moment of connection between enemies, and creates a necessary sense of distance from the personal and painful fact that Achilles killed Priam's son. The conversation risks devolving into violence on both sides, as soon as Priam, reasonably enough, moves from Achilles' abstractions to the specific purpose of his visit.

**24.669** *short-lived child* : The word rendered “short-lived,” *panaōrion* , appears only here in the Homeric poems, and its meaning is disputed. It probably means “short-lived” but it may also imply that Achilles is untimely in all things: he runs too fast and dies too soon.

**24.672** *My sole concern* : Achilles' language suggests a bitter contrast between the filial care he cannot provide for his old father (*komizō* ), and the “concern” (*kēdōn* ) that he is able to take over the destruction of Troy and its inhabitants. There is a further wordplay in the verb *kēdōn* , which suggests both “to be concerned” and “to do damage.”

**24.673** *And we hear* : “We hear” is disingenuous; Achilles and the other Greek invaders witnessed the wealth of the Troad for themselves, when they arrived to seize it for their own enrichment. But the phrase also increases the pathos; Priam's time of

happiness ended almost ten years ago, with the arrival of Achilles himself, and has become so distant that it seems like a story.

**24.675** *From Lesbos / . . . Hellespont* : These lines define the territory from Lesbos in the south, Phrygia in the east, and the Hellespont as the western and northern boundary. Lesbos, as we learn in Book 9 (9.158) was sacked and pillaged by Achilles himself, and the women enslaved; Macar is the legendary founder of Lesbos.

**24.698** *my mother* : Despite his earlier insistence that Priam's suffering is not exceptional, Achilles continues to remind his guest of his own exceptionality, as the son of a goddess who has a particularly intimate connection with the gods, while undermining Priam's achievement in reaching his tent, by presenting it as the work of the gods.

**24.753** *noble Niobe* : Leto was the divine mother of the twins Apollo and Artemis; the birthing of the twins was famously protracted because Hera forbade her from giving birth on land. Niobe, a mortal queen of Thebes, boasted that she had more children than the goddess, and was punished with the death of all her children. She remained paralyzed by grief, and eventually turned to a rock, on Mount Sipylus, known as the Weeping Rock for its constant moisture. In this version, the whole population of Thebes is turned to stone. The Niobe story does not usually include any focus on food, and the detail that the children remain unburied for nine days is added to create a parallel with the delayed funeral of Hector. The citation of Niobe may seem to sit uneasily with Achilles' emphasis on the necessity of moving on from sorrow; it is a narrative about the impossibility of recovering from trauma and grief. But the story reminds us that the meal, and the setting aside of grief, are only very brief, temporary respites: Priam will soon, like Niobe, lose all his children; Achilles, who will not cease to mourn Patroclus, will soon die and cause more grief for his own father.

**24.768** *then Niobe / . . . the gods* : These lines, from "then Niobe" to "the gods," were treated as suspect by some ancient and modern commentators, because they are somewhat unusual linguistically (more akin to the style of Hesiod than Homer), and because it seems bizarre that Niobe could be both petrified and eating food. But the lines have a magical beauty, in keeping with the poem as a whole, in their presentation of unending grief as both natural and divine, and of trauma as both limited and unlimited, both personal and universal.

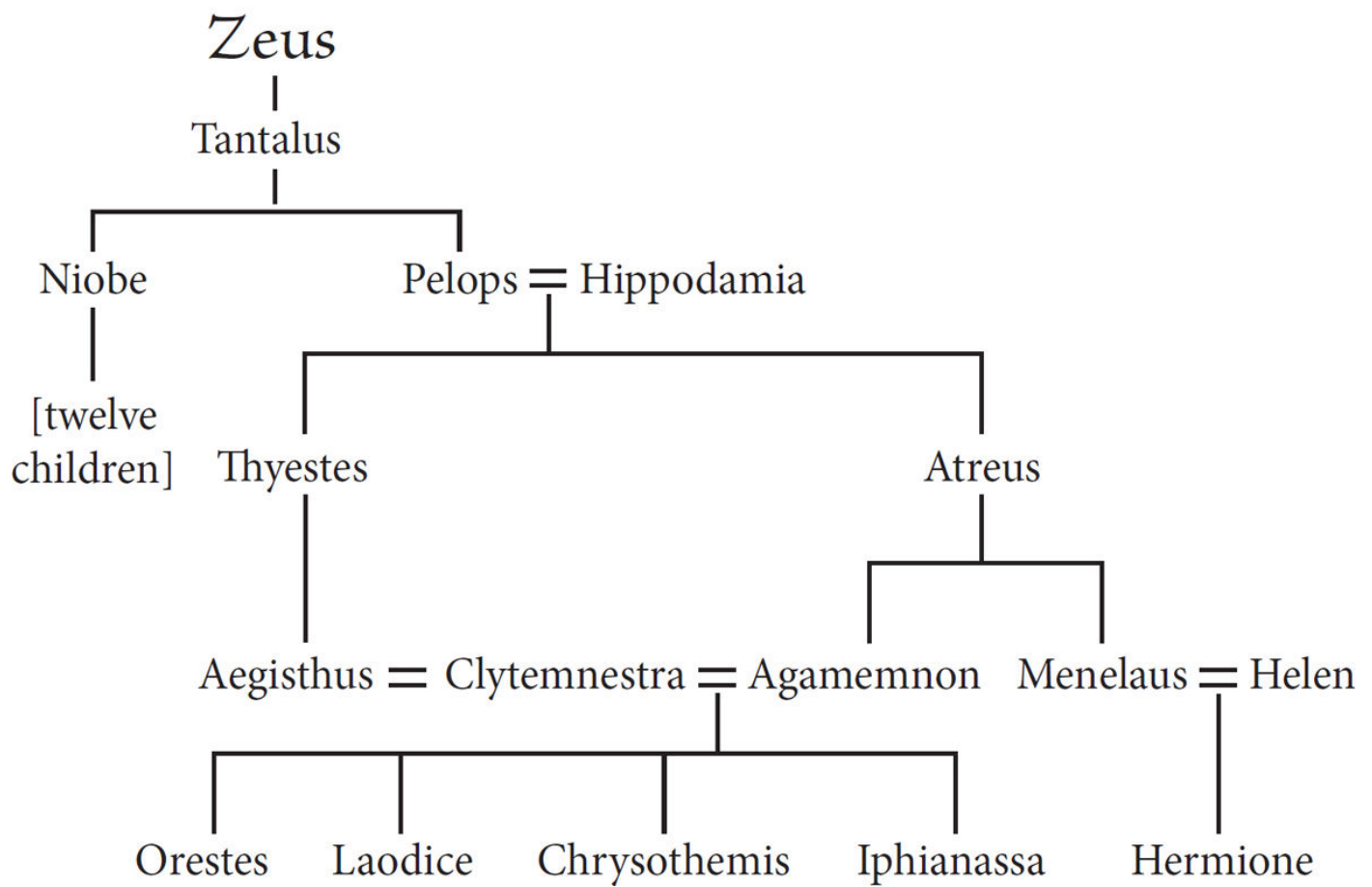
**24.775** *consumes the sorrows* : The verb rendered "consumes," *pessei*, is used for the processing of emotions, such as anger as well as grief (as at 1.244), the same verb is used by Priam, at 24.799; for his own grief. Niobe has briefly eaten literal food, but her primary sustenance, in her eternity as a rock, is sorrow.

- 24.810** *Achilles spoke to him ironically* : Achilles is speaking “ironically” or “mockingly” (*kertomeōn* ), but the mockery or irony is directed at his fellow Greeks, rather than at Priam. We have never heard of any Greek council member casually popping in to visit Achilles. The speech is also ironic in that Achilles is pretending his guest should sleep outside for his own safety, rather than to ensure he leaves promptly (which would be rude to mention).
- 24.819** *The ransom . . . would be delayed* : A euphemistic understatement marking Achilles’ newfound self-control: he does not rile himself up by thinking too precisely about Agamemnon’s ability to impede his choices.
- 24.852** *hallowed guards* : The guards are described as “hallowed” or “holy,” *hierous* , perhaps because keeping the camp safe is a sacred duty.
- 24.875** *up to the Pergamum* : The building on the acropolis, or highest point, of Troy; from this vantage point, Cassandra sees her father out on the plain. Cassandra, one of Priam’s daughters, is known in myth for her powers of prophecy, including her ability to foresee the fall of Troy; here, she uses ordinary sight to see Hector, whose funeral signifies the end of the city; his pyre is the first of many fires that will destroy Trojan bodies. This is in keeping with the tendency of *The Iliad* to transform magical elements of myth into something more realistic.
- 24.877** *She also saw / him on the mule cart*: Hector is resonantly not named.
- 24.902** *songs of lamentation* : In some ways female choral lament—a tradition that was already ancient by the time of *The Iliad* —was a rival tradition to the “famous deeds of men” (*klea andrōn* ) tradition, presenting war as a locus for grief and loss, not glory. The funeral for Hector evokes this established poetic tradition of a group of women singing together to mourn the dead. Hecuba, Andromache, and Helen provide three distinct perspectives on Hector himself and the effects of war more broadly. Andromache focuses on the suffering, enslavement, and death of women and children in war. Hecuba focuses on glory and the blessings of the gods. Helen focuses on the rare possibility of kindness and restraint, but also suggests that such things may lie dead with Hector.
- 24.948** *his gentle arrows* : The image of Hector killed by Apollo’s “gentle arrows,” as if by internal disease rather than human violence, echoes the beginning of the poem, where Apollo’s arrows were the first weapons shot.
- 24.956** *twenty years since I came here* : The chronology is surprising. Usually, the Trojan War is supposed to have taken ten years, from the arrival of the Greek fleet to the fall of the city.



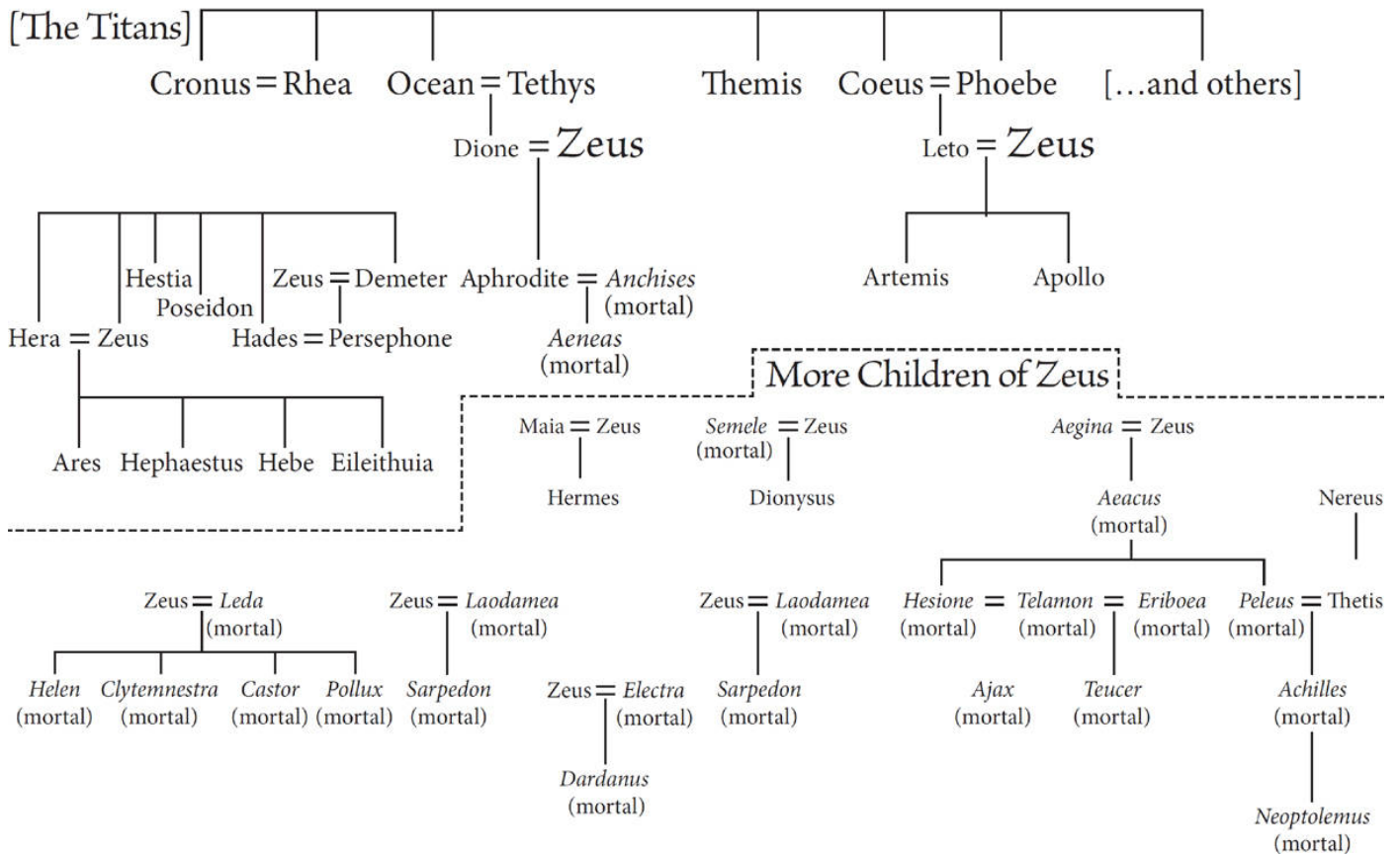
## GENEALOGIES

### The House of Atreus

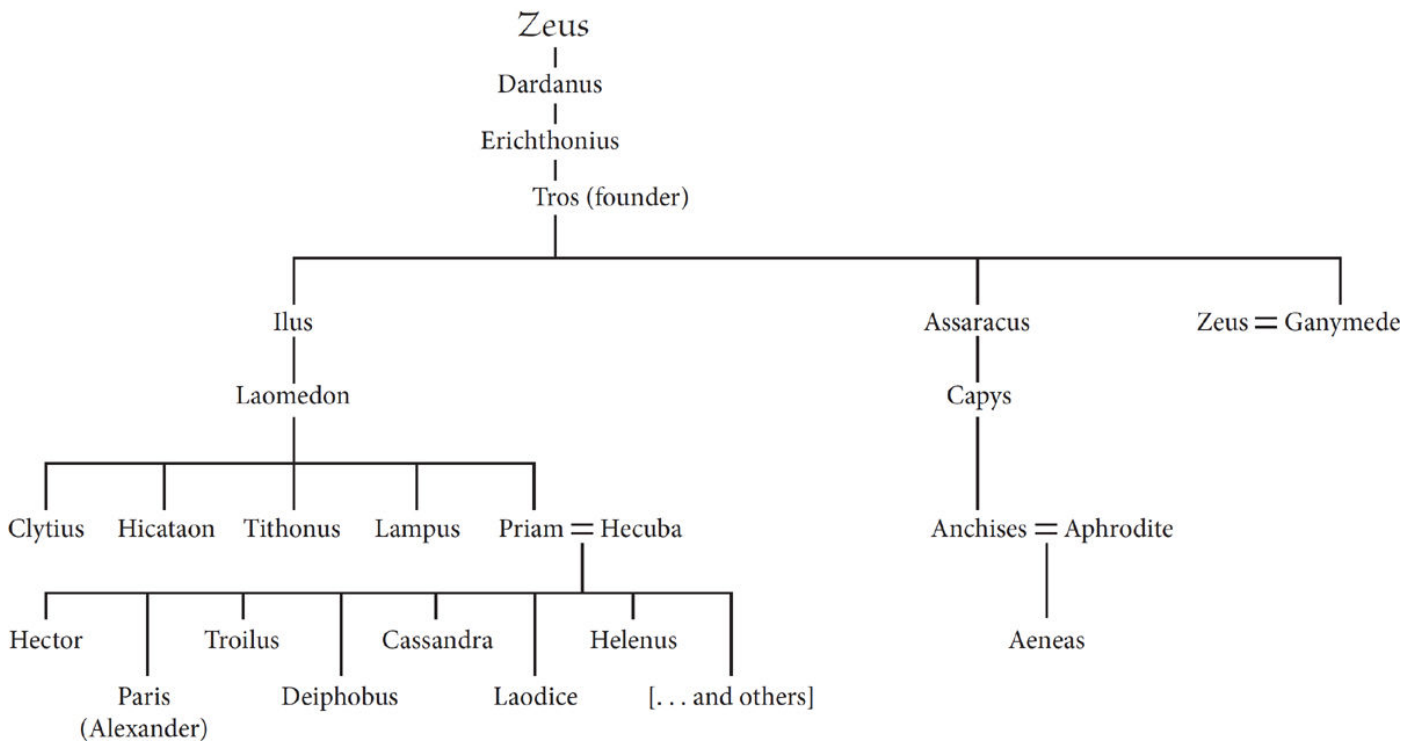


# The Gods

Sky (Uranus) = Earth (Gaia)



## The House of Troy





# GLOSSARY

## PRONUNCIATION KEY

*a* as in *cat*  
*ah* as in *father*  
*ai* as in *light*  
*ay* as in *day*  
*aw* as in *raw*  
*e* as in *pet*  
*ee* as in *street*  
*ehr* as in *air*  
*er* as in *bird*  
*g* as in *good*  
*i* as in *sit*  
*j* as in *joke*  
*o* as in *pot*  
*oh* as in *no*  
*oo* as in *boot*  
*or* as in *bore*  
*ow* as in *now*  
*oy* as in *toy*  
*s* as in *mess*  
*sh* as in *shut*  
*ts* as in *ants*  
*u* as in *us*  
*ur* as in *sir*  
*you* as in *you*  
*zh* as in *vision*

In general, “e” at the end of an ancient Greek name is pronounced “*ee*” (not silent, and never the French “é”/ay ), as in “Penelope” (*pen-el'-o-pee* ), and “es” at the end is

pronounced “*eez*,” as in “Achilles” (*a-kil'-eez*). “Ei,” “oi,” “au,” and “ou” are sometimes diphthongs (a single syllable), but often they are two separate syllables, especially at the end of a name—so, for instance, the abducted woman Briseis has a trisyllabic name (*bris-ay'-yis*), and Leitus, *lay-ee'-tus*, is also three syllables. “Ao” and “oo” are always two syllables—“ay-o” or “oh-o,” never a combined diphthong; for example, Priam’s father, Laomedon, has four syllables in his name, Lycaon has three, and Thoon has two. The combination of “ae” is usually a single syllable (pronounced *ee* or *ai*, as the speaker wishes), but combined with “r” it is two, as in the trisyllabic name Laertes (*lay-er'-teez*). Usually, speakers of English soften “c” or “g” when those letters are succeeded by “e,” “i,” “ae,” or “y,” so we pronounce the Scaean Gates as “*see'-yan*,” and Gerenian Nestor as “*je-ree'-nee-yan*,” but the Scamander River has a hard “c,” before “a,” so it is *ska-man'-der*. “Ch” in ancient Greek names is always a hard “k” (as in “kitten,” although it is also acceptable to use a slightly aspirated “k” sound, as in “Bach” or “loch”)—never the sound we use for “chips” or “chipmunk,” items that the ancient Greeks sadly lacked.

There are a few exceptions to the normal patterns, usually for names that have been in common circulation in English for several centuries or place-names that are in modern usage. For instance, “Ganymede” is pronounced *gan'-ee-meed*, not *gan'-ee-meed'-ee*, and “Samothrace” is *sam'-oh-thrays*.

Ancient Greek had both long and short sounds for “a,” “e,” “i,” “o,” and “u,” with two distinct letters for “e” (epsilon and eta) and “o” (omicron and omega). Conventional Anglicized pronunciations often reflect these distinctions, although with some inconsistencies and variations: so, for example, Hera is *hee'-ra*, not *he'-ra*, because her name has a long “e” (eta), and Achilles’ mother, Thetis, is *thet'-is*, not *thee'-tis*, because her name has a short “e” (epsilon).

Usually, speakers of English put a stress on the antepenult when a name ends in two light syllables—as in Telemachus (*tel-e'-ma-kus*, not *tel'-e-mah'-kus*)—but on the penult when that syllable is heavy or long, as in Diomedes (*dai'-o-mee'-deez*, not *di-o'-med-eez*), Patroclus (*pat-rok'-lus*, not *pat'-ro-klus*), and Demeter (*dem-ee'-ter*, not *dem'-et-er*). Some speakers use different pronunciations for some of these. In the most prominent cases, I note the variants below, to ensure that the reader will understand the meter of the translation throughout. I have often hesitated about how to Anglicize less familiar Greek names. Any inconsistencies and idiosyncrasies are entirely my fault.

' marks a stressed syllable.

Each entry ends with a reference to the book and line number of the name’s first appearance in the poem.

**Abantes** (*ab-an'-teez*): A people from Euboea. 2.644.

**Abarbarea** (*a-bar'-ba-ree'-ya*): A water goddess (naiad); mother of Aesopus and Pegasus. 6.29.

**Abas** (*a'-bas*): Trojan; son of the prophet Eurydamas, brother of Polyidus; killed by Diomedes. 5.197.

**Abii** (*ab'-i-ee*): A nomadic tribe whose territory lies to the northeast of Troy; unknown from other sources. 13.7.

**Ablerus** (*ab'-ler-us*): Trojan; killed by Antilochus. 6.44.

**Abydos** (*ab'-ee-dos*): A city on the southern shore of the Hellespont. 2.991.

**Acacesion** (*ac'-a-see'-zhon*): Mountain in Arcadia associated with the god Hermes. 16.238.

**Acamas** (*ak'-a-mas*): (1) Trojan ally; son of Eussorus; commander of Thracians; killed by Telamonian Ajax. 2.1001. (2) Trojan; son of Antenor; comrade of Aeneas; killed by Meriones. 2.976.

**Acessamenus** (*a'-ses-am'-en-us*): Thracian; father of Periboea. 21.191.

**Achaea** (*a-kee'-ya*): Region in the northwestern Peloponnese; also used collectively for alternative name for the Greek-speaking world. Its inhabitants are **Achaeans**. 2.812.

**Achelous** (*ak'-el-oh'-us*): Longest river in Greece, on the border with Aetolia. 21.256.

**Achilles** (*a-kil'-eez*): The son of a mortal man, Peleus of Phthia and a sea goddess, Thetis, Achilles was raised by the Centaur Chiron in the wilds of Mount Pelion, along with his dearest friend, his father's cousin, Patroclus. Also tutored by the human Phoenix. The leader of the Myrmidons, Achilles is known as "swift-footed" for his special skill at sprinting, which makes him the best Greek warrior at the style of fighting that requires speed (where a warrior throws a light spear to make a kill, runs to retrieve it, then runs back to throw and kill again). A prophecy foretold that the son of Thetis would be greater than his father, so the gods forced Thetis into marriage with the mortal, Peleus, so that she would not get impregnated by Zeus—which would have caused a rift in the Olympian world order. Another prophecy foretold that Achilles would die if he stayed to fight at Troy but would gain eternal fame. Achilles is quick-witted as well as quick-footed, proud, stubborn, touchy, and defensive in his desire for absolute respect, and impatient with social conventions and lies, even white lies. He plays the lyre and has a poet's expansive vision of the conflict in which he himself participates. He is killed by an arrow shot by Paris and guided by Apollo. The name Achilles is associated (by a false but ancient etymology) with "pain of the troops/people" (*achos* = pain; *laos* = common troops). 1.1.

**Actaea** (*ak'-tee-a*): A Nereid. The name suggests "promontary" or "headland." 18.49.

**Actor** (*ak'-tor*): “Driver” or “leader.” (1) Son of Azeus, father of Astyoche. 2.615. (2) Human father (or perhaps forebear) of Cteatus and Eurytus, who are also sons of Poseidon. 2.742. (3) Father of Menoetius, grandfather of Patroclus. 11.1022. (4) Father of Echeclus. 16.245.

**Adamas** (*ad'-am-as*): “Unconquered.” Trojan; son of Asius; killed by Meriones. 12.172.

**Admetus** (*ad-mee'-tus*): “Untamed.” Lord of Thessaly; son of Pheres, father of Eumelus. 2.849.

**Adrastea** (*ad'-rast-ee'-ya*): “Untameable.” A city northeast of Troy. 2.982.

**Adrastus** (*ad-ras'-tus*): (1) King of Sicyon; father of Aegialea. 2.681. (2) Trojan; son of Merops; killed by Diomedes. 2.985. (3) Trojan; killed by Menelaus and Agamemnon. 6.52. (4) Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.872.

**Aeacus** (*ee'-ak-us*): Grandfather of Achilles, father of Peleus. 2.1043.

**Aegae** (*ee'-jai*): A city in the northern Peloponnese sacred to Poseidon. 8.267.

**Aegeon** (*ee-jee'-yon*): Mortal name for Briareus, a giant. 1.533.

**Aegialea** (*ee-jee'-ya-lay'-a*): Wife of Diomedes. 5.553.

**Aegialus** (*ee-jee'-ya-lus*): (1) A town or an area under the rule of Agamemnon, in the Peloponnese. 2.685. (2) An area (or perhaps a town) in Paphlagonia. 2.1016.

**Aegilips** (*ee-ji'-lips*): An area (or perhaps a town) in Odysseus' territory; exact location unknown. 2.757.

**Aegina** (*ee-jai'-na*): Island in the kingdom of Argos, in the Saronic Gulf. Associated with the eponymous nature goddess, Aegina, mother of Menoetius by Actor and of Aceacus by Zeus. 2.670.

**Aegion** (*ee-jai'-yon*): A town in the kingdom of Agamemnon; exact location unknown. 2.684.

**aegis** (*ee'-jis*): A cloak (or sometimes a skin-covered shield), imagined as made of goatskin, that represents divine power. Usually carried or worn by “aegis-bearing” Zeus in his capacity as the most powerful of the Olympian gods, but also borrowed by his daughter Athena. 1.273.

**Aeneas** (*ee-nee'-yas*): Trojan; son of Aphrodite and Anchises; commander of the Dardanians. Second cousin to Hector and Paris. Destined to be the leader of the few Trojan men who survive the Trojan War. 2.971.

**Aenius** (*ee'-nee-yus*): Trojan ally; killed by Achilles. 21.275.

**Aenus** (*ee'-nus*): A city in Thrace. 4.698.

**Aeolus** (*ee-oh'-lus*): Father of Sisyphus. 6.206.

**Aepea** (*ee-pee'-ya*): A city on the Messenian gulf; one of the seven cities offered to Achilles by Agamemnon's embassy. 9.191.

**Aepy** (*ee'-pee*): “Steep.” City in realm of Nestor; exact location unknown. 2.706.

**Aepytus** (*ee'-pi-tus*): Hero with tomb in Arcadia, beneath Mount Cyllene. 2.722.

**Aesepus** (ee'-se-pus ): (1) A river near Zelea. 2.979. (2) Trojan; son of Boucalion; killed by Euryalus. 6.28.

**Aesyetes** (ee-see'-ye-teez ): (1) Hero with tomb on Trojan plain. 2.943. (2) Father of the Trojan Alcahous. 13.567.

**Aesyme** (ee'-si-mee ): A city in Thrace. 8.405.

**Aesymnus** (ee-sim'-nus ): Greek; killed by Hector. 11.390.

**Aethices** (ee'-thi-seez ): A tribe in Thessaly. 2.884.

**Aethra** (eeth'-ra ): Daughter of Pittheus; enslaved by Helen. 3.179.

**Aetolia** (ee-toh'-lee-ya ): A region in northwest Greece. 2.761.

**Agacles** (ag'-a-kleez ): Trojan; father of the Greek Epigeus. 16.720.

**Agamede** (ag'-a-meed'-ee ): Wife of Mulius, daughter of Augeas. 11.963.

**Agamemnon** (a'-ga-mem'-non ): Son of Atreus, who came from the cursed line of Tantalus (Atreus' grandfather). Themes running through the family lineage include ambition, conflict for power, and the killing, sometimes eating, of children (according to one myth, Agamemnon killed his own daughter, Iphigenia, to persuade the goddess Artemis to give wind to bring the troops to Troy—although this story is not told directly in *The Iliad* ). King of Mycenae. Husband of Helen's sister Clytemnestra (who, in another story not told in *The Iliad* , kills him on his return from Troy). Agamemnon, repeatedly described as “shepherd of the people” and “lord of men,” is the wealthiest of the Greek commanders, with the largest group of troops behind him. 1.8.

**Agapenor** (ag'-a-pee'-nor ): Greek; leader of the Arcadians. 2.728.

**Agasthenes** (a-gas'-then-eez ): “Very strong.” Son of Augeas, father of Polyxinus. 2.745.

**Agastrophus** (a-gast'-rof-us ): Trojan; son of Paeon; killed by Diomedes. 11.442.

**Agathon** (ag'-a-thon ): “Good.” Trojan; son of Priam. 24.316.

**Agave** (ag-ah'-vee ): A Nereid. The name suggests “noble.” 18.53.

**Agelaus** (a'-je-lay'-us ): (1) Trojan; son of Phradmon; killed by Diomedes. 8.342. (2) Greek; killed by Hector. 11.390.

**Agenor** (a-jee'-nor ): “Very manly.” Trojan; son of Antenor; father of Echeclus. 4.624.

**Aglaea** (ag-lee'-ya ): “Splendor.” Mother of the Greek Nereus. 2.798.

**Agrias** (ag-ree'-yas ): Lord of Calydon; son of Portheus. 14.151.

**Ajax, Oilean** (ay'-jaks ): Greek warrior, known as the lesser Ajax, or Locrian Ajax (from his homeland, Locris). Often appears with Telamonian Ajax, but is no relation. The quickest sprinter on the Greek side after Achilles himself, he also excels with a light throwing-spear. In the footrace in Book 23, he slips in the dung and falls over. 2.490.

**Ajax, Telamonian** (ay'-jaks ): Greek warrior. Also referred to as Ajax the great; not to be confused with Oilean Ajax, with whom he often appears. Son of Telamon, lord of

Salamis (the father's name means "belt-strap"), and Eriboea; first cousin to Achilles, because Telamon and Peleus were brothers. Huge, heavy, armed with an enormous shield, Ajax is the best Greek defensive fighter and the best at hand-to-hand combat. Dignified, brave, aristocratic. 1.187.

**Alalcomenae** (*al'-al-ko'-men-ee*): A location in Boeotia, associated with the goddess Athena, on the southern shore of Lake Copais. 4.10.

**Alastor** (*a-las'-tor*): "Avenger." (1) Greek leader, from Pylos; comrade of Nestor. 4.386. (2) Lycian warrior; killed by Odysseus. 5.890. (3) Greek fighter. He helps in the rescue of Teucer; wounded by Hector. 8.443. (4) Trojan; father of Tros; killed by Achilles. 20.602.

**Alcander** (*al-kan'-der*): Lycian fighter; killed by Odysseus. 5.891.

**Alcathous** (*al-ka'-thoh-us*): Trojan warrior; son of Aesyetes and husband of the eldest daughter of Anchises, Hippodamia. Killed by Idomeneus. 12.113.

**Alcestis** (*al-ses'-tis*): Daughter of Pelias and wife of Admetus. Saved her husband from death by dying in his stead (a story not mentioned in the Homeric poems). Mother of Eumeus, Greek leader from Pherae. 2.850.

**Alcimedon** (*al-si'-med-on*): One of the leaders of the Myrmidons; son of Laerces; driver of Achilles' war-chariot after the death of Patroclus. 16.255.

**Alcimus** (*al'-si-mus*): Myrmidon; comrade of Achilles. 19.511.

**Alcmaon** (*alk-mai'-on*): Greek fighter; son of Thestor. 12.486.

**Alcmene** (*alk-mee'-nee*): Theban woman; wife of Amphitryon; mother of Iphicles, Amphitryon's son, and of Heracles, Zeus' son, a semidivine child gifted with supernatural strength. 14.428.

**Alean Plain** (*al-ee'-yan*): "Wandering." A plain in Cilicia where Bellerophon wanders. 6.269.

**Alectryon** (*al-ek'-tree-yon*): Greek from Boeotia; father of Leitus; wounded by Hector. 17.772.

**Alesion** (*al-ee'-zhon*): A hill in the territory of the Epeans, probably in western Elis. 2.737.

**Algenor** (*al-jee'-nor*): Father of Promachus; Greek fighter from Boeotia. 14.668.

**Aloeus** (*al'-oh-ee'-yus*): A giant; father of Ephialtes and Otus, husband of Iphimedia. 5.517.

**Alope** (*al'-o-pee*): A place in the territory of Argos, under the leadership of Achilles; exact location unknown. 2.810.

**Alpheus** (*al'-fee-yus*): A river in Arcadia and Elis. 2.706.

**Altes** (*al'-teez*): Father of Laothoe, one of Priam's wives. 21.115.

**Althea** (*al'-thee-ya*): Mother of Meleager. 9.722.

**Alus** (*al'-us*): A place under the command of Achilles; exact location unknown. 2.809.

**Alybe** (*al'-i-bee*): The land of the Halizones, allies of the Trojans. 2.1018.

**Amarynceus** (*am'-a-rin'-see-yus*): Father of Diores, a Greek fighter and leader of the Epeans. 2.743.

**Amathea** (*a-math'-ee-ya*): A Nereid. The name suggests “ignorance” or “unknown.” 18.59.

**Amazons** (*am'-a-zons*): Warrior women who fight the Phrygians. 3.235.

**Amisodorus** (*am'-is-od'-or-us*): Father of Maris and Atymnius, fighters on the Trojan side killed by Thasymedes and Antilochus, sons of Nestor. According to later sources, he is also the father of the princess who married Bellerophon. 16.421.

**Amopaon** (*am'-o-pai'-yon*): Trojan fighter; son of Polyaeon; killed by Teucer. 8.370.

**Amphiaraus** (*am'-fi'-klus*): Trojan warrior. 16.402.

**Amphidamas** (*am-fi'-dam-us*): Greek warrior from Cythera. 10.328.

**Amphigenea** (*am'-fi-jen-ee'-ya*): A community in Messenia, under the command of Nestor, king of Pylos. 2.708.

**Amphimachus** (*am-fi'-ma-kus*): (1) Greek fighter; son of Cteatus. One of the leaders of the Epeans, a people in Elis. 2.740. (2) Son of Nomion, leader of the Carians; killed by Achilles. 2.1039.

**Amphinome** (*am-fi'-no-mee*): A Nereid. The name suggests “surrounding pasture.” 18.53.

**Amphion** (*am'-fee-yon*): Greek warrior and a commander of the Epeans. 13.914.

**Amphithoe** (*am-fi'-thoh-ee*): A Nereid. The name suggests “surrounding swiftness.” 18.54.

**Amphitryon** (*am-fit'-ree-yon*): Husband of Alcmene, and adoptive mortal father of Heracles, whose biological father is Zeus. 5.527.

**Amphius** (*am'-fee-yus*): (1) Trojan leader; son of the seer Merops and brother of Adrastus. 2.984. (2) Trojan fighter; son of Pelagus. 5.807.

**Amphoterus** (*am-fot'-er-us*): Trojan fighter; killed by Patroclus. 16.532.

**Amyclae** (*am-i'-klai*): A city in the realm of Menelaus in Lacedamon, in the Eurotas valley, south of Sparta. 2.696.

**Amydon** (*am'-i-don*): A city of the Paeonians, in Macedonia. 2.1007.

**Amyntor** (*a'-min-tor*): Son of Ormenus and father of Phoenix. 9.575.

**Anatolia** (*an'-a-toh'-lee-ya*): Ancient (but not Homeric) name for the “land of the rising sun”: the region, also known as Asia Minor, is roughly coterminous with modern Asiatic Türkiye, bounded by the Euphrates River to the southeast and the Black Sea to the north.

**Ancaeus** (*an-see'-yus*): (1) Father of Agapenor, a Greek leader from Arcadia. 2.728. (2) Wrestler from Pleuron, beaten by young Nestor. 23.839.

**Anchialus** (*ank-ai'-al-us*): Greek fighter and chariot rider; killed by Hector. 5.803.

**Anchises** (*ank-ai'-seez*): Father of Aeneas. 2.972.

**Andraemon** (*and'-rai-mon*): Father of Thoas; leader of the Aetolians. 2.762.

**Andromache** (*and-ro'-ma-kee*): “Man battle.” Princess from Thebe in Anatolia (not Thebes), a city inhabited by the Cilicians. Daughter of King Eetion; wife of Hector and mother of Astyanax. Her father and seven brothers were killed by Achilles with the other male inhabitants of Thebe when the Greeks sacked the city. 6.499.

**Anemorea** (*an-em'-or-ee'-ya*): A place apparently in Phocis; exact location unknown. 2.624.

**Antea** (*an'-tee-ya*): Wife of Proetus, king in Argolis. She tried to seduce Bellerophon, without success. From Lycia. 6.214.

**Antenor** (*an-tee'-nor*): Father of Archelochus and Acamas; Dardan. 2.975.

**Anthea** (*an'-thee-a*): A town in Messenia. 9.189.

**Anthedon** (*an-thee'-don*): A settlement in Boeotia. 2.604.

**Anthemion** (*an-them'-yon*): Father of Simoesius; Trojan; killed by Ajax. 4.632.

**Antilochus** (*ant-i'-lok-us*): Youngest of the many sons of Nestor of Pylos; skilled in chariot driving and running. 4.609.

**Antimachus** (*ant-im'-ak-us*): Trojan; father of Pisander and Hippolochus. 11.163.

**Antiphates** (*ant-i'-fat-teez*): Trojan fighter; killed by Polypeites. 12.231.

**Antiphonus** (*ant-i'-fon-us*): A son of Priam. 24.317.

**Antiphus** (*ant'-if-us*): Greek leader; son of Thessalus; brother of Phidippus. 2.806.

**Antron** (*ant'-ron*): A town in Thessaly, under Protesilaus' leadership. 2.827.

**Apaesus** (*a-pee'-sus*): A town under the leadership of Amphius. 2.982.

**Aphareus** (*af-ar'-ee-yus*): Greek leader. 9.103.

**Aphrodite** (*af'-ro-dai'-tee*): Goddess associated with sexual desire (*erōs*); Eros (= Roman Cupid) is her child. Daughter of Zeus by the Titan Dione (although there are alternative geneologies). Usually represented as the wife of Hephaestus and lover of Ares (in *The Iliad*, however, Hephaestus is married to Charis). Mother of the Trojan Aeneas, whom she protects in battle. Aphrodite is described as “laughter-loving.” Talented with accessories and the arts of seduction. Winner, over Hera and Athena, of the contest for the apple of Conflict, she then enabled Paris to abduct Helen, precipitating the Trojan War. Favors the Trojans. Wounded in Book 5 by Diomedes, she leaves the battlefield weeping. 2.972.

**Apisaon** (*a-pis'-a-ohn*): (1) Trojan fighter. 11.745. (2) Greek fighter; son of Hippases. 17.449.

**Apollo** (*a-pol'-oh*): Olympian god. Son of Zeus, twin brother of Artemis by the goddess Leto. Also known as Phoebus, “Bright One.” Associated with song, poetry, the sun, light, plague, medicine, archery, civilization, prophecy, and interpretation. Formulaic descriptions focus on his skill in archery and his ability to act and strike at a distance. With Poseidon, he built the walls of Troy, but was cheated of the payment by King Laomedon. Apollo is not wholeheartedly a helper to either the Greeks or the Trojans. Angered at the abduction of Chryseis, the daughter of his own priest,



Chryses, he causes the plague in the Greek camp at the start of the poem. For much of the action, he keeps his distance, and when he intervenes, it is often through the manipulation of appearances. In Book 24 Apollo is instrumental in urging the other gods to find a way to get Achilles to release the body of Hector back to the Trojans. 1.11.

**Apseudes** (*ap-syoo'-deez*): A Nereid. The name suggests “not false.” 18.56.

**Araethyria** (*ar-ai-thi'-ree-ya*): A town under Agamemnon’s rule, apparently identifiable with the later city of Phlius. 2.680.

**Arcadia** (*ark-ay'-dee-ya*): An inland region of the Peloponnese. 2.720.

**Arcesilaus** (*ar-ses'-i-lay'-us*): Boeotian leader. 2.595.

**Archelochus** (*ark-el'-ok-us*): Trojan leader; son of Antenor. 2.976.

**Archeptolemus** (*ark'-ept-ol'-em-us*): “War Leader.” Trojan. Charioteer of Hector and son of Iphitus. 8.168.

**Areilycus** (*ar'-ay-il'-i-kus*): Father of Prothoenor; a Boeotian leader. 14.597.

**Arene** (*ar-ee'-nee*): A town in the realm of Nestor, identified with the later town of Samicum. 2.705.

**Ares** (*ehr'-eez*): Olympian god associated with warfare. Son of Zeus and Hera.

Described as “raging,” “wild,” “cause of tears,” “ruin of humanity.” Accompanied by Panic and Fear. Wounded in Book 5 by Diomedes, Ares appeals to Zeus, and Zeus himself declares Ares the most hated of the gods. 2.133.

**Aretaon** (*ar'-e-tay'-on*): Trojan fighter; killed by Teucer. 6.43.

**Arethous** (*ar'-eth-oh-us*): (1) Father of Menestheus; a Greek fighter from Boeotia; “club-bearer”; killed by tricks by Lycurgus. 7.12. (2) Thracian charioteer; killed by Achilles. 20.635.

**Aretus** (*ar-ee'-tus*): Trojan; son of Priam. 17.634.

**Argeas** (*ar'-jee-yas*): Lycian; father of Polymelus. 16.535.

**Argissa** (*ar-jis'-a*): A city in Thessaly. 2.876.

**Argive** (*ar'-gaiv*): Term for inhabitants of Argos, and also used in the original as a vaguer term for inhabitants of the Greek-speaking world more broadly. The terms “Achaean” and “Danaan” are also used in this way in the original, generally translated as “Greek” in this volume. 2.207.

**Argolis** (*ar'-go-lis*): Non-Homeric term for the eastern part of the Peloponnese.

**Argos** (*ar'-gos*): (1) A city in Argolis, under Agamemnon’s rule. 1.46. (2) Giant; appointed by Hera to guard Io and prevent Zeus from having sex with her. Killed by Hermes. 2.124. (3) Used once in the phrase “Pelasgian Argos,” apparently to refer to the kingdom of Achilles, in the valley of the River Spercheus. “Pelasgian” here seems to refer to an ancient pre-Greek people. 2.809.

**Ariadne** (*ar'-ee-ad'-nee*): Daughter of Minos, the mythical king of Cnossos. Taken from Crete by the Athenian hero Theseus after he killed the Minotaur and escaped

the labyrinth. 18.735.

**Arimi** (*ar'-i-mee*): Where the Titan Typhoeus was said to be sleeping underground after the defeat in the war with the Olympian gods; exact location unknown. 2.932.

**Arion** (*ar-ai'-on*): Divine, immortal horse of the Trojan hero Adrastus. 23.464.

**Arisbas** (*ar'-is-bas*): Father of Leocritus, a Greek fighter killed by Aeneas. 17.445.

**Arisbe** (*ar-iz'-bee*): A town in the Troad. 2.992.

**aristeia** (*ar-is-tay'-a*): “Bestness.” A Greek term for a narrative sequence in which a single warrior goes on an extraordinary killing spree and slaughters a large number of enemies in quick succession, thus demonstrating his own superior skill and courage.

**Arne** (*ar'-nee*): A settlement in Boeotia. 2.607.

**Arsinous** (*ars-in'-oh-us*): Father of Hecamede; concubine of Nestor. 11.805.

**Artemis** (*ar'-tem-is*): Olympian goddess associated with archery, hunting, wild animals and wild places, and women’s rites of passage. Twin sister of Apollo, daughter of Leto and Zeus. Supporter of Trojans, hostile to the Greeks (Agamemnon offends Artemis in the course of gathering the expedition to Troy). 5.67.

**Asaeus** (*as'-ee-yus*): Greek fighter; killed by Hector. 11.388.

**Ascalaphus** (*as-ka'-la-fus*): A son of Ares and a leader of the Minyans, fighters from Aspledon and Orchomenus. 2.611.

**Ascania** (*as-kan'-ee-ya*): A locality in Phrygia. 2.1027.

**Ascanius** (*as-kan'-ee-us*): A leader of the Phrygians; from Ascania. 2.1027.

**Asclepius** (*as-klee'-pee-yus*): Demigod associated with medicine and healing. Son of Apollo; father of Machaon and Podalirius, doctors and leaders among the Greeks. Asclepius learned the art of medicine from Chiron the Centaur, mythic doctor and teacher of Achilles. 2.871.

**Asine** (*a'-si-nee*): A community in the Argolis. 2.668.

**Asius** (*a'-see-yus*): Trojan leader; son of Hyrtacus. From Arisbe. 2.993.

**Asopus** (*as'-o-pus*): River god. Mythical father of Aegina, the mother of Aeacus. 4.509.

**Aspledon** (*as'-pled-on*): A town in Boeotia. 2.610.

**Assaracus** (*as-ar'-a-kus*): Son of Tros and grandfather of Anchises. 20.304.

**Asterion** (*as-ter'-ee-yon*): A city in Thessaly. 2.873.

**Asteropeus** (*as-ter'-o-pee'-yus*): Trojan fighter; son of Pelagon; killed by Achilles. 12.125.

**Astyalus** (*as-tai'-ya-lus*): A Trojan. 6.40.

**Astyanax** (*as-tai'-ya-nax*): “Master of the city.” Nickname of Scamandrius, the child of Hector and Andromache, given to him by the Trojans in honor of his father. 6.543.

**Astynous** (*as-in'-oh-us*): (1) Trojan; killed by Diomedes. 5.192. (2) Trojan fighter; son of Protiaon. 15.605.

**Astyoche** (*as-tai'-o-kee*): Daughter of Actor. Ares secretly lay with her, and she conceived twins, Ascalaphis and Ialmenus, Greek fighters in the Trojan war. 2.614.

**Astyochea** (*ast-ai'-o-kee'-a*): Mother of Tlepolemus, leader of the Rhodians. 2.782.

**Astypylus** (*as-ti'-pi-lus*): Paeonian chariot driver; killed by Achilles. 21.274.

**Athena** (*ath-ee'-na*): Olympian goddess, never married and eternally virgin, associated with strategic and technological intelligence, city building and city sacking, warfare, crafts, construction, woodworking, shipbuilding, and weaving. Daughter of Zeus by Metis (“Cunning Intelligence”—a specifically strategic and technical kind of intelligence). There was a prophecy that the son of Metis would overpower Zeus (the stories of Thetis and Metis overlap and are probably influenced by each other), so Zeus swallowed the pregnant Metis and Athena was born from her father’s head. Favors the Greeks, with particular fondness for Odysseus and Diomedes. 1.264.

**Athens**: A settlement in Attica. 2.654.

**Athos** (*ay'-thos*): A mountain on the Macedonian coast. 14.298.

**Atreus** (*ay'-tree-yus*): Father of Menelaus and Agamemnon. Atreus struggled with his brother, Thyestes, for control of their throne. 1.12.

**Attica** (*at'-ik-a*): Non-Homeric term for the region around Athens, in northeastern Greece.

**Atymnius** (*at-im'-nee-yus*): (1) Father of the Trojan chariot driver Mydon. 5.761. (2) Trojan fighter; killed by Antilochus. 16.408.

**Augeae** (*ow-jee'-yai*): (1) A city inhabited by Locrians; exact location unknown. 2.639. (2) A city in Lacedaemon. 2.696.

**Augeas** (*ow'-jee-yas*): Father of Agasthenes, Phyleus, and Agamede; through Agasthenes, grandfather of Polyxenus. 2.745.

**Aulis** (*ow'-lis*): Location at which Agamemnon assembled the Greek fleet to set sail on Troy. In order to persuade Artemis to allow fair wind for the fleet, Agamemnon sacrificed his own daughter to her at Aulis (a story that does not occur in *The Iliad*). In Book 2, Odysseus reminds the Greeks of a prophecy given by Calchas at Aulis, that the Greeks would take Troy in the tenth year of the siege. 2.369.

**Autolycus** (*ow-tol'-i-kus*): Father of Anticlea and grandfather of Odysseus. 10.325.

**Automedon** (*ow-tom'-ed-on*): A Myrmidon; son of Diores. Charioteer of Achilles. 9.265.

**Autonous** (*ow-to'-noh-us*): (1) Greek fighter; killed by Hector. 11.386. (2) Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.872.

**Autophon** (*ow'-to-fon*): Father of Polyphontes, one of the Theban leaders. 4.523.

**Axius** (*aks'-ee-yus*): River god in Macedonia, in the land of the Paeonians. Father of Pelagon. 2.1008.

**Axylus** (*aks'-i-lus*): Trojan fighter; killed by Diomedes. Son of Teuthras. From Arisbe. 6.14.

**Azeus** (*az'-ee-yus*): Father of Actor, the Minyan king, and grandfather of Ascalaphus and Ialmenus. 2.615.

**Batea** (*bat-ee'-ya*): A steep hill on the Trojan plain. Called Batea by humans, the gods know it as the tomb of Myrine. 2.964.

**Bathycles** (*bath'-i-kleez*): A Myrmidon; killed by Glaucus. Son of Chalcon. 16.747.

**Bellerophon** (*bel-e'-ro-fohn*): Greek hero; son of Glaucus 1 and grandson of Sisyphus. 6.208.

**Bessa** (*bes'-a*): A town in Locris; exact location unknown. 2.639.

**Bias** (*bee'-yas*): (1) Athenian leader. 13.912. (2) Father of Laogonus and Dardanus, Trojan fighters killed by Achilles. 20.598.

**Bienor** (*bai-ye'-nor*): Trojan leader; killed by Agamemnon. 11.121.

**Bion** (*bee'-yon*): Greek fighter from Pylos; companion of Nestor. 4.387.

**Boagrius** (*bo-ag'-ree-yus*): A river in Locris. 2.641.

**Boebe** (*bee'-bee*): A town in Thessaly. 2.846.

**Boebeis** (*bee'-bee-yis*): A lake in Thessaly. 2.846.

**Boeotia** (*bee-oh'-sha*): A region in central Greece. Its inhabitants are **Boeotians**. 2.593.

**Boreas** (*bor'-ee-yas*): The north wind, personified as a god. 5.693.

**Borus** (*bor'-us*): (1) A Maeonian; father of Phaestus, a Trojan killed by Idomeneus. 5.57. (2) A Myrmidon; son of Periereus and adoptive father of Menesthius. 16.227.

**Boucalion** (*boo-kal'-ee-yon*): Oldest son of king Laomedon. He was born out of wedlock. He had two sons with the sea nymph Abarbarea, the twins Aesopus and Pegasus. 6.30.

**Bouprasion** (*bu-pras'-ee-yon*): A town in Elis. 2.734.

**Briareus** (*bre-a'-ree-yus*): Hundred-handed giant who helped Thetis rescue Zeus. Also known by humans as Aegean. 1.532.

**Briseis** (*bris-ai'-yis*): A woman from a wealthy family who lived in Lyrnessus, a town near Troy. Her husband and family were slaughtered by Achilles when he sacked the town, and she was enslaved by the Greeks. Briseis is claimed as a trophy woman by Achilles, but then taken by Agamemnon (in compensation for Agamemnon's loss of Chryseis); she is eventually given back to Achilles. She is reluctant to go to her alternative Greek enslaver, Agamemnon, and she expresses postmortem fondness for Patroclus, who promised she would be taken back to Phthia as a legitimate wife of Achilles. 1.249.

**Bryseae** (*bris'-ee-yai*): A town in Lacedaemon. 2.696.

**Budium** (*boo'-dee-um*): Home of the Myrmidon Epeigeus, perhaps in Phthia. 16.721.

**Cabesus** (*ka'-be-sus*): A town of uncertain location; home to the Trojan ally Othryoneus. 13.475.

**Cadmians** (*kad'-mee-yans*): A name for the inhabitants of Thebes, after Cadmus, who founded the city. 5.1054.

**Caeneus** (*see'-nee-yus*): A Lapith hero who died in the battle against the Centaurs. 1.353.

**Calchas** (*kal'-kas*): Prophet in the Greek encampment who interprets bird signs and other omens for the Greek leaders. He foretells, based on an omen at Aulis, that the siege will last ten years before the Greeks take the city. He also identifies Apollo's anger about the abduction of Chryses' daughter as the cause of the plague in the Greek camp. 1.93.

**Calesius** (*ka-lee'-see-yus*): Charioteer for Axylus; killed by Diomedes. 6.23.

**Caletor** (*kal'-e-tor*): Father of Aphareus. 13.714.

**Callianassa** (*kal'-ee-a-nas'-a*): A Nereid. The name suggests "beautiful queen." 18.56.

**Callianeira** (*kal'-ee-a-nai'-ra*): A Nereid. The name suggests "beautiful rule." 8.57.

**Calliarus** (*kal'-ai'-a-rus*): A town in Locris. 2.640.

**Callicolone** (*kal'-i-kol'-o-nee*): "Beautiful mound." A hill near Troy. 20.73.

**Calydnae** (*kal-id'-nai*): A group of islands near Cos. 2.805.

**Calydon** (*kal'-i-don*): A city in Aetolia, on the west bank of the River Evenus, ruled by Thoas and seized, in earlier myth, by the Curetes. 2.764.

**Calytor** (*kal'-i-tor*): A cousin of Hector; killed by Ajax. 15.560.

**Cameirus** (*kam-ay'-rus*): A town in Rhodes. 2.781.

**Capaneus** (*kap-ay'-nee-yus*): Father of Sthenelus and one of the Seven against Thebes. 2.673.

**Capys** (*ka'-pis*): Father of Anchises. 20.313.

**Cardamyle** (*kar-da'-mi-lee*): A city controlled by Agamemnon. 9.188.

**Caresus** (*kar-ee'-sus*): A river flowing from Mount Ida. 12.25.

**Caria** (*kar'-ee-a*): A region in southwestern Anatolia. Its inhabitants are **Carians**. 4.183.

**Carustas** (*kar'-us-tas*): A town in the south of Euboea. 2.647.

**Cassandra** (*kas-ahn'-dra*): Daughter of Priam and Hecuba of Troy. Pursued by Apollo, who promised her the gift of prophecy; when she resisted him, he turned the gift to a curse by ensuring that her prophecies would not be believed. These stories are not told in *The Iliad*, although Cassandra's role as a prophet may be suggested by her presence as the first person from Troy to see Priam returning to the city with the dead Hector in Book 24. 13.476.

**Castianeira** (*kas-tai'-a-nai'-ra*): Mother of Gorguthion. 8.406.

**Castor** (*kas'-tor*): Brother of Helen, Pollux, and Clytemnestra and son of Leda and Tyndareus. 3.291

**Casus** (*kas'-us*): An island near eastern Crete. 2.803.

**Caucones** (*kow-koh'-neez*): Allies of the Trojans. The precise location of their homeland is unknown, although they may be from northern Anatolia. 10.536.

**Cayster** (*kay'-ster*): A river in Anatolia. 2.554.

**Ceas** (*see'-as*): Father of Troezenus and grandfather of Euphemus. 2.1004.

**Cebriones** (*seb-rai'-on-eez*): Half brother and charioteer to Hector; storms the Greek camp; killed by Patroclus. 8.426.

**Celadon** (*sel'-a-don*): A river near Pylos. 7.176.

**Centaurs** (*sen'-tors*): Creatures with the upper body of a human and the lower body of a horse who engaged in a battle against the Lapiths. 2.882.

**Cephalenia** (*sef'-al-ee'-nee-ya*): An area in the Ionian Sea ruled by Odysseus. The territory of its inhabitants, the **Cephalenians**, seems to include Ithaca and all the neighboring islands, although in later sources, Cephalenia is the name given to the single island known as Samos in *The Iliad*. 2.754.

**Cephis** (*se'-fi-sis*): A lake in Boeotia (modern-day Lake Copais). 5.929.

**Cephisus** (*se'-fi-sus*): A river in Phocis. 2.626.

**Cerinthus** (*se'-rin-thus*): A coastal town in eastern Euboea. 2.646.

**Chaeropeus** (*kai-roh'-pee-yus*): Father of Nireus and king of Syme. 2.799.

**Chalcis** (*kal'-kis*): (1) A Euboean city, located on the Euripus Strait. 2.646. (2) An Aetolian town, located on the coast. 2.763. (3) The name the gods use for a mountain-dwelling owl. 14.381.

**Chalcodon** (*kal'-ko-don*): Father of Elphenor. 2.649.

**Chalcon** (*kal'-kohn*): Father of Bathycles. 16.748.

**Charis** (*ka'-ris*): Personification of “attractiveness” and the wife of Hephaestus. 18.473.

**Charops** (*ka'-rops*): Trojan; killed by Odysseus. 11.558.

**Chersidamas** (*ker-si'-da-mas*): Trojan; killed by Odysseus. 11.552.

**Chimera** (*kai-mee'-ra*): A monster; killed by the hero Bellerophon. 6.240.

**Chiron** (*kai'-rohn*): A Centaur and doctor who was the tutor to Achilles, Patroclus, and Asclepius. 4.288.

**Chromius** (*krom'-ee-yus*): (1) A leader of the Mysians; killed by Achilles. 2.1021. (2) A comrade of Nestor. 4.386. (3) A son of Priam; killed by Diomedes. 5.214. (4) Lycian; killed by Odysseus. 5.890. (5) Trojan; killed by Teucer. 8.368.

**Chryse** (*krai'-see*): A town south of Troy; home to Chryses and Chryseis. 1.56.

**Chryseis** (*kri-sai'-yis*): Daughter of Chryses, a priest of Apollo in Chryse. Chryseis is enslaved and captured by the Greeks when they sack the town. In the apportionment of spoils to the leading warriors, Chryseis is given as a trophy to Agamemnon, but Chryses, her father, supplicates to get her back; when that fails, Chryses prays to

Apollo, who brings plague on the Greek encampment until his daughter is returned home, along with animals for sacrifice to the god. 1.151.

**Chryses** (*krai'-seez*): Priest of Apollo who offers Agamemnon a ransom in exchange for his daughter Chryseis and whose prayer brings a plague from Apollo. 1.16.

**Chrysothemis** (*krai-so'-the-mis*): “Golden right.” A daughter of Agamemnon. 9.181.

**Ciconian** (*sik-oh'-nee-yan*): Name for a tribe of Thracians, led by Euphemus. 2.1005.

**Cilicians** (*si-li'-see-yans*): In *The Iliad*, this people is said to live in Thebe, beneath Mount Placus. In later sources, the Cilicians live somewhere quite different: in Cilicia, much farther south. This confusing detail is not explained; perhaps the composer(s) of the poem was unfamiliar with the actual geography of Anatolia and simply made a mistake. 6.534.

**Cilla** (*sil'-a*): A town in the Troad, sacred to Apollo. 1.57.

**Cinyres** (*sin-ai'-reez*): A ruler in Cyprus who gives Agamemnon a corselet. 11.25.

**Cisses** (*sis'-eez*): A ruler in Thrace. Grandfather of Iphidamas and father of Theano. 6.401.

**Cleoboulus** (*kee'-o-boo'-lus*): Trojan; killed by Oilean Ajax. 16.424.

**Cleonae** (*kee-oh'-nee*): A town in Argolis. 2.680.

**Cleopatra** (*kee'-o-pat'-ra*): Wife of Meleager and daughter of Idas and Marpessa. She was abducted by Apollo. Also called Alcyone. 9.723.

**Clitus** (*klai'-tus*): “Renowned.” A Trojan and charioteer of Polydamas; killed by Teucer. 15.595.

**Clonius** (*klon'-ee-yus*): A leader from Boeotia; killed by Agenor. 2.594.

**Clymene** (*klim'-e-nee*): (1) A slave of Helen. 3.180. (2) A Nereid. The name suggests “heard” or “famous.” 18.57.

**Clytemnestra** (*klai'-tem-nes'-tra*): Wife of Agamemnon and sister of Helen, Castor, and Pollux. In the absence of her husband, she took a lover, Aegisthus, and they killed Agamemnon on his return from Troy—a story not told in *The Iliad*, but mentioned repeatedly in *The Odyssey*. 1.152.

**Clytius** (*kli'-tee-yus*): Father of Calytor, son of Laomedon, brother of Priam. 3.184.

**Clytomedes** (*klai'-to-mee'-deez*): Son of Enops, whom Nestor defeated in boxing at Amarynceus’ funeral games. 23.838.

**Clytus** (*klai'-tus*): Father of Dolon. 11.388.

**Cnossos** (*knos'-os*): A city in central Crete. 2.770.

**Coiranus** (*koy-rah'-nus*): (1) Lycian; killed by Odysseus. 5.889. (2) Charioteer for Meriones; killed by Hector. 17.783.

**Coon** (*koh'-on*): Eldest son of Antenor; killed by Agamemnon. 11.324.

**Copae** (*koh'-pai*): A town in Boeotia. 2.600.

**Copreus** (*kop'-ree-yus*): Father of Periphetes and henchman to King Eurystheus. 15.850.

**Corinth** (*kor'-inth*): A city on the isthmus that joins the Peloponnese to the Greek mainland. Also called Ephyra. 2.679.

**Coroneia** (*kor'-on-ay'-a*): A Boeotian city. 2.604.

**Coronus** (*kor-oh'-nus*): Father of Leonteus and son of Caeneus. 2.886.

**Cos** (*kos*): An island in the eastern Aegean. 2.804.

**Cranae** (*krah'-nai*): “Rocky.” An island off the coast of Gytheum where Helen and Paris first had sex. 3.559.

**Crapathus** (*kra-pa'-thus*): An island in the southeastern Aegean (modern-day Karpathos). 2.803.

**Creon** (*kree'-on*): Father of Lycomedes. 9.104.

**Crete** (*kreet*): A large island in the Mediterranean, ruled by Idomeneus. Home of the Cretans. 2.772.

**Crethon** (*kree'-thohn*): Son of Diocles and twin brother of Orsilochus; killed by Achilles. 5.715.

**Crisa** (*kree'-sa*): A town in Phocis. 2.623.

**Crocyleia** (*kro'-si-lay'-a*): A place under the rule of Odysseus, perhaps a region of the island of Ithaca, or a separate island. 2.757.

**Croismus** (*kroiz'-mus*): Trojan; killed by Meges. 15.693.

**Cromna** (*krom'-na*): A town in Paphlagonia. 2.1015.

**Cronus** (*kron'-us*): A Titan; father of Zeus, Hera, Poseidon, Hades, Demeter, and Hestia by Rheia. Zeus castrated him and overthrew the Titans. 1.526.

**Cteatus** (*ktee'-a-tus*): Father of Amphimachus. 2.740.

**Curetes** (*kyor'-ree-teez*): A group who attempted to siege Calydon and fought against the Aetolians. 9.683.

**Cyllene** (*sil-ee'-nee*): (1) A mountain in northern Arcadia. 2.723. (2) A port town in Elis. 15.684.

**Cymandis** (*si-man'-dis*): The name given by mortals to a kind of mountain-dwelling bird. 14.382.

**Cymodoce** (*si-mo'-do-see*): A Nereid. The name suggests “wave-welcome.” 18.49.

**Cymothoe** (*si-mo'-thoh-ee*): A Nereid. The name suggests “wave-quickness.” 18.52.

**Cynus** (*sai'-nus*): A town in Locris. 2.639.

**Cyparisseis** (*sip'-a-ris'-ay-is*): A town in Elis near Amphigenea. 2.707.

**Cyparissus** (*sip'-a-ris'-us*): A town in Phocis. 2.622.

**Cyphus** (*sai'-fus*): A town in Thessaly. 2.888.

**Cyprus** (*sai'-prus*): A large island in the eastern Mediterranean. It had a large cult center to Aphrodite, from which she gets the nickname Cyprian. 5.440.

**Cythera** (*si'-ther-a*): An island off the southern tip of the Peloponnese. 10.329.

**Cytorus** (*sit-or'-us*): A town in Paphlagonia. 2.1013.



**Daedalus** (*dai'-da-lus*): Mythical human craftsman who designed the Cretan labyrinth. 18.734.

**Daetor** (*dai'-tor*): Trojan warrior; killed by Teucer. 8.368.

**Damastor** (*dam-as'-tor*): The father of Tlepolemus, a Trojan warrior. 16.534.

**Damasus** (*da'-mas-us*): Trojan killed by Polypoetes. 12.221.

**Danae** (*dan'-a-ee*): The mythical daughter of Acrisius; Zeus impregnated her in the form of a golden shower, and she gave birth to the hero Perseus. 14.420.

**Dardania** (*dar-day'-nee-ya*): An area in the Troad, the region surrounding Troy. The **Dardans** (sometimes called the **Dardanians**) are allies of the Trojans. 2.377.

**Dardanus** (*dar'-da-nus*): (1) A mythical son of Zeus by a goddess named Electra. Dardanus was a founder of Troy and a distant ancestor of Priam. 7.474. (2) Trojan fighter, son of Bias and brother of Laogonus; killed by Achilles. 20.599.

**Dares** (*dar'-eez*): A Trojan priest of Hephaestus. 5.12.

**Daulis** (*dow'-lis*): A city in Phocis. 2.623.

**Deicoon** (*day-ik'-oh-on*): Trojan fighter; killed by Agamemnon. 5.706.

**Deiochus** (*day-ee'-o-kus*): Greek warrior; killed by Paris. 15.460.

**Deiopites** (*day-ee-o'-pi-teez*): Trojan warrior. 11.550.

**Deiphobus** (*day-if'-ob-us*): A son of Priam and Hecuba, brother to Hector and Paris, and one of the most important Trojan warriors. Apollo lures Hector beyond the walls to fight Achilles in Book 22 by pretending to be Deiphobus (an episode perhaps partly inspired by the connection of the name Deiphobus with Apollo's title, Phoebus). 12.115.

**Deipylus** (*day-i'-pi-lus*): Greek fighter and companion of Sthenelus. 5.431.

**Deipyrus** (*day-i'-pi-rus*): (1) One of the leaders of the Greek watchmen. 9.103. (2) Greek warrior; killed by the Trojan Helenus. 13.118.

**Delphi** (*del'-fee* [U.K.] or *del'-fai* [U.S.]): The site of a sacred temple to Apollo, which housed a special oracle. Also known as Pytho. 9.522.

**Demeter** (*dem-ee'-ter*): Note that the stress falls on the second syllable (not *dem'-et-er*). Olympian goddess associated with agriculture and fertility. Daughter of Cronus and Rhea. Raped by her brother, Zeus, she became the mother of Persephone, the goddess of the underworld. 2.826.

**Democoon** (*dem-o'-ko-ohn*): An illegitimate son of Priam; killed by Odysseus. 4.667.

**Demoleon** (*dem-oh'-lee-yon*): Trojan warrior son of Antenor; killed by Achilles. 20.518.

**Demuchus** (*dem'-u-kus*): Trojan warrior, son of Philetor; killed by Achilles. 20.596.

**Deucalion** (*dyou-kay'-lee-yon*): (1) The father of Idomeneus and the son of Minos, a Cretan king. 12.145. (2) Trojan warrior; killed by Achilles. 20.621.

**Dexamene** (*dex-am'-in-ee*): A Nereid. The name suggests "welcoming." 18.54.

**Dexias** (*dex'-ee-yus*): Father of Iphinous. 7.21.

**Diocles** (*dai'-o-kleez*): A rich inhabitant of the city of Pherae, and the father of Crethon and Orsilochus. 5.716.

**Diomede** (*dai'-o-meed'-ee*): An enslaved woman captured by Achilles on Lesbos; daughter of Phorbas. 9.870.

**Diomedes** (*dai'-o-mee'-deez*): Note that the primary stress is on the third syllable (not *dai-o'-med-eez*). Son of Tydeus, one of the Seven Against Thebes. Diomedes, along with his friend Sthenelus and others of the second generation, succeeded in sacking Thebes. Diomedes is an experienced city-sacker, a fine charioteer and warrior, but also presented as younger than others in the Greek council. In Book 5, he slaughters a huge number of mortals and wounds two gods, Aphrodite and Ares. In Book 10, he and Odysseus go on a nighttime raid to the Trojan camp—an episode that parallels a more famous legend, not told in *The Iliad*, whereby Diomedes and Odysseus crept into Troy to steal the statue of Athena from the citadel. 2.490.

**Dion** (*dai'-on*): A city of the Abantes in Euboea. 2.647.

**Dione** (*dai-oh'-nee*): A sea goddess said in Homer to be the mother of Aphrodite. 5.496.

**Dionysus** (*dai'-o-nai'-sus*): Greek god of wine; son of Zeus and Semele. 6.177.

**Diores** (*dai-or'-eez*): (1) The son of Amarynceus and one of the leaders of the Greek fighters from Elis; killed by Piros. 2.742. (2) Father of Automedon. 17.553.

**Disenor** (*dai-see'-nor*): A leader among the Trojan allies. 17.281.

**Dodona** (*do-doh'-nah*): An important cult site for the worship of Zeus, near Mount Tomaros. 2.891.

**Dolon** (*doh'-lon*): Trojan; son of Eumedes. Dolon is captured by Odysseus and Diomedes in their nighttime raid, and gives up information on Trojan strategy to the Greeks before being killed. 10.387.

**Dolopion** (*dol'-o-pee'-yon*): Father of Hypsenor. 5.99.

**Dolopes** (*dol'-o-pee-z*): A hill tribe near Phthia. 9.623.

**Dolops** (*do'-lops*): (1) Greek leader; killed by Hector. Son of Clytus. 11.389. (2) Trojan spearman; killed by Menelaus. Son of Lampus and cousin of Hector. 15.694.

**Dorion** (*do'-ree-yon*): A city in Messenia. 2.709.

**Doris** (*do'-ris*): A Nereid. The name suggests “gift.” 18.52.

**Doryclus** (*do'-ree-klus*): A bastard son of Priam; killed by Ajax. 11.636.

**Doto** (*doh'-toh*): A Nereid. The name suggests “giving.” 18.54.

**Dracius** (*dray'-shus*): A leader of the Epeans. 13.915.

**Dresus** (*dree'-sus*): Trojan warrior; killed by Euryalus. 6.26.

**Dryas** (*drai'-yus*): (1) One of the heroes of old who fought against the Centaurs. 1.352. (2) Father of Lycurgus. 6.173.

**Dryops** (*drai'-yops*): Trojan warrior; killed by Achilles. 20.593.

**Dulicium** (*du-lish'-um*): An island in the Ionian Sea near Elis. 2.746.

**Dumas** (*dyou'-mas*): Father of Asius. 16.901.

**Dyname** (*din'-am-ee*): A Nereid. The name suggests “power.” 18.51.

**Echecles** (*ek'-ek-leez*): Husband of Polymele and stepfather to Eudorus. 16.245.

**Echecclus** (*ek-ek'-lus*): (1) Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.872. (2) Son of Antenor; killed by Achilles. 20.618.

**Echemmon** (*ek-em'-on*): Son of Priam; killed by Diomedes. 5.213.

**Echepolus** (*ek-ep'-o-lus*): (1) Trojan; killed by Antilochus. 4.611. (2) Son of Anchises who gave Agamemnon a mare to avoid going to Troy. 23.399.

**Echinades** (*ek-i'-nad-eez*): A group of islands in the Ionian Sea. 2.747.

**Echius** (*ek'-ee-yus*): (1) Father of Mecisteus. 8.444. (2) Greek; killed by Polites. 15.458. (3) Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.533.

**Eeriboea** (*e-er'-i-boy-a*): Stepmother of Otus and Ephialtes. 5.522.

**Eetion** (*ee'-ye-shun*): (1): Father of Andromache and king of the Cilicians in Thebe; killed by Achilles. 1.484. (2) Father of the Trojan Podes. 17.736. (3) An Imbrian who ransomed Lycaon. 21.55.

**Eileithuia** (*ay'-lay-thwee'-ya*): Goddess of childbirth; sometimes referred to as multiple goddesses (**Eileithuia**). 11.353.

**Eilesion** (*ee-lee'-see-yon*): A town in Boeotia. 2.599.

**Eion** (*ee'-yon*): Father of Rhesus. 10.543.

**Eiones** (*ay'-o-nee*): A town in Argolis. 2.671.

**Eioneus** (*ee-oh'-nee-yus*): Greek; killed by Hector. 7.13.

**Elasus** (*el'-as-us*): Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.875.

**Elatus** (*el'-at-us*): Trojan; killed by Agamemnon. 6.46.

**Eleon** (*el'-ee-yon*): A town in Boeotia. 2.599.

**Elis** (*el'-is*): A region and town of the Peloponnese. 2.735.

**Elone** (*el-oh'-nee*): A town in Thessaly whose warriors were led by Polypoetes. 2.878.

**Elphenor** (*el-feen'-or*): Leader of the Abantes; killed by Agenor. 2.648.

**Emathia** (*em'-a-thee'-ya*): An old name for regions in Macedonia. 14.293.

**Eneti** (*en'-e-tee*): A tribe in Paphlagonia. 2.1011.

**Enienes** (*en'-ee-ee'-nee*): A tribe from the area around Dodona, in northern Greece. 2.889.

**Eniopeus** (*en-ai'-yo-pee'-yus*): Trojan charioteer; killed by Diomedes. 8.158.

**Enispe** (*en'-is-pee*): A town in Arcadia. 2.725.

**Ennomus** (*en'-o-mus*): A seer and leader of the Mysians; killed by Achilles. 2.1021.

**Enope** (*en-oh'-pee*): A city controlled by Agamemnon, which he offers to Achilles; exact location unknown. 9.188.

**Enops** (*en'-ops*): (1) Father of Satnius and of Thestor. 14.587. (2) Father of Clytomedes. 23.838.

**Enyalios** (*en'-ee-ay'-lee-yus*): An epithet of Ares. 13.686.

**Enyeus** (*en'-ee-ee'-yus*): King of Scyros whose city Achilles sacked. 9.877.

**Enyo** (*en-ee'-oh*): A non-Olympian warrior goddess associated with Ares. 5.444.

**Epaltēs** (*ep-al'-teez*): Trojan killed by Patroclus. 16.532.

**Epeans** (*ep-ee'-yans*): Inhabitants of the northern Peloponnese who once fought against the Pylians. 2.739.

**Epeus** (*ep-ee'-yus*): Greek who wins the boxing contest and participates in the iron-throwing contest at Patroclus' funeral games. 23.883.

**Ephialtes** (*ef'-ee-al'-teez*): Son of Aloeus who imprisoned Ares. 5.517.

**Ephyra** (*ef'-i-ra*): (1) A town in Thesprotia near the Selleis River. Alternatively, it is sometimes said to be in Elis. 2.784. (2) A city in Argos, usually identified with Corinth. 6.203.

**Ephyri** (*ef'-i-ree*): A tribe from Thessaly. 13.392.

**Epicles** (*ep'-i-kleez*): Lycian; killed by Telamonian Ajax. 12.464.

**Epidaurus** (*ep-i-dow'-rus*): A town in Argolis. 2.670.

**Epigeus** (*ep'-i-jee'-yus*): Myrmidon; killed by Hector. 16.720.

**Epistor** (*ep-is'-tor*): Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.873.

**Epistrophus** (*ep-is'-trof-us*): (1) A leader from Phocis and son of Iphitus. 2.620. (2) A son of Evenus from Lyrnessus; killed by Achilles. 2.822. (3): A leader of the Halizones. 2.1019.

**Epytes** (*ep'-i-teez*): Father of Periphas and a herald of Anchises. 17.416.

**Erebus** (*er'-e-bus*): A part of the underworld associated with darkness. 9.744.

**Erechtheus** (*er-ek'-thee-yus*): The first ruler of Athens; raised by Athena. 2.655.

**Eretria** (*er'-et-ree'-ya*): A town in Euboea. 2.645.

**Ereuthalion** (*er'-you-thal'-ee-yon*): Arcadian; killed by Nestor. 4.420.

**Erichthonius** (*er'-ik-thon'-ee-us*): A former king of Dardania; son of Dardanus and father of Tros. 20.288.

**Eriopis** (*er-ai'-op-is*): Stepmother of Medon and wife of Oileus. 13.921.

**Erylaus** (*er-il'-ay-us*): Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.527.

**Erymas** (*er'-im-as*): (1) Trojan; killed by Idomeneus. 16.444. (2) Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.532.

**Erythini** (*er'-i-thee'-nee*): A town in Paphlagonia. 2.1016.

**Erythrae** (*er-ith'-rai*): A town in Boeotia. 2.599.

**Eteocles** (*et-ee'-o-kleez*): King of Thebes. He feuded with his brother Polyneices in the generation before the Trojan War. 4.512.

**Eteonus** (*eet'-ee-oh'-nus*): A town in Boeotia. 2.598.

**Ethiopians**: "Bright faced." In Homer, the gods regularly visit the Ethiopians and enjoy fine feasts provided by this generous and pious community of people, who live in a sun-filled land far from Troy. 1.562.

**Euaemon** (*you-ai'-mohn*): Father of Eurypylus. 2.875.

**Euboea** (*you-bee'-ya*): A large island off eastern coast of central Greece; home of the Abantes. 2.643.

**Euchenor** (*you-kee'-nor*): Greek; killed by Paris. 13.873.

**Eudorus** (*you-dor'-us*): Son of Hermes and Polymele; a leader of the Myrmidons. 16.231.

**Euippus** (*you-ip'-us*): Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.533.

**Eumedes** (*you-mee'-deez*): Father of Dolon. 10.388.

**Eumelus** (*you'-mel-us*): A Greek charioteer who comes in last in the chariot race in Patroclus' funeral games. 2.848.

**Euneus** (*you-nee'-yus*): Son of Jason and Hypsipyle. Euneus sent wine to Agamemnon and Menelaus and ransomed Lycaon with a silver bowl. 7.596.

**Euphemus** (*you-fee'-mus*): Leader of the Ciconians. 2.1003.

**Euphetes** (*you-fee'-teez*): Ruler of Ephyra who gave Phyleus armor. 15.703.

**Euphorbus** (*you-for'-bus*): Dardan; killed by Menelaus. 16.109.

**Europa** (*yor-oh'-pa*): Daughter of Phoenix. Abducted by Zeus in the form of a bull. Mother of Minos, Rhadamanthus, and Sarpedon. 14.425.

**Eurus** (*yor'-us*): The east wind, personified as a god. 2.172.

**Euryalus** (*yor-ai'-a-lus*): Leader of the men from Argos. 2.673.

**Eurybates** (*yor-i'-ba-teez*): An attendant and messenger. Associated with Agamemnon in Book 1 and Odysseus in Book 2, but these may be different characters with the same name. 1.429.

**Eurydamas** (*yor-i'-dam-as*): Father of Abas and Polyidus and a seer. 5.198.

**Eurymedon** (*yor-i'-med-on*): A charioteer and attendant of Agamemnon. 4.298.

**Eurynome** (*yor-in'-om-ee*): A daughter of Ocean who rescued Hephaestus. 18.493.

**Eurypylus** (*yor-i'-pi-lus*): (1) King of Cos. 2.804. (2.) Leader of some troops from Thessaly. 2.875.

**Eurystheus** (*yor-is'-thee-yus*): "Wide strength." King of Mycenae. He imposed the Labors on Heracles. 8.486.

**Eurytus** (*yor'-i-tus*): (1) King of Oechalia. 2.712. (2) Father of Thalpius. 2.741.

**Eussorus** (*you'-sor-us*): Father of Acamas. 6.9.

**Eutresis** (*you-tres'-is*): A town in Boeotia. 2.602.

**Evenus** (*ev-een'-us*): (1) Father of Epistrophus and Myrnes. 2.823. (2) Father of Marpessa. 9.725.

**Exadius** (*ex-ad'-ee-us*): A former companion of Nestor. 1.354.

**Fates**: Personifications of destiny. 24.61.

**Fear**: A personification represented on Zeus' aegis. 11.47.

**Flame**: A mare belonging to Agamemnon. 23.397.

**Flight:** A personification connected to Ares, because the war god has the power to make men flee in terror. 5.970.

**Furies:** Underworld goddesses who avenge violations of family ties. 9.586.

**Galatea** (*gal'-a-tee'-ya*): A Nereid. The name suggests “milky.” 18.55.

**Ganymede** (*gan'-ee-meed*): A son of Tros; abducted by Zeus to be his cupbearer and rape victim. 5.354.

**Gargaron** (*gar'-gar-on*): A peak or spur of Mount Ida and a sanctuary of Zeus, frequently called “highest” in Homer. Also called Gargara. 8.60.

**Gerenia** (*je-ree'-nee-ya*): A town in Messenia from which Nestor gets the epithet “Gerenian.” 2.407.

**Glaphyrae** (*glaf'-i-rai*): A town in Thessaly. 2.847.

**Glauce** (*glow'-see*): A Nereid. The name suggests “bright” or “shining.” 18.51.

**Glaucus** (*glow'-cus*): “Bright” or “shining.” (1) Leader of a large contingent of Trojan allies, the Lycians, along with his friend and cousin, Sarpedon. Tells a long story in Book 6 about his grandfather, Bellerophon. Fights bravely in the Trojan assault on the Greek wall, and to protect the body of Sarpedon. 2.1046. (2) Son of Sisyphus and father of Bellerophon. 6.207.

**Glisa** (*glees'-a*): A town in Boeotia. 2.601.

**Gonoessa** (*gon'-oh-es'-a*): A town in Achaea, ruled by Agamemnon; exact location unknown. 2.683.

**Gorgon** (*gor'-gon*): A monster whose head is depicted on the aegis. 5.971.

**Gorgythion** (*gor-ji'-thee-on*): Trojan; killed by Teucer. A son of Priam and Aesyme. 8.405.

**Gortys** (*gor'-tis*): A city in Crete. 2.769.

**Gouneus** (*goo'-nee-yus*): The leader of the troops from Cyphus. 2.888.

**Graces:** Companions of Aphrodite, called Charites in Greek. The personifications of attractiveness or charm. 5.451.

**Graea** (*grai'-ya*): A town in Boeotia. 2.596.

**Grenicus** (*gren'-ik-us*): A river flowing from Mount Ida to the sea. 12.26.

**Gygaea** (*ji-jai'-ya*): A lake in Lydia and the nymph of that lake. 2.1033.

**Gyrtius** (*jir'-tee-yus*): Father of Hyrtius. 14.680.

**Gyrtone** (*jir-toh'-nee*): A town in Thessaly. 2.877.

**Hades** (*hay'-deez*): Olympian god apportioned the underworld, the land of the dead, when his brother Zeus got the sky, and Poseidon the sea. Son of Cronus and Rhea, brother of Zeus and Poseidon. For the wintery half the year, Hades has the company of his niece, Persephone, daughter of Demeter, whom he abducted and forced to serve as his bride. 1.5.

**Haemon** (*hai'-mohn*): (1) Greek; comrade of Nestor. 4.387. (2) Father of Maeon. 4.522. (3) Father of Laerces and grandfather of Alcimedon. 17.602.

**Haliartus** (*hal'-i-art'-us*): A town in Boeotia. 2.603.

**Halia** (*hal'-ee-ya*): A Nereid. The name suggests “of the sea.” 18.50.

**Halius** (*hal'-ee-yus*): Trojan; killed by Odysseus. 5.890.

**Halizones** (*hal'-i-zoh'-neez*): A tribe allied with the Trojans. Its members are **Halizonians**. 2.1017.

**Harma** (*harm'-a*): A town in Boeotia. 2.598.

**Harmon** (*harm'-ohn*): Father of Phereclus. 5.78.

**Harpalion** (*har-pal'-ee-on*): A Trojan who fights Menelaus; killed by Meriones. 13.845.

**Hebe** (*hee'-bee*): Goddess of youth who acts as cupbearer to the gods on Olympus. 4.2.

**Hecamede** (*hek'-a-mee'-dee*): An elderly slave of Nestor; daughter of Arsinous; abducted from Tenedos after that town was sacked by Achilles. 11.804.

**hecatomb** (*hek'-a-toom*): A large animal sacrifice. 1.137.

**Hector**: “Holder.” Favorite son of Priam; best warrior in Troy; husband of Andromache, father of Astyanax. Hector is the fighter who holds off the Greeks and holds the city of Troy together. Formulaic epithets include “tamer of horses/horse-lord,” “man-killing” or “murderous,” and “of the flashing / glittering helmet”—all these descriptors remind us of Hector’s role as a warrior. Pious; trusts that he may be favored by Zeus and the other gods. Described as relentless as an axe by his brother Paris. Hector’s story is central to the poem, and artfully structured: in Book 6, he bids a painful farewell to his family in Troy, including his parents, sister-in-law Helen, and wife; these scenes are reprised in Book 22, when his parents again beg him not to venture beyond the wall and he again refuses to return—and again in Book 24, when the same three women whom he left in Book 6, Hecuba, Andromache, and Helen, lament his final return to the city. 1.326.

**Hecuba** (*hek'-you-ba*): Primary legitimate wife of Priam of Troy, queen of the city. Mother of nineteen children, including Hector, Paris, and Cassandra, and many other prominent Trojans. Characterized by her intense love for her children and hatred for those who have come to kill them. 6.114.

**Helen**: Wife of Menelaus, and at the time of the poem, wife/lover/kidnapped abductee of Paris. She is a daughter of Zeus and a mortal woman, Leda, who was raped by Zeus in the form of a swan. Sister of Clytemnestra. Like Athena and Aphrodite (other daughters of Zeus), Helen is powerful and deadly. Like Odysseus, she excels at recognition. Helen is the only character who has been on both sides in the Trojan War. She is one of many mortal women enslaved and traded between elite men, but she is also half divine, and the poem creates resonant ambiguities about the degree to which she may have agency in her relationships with the various men who claim her. Like Achilles, she has an unexpectedly broad perspective on the war; she weaves

images of the men competing for herself, and she shows shame at Paris' cowardice, grief, regret, and desire for things to be otherwise. 2.188.

**Helenus** (*hel'-en-us*): (1) Greek; killed by Hector. 5.926. (2) A son of Priam and Hecuba who is skilled in prophecy. 6.99.

**Helicaon** (*hel'-i-ka'-ohn*): Husband of Laodice and son of Antenor. 3.151.

**Helice** (*hel'-i-see*): A coastal town ruled by Agamemnon; the site of a temple to Poseidon. 2.685.

**Helius** (*heel'-ee-yus*): God of the sun. 3.344.

**Hellas** (*hel'-as*): A region of Thessaly, ruled by Peleus. Its inhabitants are **Hellenes** (a term commonly used in later sources to refer to Greeks in general). 2.810.

**Hellespont** (*hel'-es-pont*): The narrow waterway to the north and east of Troy, now known as the Dardanelles, Gallipoli, or the Strait of Çanakkale. Route by which the black ships of the Greeks have reached the city. 2.1002.

**Helli** (*hel'-oi*): Inhabitants of Dodona. They are connected to the oracle of Zeus. 16.306.

**Helus** (*heel'-us*): (1) A town in Lacedaemon, also called Helus-on-sea. 2.697. (2) A town ruled by Nestor; exact location unknown but presumably somewhere near Pylos. 2.708.

**Hephaestus** (*he-fais'-tus*): Olympian god of technology, fire, metallurgy, volcanoes, and blacksmiths. Physically unusual, with limbs that are bent or crooked but agile, like flames. Loving son to Hera and loving adoptive son to Thetis; wary of his father, Zeus. Most versions of the tradition, including *The Odyssey*, present him as married to Aphrodite, but in *The Iliad*, his wife is Charis. In Book 18, at the request of Thetis, he creates an astonishing set of armor for Achilles, including a marvelous shield that represents two cities, at war and at peace. In Book 21, he fights the flooding River Xanthus/Scamander with his blasts of flame. 1.733.

**Heptaporus** (*hep-ta'-por-us*): A river that flows from Mount Ida to the sea; exact location unknown. 12.26.

**Hera** (*hee'-ra*) Note that some English speakers say *he'-ra*, although the “ee” in Greek is long. Olympian goddess; oldest child of Cronus and Rhea; married to her youngest brother, Zeus. Most powerful of the goddesses, associated with institutional power and marriage. Eager for the total destruction of Troy, she, along with her stepdaughter Athena, rides to war on a marvelous chariot to attack the Trojans, against the injunctions of Zeus, who repeatedly threatens to beat her or chain her up when she works against him. Seduces Zeus in Book 14 to distract him from the battlefield and enable Greek success. 1.76.

**Heracles** (*her'-a-kleez*): Son of Zeus and Alcmene. Famous for completing the Twelve Labors and defeating monsters, Heracles saved the city of Troy from a sea monster in the generation before the Trojan War. 2.777.



**Hermes** (*her'-meez*): God associated with travel, trickery, and boundaries. Son of Zeus by Maia (one of the star goddess Pleiades). Messenger god who guides the dead to the underworld and serves as guide to Priam through the Greek camp to the tent of Achilles in Book 24. 2.124.

**Hermione** (*her-mai'-on-ee*): A town in the realm of Diomedes, in Argolis (modern-day Kastrì). 2.668.

**Hermus** (*herm'-us*): A river in Anatolia, near the birthplace of Iphition. 20.513.

**Hicataon** (*hik-a-tay'-on*): A senior advisor of Priam; son of Laomedon and father of Melanippus. 3.182.

**Hippasus** (*hip'-a-sus*): (1) Father of Charops and Socus. 11.558. (2) Father of Hypsenor. 13.544. (3) Father of Apisaon. 17.450.

**Hippemolgi** (*hip'-e-mol'-jee*): A northern tribe, perhaps nomadic, described as “milk-eating.” 13.6.

**Hippocoon** (*hip-o'-koh-on*): A Thracian leader and ally of the Trojans. 10.652.

**Hippodamas** (*hip-o'-dam-as*): Trojan; killed by Achilles. 20.524.

**Hippodamia** (*hip-o-dam-ee'-a*): (1) Mother of Polypoetes. 2.881. (2) Daughter of Anchises and wife of Alcathous. 13.570.

**Hippodamus** (*hip-o'-dam-us*): Trojan; killed by Odysseus. 11.437.

**Hippolochus** (*hip-o'-lok-us*): (1) Son of Bellerophon and father of Glaucus. 6.157. (2) Trojan; killed by Agamemnon. 11.194.

**Hippomachus** (*hip-o'-mak-us*): Trojan; killed by Leonteus. 12.229.

**Hipponous** (*hip-o'-noh-us*): Greek; killed by Hector. 11.391.

**Hipbothous** (*hip-o'-thoh-us*): (1) A leader of the Trojan allies from Pelasgia; killed by Telamonian Ajax. 2.996. (2) A son of Priam. 24.318.

**Hippotion** (*hip-oh'-shun*): Father of Morus and Ascanius; killed by Meriones. 13.1043.

**Hire** (*hee'-ree*): A city ruled by Agamemnon and offered to Achilles; exact location unknown. 9.188.

**Histiaeia** (*his'-tee-ai'-ya*): A town in Euboea. 2.645.

**Hours**: Goddesses of seasons who keep the gates of Olympus. 5.983.

**Hyades** (*hai'-ya-deez*): A constellation depicted on the shield of Achilles. 18.608.

**Hyampolis** (*hai-yam'-pol-is*): A town in Phocis. 2.625.

**Hyde** (*hai'-dee*): Birthplace of Iphition, apparently in Maeonia. 20.503.

**Hyle** (*hai'-lee*): A town in Boeotia. 2.600.

**Hyllos** (*hil'-us*): A river near the birthplace of Iphition. 20.512.

**Hyperenor** (*hai'-per-ee'-nor*): Trojan; killed by Menelaus. 14.686.

**Hyperesia** (*hai'-per-ee'-see-ya*): A town ruled by Agamemnon. 2.682.

**Hyperia** (*hai-per'-ee-ya*): A town ruled by Eurypylus; exact location unknown. 2.874.

**Hyperion** (*hai-pee'-ree-yon*): A Titan and father of Helios. He sometimes used the title of Helios. 8.645.

**Hyperochus** (*hai-per'-o-kus*): (1) Trojan; killed by Odysseus. 11.437. (2) Father of Itymoneus; Epean. 11.873.

**Hyperon** (*hai-pee'-rohn*): Trojan; killed by Diomedes. 5.191.

**Hypothebae** (*hip'-o-thee'-bai*): A town in Boeotia. Its name (“under Thebes”) suggests it was built as a suburb or relic of Thebes, presumably after that city was sacked. 2.605.

**Hypsenor** (*hip-see'-nor*): (1) Trojan; killed by Eurypylus. 5.99. (2) Greek; killed by Deiphobus. 13.543.

**Hypsipyle** (*hip-sip'-o-lee*): Mother of Euneus by Jason. 7.598.

**Hyria** (*hir'-ee-ya*): A town in Boeotia. 2.597.

**Hyrmine** (*hir-mee'-nee*): A town in Elis. 2.735.

**Hyrtacus** (*hir'-tak-us*): Father of Asius. 2.994.

**Hyrtius** (*hir'-tee-yus*): Trojan; killed by Telamonian Ajax. 14.680.

**Iaera** (*yai'-ra*): A Nereid. 18.52.

**Ialmenus** (*yal'-men-us*): A Greek; leader of the Minyans. 2.612.

**Ialysus** (*yal'-is-us*): A town in Rhodes. 2.781.

**Iamenus** (*yam'-en-us*): Trojan; killed by Leonteus. 12.171.

**Ianassa** (*yan-as'-a*): A Nereid. 18.57.

**Ianeira** (*yan-ay'-ra*): A Nereid. 18.55.

**Iapetus** (*ya'-pet-us*): A Titan, imprisoned in Tartarus with Cronus. 8.643.

**Iasus** (*yas'-us*): Greek; killed by Aeneas. 15.447.

**Icaria** (*ik-a'-ree-ya*): An island in the Aegean. 2.172.

**Ida** (*ai'-da*): A mountain in the Troad; its summit is sometimes inhabited by the gods. 2.974.

**Idaeus** (*id-ai'-yus*): (1) A Trojan herald. 3.304. (2) Trojan warrior who fights Diomedes and is saved by Hephaestus. 5.14.

**Idas** (*ai'-das*): Father of Cleopatra who challenged Apollo. 9.723.

**Idomeneus** (*id'-o-meen'-ee-yus*): Note stress—not *id-o'-men-yoos*. Leader of the Cretans (in the Greek alliance). Middle-aged, but a strong warrior. Comrade of Meriones, another Cretan leader. 1.196.

**Ilion** (*il'-ee-yon*): Ancient alternative name for Troy.

**Ilioneus** (*ee'-lee-oh'-nee-yus*): Trojan; killed by Peneleus. 14.648.

**Ilus** (*ee'-lus*): Son of Tros, father of Laomedon, and grandfather of Priam. 10.518.

**Imbrasus** (*im'-bras-us*): Father of Piros. 4.697.

**Imbrius** (*im'-bree-yus*): Trojan; killed by Teucer. 13.215.

**Imbros** (*im'-bros*): An island in the Aegean. 13.41.

**Iolcus** (*yol'-kus*): A town in Thessaly. 2.847.

**Ipheus** (*if'-ee-yus*): Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.533.

**Iphianassa** (*if'-ee-an-as'-a*): A daughter of Agamemnon. 9.182.

**Iphiclus** (*if'-i-klus*): Father of Protesilaus and Podarces. 2.868.

**Iphidamas** (*if-id'-am-as*): A Trojan; challenges and is killed by Agamemnon. 11.289.

**Iphinous** (*if-in'-oh-wus*): Greek; killed by Glaucus. 7.18.

**Iphis** (*if'-is*): Woman enslaved by Patroclus, who sleeps at his side; captured by Achilles from Scyros. 9.874.

**Iphition** (*if-eet'-ee-yon*): A Trojan and son of a naiad; killed by Achilles. 20.498.

**Iphitus** (*if'-it-us*): (1) Father of Epistrophus and Schedius, son of Naubolus. 2.621. (2) Father of Archeptolemus. 8.167.

**Iris** (*ai'-ris*): Goddess (though not an Olympian deity) who flies to take news between the gods (in contrast to Hermes, who more often takes messages to mortals and guides them between worlds). Daughter of an ocean goddess and a sea god. Swift-footed, quick-witted, and laconic in her speech, qualities that associate her with Achilles. 2.936.

**Isandrus** (*is-an'-drus*): A son of Bellerophon; killed in war against the Solimi. 6.264.

**Isus** (*ai'-sus*): An illegitimate son of Priam; killed by Agamemnon. 11.133.

**Ithaca** (*ith'-a-ka*): An island to the west of the Greek mainland; ruled by Odysseus. 2.755.

**Ithaemenes** (*ith-ai'-men-es*): Father of Sthenelaus. 16.738.

**Ithome** (*ith-oh'-mee*): A town in Thessaly. 2.866.

**Iton** (*ee'-ton*): A town in Thessaly. 2.827.

**Ixion** (*ik'-see-yon*): Mythical villain who attempted to rape Hera. 14.417.

**Jason** Father of Euneus. An important hero in the previous generation, he assembled a group of heroes, including Heracles, to sail in the world's first ship (the *Argo*) in quest of the Golden Fleece. 7.597.

**Laas** (*lah'-as*): A town in Lacedaemon; exact location unknown. 2.697.

**Lacedaemon** (*las'-e-dai'-mon*): The region in the southern Peloponnese ruled by Menelaus (modern-day Laconia). 2.693.

**Laerces** (*lay-er'-seez*): Father of Alcimedon. 16.256.

**Laertes** (*lay-er'-teez*): Father of Odysseus. 2.202.

**Lampus** (*lam'-pus*): An elder Trojan advisor to Priam; father of Dolops. 3.182.

**Laodamas** (*lay-o'-dam-as*): Trojan; killed by Telamonian Ajax. 15.683.

**Laodamea** (*lay-o'-dam-ee'-ya*): A daughter of Bellerophon; seduced by Zeus. 6.264.

**Laodice** (*lay-o'-dis-ee*): (1) A daughter of Priam. 3.150. (2) A daughter of Agamemnon. 9.182.

**Laodocus** (*lay-o'-do-kus*): (1) A Trojan; Athena disguises herself as him. 4.112. (2) A Greek warrior and comrade to Antilochus. 17.893.

**Laogonus** (*lay-o'-gon-us*): (1) Trojan; killed by Meriones. 16.759. (2) Trojan; killed by Achilles. 20.599.

**Laomedon** (*lay-o'-me-dohn*): Father of Priam and former king of Troy. 3.307.

**Laothoe** (*lay-o'-thoh-ee*): Mother of Lycaon and Polydorus by Priam. 21.118.

**Lapiths** (*lap'-iths*): Inhabitants of the Peneus valley in Thessaly. Fought against the Centaurs. 12.174.

**Larissa** (*lar-is'-a*): A town near Troy, home to Hippothous. 2.997.

**Lecton** (*lek'-tohn*): A coastal promontory at the foot of Mount Ida, the southwestern point of the Troad. 14.373.

**Leitus** (*lai'-yit-us*): A Boeotian leader; fights and is wounded by Hector. 2.594.

**Leleges** (*lel'-e-jeez*): Trojan allies from northern Anatolia. 10.535.

**Lemnos** (*lem'-nos*): An island in the Aegean. 1.759.

**Leocritus** (*lee-o'-krit-us*): Greek; killed by Aeneas. 17.445.

**Leonteus** (*lee-on'-tee-yus*): A Greek leader from Thessaly; participates in the funeral games. 2.885.

**Lesbos** (*les'-bos*): An island in the Aegean. 9.158.

**Lethus** (*lee'-thus*): Father of Hippothous and Pylaeus and son of Teutamus. 2.1000.

**Leto** (*lee'-toh*): A goddess, daughter of the Titans Coeus and Phoebe; mother of Apollo and Artemis. 1.11.

**Leucas** (*loo'-kas*): A Greek and comrade of Odysseus; killed by Antiphus. 4.656.

**Licymnius** (*lai-sim'-nee-yus*): Uncle of Heracles; killed by Tlepolemus. 2.789.

**Lilaea** (*li-lai'-ya*): A town in Phocis. 2.627.

**Limnorea** (*lim'-no-ree'-ya*): A Nereid. The name suggests “harbor.” 18.51.

**Lindos** (*lin'-dos*): A town in Rhodes. 2.781.

**Locris** (*lok'-ris*): A tripartite region in central Greece; homeland of Oilean Ajax. Its inhabitants are **Locrians**. 2.643.

**Lycaon** (*lik-ai'-yaon*): (1) Father of Pandarus. 2.980. (2) A son of Priam; disguise adopted by Apollo; killed by Achilles after begging to be ransomed as he was previously. 3.415.

**Lycastus** (*lik-as'-tus*): A town in Crete. 2.770.

**Lycia** (*lish'-a*): A region in Anatolia. Its inhabitants, **Lycians**, are allies of the Trojans. 2.1047.

**Lycomedes** (*lai'-ko-mee'-deez*): A Greek; son of Creon. 9.104.

**Lycophontes** (*lai'-ko-fon'-teez*): Trojan; killed by Teucer. 8.369.

**Lycophron** (*lai'-ko-frohn*): Greek; killed by Hector. 15.574.

**Lyctus** (*lik'-tus*): A town in Crete. 2.770.

**Lycurgus** (*lai-kur'-gus*): (1) A king who was punished by the gods for attacking the maenads caring for Dionysus. 6.173. (2) A king who killed Arethous with an ambush. 7.186.

**Lycus** (*lai ' -kus* ): Trojan; killed by Peneleus. 16.430.

**Lydia** (*lid' -ee-ya* ): A region in Anatolia. 2.554.

**Lyrnessus** (*lur-nes' -us* ): Home of Briseis; sacked by Achilles. 2.820.

**Lysander** (*lai-san' -der* ): Trojan; killed by Telamonian Ajax. 11.637.

**Macar** (*mak' -ar* ): Legendary founder of Lesbos. 24.675.

**Machaon** (*mak-ai' -yon* ): Son of Asclepius; Greek leader from Thessaly; a healer. 2.869.

**Maemalus** (*mai' -mal-us* ): Father of Pisander. 16.251.

**Maeon** (*mai' -yon* ): Leader in the attack against Tydeus, who killed him. 4.522.

**Maeonia** (*mai-yoh' -nee-a* ): A region in Anatolia. Its inhabitants are **Maeonians** . 2.1031.

**Maera** (*mai' -ra* ): A Nereid. The name suggests “sparkle.” 18.55.

**Magnesians** (*mag-nee' -zhuns* ): A Greek tribe led by Prothous and Pelion, presumably from Magnesia, by the River Peneus. 2.900.

**Mantineia** (*man' -tin-ay' -a* ): A town in Arcadia. 2.726.

**Maris** (*mar' -is* ): Trojan; killed by Thrasymedes. 16.409.

**Marpessa** (*mar-pes' -a* ): Wife of Idas, daughter of Evenus, and mother of Cleopatra. 9.725.

**Mases** (*may' -seez* ): A town in Argolis. 2.669.

**Mastor** (*mas' -tor* ): Father of Lycophron. 15.575.

**Meander** (*mee-yan' -der* ): A river in Anatolia. 2.1038.

**Mecisteus** (*me-sis' -tee-yus* ): (1) Father of Euryalus. 2.675. (2) Greek; killed by Polydamas. 8.443.

**Medeon** (*med' -ee-yon* ): A town in Boeotia. 2.601.

**Medesicaste** (*med-es' -i-kas' -tee* ): Illegitimate daughter of Priam and wife of Imbrius. 13.219.

**Medon** (*mee' -don* ): (1) A Greek leader; killed by Aeneas. 2.864. (2) A Trojan leader. 17.282.

**Megas** (*me' -gas* ): Father of Perimus. 16.873.

**Meges** (*mee' -jeez* ): Leader of Greeks from Dulicium and the Echinades. 2.749.

**Melanippus** (*mel-an-ip' -us* ): (1) Trojan; killed by Teucer. 8.369. (2) Trojan; killed by Antilochus. 15.723. (3) Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.874. (4) A Greek. 19.314.

**Melanthius** (*mel-an' -thee-yus* ): Trojan; killed by Eurypylus. 6.50.

**Melas** (*mel' -as* ): Son of Protheus. 14.150.

**Meleager** (*mel' -ee-ay' -ger* ): A Greek hero and prince of Calydon. 2.765.

**Meliboea** (*mel-ee-boy' -a* ): A town in Thessaly. 2.852.

**Melite** (*mel' -i-tee* ): A Nereid. The name suggests “sweet” or “honey.” 18.50.

**Menelaus** (*men' -e-lay' -us* ): Younger son of Atreus, brother of Agamemnon, lord of Sparta, and husband of Helen (by whom he has one daughter, Hermione). Tries to

duel Paris in Book 3, until Paris is spirited away by Aphrodite. Wounded in Book 4 by an arrow shot by Pandarus, guided by Athena. Slaughters many Trojans in his *aristeia* in the battle over the dead Patroclus in Book 17. 1.26.

**Menesthes** (*men-ees'-theez*): Greek; killed by Hector. 5.803.

**Menestheus** (*men-ees'-thee-yus*): Leader of the Athenians. 2.660.

**Menesthius** (*men-es'-thai-yus*): (1) Greek; killed by Paris. 7.10. (2) A leader of a group of Myrmidons. 16.220.

**Menoetius** (*men-oy'-shus*): Father of Patroclus. 9.258.

**Menon** (*meen'-ohn*): Trojan; killed by Leonteus. 12.233.

**Mentes** (*men'-teez*): Leader of the Ciconians; Apollo disguises himself as him. 17.91.

**Mentor** (*men'-tor*): Father of Imbrius. 13.216.

**Meriones** (*me-rai'-on-eez*): A Greek from Crete; Idomeneus' steward and comrade. 2.774.

**Mermerus** (*mer'-mer-us*): Trojan; killed by Antilochus. 14.682.

**Merops** (*me'-rops*): Father of Adrestus and Amphius. 2.985.

**Messa** (*mes'-a*): A town in Lacedaemon. 2.695.

**Messeis** (*mes-ay'-is*): A fountain or other water source; location unknown. 6.621.

**Mesthles** (*mes'-thleez*): A leader of Trojan allies. 2.1032.

**Mestor** (*mes'-tor*): A son of Priam who has died. 24.327.

**Methone** (*meth-oh'-nee*): A town in Thessaly. 2.852.

**Midia** (*mid'-ee-ya*): A town in Boeotia. 2.605.

**Miletus** (*mai-lee'-tus*): (1) A city in Crete. 2.770. (2) A town in Anatolia. 2.1035.

**Minos** (*mai'-nos*): Son of Zeus and father of Deucalion; king of Crete. 13.594.

**Minyans** (*min'-yans*): Greeks from Aspledon and Orchomenus in mainland Greece. 2.611.

**Molion** (*mol'-ee-yon*): Trojan; killed by Odysseus. 11.417.

**Molione** (*mol'-ee-oh'-nee*): Mother of Cteatus and Eurytus (or possibly a title of the two men). 11.921.

**Molus** (*moh'-lus*): Father of Meriones. 10.331.

**Morus** (*mor'-us*): Trojan; killed by Meriones. 13.1042.

**Mulius** (*moo'-lee-us*): (1) Epean; killed by Nestor. 11.960. (2) Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.874. (3) Trojan; killed by Achilles. 20.615.

**Munes** (*myou'-eez*): King of Lyrnessus. 19.383

**Muses**: Goddesses, daughters of Zeus, who inspire poetry. 1.770.

**Mycale** (*mi'-ka-lee*): A mountain in Caria. 2.1037.

**Mycalessus** (*mi-ka'-les-us*): A town in Boeotia. 2.596.

**Mycenae** (*mai-see'-nai*): Agamemnon's home, a city in Argolis. 2.678.

**Mydon** (*mai'-don*): (1) Trojan; killed by Antilochus. 5.760. (2) Trojan; killed by Achilles. 21.276.

**Mygdon** (*mig'-don*): A leader of the Phrygians. 3.231.

**Mynes** (*mi '-neez*): Son of Evenus from Lyrnessus; killed by Achilles. 2.822.

**Myrine** (*mai-ree'-nee*): An Amazon who fought the Trojans. 2.966.

**Myrmidons** (*mur'-mi-dons*): The Greeks from Thessaly under the command of Achilles. 1.242.

**Myrsinus** (*mir-sai'-nus*): A town in Elis. 2.736.

**Mysians** (*mi'-zhans*): Trojan allies; they may have lived to the south and east of the Troad. 2.1020.

**Nastes** (*nas'-teez*): Leader of the Carians. 2.1034.

**Naubolus** (*now'-bol-us*): Father of Iphitus. 2.622.

**Neleus** (*nee'-lee-yus*): Father of Nestor. 2.24.

**Nemertes** (*nem-er'-teez*): A Nereid. The name suggests “infallible.” 18.56.

**Neoptolemus** (*nee'-op-tol'-em-us*): Son of Achilles. 19.432.

**Nereids** (*nee'-ree-ids*): The divine daughters of Nereus, a sea god. There are traditionally fifty to a hundred of them, although only thirty-four (counting Thetis) are listed in *The Iliad*. 18.48.

**Neritus** (*ner'-i-tus*): A wooded mountain in Ithaca. 2.756.

**Nesaia** (*nes-ai'-ya*): A Nereid. The name suggests “island.” 18.52.

**Nestor** (*nes'-tor*): King of Pylos; oldest warrior at Troy. Typically described as “Pylian,” “horse-lord,” or “Gerenian” (Gerenia was his original home). Nestor participated in battles against the Centaurs and in the Calydonian boar hunt. Frequently tells long stories about the past while giving advice to younger warriors. 1.333.

**Niobe** (*nai'-yo-bee*): A former queen of Thebes who bragged about her children and was punished by Leto. 24.753.

**Nireus** (*nee'-ree-yus*): Leader from Syme. 2.798.

**Nisa** (*nee'-sa*): A town in Boeotia. 2.607.

**Nisyros** (*ni'-si-rus*): An island in the Aegean. 2.803.

**Noemon** (*noh-ee'-mon*): (1) Trojan; killed by Odysseus. 5.891. (2) A Greek; companion of Antilochus. 23.809.

**Nomion** (*no'-mee-on*): Father of Nastes and Amphimachus. 2.1040.

**Notus** (*noh'-tus*): The south wind, personified as a god. 2.173.

**Ocalea** (*ok-al'-ee-ya*): A town in Boeotia. 2.600.

**Ocean**: A divine river that encircles the earth. 1.561.

**Ochesius** (*o-kee'-see-yus*): Father of Periphas. 5.1108.

**Odius** (*od'-ee-yus*): (1) Leader of the Halizonians. 2.1019. (2) A Greek steward. 9.214.

**Odysseus** (*o-dis'-ee-yus*): Lord of Ithaca, and an important leader of the Greek armies. Son of Anticlea and Laertes, husband of Penelope, father of Telemachus. Primary

character in *The Odyssey*, which tells of his return home. Formulaic descriptions generally speak to his multiplicity and ability to adopt many different guises and personae. A favorite of Athena, Odysseus is the best strategic thinker and problem solver of the Greeks. He is the one who built the Wooden Horse that enabled the Greeks to capture Troy (a story not told directly in *The Iliad*). Within *The Iliad*, he is contrasted sharply with Achilles, who dislikes his wily pragmatism and willingness to compromise. 1.187.

**Oechalia** (*ee-kal'-ee-ya*): A town in Thessaly. 2.711.

**Oedipus** (*ee'-di-pus*): A ruler of Thebes in a previous generation. 23.903.

**Oeneus** (*ee'-nee-yus*): A former king of Calydon in Aetolia. 2.764.

**Oenomaus** (*ee'-no-may'-us*): (1) Greek; killed by Hector. 5.925. (2) Trojan; killed by Idomeneus. 12.173.

**Oenops** (*een'-ops*): Father of Helenus. 5.927.

**Oetylus** (*ee'-ti-lus*): A town in Lacedaemon. 2.697.

**Oileus** (*oh-wee'-lee-yus*): (1) Father of Locrian Ajax and, illegitimately, Medon.

“Oilean” (*o-wee'-lee-yan*) is used as a patronymic title to distinguish his legitimate son from Telamonian Ajax. 2.632. (2) Trojan; killed by Agamemnon. 11.122.

**Olenus** (*ol-ee'-nus*): A town in Aetolia. Its inhabitants are **Olenians**. 2.763.

**Olizon** (*ol'-iz-ohn*): A town in Thessaly. 2.853.

**Oloosson** (*ol-ow'-os-on*): A town in Thessaly. 2.877.

**Olympus**: A mountain inhabited by the major gods from which they derive the name Olympian; located between Thessaly and Macedonia. 1.28.

**Onchestus** (*onk-est'-us*): A town in Boeotia. 2.606.

**Onetor** (*on-ee'-tor*): Father of Laogonus and a priest of Zeus. 16.760.

**Ophelestes** (*of'-el-es'-teez*): (1) Trojan; killed by Teucer. 8.368. (2) Trojan; killed by Achilles. 21.275.

**Opheltius** (*of-el'-tee-yus*): (1) Trojan; killed by Euryalus. 6.27. (2) Greek; killed by Hector. 11.390.

**Opites** (*o-pai'-teez*): Greek; killed by Hector. 11.388.

**Opoeis** (*o'-poh-ees*): A town on the coast of mainland Greece, home to Patroclus; exact location unknown. 2.638.

**Orchomenus** (*ork-om'-en-us*): (1) A Boeotian town, ruled by Minyans. 2.610. (2) A town in Arcadia. 2.724.

**Oreithuia** (*or'-ay-thwee'-ya*): A Nereid. The name suggests “seasonal.” 18.58.

**Oresbius** (*or-es'-bee-yus*): Greek; killed by Hector. 5.927.

**Orestes** (*or-es'-teez*): (1) Greek; killed by Hector. 5.925. (2) A son of Agamemnon. 9.178. (3) Trojan; killed by Leonteus. 12.171.

**Orion** (*or-ai'-yon*): A constellation of a mythical hunter, depicted on the shield of Achilles. 18.608.



**Ormenion** (*or-meen'-ee-yon*): A town in Thessaly. 2.873.

**Ormenus** (*or'-men-us*): (1) Trojan; killed by Teucer. 8.367. (2) Father of Amyntor. 9.575. (3) Trojan; killed by Polypoetes. 12.226.

**Orneia** (*or'-nay-a*): A town in Argolis. 2.683.

**Orsilochus** (*or-si'-lok-us*): (1) Greek; killed by Aeneas. 5.715. (2) Trojan; killed by Teucer. 8.367.

**Orthaeus** (*or-thai'-yus*): A Trojan. 13.1040.

**Orthe** (*or'-thee*): A town in Thessaly. 2.877.

**Ortilochus** (*or-til'-ok-us*): Father of Diocles and grandfather of Crethon and Orsilochus. 5.720.

**Orus** (*or'-us*): Greek; killed by Hector. 11.391.

**Othryoneus** (*oth'-ree-oh'-nee-yus*): A Trojan ally from Cablesus; suitor of Cassandra; killed by Idomeneus. 13.473.

**Otus** (*oh'-tus*): (1) A monster; son of Aloeus who imprisoned Ares. 5.517. (2) Greek killed by Polydamas. 15.684.

**Otreus** (*ot'-ree-yus*): Leader of the Phrygians. 3.231.

**Otrynteus** (*ot-rin'-tee-yus*): Father of Iphition. 20.499.

**Oualegon** (*oo-ka'-le-gon*): Trojan elder. 3.183.

**Paean** (*pai'-yan*): A god of healing. 5.537.

**Paeon** (*pai'-yon*): Father of Agastrophus. 11.442.

**Paeonia** (*pai-yoh'-nee-ya*): A region on the River Axios in Macedonia. Its inhabitants, the **Paeonians**, are allies of the Trojans. 2.1006.

**Pallas** (*pal'-as*): An epithet of Athena. 5.81

**Palmus** (*pal'-mas*): A Trojan. 13.1041.

**Pammon** (*pam'-on*): A son of Priam. 24.317.

**Pandarus** (*pan'-da-ru s*): Leader of the Trojan allies from Zelea. Known for his skill in archery. Tricked by Athena, he shoots the arrow that breaks the truce between Greeks and Trojans in Book 4. 2.980.

**Pandion** (*pan'-dee-yon*): A Greek. 12.457.

**Pandocus** (*pan'-dok-us*): Trojan; wounded by Telamonian Ajax. 11.637.

**Panope** (*pan'-o-pee*): A Nereid. The name suggests “all-seeing.” 18.58.

**Panopeus** (*pan'-o-pee-yus*): (1) A town in central Greece. 2.624. (2) Father of Epeus. 23.884.

**Panthous** (*pan'-thoh-us*): A senior Trojan; advisor to Priam. 3.182.

**Paphlagonia** (*pa'-flag-oh'-nee-ya*): A region in Anatolia on the Black Sea. Its inhabitants, **Paphlagonians**, are allied to the Trojans. 2.1011.

**Paris**: A Trojan prince, son of Priam and Hecuba. His abduction of Helen from Sparta was the catalyst for the Trojan War. 3.19.

**Parrhasia** (*pa-rah'-see-ya*): A region in Arcadia. 2.727.

**Parthenius** (*par-thee'-nee-yus*): A river in Paphlagonia. 2.1015.

**Pasithee** (*pas-ith'-e-ee*): One of the Graces. 14.354.

**Patroclus** (*pat-rok'-lus*): Note that the stress is on the second syllable; the alternative pronunciation, *pat'-rok-lus*, will not work for the meter of this translation. Son of Menoetius; had to leave his biological home after committing manslaughter; raised with Achilles by his cousin Peleus and Chiron. Close companion of Achilles and a leader of the Myrmidons. His death leads to Achilles returning to battle. 1.409.

**Pedaeum** (*ped-ai'-yum*): A town and home of Imbrius; exact location unknown. 13.217.

**Pedaeus** (*ped-ai'-yus*): A Trojan; son of Antenor; killed by Meges. 5.90.

**Pedasus** (*ped'-as-us*): “High” or “jumper.” (1) Trojan; killed by Euryalus. 6.28. (2) A town allied to Troy that was captured by Achilles. 6.46. (3) A town controlled by Agamemnon; exact location unknown. 9.190. (4) A horse of Achilles. 16.593.

**Pelagon** (*pel'-a-gon*): (1) A Greek; comrade of Nestor. 4.386. (2) A Trojan and companion of Sarpedon. 5.912.

**Pelasgia** (*pel-as'-zha*): A place near Troy. Its inhabitants, **Pelasgians**, are Trojan allies. 2.998.

**Pelegon**: (*pee'-le-gon*): Son of the Axius river and Periboea; father of Asteropaeus. 21.188.

**Peleus** (*pee'-lee-yus*): Father of Achilles and ruler of Phthia. 1.2.

**Pelias** (*pel'-ee-yas*): Son of Poseidon and Tyro. Father of Alcestis. 2.851.

**Pelion** (*pee'-lee-yon*): A mountain on the Greek mainland where Achilles was tutored by Chiron. 2.883.

**Pellene** (*pel-een'-ee*): A town in the Argolis. 2.683.

**Pelops** (*pel'-ops*): A Greek hero of an earlier generation; husband of Hippodamia, whose hand he won through a trick. 2.126.

**Peneleus** (*pen-eel'-ee-yus*): A leader of the Boeotians; injured by Polydamas. 2.594.

**Peneus** (*pee'-nee-yus*): A river in Greece thought to flow into the Styx. 2.894.

**Peraebi** (*per-ai'-bee*): Inhabitants of the area around Dodona. 2.890.

**Percote** (*per'-ko-tee*): A town northeast of Troy. Its inhabitants are **Percosians**. 2.986.

**Pergamum** (*per'-gam-um*): The citadel of Troy, and the location of Apollo's temple. Athena's temple is also located on the Trojan acropolis. 4.679.

**Pergasus** (*per'-ga-sus*): Father of Deicoon. 5.707.

**Peria** (*per'-ee-ya*): The location where Apollo raised the horses of Admetus. 2.912.

**Periboea** (*per'-i-boy'-a*): Daughter of Aecessamenus and mother of Pelegon by the river Axius. 21.190.

**Periereus** (*per'-ee-er'-ee-yus*): Father of Borus. 16.227.

**Perimedes** (*per'-i-mee'-deez*): Father of Schedius. 15.680.

**Perimus** (*per'-i-mus*): Trojan; killed by Achilles. 16.873.

**Periphas** (*per'-i-fas*): (1) Greek killed by Ares. 5.1106. (2) A Trojan; Apollo disguises himself as him. 17.416.

**Periphetes** (*per'-i-fee'-teez*): (1) Trojan; killed by Teucer. 14.684. (2) A Greek from Mycenae; killed by Hector. 15.848.

**Persephone** (*per-se'-fon-ee*): Goddess of the underworld. Daughter of Demeter and forced bride of Hades. 3.346.

**Perseus** (*per'-see-yus*): Father of Sthenelus; a son of Zeus by Danae. 14.423.

**Peteon** (*pet'-ee-yon*): A town in Boeotia. 2.600.

**Peteos** (*pet'-ee-yohs*): Father of Menestheus. 2.660.

**Phaenops** (*fai'-nops*): (1) Father of Xanthus and Thoon. 5.202. (2) Father of Phorcys. 17.401. (3) A friend of Hector; Apollo disguises himself as him. 17.746.

**Phaestus** (*fai'-stus*): (1) A town in Crete. 2.771. (2) A Trojan ally from Maeonia; killed by Idomeneus. 5.56.

**Phalces** (*fal'-seez*): Trojan; killed by Antilochus. 13.1040.

**Pharis** (*far'-is*): A town in Lacedaemon. 2.694.

**Phegeus** (*fe-jee'-yus*): Trojan; killed by Diomedes. 5.14.

**Pheia** (*fee'-ya*): A town where Nestor fought a battle in his youth. 7.179.

**Pheneus** (*fee'-nee-yus*): A town in Arcadia. 2.725.

**Pherae** (*fee'-rai*): (1) A town in Thessaly. 2.845. (2) Home to Diocles. 5.717. (3) A town controlled by Agamemnon. 9.190.

**Phereclus** (*fer'-e-klus*): Trojan; killed by Meriones. 5.77.

**Pheres** (*fee'-reez*): Father of Admetus. 2.908.

**Pherousa** (*fer-oo'-sa*): A Nereid. The name suggests “bringing.” 18.54.

**Phidas** (*fai'-das*): An Athenian who fights against Hector. 13.912.

**Phidippus** (*fai-di'-pus*): Leader of the Greeks from the Calydnæ islands. 2.806.

**Philetor** (*fai-lee'-tor*): Father of Demuchus. 20.595.

**Philoctetes** (*fil-ok-tee'-teez*): A leader of the Greeks who was left on Lemnos after a snake bit him. 2.854.

**Phlegyae** (*fle-jee'-yai*): A Thessalian tribe who fight against the Ephyri. 13.392.

**Phocis** (*foh'-sis*): A region in central Greece. Its inhabitants are **Phocians**. 2.619.

**Phoebus** (*fee'-bus*): An epithet of Apollo. 1.62.

**Phoenicia** (*fo-nish'-a*): A land on the coast of Syria. The merchant people who lived there are the Phoenicians. 23.986.

**Phoenix** (*fee'-niks*): (1) A guardian and teacher of Achilles. Phoenix plays a crucial role in the embassy of Book 9. He tells the story of Meleager and manages, through the story and through his long-standing personal relationship with him, to persuade Achilles to delay his departure from Troy. 9.211. (2) Father of Europa. 14.425.

**Phorbias** (*for'-bas*): “Fodder.” (1) Father of Diomedes. 9.872. (2) Father of Ilioneus. 14.649.

**Phorcys** (*for'-sis*): Leader of the Phrygians and ally of the Trojans. 2.1028.

**Phradmon** (*frad'-mon*): Father of Ageleus. 8.342.

**Phrontis** (*fron'-tis*): Mother of Euphorbus and Hyperenor. 17.52.

**Phrygia** (*frid'-ja*): A region in Anatolia. Its inhabitants, the **Phrygians**, are allies of the Trojans. 2.1028.

**Phthia** (*fthee'-ya*): A region in southern Thessaly in Greece, home to Achilles. 1.211.

**Phthires** (*ftchai'-reez*): A mountain in Caria, identified by different sources with either Mount Latmos or Mount Grion. 2.1036.

**Phylace** (*fil'-a-see*): A town in Thessaly. 2.825.

**Phylacus** (*fil'-a-kus*): (1) Father of Iphiclus. 2.839. (2) Trojan; killed by Leitus. 6.48.

**Phylas** (*fai'-las*): Father of Polymele. 16.233.

**Phyleus** (*fil'-ee-yus*): Father of Meges. 2.750.

**Phylomedusa** (*fai'-lo-me-dyou'-sa*): Mother of Menestheus. 7.11.

**Pidytes** (*pid'-i-teez*): Trojan; killed by Odysseus. 6.42.

**Pieria** (*pee-er'-ee-ya*): A region in northern Thessaly. 14.293.

**Piraeus** (*pai-ray'-us*): Father of Ptolemy and grandfather of Eurymedon. 4.299.

**Pirithous** (*pai-ri'-thoh-us*): A King of the Lapiths who fought the Centaurs. 1.352.

**Piros** (*pai'-ros*): A Greek; leader of the Thracians; killed by Thoas. 2.1001.

**Pisander** (*pai-san'-der*): (1) Trojan; killed by Agamemnon. 11.191. (2) Trojan; killed by Menelaus. 13.790. (3) A Greek; a leader of the Myrmidons. 16.250.

**Pisenor** (*pai-see'-nor*): Father of Clitus. 15.595.

**Pittheus** (*pit'-thee-yus*): Father of Aethra. 3.179.

**Pitya** (*pit'-ee-ya*): A town north of Troy, allied with the Trojans. 2.982.

**Placus** (*pla'-kus*): A mountain in the Troad, overlooking Cilician Thebe. 6.533.

**Plataea** (*plat-ee'-ya*): A town in Boeotia. 2.603.

**Pleiades** (*play'-a-deez*): A constellation of the seven daughters of Atlas, represented on Achilles' shield. 18.608.

**Pleuron** (*plor'-on*): A town in Aetolia. 2.762.

**Podalirius** (*pod'-a-lir'-ee-yus*): A leader of the Greeks and a doctor; a son of Asclepius. 2.870.

**Podarces** (*pod-ar'-seez*): A leader of the Greeks. 2.838.

**Podes** (*poh'-deez*): Trojan; killed by Menelaus. 17.735.

**Polites** (*pol-ai'-teez*): A son of Priam; Iris disguises herself as him. 2.942.

**Pollux** (*pol'-uks*): A brother of Helen. 3.291.

**Polyaemon** (*pol'-ee-ai'-mohn*): Father of Amopaon. 8.370.

**Polybus** (*pol'-i-bus*): A Trojan, and son of Antenor. 11.75.

**Polyctor** (*pol-ik'-tor*): The father of the young Myrmidon as whom Hermes disguises himself. 24.493.

**Polydamas** (*pol-i'-da-mas*): A Trojan leader and advisor to Hector. 11.72.

- Polydore** (*pol'-i-dor'-ee*): “Many gifts.” Daughter of Peleus and mother of Menesthius by the River Spercheus. 16.223.
- Polydorus** (*pol'-i-dor'-us*): “Many gifts.” (1) Son of Priam and Laothoe; killed by Achilles. 20.532. (2) An opponent of Nestor in the funeral games for Amarynecus. 23.843.
- Polyidus** (*pol-ai'-yi-dus*): “Much knowing.” (1) Trojan; killed by Diomedes. 5.197. (2) A soothsayer and the father of Euchenor. 13.874.
- Polymele** (*pol'-i-mee'-lee*): Mother of Eudorus by Hermes. 16.232.
- Polymelus** (*pol'-i-mee'-lus*): Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.535.
- Polyneices** (*pol'-i-nai'-seez*): Leader of the Seven against Thebes. 4.501.
- Polyphemus** (*pol'-i-fee'-mus*): A former comrade of Nestor. 1.354.
- Polyphetes** (*pol'-i-fee'-teez*): A Trojan who fights alongside Hector. 13.1041.
- Polyphontes** (*pol'-i-fon'-teez*): A Theban leader; killed by Tydeus. 4.524.
- Polypoetes** (*pol'-i-poy'-teez*): A leader of the Greeks from Argissa, with Leonteus; son of Hippodamia and Pirithous and a grandson of Zeus. 2.879.
- Polyxenus** (*pol-iks'-e-nus*): One of the leaders of the Epeans. 2.744.
- Portheus** (*por'-thee-us*): Grandfather of Diomedes and father of Tydeus. 14.149.
- Poseidon** (*pos-ai'-don*): Son of Cronus and Rhea, and brother of Zeus; allotted the sea as his realm (when Hades was allotted the realm below the earth, and Zeus the sky). Associated with earthquakes. Hostile to Troy because King Laomedon failed to pay him and Apollo for building the magically strong walls of the city. 1.528.
- Practius** (*prak'-tee-yus*): A town and the river running through it near Troy, along the southern shore of the Hellespont close to Abydos. The inhabitants are allied with the Trojans. 2.992.
- Pramnian** (*pram'-nee-yan*): A vintage of wine. 11.826.
- Priam** (*prai'-yam*): King of Troy; husband of Hecuba, son of Laomedon, father of many children (fifty sons in many versions, by various women). He is a veteran warrior who carries an ash-wood spear; in the poem, he is too elderly to play an active part in the fighting. A passive ruler, he plays little part in the military strategy of the Trojans, beyond begging his favorite son, Hector, not to take so many risks to his life; the loss of Hector, Priam knows, will mean his own humiliating death and the sack of his city. Priam has an affectionate relationship with his lonely daughter-in-law Helen (who has no female companions in Troy, for obvious reasons). In Book 24, Priam makes a courageous nighttime journey through the enemy camp to retrieve his dead son. At the sack of Troy by the Greeks, Priam was killed by Neoptolemus, son of Achilles (a story not told in *The Iliad*). 1.29.
- Proetus** (*proy'-tus*): A king of Argos who attempts to send Bellerophon to his death. 6.210.
- Promachus** (*pro'-mak-us*): Boeotian; killed by Acamas. 14.631.

**Pronous** (*pro'-noh-us*): Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.511.

**Protesilaus** (*proh-tes'-il-ay'-us*): A leader of the Greeks from Thessaly. He was the first Greek to touch the shore at Troy and the first to be killed. 2.829.

**Prothoenor** (*pro-thoh'-ee-nor*): A Boeotian leader; killed by Polydamas. 2.595.

**Prothoon** (*pro'-tho-ohn*): Trojan; killed by Teucer. 14.684.

**Prothous** (*pro'-thoh-us*): A Greek; leader of the Magnesians. 2.899.

**Protiaon** (*pro'-tee-a'-ohn*): Father of Astynous. 15.606.

**Proto** (*proh'-toh*): A Nereid. The name suggests “first.” 18.53.

**Prytanis** (*pri'-tan-is*): Trojan; killed by Odysseus. 5.891.

**Pteleus** (*tee'-lee-us*): (1) A town near Pylos, ruled by Nestor; exact location unknown. 2.708. (2) A town in Thessaly. 2.828.

**Ptolemy** (*tol'-e-mee*): Father of Eurymedon. 4.299.

**Pygmy** (*pig'-mee*): A people from central Africa who had a mythical battle with cranes. 3.7.

**Pylaemenes** (*pai'-lai-mee'-neez*): Leader of the Paphlagonians, allies of Troy; killed by Menelaus. Father of Harpalion. 2.1010.

**Pylaeus** (*pil-ay'-us*): A leader of the Pelasgians and ally of the Trojans. 2.999.

**Pylartes** (*pil-ar'-teez*): (1) Trojan; killed by Telamonian Ajax. 11.638. (2) Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.874.

**Pylene** (*pai-lee'-nee*): A town in Aetolia. 2.763.

**Pylon** (*pai'-lon*): Trojan; killed by Polypoetes. 12.227.

**Pylos** (*pai'-los*): A town in Messene, the home of Nestor. Its inhabitants are **Pylians**. 1.334.

**Pyraechmes** (*pir-aik'-meez*): Leader of the Paeonians, allies of Troy; killed by Patroclus. 2.1005.

**Pyrasus** (*pir'-as-us*): (1) A town in Thessaly. 2.826. (2) Trojan; killed by Telamonian Ajax. 11.648.

**Pyris** (*pir'-is*): Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.533.

**Pytho** (*pai'-thoh*): A town in Phocis, sacred to Apollo; known also as Delphi. 2.623.

**Rhadamanthus** (*rad'-a-man'-thus*): Son of Zeus and Europa. 14.426.

**Rhea** (*ree'-a*): Titan; wife of Cronus, mother of the elder generation of Olympian gods. 14.261.

**Rhene** (*ree'-nee*): Mother of Medon. 2.866.

**Rhesus** (*ree'-sus*): (1) A leader of the Trojan allies from Thrace; killed by Diomedes. 10.543. (2) A river in the Troad. 12.25.

**Rhipe** (*ree'-pee*): A town in Arcadia. 2.725.

**Rhodes** (*rohds*): A large island in the southeastern Aegean. Its inhabitants are **Rhodians**. 2.779.

**Rhodium** (*roh'-dee-us*): A river flowing from Mount Ida to the sea. 12.25.

**Rhytius** (*ree'-tee-us*): A town in Crete. 2.771.

**Rigmus** (*rig'-mus*): A Trojan ally from Thrace; killed by Achilles. 20.631.

**Salamis** (*sal'-a-mis*): An island off the coast of Attica, home to Telamonian Ajax. 2.665.

**Samos** (*say'-mos*): Also known as Same (*say'-mee*). An island in the Ionian Sea, ruled by Odysseus. Not the same as the modern (and ancient) island of Samos in the Aegean. 2.758.

**Samothrace** (*sam'-oh-thrays*): An island off the coast of Thrace. 13.14.

**Sangarius** (*san-gar'-ee-us*): A river in Phrygia. 3.233.

**Sarpedon** (*sar-pee'-don*): Note the stress on second syllable, which is a long “e.” Leader of the Lycians, allies of the Trojans, and son of Zeus and Laodamea. A courageous warrior, he dies at the hands of Patroclus. Zeus yearns to protect his son, and weeps at his death. In Book 17, the two sides tussle over his body. Zeus orders Apollo to rescue his body from the fight over it. 2.1046.

**Satnioeis** (*sat'-nee-oh'-is*): A river near Troy. 6.47.

**Satnius** (*sat'-nee-us*): Trojan; killed by Oilean Ajax. 14.596.

**Scaean Gates** (*see'-yan*): The main gates of Troy, through which the Wooden Horse will eventually pass, and from which Hector leaves and reenters the city. “Scaean” means “left”—i.e., these are the gates on the west side of the city, leading to the plain and the battlefield; there are presumably eastern gates on the other side that are irrelevant to the poem’s action. 3.180.

**Scamander** (*ska-man'-der*): A river that runs through the plain of Troy. 2.558.

**Scamandrius** (*sca-man'-dree-yus*): (1) Trojan; killed by Menelaus. 5.65. (2) The name Hector calls his son, Astyanax. 6:542.

**Scandea** (*skan'-dee-ya*): A town in Cythera and home to Amphidamas. 10.329.

**Scarphe** (*scar'-fee*): A town in Locris. 2.639.

**Schedius** (*sked'-ee-yus*): (1) A Greek leader from Phocis; killed by Hector. 2.620. (2) Greek; killed by Hector. 17.393.

**Schoenus** (*skee'-nus*): A town in Boeotia. 2.597.

**Scolus** (*skoh'-lus*): A town in Boeotia. 2.597.

**Scyros** (*skai'-ros*): An island in the Aegean, where Achilles’ son Neoptolemus is raised. 9.876.

**Selepus** (*sel'-ep-us*): Father of Evenus. 2.823.

**Selleis** (*sel-ay'-is*): (1) A river in Elis. 2.784. (2) A river in the Troad. 2.996.

**Semele** (*sem'-el-ee*): Mother of Dionysus by Zeus. 14.427.

**Sesamon** (*ses-ah'-mohn*): A town in Paphlagonia. 2.1013.

**Sestus** (*ses'-tus*): A city in Thrace. 2.991.

**Sicyon** (*si'-see-yon*): A town in Argolis. 2.681.

**Sidonia** (*sid-oh'-nee-a*): A Phoenician town. Its inhabitants are **Sidonians**. 6.388.

**Simoeis** (*sim-oh'-is*): A river near Troy. 4.634.

**Simoësius** (*sim-oh-ee'-see-yus*): Trojan; killed by Telamonian Ajax. 4.632.

**Sintians** (*sin'-tee-yans*): The pre-Greek inhabitants of Lemnos who cared for Hephaestus when Zeus hurled him from Olympus. 1.760.

**Sipylus** (*sip'-il-us*): A mountain in Ionia where Niobe was turned to stone. 24.771.

**Sisyphus** (*sis'-if-us*): A legendary trickster and father of Glaucus. 6.205.

**Sleep**: A god and brother of Death; aids Hera's deception of Zeus. Also appears frequently as a semipersonified force that overcomes the weary. 14.301.

**Socus** (*soh'-kus*): Trojan; killed by Odysseus. 11.559.

**Solimi** (*sol'-im-ee*): An indigenous people in Lycia, fought by Bellerophon. 6.247.

**Sparta**: A city in the Peloponnese. 2.695.

**Speio** (*spay'-oh*): A Nereid. The name suggests "cave." 18.50.

**Spercheus** (*sper'-kee-yus*): A river in Phthia that fathered Menestheus. 16.221.

**Sphelus** (*sfe'-lus*): Father of Iasus. 15.456.

**Stentor** (*sten'-tor*): A Greek; Hera disguises herself as him. 5.1028.

**Sthenelaus** (*sthen'-e-lay'-us*): Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.737.

**Sthenelus** (*sthen'-el-us*): (1) A leader of Greeks from the Argolis and companion of Diomedes. 2.672. (2) Father of Eurystheus. 19.151.

**Stichius** (*stik'-ee-yus*): A leader of the Boeotians; killed by Hector. 13.250.

**Stratia** (*stray'-sha*): A town in Arcadia. 2.724.

**Strophius** (*strof'-ee-us*): Father of Scamandrius. 5.66.

**Stymphelus** (*stim'-fel-us*): A town in Arcadia. 2.727.

**Styra** (*stai'-ra*): A town in Euboea. 2.647.

**Styx** (*stiks*): A river in the underworld that the dead cross, and by which the gods swear binding oaths. Associated with dread and hatred. 2.897.

**Syme** (*say'-mee*): An island apparently to the north of Rhodes, inhabited by Nireus; exact location unknown. 2.797.

**Talaemenes** (*tal'-ai-mee'-neez*): Father of Antiphus and Mesthles. 2.1032.

**Talaus** (*tal'-ay-us*): Father of Mecisteus and grandfather of Euryalus. 2.676.

**Talthybius** (*tal-thib'-ee-yus*): A Greek herald. 1.429.

**Tarne** (*tar'-nee*): A town in Maeonia; exact location unknown. 5.58.

**Tarphe** (*tar'-fee*): A town in Locris. 2.640.

**Tartarus** (*tar'-tar-us*): A deep chasm below the earth where the Titans are held. 8.16.

**Tegea** (*tej-ee'-ya*): A town in Arcadia. 2.726.

**Telamon** (*tel'-a-mon*): Father of Telamonian Ajax and of Teucer. 8.635.

**Telemachus** (*tel-e'-mach-us*): Note that the stress is on the second syllable, and the "a" is short. Son of Odysseus and Penelope; he is a baby when his father goes to the war, and grows up on the island of Ithaca. 2.318.

**Tenedos** (*ten'-e-dos*): An island near Troy, sacked by Achilles. 1.56.



**Tenthrydon** (*ten-thrai'-don*): Father of Prothous. 2.899.

**Teria** (*ter'-ee-ya*): A mountain in the Troad. 2.983.

**Tethys** (*teth'-is*): A sea goddess; wife of Ocean. 14.261.

**Teucer** (*tyou'-ser*): A significant Greek fighter, known for his skill in archery. Son of Telamon by Hesione; half brother and companion of Telamonian Ajax (Ajax the Greater). 6.42.

**Teutamus** (*tyou'-ta-mus*): Father of Lethus. 2.1000.

**Teuthras** (*tyou'-thras*): (1) Greek; killed by Hector. 5.924. (2) Father of Axylus. 6.14.

**Thaleia** (*thal-ay'-a*): A Nereid. The name suggests “fertile.” 18.49.

**Thalpius** (*thal'-pee-yus*): A leader of the Epeans. 2.741.

**Thalysius** (*thal-is'-ee-yus*): Father of Echepolus. 4.612.

**Thamacia** (*tham-ay'-sha*): A town in Thessaly. 2.853.

**Thamyris** (*tham-ai'-ris*): A Thracian singer; punished by the Muses for boasting that he could best them. 2.710.

**Theano** (*thee-ah'-noh*): A priestess of Athena at Troy. Wife of Antenor and daughter of Cisseus. 5.92.

**Thebaeus** (*theb-ai'-yus*): Father of Eniopeus. 8.157.

**Thebe** (*thee'-bee*): A town near Troy in Anatolia, sacked by Achilles, and ruled by Andromache’s father, Eetion. 1.483.

**Thebes** (*theebz*): (1) A city in Boeotia, sieged by Polyneices, who led the Seven against Thebes. Its inhabitants are **Thebans**. 4.503. (2) A wealthy city in Egypt. 9.491.

**Themis** (*them'-is*): “Custom.” A goddess associated with traditional propriety. 15.119.

**Thersilochus** (*ther-si'-lok-us*): Trojan; killed by Achilles. 17.281.

**Thersites** (*ther-sai'-teez*): Described as the ugliest of the Greek warriors, Thersites speaks up against Agamemnon and the other leaders in Book 2 and is brutally beaten by Odysseus. His criticisms of the Trojan expedition parallel those of Achilles in Book 9, although the physical attributes and social status of the two characters are entirely different. It is unclear whether he is supposed to be a common foot soldier or a second-tier leader. Thersites invites comparison with Hephaestus, the divine character who also “limps.” 2.254.

**Theseus** (*thee'-see-yus*): A Greek hero of the previous generation, mentioned by Nestor as a companion. 1.355.

**Thespeia** (*thes-pay'-a*): A town in Boeotia. 2.598.

**Thessalus** (*thes'-al-us*): Father of Antiphus and Phidippus. 2.807.

**Thessaly** (*thes'-al-ee*): Post-Homeric ancient term for a large region of northern mainland Greece, stretching roughly from Mount Olympus to the River Spercheus.

**Thestor** (*thes'-tor*): (1) Father of Calchas. 1.94. (2) Father of Alcmaon. 12.486. (3) Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.514.

**Thetis** (*thet'-is*): A Nereid. The name suggests “placement.” Her most common epithet is “silver-footed,” because she rises like mist from the silver sea. She seeks aid from Zeus to help Achilles and gets Hephaestus to make him new armor. 1.546.

**Thisbe** (*thiz'-bee*): A town in Boeotia. 2.602.

**Thoas** (*thoh'-as*): (1) Leader of the Aetolians. 2.761. (2) King of Lemnos. 14.300. (3) Trojan killed by Menelaus. 16.399.

**Thoe** (*thoh'-ee*): A Nereid. The name suggests “quick.” 18.51.

**Thoon** (*thoh'-on*): (1) Trojan; killed by Diomedes. 5.203. (2) Trojan; killed by Odysseus. 11.551. (3) Trojan; killed by Antilochus. 12.173.

**Thootes** (*thoh'-o-teez*): A Greek; steward of Menestheus. 12.422.

**Thrace** (*thrays*): A region to the north of the Aegean and the Hellespont. Its inhabitants, **Thracians**, are allies of the Trojans. 2.710

**Thrasius** (*thras'-ee-us*): Trojan; killed by Achilles. 21.275.

**Thrasymedes** (*thras'-ee-mee'-deez*): A son of Nestor; a Greek leader. 9.100.

**Thrasymelus** (*thras-im'-el-us*): A Trojan; charioteer for Sarpedon; killed by Patroclus. 16.590.

**Thronius** (*thron'-ee-yus*): A town in Locris. 2.640.

**Thryon** (*three'-on*) or **Thryoessa** (*three'-o-es'-a*): A town apparently on the borders of Nestor’s realm, on the banks of the Alpheus. 2.705.

**Thyestes** (*thai-es'-teez*): Brother of Atreus; uncle to Agamemnon and Menelaus. 2.128.

**Thymbre** (*thim'-bree*): A town near Troy. 10.536.

**Thymbraeus** (*thim-brai'-us*): Trojan; killed by Diomedes. 11.414.

**Thymoites** (*thim-oy'-teez*): A Trojan and senior advisor to Priam. 3.184.

**Tiryns** (*tir'-ins*): A city in the Peloponnese, home of Diomedes. 2.667.

**Titans** (*tai'-tans*): The generation of gods preceding the Olympians; they were imprisoned in Tartarus by Zeus. 14.367.

**Titanus** (*tit'-an-us*): A town or mountain in Thessaly. 2.874.

**Titaressus** (*tit'-ar-es'-us*): A river in Thessaly that flows into the River Peneus. 2.892.

**Tithonus** (*ti-thoh'-nus*): The partner of the goddess Dawn and a son of Laomedon. Made immortal but not ageless; sometimes associated with the cicada. 11.1.

**Tlepolemus** (*tle-pol'-em-us*): (1) A Greek; leader of the Rhodians; killed by Sarpedon. 2.777. (2) Trojan; killed by Patroclus. 16.534.

**Tmolus** (*tmoh'-lus*): A mountain in Anatolia. 2.1030.

**Trechis** (*treek'-is*): A town in southern Thessaly; exact location unknown. 2.810.

**Trechus** (*tree'-kus*): Aetolian; killed by Hector. 5.926.

**Tricca** (*trik'-a*): A town in Thessaly. 2.866.

**Triton** (*trai'-ton*): Part of “Triton-born” as an epithet of Athena; it may refer to the River Triton or Lake Tritonis. 8.49.

**Troad** (*troh'-ad*): The ancient region of northwestern Anatolia in which Troy was located, corresponding to the modern-day Biga peninsula in Türkiye. Its inhabitants, the **Troades**, are allied with the Trojans.

**Troezen** (*troh'-e-zeen*): A town in the Peloponnese. 2.669.

**Troezenus** (*troh'-e-zeen'-us*): Father of Euphemus. 2.1004.

**Troilus** (*troy'-lus*): A son of Priam. 24.327.

**Tros** (*trohs*): (1) An ancestor of the house of Priam. Zeus gave him special horses as compensation for the abduction of his son Ganymede. 5.352. (2) Trojan; killed by Achilles. 20.602.

**Troy**: City on the ancient coast of the Hellespont (modern Dardanelles in northwestern Türkiye); known in antiquity to speakers of Greek as Troia or Ilion, and to the Hittites as Wilusa. 1.24.

**Tychius** (*tik'-ee-yus*): Maker of the shield of Telamonian Ajax. 7.284.

**Tydeus** (*tid'-ee-us*): Father of Diomedes; a hero of the previous generation, and one of the Seven against Thebes. 4.487.

**Typhoeus** (*tif-oy'-us*): A monster confined underground near the volcanic area near the Arimi. 2.933.

**Xanthus** (*zan'-thus*): “Yellow.” (1) A river in Anatolia, also called the Scamander (these days, known as the Karamenderes), and the god associated with that river. Objects when Achilles clogs up his streams with corpses, and rises up against him, flooding the plain, withdrawing only when challenged by Hephaestus. 2.1048. (2) Trojan; killed by Diomedes. 5.202.

**Zacynthus** (*zak-in'-thus*): An island in the Ionian Sea, under Odysseus’ command. 2.757.

**Zelea** (*zel-ee'-a*): A town in the Troad, near the Aesepus River, about seventy miles from Troy. 2.978.

**Zephyr** (*zef'-ir*): The west wind, personified. 2.174.

**Zeus** (*zyoos*): God of the sky, associated with strategy and thunder. Son of Cronus and Rhea, both Titans. Zeus defeated his father, Cronus, and established the reign of the Olympian gods. Married his sister, Hera, and has children with her (including Hephaestus); also has many other children with other goddesses and as the result of raping mortal women. Bears the goatskin aegis (an emblem of power). Associated with Mount Ida, where his special seat is Gargaron. 1.7.

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At home in Philadelphia, two cats, Pumpkin and Spice, and one dog, Pepper, listened to many hundreds of hours of *The Iliad*. They demonstrated no comprehension, which is all for the best. Hungry animals could get some dangerous ideas from this poem. I am even more grateful to the humans who have allowed me to read to them. In particular, my father, Andrew, kindly let me read my translation out loud to him for many hours—a reversal of a childhood in which he read numerous gripping long books aloud to my sister and me (from the *Chronicles of Narnia* to *Dombey and Son*). He saved me at the last minute from at least three infelicitous word choices.

I have learned a huge amount from other Homerists and scholars, many of whom I have met only on the page. Most of my work on Homer has been done at home or in the library. Every day, I envision the city of Troy in my mind, but not in the flesh. When the translation was almost done, I was thrilled to have the opportunity to go to Troy, Mycenae, Pylos, and the Greek islands. I was moved and chilled to see the hungry dogs still roaming through the stones of windy Troy, and grateful for a warm reception on the island of Chios, where people are rightly proud of their local celebrity. My experience of visiting these sites was greatly enhanced by the brilliantly knowledgeable archaeologist and tour guide Dr. Aristotle Koskinas.

My most profound debt is to the unknown, long-dead, numberless, and forgotten people whose imaginations and voices created the Trojan myths and the Homeric epics. Whatever life breathes through these pages comes from them.

On a more personal level, I am thankful for my family, and for all the friends and neighbors who have shared our lives during the years I worked on this project, as well as for essential moral and emotional support from my sister, Bee. My children's schools were entirely closed for eighteen months during the pandemic, and the last few years have been difficult for them, as for so many other young people. I am truly thankful to the many therapists, teachers, neighbors, and friends who have guided and supported all of us through some tough times. I am also endlessly grateful to my children themselves, for their sparkling creativity, curiosity, and kindness. We all spent a great deal of time confined to our home while I worked on this translation—an experience that made it all too easy to feel for the terrified Trojans, trapped in their city and constantly fearing death, and for the miserable, angry Greeks, stuck for ten years between wall and sea. And yet catastrophic quarrels were thankfully rare. Thank you, Imogen, Psyche, and Freya, for making me laugh and letting me cry, in bad times and in good, and for teaching me so much about life as well as the latest dance moves and trends, at which, as you know, I am terrible.

My partner, chariot driver, and webmaster, David Foreman, has been a constant source of connection and joy. I am grateful every day for his companionship, his kindness, his good judgment, his thoughtful competence in so many arenas of life, and his laughter. Thank you.

During the eleven years that I worked on my Homeric translations, my big orange cat Salsea was on my home desk every single day. I kept him company as he worked at his own essential tasks, observing the birds, monitoring the dog and younger cats, and taking well-earned six-hour naps. He was always respectful about not sitting on my Homeric texts, commentaries, notebooks, and keyboard. He never batted pens off the desk. His purr was rare but deep. His dignified, authoritative presence was a daily inspiration. He was a warrior, whose mouse-slaying paws were known and feared throughout our block. He died suddenly by violence when this work was almost finished. I miss him every day.



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